
SATIPANYA BUDDHIST RETREAT

Selected Talks

A selection of interesting talks if you don't know where to start

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SHROPSHIRE, WALES · UNITED KINGDOM

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Reflections on the Teaching and Practice of Not-self

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 18 min read

This comprehensive essay examines one of Buddhism's most challenging teachings for the Western mind: anattā or not-self. Bhante Bodhidhamma guides readers through the Buddha's second discourse, the Anattalakkhāṇa Sutta (SN 22.59), which completed the liberation of the five ascetics after the first turning of the Dhamma wheel. The essay systematically explores each of the five khandhas (aggregates) - body, feelings (vedanā), perceptions (saññā), mental formations (saṅkhāra), and consciousness (viññāṇa) - demonstrating how none can be considered a permanent, controllable self or soul (atta). Through practical investigation, readers learn to recognize their limited control over these aggregates and their impermanent, unsatisfactory nature. The text connects this ancient teaching to modern psychological insights about self-development, particularly Margaret Mahler's separation-individuation theory, and explains how vipassanā meditation practice helps objectify inner experiences. Bhante details the progressive stages of insight, from recognizing the separation between knower and known, to the ultimate realization that even the sense of being 'the knower' must be transcended to discover the unconditioned happiness of Nibbāna. This essay serves both as doctrinal explanation and practical guide for understanding and realizing the profound teaching of not-self.

A Reflection on the Teaching and Practice of Not-Self.

INTRODUCTION

No doctrine of the Buddha has so challenged the western mind as the teaching of not-self, anattā. It is easy to fall into what the Buddha would call wrong views (ditthi), the opposite of annihilation and eternalism. Either everything dies at death or something lives on. Here, our exploration begins with basic understandings and uses the Buddha's first teaching, The Discourse on Not-self. By following the practice he explains there, we can begin to experience what he means. It is a start.

The Self

We can describe a 'self' in various ways. It is an entity; it is substantial; it is whole and singular in the present moment and throughout time. Because it can perceive, it therefore exists. It is the

subject, the one who feels, thinks and experiences. It is the doer. It is distinct from other selves and has its own discrete character and personality. It is a mental construct, a concept.

What description attracts you most from this list?

Self as Identity

When we say 'me', what are we referring to? Normally we would have a sense of this 'me' as some central identity, a central self-reference point that is experienced as solid, unchanging and in control. When we point to 'me', paradoxically we usually point to the middle of the chest (the heart chakra), whereas we experience our self-awareness in the head. This tells us that 'me' has a feeling and a thinking part – the one knows, the one who feels, that is, the one who experiences and experiences. When it comes to the body, we would usually say 'my' body. It rarely becomes 'me'. When we fall gravely or terminally ill, then we see how intertwined the sense of me and the body is: 'I am going to die.'

We are aware of me: I can perceive myself so I must exist and as I perceive myself, I see I am distinct from others.

They are not me. I have a personal and distinct character.

This sense of me is made even more real because we do things: I act; I am what I do.

(There are those who suffer from a conflicted or weak sense of self. It is understood that such a person needs to

develop a strong sense of self before they can begin this sort of exploration.)

Should you say: this is the essential me, what might you mean by it?

Self as Eternal Soul

The self presumes itself to be permanent. While we are awake, a feeling of continual presence is experienced as

always being here. It feels other than the body, emotions or thought. Just being here. A self-awareness. It is,

therefore, eternal or timeless – in other words, outside time and so unchanging.

Do you have this sense of 'something' in you being always there? What do you make of it?

Contradiction?

These two descriptions of self and soul are not the same. Whereas the sense of self includes the body, heart and

mind, the soul suggests something ethereal that is in the body, heart and mind, but is

beyond them and is self-aware

– it knows itself.

Atta – the Self

During the Buddha's time, the word *atta* was understood to refer to that within a being that was unchanging and so immortal; solid and so substantial; in control and so all-powerful within itself. The spiritual search for the *atta* led to freedom from suffering, happiness. Because it was all powerful over itself, the *atta* would always be able to be in a state of continual happiness, in whatever way it wished to define it: contentment, peace, bliss and so on. Thus if the soul said: 'Let there be happiness', that's the way it would be. There were many sects and each had their own definition and paths to liberation. It was within this atmosphere of spiritual searching and confusion that the Buddha clarified his teaching.

The Buddha's Understanding

After his awakening, the Buddha set out to teach. The first people he sought were his five former companions *samanas* or wandering ascetics. In the ensuing days, the Buddha explained what he had come to realise and he constantly asked them if they had ever heard him speak like this before. His was a revolutionary message: There is an end to suffering in all its forms, from the slightest to the greatest.

These explanations and discussions have come down to us formalised as the first two discourses. The first presents

the platform of his teaching, the Dhamma – the Four Noble Truths. It is, therefore, known as a Turning the Wheel

of the Dhamma (Start the Wheel of the Dhamma Rolling) *Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta*. His friends were

impressed and one *Kondañña* had a deep insight, known as Stream Entry. He had broken through the delusion of his personality, *sakkaya-diṭṭhi*, as a permanent self.

The second talk, the Discourse on Not-self, completed the process of liberating all five companions. So this is the discourse we need to understand: it is the platform of this particular teaching about not-self.

THE DISCOURSE ON NOT-SELF: ANATTALAKKHANA SUTTA

To make the text easier to understand, I have translated it liberally. This link allows you to see how it is more literally rendered:

<http://www.accesstoinsight.org/tipitaka/sn/sn22/sn22.059.than.html>

In our culture, a religious person tends to think of the human being as made up of three parts: body, mind and spirit or soul. Scientific materialists would not believe in a soul or spirit and would go so far as to say that mind and consciousness are 'emergent properties' arising out of the body which, again from a strictly physics point of view, is just sub-atomic energy fields.

The Buddha, keeping his teaching around dukkha (unsatisfactoriness), divided the human into five khandas or aggregates: the physical body; feelings and sensations of the senses; perceptions; volitional formations, our habits formed by our intentions; and consciousness. We shall see the purpose of this as we go through the different sections of the Discourse.

SECTION 1: IDENTITY AND OWNERSHIP:

The Body

Friends, the body is not-self. Were my body my self, then this body would not be experienced as suffering and unsatisfactory for I could say to the body: 'Let my body be like this; let my body not be like this.' But because the body is not-self, it will still suffer and remain unsatisfactory, for no one has such power over their body to say: 'Let my body be like this; let my body not be like this.'

So the Buddha asks us to investigate and see for ourselves what power we have over the body. Now we can wave our arms about and walk here and there. When it comes to Olympic stature, it is amazing what we can do with the body.

But this is similar to a driver of a car. We can make it go slow or fast, turn left or right, but when the car coughs and grinds to a halt, then we know we are not fully in charge, even though it feels like that when we are driving.

So it is with the body. Consider: who heals the body when we cut ourselves? Our job is

to keep it antiseptic. The body does the rest. Can we stop the body from falling ill or dying? Do we have direct control over organs such as liver, stomach, intestines and so on? Generally speaking we don't have a clue what they are doing and certainly not how they are doing it. The body has a life of its own. When we sit down and really go through the body bit by bit and ask ourselves: 'Do I know what this is doing or how it is doing it. And what control do I have over it', we find that the sense of 'This body is me or this body is mine' is pretty deluded. We would be better off thinking we were renting the body.

Feelings

Friends, feelings are not-self. Were feelings my self, then feelings would not be experienced as suffering and unsatisfactory. For one could say: 'Let me experience this feeling; let me not experience that feeling.' But because feelings are not-self, we will still suffer from them and find them wanting, for no one has such power over feelings to say to it: 'Let me experience this feeling; let me not experience that feeling.'

The word 'feelings' here translates from the word vedana which includes all bodily sensations caused by the body, such as pain in the knees from the sitting posture. These also include the sensations coming from the other four senses – sight, hearing, smelling and tasting. And it refers also to all the feelings in the body caused by the mind, such as heat and restlessness when we are angry. Any sensations or feelings in the body are all vedana.

Let us consider. If you bang your head against an open cupboard, can you stop the pain by ordering it away? When you wake in the morning and feel anxious, can you stop the mild nausea by ordering it to leave? Can you command yourself never again to feel angry, distressed or anxious? Can you make any feeling of happiness continue indefinitely?

When we explore the power we have over painful sensations or feelings we again experience our limitations. We can only ignore or soothe them to a point, such as rubbing our bruised heads or

hugging ourselves in our distress.

Even when we want to cause ourselves unpleasant sensation such as sipping tea to test its heat, or unpleasant feelings such as watching a horror film, we do not directly cause feelings and we have no control over them when they emerge.

Perceptions

Friends, perceptions are not-self. Were perceptions my self, then perceptions would not be

experienced as suffering and unsatisfactory. For one could say: 'Let me experience this perception; let me not experience that perception.' But because perceptions are not-self, we will

still suffer from them and find them wanting, for no one has such power over perceptions to say

to them: 'Let me experience this perception; let me not experience that perception.'

Perception here translates the word *sañña*. When we experience anything, the mind makes a mental picture of it and

these pictures turn into concrete concepts. We then attach a word to them, shorthand for that concept. On first

tasting tea, the mind makes a copy and calls it tea. Next time, we recognise the taste. If we taste many types of tea,

our perception will grow finer and finer. We may even become professional tasters. In this way, a collection of

perceptions arrives at a concrete concept. This also happens at the more refined level of art and philosophy and so

we reach abstract concepts. All these perceptions and concepts lie dormant until circumstance brings them to mind.

Consider this. When you direct your eyes towards a flower, the eye as the primary sense base and the brain-mind

complex cause us to see a shape and the colour. Past experience tells us it is a red rose. Only when the mind offers

that definition do we know what we are looking at. We know when we are looking at a flower we have never seen

before because we have no former perception of it nor a concept-word for it. If we take this formula into everyday

experience – nature, people, places and so on – we shall find the same mechanism.

What power or control do we have over this process? Can we stop the perception of 'tea' when tasting tea? Can we

change the perception of a red rose when we are looking at it? When a person is mentioned whom we know, can we stop their image or name from arising? And if we have forgotten the face or name, can we make it come back into memory? You may understand, as you read, how the free market and monetarism work, but then have difficulty recalling the facts. Sañña here refers not to reasoning, but to the percepts and concepts that reasoning uses, much as a painter uses different hues to produce a picture. But again we find our power over the process of perceiving is limited. We cannot stop the eye seeing once it is open, though we can intentionally look at something. We cannot stop the ear from hearing, though we can deliberately listen to something. We can put what we want onto the tongue, but we rely on the taste buds for the taste. We can enjoy art, nature and relationships only in so far as our sense bases will allow us. Only in so far as our brains and minds can remember and process the data.

Habits

Friends, habits are not-self. Were habits my self, then habits would not be experienced as suffering and unsatisfying. For one could to say: 'Let me experience this habit; let me not experience that habit.' But because habits are not-self, we will still suffer from them and find them wanting, for no one has such power over habits to say to them: 'Let me experience this habit; let me not experience that habit.'

The word 'habit' here translates saṅkhâra, a difficult word to explain. It has been variously interpreted as volitional conditionings, volitional formations, mental fabrications, determinations, preparations, and even concoctions. For our purposes, saṅkhâra are the mental states or mental habits that we create through our intentions and will. It's the will (cetana) that is crucial here for it is that power that actualises our desires. Up until now with body, feelings and perceptions, we have seen we have very minimal control. But in this instance we do create our own mental states from all the joyous, happy ones to all the miserable and despairing ones. And it is here

we develop our habits of thinking and imagining. However, once we have developed a habit, we find again we have minimal control. If we have taught ourselves to get angry when the bus is late, whether we want to or not, when the bus comes late anger arises. If we have taught ourselves to get excited about and glued to the TV screen when Wimbledon is on, we find it painful when we can't gratify that desire. If we have taught ourselves to daydream a lot, we find the mind daydreaming even when we don't want it to. Habits cannot be annihilated at will. What causes these mental habits to control us is that they are attitudes that can be transferred onto other objects. We can get angry with anything that displeases us and excited about anything that pleases us. We can intellectualise or fantasise about anything. And so we swing from negative to positive depending on the situation. When we meditate, we find these mental habits arise, often without reason. If they are negative, we can choose to ignore them by distracting ourselves, react with anger or fear, or bear with them. We can, of course, practise vipassana on them. But we can't get rid of them simply by an act of will. We can determine as much as we may: 'I will not be angry ever again'; 'I will not allow myself to get so insanely excited about tennis'; 'I will stop daydreaming!' But it usually doesn't work and if it does, we will be suppressing them and we know that won't do us any good. Paradoxically, we don't want to get rid of habits. What we want is for them to help create happiness and support our endeavour to become liberated. The Buddha had habits. They were always beautiful and spontaneous to the situation for even he could not stop rejoicing when someone accepted his teaching and training. Indeed he says of those who attain nibbanic consciousness that they are 'happy and with it, contented'. Because they are beautiful, in

harmony with the situation and especially spontaneous, they no longer cause suffering. Suffering arises because of clinging, attachment, expectation and so on. Consciousness

Friends, consciousness is not-self. Were consciousness my self, then this consciousness would not be experienced as suffering or unsatisfactory, and one could say to consciousness: 'Let consciousness be like this; let consciousness not be like this.' But because consciousness is not-self, it is experienced as suffering and unsatisfactory, for no one has such power over cognition to say to it: 'Let consciousness be like this; let consciousness not be like this.' The word 'consciousness' here translates *viññāna*. These days consciousness has come under the scrutiny of science and its usage now as before is varied. You can access Wikipedia: <http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Consciousness> to find out the various usages of consciousness. The situation is made complicated by the various ways the Buddha uses *viññāna*.

The best way I can describe consciousness as an Aggregate is to ask you to imagine a multidimensional screen which can hold sensations and feelings; moods and emotions; thoughts and images. That screen is *viññāna*. And it is within this screen that habits manifest and activate. So what control have we over the processes of consciousness? It happens automatically if the information coming into the brain-mind complex is sufficiently strong enough. Sometimes because we are engrossed in something, we fail to hear the doorbell. Other times, we are not so concentrated and we become conscious that a door bell is ringing.

SECTION 2: IMPERMANENCE AND UNSATISFACTORINESS

In this section, the Buddha introduces the other two Characteristics of Existence: impermanence and

unsatisfactoriness. Here it is set out as a dialogue.

Friends, what do you think? Is the body permanent or impermanent?

It's impermanent.

When the body is ever changing [and not under our control] does that satisfy us or not?

It does not satisfy us.

So if the body is impermanent and unsatisfactory because it is subject to change, should we be

saying, 'This body is mine. I am my body. My body is my Self, my Soul?'

No, we shouldn't.

The same questions are asked about the other four khanda or aggregates: feelings, perceptions, habits and consciousness. All are impermanent and unsatisfactory and therefore we cannot say of them: 'This is mine. I am this ... My ... is my Self, my Soul.'

The Buddha is not saying here that we cannot enjoy the pleasures and joys of life. He is instead arguing that they cannot be permanent and therefore from a Self or Soul's point of view, they are just not going to satisfy.

He then drives the point home.

Therefore, friends, considering any kind of body or indeed any material form, whether of the past, the future or as we experience it in the present, whether it is obvious or subtle, within oneself or outside oneself, near or far, we must correctly say of any of it, "This is not mine, this is not me, this is not myself."

And the same formula is repeated for feeling, perception, habits and consciousness.

A WAY OF PRACTISING TO REALISE ANNATA

Vipassana – Insight Meditation

In our practice of vipassana we are attempting to realise these insights for ourselves. One advantage of the noting technique is that it directs us to what is being observed or felt. On the breath when we note 'rising', we could say 'there's rising'. If there's a pain, we could note, 'there's pain'. If there is anxiety, 'there's anxiety'. By doing this we create a separation between that which knows and what is known. There is a mental distance between the two.

When this becomes clear to us, the sense of being the knower becomes more acute. And this process of objectifying what we experience has been going on since birth.

Margaret Schönberger Mahler

Margaret Mahler (May 10, 1897 – October 2, 1985), a Hungarian physician became interested in psychiatry. She was one of the most important figures within psychoanalysis. Her main interest was in normal childhood development, but she spent much of her time with psychiatric children and discovered how they

arrived at a sense of self. Mahler developed the Separation-Individuation theory of child development. She observed three stages of development: The first, 'autistic' stage lasts from birth for about four weeks. It begins with the infant inhabiting its own world, unaware of anything outside its 'self'. There are no 'objects'. From the fifth week, it starts to objectify. Usually the first object is the mother since she is tending to its needs. This process of objectifying into a 'symbiotic' relationship lasts until the fifth month. Yet even so the other is as yet not entirely separate from the infant. There is a vague understanding that somehow someone soothes and feeds. The baby begins to smile, but it is still within an interpersonal relationship so it reacts to the mother's moods as if they were its own. Mahler says that at this stage the infant is categorising the pleasant from the unpleasant (in other words beginning to experience vedana, feeling, whereby we begin to experience the world as either pleasant or unpleasant.) As yet the baby is still 'pre-objectal'. The third and final stage to individuation is more complex and has a series of steps. From the fifth month to the tenth month, (these times are approximate), the 'differentiation' sub-phase, the self and object become more differentiated. One sign is that the infant becomes afraid of strangers. It is as though up until then the infant has been looking and now realises that 'others' out there are looking at it! Then the 'practising' sub-phase begins where the infant can crawl away and physically separate itself from mother. Mahler calls this 'hatching'. The infant still needs mother for 'emotional refuelling' and returns constantly. By the end of this phase, the infant is upright and actively exploring the world. Finally there is the 'rapprochement' sub-phase, between 15 and 18-30 months and even to two and half years, the child now begins to speak to others and significant others, like father, appear. There is a great self-assertion (the terrible twos for example) and slowly the child establishes its 'self' as himself or herself. In all it is not until the age of three that the child has objectified the outer world from itself and is able to say

confidently, 'I am a girl.', 'I am a boy'.

Objectifying the Inner World

The process of 'awakening' is the slow realisation that we are not 'the world'. Just as the infant begins to separate from the outer world to discover itself as a unique individual, the meditator is taking this process into the inner world.

We discover that we have been internally 'autistic'. We have believed ourselves to 'be' this psychophysical organism.

We then begin to differentiate between the observer, the feeler, the experiencer and what is being observed, felt and experienced, that is the knower from the known.

In terms of the khanda, the five aggregates, the body with its movements is seen as an object. We can watch our hands washing pots. Feelings derived from emotions and sensations in the body are clearly separate from the experiencing of them, just as the carpet felt is separate from the foot feeling it. At a more subtle level, when the

eyes are closed, perceptions are seen as images or cognised as concepts arising in the mind. Yes even thoughts can be perceived as objects. And at the most subtle level the screen upon which all this is happening can be experienced as an object – the screen of consciousness*.

Through this process of objectifying the interior life, the knower individuates. Yet a strong sense of a self persists: 'I am the knower.'

Beyond the Knower

So now we come to the final barrier to realising what the Buddha refers to as the 'not-born, not-created, not-subject to conditions' and so on. The feel of presence, what I earlier referred to as the 'soul', is the mirror image of the 'knowing' in the screen of consciousness.

When we see our reflection in a mirror we think this is how our face looks. If we take another mirror to view the first reflection and look into that, then we see how our face really looks like. (If you haven't done this you may be in for a shock ... or surprise.)

Similarly, we believe ‘self-awareness’, awareness-of-me, is what we are. However, in the same way that we have come to realise that whatever we experience as an object, whatever we are aware of, cannot be ‘me’, so we can’t ‘be’ the ‘self’ in the self-awareness! So now we must investigate this ‘feeling of presence’, self-awareness.. By making this feeling of a self the object of our vipassana, that is, just to sit in its presence with curiosity – and this is best done when tranquillity of body, heart and mind are established – the realisation, by direct experience, of the Nibbana dhatu, the principle or element of Nibbana is available. To know the Nibbana dhatu is also to know the Tathagata dhatu, the Buddha principle or element. (Southern Buddhism tries to avoid ‘personalising’ the experience. Northern Buddhism feels at ease referring to this as Buddha Nature/Mind.) That’s the why Buddha says in the Dhammapada No.372: those who are steady in attention and insightful are in the presence of Nibbana.

Spiritual Purpose of Human Life

Now we come to know the purpose of being here as humans. This is the realm of existence the Buddha points to as the best for awakening. It has the inherent pain of the body and the unsatisfactory nature of all the pleasures and joys of life – and the intuitive awareness to know it. It is the dukkha, the unsatisfactoriness of the world that drives us to seek the end of dukkha. All we ever wanted was to be happy. All we are doing is seeking it in the wrong place.

Yet even the Buddha continued to suffer physical pain and pleasant sensations; sorrowful occasions arose and so did joyful ones. A different relationship to this world was established, however. Seeking undiluted and ever present happiness in the sensual world, both inner and outer, was over, for the Buddha was grounded in the inner unchanging happiness of Nibbana.

CONCLUSION

We know through our practice that the outer and inner worlds become more bearable when burdensome and more enjoyable when delightful. But can we have some idea of what Nibbanic happiness might be like?

When we have clearly established the knower within ourselves, when the body is still, the heart calmed and mind silent, after we have been in that state of the equanimous observer, feeler, experiencer, we can ask ourselves what were the inner factors of the knower. When we recognise the inner qualities of the one who knows, we will know why all spirituality is drawn to silence.

Ethical Maxims for a Marginally Inhabitable Planet

Noirin Sheahan · 32 min read

This essay presents six ethical maxims developed by bioethicists to address the moral challenges of the Anthropocene and coming climate catastrophe. Drawing from decades of experience in ICUs and hospice care, the authors propose practical wisdom for navigating environmental and social collapse projected for 2031 and beyond. The six maxims are: work hard to grasp the immensity of change; cultivate radical hope beyond ordinary optimism; have a line in the sand regarding what you will not do; appreciate the astonishing opportunity of living during this extraordinary transition; train your body and mind for physiological and psychological resilience; and act for future generations of all species. Unlike abstract principles requiring cognitive analysis, these maxims function as practical guides for embodied moral action during extreme circumstances. The essay acknowledges that traditional bioethics has neglected environmental ethics, arguing that the field must expand beyond biomedicine to address the broader ethical challenges of living on an increasingly uninhabitable planet. Each maxim is grounded in clinical experience with patients facing terminal diagnoses and impossible choices, extrapolated to the collective human predicament of climate emergency.

Ethical Maxims for a Marginally Inhabitable Planet

David Schenck and Larry R. Churchill†

ABSTRACT Bioethics has largely neglected the Anthropocene and its ethical challenges. This essay asks which ethical norms will serve us well in the face of the coming climate catastrophe. It sketches the climate changes likely for the year 2031 and offers six adaptive maxims, drawn from bioethics work in ICUs and hospices, to guide us through the devastation and transition following environmental and social collapse. These six maxims are: work hard to grasp the immensity of the change; cultivate radical hope; have a line in the sand; appreciate the astonishing opportunity of life at this time; train your body and mind; and act for the future generations of all species. Because we are already in an environmental collapse and the beginnings of social collapse, these maxims are relevant today as well as for the future.

The new solidarity of fate is as yet nowhere matched by the solidarity of our feelings, let alone our actions.

—Z. Bauman (2009)

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very person living on the planet now, and all who will be born, will be impacted by the climate emergency of the Anthropocene. In this essay we challenge bioethicists specifically to think about what resources our field may have to offer for addressing the moral crisis this development represents, as well

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as the new moral challenges and dilemmas it will generate. In particular, we address this essay and its thought experiments to our junior colleagues and former students, who will be the ones among us who will confront the moral, social, and environmental crises most directly.

We are both now in our 70s. Like almost all working in bioethics, we have been asleep at the wheel for more than three decades. None of us has paid nearly enough attention to the fact that bioethics ought primarily to be framed as ethics for the bios, not merely for biomedicine. Van Rensselaer Potter's *Bioethics: Bridge to the Future* (1971), deserved far greater attention than it received. And there have been others seeking to awaken us. In 1999, in his book *The Great Work: Our Way into the Future*, the geologist Thomas Berry argued for a larger scope for medicine, and concomitantly, for bioethics:

The profession of medicine must now consider its role, not only within the context of human society, but in the context of the Earth process. A healing of the Earth is a prerequisite for the healing of the human. Adjustment of the human to the conditions and restraints of the natural world constitutes the primary medical prescription for human well-being. The medical profession needs to establish a way of sustaining the species as well as the individual if the human is to be viable as a species within the community of species. (69)

But these voices went almost completely unheeded. With a few exceptions scattered over the last 15 years (Brody 2009; Johnson 2016; Lee 2017; Moreno 2005; Pierce and Jameton 2004; Richie 2019), the field has remained steadfastly focused on biomedicine and its issues. But now the larger viewpoint—what Berry (1999) called “macrophase ethics”—is being forced upon us. The role of tipping points and cascade effects is now much clearer and more terrifying. The higher qual-

ity of data has shown how much faster things are moving than was previously thought, and the new amounts of historical data have shown us how quickly change can happen. On top of that, better modeling shows us more clearly just how impossible things will get on an Earth at an increase of 3° Celsius (C)—or even 2 or 2.5.

A Barely Conceivable Challenge

The specific aim of this essay is to explore what ethical maxims might guide us in the year 2031. Our assumption is that the current devastating trajectory for global warming will continue, or deviate only slightly. We wish we could be more optimistic, but there is little reason to think that technological remedies of sufficient scale are achievable any time soon, or that needed lifestyle adjustments in energy consumption are feasible—especially for American culture. Hence, a 2.5° C rise in global temperature over preindustrial levels is a strong possibility, possibly as early as 2041. If this is the case, humanity will be facing social, financial, and political collapse on a global scale. There will be death and suffering from immediate climate events of unprecedented magnitude, such as frequent and severe storms, flooding, heat waves, and fires, resulting in famine, food and water shortages, pandemics, wars large and small, and economic and social insecurities on a level only the poorest of nations have ever experienced. We can always hope for less devastation, but typical American optimism at this juncture bespeaks either ignorance or denial. Had we responded 30 years ago, when the science was already clear enough to motivate different policies, we might hope for more, but now, in 2021, the task is increasingly difficult, and the timeframe for adjustment is radically shortened. Given these assumptions, it becomes important to ask what kind of ethics—what kind of moral guidance for living in this severely depleted environment—will be needed. The challenge of getting our bodies as well as our minds around the hyper-complex phenomenon of the Anthropocene is staggering enough. But when combined with the projected ethical challenges and existential agonies these environmental transformations will entail, the prospect becomes almost unthinkable. Yet we must face these issues, for the alternative is moral nihilism.

It is important to grasp that our situation constitutes a singularity. There is no previous extinction event in recorded history to reflect on and learn from. As Mark Lynas (2020) has observed, one would have to “wind the geological clock back about 3 million years, to an epic called the Pliocene, to encounter a world where global temperatures averaged 2–3 degrees higher than at the start of the

20th century.” We do have five other mass extinction events to bring to our consideration of this sixth mass extinction event, and we also have the extinction of other species who reached an evolutionary dead end, all of which we could use to model the possible eventual end of *Homo sapiens*. But just as knowing that other people have died is not the same as realizing that we ourselves will die, so too knowing that other species go extinct is not the same as fully grasping the possibility of the extinction of our own species. And, of course, making the leap from our own personal death—hard as that may be to grasp—to the possible end of human life itself will hardly be easy. Human extinction is not currently on the horizon, but as the planet becomes less and less hospitable to other species, we can no longer assume that it will always be hospitable to us. How to cancel the assumption that human life will go on indefinitely after our individual death? To even pose this possibility is to generate, for most of us, a degree of anxiety and distress that makes it difficult even to continue the inquiry.

But that precisely is the point; that precisely is why it is important to push on. And what we suggest is that we would be well served to look in new directions for resources. So far, we have relied on scientists and investigative journalists to keep us informed and to rally us to action. But their work has induced a curious, counter-intuitive phenomenon: the domestication of horror. Scientists study and measure; journalists interpret and report. The better job scientists and journalists

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do in analyzing and explaining things, the more they tame the horror of what is coming. Furthermore, they teach us to approach the Anthropocene as observers, but this is problematic: no one will be an observer at an increase of 3° C. We must move from a cognitive, observer understanding of our situation to a felt embodiment of our predicament, from intellectual knowledge to bodily acknowledgment. Resources for reflection may possibly be found in practical disciplines developed for dealing with human extremes, such as refugee communities, famines, and end-of-life scenarios. Resources may also be found in communities that have faced immense suffering: indigenous peoples, survivors of concentration camps and solitary confinement, and oppressed or enslaved communities of color. We are recommending, in short, that we consult people who have dealt with situations where one set of hopes, and all fantastical thinking, have to be abandoned, and new radical hope has to be found. Our own contribution to this discussion will draw on our decades of experience in clinical bioethics consultation, which has focused on care and decision making in catastrophic, life-threatening, and end-of-life situations.

We make no claim to finality or completeness for the ethical maxims we will highlight below. Our intention is to contribute to the nascent conceptualization and discussion of the barely conceivable and yet largely undiscussed catastrophe of global warming. We encourage other bioethicists, as well as those with experience with endangered communities, to join this discussion. All of us as human beings are finally being forced to confront this climate emergency: it is not off in the future. The recent Australian and European flooding is climate flooding, just as the California fires of 2020 and 2021 are climate fires. Confronting our predicament means facing head-on the oft-avoided and grim fact that our children and grandchildren, and their descendants on down the line, will be dealing with the ramifications of the Anthropocene for decades and centuries to come.

The World in 2031

So what will the world be like in 2031? Start here: we are carbonizing the atmosphere at an alarming rate. Half of the total carbon pollution on Earth has been emitted in the last 30 years, notably after there was scientific consensus that greenhouse gases (GHGs)—carbon dioxide, methane, and nitrous oxide—are a grave threat. Temperature accelerations are causing polar ice to melt, permafrost regions to shrink, and oceans to warm and rise. Hurricanes and other severe weather events are increasing in number and severity. Houston has had a so-called “once every 500-year storm” in each of the past three years. The fires in California and Oregon are unprecedented and promise to worsen in frequency and devastation. Meanwhile, tropical rain forests in places like Brazil, which store and thus help control carbon emissions, are being systematically cleared for farming and ranching. Changing consumption habits have also fueled the rise of

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GHGs. The increase in meat eating in developing countries like China is a notable example. It is estimated that the GHGs emitted from all livestock globally accounts for 14.5 % of all GHGs (FAO 2020).

What will be the effects of global warming? The Paris Agreement of 2015, signed by 196 nations, is an aspiration to keep global warming to below 1.5° C above preindustrial levels. We are currently at 1.1, and a rise to 2.3° is already locked into the atmosphere from the carbon we have emitted in the past 30 years, even if we went to zero emissions today. Just how soon we will reach the 2.3° level is uncertain, but every day of continued emissions brings it sooner. If we link temperature change to sea level rise, 1.5° C in global warming translates into a rise of 1–2.5 feet. If this goal is not met, a 2° C rise in temperatures means a sea level rise of 3–6 feet, affecting everyone on the globe. Perhaps most notably, the

number of climate refugees from flooding, fires, and drought would enlarge, to as many as 245 million people. If global warming reaches 3.5–4° C over preindustrial levels, sea level rise will be 22–25 feet, with devastation of almost unimaginable magnitude (Maslin 2014; Wallace-Wells 2019). Massive deaths, especially among the world's poorest populations, will occur as a result of uninhabitable land, food and water shortages, and the subsequent breakdown of economies and national governments. To use potable water as just one index, currently a quarter of Earth's population is water stressed. This means that 1.95 billion people currently struggle to meet their daily needs for clean water. By 2030, the increased salination of irrigated farmland, the evaporation caused by increased heat, and frequent flooding of coastal areas will mean that an additional billion people will be without a safe source of drinkable water (Maslin 2014).

Another index is infectious diseases. Vector organisms, such as mosquitoes, are sensitive to changes like water-surface temperature, humidity, moisture, and deforestation. Climate warming would affect both the scope, intensity, and seasonality of infectious diseases such as malaria and cholera. In general, global warming will mean a substantial increase in transmission of disease worldwide (Maslin 2014). This is to say nothing of health events such as heat emergencies, mental health disorders, and broader health problems caused by declining food supply, food safety, and its consequences (Jameton 2016).

How fast will all this happen? If a business-as-usual pattern prevails and warning signs are ignored, a 2.5–3° C rise could occur as early as the early 2030s, 3–4° by mid-century, and a 5–6° rise by 2100 (Lynas 2020). Much depends on which scientific modeling of climate change turns out to be the correct one. For example, it is still unknown whether temperature will rise at a predictably steady pace with the rise of GHGs, or whether there is a tipping point, caused by a complex of feedback loops, beyond which devastating changes cascade and accelerate (Bendell 2020). What we know about past climate changes is that they appear to have been abrupt, and climate models for these sudden changes are hard to simulate. Nonlinear, cascading changes in the severity of global warming

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and its accompanying catastrophes is a high probability. Much depends as well on how quickly the world can move to green technologies like solar and wind power, electric cars, and built structures with zero GHG emissions (Miller 2020). Yet scaling up technologies such as these usually requires decades. And even if massive technological changes in how energy is produced all work perfectly, all over the globe, they will be insufficient if the cultural patterns of consumptive

capitalism, economies based on growth, and habits of increasing—rather than curtailing—energy use persist.

Mitigation and Adaptation, Collapse and Transition

Mitigation and adaptation represent two prominent ways to talk about surviving global warming. Mitigation means lessening the degrading effects of the Anthropocene, usually through technological ingenuity. Adaptation means accommodating to a new human experience through moral, social, economic, and political adjustments. These are not, of course, mutually exclusive, since any mitigating strategies will also involve adaptations, and successful adaptations both require some degree of mitigation and may also uncover novel strategies for lessening the rate of environmental degradation.

There are numerous reports of the promise of mitigating geotechnologies for carbon capture, such as vacuuming carbon dioxide out of the air and sending it into space or turning it into rock, reforestation, shooting particles into space to block sunlight, and quick conversions to solar and wind energy to replace coal and other fossil fuels (Kolbert 2021). Yet a true turnaround of our carbon-based economy will not come easily or quickly. Even in the US and Europe, where global warming is perhaps most widely understood, the political obstacles are daunting. The fossil fuel industry has hidden its own decades-long research showing the degrading effects for the Earth resulting from rapacious coal, gas, and oil production. Their legislative lobbies are well entrenched and powerful, and these companies—much like the tobacco companies in the mid-20th century—have shown clearly that they are willing to tolerate a great deal of human suffering in order to pursue profits. In addition, it is highly unlikely that the growing carbon footprints of China, India, and other rising industrial giants will be sufficiently curtailed. Reliance on mitigation through technological innovation looks more like fantasy and folly than prudence. While we believe that an all-out effort to engineer and adopt cleaner technologies should be mounted, counting on these as the solution grossly underestimates the magnitude of the task and amount of social and political change required. Thus, we are focused in this essay on moral and social adaptation.

If, as is likely, mitigation is too late, or if it fails completely, adaptation will be the task. And thinking seriously about adaptation means thinking about collapse—for some forms of collapse seem inevitable and part of what adaptation
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will have to take into account. “Collapsology” is a nascent field (Servigne and Stevens 2020), and thinking in this way is not a matter of counseling people to

give up. It is suggesting the cultural equivalent of “advance directives.” If you find yourself in a spot where mitigation has failed, and adaptation is what must be done, what will you be focused on? Will it be anger, regret, competition, survival? Or will it be living what life is available with as much quality as possible? We think it likely that by 2031 mitigation will be seen to have largely failed, and that adaptation to social and environmental collapse will be the task that is left. We assume that this means major portions of the planet will be facing the kinds of major transitions that people face in hospitals, ICUs, and hospices every day.

It is impossible to know with any certainty how severe the environmental and social collapse will be—in most places, it will probably not be as bad as the total lawlessness of “Mad Max” scenarios. Yet radical shifts will be required everywhere to manage a future more altered in living conditions and expectations than anything in human memory.

The second pairing, collapse and transition, is needed because both environmental and social “collapse” have to be part of any realistic assessment. And while neither kind of collapse is likely to be total, we must talk also of “transition.” If a total collapse (of either kind) occurs, it is more likely to come from engineering misadventures in the efforts at mitigation, not from global warming per se. (Shooting particles into space to block the sun’s rays seems a likely candidate for this kind of blundering hubris.) Good adaptation methods figure heavily into whatever transition may be possible, making for a softer landing and shorter horror, with more resources surviving to power recovery on other side. But to be clear, some environmental and social collapse seems unavoidable, meaning suffering and death on a scale no one alive has ever seen. Hence, a caveat: the use of these pairs of stark terms—mitigation and adaptation, collapse and transition—when used as a shorthand, as we are now doing, can become an intellectualized, distancing force shielding us from the horrid realities under discussion. We must move with care so as not to leave the distress behind, stewing in our bodies and psyches, while we talk abstractions. Any hope of mitigation or adaptation, or transiting out of social collapse, will require all the cognitive and emotional resources we have—minds and bodies all working with knowledge and in acknowledgment, and in concert.

Six Ethical Maxims for a Time of Collapse

Unlike principles, which are guides for how to think, pointing out moral values which could guide our cognitive processes, maxims are short guides for how to act, and they suggest practices to which we should become habituated. They often take the form of wisdom sayings and draw less from modern philosophy than

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from ancient philosophy and wisdom literature. Maxims are less how to analyze and choose and more how to be. They constitute ideas that must be practiced to be fully understood. In this way they resemble more the moral virtues than principled decision guides so familiar to bioethicists.

When describing the need for striking and memorable maxims, Pierre Hadot (1995) puts it this way:

when the time comes, they can help us accept such [catastrophic] events, which are, after all, part of the course of nature; we will thus have these maxims and sentences “at hand.” What we need are persuasive formulae . . . which we can repeat to ourselves in difficult circumstances, so as to check movements of fear, anger, or sadness. The exercise of meditation [on maxims] is an attempt to control inner discourse, in an effort to render it coherent.

Thus, in the sense we employ here, maxims are slogans, mnemonic reminders, and ultimately spiritual exercises. In a crisis, shorthand reminders of core values work better than principles that require reflective interpretation and application. In addition, the basic principles we now use most often in bioethics were crafted for an age of relative abundance, stability, and progress. Meditating on maxims ahead of time helps to shape a more realistic view of the world and habituates us, so that when the time comes, we are more likely to behave in a way ethically appropriate to the reality before us. In short, maxims can be especially useful in times of moral crisis and major cultural change. They help establish conditions that will preserve moral creativity and resourcefulness. They can be essential moral components for surviving the inevitable transitions before us.

Maxims present means of living one’s life in a coherent and honorable way in the midst of great trouble. This is in significant part why we are proposing maxims, and not principles or theories. An autonomy-driven ethic, pictured as enacted by rational, independent agents—whether deontological or utilitarian—fits all too well with the neoliberal world order, under which regime the Anthropocene has accelerated. Both the dominance of the hyper-individualistic autonomy ethic characteristic of neoliberalism and the attendant ubiquity of the utilitarian calculus—and indeed the neoliberal order itself—are inconceivable without the abundance, even superfluity, sponsored by fossil fuels. We thus endorse the critique of principlism and utilitarianism found in the ethics of care. But we are here looking deeper—we are looking for how the very idea of ethical behavior can survive in extreme conditions. Because we know that often it does not.

And this is where maxims and bioethics comes together. The maxims have ancient origins. Variants of them have been followed when dealing with human catastrophes in the past, mostly in periods in which there was far less optimism,

reliance on rational analysis, or faith in technical ingenuity. But, equally as decisive, we have seen these maxims at work in hospitals and hospices. Much of what we know about them has been learned from patients and families while doing

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ethics consultation or working in ICUs and hospices. And while it is true that collapse will involve a collection of large-scale events, all impacts will be individual and personal as well. What we have observed in the field confirms, we would argue, teachings of the world's wisdom traditions that have stood the test of times of scarcity and hardship, of social disruption, of natural catastrophe.

To be clear, we are not arguing that these maxims are the total ethics needed for the Anthropocene. To begin with, the complicity of our ethical traditions in creating the Anthropocene must be acknowledged, and this ought to prompt a revolution in approach to the foundations of bioethics. Perhaps an ethics of care should come to the fore, and an ethic of biophilia, as expounded by Eric Fromm (1973) and especially by Edward O. Wilson (1984)—developed in *Bioethics: A Path Forward* (forthcoming) by Nancy King, Gail Henderson, and Larry Churchill—should be carefully examined for its value as a foundational norm. And then there will be the many specific activities aimed at mitigation of the ongoing crisis that will certainly be needed. What we offer here is but a bare beginning. Our intention is to provoke discussion and to provide a fruitful place for that discussion to begin.

For each of the six maxims that follow we provide:

- Maxim: a formulation cast as an injunction, as is common in wisdom traditions;
- Basis: vignettes and examples from ethics consultation and bioethics that illustrate or clarify the injunctions, and texts from the 20th and 21st centuries that have been helpful to us in our reflections on the Anthropocene;
- Extrapolation: suggestions of how the maxim and basis will be useful in a time of climate emergency.

Maxim 1: Work Hard to Grasp the Immensity.

Realize how fiendishly difficult it is to grasp the scope of climate devastation oneself. Realize how hard it is for others. Effective strategy, as well as compassion, require carefully assessing the capacity of one's listeners. In keeping with this, these maxims suggest a progression. One step at a time. Begin small. Asking people to go beyond their capacity can be cruel and is generally counterproductive.

Basis. As every clinical ethics consultant knows, it is always difficult to accept

bad news that has a finality to it, like a terminal or crippling diagnosis. But some things are even more difficult than that. Some turns of events demand a change in one's whole view of the world. We are thinking here in particular of cases in neonatal units where young, often first-time parents face their newly born children who have startlingly awful diagnoses and conditions. One of the very worst we have ever worked with is a severe case of Osteogenesis imperfecta, a condition

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where the bones in the newborn's body break incredibly easily. Bone formation is flawed. There is essentially no reliable skeleton, and nurses changing diapers know they are breaking bones every time they move the child. This is not only a tragedy; it is something that goes beyond the bounds of the conceivable for many young parents. The world simply cannot be the kind of place where this can happen. And yet it is. And so the parents must reconstitute their world simply to be able to acknowledge what is in front of them.

Likewise, working with end-of-life scenarios, ethicists become acquainted with all manner of premature and tragic deaths. We can all think of cases of this kind that stretched our moral sensibilities: the young mother dying of undetectable cancer, leaving three kids behind; the star athlete dying of heat stroke through the neglect of his coaches; the healthy middle-aged man born with a Berry aneurysm that suddenly ruptures and kills him. Senseless events. How can the world be like this?

But to move beyond them, as we know from working with patients and families, it is essential to grasp just exactly what has happened. We also know that when that is done, new possibilities can be found on the other side of what looked like the endgame.

Extrapolation. The very possibility of environmental and subsequent social collapse is similarly inconceivable for most of us. How can humans have had this much impact on the natural order itself? Can we possibly unknowingly have perpetrated the extinction of thousands upon thousands of other species, and untold suffering of our own species?

The tragedies of bioethics work can give us insight into the moral nihilism senseless suffering can open onto. By moral nihilism we mean not only that past norms seem to lose their validity, but that 'right and wrong' as ways of interpreting our world are no longer anchored anywhere. And yet this sense of moral vacuity can in turn help us appreciate how difficult it is to face the Anthropocene directly. Moments of moral paralysis seem, in fact, to be a common experience for those coming to grips with the climate emergency and all that it implies. A

dose of moral nihilism may actually be essential for getting to the end of ordinary hope and allowing us to come truly into radical hope—to tap the resources that lie on the other side of ordinary hope, optimism, and reasonableness.

Maxim 2: Cultivate Radical Hope.

The kind of hope that reappears after optimism has died is hope that can be relied on. It is generally a hope that doesn't talk about or think of itself as hope. This means realizing the dangers of optimistic hope, of fantasyland and magical thinking. First, we must own our grief and anger. Second comes the realization that blaming ourselves and others doesn't help. Only when one reaches a certain level of despair can new resources of hope emerge, in oneself and in the new world in which one finds oneself. What is called for is a faith in a possible future, autumn 2021 • volume 64, number 4 503

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however improbable, embedded in action totally oriented to the situation (Lear 2006).

Basis. All of us who have worked in ICUs and with palliative care and hospice teams have watched patients and families adjust to what had seemed a hopeless situation. We recall one formerly homeless patient saying to us, "Well, Doc, if it weren't for AIDS, I'd be dead"—meaning that in coming to terms with AIDS, he had gotten himself off the street and had broken his addictions. We are also familiar with studies showing that survival rates for certain kinds of cancers are better for patients in hospice than out. By accepting a terminal diagnosis and redefining what counts as healing, an unexpected path for extended life opens up. Confirming this, the bioethicist Judith Andre (2015) talks about "open hope"; Joanna Macy speaks of "active hope" (Macy and Johnstone 2012); and Gabriel Marcel (1978) speaks of the hope that can arise when "hope-for" is released. Likewise, Albert Camus's 1947 novel *The Plague* and his 1946 essay *Neither Victim nor Executioners* are essential resources.

Extrapolation. How will you behave when there is no ordinary hope? What are the kinds of things you will always want to do—the way you want always to be, whether there is hope or not? For example, consider the central virtues of the hope that emerges beyond optimism: being kind, not abandoning people, behaving with integrity. The key is knowing that there is almost always room for something positive to be done. There are always openings, always gaps in the gloom. Practice for how you will behave when there is no more left to do—that is, when no telos-action or results-oriented action of any kind is possible.

Maxim 3: Have a Line in the Sand.

Know that there are some things you will not do, some modes of living you

will not embrace. Know that there are lives worse than death. Be prepared to die. Basis. This maxim is the core insight behind the practice of formulating advance directives. At what point is it time to stop? We are thinking of hospice patients who asked that their tube feedings be stopped, and the candidate for a brain surgery to de-bulk a benign tumor who declined the procedure, because life in the hospital and rehab was simply unpalatable to him. (Interestingly enough, he lived far longer than his projected life expectancy had he had the surgery.) For those of us in health care, there are the sobering lessons from the horrific situation that developed at Memorial Hospital in New Orleans after Hurricane Katrina, as recounted in Sheri Fink's outstanding book, *Five Days at Memorial: Life and Death in a Storm-Ravaged Hospital* (2013). As floodwaters rose in the days after the storm, the hospital lost power when the grid failed, and then lost backup power when their generators were swamped. With no power, the ventilators and other life-supporting machines stopped working. There were no functioning monitors. Without air conditioning, temperatures in the sealed units rose rapidly. As the days went by, shortages of food and medicine developed. Gunfire was

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heard in the streets; police withdrew from the area because of the danger. Under these conditions, impossible triage decisions were made, and finally, over a dozen critically ill patients were injected with lethal doses of morphine and sedatives. Extrapolation. Post-Katrina New Orleans presents us with the kinds of scenarios that can be expected to be a regular occurrence as natural and social collapse unfold. Useful reflections on how to behave in such extreme situations come from the concentration camp writings of Victor Frankl and Etty Hillesum. There is also the example of Ludwig Wittgenstein, who urged his student Drury, who was preparing to go into combat in World War II, to decide ahead of time not to engage in hand-to-hand combat, but to be willing to be killed instead (Monk 1990).

Know what you will do, and what you will not. Max Weber formulated it this way in his classic lecture "Politics as a Vocation" (1919):

it is immensely moving when a mature man—no matter whether old or young in years—is aware of a responsibility for the consequences of his conduct and really feels such responsibility with heart and soul. He then acts by following an ethic of responsibility and somewhere he reaches the point where he says: "Here I stand; I can do no other." That is something genuinely human and moving. And every one of us who is not spiritually dead must realize the possibility of finding himself at some time in that position.

Considering the likely realities of collapse and transition, it seems probable that many people will find themselves facing these kinds of decisions, and something like an internal, ethical “advance directive” could prove beneficial. This is why, for example, emergency responders run through practice scenarios. The body and the imagination need to be encouraged to engage directly that which lies outside the normal. True, drawing lines in sands that are constantly shifting in a tricky business. One must be prepared, as well, to pivot and go in unexpected directions. But these pivots are more likely to be done well if one has prepared by imagining the worst and drawing practice lines in the sand.

Maxim 4: Appreciate the Astonishing and Unique Opportunity.

Appreciate the opportunity you have to accompany humanity in this extraordinary transition and to be present to the earth and the biosphere at this time. Appreciate how amazing our bodies are, as a perceiving sensorium, as movement and in activity, sponsoring emotion and thought. Be amazed at the interconnectedness of things and their astonishing complexity. Think small, alongside thinking very big.

Basis. One of the privileges of doing ethics consultation and research in clinical bioethics is the opportunity to meet remarkable people who handle their physical challenges with courage and grace. All of us who have done this work can think

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of examples. We cite here one from our book *What Patients Teach* (2013). The patient has abdominal cancer and is in the last weeks of her life:

There is no blessing like friends. I’ve had friends who came out of the woodwork, friends I hadn’t seen in a long time or who I only saw infrequently. I have been treated so lovingly; it’s just been overwhelming to me. I’m so very grateful that I had this year to spend this time with these people. It’s interesting. The two friends who have helped me the most have both said to me that they consider it a privilege to be able to do this. Which goes to show that many times the people in your life are willing to do more to help you out than one might have guessed. (109)

There are also well-known accounts of illness that confirm the blessings that can come in extremity if one is prepared to receive them. At the end of his account of his long dying of AIDS, Harold Brodkey (1996) says: “Peace? There was never any in the world. But in the pliable water, under the sky, unmoored, I am traveling now and hearing myself laugh, at first with nerves and then with genuine amazement. It is all around me” (177). And Arthur Frank (2002) summarizes his reflections on his own illnesses, and illness in general, this way: “The ultimate

value of illness is that it teaches us the value of being alive; this is why the ill are not just charity cases, but a presence to be valued Illness restores the sense of proportion that is lost when we take life for granted” (120). Cultivating gratitude: What could be more important? This is the message—from our patients, from the dying, from our great teachers.

Extrapolation. Our patients, and many people who have faced ethical extremity, teach the importance of the “little things.” We are thinking of Masha Gessen’s interview with the former Gulag prisoner talking about his old camp:

You should see it [Site Perm-36] in the summer. Some evenings there—the light is special, and the air—sometimes you’d be going behind the outhouse, because inside it was rather unpleasant and inconvenient and you avoided it if you could, so there you’d be, taking a piss behind the outhouse, and the air was like you could touch it, and the smell of those linden trees, and the sound of the birds singing. (Gessen and Friedman 2018)

This marvelous passage brings to mind the woman we interviewed years ago who had lost fingers in a textile mill, but whose main memory of work, the memory she stressed in her account, was of how beautiful the afternoon sunlight was as it shone on and through the running threads in the very spinning looms that had claimed her fingers.

Learn then to appreciate how amazing nature is, even in (or especially) the face of loss and change. Think of the amazing greens one finds when walking in landscapes after intense wildfire, or of the astonishing color photographs of Rich-

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ard Mosse capturing the (admittedly unearthly) beauty of the devastation of the Amazon (Maher 2021). Joanna Macy’s teaching work is especially helpful in its insistence on the blessing of our being alive during this amazing time: appreciate that there is anything at all, and that we have witnessed it (Macy and Johnstone 2012).

Maxim 5: Train Your Body and Your Mind.

Learn breathing exercises. Develop the physiological capacity to deal with despair. Despair isn’t just psychological, it’s physiological.

Learn skills for getting beyond ego—not just the cognitive limits of ego, which many are at least familiar with pondering, but the emotional and physiological limits of ego.

Basis. Those of us who have worked with colleagues in health care on issues related to moral distress and burnout are familiar with the power of bodily practices to mitigate and eventually assimilate trauma of all kinds. Included in such

practices would be mindfulness, yoga, cognitive-behavioral therapy, trauma release exercises, and wellness programs (nutrition, exercise, sleep patterns). A useful advanced skill is the capacity to shift timeframes. In imagination, go out to geological, evolutionary, planetary, cosmic scales to get a different view of the Anthropocene. Consider, for instance, that the merger/“collision” of the Milky Way and Andromeda galaxies, which will take place over a period of 5 billion years, has already begun. Next, practice returning to the timescale of the human life cycle. From there, descend into an examination of the moment-by-moment construction of experience. At that level, as well as at the level of the galaxies, the Anthropocene, which looms so large for us, is invisible. Finally, come back once more to the human cycles of days, weeks, years, generations. If one doesn’t return to the human cycles, one becomes a monster. But staying always here in the human ego timeframe, one will likely die of grief or rage (both of which have their own specific fast and slow tracks).

Extrapolation. As we have seen with the COVID-19 pandemic, in time of severe social stress, moral distress and burnout can spread quite widely. They impact not just health-care workers and emergency responders, but also food workers, teachers, and mass transit personnel. Physical, psychological, and spiritual trauma are likely to become widespread as the climate collapses. Training body and mind to cope will be essential to survival and to whatever sort of human flourishing is possible on a vastly depleted planet.

Maxim 6: Act for the Future Generations of All Species.

Speak for those without voice: the poor, the future generations, other species.

Speak for the forests, the seas, the mountains.

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Act, personally and politically, to limit the damage being done to the biosphere. Every 0.5° C increase avoided is a major victory and achievement.

Basis. For the bioethicist, the COVID-19 pandemic has been a clinic in the interconnectedness of ethical problems, as well as the intertwining of the fates of nations and species. Think here of the interconnections between and among fresh meat markets in China, violated natural habitats, global trade patterns, and their economics; the disparities in health care and vulnerability among nations, and among populations within nations; the multiple failures of the health-care system in protecting its workers and its patients; the catastrophic failures of political leadership and the undermining of confidence in science and medicine. And then boil all this down to triage policies, and staffing decisions, and the allocation of PPE. All connected, all one giant web.

Extrapolation. It is essential to find creative ways to cultivate an in-depth, emotional as well as intellectual understanding of interconnection, so that when we act for a species or a group, we are acting for everything in the global web. We are all in this together, all tied together, all forming a multiplex unity. Acting with a sense of solidarity, involving mutuality and reciprocity, the development and maintenance of trust, is essential for decent survival. This understanding is the only intelligent basis for strategy and research. This insight is the foundation for the basic compassion involved in the stress on equity, distributive justice, and the acknowledgment of the gross unfairness of the basic fact that those who have contributed the least to the carbon catastrophe will bear the brunt of the chain of disasters it is initiating.

The Process Has Begun

What in many ways is hardest to realize—yet must be realized—is that the collapse is already here. The following is a list of symptoms of systems already badly out of kilter: the COVID-19 pandemic; the recent Houston storms; the wildfires in California and Australia; and the grid collapses in Texas and California. It is clearly too late to avoid the climate crisis or mitigate it in any definitive way. Adaptation and collapse have begun, albeit in slow motion.

Unfortunately, the numbing has begun as well. We are already far too tolerant of massive amounts of suffering. We are currently moving toward 600,000 COVID-19 deaths in the US. This is more deaths than in all our 20th- and 21st-century wars combined. There have been over 3 million deaths worldwide, and yet life moves along in a quasi-normal state for most of us.

Alongside this process, the temptations and provocations to ruthlessness, competition, and violence will be constant. But our greatest moral threat will likely remain the creeping normalization of catastrophe.

Which brings us back to the fundamental questions addressed by the maxims: what kind of person will you be, and what will you teach and model for your colleagues, your students, your families?

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We ourselves find this list of maxims daunting. But this is how maxims work. Maxims have to do with how we do everything we do—a tone and style of living—as well as with the implementation of certain practices. Maxims are, in significant part, about keeping morality itself alive in a catastrophe. They demand of us that which we have difficulty demanding from ourselves. This is why we put forward for discussion this list of six maxims: precisely because they are so difficult, but also—in our view—so necessary.

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Aṅgulimāla: A Monologue

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 54 min

This powerful dramatic monologue presents the complete story of Aṅgulimāla from his own perspective - from his privileged Brahmin childhood as Ahimsaka ('the Harmless One') through his transformation into a notorious serial killer collecting human fingers, to his ultimate awakening as a Buddhist monk. The narrative follows his encounter with the Buddha on the Kosala roads, his ordination, and his gradual purification of mind through meditation practice. Drawing from the Aṅgulimāla Sutta (MN 86), this dramatisation explores profound themes of karma and its consequences, the possibility of redemption even for the most heinous crimes, and the Buddhist understanding that suffering arises from ignorance rather than inherent evil. The story culminates in Aṅgulimāla's realisation of his fundamental innocence despite his terrible actions, illustrating the Buddhist teaching that liberation is possible for all beings regardless of their past. This compelling retelling offers insights into the transformative power of Right Awareness practice and the Buddha's boundless compassion.

I am amused when I look back on my life. To say I lived it wouldn't be the truth. To say I did not live it would be a lie. In the clarity and distance of old age, it seems a tale of another age, another person. Yet I remember it all as clear as day.

I was born at the beginning of the cold season, the Himalayan wind chilling the dying embers of a warm sun. My mother rejoiced, of course, as did the household of relatives and friends, but my father was more concerned with my horoscope, and he slipped away with colleagues to study the charts.

That next morning, it was an anxious father who hurried to the palace to fulfil the morning rituals of a royal chaplain. There he found the king troubled and agitated.

"Ah, Gagaji, I was dozing after my evening meal when I woke into a living nightmare. All my armour was shaking, clattering, flashing."

"Oh, that would have been the time Mantāni gave birth to our son, Your Majesty, and... I'm afraid, into an inauspicious constellation."

"Inauspicious?" A worried king has no time for sympathetic joy. "There are signs that show great promise indeed, and yet others that indicate something quite terrible."

"Something terrible, such as?" The king wanted precision.

"I can't say, Your Majesty." And at the king's growing frustration, he quickly added, "Perhaps it may be prudent to be rid of him."

My life hung on a thread. Thankfully, this king was not so easily frightened. Indeed, he was surprised my father should put such little value on my life. "But he's born a Brahmin. Surely, properly educated and carefully nurtured, he'll overcome any evil tendencies, and that promise will shine through."

This was not the first time I was to owe my life to the compassion of this young, arrogant king, Pasenadi of Kosala. My parents expressed their uneasy hope in naming me Ahimsaka, the Harmless One.

My childhood was happy and untroubled. I was my mother's favourite. I do remember being offered all manner of bribes to be good. Not that it had much effect. It seems I had an insatiable desire to chase mosquitoes, cockroaches, frogs, anything that moved, and squash them.

However, there was one extraordinary incident that shook my usual happy composure. Suddenly, a gang of boys, all friends, playmates, stood around me. One of them, a big boy, Vajiro, began jeering at me. "Creep, think you're better than all of us." They all joined in. At first, I thought they were joking. Then they began to push me around.

All of a sudden, everything went blank. When I came to my senses, the children were staring at me. Before me lay Vajiro. One by one, they sidled away. When the big boy got up, his blood-stained lips flamed with implacable revenge. "I'll get you for this!" I laughed at his threat. I felt only the power and grandeur of a conqueror. But, more ominous, I was savouring the exquisite pleasure of drawing blood.

By young manhood, I was well practised in the arts of war, and I showed such potential in my studies that my father sent me to Takkasilā, the foremost seat of learning. Such was my reputation that the most learned teacher wanted to see me. Āgamaha Paṇḍita Abhiññāna, a small, rotund, elderly man, was revered for his incisive intellect. That, coupled with a stentorian voice, made him a formidable debater. He fired all manner of questions at me, jabbing them at me with his little finger that seemed to turn them into sharp needles. It was a trait that was to take on a sinister meaning for me.

"You'll outshine them all, even me," he announced with great delight. I felt a great devotion to my guru. I began to treat him with a special veneration due to a natural father. I felt sure he saw me equally as a natural son. It was my devotion to learning and a desire to please my guru that caused me to excel.

Then, one day, I remember it too well, he glanced at me in a way that greatly disturbed me. There was suspicion in his eyes, a tightness to his face suggesting fear, or was it hatred? As the days passed, he grew more and more distant. During the final days, there were awkward silences and false smiles. I felt hurt by our loss of intimacy. Too confused to ask what the matter was. Anyway, I decided to put it all to one side, especially so since my final exams were starting. The recitations, the public debates, the competitive games. I performed very well. In fact, I was acclaimed foremost student of my year.

On the very day the results were given, my deepest anxieties were confirmed. My guru called me to see him. I expected praise. I wanted to express my unrepairable gratitude, and indeed that's what I did. But then he said, "You know, it is the duty of every student to offer a gift of homage to their guru."

"Oh, indeed," I exclaimed. "Name it, Guruji."

What he asked for came as an utter shock. "From this *ācārya*, he said with absolute authority, bring me a little finger of one thousand people."

His eyes demanded obedience.

"I can't do that," I remember stuttering.

He was silent, his glare insisting submission.

"My family are all Brahmins. We live as harmlessly as possible, to the highest standards of one who is born of the mouth of Brahmā."

"Those who refuse to pay the ceremonial gift of homage, a sacred duty to their guru, are to be detested. Such a person tramples on our time-honoured tradition. All their learning will produce but sterile fruit. Is this the behaviour of a son born of the mouth of Brahmā?"

There was an inexplicable hardness to his tone, a sneer in his question. I simply had no response. I bowed, mumbling that I would follow his wishes. When I looked up, he'd turned away and was calling for his servant. I backed away, cowed and confused.

The guru had a right to name his gift of homage, but why was mine so terrible? Why had he not asked similar of others? All he asked of them was fruit, clothing, medicine.

That night I fell into a heavy, disturbed sleep. I woke into a terrible night terror. Pointed fingers like darts burst upon me from every angle. I fought furiously with sword and shield, writhing in agony. When I came to my senses, I was lying on the floor, soaked in cold sweat and shaking, awake to the full horror of my duty.

In a daze, I got my belongings together and began to make my way homeward, a journey of two weeks or more, time to clear my head and cool my heart. I stayed in the villages en route, hardly talking to anyone, and all the time I was convincing myself of my duty. I must get one thousand fingers. How else could I possibly do so without killing? People aren't just going to let me walk off with their little finger. I have to kill. There's no other way. Such killing isn't murder. I have to fulfil my sacred duty. Who am I to renounce a time-honoured tradition? I have to do it. I have to.

In this way, by the time I arrived at the dark and dense Jālini forest on the border of my country, Kosala, I was steeled for my first killing. I found a cave on a hill that looked down on a stretch of road travelled by hunters, gatherers and merchants. Water and forest food - banana, mango, rich papaya, various nuts - were all in abundance. And I spent my first day.

That evening, in the pearl-white silence of a full moon, soft with the scuffing of cicadas, I dug a fire pit to Kālī Durgā, Divine Mother, womb of all creation. It was into this cremation ground that I would offer the flesh of my victims to gain them her protection and so sanctify my deeds. I cut my little finger and into the sacrificial fire I offered my blood as libation. Staring at the flames, I then began to develop a fierce concentration. It was going to take all the courage and strength I could muster. For all my battle skills, I'd never yet killed an animal, never mind a human being.

In the dark dawn of early morning, I rubbed the sacred ash into my body. Filled with religious confidence, I made my way down to the path. There I hid, waiting. And sure enough, in that early hour, the shuffle of a wood-gatherer with his hacks and bundles of rope.

I'd imagined a swift dagger attack from behind, but instead pulled an arrow into the bow. A more easy prey there couldn't be. But I couldn't let that arrow fly. I continued to stalk him, all the time urging myself to fulfil my duty. And anyway, what had life left for this old, feeble man but a miserable diseased end? It was a mercy to kill him.

I took a deep breath. As quick as lightning, I thrust my sword. It seemed to penetrate like a knife through butter. His body startled, tensed, and suddenly slumped, dragging me downwards, so I tumbled onto him. There I looked into his face. His eyes glazed, empty and deaf. His mouth wide open, locked in shock. Horrified, I leapt up, hardly able to catch my breath.

Suddenly, there were great cries. When a small crowd of men were racing towards me, their axes shaking in the air. All went blank. I remember nothing but standing there with these same men strewn around me, twisted and bleeding. As I realised what had happened, there came upon me that strange feeling of omnipotence. I stood towering above the slain bodies, the skill, the power, the glory of it. Like the all-conquering hero, I sliced off each little finger with a flourish. And I rejoiced. "I've done it. I've done it. And it's easy, so easy." I danced for joy and relief.

I then hid the bodies. The more I could keep the killings secret, the easier would I capture my victims. I returned to my cave. There I cut what flesh I could from the fingers into the sacrificial pyre. I then threaded the bones with vine and tied them onto a branch. Once they were picked clean by birds or ants, I'd hang it around my neck as a divine amulet.

Late that same afternoon, I heard in the distance a calling. Names being called by many over and over again. Intrigued, I went down. Of course, family and friends had come to look for the wood gatherers. Again I stalked and pounced like a tiger. My attacks were swift and smooth, the blows of death precise, clean.

Having taken the fingers of two men, moving around a bamboo coppice, there in front of me three women. Yes, I stopped. For a moment there was doubt. I felt something tight against my heart. But by now I was too committed. Two were dead before the other could turn. She stared at me, paralysed in fear, and that was the face that fell into the embrace of soft grasses and wild flowers.

Did I feel pity? None. I was drunk with conquest. I could have easily killed the rest, but for a scream of horror some distance from me. I was moving so fast I hadn't bothered to hide the bodies. The game was up. It was now a matter of stopping the news travelling beyond the village. I ran at maddening speed until I arrived at a large clearing. Many buildings nestled there among the palm trees, the place littered with busy chickens and scrawny dogs.

I was sure that once the villagers returned, they'd send a party off to the king at Sāvatti. It was on that road I lay waiting. And sure enough, a handful of men came bearing the usual crude weapons. I followed them till they had gone quite some way

from the village and well out of earshot. It was then, full of the courage of invincibility, I pounced on them. None of this low caste would have had my training. It was all becoming too easy.

I decided to take full advantage of the situation. I made my way back to the village, and in the early hours of the following morning, just when colour begins to seep into the shades, I crept into the first one-room hut, the air hot and stale with the exhausted slumber of grief. Husband and wife lay together, the children - seven, or maybe eight of them - snuggled in the opposite corner. Their pitiful defencelessness couldn't soften my cruel resolve. I bathed myself in the blood of carnage. First the man, then the woman, then the children. Quietly and speedily, I slit their throats and stabbed their hearts. And so I savaged hut after hut. I could see streamlets of blood pick their way down the slope towards the well.

Suddenly, as I left a large wooden house, a scream. I lurched back inside and grabbed that child by the throat. A rage took me. I lifted the little body until it dangled in the air, its little arms flailing, mouth agape, eyes bulging in terror, its tiny fingers wrenched into my hand, its little feet kicking the air. My grip tightened till the tiny body seized and fell limp. I stared at that beautiful little face as in a trance. I couldn't bear to acknowledge what I'd done. As I dropped the body to continue the slaughter, it was the one finger I left behind.

But that little child's cry had stirred the village. It was only because of the poor light that I was able to disappear unseen into the forest. I arrived back at my hideout, exhausted. As I lay down, the child's face returned. I turned on my side and slept through the heat of midday.

Late that afternoon, I woke refreshed and of a sudden decided to hunt animals. Each kill reaffirmed my command over life and death. In the cool of that evening, for the first time in my life, I sank my teeth into roasted boar. It was delicious. Again, I rejoiced. "Soon I'll have my hundred fingers. The debt will be paid. I'll return home in secret triumph and through my father's good offices enter into the service of the king. I'll marry a beautiful girl, inherit the farm, have many children, and my life will be a rolling countryside of nothing but contentment and joy." I danced in joy. I danced in gratitude. I danced for Kālī, my divine protectress.

The following morning I woke in more sombre mood. I realised that even now a platoon of soldiers would be searching for me. There was only one thing for it, to keep on the move without coherent plan and to range as far as possible. In this way I could at-

tack unwary travellers along any road, enter any unsuspecting village in the dark. The kill was easy so long as it remained unexpected. Even the soldiers were useless defence. Such was their clatter, I could always hear them coming.

On one such outing, I overheard a conversation that first made me laugh, and then showed me to what depravity I had descended. I heard a small crowd talking about this madman who murdered for little fingers. "A demon, Aṅgulimāla."

Me? I was Aṅgulimāla, Garland of Fingers. Returning that evening, I caught my face in a pool of water, and what I saw truly shocked me. My black hair was tortured, spikes around my head, my face hidden beneath a matted, grubby beard. My eyes seemed to bulge. My lips and tongue, blood red from betel leaf, which I chewed to calm my nerves. My clothes, torn, filthy and bespattered with human blood. And there, around my neck, the garland of fingers. Yes, a demon. A *yakkha*.

Over this period of but a few weeks, as I gathered my tally of fingers, my bloodlust consumed me. My dreams were full of it. Daydreams addicted to it. To see the horror in their eyes, to hear their screams, was my joy.

Yes, I remember. I remember it all, as clear as day.

I had now but one finger to go, and I thought to come full circle and return to the very spot on that road where I'd stabbed that poor old wood-gatherer. Then at last I would present this blood homage to my guru, against whom I'd built up a healthy hatred and often plotted how to avenge my humiliation.

As I hid in waiting, I began to hear a calling. Oh, my heart jumped into my throat. "Ahiṃsaka! Ahiṃsaka!" My mother! My mother calling me as she'd always done. How could she have known it was me? Her mother's intuition.

Mother or no, there raged inside me a desire to kill. A loud, clear no arose, yet against my will my legs began to move nearer and nearer until I saw her. I couldn't stop. I just kept advancing, my hand now taking the sword from the scabbard. I was all but ready to pounce when a tall, bald-headed monk suddenly appeared. My mother bowed to him. He must have said something to her, for my mother turned and walked back the way she came. He then continued along the road.

I was intrigued. I began to stalk this monk, moving faster and faster, yet the faster I moved, he seemed to be the same distance away. Finally, frustrated, I burst out of my hiding into the road and ran towards him. Faster and faster I ran, yet never getting any closer.

He kept on walking at the very same easy pace. Finally exhausted, I shouted out, "Stop!" And he did. While I panted, he turned round, quite unhurriedly, and replied, "I have stopped, Angulimala. It's you who haven't stopped."

I was full of rage and yet taken aback. He was smiling at me. We stood facing each other for what seemed a long time. Finally, my curiosity—at his supernatural ability to walk faster than I could run, his obvious fearlessness, and this strange reply—brought the student out of me.

"You've stopped, but I haven't!" I shouted angrily.

"This vicious craving and enjoyment in making others suffer, do you think it will end with your hundred fingers? With the murder of your own mother?"

I was dumb.

"And the consequences, the *kamma*. Don't you believe the torturer reaps in kind?"

Of course I did. Do harm, and surely harm will follow as a cart follows the ox.

"I'm fulfilling an ancient obligation to my guru," I offered in defence.

"Ha! Put yourself in the place of your victims. How would you like to be murdered, just so that some bright young Brahmin can offer your little finger as a present to his guru?"

The absurdity of my position hit me like a bolt of lightning. Why had it never occurred to me to take the victim's point of view?

"So come then," he said. "You may as well finish the job." He offered his hand. "You needn't kill me for it."

I stared at him in disbelief. He was a big man beyond his prime, but still strong enough to defend himself, offering me his little finger. His fearless act of generosity made my own courage seem puny.

"You've been amazingly stupid," he continued. "What happened to your common sense? It just goes to show how brilliance can service the most ludicrous delusions. That very dedication to your studies, and indeed to your murderings, is a virtue that will help perfect contentment even in this very life."

His compassion had utterly exposed my callous logic. The full horror of what I had done was upon me. I could hardly bear to look into his kindly yet penetrating eyes. He indeed was a guru of another kind.

He asked me to take him to my hideout. We talked of how we'd both been brought up in the lap of luxury—he, the son of Suddhodana, king of the Sakyans, north of my own country. How even as a young man he'd become weary of courtly life, how he had an insatiable hunger to know the true destiny of a human being. Were we to wander around aimlessly from life to life, suffering this, enjoying that, or was it simply death, annihilation? Or was there something else?

On the way I came across some jungle fowl. I grabbed an arrow, only to feel acute embarrassment. Such was his immediate effect upon me. I returned to gathering fruits and nuts. That midday, we ate together in silence.

It was late afternoon when I woke from a heavy sleep. Suddenly, seeing the monk again, I jumped and grabbed my dagger. He chuckled at my ferocious posturing. "Angulimala, when will you again be Ahimsaka, the harmless one?"

He asked me to sit in meditation with him. "Just observe and feel anything that comes into your attention."

I couldn't sit for long—I was so restless.

"Walk up and down, slowly," he said, "but again, just to be aware of any thoughts and feelings."

I would sit and walk in fits and starts. I just couldn't stand still.

"Patience," he said. "This is going to take some time. Don't worry, I'll stay with you till your future is clear."

I immediately relaxed with this assurance.

It took a few days to calm down enough to sit still and watch. Again and again, I re-enacted my killings. Endlessly working over the same old themes: the chase, the battle, the kill, and always the excitement, the enjoyment. I couldn't stop them dominating me.

"Don't indulge these fantasies," he warned. "Take away their nourishment and they'll simply die away. Or else they'll drive you to further atrocity. And where will it all end? The king's prison? To be publicly tortured?"

That sent a cold shiver up my spine.

"And," he added, "undermine these overpowering cravings by considering how much your victims suffered."

That was hard. I still wanted to justify myself, make light of their suffering.

Disheartened and weary, I stretched and looked into the dark emptiness of a starlit night, and there caught the first delicate arc of the new moon. I decided to meditate just once more. As if by magic, the focus of my fantasies began to change. Instead of relishing the chase and the kill, I began to see the pain and panic of my victims. It was with these images that I fell asleep.

It was still dark when I felt a hand rock my shoulder. I woke with a start.

"Continue," he said. He must have felt the change in my heart. "Get up. Shake off the sloth of sleep."

The voice was sharp, but his smile completely disarmed my angry indignation. I had by now unwittingly become a disciple. Like any good student, I obeyed. I splashed water on my face and began to sit in meditation.

And there they came—the faces tortured in pain, weeping and pleading, vivid and alive as if from the dead. I began to feel their agonies, and there arose a remorse that began to shake my body. Till it started to release, first in little spurts, then in cries, and then in loud moaning and weeping. I cried and cried and cried. I felt my very insides were gouged out. Who knows how long I filled that jungle with my wailing.

"Excellent," said the monk, smiling. "Only when true remorse arises can the heart begin to heal."

I did find his joy in my discomfort a little disconcerting.

The images of my cruelty continued to haunt my every meditation, my every action, my every dream. Every moment was shame, guilt and remorse. And I was so angry with myself. Why had I not seen the sheer idiocy of my guru's request? The gall I felt when I realised I could have said no. What had stopped me but vile servitude to custom, enslavement to tradition? And how was I ever going to compensate for such monstrous crimes?

My remorse turned to despair when I saw they were too terrible to be forgiven.

"How can we compensate for murder of all things?" this gentle monk asked. "What could replace the loss of grandparents, husband, wife, children? In such a case, we must simply bear the consequences. Isn't that enough? Do we have to punish ourselves as well?"

I began to realise that in the end, I would have to give myself up to the authorities. They would mete out a terrible, tortuous death. My identity would be revealed, my family shamed and ruined, my mother... Oh, better for me to live wild, or go to another

country far away, take my chances with uncivilised tribes, or better still, to commit suicide, secretly, somewhere the body would be eaten by wild animals, so that I remained anonymous.

He listened to my ranting and raving. Then again, in a moment of calmness: "Do you want to be a fugitive or live like an animal all your life? And having murdered so many people, you now want to murder yourself? Is there no end to your stupidity? Past deeds cannot be altered, and they will produce present and future consequences. The true question is, do you have the courage to face it, to suffer it? For this is the only way you can drain the past of its effect."

His eyes looked steadily into mine. I jumped up. I had to walk. The arguments went round and round, but the truth stood out. It was better to face the consequences. Surely the king would have sympathy for me. He'd known me since I was a baby. We'd even wrestled each other. He would understand my dilemma. What else could a disciple do but obey his guru? There was my father's influence, the standing of my family. Indeed, I could defend myself before the king as I defended my actions to my own self. And if I was shown no mercy, well, then I would have to suffer the consequences. At least, as this teacher says, I'd wipe the slate clean.

I returned and told him of my decision to give myself up to the authorities. He nodded, as if in approval. There was a long silence in which we gazed into each other's eyes. Then he said, "Would you not rather put an end to this whole weary round of births and deaths?"

"Is there an escape?" I asked.

His face shone with a smile, and he spoke with that absolute assurance of one who knows. "There is, Ahimsaka—that which is not born does not die. It is not created, nor can it be destroyed. Where there's earth, fire, water or air, it cannot be seen or heard or in any way perceived. It is the deathless, the unconditioned. If this were not so, there would be no escape from birth, sickness, ageing and death and the endless, endless rounds of rebirth."

Suddenly I heard myself asking, "You would accept me, Angulimala, a criminal, a murderer, as your disciple?"

"You can stop, Ahimsaka, as I have stopped," he replied.

A huge burden seemed to lift, and an enormous joy, born of hope, settled upon me.

First, he said, you must bury the tools of your abhorrent profession. You must no longer harm any living being, not even a cockroach.

For the last time, I caressed the beautifully wrought weapons, especially the slender blade with its snake-embraced handle. I stabbed out a trench. There I placed these precious jewels, gleaming and glistening in the noonday sun. How difficult it is to give up an addiction, an obsession. I forced my hands to cover them with soil and placed heavy boulders on them until I felt sure that I'd truly buried them for good.

Then he asked me to go in search of suitable robe cloth in cemeteries—oh, disturbing places, charnel grounds, corpses steaming the air with their sickly, sweet, pungent stench, dismembered limbs, half eaten by tigers, rodents, vultures, and strewn around the white shrouds that mourners had wrapped their dead in.

I was about to wash the cloth when my teacher told me I hadn't yet fully buried the past. I looked at him, puzzled. He pointed to a tree. There, hanging forgotten around my makeshift shrine to Kali, was the garland of finger bones, gently swaying in the sighing breeze, their chimes hollow and choked.

I laid them down in a circle, each finger pointing inward to the now empty pit. And on the burial mound over these sacred bones, I planted a frangipani tree, whose white, sweet, perfumed flowers would ever shower their sad grave. I watched over this cemetery, recalling their murders, begging forgiveness, till sleep overpowered me.

The next day I washed the white cloth, and with my teacher's needle and thread made robes. He then shaved my head and beard, and finally all was ready for me to make my request.

"*Bhagavā*, may you be my guide. I shall live dependent on the *Bhagavā*."

"Come," he replied, "and conduct yourself diligently according to the customs of ascetics."

That evening, for the first time, bliss was the object of my meditation.

The following day, he wanted to return to his monastery in Sāvatti. He sensed my fear. "I will not recognise you," he assured me, knowing how different I looked.

When we arrived at the first village, there were shouts of recognition. "*Bhagavad Gautama!*" A great thrill passed through my body. I'd only heard of this great teacher. I couldn't believe my good fortune.

The villagers told their tales of Angulimala and how they thirsted for revenge. "Ah," said the *Bhagavā*, "your revenge makes you no better than he. Let the king deal with him. Oh, the law of *kamma*. Better to live good lives and offer your merit to your departed loved ones. That is what they need."

None recognised me. As a young, clean-shaven disciple, it was proper for me to keep my eyes lowered and remain silent. He asked them to help me dye my robes.

That evening I approached the *Bhagavā* in ochre robes. I knelt before him and asked him for a name.

"You shall be known by the name of your innocent childhood," he said. I was to be known as Bhikkhu Ahimsaka, the Harmless One.

That day all the villagers took a day away from their labours. He talked both to the group and to individuals, calming and consoling them. And so we continued, staying at village after village, until we saw ahead of us the walls of the capital city, Sāvatti.

The monastery, on the outskirts of the city... It was a set of buildings with a large meditation hall, neat footpaths, bushes, flowers and trees bordering well-kept lawns. Everyone stood waiting, hands joined before them in *añjali*. They greeted him with silence and smiles.

I was shown to a hut hidden in the tamed forest grove close by, a sturdy little bamboo affair covered in layers of banana leaves. No more than two good strides in length and one in breadth. I had that strange feeling of coming home.

I lay there that night on the soft-platted palm-leaf mat, listening to the crickets and the conversation of owls, musing how my life had so quickly turned around. Truly miraculous.

During the first few days I would constantly visit the *Bhagavā*, but his attendant, the elder Ānanda, would always tell me to go back to my hut and practise. I felt annoyed and frustrated. Then one day the *Bhagavā* asked to see me.

"Dear friend," he said, "it's not proper to develop an affection for the teacher. I can't bring about your deliverance from suffering. You must take refuge in the teachings and the practice, but above all in yourself. I can only point the way. So please don't come unless called."

That day I felt utterly dejected, abandoned. So much so, I even began to dream of being Angulimala, and all the pleasures of hunting assailed me. I was guided skillfully, and I came to realise that it was this craving to be teacher's best boy that had so angered my fellow students. I was a creep.

Then, early one morning, there were drums, and the occasional salute of trumpets. The king and his army are en route somewhere. To my horror, I suddenly realised they were coming to the monastery. You can imagine my alarm. I'd all but decided to run away when a young monk came and told me to come at once.

As I entered the *Bhagavā's* room, he saw the look of anxiety on my face and smiled. With an insistent gesture, he motioned me to sit by him. We sat and waited as the marching footsteps approached us. And suddenly at the door stood the king—a short, stocky, heavily bearded man, the warrior in his eyes.

The king and his officers paid homage to the *Bhagavā*. I knew all of them, though none recognised me. I did keep my head low.

After the usual pleasantries were exchanged, the king explained they'd come for the *Bhagavān's* blessing. "It's this Angulimala. I've sent out dozens of platoons, but to no avail. He's murdered hundreds, wiped out whole villages. Extraordinary. But how to deal with a deranged madman? Why is he collecting fingers?"

There came a burst of suggestions. "He's possessed." "A demon." "A lunatic."

When the excitement had calmed, the *Bhagavān* said, "What would you say, your majesty, if such a dark-hearted murderer were to become a monk?"

I could feel the panic rising in me.

"What?" shouted the king, his mouth agape with incredulity. A chorus of scoffing supported his scorn.

"Don't be so dismissive," urged the *Bhagavān*. "Even this Angulimala can transform himself."

"Transform himself?" The king continued to shout. "When I catch him, I'll transform him. I'll have him roasted alive."

There were great guffaws and equally delicious torments suggested. But one especially made my hair stand on end: "I'd have him slowly cut to pieces so that he could watch his body being eaten by dogs."

It wasn't the horror of it, but the voice. It was that childhood enemy, Vajiro, now an officer in the king's guard.

"Do you really think that revenge can ever be satisfied? Whatever you do, the bereaved will complain it wasn't harsh enough. Violence breeds violence. It can only be attained by compassion. This is an ancient law."

There was an uneasy silence.

"You did come for my advice." Again that smile. The king looked around at his company. Everyone was baffled.

"So you want us to catch him and bring him to you, *Bhagavā*?" suggested the king.

"No need for that." And turning to me, the *Bhagavā* cheerfully announced, "Here he is. Angulimala, now Bhikkhu Ahimsaka."

The whole company, to a man including the king, instinctively grabbed their swords. There was a stunned silence.

"Perhaps you know him?" asked the *Bhagavā*. I looked up in surprise. The king glared at me.

"Ahimsaka," he said at first in shock, and then in growing surprise.

Ahimsaka, son of Gaga and Montani. He related the circumstances of my birth. But why, he asked, why the fingers? I then told him about the gift demanded by my guru. Realizing my predicament, a sympathy grew towards me among the king and his company. Indeed, I could see sadness shadow the king's face.

After a long pause in which the king kept looking at me and then to the *Bhagavā*, he said, "You're a lucky man, Bhikkhu Ahimsaka, a very lucky man." With that they began to leave. But the king, as he reached the door, turned and warned me not to leave the *Bhagavā*'s order. We listened to the marching steps. The *Bhagavā* turned to me and smiled. I took a very deep breath.

The very next morning, as I was preparing to go on alms round, there was a knock at my door. I opened it to find what I most dreaded standing before me. My mother. Was a basket of food enough for an elephant? Here and then I began to sob, to sob uncontrollably. No doubt she thought it was remorse for the shame that I'd brought upon the family. Not so many days ago, I was stalking this very woman, intent on stabbing her

through the heart, slicing off her finger. This woman, my mother, who bore me, suckled me, tended to my every care. My heart cramped into a solid spasm of agony. If ever I were to describe hell, it would be the heart-wrenching compunction I felt that day.

Happily, even hell passes. But this was the bloodiest of daggers I'd pierced into my own heart. I told her my tale, and of the king's stipulation not to leave the Order, and that I needed time to cure the festering in my heart. I sensed her disappointment. She'd wanted grandchildren and all that. And as for my father, he wasn't surprised, of course. Hadn't he foretold it? It was that I had become a disciple of someone who wasn't a Brahmin that he found offensive. Eventually, he offered me his blessing.

Not everyone came to accept me, of course. On alms round, children poked fun at me, making up silly songs about Aṅgulimāla. But more serious, people threw stones at me, some bouncing off my head. I'd just walk on. They would eventually tire. But I was attacked viciously once. A few of the aggrieved families whipped up a crowd to such a righteous frenzy that they beat me with sticks and were taking me out of the city to kill me, when the guards at the gates stopped them. Ironically, it was Vajiro in command of the post. With a great look of disdain, he ordered a platoon of soldiers to escort me back to the monastery. It took days for the bruises to heal, but luckily there were no broken bones, saying to myself, "If this is all the *kamma* I have to suffer, how fortunate indeed."

It was on one of these alms rounds that something quite remarkable happened. I'd stopped in front of a house in case someone should want to offer food, when I heard great cries. A man came out, looking desperate, saw me, and shouted, "This is no time to come begging. Can't you hear my wife?" Her cries resurrected the screams of my victims. I was so depressed by this that I went to see the Bhagavā.

"Go back and offer this blessing," he said. "Say, 'By the power of a harmless life, let that mother's pain cease and the child be born safe.'"

"Harmless life?" I said incredulously.

"Since your spiritual life began, from the day of your ordination," the Bhagavā replied.

Yes, I thought, at least I could make an offering of my harmless life, albeit a little short. How wonderful if I could actually assist a birth, I who had assisted so many deaths.

She was still crying out and praying to the gods. Quite a crowd had gathered outside the house. I stood at the gates and offered my blessing: "Sister, since I was born into the noble life, I do not recall having ever intentionally killed a living being. By this truth may you be well and may your child be safe."

Everyone began to scoff and jeer. I could feel the anger rising. I left at once. That evening the clamour of a crowd approached my hut and called for me. I began to panic again. I took a deep breath and opened the door. And there before me stood a man holding a baby. There were shouts of "Sādhū, sādhu, sādhu, well done." Presents were laid before me and a garland of the most beautiful white frangipani was placed around my neck. They told me that almost immediately after my blessing, the baby was born and both mother and child were well. I was to be honoured guest at the feast. It was all I could do to blubber my thanks.

Oh, to my surprise, my chant has become a magical mantra for mothers to be. And from that day on, the children stopped poking fun. Coarse words became kindly greetings, and the stones turned into flowers, incense, and sweets. My heart ached with relief and joy at their forgiveness.

After many years, once I felt sure enough in my practice, I decided to go to the neighbouring kingdom of Magadha, where no one would recognise me, in order to live a more solitary life. I found a secluded forest, not far from the prosperous capital of Rajagaha. It was the dry, hot season, so I made my home beneath a great shady fig tree. In time, the villagers generously built me a hut.

There I continued to work, work hard, through all the mental anguish. There were the burning hurts and scorching revenge towards my enemies, especially my guru. It stung to know, to find out, that he had believed the malicious slander that I had been scheming to have him removed so that I could take his prestigious post, and that he had given me such a heinous obligation out of hateful spite. Then there was the nauseous guilt and agonising remorse towards my victims, as well as all the usual unquenchable lusts, paralysing fears and so on. Oh, I thought they'd never end.

And yet, over the years, everything began to subside. And in the clearings it became so obvious. No one had actually ever made me suffer. No one. Not the plots of my enemies, not the punches of Vajiro, not even the vicious malevolence of my guru. All the ensuing hurt and hate was of my own making. Was it not my own befuddled thinking that led me to murder? The demonic delight I took in killing, was that not mine to develop? And all the self-pity, self-hatred, guilt, remorse, and so on, and so on, and so on. Was that not all direct consequence? All the time I was blaming others, unwittingly, I was creating my own hell.

And so it was that since none had actually caused me to suffer, I lost all reason, all need to forgive anyone. And it was then I saw as clear as day. But for mistaken understanding, deluded reasoning, I had never actually meant any harm, never meant to cause anyone any suffering whatsoever. And so it was that I lost all reason, all need to be forgiven.

I was like a man who, wandering through a forest, kicks a crooked stick only to disturb a viper. Just because he's mistaken doesn't mean he and others won't be bitten. Is this not a great paradox of human life that we are at once responsible for our moral behaviour, yet because we are fundamentally not immoral, not bad, not evil, but ignorant, mistaken, deluded, we are therefore intrinsically innocent? Indeed, if this were not so, how could we ever attain purity? And without purity, there can be no liberation from suffering.

These insights came early one morning. From my hut, perched on the side of a wooded valley, I watched the sun rising through the golden air, full of sweet early monsoon blossom and the trill of songbirds. And there arose in me such relief and release. And I remembered how the Bhagavā had answered me on the killing road: "I have stopped, Aṅgulimāla."

Now, I've stopped too. I've done what had to be done. My heart is purified of all defilements and I live in utter contentment and peace.

Greeting the Devadutta

Noirin Sheahan · 6 min read

This deeply personal essay chronicles Noirin Sheahan's journey through major throat cancer surgery and recovery, framed as an encounter with a 'devadutta' (messenger from the gods). The essay begins with her diagnosis requiring removal of the pharynx, oesophagus, and larynx, leaving her unable to speak or eat normally. Rather than viewing this as pure catastrophe, she recognizes the illness as a profound teaching on impermanence - showing how all pleasures, including speaking and eating, must eventually end.

The narrative follows her from pre-surgery meditation sessions supported by the sangha community, through the initial post-operative nightmare of fear and disorientation in intensive care, to gradual acceptance and healing. She describes the terror of inhabiting an alien body, the loss of familiar sensations, and overwhelming anxiety. Yet through mindful engagement - deliberately turning her wrists and ankles as acts of choosing life - and sustained by the mettā of friends and community, she finds moments of profound communion with truth beyond the self.

The essay illuminates how physical crisis can become a gateway to deeper Dhamma understanding, demonstrating practical approaches to working with aversion and fear while emphasizing the crucial role of sangha support in times of great dukkha.

Greeting the Devadutta!

It has been a challenging but very rich time for practice these past six months. I won't attempt a full

report here, but maybe over the next year I'll reflect and write some more if it seems useful. Here I'll

just focus on the time around the operation.

As many of you know I'd been having throat pain and difficulty swallowing for over a year before a

major cancer was diagnosed in July of this year. The news was grim: major surgery required to

remove the tumour, which would also mean removing the pharynx (linking the back of the mouth

with the rest of the throat) the oesophagus (food pipe) and the larynx (voice box). The surgeons would

then take a section from the jejunum (small bowel) to replace the oesophagus, while the

trachea

(wind pipe) would be diverted to the front of the neck, so I would breathe through this opening rather

than through the nose and mouth. Even with all this surgery, the odds were only 50:50 that the

outcome would be successful, with the first two weeks post-op being critical. Because of losing the

voice box, the only way to speak after the operation would be with an electro-larynx (a mechanical

sound source held against the throat), and perhaps several months later a 'voice valve' could be

inserted in the throat. How well I could speak and swallow food would depend on how well the tongue

and jaw and other tissues healed after the operation.

And that was the best scenario! If, on opening up the throat they found the tumour had grown too

close to major blood vessels then the surgery would have to be aborted, and no other treatment could

be offered.

With only two weeks between the diagnosis and the surgery my mood swept between bright "it will all

work out somehow" bravado, through to fear, confusion and all shades in between.

There were

moments of calm too, and the faith that my core desire for this life, to come to know and understand

the Dhamma, would not suffer. Indeed I could only profit from this 'devadutta' (messenger from the

gods) showing me the reality that all pleasures, including the pleasures of speaking and eating, must

sooner or later come to an end. Bhante reminded me that 50:50 odds weren't all that bad, and

optimistically predicted that that within a year I'd be well enough to help him with some interviews at

Satipanya. His vision helped me meet the devadutta with some enthusiasm.

Messages of goodwill started pouring in from friends and family and from so many of you who I had

met on retreats or through teaching. I thought I'd better try to harness all this good energy, and the

evening before the surgery friends from our Dublin meditation group gathered round

my hospital bed
for a sit. At the same time, Bhante led a sit at Satipanya dedicated to my healing and
friends all
around Ireland and even throughout Europe joined in. The collective outpouring of
compassion and
goodwill lifted my spirits and by the following morning I was in good heart for the sur-
gery.
I woke, twelve hours later, to find my great friends Margaret and Pat, beaming at me.
The operation
had gone well – no hitches. In my post-anaesthetic blur, I was also euphoric and, unable
to speak,
kept tracing out the letters ‘love’ in the air. But when I woke the next day it was as if
into a nightmare.
I found myself terrified of my new reality, terrified of life, wanting to curl up into a ball
and shut out
the whole world. My body felt alien, a strange new entity from which my mind recoiled
in dread. I
didn’t have much pain, but it was as if I didn’t recognise much of my body. Partly this
may have been
the effect of the anaesthetic, and partly, as I found out later, that many nerves were cut
during
surgery, so that I had lost sensation in much of my neck and tongue. I could barely
move and
strange-tasting secretions flooded my mouth and throat. I couldn’t swallow them back -
surely I
would drown? It took a long time to trust that my airway was now separate from my
mouth so the
flood couldn’t drown me.
I was in the semi-darkness of ICU (Intensive Care Unit) hooked up to a ventilator to help
me breathe,
heart and blood pressure monitors, a urinary catheter as well as several other tubes
draining away
fluid from the wounds in my neck and stomach. Every so often a nurse would insert a
tube into my
mouth or windpipe to suck out secretions. All around me machines clunked and
bleeped.
My body burned with anxiety and I felt weak, helpless and immensely frightened.
Where was peace or
goodness to be found? Remembering the meditation of the pre-op day and the many

cards and

goodwill messages I had received, I sensed that the surrounding ocean of goodwill was the only thing

carrying me through. As for myself, I felt myself to be completely out of metta or courage. But

goodwill there was, though I could not acknowledge it at the time: through little gaps in the mayhem I

would murmur in my heart ‘this is the Dhamma unfolding’ to help me remember the greater truth. I

found I could turn my ankles and wrists. Each turn was a deliberate choice to engage with life,

especially with this new body which frightened me so. Turn by turn the seconds and hours slipped by.

During those first nightmare days, my friend Margaret was the up-front manifestation of all the wide

ocean of goodwill that surrounded me. For hours she sat there, holding my hand, or placing cool

cloths on my forehead and limbs. Her presence was calming. It was calm I craved, not stimulation of

any sort. What conditions could favour calm? I tried to minimise input from the world.

Even opening

and reading the cards that were still arriving brought up emotion. I opened just one or two a day, and

so, over several weeks, the huge outpouring of compassion for my situation trickled gradually into my

heart.

Conversation mostly brought a host of emotional reactions, now that I could only scrawl words on a

whiteboard to reply. How to make visiting hours a support as opposed to another challenge? I asked

family not to call – I reckoned the dukkha of attachment to my previous ‘caregiver’ role would be too

much to bear in my vulnerable condition. I asked for only a few women friends whom I sensed as

calming ‘yin’ presences, and who I felt would be happy to sit quietly and just ‘be there’.

Most men

with their more stimulating ‘yang’ energies were barred for those first weeks!

Touch became an important means of contact, now that speech was gone. There were

precious

moments when I felt a warm, calm energy flowing from my friends' hands into my heart and mind.

Then I would be alone again, working as best I could with aversion; turning my wrists with mindful

deliberation, turning my ankles, choosing the reality on offer.

When I could relax deeply I would often come to a scared stiff edge of reason with my mind

desperately afraid of some dark reality being presented through my body. But time and again I found

some channel through the darkness – a channel of 'unknowing' I called it – a meeting with that which

lies beyond the self. This was always a wonderful experience. Each time that blessed channel opened

I knew again that the deepest desire in life is not for good health or any of the wonders that world can

offer, but for this deep communion with truth. At these moments I could greet the devadutta gladly.

These moments inspired me to continue the work with anxiety and other aversive mind-states, to

keep turning towards them rather than being overcome and defined by them. And, with the aid of

doctors and nurses and the whole health-care system and medication and those machines that

clunked and beeped, my body started to recover. As I grew stronger physically, some of the anxiety

receded. I began to feel my way back into social life with the understanding and encouragement of

friends. When I could bear the thought of the outside world, I could look through my cards and know

there was a deep wellspring of compassion and goodwill around me. And so, little by little, I began to

relax into my new life.

'We just follow circumstance.' — Bhante Bodhidhamma

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 2 min read

Drawing from a profound Zen saying by Dōgen Zenji about following circumstance even when 'the world ends,' Bhante Bodhidhamma explores how Buddhist practice prepares us for the most challenging situations life can present. Using contemporary examples of global crises—thermonuclear war, climate catastrophe, and natural disasters—he examines two fundamentally different responses to overwhelming circumstances.

The essay contrasts the self-preserving reaction that tightens around ego-protection with a fearless acceptance that expands to embrace the full situation of ourselves and others. When we identify strongly with this human form, we become trapped in existential loneliness and the very fires we seek to escape—what Buddhism recognizes as the Hell Realm. However, through cultivating Right Awareness and developing an 'unshakeable heart,' we discover a deeper refuge that cannot be breached by external circumstances.

Bhante Bodhidhamma reveals how genuine vipassanā practice develops satipaṇṇā—the intuitive wisdom that allows us to remain both fully engaged with challenging circumstances and inwardly stable. This teaching shows how Buddhist training transforms our relationship to crisis, moving from self-obsessed suffering toward compassionate collaborative response, ultimately discovering the refuge of awakened awareness that remains unshaken regardless of external conditions.

I came across this saying from Dōgen Zenji, the founder of Japanese Sōtō Zen. “When the world ends, and the fires blaze unobstructed through everything, and all falls to ruin, we just follow circumstance.” (Kinder Smith) There are two possible ways in which we, all life in fact, could fall to ruin by fire at this present time – thermonuclear war and climate crisis. We have seen from massive earthquakes, most recently the devastation in Turkey and Syria, what the consequences are. Immediate death, long term physical pain and anguish and eventual death, disabled for life and lives filled with grief and despair. And the possible aftermath of political instability and social turmoil. In such a scenario, will we be able to ‘just follow circumstance’. At first this phrase may seem too cool to be true, even callous. Does it mean we have to harden our hearts, stay aloof and save ourselves. Or might that circumstance expand beyond its tight self-centred circumference to embrace the full surround of impact on others. That can only arise from a fearless total acceptance, ‘this is the circumstance now’, the total circum-

stance of myself and others in this situation, recognising that collaborative effort will produce the best results for everyone. And to mourn shared loss together most healing. In encompassing others, we lose the suffering of self-obsession. In its most exemplary expression to give up one's life for another. That is a hard ask for the self will be consumed with self-preservation. The more we identify with this human form, the more will the circumference tighten around us. But this will not release us from the fear and despair. Worse, it will magnify it. The self will stand exposed to its essential existential loneliness. Unable to bear the suffering, the self becomes the very fires it seeks to escape. This is the Hell Realm. Is there an alternative? An escape? A refuge? There is an even deeper circumference within us of a different kind, one that cannot be breached. No matter what fires burn within us or outside us once accessed we find ourselves insulated and yet able to 'follow circumstance'. Both fully aware and mindful, engaged fully in the surrounding situation, we discover the Unshakeable Heart. This is the purpose of our practice: to discover and experience over and over until we settle permanently into that intuitive awareness, Satipanya.

Laryngectomy

Noirin Sheahan · 18 min read

In this profoundly honest and moving essay, Noirin Sheahan reflects on her experience of losing her natural voice following laryngectomy surgery. She explores the practical challenges of communication through whiteboards and electronic devices, the social isolation that can arise, and the deeper psychological and spiritual implications of such a significant physical change. The essay traces her journey from initial denial through miraculous thinking and daydreams of healing, to eventual acceptance and recognition of grief as a natural response to loss.

Drawing on key Buddhist teachings, Noirin examines how physical disability challenges our sense of identity and self-worth. She references the final link of paṭicca samuppāda (Dependent Origination) to understand how we 'take birth' in concepts of ourselves, and explores the arising of shame, anger, and the desire 'not to be' when reality doesn't match our self-image. The essay sensitively addresses misconceptions about kamma and disability, while finding profound Dhamma lessons in the experience of living with a significant physical limitation.

With characteristic humor and insight, Noirin shows how even the most challenging circumstances can become teachers, referring to her condition as 'Devadutta' - a messenger of difficult but valuable teachings. This essay offers valuable perspectives for anyone facing illness, disability, or major life changes, demonstrating how mindfulness and Buddhist wisdom can transform suffering into understanding.

Laryngectomy Dhamma.

Hello again! First an update: I'm living in my own home again – just came back last week. Many thanks

to all my friends and family for helping me get this far, and especial thanks to Margaret and Pat with

whom I have been staying since I left hospital in September. For their friendship, tireless care,

encouragement and quiet, unfussy kindness, I am truly grateful.

What follows is another reflection on life since my laryngectomy (removal of the vocal chords) last July..

This time I'm going to explore my experience of living without my natural voice. I'm only scraping the

surface of this teaching. In fact this essay is my first attempt to reflect on the experience. But for what

it's worth ... here goes.

At many levels its easier than I could have imagined. Like the way shopkeepers hardly bat an eye when I

write on the whiteboard instead of asking them verbally for what I want. Texts and emails still work

fine. And among friends, when discussions get deep, the slow pace of writing can be OK. It gives time

for relaxation and reflection by contrast to the fast pace of speech. And at times it can be great to be

able to take a back-seat and listen to conversations without any pressure to contribute. Once, when

someone came to dinner and I was exhausted by the effort before we even sat down at the table, I felt

so relieved to be able to stall the pace, writing slowly, giving myself time to take a few breaths and

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If you press it against the throat the buzz penetrates to the vocal cavity where it can be modulated into

speech sounds by moving your jaw and tongue and lips just as you would when speaking normally. A

wonderful device really ... but ... do you remember the Dalecs in Dr.Who? That's what to expect when

we meet! The first thing Bhante asked me to say was "Exterminate them!"

Children love it – I'm a great novelty for them. And sometimes it gives me a laugh too. Those are the

good days. But it's hard work by comparison to natural speech. My tongue and other muscles round my

neck have been damaged by the surgery, so I can only speak quite slowly and have to make a big effort

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for their patience and understanding here. I do have good fun in conversations on occasion but lots of opportunities for light-hearted interaction get lost. During the initial recovery period and the radio / chemo treatments, I hardly thought about losing my voice at all. I had plenty of fear, anxiety and other forms of aversion, but they weren't connected to coherent thoughts of having lost my voice. The only thoughts that came up were mildly consoling ones. For example, I often thought "I don't need to talk right now" or "You don't need to talk a lot of the time". But the down-side of my situation was literally unthinkable. Then a friend gave me Colm Toibin's book 'The Testament of Mary'. This opened Pandora's box and the snakes came sliding through! I wondered why the book was making me so happy (it's a powerful but not at all a happy story). I found I was buzzing with the delightful thought of Jesus's miracles! I had never reflected much on that aspect of the Christian story before. But now ... the possibility of a miracle .. and maybe for me ... a glimmer of hope was born! At one level, of course, I could

laugh at myself. But a moment later I was sucked in again. Miracles happened then – why not now? I could go to Lourdes, Knock, Medjugorje! Or why not a Buddhist healing – that would be more appropriate! Bhante's Bodycare. The Medicine Buddha. And sure, while he was curing my throat, couldn't he give me back my strength and mobility in my arms and neck and shoulders as well? How about the body of a thirty-year-old? That would be grand. Smiling happily, heart soaring, I just knew the healing was coming my way soon. Then a wave of rationality would wash over: 'Come on Noirin, get a grip!' The daydreams didn't come up in formal meditation but for days or even weeks they flared up again and again in daily life. This was my first emotional reaction to the laryngectomy – getting high on the thought of reversing it all! The high certainly lifted my spirits, but the effort of continually reigning in the delusion was exhausting. Eventually I got fed up with the daydreaming mind and really wanted to stop buying into the delusion. But ... how to do this without suppressing the hope, and the desire for well-being? I noticed it only happened when I was in good humour. The mind would catch on to the good humour and build a great future of health and strength. Why couldn't I just enjoy the good humour instead? I tried the note 'dreaming of now, dreaming of now' to help bring me back to the present moment. I could feel the happiness, and on the edge of this, my painful flickering attempts to grasp at it, to make it mine, to project it into a wonderful future. As I focused on these feelings, the other aspects of 'now' sank in: no miracle, no voice box, no speech. Happiness turned to sorrow, but I preferred it to delusion, and my heart began to open, grateful for the Dhamma lesson, glad to be touching at last on the grief of losing my voice. With that the heady daydreams disappeared and I was able to start thinking rationally about the reality

of my situation. I had been wondering when it would hit me. Now that I could recognize the grief I could also see it had been lurking, unrecognised, in my earlier fear and anxiety. I had been turning away from the obvious reality in terror, having no idea how to live without a voice. I was reminded of the opening words of C. Day Lewis's "A Grief Observed": No one ever told me that grief that was so like fear. It was a relief to be able to name it as grief. With that, compassion arose and I could acknowledge the loss. It was as simple as saying: Yes Noirin, this is tough. But that simple recognition meant everything. I felt more able and willing to care for a being who lives with laryngectomy.

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or ‘mouth’ their words silently. If I’m in good humour, this can be amusing. But if I’m not, it can trigger rage. One time, when I was in a sulk, a nursing attendant assumed my incommunicative state meant that I didn’t understand what he was saying (in fairness to him I wasn’t even nodding to acknowledge his message, just glaring at him - so you could say I got what I deserved! Such is the cost of expressing anger angrily. His response was just a reflection of what I was putting out into the world). He started speaking loudly, one word at a time, miming and gesticulating in his efforts to communicate. I wanted to shout: “I’m not stupid, I’m not deaf, I’m just furious can’t you see!” But of course I couldn’t (just as well or I would have had plenty of ‘wrong speech’ to regret!), and scrawling it on the whiteboard didn’t seem like an option. When he left I paced the room, dragging my drip-stand with me, livid with rage and frustration. Later, I remembered the Buddha’s words: What the world finds ugly, I find beautiful. Everything around me and within me seemed despicable and horribly ugly. And yet the Buddha would find this beautiful? Tears of rage and self-pity flowed into the incomprehensible consolation of his vision. Then again, there is the temptation to find fault. Someone must be to blame for all this. Myself? For not taking the warning signs seriously enough? My doctors? My kamma? The Buddha taught that misfortune can occur for many reasons – e.g. heredity or environment as well as resulting from past misdeeds. So I cannot assume that this is a fruit of ‘bad kamma’. Intellectually I accept this, and am very glad that I don’t have to see this as punishment. But when a neighbour called and, probably troubled by my condition, said: “I don’t know what you did in your previous life but I hope you enjoyed it at the time!” I saw how little I understood the teaching at depth. I reacted with deep anger at her judgement but once

again I was saved by the slow pace of the whiteboard and her visit passed off cordially. Good thing too, as it was Christmas eve! But later as I reflected on her remark and my reaction, I saw my deeper fear: this speechless condition was a sign to all that I was being punished for my misdeeds. With that my resentment toward the neighbour diminished. I saw that what was troubling me was not her judgement but my own confusion, at the heart level, regarding the law of kamma. I was shocked and depressed by that glimpse of my judgemental mind's reaction to having a disability. Another deep layer of dukkha needing exploration. What could give me heart for the journey? I

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Noirin Sheahan

A Field of Barley

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 2 min read

In this deeply personal reflection, Noirin Sheahan shares her experience of encountering a beautiful field of barley and the complex emotional responses it evoked. The essay demonstrates how the final three factors of the Noble Eightfold Path—sammā vāyāma (Right Effort), sammā sati (Right Awareness), and sammā samādhi—can serve as practical guides when confronting the challenging realities of attachment and impermanence.

The narrative traces the journey from initial delight and grasping desire through aversion and the impulse to look away, to a deeper acceptance facilitated by muditā (appreciative joy), one of the four brahmavihāras or divine abodes. Through careful attention to physical sensations and emotional responses, the author discovers underlying grief about transience—the painful truth that everything we love will pass away.

This teaching illustrates how mindfulness practice can transform our relationship with beauty, loss, and even death itself. Rather than turning away from difficult truths, the cultivation of Right Awareness allows us to remain present with both joy and sorrow, finding a deeper peace that encompasses life's full spectrum. The essay offers practical wisdom for anyone seeking to understand how Buddhist training can be applied to everyday moments of beauty and the inevitable encounters with impermanence that define human existence.

Noirin Sheahan On a sunny afternoon last weekend, I walked by a field of barley, mesmerised by its beauty. The stems were unusually tall, almost shoulder height, and a light breeze rippled the leaves into exquisite shades of green and gold. It was as though I had entered a van Gogh painting! Something hungry inside wanted to devour the scene, master it, keep it for a rainy day. And that something felt frustrated and angry at the impossibility of this. The final section of the eightfold path - training the mind using the factors of Right Effort, Mindfulness and Samadhi[1]- turned up as guides. Mindfulness registered delight at the scene, desire to swallow it up, anger at my inability to do this. It registered the physicality of this emotional cocktail: desire opening the chest, pushing the head upwards, anger tightening the face and throat, furrowing the brow and eyes. The clash of opposing forces felt painful. Craving for beauty morphed into disgust. Desire switched course in an instant, told me to forget this nonsense, look away, think of other things. Again there was a strong physical component: desire was now trying to turn the neck, head and eyes away from the barley field, find a new draw for the imagination. This felt like the easy option, and the force of mind com-

manding “Move on” was almost irresistible. At this point Right Effort stepped up to prevent me taking the habitual easy option. I reminded myself of Mudita, appreciative joy, which the Buddha described as a ‘divine abode’ for the mind. Despite its transience, we are to take in the beauty of life, let it halt the river of thought that persuades us to do something more useful than stare at a field of waving barley. Armed with the motivation to practice mudita, I found the willingness not to turn the head and eyes away from the scene. Mindfulness registered aversion and disgust but also moments of ease when the mind rested in silent wonder at the sight of green-gold barley. Gradually those moments grew longer, and drew thoughts to a close. This is Samadhi, the mind’s natural preference to rest, let go of its protests and useless babble. After a while I could relax enough to let attention sink into the unpleasant tightness in the chest, neck and face. The close-up physical perspective let me glimpse shades of grief which I hadn’t previously registered. The field of barley was showing me the heartbreaking truth of transience: what we love is forever slipping through our fingers. Once I could feel and acknowledge grief, the experience became easier. Physical tensions relaxed and I could appreciate the beauty without grasping it painfully. Appreciative joy mingled with sombre thoughts of death and dying. I was surprised at how calm the mind remained as it acknowledged that my personal story along with my experience of life would come to an end. Despite twinges of grief, the thought seemed more acceptable than usual, even somehow beautiful, as if it too were dancing in waves of green-gold barley. Thank goodness for Mindfulness and how it can be shored up by Right Effort at times of need; how it enables the stillness of Samadhi, where we can ponder unwelcome truths without adding to our fear of death, our hunger for life. I trust the trio to work hard at my death-bed, persuading me not to turn away in disgust, perhaps reminding me of death’s dance in a field of waving barley.[1] Usually translated as Concentration which unfortunately suggests straining, while Samadhi denotes an unforced gathering of mind or peaceful abiding.

Satipanya Porridge

Noirin Sheahan · 2 min read

This intimate essay by Noirin Sheahan transforms the simple act of eating porridge into a profound meditation on the nature of existence. Beginning with mindful attention to the sensory experience of breakfast, the narrative unfolds into deep contemplation of predator and prey dynamics, both literally in the eating process and metaphorically in human nature. The author skillfully weaves together personal reflection with fundamental Buddhist insights, particularly anicca (impermanence) and the reality of dukkha (suffering and unsatisfactoriness). Through honest observation of her own reactions—from enjoyment to revulsion to acceptance—she demonstrates how mindfulness practice reveals the transient nature of all experiences, including our attachments to them. The essay continues through the washing up, showing how sustained awareness transforms ordinary activities into opportunities for loving-kindness and appreciation. This piece exemplifies how Vipassanā meditation extends beyond formal sitting practice into every moment of daily life, revealing the 'simple abundance of the present moment' and the profound teaching that 'just this is enough.'

The spoon is raised, the head leans forward, mouth opens and warm, velvety porridge pours onto the tongue, eclipsing all other experience. After a while the jaws start moving and raisins are torn open and nudged around the mouth. A smile settles into my face as I relax and enjoy the first spoonful of porridge.

Savouring a raisin I am struck by the contrast between its soft juiciness and the hard sharpness of the teeth tearing into its flesh, destroying it. A TV image of an old bull being eaten by lions comes to mind. The bull moaning, the lions feasting. My sympathies were all for the bull when I watched the TV program, but now, although I feel for the vulnerability of the raisin, my tongue demands its sweetness and my teeth tear into it without mercy. I recognise in myself both bull and lion, predator and prey. Revulsion follows, not wanting any part in this contorted human nature, and pinching, bitter sensations fill my head and

chest. After a while, although I'm writhing inwardly, I am not above noticing that the fairly

neutral sensations of porridge feel much, much nicer than the bitterness in my own flesh.

There is some humiliation that the uninteresting taste of porridge (by now it's even cold)

calls attention more than my anguish at the dilemma of suffering! In dismay I try to resist

the comfort of cold porridge, but luckily I don't seem to be in charge of this show! After another few spoons there is only gratitude for the kindness of anicca (the transience of all

experience) which brings all suffering to an end. I notice again the sweetness of raisins and there is a sad appreciation of their ready giving way to the reality of sharp teeth and

grinding jaws. I dedicate the merit of breakfast to the welfare of the moaning bull and of all

suffering beings.

Now another bowl of porridge is almost empty, and I notice I have become disinterested in

the business of eating. My mind recedes from the situation. I also notice however that the

porridge feels just as velvety as at the first spoonful, the raisins taste just as sweet, the jaw

and tongue movements are as vivid as ever. It's only my attachment to the activity which is

dying away. This gives me a foretaste of my own death, and the knowledge that everything

except myself will survive this unscathed. I shiver with fear and excitement at my growing

acquaintance with a consciousness which does not mourn my passing. But this notion seems

too much for me to handle, and instead a bitter-sweet acknowledgement of my share in the

cycle of life and death settles into my heart.

After breakfast, washing the bowl and spoon, the mood changes to appreciation for warm

water, the colours of suds and hands and sleeves and bowl and sink, the gentle movements

of lifting and rubbing. I am relieved at the mood change, but sense something missing,

something being held back, dammed up. For a moment I'm puzzled but then the dam busts and goodwill quietly floods the scene, loving each moment of the immensely rich interaction process we call washing the dishes. Another smile settles on my face and I am thankful again for this meditation practice which has no favourites, finding each experience equally worthy of full attention. And so the day evolves from moment to moment, each self-made drama succumbing to the simple abundance of the present moment. Just this is enough I hear myself say, feeling the softness of the dish-cloth, the weight of the bowl, a sigh of contentment. Just this is enough.

Delusion, Caring for Illusion

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 2 min read

This essay examines the Buddha's profound teaching on anattā (not-self) and offers a nuanced approach to working with our deeply ingrained sense of self. Bhante Bodhidhamma guides us through the traditional investigation of self-hood within the five khandhas (aggregates) - body, feelings, perceptions, mental formations, and consciousness - showing how none can be found to contain a permanent, satisfactory essence that could constitute 'me' or 'mine'.

Rather than advocating the suppression of our sense of self, the essay presents a middle way approach. Drawing on the Buddha's teachings about self-compassion and the importance of cherishing ourselves enough to follow the spiritual path, Bhante Bodhidhamma suggests we can work mindfully with our sense of self as a teacher. The instinct to identify and define ourselves, though ultimately illusory, can become a guide to liberation when met with Right Awareness.

The teaching offers practical wisdom for meditators who struggle with the apparent contradiction between the doctrine of not-self and the necessity of a functioning sense of self in daily life and spiritual practice. By learning to observe the pushing and pulling of identity formation without resistance, practitioners can use these very movements of self-construction as opportunities for deeper insight into the nature of experience itself.

The Buddha's teaching on anatta (not-self) asks us to investigate our sense of self. To each of us, this is precious - our sense of being unique, individual, an entity in our own right. The Buddha doesn't confirm or deny this. But he questions our automatic assumption of self-hood within our body-mind system. He asks us to see can we find any essential self- essence within this, can we locate it, define it, pinpoint it. How about my body – surely that contains me? But when I look deeper, all I find is an array of shifting sensations. And when I think about it, can something so obviously vulnerable as this body represent my essential being? What about feelings? These certainly feel like me! But they change so easily ... same for perceptions, habitual drives, even my subjective experience – all changing, at the mercy of external conditions. Can something so precious as my sense of self really be so unreliable? If so, I'm most unsatisfactory! Instead of drawing such an unhappy conclusion, the Buddha asks us to follow the investigation with a question: Since I cannot find anything in my body or mind that is reliable, permanent, satisfying, should I assume that my essential self is contained within my body

and mind? When he asks this question of his disciples they answer 'no'. He approves, confirming that nothing in our body-mind experience, can properly be thought of as 'Mine / Me / Myself'. When we make one of our habitual mistakes, thinking of our bodies, achievements, experiences as 'mine', or get caught up in plans, dreams, arguments, or mistaking this hot and bothered entity as 'me', we've fallen into delusion. But there is a danger of throwing out the baby with the bathwater. The sense of self is central to our life in the world and also to our spiritual life. Just because we keep getting it wrong, mistaking our bodies, emotions, ideas etc. as 'me' or 'mine', this doesn't mean the sense of self is inherently useless and needs to be quelled whenever it arises. On the contrary, the Buddha asks us to spend time directing kind good wishes towards ourselves. We need this kindness to fulfil our unique potential for full liberation. If you cherish yourself, he says, then follow the spiritual path. Cherish ourselves? Cherish an illusion? A mistaken identity? Yes! Mindfully of course. When the sense of self is strong we feel for a moment the pleasure of this – perhaps we think of it as being centred, well defined or happy. But something deep inside wants more. It wants these feelings, this perception of 'me' to be permanent. Gradually the illusion breaks down. We realise it was a mistake. It didn't define an essential, unchanging 'me'. But mistakes are just mistakes. We don't have to despair. We can learn from them. Keeping attention on the experience we feel physical pushing and pulling within body and mind, pulling towards some new definition of 'me / mine' as we push away whatever appears to threaten that. Can we allow all that pushing and pulling to lead us along the path? At times it leads us to new definitions, new understandings. At times it leads us to a simpler experience of sensations and feelings without any conceptual overlay of 'me / mine / you / yours' etc. Then the desire for identity pokes out again, pushing and pulling us into some new definition of who or what we are. The instinct to identify is strong within us. It won't be quelled just because we've heard the teaching on not-self. Rather than fight with the instinct, we can let it be our teacher, our guide to liberation. Cherish the illusion – mindfully of course!

Three Score Years and Ten!

Noirin Sheahan · 17 min read

In this deeply moving autobiographical essay, Noirin Sheahan traces her remarkable spiritual journey from childhood in 1950s Catholic Ireland to her 70th birthday spent in silent retreat in Portugal. Beginning with the family rosary practice at her grandmother's house in Cork, she describes how this early form of meditation planted seeds that would eventually flower into Buddhist practice decades later. The essay chronicles pivotal moments including a profound childhood spiritual insight at age eight, family tragedies including her brother's death and mother's mental illness, her career in medical physics, and a transformative mid-life crisis that led her to prioritize spiritual development above all else.

Noirin candidly shares her struggles between Christianity and Buddhism before committing fully to the Buddha's path under Bhante Bodhidhamma's guidance. She describes profound meditation experiences including insights into anattā (not-self) that brought both terror and liberation, her journey through cancer and major surgery, and her eventual move to Satipanya Buddhist Retreat where she now teaches. The essay beautifully illustrates how dukkha (unsatisfactoriness) can become a teacher, how mindfulness transforms relationships, and how the Three Jewels provide refuge through life's inevitable challenges. Written with remarkable honesty and wisdom, this memoir offers inspiration for practitioners at any stage of their spiritual journey.

Three score years and ten!

How did it come about that I should spend 12 hours of my 70th birthday sitting in silence or taking baby footsteps around a house in Portugal? And then come back here to Satipanya to celebrate my 'official' birthday with all of you?

I think it traces back to summer holidays in my granny's house in Cork and the habit of the family rosary – everyone gathered in the evening, knelt down and said the prayer together. Ireland in the 1950s was very much a catholic country and Sunday mass and confession and so on were a big part of life. I don't think many families still kept up the practice of the daily rosary but I'm very grateful that it was still alive in my Granny's house while I was a child.

The rosary is a prayer that takes about 15 minutes. There are five 'mysteries' to contemplate, each one a different scene from the life of Christ – or from his death and resurrection and beyond. It somehow clicked with me – to hold an image in the imagina-

tion while saying a very simple, repetitive prayer – it gave me a way of taking to heart what was taught as truly important and fundamental in life. It was a form of meditation – bringing my mind to a quiet place where I could sense some connection with deeper truth.

After the holidays my mum, dad and brother Conor and I went back to Dublin. We didn't say the family rosary at home, it obviously didn't mean much to my mum or dad, and definitely not my brother Conor. He was a carefree and wild, always getting into some sort of trouble, whereas I was a dreamy child – at least that's how my granny described me and I think she was right.

So, maybe because I liked dreamy images from the life of Christ, I continued the rosary on my own, though snuggled up in bed rather than on my knees on the cold floor. Climbing into bed I'd be grumbling that I'd much prefer to daydream than say the rosary, but I'd make a bargain with myself to say just one mystery and then daydream, but when I got to the end of the first mystery, I'd decide to do a second mystery and then daydream ..., and so on till I got through all five. By that time, sleep beckoned and I no longer had the energy to bother daydreaming!

In retrospect I'm very grateful for the family rosary practice –both because it put some limit on my habit of daydreaming and because it was my first taste of meditation – a quieting of the mind as it opens in awe. I lost the habit as I grew older. Though I've no memory of deciding to stop, it may have been after what you might call my first spiritual insight, which came when I was eight. I was praying one evening when I suddenly knew that there was a presence beside and around me that was separate to me. It seemed to drop like a thud into my mind. One moment I was the only one in the room, then suddenly there was also this mysterious presence which I took to be God.

While I didn't feel God's presence as threatening, I didn't feel it as loving either. It was just 'there', 'other'. The main way it affected me was to show me that I'd been making this big mistake – that all my thoughts of God and my prayers had all been make-believe, that I'd never known God till now. Maybe I got myself mixed up with the idea of false gods – from the first of the ten commandments – thou shalt love the Lord thy God and thou shalt not put false gods before me. To my mind I had committed a dreadful sin – made up a false image of God. The guilt multiplied up with the judgement that I'd never said any proper prayers in my life (hundreds and hundreds of sins), and because I'd never confessed these, I'd made bad confessions (each one a mortal sin!) and then I'd compounded the problem by going to communion with the mortal sin of a bad confession on my soul and so I'd made bad communions (more mortal sins!).

Within a few minutes I had clocked up several hundred mortal sins because in those days you went to confession and communion every week. The reason I know I was eight when this happened is because I had to multiply my two mortal sins per week (for my bad confession and bad communion) by 52 for every year since my first communion, which was when I was five, and I had to add in extra bad confessions and bad communions for all the feast days and Christmas days. And I found even more as I scoured through my little green catechism to be sure I got them all multiplied up correctly before my next confession.

I imagine I stopped saying the rosary after that – there couldn't have been any joy or peace in it. Although the guilt probably undermined me subconsciously, the episode didn't mark my life at the surface level, which was a good thing. Beyond making sure I got to confession as soon as possible to get all my sins forgiven I don't remember thinking about it much and I doubt anyone in the family or among my friends knew anything had happened.

So that was the first phase of my religious life – meditation, devotion, mystery, a thud of insight and then a plunge into guilt.

In many ways I had a happy childhood. My brother Conor was just a year older and we were very close and there were dozens of children our age living nearby, so always someone to play with. My dad worked as a weather forecaster at the airport and we didn't have financial problems. However there was always a background anxiety hanging over us, because my mother had bipolar depression. It was first diagnosed as post-natal depression after Conor was born and then again after my birth. In those days there was no psychotherapy available or even much kindness in psychiatric practice, just Electric shock treatment and heavy sedation. And so she never really recovered. For much of our childhood she was in bed and very depressed, and every six months or so she would have an acute flare up, and get into rows with family or neighbours, until eventually she had to be admitted to hospital again for more ECT and sedation. While she was in hospital, myself and my brother would stay with cousins, sometimes both at the one house, sometimes split up.

At the time, I didn't see this as a problem, I liked my cousins and enjoyed staying with them. But I know now that my mother's illness took a toll at a deeper level, and underlay my later mid-life crisis and the fear that suddenly emerged during a retreat in 1999.

Another major sorrow was that Conor's wildness caught up with him just after he turned 18 – he went out to a dance one Saturday night and never came home – he was killed in a road accident. That was a devastating blow for all the family as you can imagine.

But life went on. Although I had lost the habit of the rosary, I never lost the sense of mystery that it had kindled. There was a strong wish to understand the deeper truths of life which was why I opted to study physics after school, on the assumption that understanding the basic laws of physics meant I would understand life itself and be happy.

But even before I finished college, I realised I was onto the wrong track. Nothing I was learning was helping me understand life better or be any happier. Though that was disappointing, there were lots of compensations – the physics class was small – only 12 of us and we made good friends, hiking over mountains at the weekends, renting cottages in the country during holidays, playing tennis into the long summer evenings, frantic study before the exams, and of course many pints of creamy Guinness to help us put the world right – when I started college a pint cost 18 pence, by the time I'd finished it had gone up to a staggering 23 pence!

So college was a wonderful experience and our physics class still gets together frequently – in fact we're having a collective 70th birthday party next month as we've all reached this milestone during the year.

After college I did a teacher training course, only to discover that teaching wasn't for me either. At a bit of a loose end for a while, I was delighted to discover that there was a career called "medical physics" and jobs in this area in most big hospitals. The delight was from the thought that, even though I might not understand life deeply, I could contribute meaningfully to it.

My first job was in London, in the Royal Free Hospital, with a team who were researching lung function and especially the role of aerosols in diagnosis and in treatment. It was a dream start – a small friendly team, enthusiastic about work, curious to try new techniques, a very happy work environment. Plus a deepening relationship with Adrian, who I had met during the teacher training course. We were well suited and happy until my mother suddenly took a dislike to him. Once there was talk of the relationship becoming serious and him buying a house, he suddenly became, in her eyes, not good enough for me. And the sad thing was that I hadn't detached myself enough to withstand her disapproval. Once she lost confidence in him, I lost confidence in him. The joy in the relationship went out and eventually we broke up. In retrospect I can see that this failure to define myself as separate to my mother left me with a lot of bitterness and self-doubt.

But as always life went on, and after three years at the Royal Free, I came back to Dublin in my mid-twenties, working in a number of different hospitals until I took early retirement in 2007, aged 53. The first decade or so was a happy time – friendly colleagues, stimulating work with lots of fascinating research, enough challenges to make things interesting, enough routine to keep me grounded. I made good friends, we played tennis, squash, went hill walking, hired cottages together for holidays.

In retrospect, the most important incident was when colleague gave me the book ‘The Tao of Physics’ by Fritz Capra. This linked modern physics with Eastern mysticism, and opened up a whole new world for me. I was overjoyed to realise there was another way of understanding life that didn’t involve maths and physics, but meditation. I found DT Suzuki’s Zen Mind, Beginner’s Mind and started practicing meditation. A while later I found a meditation group and another chapter in life opened up – weekly meetings, dhamma study, retreats, and perhaps most important of all, close friendship with others in the group – we are still good friends to this day.

One claim to fame for our little group was that we can say we ‘discovered’ Bhante Bodhidharma, invited him to teach his first ever retreat in Dublin back in the mid 1980s, and he came back for several years afterwards to teach weekend retreats. Our group was also party to his first 10-day retreat which was held in Kerry in the late 1990s.

For a decade or more, I couldn’t make up my mind between Buddhism and Christianity. I think some of it stemmed from fear of damnation because I was now definitely putting a false god before the true God of the catechism. And some was the sense of identity with the Christian story – I really wanted to believe it all, whereas the Buddha and the vague notion of enlightenment didn’t appeal to me at that personal-story level. I did quite a number of silent meditation retreats with the Carmelite order as well as the weekends with Bhante or other Buddhist teachers and found both forms to be very helpful and inspiring. The main attraction of Buddhism for me was the friendship group, they were my own age, good fun, open to questions, we used to go out hill walking together, went away on a cycling holiday, celebrated Christmas and birthday parties. Whereas the people I met at the Catholic retreats were usually much older than me, more settled in life and more pious than questioning so there wasn’t much discussion and I never developed any friendships.

I am so grateful that the spiritual aspect of my life opened up, because as middle-age approached, the lights went out in other areas. After the disappointment over Adrian, I never again managed to form a committed relationship, and the fun went out of medical physics once I became senior, had to take responsibility for services. It came to a

head in my mid-forties, while I was also doing a course in ‘The Spiritual Exercises of Ignatius Loyola’ – a form of spiritual training in daily life developed by the Jesuits. The course is well known for making people more vulnerable than usual and in my case this plus a combination of work-stress and unexpected relationship issues brought on a mental-health crisis – couldn’t sleep, couldn’t stop crying, couldn’t find anything to believe in.

I offered to hand in my resignation at work, but the hospital was very decent, they could see I was unwell, and persuaded me to take six months off to think about things and then make a decision.

During those months as I looked back on life, it seemed to me that the only thing that hadn’t let me down was meditation practice. Career and relationships just seemed burdensome now. Family held no joy at all. Although I loved my father very much, and we had played bridge together for many years, but he died when I was thirty and my relationship with my mother, never strong to start with, went further downhill after that. I did have good friends from college days, and from work and from my meditation group. They were a support, but not a reason to live. The only thing that offered hope was the spiritual realm – I’d lost confidence in the world.

And so I made the decision that from now on, spiritual development would be my principle aim in life, everything else would come secondary to it. Being realistic, I knew I didn’t have what it would take to head off into the hills as a hermit, and I was too old (45 at that stage) to be taken in as a novice nun. Also the recent breakdown showed me I needed to be gentle with myself, not expect too much, take baby steps rather than giant leaps. So I changed my work arrangement at the hospital, took a part time appointment at basic grade level so that I wouldn’t have so much responsibility and could organise my work-time so as to take months off as needed for retreat and then work full time between retreats. This gave me the means to support myself financially as well as the time needed for spiritual development.

Although I was still undecided between Christianity and Buddhism, the decision was made for me, because the teacher who was guiding me through the Spiritual Exercises, cut me off completely once I had that breakdown. It wasn’t done unkindly, it was just their policy. You go to a doctor for mental health issues and come back to spiritual practice when you’re balanced again. Whereas when I told Bhante about the breakdown, he hardly blinked an eye, just told me to get back on the cushion and watch the emotional storm. From then on I never wavered, I realised Buddhism, at least in the form Bhante taught, was what I needed to hold me together in life.

In retrospect I can see that my life became happier from this point onwards. I had been happy as a child and young adult, because things were mostly easy, going my way. But the happiness that started growing now was coming from a deeper place, from the wisdom of the first noble truth, realising that nothing in life was going to satisfy, and the inspiration of the third noble truth, trusting in the possibility of being free from suffering, content and happy.

One way I first noticed this growing happiness was the transformation I found in my work colleagues. Many whom I had dismissed as foolish or unreliable before I had taken my 6 months leave turned out to be wise and trustworthy once I returned! I could genuinely enjoy their company again. I also began to see an improvement in my relationship with my mother. Having taken a decisive step in my own life, a new level of respect started to grow between us. By the time of her latter years, hatred had transformed to love and we were quite at ease with one another. I moved back to the family home to support her after she turned 90. Although I'd earlier dreaded the prospect of her becoming dependant on me, caring for her turned out to be as easy as tying my shoelaces, not blissful but just ordinary, not a problem.

Considering my earlier dread of her depending on me, and the contrasting simplicity of caring for her in her final year gave me vivid proof of the fruits of spiritual practice, and brought a lot of happiness.

But I've skipped forward 20 years there – back to my mid-life crisis now. It was around this time that Bhante started teaching 10-day or longer retreats in various locations in Ireland and the UK before moving to Gaia House as Spiritual Director. I became one of the regular attendees. It was towards the end of my first 2-week retreat that I had an insight, which was possibly a revisiting of my childhood insight of God as a real presence, separate to me. While I was walking along the garden path, I became aware of an expansive presence, a still, peaceful knowing, which filled the sky and pervaded everything around me. In that moment I knew that all my sensory experience was in total harmony with this presence: seeing, hearing, moving, these were not disturbing or disturbed by the presence. The only thing that was at odds was my belief in being a separate person, independent. I saw the experience as a demonstration of the truth of anatta, and in a flash knew that I would have to lose the identity I called Noirin if I was going to attain Nibanna.

Although I'd always wanted insight, as soon as it came I wished it hadn't! It brought up a huge surge of fear – felt like particles of fear were surging up my throat and out my mouth. While I hadn't felt the presence as threatening in any way, just peaceful, knowing, non-interfering, what frightened me was the knowledge that I'd been making

this huge mistake, identifying with the story of my life. Who could I rely on if not myself? And I obviously couldn't rely on myself because I was the one making the mistake of identifying as me!

This marked another turning point in life – a plunge into fear, but also a waking up. Bhante's support was wonderful, he radiated confidence that I could work with the fear, and I had begun to believe him even before the retreat was over. It wasn't easy though – since mid-life I'd always had problems sleeping and now sleep seemed out of the question. Also the fearful turbulence led to auditory hallucinations among other things - every now and then, it seemed as though a hurricane was blowing up, the wind was howling, trees smashing. Or else someone would be rubbing a packet of crisps right in my ear, or walking with very heavy footsteps round and round my seat. Fortunately the visual field wasn't affected so all I had to do was open my eyes to check that none of this was real and then go back to working with the anxieties and fear underlying all this strangeness.

What seemed even more fearful was that my face would twitch spontaneously, my tongue waggle around my mouth. The notion that I was not in control of my own body movements seemed to me horrific.

The twitching and hallucinations eased off after the retreat was over, though fear and anxiety accompanied me for a long time along with sleeplessness. The payoff was increased mindfulness because the fearful thoughts were even more upsetting than the present-moment feeling of fear, so for my own peace of mind I had no choice but to be mindful. "Condemned to the present moment" was how I thought of myself!

In time I started to see how I was benefitting – boredom, for example, was a thing of the past, and I had no time for hopelessness or negative thinking – the call to presence was too strong. In turn, all my relationships grew more trusting and appreciative. This was particularly true within the family. As the bond between myself and my mother strengthened, so also that bond extended to my many cousins, aunts and uncles. Although circumstances prevent me seeing them often, I sense them as a source of friendship, joy and care.

The deepest gift was the steadily growing faith in the Dhamma. Especially the truth of dukkha and how simply being mindful of dukkha led to positive change. I was very chuffed when, in 2003, Bhante asked me to assist him in teaching. I felt this as a great honour, and a confirmation that I had turned a corner in life.

Trust in the Dhamma was my saviour when, in 2005 I was diagnosed with throat cancer, which was treated with radiotherapy, giving me 7 good years until it returned with a vengeance leading to not just major but 'heroic' surgery in 2013 with only a 50:50 chance of survival. It also meant losing my voice box. I've written about that in some essays on the website, so won't say much here, except that this unwanted turn of events brought deeper faith and insight along with its natural share of sorrow.

And so lets skip forward to 2020, when after a fall in which she broke her hip, my mother died. A peaceful death, I'm happy to say, and I was with her at the time which was a gift I will always treasure.

By this stage I was long retired and had always thought of coming to live near Satipanya after my mother's death. She died in January 2020 and in March I came to Satipanya to join the final month of the winter retreat. But then the covid lockdown happened and I never went home!

Initially it was because it was considered unsafe to travel, but as the weeks and months went by, it became clear that there really was no good reason to go back to Dublin, and that I would be far happier staying at Satipanya. Luckily Bhante was also pleased to be able to offload some of the management responsibilities, and I was happy to take on more of the teaching, so the covid lockdown was, for me, a great blessing – opening up a new phase in life for me which I trust as very beneficial.

To mark this new phase, I took lay ordination in 2021, to help me take heart in the Dhamma as the inspiration for my life and dedicate the remainder of my time on earth to practice in accordance with the Buddha-Dhamma-Sangha. Part of this is an annual retreat, which I take during the winter months. As a treat for my 70th birthday I booked a house in Portugal from January last year till the middle of February, and spent my 70th birthday exploring the joys and woes of the inner life, opening some doors in my mind, making peace with those that remain stubbornly closed.

I honestly can't think of a more satisfying way to mark my 70th birthday.

A final word about friendship ... One wonderful aspect of dhamma practice is that you meet the best of people, considerate, honest, good-natured, kind, making the best of life's vicissitudes, interested in spiritual matters. It's a heaven realm from that point of view and I want to thanks all of you reading this for the deep contribution you have made to my life.

I want to finish by thanking Bhante Bodhidhamma for forgiving my many mistakes and encouraging me at every opportunity. Although his joi-de-vivre can sometimes be infuriating (why can't he just get despondent and defeated like any normal human be-

ing? I'd be thinking to myself) there is always some small corner of my mind that's willing to trust his good humour as a guide through whatever difficulty is presenting. Just as the rosary guided me in childhood, Bhante's teaching, friendship, and unstinting support have guided my latter years, gentling the decline into old age, inspiring faith in what lies beyond.

As Winter Approaches

Noirin Sheahan · 2 min read

This deeply personal essay by Noirin Sheahan weaves together grief, seasonal change, and Buddhist teaching in a moving exploration of embodied awareness. Writing in November, she reflects on her mother's death and love for winter evenings, using this memory as a foundation for examining our relationship with the physical elements that constitute our bodily experience.

Sheahan explores the traditional Buddhist understanding of the four elements (mahābhūta) - earth, water, air, and fire - showing how seasonal changes, particularly the fading light and warmth of November, can become teachers rather than sources of depression. She examines our deep attachment to bodily comfort and the mental commentary that overlays simple physical sensations, drawing on the insight that most of us live 'at a little distance from our bodies.'

The essay offers practical guidance for using winter's challenges as opportunities for mindfulness practice, suggesting we learn to rest attention on immediate physical sensations like cold toes or warm hands, observing both the raw experience and our mental reactions. Through patient observation, she shows how the overlay of preference and aversion can simplify and even cease, revealing an intimate connection with present-moment reality that serves as a counterpoint to mental proliferation.

Traditionally, November is the month of the dead, the 'Holy Souls' in Christian understanding. It's a time to remember those we have lost. I am especially remembering my mum who died in January. She used to love this time of year - closing the curtains early and looking forward to long evenings by the fireside. For many people November has the opposite effect. As the days get shorter and the sunlight fades a gloomy depression mounts. It's humbling to see our dependence on physical basics like daylight and sunshine for optimism and good humour. It's also an opportunity to reflect on the teaching on the elements – earth, water, air and fire – the basis for bodily experience. Earth represents solidity; we sense this as pressure, hardness, softness, weight. We experience the water element when it spatters into our face as rain, lets eyelids skim over the delicate surface of the cornea. The air element represents movement – we sense this when we turn our head, when the legs swing while we walk. The fire element is responsible for the November blues; changes in temperature and light tell us that this element, like the others, is not to be taken for granted, not ours to have when we want it to discard

when we want something else. We're very attached to bodily experience! As a baby it was our main source of pleasure and pain. Later the mental world became more prominent – the pleasure of reading, socializing, achieving, the pain of misunderstanding, rejection, failure. Delusion allows our mental life to take over the show; like James Joyce's Mr. Duffy, most of us live "at a little distance from our bodies". The fading of heat and light at this time of year provides a wake-up-call. Warmth is the vital sign of life while light has spiritual as well as physical significance – near death experiences often report moving through a dark tunnel towards light. No wonder we are so deeply attached! To go to the root of the problem we need to rediscover the pleasure and pain of the embodied life, rest attention on cold toes or warm hands. There's the simple physicality of warmth or coolness; there's also the overlay of commentary, liking, disliking, desire & aversion. As we watch, the overlay simplifies down, and when conditions are right, stops. What a relief! An easy intimacy grows, but so delicate! It shatters with any grumbling for more heat, brighter light ... Slowly and painfully we learn to drop our preferences, be grateful for whatever sensations the body offers. These sensations provide our footing in reality, a welcome counterpoint to the unending chit-chat of the mind. With our feet planted firmly in reality, our true nature can take shape. I like to remember my mum's November evenings when she gladly turned away from the hustle and bustle of life to rest by her fireside, read her books. I can follow her lead, retreat into my body, let it become my focus for winter evenings, curl up with the book of Dhamma – the real-life one printed on direct experience. The chapter on the elements is always a good place to start. What better way to greet the cold, dark days of November than by learning to love the vibrant stimulation we term 'cold', discovering peace in darkness? Thanks for the memories, Mum.

Attachment: The Five Khandhas

Noirin Sheahan · 47 min

In this teaching, Noirin Sheahan examines the five khandhas—the aggregates of clinging that form our entire conditioned experience. Using the striking metaphor of free-fall from an airplane, she illustrates how we desperately grasp at material form, vedanā (feeling-tone), perception, saṅkhāra (mental formations), and consciousness in our futile attempt to find security in an inherently unstable world.

The talk explores each khandha in detail: how we cling to our bodies and possessions (form), chase pleasant feelings while avoiding unpleasant ones (vedanā), create fixed perceptions including the sense of self (saññā), identify with emotions and mind-states (saṅkhāra), and finally attach to the very awareness that experiences it all (viññāṇa). Noirin shows how all clinging ultimately reduces to wanting pleasant vedanā, and how understanding the three characteristics of anicca, dukkha, and anattā in relation to each khandha can lead to the joy of non-clinging.

Drawing from personal retreat experiences and practical examples, this teaching offers both theoretical understanding and experiential guidance for recognizing our patterns of attachment and discovering the peace that comes from letting go—the taste of nibbāna itself.

Tonight I want to talk about the five *khandha*, which is a teaching often translated as the five aggregates of clinging. By now I am sure you are aware that clinging to our experience as "me" and "mine" causes suffering.

This is expressed in the second noble truth, that desire is the cause of suffering. Unless we can see desire as it arises, it generates a sense of self, and this newly created "me" devotes all my energy to trying to get more of the pleasure and get rid of the pain or distress. But this is stressful.

In moments of equanimity, when we can let things arise and pass away, we get a taste of freedom, a glimpse of the third noble truth, the cessation of suffering. All of the Buddha's teachings concern suffering and the end of suffering, but each time he gives us a slightly different perspective on this central theme. The better we get to know them all, the more choice we have in finding one to suit our circumstances.

For example, the wheel of dependent origination focuses on the step-by-step process which ends up in *dukkha*. We notice these links when our attention is drawn into a momentary experience of one thing leading to another. By contrast, the teaching on the khandha focuses on what it is we are clinging to. It's like taking a cross-section through our experience at any one time. The wheel looks at detail to find out how we create suffering. The khandha looks more broadly to discover what we are clinging to.

The word khandha is usually translated as an aggregate, which means an amalgamation of many separate elements. Aggregate is not such a common word, but sounds good by comparison to another translation of khandha as a heap. It's not very flattering to think of ourselves scrabbling round in five heaps of stuff as we make our way through life, but maybe this is a poignant image for our predicament.

The first of these heaps consists of material form. The second of *vedanā* or feeling. The third is composed of our perceptions. The fourth is our habitual tendencies or *saṅkhāra*. And finally we have consciousness. These five heaps cover all of our experience in life apart from the experience of *Nibbāna*.

We cling to the khandha because we don't see their basic characteristics of *anicca*, *dukkha*, and *anattā*. One metaphor which is often used to convey the true nature of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anattā* is that of free fall. Everything is slipping away at a great rate and you're completely out of control. There's nothing you can cling to. It's all disappearing too quickly. At first you're scared stiff because of the crash to earth you are anticipating, but in our fall into the reality of the three characteristics the crash never comes. Bit by bit we learn to relax and enjoy the experience.

So now I'm asking you to stretch your imagination a bit and think of your whole life as a long fall out of an aeroplane. Everything is slipping by at an alarming rate. Nothing gives any stability. You're spinning and tumbling out of control. You reach out in a vain effort to find anything that could slow things down. And suppose there are various objects that offer hope. Falling through a flock of geese, you could clutch at a few legs. The birds get dragged downwards, but they slow your fall and even hold you steady for a while. Relief. But then the rest of the flock descends to rescue the tethered geese by pecking at you so that you have to let go. You land on the wing of a glider plane. This offers a few moments bumpy ride, but your weight tips the plane over so you get ejected. Again and again you reach out for whatever will give you stability. These images represent our attempt to cling to the first khandha, material form.

If you were a very astute free faller you would have noticed that you feel good when you're managing to cling on and you would realize it's the feel-good you really want and start wondering whether there are easier ways of getting that pleasure. Now you

are intent on clinging to the second khandha, *vedanā*, or feeling, as a means of coping with the reality of ultimate doom. You have found one way of getting a pleasant feeling from the temporary security offered by material form. But all that pecking from wild geese is no fun and the bumpy rides are very bumpy, so you start looking around for other ways to help you feel good.

You notice the turning on your back helps. The sky looks much more stable than the fast approaching ground. Also, you come across a nice little heap of glasses and lenses that are falling to earth around you. Putting on rose tinted spectacles certainly helps. And also looking through lenses that make the ground seem far away. All these allow you change your perception of the situation. So now you're clinging to the third khandha, perception. You're choosing the perceptions of life that help you feel safe and secure.

But sometimes you can't find the right glasses and you notice that certain thoughts and patterns of behaviour also help you cope. For example, roaring and shouting about how awful and unfair it is that you fell from the plane gives you a bit of a buzz. And luckily, for the first few years of your free fall, there's a kind mother figure falling to earth alongside you who never fails to respond with milk and bickies. So now you're clinging to the fourth khandha, habitual behaviour, *saṅkhāra*. You're developing habits that give you a fleeting quick fix of pleasure.

But roaring and shouting gives you a headache, so as a last resort you turn to mindfulness. You learn to watch your experience without interfering. Things get peaceful. There's a soothing sense of simply being an observer, slightly aloof from the drama of your life. Now you are clinging to the last khandha, consciousness. Again, this gives that all-important hit of pleasant feeling. But sooner or later you lose the balance of mind that allows the impartial observer stance and get all embroiled in the drama again. In dismay you look around for some passing geese to grab hold of or a pair of spectacles.

That gives a crude image of our life as a vain effort to give ourselves a temporary illusion that things are going our way, that we are in control and that we will somehow survive this doomed fall to earth. We grab hold of whatever will help us feel good. Practising with the khandha is like learning to enjoy the free fall. To our enormous relief, we discover that the ground is also an illusion. So we're free-falling, without danger of a sudden crash.

To make this discovery, we need to get to know the khandha. What are these features of experience which delude us into thinking they could provide a secure abode within the reality of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anattā*? Can we feel the stress involved in clinging? Can we learn not to panic when they eventually let us down and we sense the free fall?

With continued attention to experience, these in-between moments of non-clinging become clearer and less terrifying. This is how we learn to enjoy the free fall. As we sensitize ourselves to the contrasting experiences of clinging and non-clinging, the Buddha assures us our nature automatically shifts towards non-clinging. We become happier and more content. Ultimately, we become enlightened, meaning we have been liberated from the futility of clinging.

So let's have a look at the first khandha, material form. This includes the body and all its sense bases, eyes, ears, etc., as well as the external material world, earth, plants, animals, mountains, houses, cars, computers, mobile phones, food, etc. Anything we can touch or see or hear or smell or taste is part of this first khandha.

We cling very tenaciously to the material form in our own body. Notice all the thoughts and emotions resulting from a headache or other pain. Any illness is a great teacher about how we cling to our bodies. We usually build our future around being able to walk, run, lift, carry etc. Not to mention hear, see, eat and talk. We get quite a shock if any of these fail. There's no way around the dukkha, but we can experience it moment by moment and let it teach us about the mistake we're making in assuming we can rely on our bodies to support our agenda in life.

And we accumulate so much material form around us in life. House, car, mobile phones, clothes, garden, books, furniture, etc. Often we don't notice our attachment to these until we lose them or they let us down in some way. If the car breaks down, or someone breaks into your house and steals the TV, there will probably be a lot of dukkha to endure.

One mistake that's easy to make when we hear this teaching is to start to disdain the material world, including our own body, as the source of dukkha. This is a mistake. Neither the world nor our body cause dukkha. Only our mistaken belief that they can offer us permanent support and be the basis for a happy life. The Buddha asks us to treat these with care and respect. It's only in an intimate caring relationship for our bodies and the material world that we experience how we stress ourselves out in the effort to grasp these as "me" or "mine". We can't learn that from a distance.

To encourage this positive relationship think of your daily activities as an aspect of *mettā* for the material world. When you are eating, doing yoga, washing your hands, do all these in a spirit of self-care. In your daily chore, can you do this as an act of gratitude for the safety and ease the physical structure of Satipanya offers us? We wouldn't be here in retreat if the walls and roof weren't holding together or if we had no plates to hold our dinner. If you're doing some gardening, can you see this as adding beauty to

the world? When you take a walk around the meadows during the break times, can you see this as an act of appreciation for the material world around you? Trees, sky, ground, wildlife.

Let's look now at the second khandha, *vedanā* or feeling. We've already come across *vedanā* as one of the steps in the wheel of dependent origination. *Vedanā* describes the way we categorize sensations as pleasant, unpleasant or neutral. If we don't tune into *vedanā*, our system then moves on to the next link in the wheel, generating desire for pleasant *vedanā*, aversion to unpleasant and to ignore the neutral. Once this wheel has moved past *vedanā*, it gets progressively more difficult to stop before it ends up at *dukkha*. By contrast, if we learn to tune into the basic pleasure-displeasure neutrality of sense contacts and know from experience the pain of *dukkha*, we can persuade ourselves to enjoy the pleasant without clinging, to bear with the unpleasant without pushing away, and to pay close attention to the neutral because the lack of stimulation is very relieving to our frazzled nerves.

In fact, clinging to all the other khandha boils down to clinging to *vedanā* as explained in the teaching on the Wheel of Dependent Origination. So why do we study all the other khandha? It's because we're so deeply enmeshed with these that we rarely notice the feeling-reaction coupling at the core. But reflecting on the khandha helps us see through the illusion we are creating.

For example, take material form. Imagine primitive man making his way northwards across Europe. It gets wetter and colder, unpleasant *vedanā*, so he builds himself a hut to shelter in. The hut is associated with pleasant *vedanā*. He likes it. He starts to think of it as home. Fast forward to our modern homes that we work 40 years to pay for, with all their decor and furniture and gardens. This attachment covers a huge section of our life. We think it's the house, garden etc. that we want and need. But actually it's the pleasant *vedanā* it gives us from physical sensations like warmth and comfort and concepts like security, safety, status that generate more pleasant *vedanā*.

If we are lucky enough to have somewhere we can call home, reflecting on our relationship with our home will bring up pleasant thoughts of being cosy and secure and the very unpleasant thoughts of losing our home. To reflect mindfully, we have to keep letting go of whatever desires might come up, for instance, to paint the house. If we hadn't made the effort to be mindful, the thought of our home could have turned the wheel all the way to birth and we would be out painting the house before we knew where we were. And, of course, the rain and wind would eventually destroy our careful painting so the wheel would turn on to *dukkha*.

By reflecting on the khandha of material form we are learning to let the wheel come to rest at the point of vedanā while we think of our home and other possessions. This purifies our relationship with the first khandha. We become more appreciative of our possessions. We enjoy them more fully and are not quite so dismayed and appalled when they go the way of all things into the abyss of loss and decay. We paint the house mindfully, knowing all our efforts will come to naught, apart, that is, from the effort to be mindful. That's the one that will pay dividends.

It's the same with the other khandha. We bind ourselves to these for the sake of the pleasant vedanā they offer. Vedanā is really the key to unlock the chain binding us to suffering. So during retreat here this week, really try to sensitise yourself to the pleasantness, unpleasantness or neutrality resulting from physical sensations and the mental world of thoughts, ideas, memories. The better you can do this on retreat, the easier it will be to reflect on the khandha mindfully afterwards, feeling the associated pleasant and unpleasant feelings as we think about these and the role they play in our life. Reflecting like this teaches us the futility of clinging. The wheel comes to halt more and more often at the point of vedanā as we contemplate the khandha.

Let's go on to look at the third khandha, perception. A perception is the mind's attempt to categorize whatever stimulus it receives. For example, a certain pattern of pressures fall on the eardrum and the mind recognizes a ringing tone. One teacher uses the image of a filing cabinet to illustrate this khandha. Whatever comes in has to be sorted into its correct file. The more attached we are to this khandha, the more time we turn our back on the incoming sense data, ignoring most of them in favour of a preoccupation with files and sub-files and finding the exact category for each sensation.

The stimulus can be mental as well as physical. Suppose some loud, high-pitched vibrations impact on the ear and we perceive these as a ringing tone. The perception, ringing tone, in turn, stimulates the mind to do some further classification, perhaps comparing this vibration with the memory of our house alarm and alarm clock before ending up with the concept doorbell. A concept is a mental amalgamation of the memory of many perceptions which is cemented by beliefs and culture. Primitive man, for example, would not have had the concept doorbell, and if he heard one, might have been sorting through his memory of birdsongs to try to recognise this peculiarly shrill one.

Concepts get strung together to form thoughts and mental images. A pattern of light, shade and colour falls on the eye and the mind recognises our neighbour's face and we think, "here's John from down the road." It's truly amazing how the mind can recognise and classify the complex patterns of sight and smell and sound that it is bombarded

with each moment. But each perception is just a guess at the reality that stimulated it, like my seeing the red cloth brushing the floor and my mind constructing a life-size image of Bhante Bodhidharma, as I explained in another talk.

So perceptions with their resulting concepts, mental images and thoughts are very, very clever guesswork based on what we remember and what we believe to be likely and some incoming data from the senses. They impose a structure in the world that we would swear to be true. And this can certainly be helpful. For example, we need to recognise a certain pattern of light as a cup in order to drink tea. Could we accept our perceptions as helpful, clever ways to represent reality, but nothing more than that? A temporary classification which needs to be continually reconfirmed by checking against our sensory input. Then we wouldn't get so startled when the cup shatters into little pieces spilling all the tea.

Take for example our deeply held belief that there's someone called "me" whose location is probably within or nearby my body. This "me" is, or should be, in control of my body and my life. The Buddha taught that this perception of self is created as part of the reaction to *vedanā*. In order to get what it wants, or get rid of what it doesn't want, the mind-body complex lets desire generate a perception of a self that can take decisions and get the body into action. It's a wonderfully clever way that our biology has found to satisfy its needs.

Despite our deep belief in the reality of me, the Buddha teaches that the real truth is *anattā*, not self. This is a very difficult teaching to get our heads around. But some people have sudden insights into *anattā*.

While walking in the Himalayas, D.E. Harding experienced a moment in which all his mental chatter died down. As if I had been born that instant, innocent of all memories. He looked down to find a pair of trouser legs terminating in a pair of brown shoes, sleeves terminating sideways in a pair of pink hands, and a shirt front terminating in nothing whatsoever. But this nothing, this hole where his head should have been, was no ordinary vacancy. The emptiness was filled with mountains, trees and sky, everything in his visual field. He had lost a head and gained a world. There arose no questions, he said, but only peace and a quiet joy, and the sensation of having dropped an intolerable burden.

So the perception of *anattā* is a very beautiful one which can arise quite naturally when the mental chatter dies down. But the thought of *anattā* is often unsettling or even frightening. The Buddha never answered questions of the form, do I exist or is

there a self, but asked people to experience for themselves that the perception of self is conditional. It arises when there is a desire for whatever *vedanā* is felt. The sense of self, like all perceptions, is the mind's guess at how to interpret present reality.

When a pattern of black and yellow light strikes the eye and gives rise to the very unpleasant thought of a tiger about to pounce, it makes a lot of sense to get our biological act together using the concept of me being in control and putting all my energy into escaping. And if the tiger catches us and we see we're doomed, it makes sense to change our minds and see that this painful, frightened entity is not our true self. In that sublime state, we could even wish the tiger Bon Appétit!

Can we see the self as a temporary, provisional, best guess at interpreting present reality? Very helpful at times, but not the ultimate truth. Can we see it wax and wane as circumstances dictate? For example, the way a sense of me suddenly blossoms when something nice happens. It's very interesting to note that you didn't remark on its absence before the sudden blossoming. The experience of not-self is very subtle and unobtrusive. That's why we don't notice it. It's quite an unremarkable experience, until we think about it. The experience of self, on the other hand, always calls attention, even if it's an unpleasant experience. For example, the way that sense of me crumples or rears up in anger when something unpleasant happens.

Let's look now at the fourth *khandha*, *saṅkhārā*. There are many translations for *saṅkhārā*. Mental formations, mental factors, mental habits, habitual tendencies, even concoctions. In everyday language we refer to some of these as moods and emotions such as depression, anger, love, joy. Others, such as laziness, we might think of as a state of mind, while others, such as wisdom, we might think of as a mental attribute. Each moment the *saṅkhārā* changes with the circumstances we find ourselves in, but each of us favour different sets. For example, some of us have a tendency towards anger, others for delusion, others for joy.

Our characters and personalities are determined by our *saṅkhārā*. Some *saṅkhārā* are unwholesome in the sense that they lead to suffering. Others lead towards *Nibbāna*, termed Beautiful *saṅkhārā*. Others are ethically neutral. They can be present in either wholesome or unwholesome states. One of the neutral *saṅkhārā* is volition, which is particularly important because it links with *kamma*, the ethical force at work in life.

Volition, also translated as intention or will, factors into every conscious moment. Even seeing and hearing are intentional. So every moment we are sowing *kamma* for ourselves. *Kamma* is like a seed. It ripens as fruit. Actions or speech motivated by kindness or other beautiful qualities ripen as various forms of happiness. Actions motivated by hatred or other unwholesome qualities ripen as unhappiness.

Kamma ripens in many ways, but perhaps the most important is the type of *saṅkhārā* they develop. If we're motivated by greed to steal someone's wallet, we develop habits of greed, deceitfulness, shamelessness, among others. If we're motivated by kindness to care for a sick child, we develop habits such as patience, compassion, love. It is the motivation that matters, not the act itself. If we care for the child because we feel trapped into this role and we let resentment be shown and make cruel remarks now and then, then we develop cruelty and resentment rather than beautiful *saṅkhārā*.

Non-attachment and non-hatred are amongst the beautiful *saṅkhārā*. These are very unexciting terms, but I had a striking demonstration of the beauty of non-attachment during one retreat. There was a bed of wild flowers in the garden, and I was enthralled by the gorgeous colours. But my mind would get lost in thoughts of sowing a flower bed like this at home, and my friends would surely want one too, and on and on it went until I was tense with anxiety about these future gardens. Although the scene in front of me was beautiful, I felt contorted by tension. I sadly decided I would have to forgo the gorgeous flower bed if I was to get any peace of mind.

Then one day as I was drying dishes, there was a moment where I simply felt the weight of the cup and the softness of the cloth, and my mind expanded into a beautiful freedom. It was a moment without attachment, but one of the most beautiful experiences of my life. I had never realised how much I was clinging until I experienced that one moment of non-attachment. Comparing this with my experience at the flowerbed, I could see that attachment leads to misery, while non-attachment allows perfect contentment.

Non-hatred also sounds mundane but can be put in more positive language as friendliness, kindness, love and patience. As you would expect, compassion, equanimity and sympathetic joy are also among the beautiful states of mind.

We cling to this *khandha* by identifying ourselves with our emotions and mind states thinking I am angry, I am happy, I am sleepy. The truth of the matter is that these are temporary states of mind which arise because of certain conditions and cease when these conditions pass away. When we get closely identified with any mind state we become blind to any alternative way of viewing the situation. So the mind loses its flexibility.

During a long car journey I was feeling a bit sick and very grumpy. A friend smiled and made some pleasantries. For a moment I forgot to be grumpy and my heart lifted but then I remembered I am grumpy and started sinking back into the state. But the momentary lift showed me the state wasn't the absolute truth and I could make the effort

to be sociable. I found myself resisting, feeling who would be disloyal to my grumpy self, who deserved my loyalty. On digesting this, my sociability-related *saṅkhārā* won out over my self-loyalty ones, and I decided to perk up a bit.

As always, mindfulness is the key to seeing through delusion. In this case, the belief that I am grumpy, rather than a more accurate belief such as grumpiness is here now, but conditions could change. It's also easy to cling to *saṅkhārā* like love, joy, compassion, understanding, not seeing how these come and go depending on circumstances. When we've had a good meal or heard some good news, we can feel kind, happy and understanding. It's so tempting to believe this is the real me. But then there is shock and grief when this wonderful state gets broken down again. Can we notice the beautiful *saṅkhārā* objectively, enjoying them while they last, letting them go when the conditions change? It's a tough practice. We have to let everything go for the sake of complete freedom.

This brings us to the last of the *khandha*, consciousness. To be conscious is to experience the other four *khandha*, the sensory world around us and the mental world within. If we are unconscious, this experience vanishes. This is the sense in which the term consciousness is used when it refers to the fifth *khandha*. Consciousness can also be used to refer to the experience of *nibbāna* but that's not included in the *khandha*. The *khandha* only describe what we cling to, and *nibbāna* is what we're left with when we stop clinging to the *khandha*.

Consciousness is often likened to a screen on which a film projects. The light from the projector has to fall on the screen if we are to see the scenery and characters. If there was no screen, the light would just pass through and if there were no dust in the air to scatter it, the light beam would be invisible. It would make no impact on us. In the same way the various dramas of our lives as well as their component parts of sights, sounds, smells, tastes, body sensations and mental activity all have to project onto the screen of consciousness to have any impact on us.

Is there a difference between consciousness, awareness and mindfulness? Sometimes the words are used interchangeably, so it can be confusing. For this talk, I use awareness and mindfulness interchangeably. We all know that we can be conscious though not mindful. We are on autopilot, letting the mind run away on thoughts but not noticing that these thoughts are just part of our present experience. Going back to the movie analogy, it's as if we're in the movie, playing our role, feeling our feelings, totally immersed in the plot.

Mindfulness turns attention to our conscious experience and the mind starts taking an interest in what's being projected on the screen. It's often described as a different level of consciousness. We can have stretches where we see the film quite objectively, like watching ourselves acting in the movie of our lives. Then we lose mindfulness and get sucked into some aspect of the plot that was on the screen, acting it all out with gusto.

The Buddha taught that there are six separate doorways to consciousness, involving the five senses and also the mind, for example, when a thought or memory falls on the screen of consciousness. Certain conditions have to be fulfilled for each door to open. In order to hear a bird song, for example, we need the bird to sing, good hearing, as well as attention. If any of these is missing, then hearing consciousness does not happen. Although we say, isn't the silence beautiful, we can't actually hear silence. Perhaps what we're enjoying is the absence of hearing consciousness. It's the same for all the other senses. We need the sense object, sensory physiology and attention. Sight, sound, body sensations, smell, taste and mental activities. All of these are separate doorways to conscious experience. But they are completely separate independent experiences.

I first noticed this separation of the different fields of consciousness one time while walking during a retreat. I was noting the feeling of the feet swinging forward and stepping down onto the ground. So my attention was on body consciousness. But then I suddenly saw the tip of my foot appearing and disappearing as I felt it come to the end of the forward swing. I found myself being amazed that these experiences coincided so perfectly. Before that, I would never have questioned that the sight and feel of the foot would coincide. But now I could sense that logical expectations, sight and bodily sensations were occupying three separate worlds. It seemed a pure wonder and an incredible gift that they all fitted into each other so neatly. I was tasting the separation of consciousness into its six fields.

Can you tune into the different fields of consciousness, for example vision, hearing and bodily experience? Joseph Goldstein recommends using noting phrases of the form sounds being known, walking being known, to turn attention towards that entity which registers experience. Can you get a sense of how separate are the worlds of hearing, seeing and physical sensing?

The Buddha also taught that we only experience one doorway for consciousness at a time sight or sound or smell or mental activity. But this is all happening at such a fast rate that we don't notice the separate registrations. Once I was walking towards a door to open it feeling the feet lifting, moving. Then my hand went out to grasp the handle of the door touching turning pushing pushing then my foot lifted to take another

step at the moment I felt the foot lift I realised my hand had disappeared totally from consciousness. I got such a fright I looked down to see if my hand had dropped off. But it was still there and I realised it was simply that perception had sharpened so that I was experiencing just one sensation at a time.

These kinds of experience undermine our usual fascination with the plot that's playing on the screen of consciousness and make us wonder about the nature of consciousness itself. To study this fifth *khandha*, we need to calm ourselves in meditation sufficiently to extract ourselves from the fascination of the plot and simply watch the film. Then at times we might relax enough to get a sense of what often feels like a more stable sense of self, the one who watches the film, the one who knows experience, the observer, the witness. At those moments we're noticing our identification with the fifth *khandha*. We sense this is happening within me or I am observing all this.

Bhante uses the analogy of looking through a shop window. You see the goods inside but might also notice your own reflection as you watch. If the stuff for sale doesn't appeal, you might get more interested in your own face. In the same way, when our consciousness film is not too exciting, we can bring attention to the sense of me, the one who experiences, observes and knows all this. Although at first it feels like a deep and reliable sense of self, it also begins to shift and slide when the spotlight turns upon it. So we begin to lose faith in this final *khandha* as a stable source of happiness.

At other times we lose that sense of watching the screen but remain mindful. We feel more intimate with sensations and feelings. They're no longer out there on the screen for me to watch. This is the loss of identity with the fifth *khandha*. Sensations and feelings arise and pass just as before, but no one is watching anymore. It's an experience of *anattā*. Our whole system functions just fine without the usual sense of me being in charge or watching the film. In our earlier analogy, we're now tasting freefall, no longer clinging even to this fifth *khandha* for security.

Each sensation of life is intimately known, but there's no central control system, no observer, no unknowing. We glimpse the state of non-clinging, the end of suffering, *nibbāna*. However, until our trust in this state deepens to total enlightenment, the sense of self sooner or later rears its head again as we start clinging to familiar experiences to help us feel secure.

Studying the *khandha* helps us to discover what it is we cling to unwittingly creating *dukkha* in the process. Ultimately, all our clinging boils down to wanting to feel good, clinging to pleasant *vedanā*. In an effort to do this, we scrabble around in the heap of material form, buying goods, nice clothes, makeup, in an effort to feel secure about our bodies and our material well-being. Or else we polish our spectacles, choose a new pair

of lenses as we immerse ourselves in the heap of perceptions. At other times we get lost in the heap of *saṅkhārā*, repeating old habits in an effort to get things stable. When we're relaxed and mindful, we fall into the heap of consciousness, concocting stability from the illusion that there's someone called me who experiences my life.

The good news is that deeper awareness of our habit of clinging and how much it hurts makes us more willing to let go and free fall with the truths of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anattā*. We get more curious about the state of non-clinging. Instead of the temporary highs offered by the *khandha*, we become enthralled by the possibility of letting these slip through our fingers. We discover the stability offered by knowing the instability of life.

May these reflections on the five *khandha* help us experience the joy of non-clinging.

Building a Raft to Cross the Floods of Becoming and Ignorance

Noirin Sheahan · 42 min

In this retreat teaching, Noirin Sheahan continues her exploration of the Buddha's raft simile, examining how we cross the floods of becoming (bhava) and ignorance (avijjā). The flood of becoming relates to our attachment to roles and identities - as parent, teacher, or social activist - and our projection of these into the future. Through vivid examples like a challenging classroom scenario, Noirin demonstrates how mindfulness, mettā, and moral resolve can form a raft to navigate threatening situations without losing our spiritual integrity.

The flood of ignorance represents our fundamental confusion about how to be truly happy. Even in peaceful moments, we experience underlying unease and restlessness. Noirin addresses the crucial challenge of letting go of our spiritual achievements - the very rafts that carry us to safety. Drawing on the Buddha's instruction that we must abandon even skillful states and Dhamma understanding, she explores the painful but necessary process of non-attachment to our insights and elevated states.

Using post-retreat experiences as a teaching tool, Noirin shows how attachment to spiritual highs leads to inevitable falls from grace. The teaching emphasizes seeing ourselves as perpetual students rather than experts, celebrating our understanding while remaining willing to let it go. This talk offers practical wisdom for both meditation practice and daily life challenges, showing how spiritual maturity involves embracing uncertainty and moving unburdened toward deeper freedom.

Tonight's talk continues with the teaching known as the raft which describes someone following a path that leads to a shore that is perilous owing to a great expanse of water. Across the water he sees another shore where the ground is secure. He gathers grass, twigs, branches and leaves, binds them together to make a raft and paddling energetically crosses the flood. The near shore, if you remember, stands for self-identity, while the far shore represents freedom. Ultimately, this means the complete freedom of *Nibbāna*, but for the purpose of this sutta, we're best to think of the far shore as those temporary periods of freedom that emerge when we've worked our way mindfully through some struggle. The water refers to the four floods which represent those as-

pects of life we identify with: sensuality, becoming, views and ignorance. On the near shore we are unwittingly taking on a false identity and will suffer on account of that because sooner or later this identity will be threatened.

Last night we looked at the floods of sensuality and views. Tonight we look at the other floods, starting with the flood of becoming. This flood relates to our identity as a person with a future and a past. It's especially connected with our roles as parent, daughter, technician, cook and so on. More subtly, we also assume social roles such as respectable person, good friend, social activist, etc. We're not fully aware of some of our roles or consciously choosing to play them. For example, we can play victim roles in certain circumstances when we don't know how to cope with misfortune. At other times, we play the role of bully in an attempt to control ourselves or others. In other circumstances, we'll end up playing roles of mother hen, wise owl, grumpy grouse. We have a whole menagerie inside us, waiting for their moment on stage.

Just as sensuality and views can play meaningful, beneficial parts in our lives, our roles can also serve us well. They give us predictable ways of interacting with others which simplifies social situations and lets us all work together well. The problem only comes when we forget that these roles are temporary and contingent. There will come a time when they are not appropriate and unless we can let go we will suffer and so also will our relationships. Retirement for example is a challenge for most people. Our role as electrician or teacher or secretary which we knew so well is suddenly gone. We don't know who we are anymore or what to do with ourselves. As children turn into adults, we find it difficult to let go of parent-child roles.

Why is this flood termed becoming? Why not call it the flood of roles? If we're looking back on our role as teacher or parent, that isn't a problem. It's a way of understanding and appreciating our lives, learning from past mistakes and forgiving these. It's only the projection of that role into the future that gets us swept off our feet. The energetic pull of the flood is towards the future. So becoming describes the feeling tone of this flood very well.

Retirement and other major role changes in life are strong currents in the flood of becoming. But we get swept away in small ways every day. We can use each of these smaller floods as opportunities to practice making a raft and getting safely to the far shore. In meditation, how often do we get carried away into a fantasy about how wonderful we are? It might be that we're going to write the most spectacular novel worthy of a hundred Man Booker prizes. In another meditation, we'd be climbing Mount Everest without oxygen, winning Wimbledon, awarded the Nobel Peace Prize. These are mini tsunamis in the flood of becoming.

Instead of condemning yourself for these, see how well you can stay afloat in their midst. Body awareness makes a great raft. The mind can be sparking with ideas on how we will impress the world, but the body is sitting there in meditation, grounding us. In my experience, this flood seems to be pulling me towards a very pleasant, enticing future. This imagined future would be reflected in my body as pleasant sensations. If I can locate and hold attention on those sensations, the sparky thoughts and ideas fade and I get a better sense of the energies surging around my body, generating all those pleasant sensations which my mind is interpreting as a wonderful future. At times, then, I might be persuaded to relax a bit, enjoy the pleasure in the here and now.

As I relax, I might detect a couple of separate strands to the energies flowing around my body. At one level, there is self-care, *mettā*. A kindly streak within me is quietly generating pleasant sensations as an expression of care. Then there are the energies driven by desire, clutching onto the pleasure, embroidering a magnificent future out of it. Although I'm strongly attached to this aspect of the experience, I have to admit that the light of awareness shows it up as painful, stressful. Essentially, I'm rejecting the pleasure being offered by my *mettā*-streak, saying, this isn't worth anything, what I need is a great future.

If I can sit with the emotions and feelings generated within this flood of becoming, I'm undermining the delusion at its core. This person I'm so identified with, the soon-to-be Nobel Prize Peace Winner, can I find that person here and now? Are they in my chest, my stomach, my throat, my face? From afar it seems the answer is yes. I might find a hot spot in my throat, for example, where that wonderful person resides. But when I look closely, all I find are physical sensations, pleasant feelings and the deep displeasure of confusion. Where did that wonderful person escape to? Why can't I pin them down?

By now, awareness has penetrated the flood of becoming deep enough to be exploring the underlying flood of ignorance. Caught up in the delusion of self, I'm looking for my essence as something objective that I can know, discern, pinpoint. But I have to admit, sadly, that everything I know keeps dissolving, changing, become other than whatever it seemed to be a moment ago. All very unsatisfactory. Sooner or later, I give up on the futile search. With luck, I'll surrender, for even a few blessed moments, to the truth of *anattā*. No longer interested in defining myself as an essential separation from the rest of experience. What a relief. A toehold on the far shore.

I'll say a bit more about the flood of delusion later on but for now I want to come back to the flood of becoming and your daydreams about the wonderful person you truly are if only the rest of the world would wake up and take notice. I'm not encouraging you to daydream but to let the raft of *vipassanā* bob up and down on the waves of this flood as you paddle your way to the far shore.

Let's look at a potential tsunami from daily life. Suppose you're a geography teacher standing in front of a class of teenagers. Some of them are listening, some look bored and abstracted, while a group in the back are laughing and chatting. You call for silence, but they ignore you. Jack, stop talking and pay attention, you call to the ringleader. Give me one good reason, sneers Jack, getting a laugh from his buddies. Okay, leave the class now and go to the headmaster's office, you order sternly. Come and make me, he retorts, leaning back in his chair defiantly. Your blood is boiling and you want to murder him. You're also aware that the class has gone still, with all eyes on you to see your next move.

It's the flood of becoming, resting as always on the flood of ignorance, which is making your blood boil. You're identified with your role as teacher and it's under severe threat. If you can't control the situation, the class will lose respect for you and you might also lose confidence in yourself as a teacher. All this is very real. But for spiritual practice, we have to be prepared to look underneath the surface reality. From the spiritual perspective, the danger is that you're being severely tempted to act on anger. Although it can seem counterintuitive, working at the spiritual level can have unexpected benefits at the surface level. If we can muster goodwill in a challenging situation, others often pick up on this and follow suit. For the start, though, we have to put aside any desire for specific outcomes. We have to let all worldly considerations go and give all our heart into gathering bits and pieces for our raft.

Mindfulness would be a great starting ingredient. If you can register your anger and that you're feeling threatened, you will then have some objectivity on the situation. Some degree of calm would greatly help, so you can feel your feet on the ground for a few seconds or take a mindful breath. If you can, add in a *mettā*-wish such as, may I handle this situation wisely? With mindfulness, calm and a degree of *mettā* on board, you may be able to give *mettā* the flavour of equanimity with the wish like, may your behaviour not provoke me to react. This acknowledges the danger of reactivity within a sentiment of goodwill. It forms a wide net for *mettā*. Hopefully your anger will be caught within this.

While none of this changes anything externally, it will have changed things radically within yourself. The situation has now been encompassed within your Dhamma practice, and no matter what happens next, you will be on board a raft rather than drowning in the sea of becoming. You've also saved yourself from the worst outcome – giving Jack a clatter and possibly getting the sack or maybe even being charged with assault. Even if you make an utter fool of yourself and get the sack anyway, it means teaching teenagers was never going to be your career. What matters from the spiritual perspective is not whether you get the sack but how you handle that setback if it comes.

Supposing mindfulness, calm and mettā got you into some sort of a raft and you feel enough confidence to launch into the flood. My imagination can't stretch to anything more original than, I can't force you out of the class Jack, but I want you to know that I'm appalled by your behaviour and unless it improves radically, I'll be going to the head myself after class with the full story. You're afloat for the moment, but need to be paddling constantly in case any retort from Jack causes a wave to topple you back into fury.

So is there anything else that could add buoyancy? One would be to extend your mettā-wishes to Jack and the rest of the class with something like, May we make it through this crisis? If you have a strong faith you could ask the Buddha or Quan Yin for help or any devas who happen to be nearby. This would be adding faith and devotion to your raft. One very powerful mettā practice is to see all beings as enlightened except for ourselves. Everyone else is playing their roles here on earth with only one purpose in mind, to liberate us from suffering. Our supposed enemies are only pretending to threaten us in order to sharpen our practice. If you could manage even a momentary glimpse of that possibility, it could turn the raft into a cruise ship. No longer are you the teacher, they are the teachers and you are the pupil. This radical shift in perspective may let you see some humour in the situation and find a creative way to handle it.

But suppose you didn't manage to build any raft and are striding towards the back of the class, intending to catch Jack by the scruff of the neck and give him a good clatter. If you've been saying the precepts regularly, then the phrase, not to harm living beings, may pop into your head to bring you to a halt. This would be to start your raft with morality. Acknowledging the harm intended, you might resolve to find some other way of dealing with the situation. To borrow Bhante's phrase, a resolute resolution is what's needed here. I can do no harm. I ought to do no harm. I want to do no harm. I will do no harm. Resolutions are strengthened by a physical gesture and in this case to turn around and walk slowly back to your desk could fit the bill.

The trouble is that you've already let your emotions escalate as well as heightening the tension in the room. So there will probably be a strong temptation towards harsh speech as a means of saving face and regaining some control. Hopefully, you will also remember the precept against wrong speech and start casting around for some wisdom. Equanimity is a major support at times like these. If you practice saying something like, may I not make things worse for myself, during minor difficulties, the phrase may come back to save you in a situation like this. Patience is also a saviour in threatening situations. Patience allows you to acknowledge aversion for the situation and the wish that it would change. But both the aversion and the desire for change are encompassed in equanimity. Phrases like everything in its own time or things are unfolding just as they should strengthen patience. Steadied by morality, resolve, equanimity and patience. You might then be ready to launch into the flood and find some words to resolve the situation.

Let's finish the story on an optimistic note and presume we make a good enough raft and paddle it energetically enough to get to the far shore. Whatever way the situation played itself out, we've kept our integrity and somehow got ourselves out of danger. It might be hard to think of the incident as a spiritual practice, but keep in mind the image of a rickety raft made out of grass and twigs and leaves. Our practice doesn't have to look pretty. It just has to get us across the floods. Although we'd probably be rattled by the whole experience, we've actually done ourselves a lot of good in spiritual terms, avoiding a severe temptation to indulge anger. Our teacher role has submitted to the demands of the Dhamma, and as a result we would be in a much better position to handle the flood of becoming in future.

Finally, let's look at the flood of ignorance which underlies all the other floods. Ignorance is a harsh sounding word for something as innocent as not knowing how to be happy. Perhaps we could call it the flood of confusion. No matter what we call it, the fact that we don't know how to be happy underlies all our suffering in life. To traverse this flood we need a raft made out of the Four Noble Truths. We need to fully understand *dukkha*, let go of the desires that cause *dukkha* and realize for ourselves there is a state of perfect contentment when we let go of unskillful desire. To accomplish all of these we need to follow the Eightfold Path. We paddle our way through this flood in quiet moments when the other floods have subsided.

We may be sitting quietly at home, physically comfortable, fed and watered, not troubled by anything in particular, just relaxing. But still there's an underlying unease. After a few moments we get restless. We want something to fill our minds, get us going again. This is the flood of ignorance. Even when all the external conditions for peace

and contentment are there, we don't know how to be happy. We see this very clearly in meditation practice, how the mind keeps creating stories and dramas to fill up the quietness. Even unhappy stories and bad dramas are preferable to nothing at all.

We also experience the flood of ignorance as we draw near the far shore and have to decide what to do with our raft and it's that aspect of the flood I'd like to focus on tonight. Suppose we had managed to get our cruise ship together and see Jack and all the other pupils as enlightened beings. A great wave of love pulls them into our heart and produces some wise words which resolve the crisis. That wave of love seeps into our geography teaching and the remainder of the class passes like a dream, with everyone, including Jack and his buddies, paying rapt attention.

By the time the class is over, we're walking on air. We've got through the flood of becoming in great style, but we're still in danger from the flood of ignorance. When we're walking on air, it's very easy to believe this is the real me. We think our troubles are over, that Jack will never misbehave again, and even if he does, we know how to handle the situation. Just picture him as the Buddha. What could be simpler?

This, of course, is to be swept away on the flood of ignorance. We've identified with the happiness that has come our way, and think we're in control of it, but we'll always be able to summon it at will. But until we're fully enlightened, our happiness will always depend on conditions. After a while, we'll come down to earth. And at the next class, we might be so shocked to find Jack back to his old tricks that we can't muster any metaphor for him at all, never mind picture him as the Buddha.

Let's recap on the Buddha's words on getting to the far shore.

And what should the man do with the raft? There is the case where the man, having crossed over, would think, "How useful this raft has been to me! For it was in dependence on this raft that, making an effort with my hands and feet, I have crossed over to safety on the far shore." So we're tempted to hoist the raft on our shoulder and take it with us on our journey. But according to the Buddha, this isn't wise. We're to leave our beloved raft behind. "Why don't I, having dragged it on dry land or sinking it in the water, go wherever I like?" In doing this, he would be doing what should be done with the raft.

So we should first reflect on our raft and appreciate how well it has served us. In this case we would reflect on our ability to picture the pupils as enlightened beings. Doubtless there'll be a temptation to think, "I know how to do this now, I'll always be able to do it." But that would be to carry the raft on our head as we go on our onward journey. It's delusional. We have to rejoice in our raft while letting it go.

Letting go of skillful qualities is one of the major challenges on our spiritual path. It's quite natural to get attached to *metta* and states of deep concentration or joy or tranquillity. Our job, though, is to note these, just as we note physical sensations or any of the hindrances. It is within that objective knowing of these as transient experiences that we can free ourselves from the *dukkha* of false identification.

If we don't manage this, the fall from grace can be very sore indeed. One moment we're light as a feather, loving everyone deeply. Somehow our hold on this gets broken and we're distraught to find ourselves back as the old me, with all of our petty grievances perfectly intact. In fact, we're in a worse mood than usual because of having somehow lost our footing on that wonderful far shore. This can be a very deep shock and sorrow.

One problem is that we often don't know we're attached to something until we lose it. The post-retreat period is a good teacher in this regard. For a while we may be walking on air, at peace with the world and even our old enemies. But somehow we fall back into our old ways. It can be quite shocking to see how easily we get sucked into these sense pleasures, even though we know they're transient and unsatisfactory. Worse still, we can be tempted to blame ourselves and everyone around us for our fall from grace. Even the dog and the goldfish are despicable.

Eventually, of course, things even out and when they do, we will be able to appreciate again the benefits of the retreat, but this time in a more balanced way, knowing that whatever new levels of *metta* or clarity we might experience, they will come and go.

The first time I really became aware of this was after a three-week retreat in Nepal, which had followed on a pilgrimage around India. I was walking on air, inspired and confident that I had undergone an enormous transformation for the better. The exalted state survived the journey back to Delhi, but when the taxi to the airport was over an hour late and no other taxis to be found, it started to quake a bit. Luckily the plane was even later than my taxi, so I got home all right. But my first night in my own bed was one of deep distress. It really felt like bereavement. I was heartbroken for the loss of that beautiful state of confidence, clarity and inspiration.

Nowadays I try to prepare myself for the fall from grace and to see the post-retreat period as part of the retreat itself. While on retreat I'm often looking forward to the ending and to relaxing the intensity of practice. And at first the wide world seems very lovely but sometime later despondency of one form or another descends. As Sarah, who often does long retreats here at Satipanya, put it, "I can feel worse on retreat, but I know it's all worthwhile. Whereas at home I can feel much better, but there's a background sense that I'm wasting my life." That expresses my own sentiments very well.

I nowadays spend time during the end of the retreat acknowledging the deeper levels of peace, kindness or understanding that I've been noticing from time to time. This is to appreciate the raft. I then remind myself that these aren't mine, that they depend on conditions like the rule of silence, the schedule, the company of other meditators and so on. Although this brings grief, it also allows gratitude to flow for these supports and for Bhante's work in establishing Satipanya and guiding us all along, and for all my efforts to practice during the retreat. During the post-retreat blues, I can then be more compassionate and take care of myself wisely.

Another danger is to neglect practice in the immediate aftermath of a long retreat, to think, "I've done enough of that for the moment, I need a break." To counter this reaction, I arrange to meet up with meditation friends, make a special effort to go to meditation group meetings and to get back into my own daily practice. The more Dhamma supports I can find in the outside world, the easier it is to get through the blues. In summary, the post-retreat period gives us practice at letting go of whatever rafts get us through the floods.

Note that the Buddha gives us two options here. Either we are to sink the raft in water or to drag it onto the beach and leave it there. My understanding is that we sink our raft in the water when we use it to navigate through the flood of ignorance.

Let's take an example. Suppose we have used a raft of *metta* to get us through a flood of views. We're now at ease. We can see the other person's point of view. We see them as a friend and we look back at our little hissy fit. We can giggle at our pettiness. The raft has done its job. So we spend a moment to value our *metta* practice, being grateful for it, resolving to continue to develop this. With that, we simply let the whole matter go. If we were meditating, we would return to the breath. If we were taking a break in daily life, we would move on to the next task. That would be to leave the raft on the beach. A very simple letting go.

Now suppose that as we are reflecting on our *metta* practice, valuing it, being grateful for it, we find it hard to say goodbye, to let it go. We then have to work with our attachment to the beautiful state of *metta*. We acknowledge whatever emotions show up and let them burn out. This is to sink our raft in the water. We are working with the flood of ignorance, seeing more deeply into the second noble truth that desire for the state of *metta* is causing us to suffer. We're learning the humbling lesson that goodwill is not ours to own. It comes and goes depending on conditions. Ironically, it can make us quite angry to realise that. It's only with lots of patient effort that we can be persuaded to let the raft sink away.

Related to this, we have the Buddha's last words from the sutta: "In the same way, monks, I have taught the Dhamma compared to a raft for the purpose of crossing over, not for the purpose of holding on to. Understanding the Dhamma as taught compared to a raft, you should let go even of Dhammas, to say nothing of non-Dhammas."

Just as we let go of *metta* or whatever got us across the flood, we also have to let go of whatever Dhamma wisdom we have mustered. This again is a deep challenge. We treasure our understanding of the Dhamma. It represents our only hope of happiness. So naturally we get attached. But all attachments bring pain. It's very painful to have to admit that our understanding is insufficient.

In words, it all sounds so simple. Desire causes suffering. Let go of desire and suffering ceases. We agonise within ourselves: "I know that already. Why can't I just do it?" It seems such a mystery. The drill, as we know, is to keep relaxing around the tensions, noting all the protests, the emotions, the confusion, the frustration, until the moment comes when something inside shifts and we're at ease. We might not be able to put into words what we've learned, but we're no longer quarrelling with ourselves. We've experienced again that letting go of desire allows suffering to cease.

But oh, the temptation to attach to our new level of clarity, to think, "OK, now I know and I won't ever get mixed up again." And then unwittingly cause ourselves repeated agony. In this teaching the Buddha emphasises that we must look on our understanding as part of the raft, to be really grateful that it got us across the flood, but then to let it go.

The attempt to do this will show us our attachment. As I reflect on any new level of insight, delight will generally emerge. But in that delight, there's often a streak of pride and my head literally starts swelling. The discomfort of a swollen head shows me very graphically that, despite my new insight, I've still a long way to go. There is then the effort to accept this unpalatable fact and make peace with the unenlightened being that I now am.

To help with the process we can bring to mind the pain of attaching to Dhamma understanding. We experience this in various ways. One is when we try out a different meditation technique. At first it's a welcome change. Then after some time we find it hard to concentrate. It doesn't seem to let us relax as much as our usual method. But our warrior spirit compels us to give it another go. After another aeon of fruitless effort we're confused, angry and frustrated. We can't catch any thoughts. They're exploding all over the place and we believe them all. This turmoil is coming from being attached to views on how to meditate and to our role as competent meditator. So we have the flood of views criss-crossing with the flood of becoming.

When this happened to me, Bhante's advice was excellent: "Stick with the new technique until the aversion passes. Then make a rational decision as to which is better for you." This helped me work through my attachment to the deeply focused form of Mahasi meditation that Bhante encourages.

Another way we can work with this attachment is during Dhamma discussions. We can get hurt when our opinions are challenged or become afraid to express any views. Then again we can be delighted when our opinions prevail, but perhaps there's a tinge of pride in that delight. If we can bear the fear or hurt or pride mindfully, the discussion is actually a very beneficial one. No matter whether we're learning any new information, we're loosening attachment to our Dhamma views.

Reflecting on the pain of attachment makes us more willing to admit that our understanding isn't perfect, that we need to let go. We need to see ourselves as perpetual students rather than give in to temptation and view ourselves as experts. Some statements from arahats reflect a state of continual investigation even after enlightenment. For example, Mechi Kyo says, "I cannot detect a single moment when greed, hatred or delusion have any power over my heart." This indicates that she is still confirming the Dhamma for herself, still investigating.

To see ourselves as perpetual students rather than experts, we are, in the Buddha's words, letting go of the raft of Dhamma. But we can love the raft even while we let it go. We can celebrate and cherish every scrap of understanding that helped us through the flood. Essentially, this is a *mudita* practice, celebrating what is ephemeral, transitory, disappearing in front of our eyes.

Before closing, I'd like to go back to the beginning. The sutta starts out with someone following a path that leads to a perilous shore. So too our spiritual journey is always leading us to new challenges. It's interesting that the Buddha doesn't ever suggest turning back and retreating along the path. This signifies that we can't escape spiritual challenges by keeping to sections of the path we already know.

Supposing you've excellent concentration and can easily access tranquillity when you follow your breath. As the geography teacher under attack from Jack, you could simply let all your attention dwell on your breath. And so your anger would pass and you could go on with the class, ignoring the tensions caused by the incident. If you do the same thing whenever the memory of the incident comes up in meditation, then you won't be developing spiritually. It would be like turning back on the path whenever you come to a perilous shore, and the Buddha isn't recommending that.

Instead, we must take our practice to the edge of our comfort zone, to where we don't know what to do and are flying on a wing and a prayer. That's where we build our raft. And that's how we learn the Dhamma.

May our Dhamma understanding serve us as a raft until, safe at the far shore, we lay down our raggle-taggle of knowledge and skill and move unburdened onwards.

Healing the Mind-Body Relationship

Noirin Sheahan · 3 min read

This essay explores a specific meditation exercise from the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10) - noting 'There is a body' during formal practice. Noirin Sheahan guides us through the transformative process of objectifying our relationship with the physical form, moving from taking the body for granted to experiencing it as neither 'me' nor 'mine.' Through detailed experiential descriptions, she reveals how this simple noting practice can lead to profound shifts in perception - from identifying with the body to recognizing its objective nature, from ownership to gratitude, from delusion to clarity. The essay addresses the complex psychological dynamics of our mind-body relationship, acknowledging how we oscillate between identifying with physical sensations and mental formations like feelings, perceptions, and consciousness. It offers practical guidance for healing our relationship with embodied existence, recognizing the body as a reliable partner in meditation that grounds us in reality and provides a stable foundation for awareness practice.

There is a Body: Exploring the mind-body relationship.

One of the exercises given in the Satipatthana Sutta (often considered the most important teaching because it guides us along a 'direct path' to liberation and is suited to both lay and monastic practitioners) is to note: "There is a body" while sitting in formal meditation.

This might provoke the thought "Of course there's a body, I'm sitting here, what's the point in stating the obvious?" A perfectly reasonable question. But remember we're in formal meditation, so questions are just another thing to be aware of. So we note "questioning ... questioning" and explore the experience of questioning. What flavours do we find here? The flavour of uncertainty perhaps? That's one I find quite easily in meditation – at least one thing I can usually count on!

Changing the noting word to "Uncertainty ... uncertainty..." allows me relax into a new view of experience. Sometimes I need to relax and allow uncertainty show me its nebulous aspect. Clouds of doubt may seem to be puffing out of the body. Where am I in all this strangeness? Sometimes I seem to be centred in one or other of the puffing clouds. Sometimes I seem to be lured back inside the tissues of the body. The noting

words might change to “heaviness ... heaviness ...” as I register the earthy nature of the body. The closer I get, the more certain I feel. Something seems reliable at last. For a moment!

For a moment I know the hardness and heaviness of the bones in the arms, the back, the legs, the skull, and then uncertainty creeps in again: Whose arms? ... There seem to be arms hanging from my shoulders as usual. And if I try, I can lift them. But the notion ‘my arms’ doesn’t seem to fit. The phrase “There is a body” comes back to mind and now finds resonance. This no longer seems to be stating the obvious, but a lifeline, a way of making sense of a strange and unsettling situation.

Knowing the body objectively as fostered by the phrase “there is a body”, I sense gratitude for its stability, its powers of movement; for the life it offers, moment after moment. And yet it is, in this moment at least, quite obviously not me, not mine. Another question arises: How can something so close, so intimate, be other than me and mine? In answer, fear and aversion displace gratitude, compete for dominance, struggle to proclaim their story. But neither can get a lasting grip on the situation; the body simply breathes through them. It takes no notice, bless it!

The body-mind relationship is complex. At times we identify with the body, at other times with some aspect of the mind: feelings, perceptions, habits, consciousness. Its like being made up of a squabbling committee! And yet all our complex mental life, our hopes, fears, ambitions, dreams – all depend on their being a body breathing away quietly in the background, heart pumping, stomach digesting, feet walking.

In our delusion, we take this miracle of biology totally for granted. Not a healthy way of relating to our earthly nature. The Satipatthana exercise of noting “there is a body” gives us a practical way of healing the mind-body relationship.

Like all intimate relationships, the mind-body one is a challenge. Who likes being totally dependent? And yet here we are, tied up within a very unreliable, mortal body, full of blood, sweat and tears, liable to feel pain at any moment, prone to illness, growing older and less able day by day. No wonder the mind tries to deny such an unedifying relationship, escape into fantasy!

Luckily the body holds no grudges. And luckily, greed, hatred and delusion are no more permanent and reliable than gratitude, compassion or any other state of mind. Within the gaze of mindfulness, the body is the perfect partner. It puts a limit on fantasies of hope and fear, and gives delusion free reign to express distress and displeasure at being tied up in chains of mortality. When the storm abates, its there, ready to get on with the practicalities of life.

Try the exercise sometime: sit in meditation and note “There is a body”. Let the reflection take you on whatever merry-go-round it likes, trusting this as the Buddha’s suggestion for how we might heal our mind-body relationship.

Homeward Bound

Noirin Sheahan · 4 min read

This contemplative essay explores the universal experience of transitioning from intensive retreat practice back into everyday life. Noirin Sheahan candidly examines how quickly old patterns of attachment reassert themselves after a month-long winter retreat at Satipanya, using the example of food and eating to illustrate how greed (lobha) can override the clarity gained during formal practice. Rather than falling into despair, she demonstrates how to meet these patterns with mudita (appreciative joy) and self-compassion.

The essay offers practical insights into working with attachment and aversion in daily life meditation practice. Sheahan describes how to investigate emotionally charged feelings with curiosity rather than suppression, allowing pleasant experiences while remaining aware of their impermanent nature. She shows how the breath can serve as an anchor for developing metta and gratitude even amid the pull of worldly concerns.

The piece concludes with the profound recognition that all beings are 'homeward bound' - drawn by an innate longing for freedom that transcends worldly attachments. This teaching resonates with the Buddhist understanding that once we glimpse the path to liberation, there is no turning back from the journey toward awakening, even as we navigate the challenges of integrating practice with daily responsibilities.

Homeward Bound.

In the last days of retreat, my mind starts longing for home, projecting delight into the release from

the rigours of the schedule, the inward focus and constant noting. In more sober moments, it

laments the fact that my current commitment to the path will surely suffer when I'm let out into the

big bad world.

I've just finished a month of the winter retreat at Satipanya, and sure enough, both predictions came

true. There was the joy of release and my heart soared happily into the world beyond the gates of

Satipanya. And there was the disappointment of seeing how quickly attachments reasserted their

stranglehold. Take food for example: I had resolved to make a special effort at mudita

(appreciative
joy) at mealtimes on retreat. A surprising bonus was the ease with which I could listen
to stomach
sensors telling me when enough was enough. With this came the quiet joy of non-greed
– seeing
how much happier I was when I could confidently declare that that two modest meals a
day is really
all I needed. Over the past years, some inner demon had chosen food as an excuse to
torture me
with anxiety - what a relief to be able to chat quietly to this demon at last. So much un-
necessary
suffering! But on the journey home the demon gobbled up sandwiches, chips and a
scone without a
by-your-leave, and I tried lobbing a few thoughts of mudita in its direction to stem the
guilt when
another scone and apple tart followed at tea time!
Contemplating the fall from grace brought a temptation towards despair. But what good
is that? The
demon of greed isn't going to be overcome by aversion. I was glad to be able to detect
and develop
thoughts along the lines of "OK I'm far from enlightened, but I know the right direction
and I'll get
there eventually" to nudge my attitude towards acceptance and self-forgiveness.
In meditation I let myself feel the deep attachment to home amidst the backdrop of the
seated
body, the waves of breath. Every sinew strained outwards towards the roof and walls,
the people
beyond those walls, the memories and assurances that these walls contain. Attention
was drawn to
parts of my body associated with a mental brightness which proclaimed the story of
'me' and 'mine'
in defiance of those darker regions where attention could barely skim. But as usual,
curiosity got the
better of me. Exploring those darker regions, defiance crumpled into gratitude that
there is more to
me than my proclamations. And that this 'more' is forgiving. Just acknowledging its
presence stirs
compassion for the dukkha that currently limits my self-knowledge.
In that sense, meditation is no different at home than it is on retreat. I'm always

working at the
limits of my understanding. At home though, pleasant feelings are more abundant what
with the
delights of relationships and news and entertainment not to speak of scones and apple
tart! It's easy
to lose mindfulness and follow pleasant fantasies. The wake-up moment then sets the
meditative
challenge. Can I allow myself to feel the pleasure generated by the associations with
home? The
temptation is to quench the pleasure, assuming it represents only greed, hurry back to
more neutral,
manageable sensations like the breath. It takes courage to look a bit deeper and explore
the
emotionally charged bonds of attachment.
Although there is greed, this can be held in check by curiosity. Taut lines of tension
clutch at feelings
of delight and the wisdom of non-greed can only creep in tentatively. As my body
relaxes its grip,
delight takes on hues of anxiety & resentment as I sense myself losing my frail grasp on
pleasure.
These feelings clamour for attention, and it's easy to overlook suggestions of strength
and

confidence seeping in with each breath. Acknowledging these is key. Breath by
breath, the bonds of
attachment transform to mudita.

Walking a tightrope between neediness and the fear of loss, the breath whispers
gratitude for walls
and floors I usually take for granted. Various people and circumstances that shape my
life hover
tentatively in mind, evoking their emotional footprint. In the space of meditation these
dissolve into
a bewildering flux of sensations and feelings. The pleasant ones stir joy and various
shades of metta,
the unpleasant ones confirm that everything dear to me will soon pass away. For a
while my being
finds a precarious peace in that blessed state of non-clinging where there is the courage
to love a life
that is forever slipping through my fingers, dissolving and disappearing, beyond any

possibility of

grasping or control.

Despite the new depth of understanding, it's easy to forget all that as soon I get off the cushion and

launch into everyday life. The main challenge has been to count the blessings of home, rather than

bow to the demons who insist that this just isn't good enough. With that bit more appreciation for

what is usually taken for granted, I find more compassion for what disturbs me, more trust that all

those I meet (even my nearest and dearest!) have the potential for full enlightenment, and thus are

fully deserving of my care and attention.

In the deepest sense, we are all homeward bound. The draw towards freedom exceeds all worldly

attachments. Once we sense this, there is no escape! The homing instinct keeps calling us back to

presence, to our frail grasp on wisdom, to the path of non-attachment.

Noirin / Ayya Punnyanandi

Kamma

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 27 min read

In this profound evening talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma presents the Buddha's nuanced understanding of kamma (Sanskrit: karma) as the fundamental law of conditionality underlying all existence. Moving beyond popular misconceptions, he clarifies that true kamma is not fate but rather the will (cetanā) that empowers our intentions into actions.

The teaching distinguishes between five universal laws affecting our lives: physical laws of nature, biological inheritance, mental formations, societal conditioning, and the Dhamma itself. Through vivid imagery of interconnected waves in puddles, pools, lakes, and oceans, Bhante illustrates how multiple karmic streams converge to create each moment's experience.

Central to the discourse is the distinction between moral behavior and spiritual skillfulness (kusala) - actions that lead toward Nibbāna. The talk emphasizes that while external circumstances arise from countless causes, our inner response to any situation constitutes our true kamma. This understanding places complete responsibility for our psychological conditioning and spiritual development in our own hands.

Drawing from the Dhammapada and core Buddhist principles, Bhante explains how renunciation differs from self-mortification, serving as reconditioning of the will toward Dhamma-cetanā - the awakened intention bent on liberation. The teaching concludes with practical guidance for maintaining moment-to-moment awareness as the foundation for transforming unwholesome habits into wholesome ones, ultimately leading to the 'warm, still waters of Nibbāna.'

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhasa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-enlightened one.

Now we've come to the end of the seventh day. We're well into the course, well adjusted, in fact, having a great time. How else could it be? I'm sure that those who will leave tomorrow will now regret bitterly that they will not be staying or have not stayed for the full eight weeks. The fact is that once you've got through the first seven days, you can actually keep going with very little effort.

It's also true that those staying for three weeks or more can train themselves to sleep less, down to three and a half or four hours a night. When a meditator does that, they experience the next three days similar to when they started, going through the healing

torture of raising energy one more notch. If after five days they still feel exhausted during the day, then it's okay to go back to five and a half hours. The fact we can do with less sleep during a meditation course is because of the purifying effect and the transformative effect of the practice. The practice lets mental turbulences release themselves and transforms that violent energy into a pure calm flow as when water having bubbled and boiled over rapids transforms into a deep and powerful gentle river.

But why do this? Why do we have to lift energy? Because in so doing, we squeeze the hidden turbulence out of the system. Remember, this turbulence also turns inwards. It drags us down and causes us to feel that dullness and lethargy, as when water trapped is overgrown with weeds and often turns fetid and rank. But when we refuse to go down but stay awake, that deeper layer of turbulence begins to manifest as some form of mental turbulence. And so we can work with that deeper layer of our psychology. So though staying on for three weeks or more, let's see if we can lift our energy.

Now all this week we've been looking inward and trying to understand how suffering arises and how it passes away. Indeed, that is what we mean by *kamma*. You will notice, by the way, I am using the more common Sanskrit form of the word with the R, karma, which is now in the Oxford English Dictionary. In the Theravāda Pali script it doesn't have an R, kamma. But that aside, we need to understand the Buddha's teaching around karma so that we can take our practice into ordinary daily life.

First, it's important to understand the underlying philosophy of causality, cause and effect. As we all know, and as our science understands, nothing comes into existence without a cause. Nothing happens without causes. What happens is the effect, the consequence, of some past action or event. That's our usual understanding. Remembering our iconic toast, once that lever is pressed, we know the bread will be transformed. Equally, when one of those terrible diseases hits the animal population, mad cow disease or foot and mouth, scientists set about searching for the cause. We sometimes go far back in time to understand the cause of present day events, such as an earthquake. We try to see our present psychological problems in terms of what happened to us in childhood, and so on.

The Buddha stated this in a very simple way. Literally, the Pali translates as, "Because that arose, this is now arising. Because that did not arise, this does not arise now." Here we have a more subtle understanding. We tend to look at karma only in the positive. This happened to me because that happened previously. I got my wages at the end of the week because I worked. But the negative is also true. I didn't make any money this week because I was sick and couldn't work. Because we do support a worthy cause, some benefit arises. Because we fail to do so, some benefit fails to materialize.

Now if everything that happens now is indeed caused by some past event, that suggests everything is set, predetermined, everything is fate. Where then would choice and free will figure? What's more, if indeed everything is determined by past events, where does creativity come in? Surely we'd be looking at a universe constantly repeating set patterns. The same cause and effect spinning around each other. A monotonous dance.

The Buddha points out that things also happen because of a conjunction, a meeting of various lines of actions that come from various past causes to create a single new event. Jung, the psychologist, called this synchronicity. Again, the Pali translates literally as "because this is, so that is, because this is not, so that is not." For a person to receive their wages either in hand or in the bank account takes a lot of things to come together from various sources. There's the amount of work done, the registering of it, which implies all the office work, the transfer of money, which implies all the banking system, and so on. I shall spare you the details of how a piece of toast ends up succulent on the tongue.

Here we have an understanding that is reflected in modern chaos theory. Dependent on supporting conditions, it may be that a flap of a butterfly wing in the tropics could eventually develop into a tornado in little old UK. That is, supporting conditions of weather patterns may come from different sources to conspire, as it were, to use that little flapping as a catalyst to create a catastrophe. By the way, I find it typical of our present-day gloom and doom that a positive spin could not be given to it. Conditions creating a great summer, for instance.

It is also important to take this understanding into our moral behaviour. A small act of kindness whirled by supporting conditions may bring an end to an age-old quarrel, an age-old war.

Now if it were true that the universe was only a confluence of unrelated events, different events totally unconnected with each other in the present and arising with no connection to the past, then we can imagine only chaos, real chaos. How could there be any coherence? Or if there were, it would be by mere chance, and then only for the occasional moment. Yet without these haphazard meetings, there can be no creativity. We may unexpectedly meet a friend and suddenly a choice arises whether to do something with our friend or carry on doing what we'd set out to do. I set out looking for work. Others are looking for workers. Opportunities arise. Some improbable, some just up my street. Hopefully.

So to understand the picture fully, we need to blend these two positions together. Something happens now because the different parts of that event come from a structured past and because they happen to all come together at one and the same time.

Even in this statement we do not catch the boggling complexity of the situation because what the term "structured past" fails to get across is the idea that every moment in that structured past was a similar confluence of various karmic lines.

There is the story of the boy who was drowning in a bog and the local poor farmer who saved him. The rich father of that boy wanted to give the farmer some money. The farmer would have nothing to do with it. So the rich man offered to give the poor man's son an education. As things turned out, the rich man's son was Winston Churchill and the poor man's son was Alexander Fleming, the discoverer of penicillin. When Winston Churchill fell ill with pneumonia, it was Fleming's penicillin that saved him, saved twice by the same family.

Here we see a graphic example of the interaction of two differing lines of past karma meeting to create unexpected results. What possible connection could there have been originally between the poor and the rich boy? There will be those who argue that this was the product of karma coming from a past life, and there may be some truth in that. But I tend to lean on the side of chance. Our general disposition is to try to make sense of everything, even if it does not solve the problem. To be sick and not know what is wrong with you is worse than finding out what is wrong but can't be cured. One learns to bear with it. Even if it's terminal, one can come to terms with it. But not knowing is an anxious and frustrating place for us to be. And as we shall see, there are other laws that really do bring that element of chance into our lives.

So here we have the basic law underlying the teachings of karma, the law of conditionality. Everything arises in the present moment dependent on past and present conditions. Nothing arises spontaneously of its own cause. There is nothing causeless in the relative universe simply because everything is related. You can see though that this is not a mechanical law, we don't live in a simple one-and-one-makes-two logical universe. There's something quite unpredictable about the universe and indeed about our lives as human beings. In fact, the Buddha said, if you were to try to work out your karma, it would drive you mad.

To give you a sense of what it's all about, I'd like to ask you to practice a little visualization with me. You'll have to close your eyes for this one, and imagine. Imagine there's a little puddle, and a tiny stone lands in the center of it. See how the waves expand outwards, hit the edge and flow back to the centre. And how this continues until the momentum slowly dies away. Now see that puddle showered with little stones of various sizes. Can you see the turmoil? And yet there's that underlying pattern. As waves criss-cross, there are new meetings, each wave affecting the other. Everything is interconnected.

Now take a large pool and place that puddle in some quiet little corner. Again see how the stone creates a wave that flows out to the edge and back again and also flows against that little puddle and affects all the wavelets there. Now shower that pool with stones of various sizes and again see the apparent turmoil and the underlying structure.

Now take a large lake and place that pool with its puddle in a hidden corner and again watch that first wave splash out from the centre and make its way to the bank and back, again affecting all the waves in the pool with its little puddle. Again shower the lake with rocks and boulders. Oh, what a creation!

Now take a sea and again place that lake with its pond and puddle in some quiet corner. Again, see that first splash and the wave launching out to the surrounding beach, crossing over the lake, the pool and the puddle. And now again the sea is bombarded with pebbles, rocks and boulders. What mayhem!

And finally the vast ocean. Hidden somewhere is that sea containing the lake, the pool and the puddle. Again a great wave. Watch it flow outward and as it lifts the pool and the puddle it hardly affects them, so great is it. Both are simply lifted up in the great swell. And again so many swells.

And one last little thing. Focus again on that little puddle and notice that the turbulent which hits it does not penetrate. It only causes the inner water to vibrate as when we strike a balloon. And as you slowly zoom away, you notice it's intimately surrounded by lots of other little puddles. And one final observation. Waves are not water moving. It is simply a force that runs through the mass, causing it to rise and fall.

So now there's our image. It's a way of symbolizing how each of us are at a crossroads of lesser or greater confluences. And what we need to be very clear about is what constitutes karma, personal karma. That karma that has to be cleared up, purified and refined as a part of the process of becoming liberated.

We can take these images in various ways to see how intricately complicated the universe is. On the grand scale we can see the puddles as human beings, the pool, the society we create, the lake, the earth we live on, the sea, our galaxy and the ocean, the vast cosmos. Alternatively, we can take it on a more interactive human level, making the puddle stand for individuals, the pool for the family and relatives, the lake for our society, the sea for our culture, and the ocean for mankind.

Here we have used the word karma in a more popular way to describe how all things come to be, all cause and effect, but the teachings make a finer distinction. They point to five different laws. They equate with our own modern understandings.

The first are the physical laws of nature. Luckily, we live in a fairly benevolent climate. Some parts of the world suffer greatly from floods and droughts, and perhaps most dramatic of all in recent times, earthquakes, hurricanes and tsunamis. Yet even we in temperate climes are affected in all sorts of ways by the weather. How the cold and dark of winter keeps us indoors. At an extreme level some people suffer from depression because of light deprivation. It's the time we prefer to catch colds and flus. And then summer with its flowers and sun, more than occasional these days, happily. How we love to bask in the warmth. How a sunny day lays us out on beaches like pancakes, and so on. But it's much bigger than that, how dependent we are on that very sun, how inexorably tied up we are with the laws that govern the physical universe. Who knows what distant galactic explosion might not blast this puny little planet out of existence. Not to talk of black holes. Now there I go being gloomy and doomy. Alternatively, it may remain a favoured place for the evolution of consciousness and simply die away gracefully with the rest of the universe.

In popular Buddhism, there is much confusion over this. Much like the monotheistic religions, people believe that storms and earthquakes and tsunamis are sent to us by our past karma, our sins. Not because there is some judging God doing it, but because of the lord of cause and effect, karma. There's a telling story, a later attachment to one of the verses of the Dhammapada, the collection of the Buddha's sayings. A ship suddenly stops in the middle of the sea. The wind suddenly drops. The captain and crew are mystified. Luckily, there's a group of monks on board who have supranormal powers. They sit in meditation and announce to all that the reason the ship has stopped is because of the bad karma of the captain's wife. It seems that in a past life she drowned many dogs, and there would be no sailing until she left the ship. Can you imagine how she felt? Worse was to come. How could she leave the ship in the middle of the sea? There was only one way for it, so they chucked her overboard. The wind blew, the ship quickly caught sail, and soon made harbour.

The next is concerned with the law of seeds, as it translates. This is anything to do with life, with biology. As for humans, that refers to our DNA. And here lies another regular misconception. It does say clearly in the discourses that the way we behave morally has an effect on the way we look. Hatred leads to an ugliness, love and joy to a beauty. But our dispositions are only one in a number of factors. The overriding factor must be our genetic makeup, which comes to us from a long history of evolution. So we should hardly feel that we're undergoing the consequences of a hateful heart in the past life, if we happen in this life to look like the back of a bus. So what is our actual true karma in terms of the process of awakening? It is how we deal with being plain or plain ugly. Even though ugliness and beauty are all to do with human convention, non-

etheless they affect us. In the same way as ugliness, for instance, might lead to low self-esteem, beauty can lead to conceit, both unskillful, unwholesome. Ultimately, of course, how we look should not be of any consequence to us. But the fact remains, however, that the way we feel does have an effect on our looks. Not simply body language, but even the shape the face grows into can express a constant underlying mood. Depression or joy, for instance. Even so, the body we have is not something we have directly caused by our actions.

The third law is the law concerning the mind. Again, this tends to focus on how the mind works, how consciousness arises and contacts the world and so on, and especially the psychology of dependent origination we've covered. But implied, of course, is our relationship to the world around us. Was it a conscious choice to be born into the family we were brought up in? Did we make a decision to be born in this country and not another? How all overpowering on our minds and hearts, our personality and character is the family and society we are born into. The way we see things, talk about things, our opinions, even the very language we use has been pre-set, pre-determined for us. We are born into a set of values, a history, a culture and a civilization. We are profoundly conditioned by them. Indeed, how else can we be human beings if not as members of a family and a country with all that that implies? Has it all been the result of my own personal past actions? Hardly. Yet here I am with an identity that firmly locks me into time and place. Again, there is some connection, but not necessarily because of a personal action, moral or otherwise. It may be just the way things came together.

Then there's the Dharma, often translated as the law or the norm, the truth as to the way things really are. Penetrating the world within, our feelings, thoughts and emotions, and the world without, living organisms and the material universe, are the spiritual truths that teach us about our relationship to this interior and exterior life. And within these teachings, that are only concerned to liberate us from suffering, lies the law of karma itself.

So what did the Buddha mean by karma, specific to the process of liberation? Karma here means action, what we do. It's not to be confused with the result of action, which is properly termed *vipāka*. But what is it that actually creates an action? Is it not will? Just consider what happens when we do walking meditation, or indeed anything on an intensive course like this. We first try to become aware of our intentions before we actually act them out. This has been a very important part of our training because usually we don't distinguish between the two. In ordinary daily life we rarely stop to consider an intention. As soon as the desire arises we tend to act upon it. Who would want to

pause and note the intention to open a door once they've decided to leave a room? It's normally when we're in a state of doubt or conflict do we consider whether to respond to an intention or not. Usually we just react.

But until we've begun to meditate, we may not have realized the crucial role of will. For will is that power that brings something out of potential into the actual, within ourselves and into the world. If a thought comes to mind, I need not necessarily follow it. To cause it to continue means something has been added to the original impetus, the original stimulus. Perhaps an image of someone I dislike arises. I could just stop it there. Something must empower it to develop. Perhaps an idea comes to take a holiday in an exotic place. It could stop there, or I may end up right where I had imagined. What is it that empowered that desire in my mind to throw it into the world out there? That empowering is what the Buddha meant by will. And he goes so far as to say, "Disciples, it is the will, *cetanā*, that I call karma." So will is the power that brings potential into actual. It is that which conditions.

It is the will that has created this inner environment that we live in. It is the will that has created and is developing right now all our emotions and thoughts, and it is our will, our will to live, that keeps this body alive. It is activated in a conscious way when we deliberate, but it is active also in an unconscious way out of habit for the will itself is also conditioned. That's why we can teach ourselves to do something even when we're not watching. I'm sure you've experienced coming back from a daydream to find the mind happily noting rising, falling.

Now from an intention there arises through the empowering of will an action. Many actions form a habit. Many habits form a personality and character, and once you've got that, well, you've also got your destiny. The crucial link in the chain is the movement out of intention into action, be it a thought, word, or deed.

So how does this psychology link in with the end of suffering? First let us remember that will does not have understanding, it's just a power. What guides our will is the way we see things. It is our understanding, deluded or wise, that commands the will to empower a desire. Although there are many times we perform neutral actions, such as tying up our shoelaces, a lot of the time we could ask ourselves whether something is skillful or not.

Now here, we must make a distinction between the moral and the skillful, the immoral and the unskillful. All of us have given up gross, immoral behaviour. Have we not? I mean, we're not about to kill or steal or tell whoppers. No doubt we infringe the moral law in some small aspects, little piccadillos, but nothing to get us in serious trouble with the police. But when it comes to skilfulness, well, we've a long way to go.

By *kusala*, skillful, wholesome, virtuous... The Buddha meant all those actions that lead us to the end of suffering, *Nibbāna*. The path leading to that liberation is always against the flow self would have us follow. Before the Buddha took his seat beneath the Bodhi tree, where he was to become enlightened, he put his bowl in the river and it flowed upstream. It's a metaphorical way to show that the path of enlightenment is against our self-conditioned will. There's a verse in the Dhammapada which says that those who are not mindful, not skillful, are as if dead. So beware, only dead fish go with the flow.

To turn that self-conditioning around and to follow the desires of the Dharma is what spiritual training is all about. The whole of spiritual training could be said to be the reconditioning of the will. For once the will is behind the desire to become enlightened, awakened, then it becomes known as *Dhammacetanā*, the will that follows the true law. What in Mahāyāna is called *Bodhicitta*, the mind bent on enlightenment. Now when that happens, the path is straightened up. No more side alleys, no more diversions, no more wanderings in the garden of lotus eaters. And this is when we come to understand the importance of renunciation in our spiritual practice.

Renunciation must not be confused with self-mortification if what we mean by self-mortification is to make ourselves suffer in order to get rid of suffering. The Buddha discovered that to be simply painful, ignoble and unprofitable. It gets you nowhere but into more suffering. Renunciation, on the other hand, is the practice of confronting unskillful will, unskillful conditioning. It's the process whereby we undo self-conditioning and create a dharma conditioning.

Today, lots of people diet. Why? Is it not to contain their greed? Say, for the few who truly have a weight problem, the reason most do it is to get back their youthful shape or to rein in their insatiable appetite. Such people are forever in that exhausting tug of war only the self can invent, at one time feasting as if there's no tomorrow, and then bloated and obese, dieting because there might very well not be. In olden days, when our society was more spiritually bound, dieting was called fasting. But the reason for fasting was not for worldly gains of health and beauty, but to tame the will to undo conditionings forged by greed.

The Buddha instituted for his order members and any lay member who wanted to increase their spiritual effort the rule not to take food after midday. We don't have to stop eating altogether to practice renunciation. For the reason is to let go of all conditioning of eating for greed and not for nourishment. Not to let go of food itself. This is

the difference between renunciation and self-mortification. The self-mortifier blames his body for his greed and so denies the body what it needs. The renunciator blames attitude.

Take the bad habit of snacking. Rather than blame the body and go on long punitive diets, better to sit quietly with the craving and wait for it to pass. Or if that's difficult, put the mind onto something more skillful such as taking a walk. And that's the main reason for not eating after midday on this course, to investigate greed and to let it go. Remember, every time we let go of an unskillful conditioning, we also strengthen our will to follow the Dharma, our *Dhammacetanā*. And as I'm sure you've all experienced, there's the added advantage of being a little more awake in the evening.

The same practice can decondition any unwholesome habit we have. Just think how addicted we become to the TV. Now how to tackle that? Well, if you want to hit it head on, just sit in front of the box with a cup of tea and biscuit, and when your favourite programme comes on, don't switch the TV on. Just sit there and watch the inner programme. Now that's spiritual training.

And this is where our free choice really lies. Free choice here is not some anarchic behaviour, do as I want to do, when I want to do and how I want to do. That's how the self would have it. But we don't live in our own universe. We aren't creator gods. Choice arises when the possibility of two or more actions arise in a given situation. Most of our lives we have little choice. We have to get up to work, we have to go to bed to rest and so on. But there are many sorts of choices we do have to make. Some are trivial, to have tea or coffee, walk this way around the park. Some are practical, pragmatic, the best way to buy a house. But for the trainee, choices become important when there is an ethical or spiritual value to them. Ethics is concerned with the way we treat ourselves and other human beings, or living beings and the earth. Spiritual decisions are more personal and concern our own inner growth.

Once we've made a decision and empowered it, we've created an act of thought, word or deed. And whether we like it or not, there will be a result. So what we come to understand is that there is no absolutely free will and that ultimately our choices are whether to empower those thoughts, desires, intentions that lead to suffering or those that lead to the end of suffering. So that we can say that the process of awakening, of liberation as it shapes our characters and personalities is simply the switch from unwholesome habits to wholesome ones.

Here we come to the other core teaching of the Buddha concerning karma. Many people these days don't believe that. That's why there's an attitude of, well, if you can get away with it, all the better. Even in the Buddha's day, there was a famous teacher

who said it was irrelevant what you did by way of good or bad deeds. Your karma, meaning your destiny here, was set. He said if you went down one side of the Ganges and murdered, pillaged and created mayhem, or whether you came up the other side performing immense deeds of compassion, it would not make a blind bit of difference.

Now two of the great insights the Buddha had upon enlightenment were concerned with this sort of karma. The first was that he saw all his past lives and saw clearly how all the ethical and spiritual decisions he had made had led to his becoming a fully self-enlightened Buddha. And then he also saw beings moving from one realm to another according to their ethical and spiritual decisions. What had been seen first of all as a personal individual law was now understood to be a cosmic law. It was true for all beings.

Now here we seem to have a contradiction. At one time we are saying that the situation we find ourselves is not entirely of our own making. And you hear the Buddha seems to be saying as much. To clarify this situation we must understand that although the world out there has its own relative existence and reality it remains even when we are not here what we experience of it and how we relate to that experience is all of our own creation.

When we came here to join this course we all saw this building. No one will deny this building exists and has some objective reality yet did we see the same building? Is it not true that each of us had a different image, a different feeling, a different understanding of the place, even if only in delicate shades? In other words, Buddhism teaches that even if the world out there has some objective reality of its own, we only know it from our own subjective perspectives. What seems to have great beauty or meaning to one person strikes another as indifferent. Think of the arguments of modern art. Is it art or isn't it? Who knows? Well, we could say only the judges know. But then they only know for themselves. And if anyone has an opinion, well, that's their judgment. In this way, there can be no absolute objective standard in art existing out there in the universe that are only agreed conventions among human beings.

So it's not the situation we find ourselves in but the way we are in any given situation that is our karma proper, that karma that pertains to the process of liberation. Take one of those earthquakes. There will be some who go through the experience with utter horror and yet others with calmness. There was the case of a mother and child trapped beneath concrete. To keep her child alive, the mother cut her fingers and had the child suck her blood. Right there in the midst of that horror there can arise such selflessness and heroism, whereas no doubt others scream themselves to death.

There are people you meet who have to suffer terrible diseases and misfortune. Some are emotionally gnarled by the experience, embittered, self-piteous, humourless. A while back I remember there was a policeman who was shot and lost the power of his legs. It seems he made a valiant attempt to make sense of his life but eventually committed suicide. Yet we have the heroic example of many people cruelly paralysed in all limbs and yet still find life meaningful. I met someone who was so paralysed after a car crash, though happily he did recover. While lying there it came to him that his life was still, as he put it, authentic.

In other words, how we experience our lives is the way we have conditioned ourselves to experience our lives. Of course, our parents, family, culture and so on have had enormous influence in the way we see things. But, and it's hard for us to accept this, they actually only have influence. Yes, even as utterly vulnerable children, it is still our own decisions that make our conditionings. Ultimately, it is we who have made the internal decisions that have brought about our particular way of relating to the world. In the final analysis, then, we must take on the entire responsibility of our own perspectives and attitudes. And it is because of these perspectives and attitudes that we have created the inner environment in which we continue to live.

So when we feel unhappy, it's an utter waste of time to seek the solution out there, for the fundamental reason lies within our own hearts and minds. It is futile to seek someone to blame. At first this may seem unfair. How could I have known as a baby, as a child, or even as an adult? But what if it were not so? If indeed other people can make willful decisions that actually condition my inner attitudes? Then how could I ever change without having to change them also? Everybody whom I think has conditioned me, rather than influence my conditioning, and by implication all those who conditioned them and so on to all people, everybody would have to be liberated before I myself could attain that liberation. But when we see that others can only influence our decisions and that we alone are the sole creators of our deeds, then firstly we stop empowering people to dominate us and secondly we take full responsibility for our decisions and our own psychological conditioning. Now once we do that, we are on the noble path to liberation from all suffering, for we can purify our hearts and clarify our understanding, both necessary preconditions for the attainment of *Nibbāna*.

So now we've talked about the fundamental laws of conditioning how we live in uncertain times all the time for we do not know what lines of events will come together for us in any given moment that's indeed why the Buddha told us not to try to work out our karma it would drive us mad We talk to the many laws that affect us from nature to genetics, from psychology to family to society. We discuss the difference between morality and skillfulness, how the former is included in the latter, how skillfulness is the

whole noble path that leads to liberation. We saw how the Buddha puts his finger so firmly on the role of will in our conditioning. And finally, how there is an underlying moral law within the universe that dictates that unwholesome actions will have negative effects and wholesome actions positive effects within our own psyches.

And it is upon this final note that we need to concentrate, especially in our daily lives. Why is it that so many people seem to get away with it and so many people don't seem to get their just reward? It is only when we look inwardly that we see there is a justice based on this moral law. Remember, the effects of one's actions outwardly can never be determined. There are too many variables. But inwardly, all our decisions are going towards creating an ugly or a beautiful environment. And just because a person may be good at suppressing their guilt, anger, fear and so on, doesn't mean they've escaped them. These turbulences, as our meditation makes so obvious to us, are always there, lurking in the depths, causing slow havoc in the body. But worse, they are secretly skewing our perspective of the world, as Freud understood so well, so that we find ourselves falling again and again into the same old situations, the same old problems, the same old traps, the same old unsatisfactoriness. And it could all be so different. And it will be different once we take hold of this wild bull and begin to train it in the ways of the true law.

The Buddha warned us that the way is gradual. It's going to take some time. Think in terms of decades, not years. But although the path is hard, it should not be laborious. Think of the drudgery or training for an Olympic sport. Every day, for instance, rowers can train for six hours, and most of it rowing, that monotonous movement, forward, backward, forward, backward. They probably go through days of sheer boredom, I don't know, but they are fired with the will to win. That same drive to become awakened is called *saṃvega*, translated as a sense of urgency about our task, an enthusiasm. That's the feeling of *Dhammacetanā*, the will of the true law.

Though the path ahead of us is hard, tough, demanding real determination and stamina, yet there is a joy to it, a subtle joy, that suffuses the spiritual life, and that joy is hope. Hope is not expectation, rather expectation is hope with a date put on it. No, hope is the heart's secret delight when it is informed through faith and insight that there will be a time when we shall enter into that blissful peace and contentment of *Nibbāna*. It is this hope we should savour and from that heartfelt base we should express our wisdom, little though it may be, into the world. And in this way everything we do will be perfumed with love, compassion, joy or peace.

Let's pause here for a moment.

And so the connection is made between our training here on an intensive course and our training in ordinary daily life. If in our understanding there's a hair's breadth of difference between the two, that gap is a chasm that will greatly undermine our progress. The Mahāsi Sayadaw, reinforcing the words of the Buddha, moment-to-moment mindfulness is the secret of success, points to the essence of our practice, and that practice is full-time. Six hours a day just won't do. Save for the hours of sleep, not a moment should pass when we are not making that effort to be aware, a calm, bright attentiveness. That's all we have to do to become fully awakened. It's as easy as that and as hard as that. But do we have a choice in the matter? Is there any free will to be exerc

Mettā for a Cold Heart

Noirin Sheahan · 2 min read

This compassionate essay by Noirin Sheahan addresses one of the most challenging aspects of mettā (loving-kindness) practice: working with states of deep anger, resentment, and emotional coldness. Drawing from personal experience and wisdom, she explores how vipassanā meditation naturally reveals the self-torture inherent in holding onto enmity, showing how greed, hatred, and delusion fuel our cycles of vengeance and self-judgment.

The essay offers practical guidance for those times when traditional mettā phrases like 'May I be well and happy' feel impossible or even repugnant. Sheahan describes how deep seeds of hatred can be excavated by meditation practice or traumatic events, making loving-kindness practice initially more painful than insight meditation itself. She draws on Thomas Merton's wisdom about prayer becoming impossible when the heart turns to stone, reframing cold-heartedness as a revelation of deep suffering worthy of honour rather than condemnation.

With gentle wisdom, the essay suggests treating our closed hearts with the same patience we would show an injured animal, emphasizing that even the coldest heart-states ultimately respond to sustained patience and gentle investigation. This teaching offers hope and practical approaches for practitioners struggling with seemingly impenetrable states of anger and emotional shutdown.

Metta for a Cold Heart!

A cold heart is the antithesis of the friendly goodwill of metta. The coldness may seem impenetrable, but if we mindfully follow the process of enmity we might see how it is generated by greed, hatred and delusion. We may notice the enticement of delusive, unanswerable questions like „why did this happen ...how could you do this?“ the seductive longing for the downfall or our enemy, as well as self-judgement which condemns such vengeance. As we let the thoughts go we might feel ourselves caught in a sore, hurting state. Vengeance pulling the heart and mind and flesh in one direction, self-judgement blocking their path, delusion compounding the misery with its attempts at explanation. If we watch all this drama until we see that this is self-torture, then we accept defeat. We cannot knowingly torture ourselves forever. At that point it's often possible to find, buried within the confusion and humiliation of defeat, the willingness to move towards peace, to acknowledge what is good both in ourselves and in our enemy.

Thus vipassana naturally undermines our tendency towards enmity and develops our capacity for friendliness and forgiveness. But the seeds of greed, hatred and delusion are sown deep within us, and the whole battle can be re-enacted with even the slightest encouragement. Metta, the Buddha taught, is the antidote to hatred. We develop goodwill for ourselves and others by repeating phrases such as „May I / you be well & happy’. A sense of kindness may arise and we might feel our body soften. These healing feelings further encourage us towards peace and reconciliation.

Sometimes a deep seed of hatred can be excavated by meditation practice or by some traumatic life event. At those times, practicing metta may be even more painful than vipassana as we feel ourselves squirm away from any possibility of goodwill or trust or forgiveness. Instead of feeling soft and warm we may feel the tension of anger rising and gripping us. The words „May I / you be well’ may seem ridiculous and be rejected in derisive scorn. This can lead to even deeper turmoil. How rotten can I be that I can’t even wish myself well, or my friends or family, or even my dog!

At such times I find it helpful to remember the words of Thomas Merton, „Prayer and love are learned in the hour when prayer becomes impossible and your heart has turned to stone.” I encourage myself to see cold-heartedness as a revelation of deep suffering, a state to be honoured rather than despised. If we saw a dog injured on the roadside, would we kick it and say “You disgusting animal, clean up that wound before I see you again.” But yet we can easily compound our emotional hurt with such self-disgust. I try to tread very carefully here – noting the self-disgust, the wish to turn away, as well as the turmoil or coldness I am turning from. Sometimes the words of metta may seem aggressive – a desperate attempt to cover up a wound even with a dirty bandage. If so I relax as best I can into the simple experience of the hurting state. Sometimes it can seem OK to receive goodwill from friends, family (or the dog!). At other times receiving is also out of bounds. But if I keep gingerly investigating my condition I may eventually

find a chink in my armour. Then I might be able to turn towards my closed heart, saying perhaps “For as long as you need to be closed that’s OK, I’m willing to wait, I will wait.” Even the coldest heart-states ultimately succumb to patience.

Mid-winter Darkness

Noirin Sheahan · 4 min read

In this deeply personal reflection, Noirin Sheahan explores how her laryngectomy surgery opened unexpected doorways to contemplative insight. Writing in the format of a letter to 'Lary' (her laryngectomy condition), she describes morning meditation experiences where both light and darkness become objects of contemplation. The essay beautifully weaves together the Buddhist understanding of longing and aversion with the raw reality of living with serious illness. Noirin examines how her initial terror of the medical condition led her to discover what she calls 'peaceful darkness beyond' - a space where restless desires can find resolution. The piece demonstrates how physical trauma can paradoxically deepen one's meditation practice, offering glimpses of what lies beyond ordinary life and death. Through mindful attention to breathing and bodily sensations, despite fear and aversion, she cultivates the courage to rest with difficult emotions. This honest account shows how the Buddhist path of bearing witness to suffering - including anger, frustration, and loss - becomes a doorway to peace.

Mid-winter Darkness.

Since my laryngectomy, I've started writing a column on living mindfully with this condition for a laryngectomee support group called Webwhispers. The column is called 'Dear Lary' (Lary being short for 'Laryngectomee') in an effort to cultivate a friendly relationship with this new phase of my life. Here is the column I wrote for the January edition – I hope it speaks also to the Satipanya Sangha.

It's Sunday morning, 21st December, the mid-winter solstice. From now on the days will start to get longer – such a lovely thought! I love springtime and am always so sorry when 21st June comes along and know the light is starting to ebb away again. I snuggle back into the bed-clothes and luxuriate in their warmth for another five minutes.

Five minutes turn into ten as thoughts and feelings rise and fall away. I love this time of day, and if I can get my mind to settle, can appreciate the wonder of just being alive and warm and comfortable. Then the various pressures of my 'to do' list die into the background. I often forget about you altogether at these times Lary, as well as the other troubles of the world. (I still think of you as trouble, Lary, though deep down I have to admit you may actually be a blessing.)

I suppose I've always been a bit of a dreamer. Maybe that's why meditation appeals to me so strongly. As I relax, I notice a bright light in my mind. It's very ordinary – just a mental image, not any kind of apparition. Just as you might have an image of your

friend or husband or daughter in your mind. Or your sitting-room, or the colours of sea and sky as you remember a day at the beach. It's the same thing. But I've only recently started to notice it. As soon as I do, I feel a surge of attraction towards it – as if I want to swallow it up, to let it light up my whole being. But from experience, often bitter experience, I've learned that my longing to get closer to this light, to get more of it, to swallow it, are all in vain. It's always tantalisingly beyond my reach. I tune into the feeling of breathing to try to keep myself grounded, not get so lost in my passionate desire for this ... this what? A dream of light? Of life? Of love? Or all the beauties of the world?

The feeling of breathing, by comparison, that sensation of the tummy and chest rising and falling with each breath, seems strange ... light years away ... a different world altogether. It even frightens me for some unknown reason. But over the years of meditation practice I've learned to appreciate the body despite all its associated strangeness and fear. I know that attending to simple sensations cultivates kindness and

courage and other strengths. So I bear with my aversion for the body. And then, another

miracle, I sense a darkness which is equally as enticing as the light. While the light seems to represent life, the darkness represents something equally beautiful beyond life.

I first noticed it on the night after my laryngectomy – after meeting you Lary. Since then the darkness has become my best friend. And it's very close to my own body, as if my

breath is just barely brushing against it. Something so peaceful, completely beyond words. For a while all my wishes and longings die out willingly into the darkness. It's such a relief to know there is this outlet for deep longings. When I can't find the dark channel this longing for life and beauty and love just fire me up with restless energy and

the frustration of unfulfilled desire. But for now, they flow unobstructed and die away peacefully into the blessed darkness.

So this is something I have to thank you for Lary. Perhaps it was the terror I felt for you that drove me to this edge of my known world, to sense the peaceful darkness beyond, and the possibility of dying in peace.

I can't yet rest for long with this pouring of my life energies into darkness. Sooner or later my mind wanders, or I get pent up with desire to know just a little bit more about the light or the darkness, or to sense a deeper peace. Basically my natural human longings tip me off balance. Then it's the work of bearing with the sense of loss or frustration or anger or whatever surfaces. The light and darkness still hover as mental images but now it's a struggle to see them through the turmoil of emotion. But I know

that this is an equally valuable stage in meditation – learning to bear with emotions, to name them, allow them come and go without judgement or any effort to change them for any preferred state of love or bliss or wisdom. I'm more and more willing to bear with this struggle, trusting to this painful path towards peace.

So, Lary, on this mid-winter's day, let me thank you for what you have brought into my life - a love for darkness. And in the darkness, some glimpse of what lies beyond life.

Once you showed it to me, you planted a seed in my heart and now there is a growing trust in this ocean of peace into which all our energies can sink.

May we both rest easy in the peace of mid-winter, Lary.

Pity, Sorrow and Compassion

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 2 min read

In this insightful reflection, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines three distinct emotional responses to others' suffering, revealing how our sense of self can distort our reactions. He begins by exploring 'pity' in its negative sense - a feeling that maintains separation and may harbor hidden smugness or even schadenfreude. Through honest vipassanā observation, practitioners can become aware of these subliminal attitudes that contradict our self-image.

Bhante contrasts this with genuine sorrow - a direct resonance with another's pain that can be physically felt, illustrated through poignant examples including his own encounter with a suffering child in Calcutta. However, he identifies compassion as the essential transformation: the active desire to alleviate suffering that moves us beyond mere feeling into beneficial action.

The teaching emphasizes practical application in daily life and meditation practice. Rather than self-condemnation when we notice the conceit of pity arising, Bhante advocates for simple acknowledgment without acting on these impulses, allowing genuine sorrow to naturally develop into compassionate action. This approach offers a concrete method for practitioners to work skillfully with the persistent delusion of self while cultivating the brahmavihāra of genuine compassion.

Pity - feeling sorry for: I'm using this term in its negative sense. When we hear ourselves say, 'I pity Jack', how does this 'I' define itself? There may be a genuine sorrow for the person and their situation, but somehow this 'I' stands apart from it. It is saying to itself: he does deserve it; he's such an idiot; I'd never get myself into that situation; thank heavens I'm not like that. There may be somewhere a smug satisfaction. Indeed, there could be there, quietly ignored, a feeling of schadenfreude, a sense of joy in another's suffering. Just because we are not aware of these subliminal feelings, doesn't mean they don't have effect. I'm sure we've heard that false tone in another's voice, that overly affectation of sorrow on the face. But are we aware when we also 'pity' someone. It's often a case that in vipassana, if we honestly note what the mind is thinking, that we wake up to these hitherto quietly suppressed attitudes which don't fit into our esteemed self-definition. Sorrow is a genuine feel for the suffering of another. It can actually be felt as a direct resonance of the other's pain, both psychological and physical. I know someone who felt the pain of her daughter when she broke her arm.

She had to have her arm in a sling. The daughter felt nothing. This sort of 'sorrow' is very rare of course, but all of us are touched when we see someone suffer, especially if it is a child or animal, for their innocence and vulnerability add poignancy to the situation. I was once in Calcutta and as I turned a corner there was a little girl, squatting in the dry, dirt road sucking on a black-brown desiccated banana skin. To this day I can still feel the shock in my heart. But did it move me to do anything? That to me is the difference between sorrow and compassion. Compassion is the desire to alleviate suffering. It moves one to do something. Anything – even if it is only to try to influence someone else to do something. I'm sorry to say I did nothing to help that little girl. And I'm left with an unrequited sorrow. That is the penalty when sorrow does not transform into compassion. So, since the delusion of self is always active, how might we proceed? It is to acknowledge the conceit of pity, but not denigrate oneself for it. It's enough to acknowledge it and determine not to act on it. To feel instead the genuine sorrow and to act on that. In this simple way, our pity diminishes and our compassion increases.

Sixth Maxim: Act for the Future Generations of All Species

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 4 min read

This essay examines the sixth and final ethical maxim proposed for addressing climate catastrophe: "Act for the future generations of all species." Drawing deeply from the Metta Sutta's universal loving-kindness teachings, Noirin Sheahan explores how the Buddha's words "Whatever living beings there may be, whether they be weak or strong, omitting none" directly relate to our climate responsibilities toward both current climate refugees and future generations.

The teaching addresses a fundamental challenge in climate activism: how to open the heart to planetary suffering without falling into either pity (positioning oneself as superior) or overwhelm (compassion fatigue and despair). Using the Buddha's teaching that "the whole world can be found within this fathom-long body," the essay provides practical guidance for working with the physical sensations that arise when contemplating global suffering.

Through detailed meditation instructions, the author demonstrates how tracking aversion and tension in the body can lead to a balanced middle ground where compassion flows naturally without exhaustion. This process reveals the interconnection between wisdom and compassion, dissolving the delusion of separation between "self" and "world." The essay concludes with practical suggestions for translating this inner work into concrete action for climate and environmental justice, making it both a profound meditation teaching and a guide for engaged Buddhist practice.

Noirin Sheahan This tip looks at the last of the six maxims which have been suggested as ethical preparation for climate catastrophe. This advises us to “act for future generations of all species”. Here’s how the authors elaborate: Speak for those without voice: the poor, the future generations, other species. Speak for the forests, the seas, the mountains. Act, personally and politically, to limit the damage being done to the biosphere. Every 0.5° C increase avoided is a major victory and achievement. We are to concern ourselves with the welfare of those far beyond our circle of friendship or kinship. The Buddha’s teaching on compassion asks the same, and these lines from the Metta Sutta link closely with the maxim: Whatever living beings there may be, Whether they be weak or strong, omitting none, The great or the mighty, medium, short or tall, The seen and unseen, Those living near or far away, born or to-be-born, may all beings be at ease! The words are easy to say, but challenging to put into action. Weak or strong omitting

none. Considering climate change, the weak could be considered as those currently suffering, for example peoples in East Africa who have suffered decades of drought with resultant famine, homelessness and political instability, war and mass migration. The strong could be considered as those in relatively stable environments like Europe and the US, long beneficiaries of the resource-hungry technologies causing climate change. It's helpful to bring both weak and strong together as the tendency to blame can find no suitable resting place – neither the climate refugees nor the far-right activists opposing them, nor the climate deniers exacerbating the crisis. Weak and strong, omitting none. Neither can we console ourselves by ignoring the forecasts of what our grandchildren may have to face: Those born and to be born; May all beings be at ease. To “act for future generations of all species” is to consider the whole world, to let the mind linger on wildfires, floods, drought and the devastation these bring for people and wildlife as well as nature itself, the essential basis for new generations. When considering the world in this way, I've found it helpful to remember the Buddha's teaching that the whole world can be found within this fathom long body. ‘The world’ here means the totality of our experience. In meditation we are normally focussed on our inner world of sensations and feelings. While working with this maxim, the totality of our experience includes our thoughts and imaginings of the outer world, planet earth with all its inhabitants. Imaging drought and starvation brings tension: the jaws clench, the eyes wince. We usually ignore these seemingly trivial reactions but they are a key to the conundrum of compassion: how do I open the heart to the suffering of the world without causing myself to suffer? Here is an example of working with this conundrum from my own experience. Remembering that ‘the world can be found within this fathom long body’ draws awareness towards the physical tension in my jaws, eyes and elsewhere. This gives me the objectivity needed to register aversion, the attempt to get rid of suffering. Tracking the pushing sensations of aversion I realise that I am attempting to push away the imagined suffering so that ‘I’ can be above it all, directing good wishes towards those who suffer. At times I sense this image of myself as superior, powerful, full of resources, while ‘the world’ is weak and needy. This is pity, easily confused with compassion. As I acknowledge pity, I notice how exhausting it is to imagine myself above the suffering of the world, how much effort I have to put into my good wishes. In time I run out of steam and sense myself as drowning in the imagined suffering of the world. Anger, blame and despair compete for attention as I scramble to get back on top of things. This is overwhelm, compassion fatigue, burn-out. Mindfully tracking experience as it bobs between these extremes, I find myself drawn towards a middle ground where the distinction between ‘me’ and ‘the suffering of the world’ is not so pronounced. This is a kind of no-mans-land and the lack of direction can be disconcerting, but since pity and overwhelm are dead ends I have no choice but to explore this territory. I sense my boundaries loosening as mental images and thoughts are pulled down-

wards into the body, making everything feel unstable, uncertain. It's nerve-wracking and the breath becomes jerky, but if I can stick with it long enough, a joyful fascination makes itself felt. Unpleasant sensations grow more pronounced, but habitual aversion towards them is held in check. I am now sensing these sensations as my best attempt to become conscious of the suffering of the world, while holding them in awareness is recognized as my best attempt at compassion. Although the sensations are unpleasant, the holding feels pleasant and thus a tentative equilibrium forms. Within this equilibrium, I see that the unpleasant sensation are caused by anger, which is being directed at the felt sense of myself as responsible for fixing this problem. With that, the expectation that I should be able to fix the problem fades. Instead of there being a bubble of 'me' holding all the responsibility to save the world, the resources now seem to be shared equally. I sense a growing confidence that an essential goodness will continue no matter what devastation may be forthcoming. The endeavor to expand my circle of goodwill has dissolved a layer of delusion, demonstrating the link between wisdom and compassion. With this more balanced perspective, it becomes easier to think about practical ways I could help – which charities I could support, which actions I could take as a personal or political level. The sixth maxim challenges us to expand our circle of concern towards all the inhabitants of the earth, including nature itself. The Buddha's teaching that 'the whole world can be found within this fathom-long body' provides a practical way to open the heart to meet this challenge.

Struggling with Anattā

Noirin Sheahan · 2 min read

Noirin Sheahan offers an unusually honest and intimate account of grappling with anattā (not-self), one of Buddhism's most profound and challenging teachings. Moving beyond intellectual understanding, she describes the jarring transition from romanticized notions of expanded consciousness to the stark reality that anattā literally means the absence of 'self' - a realization that initially brought horror rather than liberation.

The essay explores the deep psychological resistance that arises during meditation when approaching the direct experience of not-self. Sheahan vividly describes the internal struggle between the ego's desperate attempt to maintain control and the natural flow of experience that occurs when we truly let go. She maps the physical sensations of this resistance - the tension, the gasping for breath, the familiar comfort zones - alongside the profound ease and friendliness that emerge when fear finally dissolves.

This candid reflection reveals how anattā manifests not as a philosophical concept but as a lived reality that challenges our deepest assumptions about control and identity. The essay offers valuable insight for practitioners who may struggle with similar resistance, showing how the very qualities we most value in ourselves - peace, friendliness, ease - are discovered to exist beyond our control or understanding, pointing toward the liberating truth of not-self.

Struggling with Anatta.

The idea of anatta (often translated as „not-self“) used to fascinate me – inspiring a lovely image of an

expanded mind which covered the whole universe. Some texts mentioned fear – but I just knew I

wouldn’t be afraid ... until I caught a brief glimpse and realised, to my horror, that the expanded mind

didn’t include me – that “I” was left behind for that brief moment and that “I” would always be left

behind in the experience of anatta. It was so obvious – the words not-self said it plainly – but I skipped

over this till the moment of insight.

Now I don’t often think about anatta ... there are no nice images to entice me and thoughts fade into

vagueness. It's a relief if my mind simply relaxes, gives up on the question. I feel the breath going in and out, and am relieved to know that the whole system functions, that life happens, even though it's all beyond my understanding.

But in deep meditation I still fight hard against this truth. I may be experiencing the rising and falling of the breath, with thoughts and emotions coming and going, and forget myself within the flow of experience. But if there comes a sense of something strange and new, then a strong sense of "me" emerges, straining to master the situation. On the out-breath, I feel myself daring to relax, wondering "what is it that I am experiencing?" I can feel various sensations – softness or heat in various tissues perhaps – these are comforting, suggesting there is nothing to be afraid of. But there is usually tension as well in other tissues, and a scary gap opens up between „me“ (where it's all soft and warm and safe and known) and „that“ (whatever lurks in the vague, unexplored, seemingly uninhabitable tension).

It feels as if I must die to cross that gap into the unknown. Having been at this juncture so often, I can encourage myself the only thing to die will be fear. But I have to let go of these thoughts and memories in order to relax completely into the felt sense of my present experience.

Fear wins and I snatch at the next in-breath, tensing and gasping in an effort to hold on to all I know, to prevent myself dissolving into the unknown. This effort in turn becomes unbearable and the wish to relax and trust persuades me to breathe out again. The struggle continues until somehow fear dissolves and my senses can explore what was previously beyond my comfort zone. To my surprise I find I recognise a newfound depth of friendliness and ease within myself – as if it were a place I once inhabited within my psyche but had long forgotten. Although I would love to hold onto this experience forever, I find I must forgo all temptation to interfere. Friendliness cannot be

imprisoned and any
attempt to control obliterates ease.

The truth of anatta sinks in a little deeper as I learn that I am not in control of what I
most value within

myself. At my best, I am beyond my own understanding and control. As Mary Oliver
says in the last

lines of her poem "Sleeping in the Forest":

All night I rose and fell, as if in water,
grappling with a luminous doom. By morning
I had vanished at least a dozen times
into something better.

Noirin Sheahan

Stumbling towards Gratitude

Noirin Sheahan · 5 min read

In this deeply personal essay, Noirin Sheahan explores the complex relationship between gratitude and suffering following her laryngectomy surgery. Drawing from her experience at a meditation group meeting where communication difficulties triggered intense frustration and anger, she demonstrates how satipaṭṭhāna (Right Awareness) practice can transform negative mental states. The essay beautifully illustrates the Buddha's teaching on dukkha (unsatisfactoriness) in everyday situations, showing how physical limitations can become devaduttas (divine messengers) that deepen spiritual understanding. Sheahan's honest account of moving from self-pity and separation to acceptance and compassion offers profound insights into the practical application of mindfulness during difficult circumstances. Her reflection on the 'merciful separation of consciousness' reveals how understanding the limitations of human connection can paradoxically lead to greater peace and gratitude. This essay demonstrates how consistent meditation practice creates a reliable refuge where even ingratitude can be acknowledged, understood, and ultimately transformed into wisdom.

Stumbling towards Gratitude.

Since my laryngectomy, I've joined a web-based support group called Webwhispers. Most of the members are American so in November they are particularly focussed on Thanksgiving. It made me think about why it is that I'm not feeling grateful more of the time. I have so much to be grateful for: the Dhamma, great friends, a lovely home, a pension, my mum and other family, a body that work pretty well. And so much more.

Yet it's so easy to get upset at small things. At our last meditation group meeting for example, we were meeting in a nursing home where Jimmy is recovering from surgery. Normally we meet at Jimmy's house on Wednesday evenings, do an hour's meditation together, discuss some text and chat over cup of tea. I've been going to the same group (though venue has shifted all over Dublin as new people joined and others move away) for almost thirty years now. That's another thing to be grateful for. And the friends I've met through that group – my best friends now. They have put themselves out time and time again to help me especially since my operation last year. Shouldn't I always feel grateful to them?

And yet ... those little things ... the trouble started when I dropped into a supermarket on my way to the nursing home to get a mug of tea and then got

distracted by so much enticing stuff on the shelves and stuck in a long queue at the check-out and the assistant not being able to find 'mug of tea' on the check list and having to call the supervisor ... and realising I would be late and trying to hurry with my backpack full of groceries and a mug of tea in my hand and electro-larynx jiggling around my neck and headset microphone slipping off and the loudspeaker (tied around my waist) bumping my tummy as I stumbled along getting hot and sweaty, and arriving breathless and seeing that they had all signed in ahead of me (damn why couldn't one of them be late!) and finding them all chatting by Jimmy's bed. How is it such pleasant sounds come out of their mouths without any effort whatsoever? My mind is feeling small and peevish. They say hello – I put my face into a smile and nod vigorously at everyone, but can't reply with my hands full (you need a free hand to use an electro-larynx) and nowhere obvious to put my blessed (blasted?) tea, and then struggle to get my coat and

backpack off – also my jacket and cardigan as it's hot in there. All the time they're chatting and laughing– so annoying - my ill-temper finds fault with everyone and everything.

Then they decide to go to the chapel for meditation as Jimmy is now sharing his room with another man. Others gather up my jacket, cardigan, backpack, coat, tea as we head out. Why is it so hard to feel grateful for these small kindnesses? Instead I'm feeling irritated, dislocated, a nuisance, a burden to myself and everyone, bad humoured. I haven't yet said a word and when Margaret asks a simple question about my car I misunderstand her and answer 'no' for 'yes' and then seeing my mistake, try to explain while my electro-larynx refuses to find a sweet spot (an area on the neck where the sound transfers into the throat). I get more annoyed that she doesn't understand me as I bellow (feels like a bellow, sounds like a whisper) through the din of the electrolarynx "I'm still waiting to hear from Toyota". She looks puzzled "you're wanting to head for Tullow town?" she asks. I feel the voluntary component to the grimace that purses my lips and lifts my eyes to heaven, but don't have the necessary humility to arrest these, so annoyance and exasperation settle in deeper. At last we arrive at the chapel and sit down, Emer with my jacket and Margaret with my bag, Patricia beside me trying not to knock over my tea, Jimmy at a safe distance from my anger and ... blessed silence.

I'm steaming with annoyance and irritation, up tight, miserable. I feel separate from the others – no, I want to be separate from them. My mind huffs: "They don't understand what it's like not to be able to speak easily ... they don't care". Alongside anger and self pity the habit of mindfulness brings some perspective and I begin to feel that sense of separation more objectively, my flesh searing

with indignation, shrinking away from the world and clinging to my bones, my breath rapid, my head high and haughty. After a while of acknowledging my internal miseries, and against all my expectations some buried goodwill pushes my attention outwards and it seems that a new source of energy is coming from a point outside me somewhere in the midst of our little group. My flesh still shrinks away, trying to resist, but a flow of goodwill streams into my stomach and heart and gathers at a point in my neck where my voice box used to be. After another

while my mind can allow the notion of the others as friends. I'm still pulling back, tense and mistrusting, but aware also of a compassion that surrounds my nonsensical reaction, like a mother cradling a squalling child. My mind forms itself around the source of indignation: 'they don't know what it's like not to be able to speak'. As the meditation goes on I feel more and more the truth of this. They don't know. They can't know. Very slowly I begin to feel both the sadness and the beauty in that. We are separate beings. They would probably like to be able to share the burden, but what can they do? Stop talking in my presence? I start to make some peace with the practical limitations to human love and care. They don't know and it's OK that they don't know. They have their own troubles to bear, their own devaduttas. And because of this merciful separation of consciousness into separate beings, I am shielded from their troubles. So they chat with lovely melodious tones, they chuckle or laugh out loud. It's OK. For the moment anyhow. In this chapel with its blessed silence.

This is something to be truly grateful for – this mindfulness practice that allows negativity be acknowledged and transformed. Even if I don't feel grateful much of the time, I can trust mindfulness to lead me to a deeper place where that very ingratitude is allowed to be expressed, acknowledged, understood, and when the time is right, released.

With my friends and other sangha to support me in this wonderful practice (nowadays I think of it as the Buddha-dhamma), I can trust the devadutta of laryngectomy to keep leading me to deeper understanding and peace.

Summer Meadows

Noirin Sheahan · 2 min read

In this heartfelt personal essay, Noirin Sheahan shares her journey of discovering the wildflowers blooming at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat, sparked by reading Joanna Macey's 'Active Hope' on facing climate crisis through gratitude. What begins as an overwhelming encounter with nature's abundance becomes a profound dhamma teaching as she observes the arising of aversion, then greed, and finally doubt in her relationship with the natural world. Through mindful observation of flowers like Herb Robert, Red Campion, and Stitchwort, she learns to work skillfully with these mental formations rather than being overwhelmed by them. The essay beautifully illustrates how every aspect of life—from butterfly walks to political activism—can become part of our spiritual path. Sheahan demonstrates how mindful encounters with the vulnerable, fleeting, and unreliable aspects of nature mirror the Buddha's teachings on impermanence and offer opportunities for developing compassion and wisdom in our daily lives.

Wildflower Wisdom

Oblivious to the pandemic and all its consequences, the wildflowers have been blooming here at Satipanya and giving me a few dhamma lessons in the process. My interest was sparked by reading Joanna Macey's 'Active Hope' last year, a guide to facing the climate crisis. One danger, she says, is that we get so overwhelmed by anxiety that we do nothing. To combat this, we need to start with gratitude: to develop and express appreciation for the natural world that supports us and is now so deeply threatened. Whatever actions we may take to combat the threat will then stem from good-will and be more effective and sustainable as a result.

So when Eddie, one of our dhamma group in Dublin, suggested a butterfly walk, I was enthusiastic. Luckily it was a beautiful sunny day and butterflies fluttered in abundance. It was a bit of a downer therefore to find aversion showing up. It all seemed so overwhelming – so many different butterflies, so many different wildflowers, so much beauty and profusion. My brain ached!

I kept reminding myself of the motivation – to develop and express appreciation for the natural world – as I adjusted myself to the news that this was going to be a long journey, that the heart was only going to open chink by chink to the biosphere. 64 years of ignoring the 'weeds' under my feet weren't going to be pushed aside that easily!

By the time those 'weeds' started blooming this year, aversion had given way to a

tentative curiosity. Little pink flowers (from a photo Eddie identified these as Herb Robert) became differentiable from a companion pink (Red Campion). When I went out for my walk, these became friends greeting me on the roadside. With their encouragement little white flowers (Stitchwort) began to form a niche in consciousness, soon followed by the taller white ones (Yarrow) and yellow ones As you can probably guess, greed was now triumphing over aversion, my heart aching with desire to know and name all the flowers peering at me whenever I glanced at the hedgerow. Doubt crept in – what was the point in making my daily walks stressful? Would I not be better off to cultivate tranquility, just feeling my feet on the ground as I walked?

Remembering the motivation – appreciation for nature as a way of countering the paralyzing anxiety associated with climate crisis – I could see that the stress was worth bearing. On this side of enlightenment what relationship is free from greed? I could work with it mindfully and balance it out by spending more time admiring each flower, letting them draw me deeper into this new relationship, wishing them well as they coped with weather changes now and to come.

Maybe thanks to Joanna Macey's strategy, I now find myself on the biodiversity policy group of the Green Party. Although my expertise on Herb Robert might not save the planet, I will surely be able to compile an email list or in some way contribute to this work. No doubt greed and aversion will make their appearance here too. But that's OK, they have their place in life. Greed counters laziness, my tendency to ignore what I don't yet understand or value; aversion tells me when I've had enough, need to relax, let someone else compile that email list.

Nature, politics, committees can all be part of our path to freedom. The truth seeps in as we follow the breath in meditation, contribute to a meeting, discern one pink flower from another. Each mindful encounter with the world is to care for what is vulnerable, fleeting, unreliable – the perfect Dhamma teaching.

Teaching through an Electro-larynx: The Oval Age-Old Bath

Noirin Sheahan · 4 min read

This inspiring and candid essay explores how Noirin Sheahan (Ayya Puññyanandi) adapted her Dhamma teaching after laryngectomy surgery required her to use an electro-larynx device. With characteristic humor, she explains the technical challenges of speech - how 'The Four Noble Truths' might sound like 'Deplore Mouldy Dudes' and the 'Noble Eightfold Path' like an 'Oval Age-old Bath.' The essay details the innovative solutions developed for retreat teaching: pre-recorded talks, assistive technology for hard-of-hearing adapted for group communication, and collaborative reading formats that enhance discussion. Through retreatant feedback and practical examples, Noirin demonstrates how physical limitations need not impede the transmission of Buddhist wisdom. Her account reveals how the Dhamma community's willingness to adapt and support each other allows the teachings to flow through any obstacle, transforming what might seem like tragedy into an opportunity for deeper connection and understanding.

Teaching through an Electro-larynx: Deplore Mouldy Dudes? The Oval Age-Old Bath?

Why might a Dhamma teacher be asking you to deplore mouldy dudes? Like the Buddha's teachings,

the answer is 'in this fathom long body'. So put a finger on you Adam's apple. Now say "T". And then

"D". Feel the difference? Say "Sssss". And now "Zzzzz". Getting the picture? Your vocal chords

vibrate for some consonants and not for others. That's how our ears tell one from the other. And

while an electro-larynx is a wonderful invention, it doesn't have the magical capability of our vocal

chords to shut itself off for a fraction of a second while we say "T", or "P" or other consonants.

Physiology lesson No 2: Try saying "Shhhhh" while you hold your breath. Do the same for "S" or "F".

Not much luck? These need a little stream air flowing through narrow gaps between your teeth, lips

or tongue as these shape themselves into funnels to convey these various hissing sounds. You can

make a muted impression of them by first opening your mouth and then closing it rapidly to puff some air through the gaps. This is the best you can do after laryngectomy, when you breathe through a little opening (stoma) in the front of the neck rather than the nose and mouth. Basically, an electro-larynx preserves the vowel sounds reasonably well, but the consonants provide a guessing game for your ears. And so, when I intend to say The Four Noble Truths, your ears might hear Deplore Mouldy Dudes! And when I encourage you to follow the Noble Eight-fold Path, you might think I'm asking you to wallow in an Oval Age-old Bath! On top of that the electro-larynx sounds mechanical and robotic. How could I possibly teach with a voice like Daffy Duck? I thought that phase of life was surely over. But Bhante wasn't having any of that nonsense! He gave me a year to recover, but then ... Onwards! He scheduled me in for three week-long retreats during 2015. As usual, he was right. People rise to the challenge – it's heartening to see how true this is. It can even be fun to watch the Dhamma seep through a few Mouldy Dudes and other obstacles! In my youth, the only robot models were the evil Daleks in Dr Who. But one younger retreatant said she would listen even more intently to meditation instructions from Seven of Nine! But, if you're not a Star Wars fan, don't worry! If you come on retreat with me (and I hope you will) you won't be struggling to translate an electro-larynx drone for the evening Dhamma talk. Earlier this year I wrote out my talks in advance and my friend Finola read and recorded these. We'll update these as needed. So far, the retreat facilitators have been willing to do much of the remaining talking for me – short readings now and again to punctuate the day and inspire us to greater things. My communication is good enough for interviews and for occasional reminders. Bhante

has recorded all
the chanting as well as the evening metta guidance, so we use these for the morning
and evening
pujas. Basically it will be the same as normal – just an unruly mind and aching body to
contend with!
During the summer I came across some technology designed for the hard-of-hearing
and used this
during the October retreat. It's just a microphone, portable amplifier and earphones.
Normally the
hard-of-hearing person uses the earphones. I reverse this and ask others to wear the
earphones
while I speak into the microphone. This means I can turn the volume of the electro-
larynx way
down, as even a whisper can be heard quite clearly using the earphones. This cuts out
the loud
background noise and means I can talk quietly to someone in the interview room
without disturbing
others in the walking hall. We also used it in the meditation room for group interviews
and
whenever the spirit moved me to say something. A bit strange having all this techy stuff
in a

Dhamma hall – but as one retreatant commented it can also be quite touching when
we're all wired
up together!
For the local-group meetings on Thursday evenings I decided again to write out the
Dhamma talks in
advance and each person read a part aloud. This is something we have done in our own
meditation
group in Dublin for many years. We agree on a book, and then read a few pages
together – each
person reading out a paragraph or two. Reading aloud like this often gets over
whatever self-
consciousness we tend to feel in talking about the Dhamma, and the discussion
afterwards is the
richer for this. Similarly in the Satipanya local group, the shared reading made for a
more open and
enjoyable discussion afterwards. And luckily I enjoy writing but have to steel myself
before giving a

Dhamma talk, so this format makes life easier for me. Giving a Dhamma talk can be exhilarating and deeply moving, but it can also be a bit daunting unless and until you relax into the experience. I'm spared all those collywobbles nowadays!

I asked the people who came on retreat this year to give some feedback on what it's like to be led by a laryngectomee, and the responses have now been posted on the website (in the section with my profile). It was very heartening and quite humbling to hear how positive people were in their evaluation. Although the sound of the electro-larynx sometimes grated, what came through loud and clear was people's willingness to work together to let the Dhamma unfold and express itself in this post-laryngectomy phase of my life. To quote from one retreatant: when something tragic happens, we can all rally and something quite wonderful fills the loss. Teaching the Dhamma is truly a great privilege and a joy. I am deeply grateful to Bhante for his leadership, encouragement and persistence in prising me out of my comfort zone and onto the podium with or without a voice-box! I am also very grateful to all who have come on retreat with me either pre- or post-laryngectomy. May your implied respect continue to gladden my heart and encourage me along this path to freedom, happiness and peace. And may all the Mouldy Dudes and the Oval-Age-Old-Bath eloquently map the way!

Noirin / Ayya Puññyanandi

Temporary Ordination

Noirin Sheahan · 3 min read

In this deeply personal essay, Noirin Sheahan shares her experience of taking temporary ordination as a Buddhist nun with Ayya Ariyañani at Passadhi retreat. What begins as a dutiful commitment to deepen her connection with the Dhamma becomes a profound journey of self-discovery and acceptance.

The essay candidly explores the unexpected challenges of temporary ordination - not the shaved head or robes, but the difficulty of accepting her new Dhamma name 'Puñña-nadi' (Rejoicing in Merit). Sheahan's initial resistance to the name becomes a mirror for her habitual patterns of rejecting unwelcome aspects of life, including the reality of aging, sickness, and death. Through mindful observation, she transforms this aversion into a tool for greater self-acceptance and courage in facing difficult truths.

The retreat experience, combining silent meditation with discussions about monastic life in Burma and elsewhere, provides space for the deep implications of ordination to unfold. Sheahan reflects on how temporary ordination offers a powerful opportunity for symbolic rebirth - a chance to make more skilful choices supported by wisdom and community. The essay concludes with her contemplation of whether this temporary experience might lead to a more permanent commitment to monastic life, leaving readers with the question of how deeply we are willing to transform ourselves in service of the Dhamma.

Temporary Ordination

When the opportunity came to take temporary ordination with Ayya Ariyañani at the retreat in

Passadhi earlier this year I took it almost unquestioningly. Not that I was overjoyed, or even terribly

enthusiastic. To some extent it was the urge to do my duty, to pay respect to the people and to the

tradition that makes sense of life for me. Underneath this weight of obligation trickled the trust that

something good always comes of taking every opportunity to deepen my commitment to the

Dhamma.

My mind didn't dwell long on the challenge before me, but some instinct drew me to a wig shop so

that I could conceal my bald head after the retreat! Once I had the wig in place I found the courage to tell my mum of my plans. To my surprise she took it fairly easily – I had been anticipating massive grief because my mum and her generation were, like me, brought up as Roman Catholics. Although this issue is still unresolved for me, it was very encouraging that my first disclosure was gently received.

All in all, then, I approached the retreat with a fairly light heart. Having my head shaved didn't disturb me much - apart from the bitter cold of the first night bald as a baby! I found the peachy-pink robes quite attractive and easy to wear. To my utter surprise it was my new name which upset me.

When I heard Ayya Ariyañani say the name 'Puññanadi' the sound sank into my psyche and echoed

back 'Poo' and 'Puny' and 'Punitive'! I vaguely heard the translation as 'Rejoicing in Merit' but my

heart was too busy with misery and anger to be consoled.

The following meditation was a turmoil of rejection – how could I own such a horrid name? What on

earth had I taken on here? Who would want to know someone called Puññanadi? But mindfulness did

its quiet work and even before the meditation had finished my thoughts were converging towards

acceptance of this stranger, Puññanadi, who had just come to live within me, and a determination to

do my best to befriend her.

The battle re-ignited time and again over the next few days, until it came to me that, if I could have

the courage to tell people that my name was Puññanadi, then I could also tell them all kinds of other

unwelcome news – including news of old age, sickness and impending death. I reflected that

concealing bad news was an automatic habit of mine and often very unhelpful. This aversion towards

my new name would give me exactly the opportunities I needed to undermine this habit. The name,

Puññanadi, now seemed like a net I could cast around me to catch all unwanted thoughts rejected out into the world around me. Once caught I could draw them into my heart and learn to live with them. I felt stronger and happier now that I had this new tool to help me live my life, and so myself and Puññanadi began to make our peace.

The retreat allowed for silent meditation and also for discussions and DVDs illustrating the life of nuns in Burma and elsewhere. This mixture allowed us to take in the meaning and implications of ordination and let it sink deep. On reflection, the retreat provided a powerful opportunity to make a symbolic new start in life – this time with the wisdom and support to make more skilful choices.

My thanks to Ayya Ariyañani, to Ayya Aggañani (Marjo Oosterhoff) for organising the retreat and all

my ‘sisters’ in temporary ordination.

Now the question is, could I do take on the robes again – this time without a time-limit?

Can Puññanadi take long-term residence in this body, this life?

The Characteristic of Impermanence

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 16 min read

In this profound dharma talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines anicca (impermanence), the first of the three fundamental characteristics of existence that the Buddha identified as sources of our delusion. Drawing from cosmic scales—galaxies and stars—down to the microscopic level of moment-to-moment sensations, he reveals how everything without exception exists in constant flux.

The talk addresses our tendency to focus on the arising of new phenomena while remaining blind to their passing away, creating what he calls the "illusion of continuity." Bhante emphasizes how contemplating death, aging, and sickness serves as a spiritual protection, undermining the ego's grip and revealing the groundless fear that drives much of our suffering. He explores how this contemplation, rather than leading to despair, opens us to the preciousness of each moment.

Referencing the Dhammapada's teaching that "all conditioned things are impermanent," Bhante shows how deep insight into transience can lead to stream-entry, the first stage of awakening. The talk concludes with William Blake's mystical poetry, illustrating how an awakened being relates to the world—kissing joy as it flies rather than binding it, thus living in "eternity's sunrise." This teaching offers both philosophical depth and practical guidance for developing vipassanā insight through observing the arising and passing of phenomena in meditation.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-enlightened one.

Over the past couple of days, we've concentrated on suffering. Not simply how physical and mental pain cause suffering, but how pleasure does so. Now, see how I phrased that? It's wrong, isn't it? Nothing causes us to suffer, but the relationship we have to what we experience. In other words, it's not pain that is the primary cause of our suffering, but our aversion to it, our fear of it. Pleasures and joy do not cause suffering, but our indulgence and dependence on them does.

We have to be very careful how we use language. In what we say, how we say, is contained our view of things. So just by picking ourselves up on a simple slip such as, "this headache is unbearable," "I can't stand these people," "these politicians make me sick" – just by catching the way we talk about things and people, we can correct our view. Eventually, the penny will drop. There will be a change of heart.

Now there's an expression which tells us how things happen at the psychological and spiritual level. It's not good enough to understand the Dharma. It's not even good enough to be convinced of the Dharma. We have to work so that the correct view, the Dharma, begins to bring a change of heart. That's why in the Eightfold Path, after the number one, Right View, there comes Right Attitude. Then only does Right Speech, Right Action and Right Livelihood follow. But we need to start somewhere, and that's to correct our view.

Now the Buddha tells us that we have three fundamental delusions about the way things really are. He puts it to us directly. No fudging. This is the way it is. He declares that not seeing the three characteristics of existence clearly causes our lives to be unsatisfactory, if not downright unbearable. The first two concern everything that has existence, and one pertains only to sentient beings, and that includes us, human beings. These three characteristics are impermanence, unsatisfactoriness, and not-self or insubstantiality.

The unsatisfactoriness is this suffering we create. That's *dukkha*. Dukkha means in itself a hard place. That's life. As the comedian said, "Life's hard and then you die." Again, translating from other languages never quite makes it. And dukkha has such a breadth of meaning, books are written about it. In fact, if we take the Buddha's own pithy description of his teachings – "I teach only dukkha and the end of dukkha" – it really does become the biggest word in the Buddha Dhamma. In the past it was translated as suffering, but that's the wild end. Most now translate it as unsatisfactoriness. It's the lack of comfort, the lack of contentment, always wanting something, and as one writer puts it, just the lack. And this is what we've been pondering when we've talked of the hindrances and the problems of pleasure.

Now it's the turn to look at impermanence. Paradoxically, if there's one unchanging truth about the material and mental universes, it's that everything, without exception, is in a process of change.

I read an excellent book on the cosmos, on galaxies and super-galaxies. Astronomers estimate at least 100 billion galaxies – 100 billion! And some of these galaxies have millions, if not billions, of stars. The pictures of them are stunning. These colossi spinning in the emptiness of space. Huge vortices of unimaginable energy. Stars being formed,

others exploding. Black holes with inverted energy that sucks everything into them from light years away. It's so big, it's beyond fantasy. The mind – well, my mind – just can't grasp it. I get lost after a few stars. I look up at the night sky and I simply cannot mentally perceive what's going on. It's too vast, too overwhelming. And it's all, all of it, in a state of ferocious change.

Coming down to earth, getting my feet back on the ground, I find the same. The ever-changing seasons, the appearance of flowers in spring, their bloom in summer, their disappearance in autumn. The leaves bright yellow-green in spring, deep green in summer, mellow brown in autumn, and then just a load of litter. The tireless sun, rising and setting every day. The snow, the ice, the sleet, the slush, the rain. There's a pattern to it all, but it's hidden, as it were, within change. There are laws governing change, but there's always change.

And human society. Just look at human history. Look at human progress, or perhaps the better word is progression, throughout the comparatively short time we've been here. Constantly changing. A restlessness. War and peace. The growth and collapse of huge civilisations. Coming down to the present, the daily news with its constant flow of changes. Businesses starting, businesses flopping. Politicians doing this, undoing that. Unions, workers, voluntary bodies. The list is legion. People doing things, changing things. Sometimes unskillfully, sometimes skillfully. But nothing can be left alone. Someone's always around to change things. Everyone everywhere, it seems, has to be doing something.

Finally, we close in on ourselves. And what do we find? Change. We change our dwellings, our friends, our jobs, sometimes our spouses and partners. Children come and go. And as we progress through life, we change inside. Things happen to us that change the way we see things. Just think how much we've changed since we were born, since we were just a bundle of gurgling, screaming flesh.

And our bodies. Every seven years – some books say five – every single atom in the body has been replaced. Next time you look in the mirror, remind yourself you didn't have that face seven years ago. And the different parts of the body are changing at different rates. We'd live a long time if our longevity was measured by our bones. Sometimes the liver grows old faster than the heart, and we die of some liver disease. Sometimes it's the heart, or the lungs, or the brain. A lot depends on how we've treated the body, but for the most part it seems to depend on our genetic makeup. In my own family, we all seem to die of strokes. I only know of one case of cancer. I have a friend whose family all die of cancer, and early too. But whatever way we go, go we must, because death is the corollary of birth, and without birth and death, there's no change.

Now the upside of change is this birthing, these beginnings, the newness, the creativity. When we look at nature we learn that over the ages she has created masses of variations in plant and animal life. It's said that 99% of all species have become extinct. Now this seems a very high figure, but it gives an idea of how creative nature is. But it couldn't create anything new if the old didn't die.

We as human beings love to concentrate on the new, on the present fashion, the new song, the new celebrity. It's exciting and wonderful. We're always on the lookout for the new dish, the new film, the new clothes. The whole of our society is geared to the creation of the new. The whole of industry is about producing something new, upgrading. Whether it be a new source of energy, a new gadget, a new drug, a new computer game, a new perfume. So long as we concentrate on the new, we feel happy, for in our understanding, new seems to always mean good.

Individually, we concentrate on what we're going to do tomorrow, at the weekend, next week, next year, where I want to be in ten years' time, how I shall spend my retirement. Our delusion demands we look ahead. We plan for the future. And for the most part, it's exciting. It's so exciting that we don't see that things are disappearing, that things die out. We don't notice that to create something new, we have to get rid of something old. We become blind to the downside of change.

Now self cannot live long in the present. The present moment is death to self unless it presumes a next moment. Suddenly something happens that pulls us up short. I woke up one morning and brushed my teeth. All my teeth were there. At breakfast I bit into an apple. There was a snap, a crack, a front tooth fell out. Just like that. Where there had been a tooth, there was now no tooth.

Life can sometimes be like that, can't it? You wake up one morning feeling a little off, and after examinations and tests, you're given six weeks to live. You step out on the road, and bang, you're dead. There was an elderly woman got on the same plane as I did from Colombo, Sri Lanka, to London. We were half an hour into the flight and she began to fret. She had asthma and other complications, it seems. She was probably planning to spend Easter with her family. She was dead in an hour.

A good acquaintance of mine got drunk one night and went down to the cellar to get more booze. He slipped. He's now in Mandeville Hospital, paralysed from the neck down.

When such things happen around us, it's a shock, a real shock. When it happens to us, it's a trauma. Why? Why should we be shocked? Why should we be traumatised by events that are happening all the time? Isn't it because we don't care to look at the downside of impermanence? We don't want to look at it. It's scary. Yet with the appearance of the new, the old has died.

The Buddha tells us that this is one of the great weaknesses of self, that level of consciousness which identifies with the body and the personality. It's very frightened by death, death in all its forms. The mini-death of my tooth, the mega-death of my body. If I am that, what happens to me when that disappears? The thought is too horrible to contemplate. It's got to mean annihilation. If I am the body, then I'm nothing when it's dead. If I am the personality, and that can only exist in a body, in a brain, within a given culture, then when the body dies, everything I've come to know as me, everything I am, evaporates, dissolves. There's nothing left. Death is an utter annihilation.

Now such thoughts can definitely make us gloomy. After all, there's something utterly final about death. There's no coming back. That's it. When they asked how much the old rich woman had left, the lawyer said, "Everything." When we really absorb the fact that we take nothing material with us, it can undermine our purpose for living. Why make an effort? Why bother about what sort of house I've got? What sort of car? What does it matter? The grim reaper takes all. Not a single penny of all the billions I have are of any use to me come that moment. Why live?

What about my relationships? How much of my happiness is dependent on being loved by someone? How much on being able to love someone? Yet what love lasts? Isn't there something rather sad, perhaps a little pathetic, about continuing to love someone who has died? Yet who doesn't?

Meditating on death and all its implications is a tough one. Yet to meditate on death is known as a protection. What's it protecting us from? It's protecting us from the illusion which self loves to deceive us with – the illusion of continuity. Death doesn't come to me. Yes, I know everyone dies, but that's everyone else. And anyway, if I do have to, it won't be yet. It's too distant in the future for it to be of any importance to me, for it to have any effect on my life now. How many of us go to bed and remind ourselves that we may die in our sleep that very night? A chilling thought, yet we could. My most enduring teacher, Bhante Revatadhamma, arrived back from a long flight and complained of something in his chest. The monks massaged him and he felt better. He died that night.

Contemplating death, my death, gets me in touch with that fear. And the amount of fear I feel on the thought of death or when death approaches me or when it's my turn to die is the measure of the delusion that I live by. This fear is the ground emotion of

self. Self grasps and gathers and aggrandizes to allay the feelings of anxiety. It builds up shoring walls against the possibility of death. Self fights and battles and wars to defend its territory, its possessions. For to lose an inch is to lose an inch of self. And to lose an inch of self is to suffer a mini-death. And when the odds are stacked against it, self runs, flees, flies in a madness, lost in a paroxysm of fear.

How can we guard ourselves against such suffering? We do it by constantly chipping away at the delusions self would have us believe. And the delusion which comes because we don't care to observe and acknowledge impermanence is the illusion of continuity. Because we concentrate on the new, and the new is arising out of the old, we believe that reality is one continual flow of events happening to a static me. The I, the consciousness that knows what's happening, feels itself to be constant and utterly separate from the flow of change and therefore not part of it.

The contemplation of the ever presence of death is the most potent corrective that undermines this fundamental delusion. It brings us back into reality. This is the way it is. Sure, fear arises, but it won't make us run. We see that fear is arising out of the inability to deal with reality. So in our meditation we look straight into the terrorizing eyes of fear. We investigate fear. We feel its sickliness. We sit calmly in the nausea. Slowly we come to feel at ease with that fearful inner environment. We find we can sit still in the midst of the whirlwind. We can find the eye where all is still and untouched by the surrounding tornado.

Slowly we lose our fear of fear, our fear of anxiety. Now I ask you, if we lose our fear of fear, our fear of anxiety, what can possibly frighten us? That's the place we've got to work towards – being able to sit still amidst the icy winds of fear. Then the rest will take care of itself. As always, when we leave the heart alone, we find that she cures herself. Like any turbulence, when we stop twirling it, when we stop energizing it, it loses momentum, exhausts itself, and finally comes to a stillness.

All we have to do is to find that aloof position of the observing within us, knowing the presenting fear and the fear of fear, and slowly all will quieten. In the end all fear vanishes and all possibility of fear is extinguished. The liberated one is fearless. In Buddhist iconography, this is symbolized in the abhaya posture, the posture of fearlessness, where the Buddha holds up his right hand, the palm facing us, offering us the protection of fearlessness. This posture we can internalize. We can visualize that hand between our awareness and emotions, and so protects the knowing from being swamped and hijacked. We can even visualize that hand before our heart and it acts as a protection against the emotional bombardment of other people.

So, contemplating death is part of our practice. That's why I include it in the evening meditation. The spiritual reason is that it undermines the hold that self has over us. When the self is broken asunder, that is our liberation. And it's not only death we should contemplate, but sickness and aging. These are mini-deaths. The one protects us from the intoxication of health. That's what the Buddha calls it – intoxication, a bewilderment, an obsession with our health. And contemplating aging lifts us out of the intoxication, the bewilderment, the desire constantly to be youthful. We always want to be young, somewhere between our twenties and early thirties. But time doesn't care for that.

Now the contemplation of death should be brought into everything. Just a momentary reminder of the impermanence of things. Relationships come to an end. Children leave the nest. The car breaks down. A ring, symbol of so many treasured memories, can be lost. A precious vase broken. Everything, everything comes to an end.

But paradoxically, this doesn't make us gloomy, honestly. This doesn't lead to depression and despair. Not if we also contemplate the fact that at all times the universe is creating itself, that we will continue to recreate ourselves until we achieve liberation. This is the Buddha's teaching. He repeated over and over again to his critics and sceptics, "I do not teach eternalism or annihilationism, but dependent co-arising."

So it is that death is never an end but a beginning, be it the end of a day, or year, or life. And this won't stop till the day of our death as *arahats*, fully enlightened beings. That's why, after our little contemplation on sickness, old age and death in the evening, we go on to contemplate the enlightenment, the liberation, the awakening, the Buddha within, within us. That's what we're trying to bring into realization. And this balance of birth and death, appearance and disappearance, brings us to appreciate the preciousness of the very moment in which we live, the preciousness of that which exists and upon which our lives depend.

Each present moment is to be received as a treasured present. So never mind a Ming vase, the old market crock is treated with gentle carefulness. If we can begin to treat things with this carefulness and gentility, how much more so living beings, human beings, my own being. For underlying all this change, all this birthing and dying, is something which neither is born nor dies. The Buddha is quite clear about this. There is an unborn, an undying, an uncompounded, an uncreated. And that's where we're trying to get to, to try and reach that deathless ground which exists right in the midst of all these fleeting phenomena and yet is untouched by it.

That's the Buddha, walking about North India in the heat and the dust, going on alms rounds, talking to all sorts of people – some poor, some rich, some clever, some stupid, some powerful, high caste and low caste – all day long, mingling, a part of the world, affecting the world for the good. Yet within all that, the nirvanic peace, untouched by the exigencies of life. When he comes to die, he's still teaching. Finally, lying on his right side, he lets go of his decrepit, sick old body. Just like that. Easy-weezy-peasy. No fuss. No fear. Just letting go. Just going on.

And that's exactly what we're learning to do in our meditation. We're learning to let everything go, allowing everything to arise and pass away. And that's exactly the purpose we observe impermanence in all its aspects. This impermanence, this transience as taught by the Buddha, isn't the change of one substance from one shape into another. It's not as though there's a piece of clay and we can mould it into a cup, screw it up and mould it into a saucer. That's what happens when we concentrate on the new and we see only the new arising out of the old. We suffer from this illusion of continuity.

Just take this body. We've already said that every cell is replaced over a period of seven years. But it's all so slow that we don't perceive the process of change. But we also don't see the change so long as we are pleased by it. It's when those first wrinkles appear on the face or the hairline recedes a mite. Then, suddenly, we see change. Change in its darker aspect. That things are actually passing away. Just imagine if you got up one morning and looked in the mirror and saw someone else's face. Shock, horror, trauma. But at base, that's how discontinuous life is.

The Buddha tells us there's radical change. What has come to be must collapse before what is to come can arise. That's the sort of level of insight we'd all like to get to in our meditation. One of our first insights is to see the transient nature of our body in the breath, of our emotions ballooning and deflating, of our thoughts flitting. And if we keep our investigation right there, acknowledging the arising and the falling, we begin to balance our view. Before we come to *vipassanā*, we are aware of the new, the arising. Now we balance that with acknowledging the falling, the passing.

There comes a time when we become more and more aware of the passing. We see quite distinctly that the world does really come to an end. It just breaks up, moment after moment. And if the insight into transience is to be developed rather than the other two characteristics of unsatisfactoriness and not-self or insubstantiality, then such a profound vision of the way things arise and pass away completely, moment after moment, will launch us into the first path and fruit of stream entry, the first level of spiritual liberation.

Indeed, insight can come by observing impermanence at any level, whether at the microcosm of instants or the macrocosm of the stars. And that's what we really want, because with insight there comes a change of heart. There's a change in the deepest seat of our consciousness, a veritable turnaround. And that's what brings about not just a change of behaviour, but the purification which brings in its trail a deep sense of joy and purpose to our lives.

The constant observation of transience will eventually get that penny to drop. Whether we observe it in the stars, the seasons, in the aging of the body, in the suddenness of death, or in the microcosmic world of moment-to-moment sensations, it will eventually begin to dawn on us, really dawn on us, that nothing, absolutely nothing, is worth holding on to. Not even for a moment. Not even for a nanosecond. Why? Because there's nothing there to hold on to. Like grasping water. Like grasping water.

So it is that the contemplation of *anicca*, impermanence, in all its aspects, leads to an easy renunciation of trying to find happiness in a world of pleasure and pain. Samsāra, the world of ever unquenchable searching, is this very relationship we have to the world out there and the world in here. Once we begin to let go of that unwholesome attachment, the world with all its pain and pleasure can't make us unhappy or happy. We've found that inner spiritual solitude and contentment that nothing can disturb.

Let's pause here for a moment. So all we have to do is observe, just watch, whether it's the rising and falling of the abdomen, or the rising and falling of the foot, or any movement whatsoever. For there's always a beginning and an end. A beginning and an end, and nothing repeats itself. What has arisen has gone, has arisen and gone for good. Let us have that faith in the higher faculty within us, *satipaṇṇā*. Let that intuitive intelligence do the work, get out of the way, just watch, just observe, and all will be revealed. It's as simple as that.

The Buddha says in the Dhammapada, "All conditioned things are impermanent. When we really see this, we become disenchanted with the world. Just this is the path that liberates us from all our suffering."

Let me leave you with a more salutary note that so expresses for me the way an awakened being lives. William Blake, our homegrown mystical poet: "He who binds to himself a joy does the winged life destroy. But he who kisses the joy as it flies lives in eternity's sunrise."

May your profound insights into the characteristic of impermanence, *anicca*, allow such a depth of detachment that in an instant all *dukkha*, all unsatisfactoriness, will evaporate completely. May you all be fully liberated from the delusion of continuity and attain that unchanging *nibbāna* sooner rather than later.

The Noble Silence

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 34 min

In this talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma explores why intensive retreat conditions are essential for deep vipassanā insight meditation. Drawing from the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10), he explains how 'noble silence' involves systematically shutting down the outer personality to access deeper levels of mind. The talk examines the Buddha's teaching on the five hindrances (nīvaraṇa): sensual desire, ill-will, sloth and torpor, restlessness and worry, and sceptical doubt. Using vivid analogies—including the story of catching a snake with six exits—Bhante demonstrates how these mental obstacles prevent clear seeing. He provides practical guidance for working with each hindrance through Right Awareness, explaining how fantasies and internal dialogues feed negative mental states. The teaching emphasizes the importance of sīla (moral conduct) in creating a safe container for inner work, and shows how external silence naturally calms the mind's agitation. Essential listening for understanding why retreat conditions support the purification and insight functions of vipassanā meditation.

Buddhism without insight meditation would be like a whole system of medical theory without the medicine. The practice of insight vipassanā has two functions. It begins to reveal to us a way of being in the world and in daily life and it begins to reveal a way of discovering the deepest recesses within our mind. Here we are concerned with finding out why this is and how it is done. We are going to see why intensive retreats are important to the ardent meditator.

Within the process of vipassanā insight meditation there are two functions. Firstly to purify the mind and secondly to make insight. Both are achieved by the slow establishment of silence. Silence here means stillness, quietness, a situation such as a very bright, clear, windless day in which to observe the countryside.

To make this easier for us to understand, I've drawn a diagram to suggest the human is made up of three major casings, and each casing is made up of layer upon layer. The first casing, the outer shell, is the personality, the outer person everyone else knows us by. It is the way we relate to the world, communicate with it. It's how we interact with people.

In order to delve deeper into our mind, this outer circle, this casing, has to be shut down, quietened. This is why, when we look at the guidelines for an intensive retreat, we see people are asked to keep silent outwardly. There is no longer to be communica-

tion or interaction with others. As far as we are concerned, other people are here, on the course, as silent companions, who are dumb, deaf and blind. There's no need anymore even to greet people, to say hello in the morning, or to ask how they are. There's no need even to signal to people to let them pass on the staircase. One decides for oneself, either moving or waiting for the other to pass. At mealtimes, we eat as if no one else were in the room. We just let go of the usual graces of passing the salt and pouring out another's drink. We are learning to be alone. For on the journey inward, there will be no one to accompany us.

People who come on a course for the first time find this very strange, even a strain. They feel it selfish and unnatural. Well, of course it is strange, but such behaviour is there for a purpose. When we see others are behaving in the same way, the strain will go. It would be selfish if it was not an agreed contract between all members of the course, but we have agreed to behave like this for the duration. It is unnatural, if by unnatural we mean unusual. But again, there are many unnatural things that have to be done in different circumstances for different purposes. How unnatural it is to push buttons eight hours a day or walk a tightrope. The purpose of this silence between meditators to the point of non-communication is because we need to shut down the outer person in order to gaze into the inner person. As we shall see, this takes great effort, and our energy will be dissipated if it has to go outward to people.

This is also the reason we slow down our movements to about half pace. Our lives are generally full of rush and bother. We create great disturbances and noise by the way we go walking heavily on our feet, tramping upstairs, the way we bang doors, the way we open and close curtains. At mealtime we make a great crash with the knives and forks and spoons. Some people slurp their drink or chomp their food totally oblivious to the noise they're making. In other situations this might be acceptable behaviour, but on such a course as this, any noise means that the meditator is not being aware of creating silence. Such noise will also draw another meditator's attention, thereby distracting her from the business of looking inward.

Especially around and in the meditation room, great effort must be made by meditators not to create even a milli-decibel of noise. That is why meditators are asked to move extremely slowly and deliberately. And this is most important in the meditation room itself, where any action, such as preparing to sit or changing posture, should be done with the quietness of a door mouse. Being aware of the noise we make will heighten our sense of awareness. Being aware of the silence we are creating will deepen our concentration. In this way, meditators find their meditation greatly enhanced.

The outer person is not simply an expression of the inner person. It also has its own effect on the inner person. If we outwardly get caught up in someone's excitement, we find ourselves getting excited within us. If we're with someone who's depressed, often we ourselves begin to get depressed. Moods and emotions are infectious. The meditator experiences the calming of the inner person when the outer person is stilled.

This stillness is most important on the level of morality. If we do harm to any being, this causes great disturbance in the mind. If we get angry and have an argument with someone, this causes a great fire of agitation that can take hours to die down. Such happenings on a course such as this would destroy the whole environment immediately, not just for the two litigants either. For this reason, all participants take on certain training rules which cut out this possibility. Here, within this space, all meditators should feel very safe, very secure, protected. How impossible it would be for us to look inward if we knew someone here was waiting for an opportunity to kill us.

No, we have all agreed to do no harm whatsoever, not even to a bug. We have also agreed not to steal another's possessions, to have no sexual activity whatsoever, not to talk at all so no one can get into an argument in the first place, and finally, to take no alcohol or drugs. In this way, we have a basis for a very harmonious and peaceful society. We can rest in this environment. What's more, to stop causing harm to ourselves, we've taken on a rule not to eat after twelve, so there's no chance of overeating. We've also determined not to oversleep, thereby tempting others to become lazy and waste the weekend. And we've determined not to disturb anyone by arousing the passions with perfumes and aftershaves, music, dancing and hula hoops. So you can see this *śīla*, morality, is vital in this sort of situation. It is of paramount importance if we're going to close down that outer personality and turn the energy inward to discover the inner person.

It's very difficult at first. It is hard to slow down and be deliberate about everything we do. Even turning the handle of the door must be done with careful, slow deliberation. But with effort, our mindfulness will increase. Then, once this has been achieved, the problems of tackling the inner person can be faced.

By this inner person I mean all the moods, emotions and feelings, all the fantasies and all the interior dialogues. To achieve this silence of mind we have to understand how we achieved such a busy mind in the first place. It was through wrong view and wrong intention that we built up a mind full of negative states. These negative states, for the most part, lie dormant and arise only when certain stimuli come along. For instance, my anger presupposes a certain disposition to react with anger when something happens. We've taught ourselves to get angry whenever someone disagrees with us.

We've found this a very useful ploy, since for the most part it wins the argument for us, or at least most opponents retire frustrated if not defeated. Until similar occasions arise, our anger will lie dormant.

However, as soon as we sit in meditation, just then when all stimuli have been shut down around us, just then when in a perfect circumstance of silence and support, all the anger starts coming up for no apparent reason.

To illustrate why this is, an interesting tale is told in the scriptures of a teacher of the Dharma, who actually never meditated. He noticed that over a period of time, all his students became highly attained spiritually, and some even had a hat. He finally decided to go and seek their help. However, when he approached them, they'd simply say they were too busy and pass him on to another. The reason was that he had the sort of mind which questioned and argued. They presumed he'd never take their advice. Eventually, one of the monks asked him to approach a young boy. A little humbled, he nevertheless did so and asked the child how to meditate.

The *sāmaṇera*, or young novice monk, asked him how he would catch a snake he knew to be in a mound that had six exits. The Dharma teacher said he would do this by blocking up five exits and would simply wait patiently for the snake to come out. The young *sāmaṇera* said exactly so. He pointed out to the teacher that if he wanted to observe the mind, he had to close the five senses.

In other words, when we meditate, we are stopping the mind using its usual means of expression. Normally, if we are angry, we'd shout and throw something. It would be expressed in some way. But now, in the outer silence of the senses, in the stillness of the sitting posture, the mind becomes filled with its own anger and nowhere to express it. Suddenly, the meditator is faced with raw anger.

Unfortunately, it's not quite as simple as it seems, for now this anger does find an outlet, and that's of course the mind itself, the sixth hole in the mound. The mind itself creates a dream in which anger can satisfy itself. There we are, sitting very still. To anyone coming into the meditation room, we seem so quiet, so silent. But internally, our minds are in a vast commotion. Fantasies of shouting and hitting, of slaughter and mayhem, vast battles in huge war arenas are conjured up in our minds, fuelled by all the unleashed anger that can no longer find expression through the body into the world.

Even though these fantasies are not willed by the meditator, even though she finds herself caught up in them unwittingly, she is not only entertaining the anger but feeding it. How do we know this? We know this because the fantasies, if left unchecked, grow more and more violent, more and more angry, so that states of mind are being developed.

Fantasies and all internal dialogues have to be vigorously noted as soon as one becomes aware of them, and the attention brought back immediately to the underlying feelings or sensations of anger in the body. And if these sensations are not obvious, then we must return to the process of breath.

Now of course it's not just anger that causes this type of mental agitation. The Buddha in fact taught there were five causes that hindered the meditator's progress. They are called *nīvaraṇa* and are normally translated as hindrances. The five hindrances to concentration are sense desire, ill will, sloth and torpor, restlessness and worry and sceptical doubt.

When these states of mind arise, we also recognise them in the meditation for what they are. In a volume of smaller sayings, this is how the Buddha tells meditators how to meditate on these states of mind: "Herein, O disciples, when some desire is present, the meditator knows there is some desire in me. And when desire is absent, he knows there is no sense desire in me. He knows how the latent sense desire comes to arise. He knows how to reject sense desire once it has arisen. And he knows how to prevent the arising of sense desire in the future."

For sense desire, read also ill will, sloth and torpor, restlessness and worry, and sceptical doubt. We shall take these five in turn and see how they cover all negative states of mind. It's a neat classification by which the meditator can quickly recognise what state of mind he is in and so quickly decide on a course of action. The instructions which follow are particularly to do with vipassanā insight meditation, though they can be useful in ordinary daily life.

It is a fact that our minds will always seek satisfaction now here and there. The mind always wants to be happy, excited, or at least contented. We have throughout our lives taught the mind to seek this happiness in pleasurable sensations that arise in the body. So whenever a stimulus from the outside world impinges upon the senses, be it pleasant music, a lovely scene, a cool ice cream, whatever it is, those resulting sensations is what the mind loves to indulge in, splash about in, wallow in.

When, in the situation of an intensive meditation course, all these stimuli are taken away, the mind becomes agitated and thrashes about, looking for those sensations it has come to expect. The body expresses that desire with empty feelings, craving feelings, wanting feelings, just like the pangs we feel when we get a little peckish and there are no biscuits about.

In the silence of a retreat there is no way to satisfy these demands, so the mind does a double take and tries to create them all within itself. Suddenly we are in cascades upon cascades of dreams, fantasies and dialogues. Vast epics are played out in the mind, all expressing our desire for satisfaction now here, now there.

Sexual pleasure and erotic delight are without doubt the most delicious of sensual experiences. You can see its search already dominating the lives of fourteen and fifteen year olds. Our society has encouraged its indulgence. A whole generation and the up and coming generation are left gasping like salivating dogs at the smell of meat. So we as a culture stand agape before tantalising flesh. Whenever you look at newspapers, billboards, virtually all films, the pleasures of sex are turned at us. The power of the image conditions our minds to seek these pleasures. And if it is reinforced with actual experience, sexual, erotic desire becomes for us a great craving and attachment. Should we then be so surprised that once all the avenues for its indulgence are shut, it becomes so insistent in the mind?

I talk of sex since that is a very usual hindrance of desire. But others include food and drink, power and status, fame and glory. Indeed, any pleasure you can name can develop this obsessive quality.

What can we do? In a meditation course, we are concerned to shut down the higher faculties of the mind. We are concerned to shut down imagination and thinking. When these are calmed, the intuitive mind is no longer clouded and can begin to see things as they really are. Therefore, our aim is to put an end to fantasy and imaginative thinking for the duration of the course.

The most important starting point is our determination not to get caught up in them. This has to be a most determined decision, a most resolute resolution. If there is one chink in that resolution, one little teeny-weeny bit of undetermined will, if there is but one small milli-ounce of will that still wants to indulge in sensual pleasure, we can be assured that before we know it, the whole mind will be indulging, and the resolution will have been destroyed. The meditator becomes discouraged. She says she can't control her mind. The meditator gives up and says meditation is not for him. Our wills must be steeled against sensual indulgence.

In this way, as soon as there is so much as a tickle, the attention will be immediately drawn to it. As soon as the meditator is aware of it and remains aware of it, noting it, it will begin to pass away. This is an important point to grasp. When a thought arises out of the subconscious, say a sudden picture of cheese, that image is immediately grasped by desire, our conditioned states of mind, the *saṅkhāra*. Energy is put into it, and the whole higher mind becomes engaged in developing that initial image. And so the powers of imaginative thinking will go into creating a huge banquet around the initial image of cheese.

The meditator, who has made that resolute resolution, who is ardent and energetic, will catch that fantasy at birth, that first image. In so doing, he preempts the conditioning to develop it. He gets between the desired image and the desiring attachment. This stops, this calms the higher mind, and the awareness can then gaze intelligently and energetically at the object. The higher mind can be engaged in naming it, in labelling it, but that distance of the objective observer must be kept inviolate.

The object, the image of cheese, has been produced by latent energy in the subconscious. It needs fuel. It needs the higher mind to develop it, or it will simply lose energy. To the meditator's delight, as she gazes, observes this image intently, it passes, it just fades away. Most times it just vanishes. She is left with feelings in the body which are then more easily observed just as the sensations caused by the breath process are observed.

Here then is how we tackle sensual desire in vipassanā insight meditation. We determine with an unshakable active resolution not to get caught up in sense pleasure. We determine with an unshakable resolute resolution to be awake, alert like a sentinel.

As soon as any pleasing image or feeling arises, the meditator zaps it with alert, keen, intelligent awareness and stays with it, regarding it as a scientist, with objectivity, until it passes away. Then, back to the breath process.

As with sensual desire, so also with other images, thoughts and feelings concerning the whole area of ill-will and aversion. Images of people and things we dislike, grudging dialogues where we never forgive the insult or the harm done, the great battles and wars fought to death inspired by revenge, scenes of cruelty and inflicted suffering on our enemies and rivals.

All these, like desire, give the mind great satisfaction, for the mind wants to indulge its ill will. There is relief to be had in letting off steam. There's pleasure to be had in revenge and cruelty. But with the same technique of alert, keen awareness, we catch these movements of aversion in the mind, snip them quickly in the bud, and know

them to be aversion and ill-will. Know them to be harmful and observe them intently and equanimously. We must become the objective observers of the mind's ill-will and aversion.

One of my meditation teachers, the Venerable Ujjanaka, used to call the third hindrance, sloth and torpor, the meditator's two very good friends. And that's just how they present themselves. They are very clever, full of subtle argument and pretense. But we must beware, for they are fifth columnists, traitors, and will sell us out to the enemy.

They tell us we're tired. We've worked hard enough. There's no more energy. It's too much, too much suffering. No one has suffered like me. It's time to rest now. Ah, sleep, sleep. You've earned it. Just a little rest, just five minutes, that's all. What's five minutes? And we'll wake up so refreshed. Go on, that's it. Just lie down. Rest just a moment. Ah, and we've gone. Five minutes, sixteen minutes, one hour, two hours, three hours, and we wake. And we know we've been duped. No, we've fooled ourselves.

As very small children, we're often taught to find the end of our problems in sleep. When their children are irritable or weepy, or making a lot of noise, parents will say they're tired, they need sleep. Now maybe they do, but often it's an excuse for putting the kids to bed and out of the way. Either way, the children learn to overcome difficulties by zonking out.

Of course, one does wake refreshed. Sometimes sleeping on a problem does help. The mind has subconscious ways of dealing with such things. But often, sleep is an indulgence, the Sunday lie-in. The whole day in bed with newspapers, plus trays of food and videos. But here, on our *vipassanā* insight meditation course, the indulgence in sleep is a destructor. For sleep saps our energy and leaves us groggy, our wills in tatters.

Our bodies work according to what is known as the circadian cycle. If this cycle is disturbed, we feel terrible. This is what happens in international flights and causes jet lag. Our sleep rhythms are disturbed. When we wake at the end of a sleep sequence and indulge in another hour or two, we unwittingly set up another cycle of sleep and we will feel groggy until it has been completed. The cycles vary in individuals from as little as five hours for adults to twelve or thirteen hours for young children. Here, of course, we have to beware not to start a cycle, or else this whole weekend meditation becomes an intensive sleeping meditation course.

Now all this has to be tempered by the fact that many of us live highly pressured lives, full of stress and worry. This takes its toll on our bodies and minds, and on a weekend course the whole Saturday can feel terrible, depending on what state of mind

we've come with. But we still have to make sure that if we are going to sleep during the rest periods, that it is a real tiredness and not laziness, not the listlessness of depression, not a conditioned reaction to suffering, to boredom.

The Buddha, again in the shorter sayings, gives advice to his great disciple Moggallāna, who became an adept in all the great powers. He suggests six ways of overcoming sleepiness before deciding to lie down. Firstly, he says, not to dwell on it, not to give it attention—that is, to keep the mind on the process of breath, raising energy into the observation. If this doesn't work, the meditator should think about how harmful sloth and torpor are and recall to mind the effects they know of and then go back to the breath. The next is to repeat whatever doctrine one knows off by heart till the sloth is dispelled.

If this doesn't work, the Buddha advises us to rub our ears and limbs with the palms of our hands. Then the Buddha advises that if this fails, we should splash water over our faces. If that fails, we should walk up and down. At the end of all this effort to stay awake, if tiredness still overcomes us, then we should lie down. But mindfully, and he goes on, "Having awakened, you should rise quickly, thinking, I won't indulge in the enjoyment of lying down and reclining, in the enjoyment of sleep."

So what the Buddha wants us to do is to be aware of not giving in to tiredness. We have to test it in the context of our particular insight meditation practice. We can firstly try to put energy into observing. If that fails, we can rise and stretch ourselves slowly and silently. If that fails, we can do walking meditation. But if tiredness still seems to overcome us, then we can lie down with a determination to wake mindfully.

In longer courses, meditators always experience a loss of demand for sleep. Often, the first day or two is nothing but sloth and torpor. But then, because of the power of awareness and its purifying effects, sleep time drops to six hours and sometimes to four. Even in a week-long course, some meditators do without a night's sleep.

The difference between sloth and torpor is that sloth is felt in the body and torpor is felt in the mind. Often meditators experience torpor like a heavy cloud on the mind. Again, it is a matter of observing it and returning to the process of breath. But if one feels overcome by it, then walking meditation is the best answer.

Restlessness and worry, agitation and anxiety are the fourth hindrance. When we sit for some time, even if we begin in a calm way, a feeling can arise to get up, to move. We get fidgety. We start thinking about the time. Is the half hour or hour up yet? Maybe I've missed the bell. This restlessness can be caused by any reason. It might be some worry,

real or imagined, that keeps coming up in the mind. It might be a lot of unresolved feelings which are all repressed and unknown to the meditator but cause such agitation in the mind and body.

In meditation the causes of such things are not important. We have to deal directly with the presenting problem. When restlessness comes we must raise our determination to sit still till it has passed or until the time allotted to the meditation is finished.

Here, unlike sloth and torpor, the energy is high, but it's fractured and bursting out all over the place. So our determination is placed into focusing the energy. When restlessness arises, we're much more concerned to sharpen the concentration and establish equanimity. To sharpen the concentration we can rest the attention on the breath, and whenever restlessness claims our attention we simply note it vigorously so as not to let it affect our thinking and our will to remain.

Remember, the work of a meditator is to see things objectively. When the restlessness is observed, it is done as by a stranger in an art gallery or museum. The restlessness manifests in the body, is seen and observed as something other. The awareness keeps its distance.

If there is ever a feeling that the restlessness is getting the better of us, if its suggestions to get up, to finish, cause us to make even the slightest movement of a finger or an eyelid, then we must take refuge in the breath process, bringing the concentration to bear until we have re-established our equanimity.

It is very important in this practice to overcome restlessness. If we give in, the next time is always that little bit harder to resist. If we are patient and wait until the restlessness begins to subside or even pass altogether, the next time will be that much easier.

Finally, there is sceptical doubt. Now this can be quite a disease with some people. The Buddha said the sceptic was the least able to make spiritual progress. The reason is that a person who doubts never moves. If I doubt whether I can dive off the top board at a swimming pool, I'll never do it. If I doubt my doctor's ability, I won't take the medicine.

As a hindrance to insight, there are three types of doubt. First, there is the doubt in the Buddha and what he taught, the Dhamma. Was he really enlightened? What does that mean anyway? How do I know he wasn't really as deluded as all of us? This Nibbāna is probably a hoax. It's just annihilation or something.

Then there's doubt in the meditation teacher. Well, how much does he know? How do I know he knows anything at all? He doesn't look saintly to me. She doesn't look enlightened at all. Maybe she's just on an ego trip.

Finally, there's doubting oneself. Yes, the Buddha was certainly enlightened. I've no doubt about that. The teacher's very good. She knows what she's doing. She's an excellent teacher. He's very fair. I understand him. It's me. I'm not up to it. I can't do it. I don't have the perfections, the necessary ability to achieve anything.

To undercut these sorts of doubts, that is why, of course, at the beginning of the weekend course we always take refuge in the Buddha, Dhamma, Sangha, the Triple Gem. It's important to build up trust, to build confidence in the Triple Gem. This just means that a meditator will give it a go, that there will be a complete dedication to the task in hand, a steadiness of commitment.

Over such a short period as a weekend course, all that is asked is a total self-giving just for that period of time. In this way, after the weekend, a person can judge whether in fact there is anything to be gained from this meditation. We can think about it after the experience. If we don't lend ourselves totally to the experience, we'll never know whether it really works or not. It wouldn't be fair to oneself to give something a half-hearted go and then say, well, I didn't get much out of that.

By committing oneself totally to this meditation practice for a period of time, after that period, a meditator can look back and ask whether in fact there was any benefit. If a person suffers from overweight and goes to a health farm, he doesn't go there with his own set of conditions. He'll follow the regime. Going to a health farm demands a certain surrendering to the system, allowing the system to work itself on the person. It's not horrific. The person has read about such farms, has had friends who have gone there and praised the place and so on. He knows generally what to expect, and it doesn't last forever. He goes on trial for a serious, dedicated, energetic trial.

It is in this way we can overcome sceptical doubt in our meditation practice and on such a course as this. We dismiss all doubt, push it gently to the side and dedicate ourselves to the practising of the technique. After we've gone through the ordeal, then we can look back and judge. If we have gained nothing, then at least we've cleared out one venue of exploration. Now we know vipassanā insight meditation is not for us.

We have to be so careful not to waste precious time getting caught up in all that internal argumentation. Voice 1 saying, "Let's go, this is silly." Voice 2 saying, "No, let's stay, it's interesting." Voice 3 saying, "This is all very dangerous." Voice 4, "What is all this Buddhist stuff anyway?" Voice 5, "We should have gone to see that film."

Doubt creates great splits in the mind, and all the emotions of fear, frustration, depression, and so on are conjured up, all adding fuel with voice upon voice. We get caught up in views and opinions. We lose the balance of our minds and become more and more confused by the arguments, raging on and on until we give up in despair. "I'll never know the truth. The truth can't be known." Or we end up in cold dismissiveness. "It's all rubbish."

This hindrance of sceptical doubt is easily undermined by raising confidence in the triple gem, the teacher and oneself. Remember, faith is not belief. The Buddha didn't ask us to believe him. He just said, "Come and try, see if it works."

When sceptical doubt arises in the mind, just smile. Brush it gently to the side. Say to yourself that you will deal with all these worries after the course. Remind yourself that all doubt is dispelled through experience. For what is the root cause of all our doubting if it is not ignorance? We don't actually know. We're afraid of our unknowing. When we know, there is no doubt.

I can spend a whole lifetime worrying and doubting whether I can dive off the top board or not. But when I experience it, when I do it, what happens to the doubt? Doubt is a great conjurer. We must determine not to get caught up in its tricks. We must determine to put our effort into the practice.

So there we have the five hindrances, the *nīvaraṇa*, which create so much bother and commotion within the inner person. The Buddha likened this mind to a pot of water. When the water is mixed with different colours, it is like a mind possessed with sensual desire. A person looking into it cannot properly recognise their own face. When the pot is boiling and bubbling, it's like a mind filled with anger. When the water is covered with moss and water plants, it's like a mind overcome with sloth and torpor. When the water is stirred and agitated by the wind, it is like a mind overcome with restlessness and worry. When the water has become turbid and muddy, it is like a mind overcome with doubt.

In all cases, when a person looks into such a pot, he will not recognise or see the image of his own face. When we are overcome by these hindrances, we cannot see things as they really are. We are deluded by them. Although these hindrances do not entirely disappear till full enlightenment, when we learn to deal with them on a meditation course, we are achieving the first steps in overcoming them.

The Pleasure Syndrome: Understanding Dukkha Through Paṭicca Samuppāda

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 21 min read

In this profound evening talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the psychological mechanism by which pleasure becomes a source of dukkha (suffering/unsatisfactoriness). Drawing from the Buddha's teaching of Paṭicca Samuppāda (Dependent Origination), he traces the chain from initial contact (phassa) through feeling (vedanā) and craving (taṇhā) to grasping (upādāna) and becoming (bhava).

Using the relatable example of eating toast, Bhante demonstrates how we construct elaborate mental worlds around simple sensory experiences, leading to identification, addiction, and ultimately suffering. He explains how the "pleasure syndrome" operates not just with basic sensual pleasures but extends to all worldly pursuits—fame, power, wealth—and even refined aesthetic and spiritual experiences.

The talk addresses the crucial distinction between experiencing pleasure and indulging in it, showing how Right Awareness (sammā sati) allows us to enjoy life's pleasures without falling into the vicious cycles of craving, frustration, and fear. This teaching offers practical guidance for retreat practitioners learning to observe their reactions to pleasant experiences without being enslaved by them.

Suitable for those with some meditation experience who wish to deepen their understanding of how mental formations create suffering and how vipassanā practice can reveal the path to true contentment beyond sensual happiness.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhasah. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhasah. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhasah. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

So now we've managed to get through the fourth day. The first three days were bad. Blood, sweat and tears. If you think about it, how else could it have been? In one wild axe we cut through old habits and established new ones. That's always got to be painful in itself. Never mind the difficulty of the posture and so on. It's a bit like finding yourself in the army, or worse, a prison, subjected to a new regime. Here, of course, willingly so.

We all of us have particular, perhaps peculiar habits. We get up at a certain time, sleep for a certain amount, have breakfast at this time, not that, and so on. And what we find is that if our habits are disturbed in any way, there's always the pain of dislocation. If there's a good reason, we don't mind. We take it with good heart. But if there's no reason, or rather we don't see a good reason, we get irritable and bolshie.

When we come into spiritual training, we always find there's a routine to get used to. And for the most part, it's always training with other people. It's difficult also because we're stuck in our ways. To change our habits is to loosen us up a bit. So these past three days have been a sort of spiritual boot camp. From now on, I hope, you begin to feel a relaxation, an ease with the rhythm of the course, and a lessening of gross physical pain caused by the posture. But more, I hope that you've accommodated psychologically, and no longer find yourself struggling with, or at worst against, the schedule.

So now, the other great problem arises. Up till now, we've had to deal with pain in all its variegated form. From now on, I think you'll find there will arise moments of ease, even pleasure and delight. I'm not saying to expect it, but it may just come up, and here we can fall into the grave error of negligence and indulgence. Remember, the purpose of *vipassanā* on a psychological level is to take the suffering out of pain and the indulgence out of pleasure and see if there is a relationship with the world beyond all that which is actually more satisfying indeed, rewarding.

We need then to understand the pleasure syndrome and to be convinced intellectually that happiness, true contentment is not to be found there indeed, cannot be found there. *Nibbāna* has to be something other than sensual, mental or emotional worlds that can be so enjoyable.

This brings us to the psychological paradigm that the Buddha discovered known as Dependent Origination or perhaps better Interdependent Origination, the *Paṭicca Samuppāda*. Some of you will have seen the representation of this in the Tibetan picture called The Wheel of Dependent Origination. Here, I shall only be concerned with the part that relates specifically to the problem of indulgence and suffering, and I shall indicate the Pali terms for those who are familiar with this teaching.

The Buddha begins by pointing out that at root the problem is one of ignorance. It is from this position of not knowing that we presume to know, and our presumptions become our delusions. And it is according to our deluded understanding that we live out our lives, causing distressful, occasionally anguished cycles of behaviour.

The first thing about pleasure is that it brings delight. An obvious statement, no doubt, but herein lies the whole problem. Now take toast. I've yet to meet someone who doesn't like toast. Some like it hot, some cold, some soggy. Some with marmalade, others with honey. Most with anything. But up until now, I'm of the opinion that all human beings love toast.

When delicious toast falls upon the tongue, all that happens is certain chemical and electrical signals are passed on into the brain, and the first percepts are simple and basic. At this level, known as contact, *phassa*, the mind perceives only hot and cold, sweet and sour, and so on. It's not until there's been a moment of digestion in the mind itself that definitions such as toast arise, and with them all the memories of scrumptious times and warm kitchens going back all the way to childhood, the great British breakfast. All these connections go to build up, around that initial taste, a glorious euphoria. This is the level of feeling, *vedanā*, and it includes other mental attributes, such as perception and memory.

Once this glorious state has arisen, there comes the desire to get into it. Now that's the greed, that's the *taṇhā*. But what is this *taṇhā*, this greed, this craving? It is just that wanting to indulge. The judgmental mind arises, this is good, this is wonderful. How amazing that a simple piece of toast can create such a glorious interior environment. I'm so happy. This is the life.

Now I hope that during meal times you're getting into contact very clearly with this mental state. Hold for a while a tantalizing morsel just in front of your mouth and really experience that craving, that wanting to snap at it and gobble it all up.

As soon as *taṇhā* has arisen, as soon as the craving for a pleasure has arisen, the next moment is one of identification. I am this desire. I am this delight. There's no objectivity. There's no separation between the enjoying and the enjoyer. They become unified. I, me, want toast. Now this is called *upādāna*, grasping.

What follows is the action, *bhava*, a gluttonous dance, the actual indulgence, and that's the moment when this whole process has been empowered by will, *cetanā*, and in so doing *kamma* is created and the habit is reinforced. The habit not just of indulging in toast, if that isn't bad enough, but of the whole deluded understanding that happiness, true contentment is to be found in sensual pleasure.

So let's review these kernel links on the wheel of dependent origination where the Buddha points out we continue to reinforce our delusions and so cause ourselves continuous suffering. First there is the initial contact with the object. Here, although we're just talking about the sense of taste, it doesn't simply refer to the five senses but to the

internal senses of the mind. It's the same syndrome when we're indulging in fantasies or daydreaming. This initial contact refers simply to the primary stimuli that come into consciousness, that we become aware of. As for the sense of taste, the five flavours as enumerated by the Chinese tradition seem to be apt: sweet and sour, salty, bitter and astringent. All, or some of these, are worked into a concept in the mind and there's a recognition. Toast.

Now this *phassa* refers only to initial contact. By the way, at times it is useful to know the Pali words. It is true of translation from any language that one cannot entirely grasp a foreign word with all its meanings and nuances in another language. That is why I would like to introduce you in this course to key words. But you don't have to learn Pali to make spiritual progress. Thank heavens for that, or I'd give up now myself.

This contact is very basic. With the eyes, it is simply colour and shape before it takes on any meaning. With hearing, it is the volume, pitch, tone, quality and movement of sound before any tune or recognisable speech. If you think it's not possible, just repeat a word to yourself like banana and keep doing it concentrating just on the sound. And I think you will find that soon enough, it really does become a nonsensical sound. Banana. Banana. Banana. Banana.

At the very base of this contact, *phassa*, are the four great elements. Earth, the qualities of hard and soft; water, the quality of cohesiveness, elasticity, stickiness; fire, the qualities of heat and cold; and finally air, the qualities of movement and stillness. It would seem the ancients, including the Greeks, thought that they were the building blocks of the universe. From a spiritual insight point of view, whether they are or not is not relevant. What we are experiencing is how we, the mind, contacts the world, and how from these initial stimuli, or impulses, we create a world.

And remember, how we contact the world is dependent not only on the stimuli coming at us such as light, but on the receptive sense, the I. What a person who is colorblind sees is not the same as someone with ordinary sight. The world we live in is of our own making. We construct it from this initial contact, from stimuli, from the sense base and from a primary cognition, a recognition of it.

Now what is important about this level of perception is that there is as yet no distortion by way of thought, past experience or emotional value. That's why the sensations of the breath are so important in our practice. They are neutral and so they don't have great historical, emotional or conceptual value. So we can easily see the simple qualities of movement. And to see movement in detail is to begin to experience radical transi-

ence. Radical impermanence. Everything really is arising and passing away. A sensation appears and then disappears completely. And to perceive transience at the profoundest level is to be liberated.

So although we've centered on toast, and I owe it to my teacher, Sayuru Janaka, to see the process of eating as a very wonderful opportunity to experience all this, we can take this investigation into every moment of our lives. When hearing a bird or a car passing, or the wind in the trees, when looking at a flower or the landscape or the shrine, when smelling the aromas of food or of the incense, when feeling the points of contact in movement, both in formal walking meditation and simple actions such as feeling the sheets before you pull them back and rise from the bed. We can say that this is our work, to get down to this level of perception. Bury yourself in the body. Once this level of perception is clarified, then all the steps to building a world begin to reveal themselves. And what is important to us is that we see clearly how we mess things up. Things can be so much better.

So that is the point of contact. And that brings me back to the piece of toast. As soon as this recognition, it is toast, occurs, all our memories, conceptual and emotional, around toast engender an emotional response. That interior atmosphere of pleasurable joy, an internal environment of delight, this is *vedanā*, feeling. It's not that we need to remember actual memories, though I dare say, if we set to it, we could write a book, *The Memoirs of a Toasterholic*.

Now *vedanā* refers to feeling, all feeling. We're lucky in English because the word feeling covers virtually all the meaning of *vedanā*. We say, I feel the wind on my cheeks, the sun on my face, and I'm not feeling well. All this refers to sensations in the body, physical feelings. But we also say, I feel sad, I feel happy, a great emotional feeling came over me. This obviously refers to our heart life. So *vedanā*, feeling, refers to everything we feel: sensations, feelings, moods and emotions. And unsurprisingly, they can be divided into pleasant, unpleasant and neutral feelings.

Returning again to our mystical toast, once this inner environment of pleasant feelings has arisen, then there is what might be called a movement within the mind, an attraction, a drawing towards, all of which has the flavour of wanting, desiring, craving, a desire to sink into it, to immerse. That's *taṇhā*, craving, the desire to indulge. Again, *taṇhā* is more than indulgence. It is how we react to what is pleasant, unpleasant or neutral. Towards the pleasant, there is that reaction of wanting. Towards the unpleasant, of not wanting. And towards the neutral, of ignoring it. We ignore neutral feelings because desire seeks something stimulating. We need to be very alert to catch these reactions, and that's also very much our job.

As we shall see later, if we can hold the process to this point, we are in the best position for a dharma insight, a spiritual insight. Now once this point of feeling, *vedanā*, has arisen, then there's that sudden collapse into identification. I, the self, want that. Me, I want it. That's the grasping link, *upādāna*, on the wheel of dependent origination. This is the moment we lose objectivity. From now on we are ensnared in the desire, compulsive behaviours, addictions, and so on, and nothing can stop what happens next.

Once there is that identification with want, we become two-year-olds. The whole desire is impulsed with energy. And before we know it, we empower that desire. We make a decision, often quite unintentionally, compulsively, impulsively. Will, *cetanā*, arises to bring into fruition that desire of self. I become *bhava*, I become a toast eater. How crucial that moment is. Whenever we do something, create an action, be it of a thought, word or deed, we bring an idea, a desire, out of mere potential into the actual. This is the moment of becoming, on the dependent origination. This is the moment when we create *kamma*. This is the moment when we exercise the power of will.

The toast is eaten with blind gusto, eyes shut with little low guttural gruntings. Now surely it is obvious how the simple indulgence in a harmless piece of toast can gather such emotional commitment and physical momentum that the act turns to addiction, even to self-destruction. Such can be the path of a toast devotee. However, oh the misery of it, pleasure decreases while craving increases, and we find ourselves in a spiral of famished dissatisfaction.

We have a great party of Thanksgiving to toast. We all agree to have another, but it never lives up to the promise. There's always that desire for one more, but that second piece never lives up to the promise of the first, especially as we come close to the end of our proper physical appetite, and we begin to feel we've overeaten with all the unpleasant feelings that arise. Our greed is always greater than our need. This is the inbuilt obsolescence of pleasure. Even though we adore toast, we can have too much of a good thing.

So the saying goes, why is it that the same pleasure source can't give us the same continuous buzz? Take horror movies. Many people like the thrill of being frightened. Not really frightened, of course. Pretend fright. But you can see from the vast variety of horror movies how writers have to be ever more creative and horrifying to maintain the level of buzz. When we see those old Frankenstein movies, we can't help but chuckle. Poor old Frankenstein with that bolt through his neck. We become bored so quickly and then starts the search for variety, for distraction. Variety is the spice of life. Well, it is, isn't it? If life is the pursuit of happiness in pleasure.

Until now, we've been fairly basic in our idea of pleasure, basic sensual pleasures. But this refers to all pleasure, even the most refined, artistic, aesthetic pleasures, even the most ecstatic, elevated, exalted states of spiritual bliss. It's all worldly pleasure, as far as the Buddha's concerned. And any indulgence in it will bring about that characteristic vicious cycle of delight, satisfaction, boredom, search for variety, delight, satisfaction, boredom, search for variety, and so on. And what we find is that the more we indulge desire, the greater the attachment, the greater the addiction.

Herein lies another angle on our delusive states. It is only when our addiction is fulfilled do we feel normal. Let's consider that. Taking an obvious case of the drug addict. So long as there's craving, the addict feels out of balance, in a state of suffering, agitated, ready to commit crimes. But when they're drugged up, they feel fine. It wouldn't occur to them to commit a crime. They're happy, fulfilled.

And that's what happens to us, isn't it? We open the fridge door, and there's no milk. No milk for tea. A spat of anger. We look around for someone to blame. Then the depression. The awful thought of having to drink tea without milk. No way. Better to suffer a dash to the shops. Suddenly we're rushing down the streets for a bottle of milk. Rushing. Why? Anger. Desire. And all to get that feeling of well-being, of happiness in pleasure, from a cup of tea.

Perhaps this syndrome can more easily be seen in the way humans behave sexually. When sexual happiness becomes just an end in itself, then again there is this underlying belief that happiness is to be found in raw physical pleasures of sex. The Kama Sutra, the Indian text that goes into all sorts of erotic postures, is yet another manifestation of how the human heart spins off into addiction, an insatiable desire for more. But like anything else, the same old routines become boring. The Kama Sutra is an expression of a very bored and occupied ruling caste. When ordinary sex becomes boring, there's a search for sex with a difference, kinky sex, fetishisms. This soon gets boring too, and kinkiness may turn to deviation, and the fall into crime is always possible.

It's not just compulsive tea drinkers and drug addicts and sexual obsessives, but anyone who is lost in the four great worldly pursuits: all the pleasures of life, fame, power and riches. What else does the self want? I wants to be famous, powerful, rich and have any pleasure it wants right there at its fingertips. Just think of all those people we give power to, the media barons, the multinational executives, the prime ministers. Just think of all those we adulate, the film stars, pop stars, sports stars, and pay out of our noses to satisfy. Just think of how we allow people to amass ridiculous fortunes, the Bill

Gates of this world. Why do we, as a society, allow such grossness? We need only examine ourselves and see how much our own lives are driven by these same self-driven desires.

Sometimes if we're truthful with ourselves we shall catch ourselves in some dark fantasy and then we can see how desire unchecked that has become an addiction so easily leads to crime. When desire is unsatisfied, frustration, anger and self-righteousness arise, and then into robbery, violence, murder, and what have you, sometimes on a massive national scale. It's frightening when we look back at human history to acknowledge how destructive this essential delusion has been, this delusion that we can find happiness in pleasure. Indeed, it leads to criminal insanity. What else would you call Stalin, Hitler, Pol Pot and such like, and all their myriad cronies, but criminally mad? So much of this terrible destruction comes about because of frustration. The anger we feel when we don't get what we want. That awful little vicious circle. I want, can't, will have. How easily a seemingly harmless desire can turn into a nasty aggression.

Little children are wonderful at manifesting this one. They get angry when they can't get what they want and when they really can't get what they want, they cry. If the vicious circle of desire, desire frustrated and violence fails, then there's nothing for it but to spin off into depression and self-pity.

Worse, underneath all this, is fear. Fear of loss, fear of change. The more we treasure an object, anything we become attached to, the more we fear its loss. Hence the locked door. Hence the worry that the car might be stolen. It's not that such fears aren't legitimate, there are thieves about. But even if there weren't, there'd still be the fear of the possible loss of pleasure. Remember here, pleasure refers to anything, anything at all, that brings us delight.

Take hearing and all it means in terms of human communication and the joy of sound. What a loss that would be! As soon as we have an earache, especially if we haven't had one for ages, suddenly fear arises. Could this be serious enough to make me deaf? Can you imagine the feelings of Beethoven as he began to realize that his hearing was going? What a mortification! Not that he allowed such a catastrophe in any way to diminish his work. And that's the point. Those who have lost their hearing, once accommodated, find it does not undermine the quality of their lives. Indeed, they find other treasures.

Now this fear of the loss of treasured things is so great that a huge industry of insurance is built up around it, costing billions of pounds, trillions. Why? Because the self needs to protect itself against loss, with all the anger, grief and despair that it brings. Self has created a little island unto itself and must guard its possessions against the rest

of the whole universe. It's only when you join a large community such as a monastic sangha that you realize that it need not be like that. It is through shared responsibility that so much of this emotional pain can be dissolved.

In Islam, the community is of utmost importance, the Ummah. Muhammad, after all, lived right there in the midst of community and taught people to help each other bear the unfortunate vicissitudes of life. When the Buddha established the Sangha, almost everything was to be held in community, shared. But it does mean that the self has to let go of this idea of mine and begin to move towards ours. Such behaviour leads to a lessening of that self. And remember, the less we have of self, the greater is our true happiness.

For it is happiness that we're searching for all the time. Psychologically, the whole of our life's effort is to find happiness. Think about it. Even in the most terrible circumstances, we're searching for happiness. The person in pain seeks relief. The person in prison seeks distraction, seeks release. Even if we were tied up to a chair, we'd spend our time trying to find the most comfortable position. But the whole search is a wild goose chase and we find ourselves revolving around this cycle of desire, frustration and grief. But worse, when it all gets too much, there's a downward spiral into despair and that ultimate dark desire to escape it all, suicide.

I remember the story of an Australian property tycoon not many years ago now. The bottom fell out of the property market and he committed suicide. A friend who found she was going blind began to consider suicide. I'm sure you all have similar examples. Perhaps you yourself have suffered such situations.

So the question is, is there a way out of all this? Is there something better? Well, that's the message of the Buddha. That's his good news. There is a way of relating to the world, to the world of pleasure, in a way that doesn't bring suffering, and the kernel of that understanding lies in that area of indulgence.

During this time on retreat we have an excellent opportunity to see how this whole syndrome works, how it is that indulging in pleasure brings dissatisfaction, and how it could be that without indulgence, pleasure can be enjoyed, can be appreciated, can be experienced simply as delightful. We can't live in this world as human beings without experiencing pleasure. Pleasures are a given. It's our natural heritage. It is simply how we experience some of the contact we have with our environment and our inner selves. So the teachings of the Buddha has nothing to do with getting rid of pleasure.

He himself talks in this way to Ananda, his cousin, and a close companion for the last 20 years of his life. After going on alms round he would say, let's go to a beautiful shrine. Why? Why should he ask to go to a beautiful shrine? Why not a dung heap or a desert? Or just any old shrine? Why beautiful? And he even names a few. The Buddha obviously appreciated beauty, but did he indulge in it? Did he define the measure of his happiness by it?

How can we be with pleasure in a non-indulgent way and still enjoy it? Wouldn't that be amazing? We'd have our cake and eat it. We'd be able to enjoy pleasure and not have to suffer any of the vicious cycles of frustration, grief, fear and so on. Well, we can. And what's more, we find we can enjoy things even more fully. And it's all in the magic of *satipaṇṇā*, a level of consciousness which directly experiences and yet is not caught up in that experience. That's why it's so important to discover what that level of consciousness is and how to maintain it.

Consider, when we are governed by desire, doesn't that desire define for us what is pleasurable? A friend asks you to a meal and says they'll cook spaghetti. There in your mind right away is the thought of a plate of delicious spaghetti and perhaps all the delight of a Tuscan holiday. You look forward to it. But what's offered is a plate of Heinz 57th variety. On toast. Of course, one is polite. But it would be a hard task to cover one's disappointment. Now, actually, Heinz 57th is OK. I mean, it's edible, and if you're really hungry, it's more than palatable. But as you eat it at your friend's, there's just a mild disgust with it, and the mind's full of horror stories about additives.

Isn't it the same with anything? Desire creates expectation, and that expectation cramps the real experience, blinds one to real experience. This judgmental mind, based on the skewed appreciation of what self likes and does not like, divides the whole of experience into black and white. I saw a tree expert on TV once. He was full of the glories of trees. Then he came upon a copper beech, and this disgust started pouring out of him. Words like disgusting, filthy, ugly started to come up. How can you be passionately hateful of a tree?

To get out of this pleasure-indulgence syndrome we need to exercise precise awareness and on a course of this nature we can begin to see clearly how the self traps itself if we watch carefully what happens whenever pleasure arises. To distinguish between the pleasurable feelings and the desire for them, to really catch that moment, to feel the desire to indulge, to really feel it and then to wait till it passes. And when it's passed, to taste the food. What is the experience of tasting food without previous expectation, without craving? To taste food just as it is, not as we would like it to be.

What sort of mental state arises when we are experiencing something delightful and not indulging in it? And how do we experience that state? Is there identification with it, or is it like being with someone or another person who is happy? The difference between someone who identifies with pleasure and someone who is with their experience of pleasure, as with a good friend, is aptly put by a tale told of my favourite author, Samuel Beckett.

Some of you may know his work, perhaps the most famous, *Waiting for Godot*. His work could be described as one long meditation on decay and death, but always with a wonderful, ironic humour. He was out walking with a friend in some beautiful countryside in France where he lived. His friend was overwhelmed and exclaimed, Oh, what beauty! and then asked, Doesn't it make you want to live? And Beckett, after a characteristic pause, replied, Well, I wouldn't want to go that far.

Now, as always, there are two processes we need to go through. The seeing is *sam-mādiṭṭhi* on the Eightfold Path, its correct view, right understanding. Listening to this talk, I hope you are at least partly intellectually convinced by the arguments. Later, your own thoughts about this matter may arise. But please, don't make an effort to think. That you can do after the course. But as you sit in meditation, you can begin to experience at first hand these physical and mental events. And then we realize that we can't do anything about it. To push them away would be to suppress them.

So the second process is to leave the emotions of craving alone and let them arise and pass away. This is the level of psychotherapy. If the first process of understanding and seeing is psychoanalysis, the second is psychotherapy. Both are needed. The one to clarify our understanding, and the second to allow the heart to heal itself. And it is in suffering, in bearing gladly these emotions, desire, grasping, frustration, grief, fear, that we come to realize directly for ourselves how much suffering we cause ourselves through acts of indulgence. This is the spiritual insight, the dharma insight, into the characteristic of suffering, *dukkha*.

And it's only when we suffer the consequences of our delusions and when we really see how suffering arises and passes away that we find the resolution to overcome the habitual temptations of our cravings. That's the reason spiritually for bearing with the mental distress, for developing the virtue of forbearance, of endurance. This is to allow the suffering to express itself and to remain fully conscious of it. It chisels into the understanding the consequences of unskillful behaviour, so that the fear, the dread of those consequences, outbalances the strength of any craving. There was a friend's father who said he couldn't give up smoking, that is, until he had a heart attack.

Let's pause here for a moment. So, we've looked at the process whereby we create conditionings around pleasure, the role of contact, feeling, desire and craving, grasping and identifying, and finally the act, the becoming, the creation of *kamma* of our conditioning. Now, in our meditation, we can direct our attention at the mental, emotional and physical processes within us to realize all this for ourselves. But be careful not to get caught up in thinking about it. It will take us away from the direct experience. The purpose of this talk is to convince you intellectually enough so that you really want to investigate this matter for yourself. I hope it's left you with a burning desire to maintain that moment-to-moment mindfulness. Yes, not all desire is self-based and deluded. Desires also arise out of our fundamental nature, the desire for true happiness and freedom from suffering. That sort of desire leads us to the end of wrong desires, so we should follow it. When we finally reach the end of suffering, then there will be no need for such desires.

Indeed, it is the very absence of sense desire, wrong desire, that the Buddha calls *Nibbāna*. In the Dhammapada, the Buddha says, Whoever gives up desire for sense pleasures, whoever renounces worldly ambitions, whoever abandons seeking comfort in the world, they destroy that desire for happiness in sensual pleasure and becoming. Such a one is a brahmana, a fully liberated being. I pray your incisive perceptions into the horrors of indulgence may cut asunder the delusions of craving, and that you may achieve the great liberation from all suffering, sooner rather than later.

To Love or To Be Loved. That is the Question.

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 2 min read

This teaching examines the subtle difference between loving others genuinely and seeking to be loved to satisfy our own psychological needs. Bhante Bodhidhamma draws on both Buddhist psychology and Western psychoanalytic insights to explore how the anusaya (latent tendencies) influence our relationships. He explains how early separation from maternal union creates a lifelong longing for connection that can distort our expressions of love into unconscious strategies for gaining approval and reassurance.

The essay reveals how insecurity about our sense of self drives us to seek validation through relationships, leading to anxiety about being liked and good enough. When we offer love primarily to receive love in return, we develop neediness and selfishness that ultimately undermines genuine connection. Paradoxically, when our intentions genuinely focus on caring for others' wellbeing without expecting gratitude, natural self-esteem and virtue arise.

Bhante offers practical guidance for cultivating pure loving: heightening awareness of our intentions, ensuring conscious wholesome choices, and daily reflection on our motivations in conversations and actions. This teaching provides valuable insight for anyone seeking to transform relationships from ego-driven transactions into expressions of genuine mettā (loving-kindness).

The Buddhaddhamma teaches that we have unconscious desires, the anusaya, latent tendencies. The habits we have formed lie beneath our conscious life and rise only when some stimulus activates a given unskilful reaction. But like little devils, the anusaya are always there influencing the way we behave. Freud also was well aware of this and we have the 'Freudian slip' to tell us how embarrassed we can be by such unwelcome intervention. The whole area of love is fraught with such little devils. And we have to ask ourselves constantly: Am I thinking, saying and doing this as an expression of love for the other or as a means to get them to love me, appreciate me or both? According to psychoanalysis, as babies we are utterly identified with our mothers. As the necessary separation takes place so we can become individuals in our own right, we lose the safety and warmth of that union. So there is a longing to re-establish such a heavenly union for the rest of our lives. One reason why falling in love is so enthralling, is because it reminds us of that earlier union with our mothers. The Dhamma digs a little deeper to the sense of self and how it drives us to seek delight 'now here, now

there'. But it sits on a bed of insecurity, highlighted only when the shadow of death is glimpsed. There is no greater reassurance in that dread than the embrace of another. False refuge, yet it does serve to allay the sickled ghost. In that need, we find ourselves unconsciously offering our love in order to be loved. Yet in doing so, we are developing all the neediness and selfishness that insecurity can develop. We become anxious about whether we are liked or not, good enough or not. We must butter up our self-esteem by doing good for the other, impressing the other. We find ourselves going over the top to help and find we are even becoming nuisances. Rejection for such 'generous offering' stings and we tend to blame the other for their ingratitude. 'I have done so much for you' Paradoxically, when all our intentions bend to love, to care for the other, sensitive to their needs, we find that self-esteem arises naturally. Such is the product of virtue. There is no need for appreciation or gratitude to be expressed. What practice can we set ourselves to move towards a pure loving? First, we must heighten our sense of awareness around our intentions now that we are forewarned. Second, we must be sure the intention is a fully conscious act so that the unwholesome intentions are not reinforced and so, unexercised, simply wither. And the reflection after any conversation or act and especially at the end of the day, gently pointing to errors and being joyful at successes that lead to a greater love and care.

Wildflower Wisdom

Noirin Sheahan · 2 min read

Noirin Sheahan shares her journey of discovering dhamma teachings through wildflower identification at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat. Inspired by Joanna Macey's approach to climate anxiety through gratitude and nature appreciation, she chronicles her evolution from overwhelming aversion to curious engagement with the natural world around her.

The essay traces the familiar pattern of the three unwholesome roots (lobha, dosa, moha) as they manifest in her botanical learning journey - from initial aversion to the complexity of identifying species, through growing greed for knowledge, to finding balance through mindful appreciation. What begins as a butterfly walk becomes a metaphor for how mindfulness practice can transform our relationship with the world's complexity.

Sheahan demonstrates how everyday activities like nature walks can become vehicles for dhamma practice, showing how each mindful encounter - whether with wildflowers, political committees, or meditation cushions - offers opportunities to care for what is "vulnerable, fleeting, unreliable." The essay beautifully illustrates how environmental engagement and spiritual practice can support each other, with nature study becoming both a form of loving-kindness practice and practical activism that counters climate despair through present-moment awareness and appreciation.

Oblivious to the pandemic and all its consequences, the wildflowers have been blooming here at Satipanya and giving me a few dhamma lessons in the process. My interest was sparked by reading Joanna Macey's 'Active Hope' last year, a guide to facing the climate crisis. One danger, she says, is that we get so overwhelmed by anxiety that we do nothing. To combat this, we need to start with gratitude: to develop and express appreciation for the natural world that supports us and is now so deeply threatened. Whatever actions we take to combat the threat will then stem from good-will and be more effective and sustainable as a result. So when Eddie, one of our dhamma group in Dublin, suggested a butterfly walk, I was enthusiastic. Luckily it was a beautiful sunny day and butterflies fluttered in abundance. It was a bit of a downer therefore to find aversion showing up. It all seemed so overwhelming – so many different butterflies, so many different wildflowers, so much beauty and profusion. My brain ached! I kept reminding myself of the motivation — to develop and express appreciation for the natural world — as I adjusted myself to the news that this was going to be a long journey, that the heart was only going to open chink by chink to the biosphere. 65 years of ig-

noring the ‘weeds’ under my feet weren’t going to be pushed aside that easily! By the time those ‘weeds’ started blooming this year, aversion had given way to a tentative curiosity. Little pink flowers (from a photo Eddie identified Herb Robert) became differentiable from a companion pink (Red Campion). When I went out for my walk, these became friends greeting me on the roadside. With their encouragement little white flowers (Stitchwort) began to form a niche in consciousness, soon followed by the taller white ones (yarrow) and yellow ones As you can probably guess, greed was now triumphing over aversion, my heart aching with desire to know and name all the flowers peering at me whenever I glanced at the hedgerow. Doubt crept in — what was the point in making my daily walks stressful? Would I not be better off to cultivate tranquility, just feeling my feet on the ground as I walked? Remembering the motivation — appreciation for nature as a way of countering the paralyzing anxiety associated with climate crisis — I could see that the stress was worth bearing. On this side of enlightenment what relationship is free from greed? I could work with it mindfully and balance it out by spending more time admiring each flower, letting them draw me deeper into this new relationship, wishing them well as they coped with weather changes now and to come. Maybe thanks to Joanna Macey’s strategy, I now find myself on the biodiversity policy group of the Green Party. Although my expertise on Herb Robert might not save the planet, I will surely be able to compile an email list or in some way contribute to this work. No doubt greed and aversion will make their appearance here too. But that’s OK, they have their place in life. Greed counters laziness, my tendency to ignore what I don’t yet understand or value; aversion tells me when I’ve had enough, need to relax, let someone else compile that email list. Nature, politics, committees can all be part of our path to freedom. The truth seeps in as we follow the breath in meditation, compile an email list, discern one pink flower from another. Each mindful encounter with the world is to care for what is vulnerable, fleeting, unreliable — the perfect Dhamma teaching.

All in the Mind

Noirin Sheahan · 2 min read

This insightful essay by Noirin Sheahan examines the profound Buddhist understanding that all suffering is fundamentally mental in nature. While physical pain and life's challenges are real, the essay demonstrates how our suffering comes not from these experiences themselves, but from the mind's reactive patterns of panic, resistance, and endless questioning.

Drawing on direct meditation experience, particularly walking meditation, Sheahan illustrates how the six sense spheres (the five physical senses plus mind as the sixth sense) operate as distinct dimensions of experience. This recognition offers practical liberation: when caught in cycles of anxious thinking or emotional turmoil, we can consciously shift attention to any of the five physical sense spheres—sounds, sights, bodily sensations—as refuges from mental reactivity.

The essay includes a powerful personal account of overcoming anxiety by recognizing the voluntary nature of worried thinking and choosing to rest in the simple experience of bird-song. This demonstrates the Buddha's central teaching that we have moment-to-moment choice in how we relate to our experience. Rather than being victims of our mental habits, we can learn to 'not pick up heavy suitcases' of anxiety and distress, finding freedom through mindful sense contact rather than compulsive thought patterns.

If we suffer a physical disease, a broken bone, a bereavement, we might get sympathy and attention. But if people suspect our problems are 'all in the mind' they usually want to get away as fast as they can! And yet suffering is 'all in the mind'. The pain of a broken bone is physical. True we might writhe in agony, convinced our leg is where suffering is located. But the leg just gets on with the business of tissue repair. It's only the mind that panics, thinks 'this is unbearable', gets us moaning and contorted in an effort to soothe ourselves. When the mind is still in meditation, we can sometimes see that physical sensations are separate from mental reactions like emotions and thoughts. In fact all of the six senses (five physical senses plus the mind, which forms the sixth sense in Buddhism) occupy distinct 'spheres' within experience. I first saw this during walking meditation. I noticed that the sight of the foot swinging forward was totally separate from the sensation. It was as if they occupied separate universes, different dimensions. One contained colours and shapes, the other sensations. There was no possibility of communication between the two, and it was a third dimension, the mind, that put the

information together and decided they both described a foot moving forward. I was amazed that I could walk so easily even though my legs, eyes and mind were confined to separate dimensions! This isn't just academic. The Buddha's only purpose in teaching was to point us along the path to the end of suffering. One very practical consequence is the possibility of letting attention rest in one of the five physical sense spheres, to get a new perspective on our mental life. In meditation we notice the incessant stream of thinking that often seems to get in the way of calmer experience such as the sensations of breathing. We begin to see for ourselves that suffering 'is all in the mind'. I learned this one time when my mind was afire with anxiety, repeating questions endlessly — What was going on? Why couldn't I get on top of this anxiety? By chance, my attention was momentarily called by the sound of birdsong, interrupting the flow of questions. My mind relaxed as I listened. But as soon as I noticed this 'lapse', it hurried back to its urgent duty of fretting. As relaxation changed to anxiety I felt the voluntary nature of thought. I sensed myself choosing to fret, to indulge anxiety. It was as if I was choosing to pick up heavy suitcases. I was amazed to realise that I had a choice in the matter. But now there was no escaping that choice. Would I continue burdening myself with anxious questions? Although the answer is obvious, it felt scary beyond words to stop, to accept the reality of not knowing what was going on, or how to get on top of anxiety. It was like taking a step over a cliff. And yet, something deep within commanded that I stop fretting, accept that I did not know any answers. With my heart in my mouth, I surrendered to that truth. Next moment, anxiety disappeared without trace! Luckily, suffering is 'all in the mind'. And we have access to five other dimensions of experience which show us the way out. At each and every moment we can rest attention in sense contact, learn to recognize the possibility of not reacting, not picking up heavy suitcases of anxiety, depression, woe, and misery. We can choose sense contact rather than thought as our guide, step over our mental cliffs, fall into freedom.

Climate Crisis: A Personal Reflection

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 17 min read

In this deeply reflective essay, Bhante Bodhidhamma addresses the climate crisis through the lens of Buddhist teachings, offering a personal exploration of how to maintain spiritual equanimity while facing potential civilizational collapse. Drawing on fundamental Buddhist concepts of anicca (impermanence) and kamma, he contextualizes current environmental threats within the broader framework of saṃsāra and the inevitable cycles of arising and passing away that characterize all conditioned existence.

The essay examines the psychological responses to climate crisis—denial, anger, grief, and despair—through the Buddha's encounter with King Viddhudhabba's destruction of Kapilavatthu, illustrating how even the Buddha had to accept certain karmic consequences. Bhante emphasizes three key opportunities the crisis presents: confronting our deepest fears about death and impermanence, growing in virtue (sīla) through conscious action and reduced consumption, and developing insight that transforms selfish concern into compassionate engagement for all beings.

Including the Upajjhaṭṭhāna Sutta (AN 5.57) on the five subjects for contemplation and teachings on maraṇasati (mindfulness of death), the essay provides practical guidance for daily contemplation. Bhante advocates balancing realistic acceptance of our limitations with committed action, suggesting that spiritual liberation remains possible even amid global catastrophe. The work concludes with recommended practices including mettā meditation and contemplation of nibbāna's qualities, emphasizing that genuine spiritual development requires acting not just for personal liberation but for the benefit of all beings.

Climate Crisis : A Personal Reflection

Work for the best : Prepare for the worst.

Once the report came out from the UN scientists giving us about 10 years to mend our ways or face

the destruction of the planet as we know it, the temperature around Climate Change is measured

in the now named Climate Crisis or Climate Emergency. Even so, the last COP meetings in Madrid

deepened the crisis with their inability to agree on viable agenda to end global warming. More and

more people are alarmed, and understandably especially the young. This brings with it

all the
negative mental states of anger, anxiety, grief and waiting in the wings, despair.
There is already a lot of literature concerning a Buddhist response to Climate Crisis and
this is but
a personal response, reflections which have helped me come to terms with what is hap-
pening.
Firstly, the need to see the 'bigger picture', a wider perspective. The Crisis may bring
untold
suffering and in a comparatively short time the deaths of billions of people, not to
mention all the
other creatures. So it is as well to remember that all are individual deaths. Each will die in
their own
way. Some will die in peace, others in despair. We do not die each other's death.
What is more, we are all going to die anyway! And some will peacefully, some not so.
Even if the
Crisis is averted, every human being and all creatures living now will eventually die. It
is the scale
and possible manner of death that horrifies, not the individual experience for there are
millions of
people dying every day and many also in dreadful circumstances.
David Attenborough, who presented all those wonderful nature programmes, warned
of the loss of
civilisation as we know it. This is another death. But there is nothing remarkable about
that.
Civilisations have come and gone – Mohenjo-Daro, Mesopotamia, Egypt – and all those
lesser
ones wiped out in the last 500 years since the expansion of European civilisation. It's
just we think
ours is supreme and would a terrible loss. In many ways we are superior – scientific-
ally,
technologically, even artistically, but ethically? It was the pre-industrial civilisations
that
flourished a Buddha, a Moses, a Socrates and a Lao Tse.
And then there is destruction of life on earth, but that will not include Gaia herself. She
will
continue to bring forth life. There have already been five extinctions. And each time
there has been
a regeneration and there has been one creature to survive who then developed even
further in the

next flourishing. It would seem each time there were even more sophisticated beings. Homo Sapiens is the crowning glory so far. But who knows what she will produce after a few million years? I get the sense Gaia is becoming more canny with every collapse and that, of course, works well with Darwinian Theory. The cockroach has survived all extinctions! But my money is on the frog who got through the last one. As an amphibian, it has that adaptability and spawning creates so many tadpoles. It may be that in millions of years' time, we may be taking rebirth again as Frogo Sapiens. And if I am right, Frogo may be even more sophisticated than we are – Superfrogo. But will it be any different. Not at all. They will still suffer from greed, aversion and delusion. And the whole round will start again, though considering their super abilities, they will probably bring about their demise even more quickly. This is the world of Samsara – the world of ongoing vagabonds. And we must not forget that the sun is also time bound. There will come a time when it explodes into a supernova and that's the end of Gaia. That exquisite pale blue pearl, tiny amidst the vast cosmos, will fade into a wandering rock. This is the teaching of impermanence, anicca: everything that manifests will perish; nothing remains; nothing is reliable. These are not contemplations easy to accept, but they give a basic platform to work from.

If we are indeed heading to our self-made destruction, why are people so reluctant to do anything? Even deny the science? There are many factors that have driven us into this crisis: economic, social, ecological, but the underlying cause is ethical - greed. The world is in the grip of Consumerism, a religion we all follow to some extent or another. And this issues from the deluded desire to seek true

happiness in
the sensual world. We know intellectually it is not possible since everything changes,
nothing lasts,
but even so we try. We build walls of safety around us by acquiring wealth, fame and
power. We
hold tight onto what we have. We fend off those who would undermine us or run away
from them.
Rooted right there in our entrancement with the world is the cause of our inability to
let go of the
simplest of habits. In the extreme we will rather kill than give up a treasured
dependency –
addictions of every description. Even if we determine to give up our morning tea or
coffee, we will
be proud to do it once, even a few times, but for good? No that's too much! And this
crisis is asking
us to change our very lifestyles.
Anyone who has done a week retreat knows the first three days to be blood, sweat and
tears until
we have adjusted to the routine, very different from our ordinary daily lives. Yes, we
can change,
but it may take outer conditions to make us do so. Already hurricanes are wiping out
the Bahamas,
seas swamping islands, typhoons emptying cities and fires consuming whole forests
and their
creatures. But it hasn't touched the majority – and especially the majority of the richer
nations.
And therein lies our paradox. We don't usually do anything until it really hurts and by
then it may
very well be too late.
Added to all this is denial. There are those who simply don't want to think about such
things (and
who can blame them such is the feeling of impotency?) and there are those whose
investment in
the status quo will not allow them do so. So, even as this human world is rent with
regional wars,
local political upheavals and fundamentalists, we are chained to a neo-liberal economic
system
that has no social responsibility.
It does look bleak! And the situation may arise where nothing can stop runaway global

warming.

There is a telling event in the Buddha's life. King Pasenadi of Kosala was a dedicated disciple of the

Buddha. His son, Viddudhabba was not so. He had married into the Buddha's clan, the Sakyas, but

they thought his caste was too low for them and they tricked him into marrying a slave girl. The

king came to know of it and in a rage, took his army to destroy the Sakyas. The Buddha was able to

intervene three times. And three times the Viddudhabba turned back. But on the fourth time he

set out, the Buddha said he could nothing. He accepted that Viddudhabba would exact his

revenge. Kapilavatthu, the Sakyan capital was razed to the ground and many killed. No doubt the

Buddha went to console his people who founded another city. Even the Buddha could not stop the

karmic consequence of Sakyan duplicity.

We may now be tempted to think that humankind is hopelessly lost in delusion; that nothing can

be done. But acceptance is not resignation. That leads to despair. Acceptance brings a realistic

appraisal of the situation and so reveals possibilities. But those of us dedicated to the Dhamma

have deeper reasons to combat global warming.

The Buddha told us this was the best of rebirths. The human condition offered the most fruitful

circumstance for liberation. Even for those who do not believe in rebirth or transcendence, living

according to the Dhamma brings beneficial results in the here and now. Considering the preciousness of this human birth we owe it to ourselves to take advantage of this opportunity.

Firstly it is an opportunity to work with our deepest fear - coming to terms with death. Many will

know the work of Elizabeth Kubler-Ross who pointed to five stages in the dying process: denial,

anger, bargaining, depression and acceptance. This is not a linear process, nor is death the only

time we would go through such a process. We might experience all or some of these

stages when
someone close to us is dying. And even if we lose our mobile phone! Contemplating our death is

one way of getting in touch with these reactions and working with them. The fear of death is the
measure of our delusion. Our insight practice will make us feel at ease with the fear and finally
undermine that fear. And that releases energy to engage in the struggle against global warming.

It is also an opportunity to recognise our limitations as the Buddha did with Viddhuhhabba. We

can only do what is in our power to do. Beyond that we may be able to influence others. But

beyond that is only frustration and burn out. To recognise our limits is again to be realistic so we

do not fall into reactions of false guilt and shame.

Secondly, it is an opportunity to grow in virtue. To acknowledge we can do something, no matter how

little, brings with it a moral obligation. We have to do what we can, not just for our own benefit,

but also the benefit of all. Even in a situation where everyone is perishing, we still have a moral

obligation to help others. It may be we can only offer donations, write letters, send emails. It may

be we can only send out metta. But we can always examine our own carbon footprint by

questioning what we buy, how we use electricity, how warm we keep the house and the use of the

car and planes – even how much water we boil when we want a cup of tea. It is not about getting

neurotic over these, but just recognising what is sufficient and what is indulgence or carelessness.

Thirdly it is an opportunity to grow in insight and liberate ourselves from suffering. And here we

come across the great paradox of the spiritual life. If whatever we do, is done solely with the aim of

liberating ourselves, we are doing it for selfish reasons. This is the do-gooder syndrome. We simply

end up scoring points, convincing ourselves that such have been our meritorious deeds we are

bound to be liberated by them. Instead, they have all increased the sense of the deluded self.

This is true even for retreatants. If we practice just to liberate ourselves, it becomes a self-centred

practice. If we practice also for the benefit of others, it becomes a communal act. It gives a greater

incentive too. The Great Doubt came to the Buddha as he sat under the Bodhi Tree. The doubt was

fuelled by the isolation of doing it for himself and Mara, the Tempter, suggested he drop the whole

escapade and return to his family and lay life. But he grounded himself by touching the earth and

the Earth Goddess rose to reassure him that he had perfected the virtue of generosity.

He wasn't

'striving diligently' just for himself, but for all beings.

When our actions are for our own benefit, then we should acknowledge that as self-care, not

selfishness. And when we act on behalf of others, we should not consider that as not caring for

ourselves. The extent of our generosity is an indication of our 'selflessness'. In the same way, where

we find negativity, we act towards its opposite. Where we find anger, we generate forgiveness and

undermine resentment. Where we find resistance, we develop patient forbearance and where we

find suffering, we offer assistance as best we can. And it is contemplating the Dhamma that all

beings, no matter how evil, how foolish, will eventually liberate themselves from suffering, that will

transform despair into hope.

This is all best done in community. It is with others, whether the wider movement of Extinction

Rebellion or a small local group of activists or a virtual group that we will find moral support,

opportunity for concerted action and comfort of heart.

Whatever happens we must seize the opportunity to develop our spiritual life. The way lies in

paradox. The more we give, the more we receive; the more we protect others, the more we are protected; the more ready we are to face disaster, the more we are fearless in our endeavour to save all beings. Even in the most dire circumstances, liberation is at hand. So we should do what we can to bring an end to the crisis. But it is as well to consider failure and steel ourselves for such an outcome. And here the contemplation of kamma and death are the most powerful healers for such contemplations will help us greatly undermine despair.

These two Discourses by the Buddha on kamma and death will greatly help us if we make these contemplations a daily practice. A few minutes of reminder is enough. Whenever we do this sort of exercise we should balance it with Metta practice and qualities of Nibbana which are listed below.

These texts are downloaded from Sutta Central
AN 5.57 Upajjhatthana Sutta: Subjects for Contemplation
Translated by Sujato Bhikkhu

“Mendicants, a woman or a man, a layperson or a renunciate should often review these five subjects. What five?

‘I am liable to grow old, I am not exempt from old age.’ A woman or a man, a layperson or a renunciate should often review this.

‘I am liable to get sick, I am not exempt from sickness.’ ...

‘I am liable to die, I am not exempt from death.’ ...

‘I must be parted and separated from all I hold dear and beloved.’ ...

‘I am the owner of my deeds and heir to my deeds. Deeds are my womb, my relative, and my refuge.

I shall be the heir of whatever deeds I do, whether good or bad.’ A woman or a man, a layperson or a renunciate should often review this.

What is the advantage for a woman or a man, a layperson or a renunciate of often reviewing this: ‘I

am liable to grow old, I am not exempt from old age’? There are sentient beings who, in-

toxicated

with the vanity of youth, do bad things by way of body, speech, and mind. Reviewing this subject

often, they entirely give up the vanity of youth, or at least reduce it. This is the advantage for a

woman or a man, a layperson or a renunciate of often reviewing this: 'I am liable to grow old, I am

not exempt from old age'.

What is the advantage of often reviewing this: 'I am liable to get sick, I am not exempt from

sickness'? There are sentient beings who, drunk on the vanity of health, do bad things by way of

body, speech, and mind. Reviewing this subject often, they entirely give up the vanity of health, or

at least reduce it. This is the advantage of often reviewing this: 'I am liable to get sick, I am not

exempt from sickness'.

What is the advantage of often reviewing this: 'I am liable to die, I am not exempt from death'? There are sentient beings who, drunk on the vanity of life, do bad things by way of body,

speech, and mind. Reviewing this subject often, they entirely give up the vanity of life, or at least

reduce it. This is the advantage of often reviewing this: 'I am liable to die, I am not exempt from

death'.

What is the advantage of often reviewing this: 'I must be parted and separated from all I hold dear

and beloved'? There are sentient beings who, aroused by desire and longing for their dear and

beloved, do bad things by way of body, speech, and mind. Reviewing this subject often, they

entirely give up desire and longing for their dear and beloved, or at least reduce it. This is the

advantage of often reviewing this: 'I must be parted and separated from all I hold dear and

beloved'.

What is the advantage of often reflecting like this: 'I am the owner of my deeds and heir to my

deeds. Deeds are my womb, my relative, and my refuge. I shall be the heir of whatever

deeds I do,
whether good or bad”? There are sentient beings who do bad things by way of body,
speech, and
mind. Reviewing this subject often, they entirely give up bad conduct, or at least reduce
it. This is
the advantage for a woman or a man, a layperson or a renunciate of often reflecting
like this: ‘I am
the owner of my deeds and heir to my deeds. Deeds are my womb, my relative, and my
refuge. I
shall be the heir of whatever deeds I do, whether good or bad.’
Then that noble disciple reflects: ‘It’s not just me who is liable to grow old, not being
exempt from
old age. For all sentient beings grow old according to their nature, as long as they come
and go,
pass away and are reborn.’ When they review this subject often, the path is born in
them. They
cultivate, develop, and make much of it. By doing so, they give up the fetters and
eliminate the
underlying tendencies.

‘It’s not just me who is liable to get sick, not being exempt from sickness. For all
sentient beings get
sick according to their nature, as long as they come and go, pass away and are reborn.’
When they
review this subject often, the path is born in them. They cultivate, develop, and make
much of
it. By doing so, they give up the fetters and eliminate the underlying tendencies.
‘It’s not just me who is liable to die, not being exempt from death. For all sentient beings
die
according to their nature, as long as they come and go, pass away and are reborn.’
When they
review this subject often, the path is born in them. They cultivate, develop, and make
much of
it. By doing so, they give up the fetters and eliminate the underlying tendencies.
‘It’s not just me who must be parted and separated from all I hold dear and beloved. For
all
sentient beings must be parted and separated from all they hold dear and beloved, as
long as they
come and go, pass away and are reborn.’ When they review this subject often, the path

is born in
them. They cultivate, develop, and make much of it. By doing so, they give up the fetters
and

eliminate the underlying tendencies.

‘It’s not just me who shall be the owner of my deeds and heir to my deeds. For all
sentient beings

shall be the owners of their deeds and heirs to their deeds, as long as they come and go,
pass away

and are reborn.’ When they review this subject often, the path is born in them. They
cultivate,

develop, and make much of it. By doing so, they give up the fetters and eliminate the
underlying

tendencies.

For others, sickness is natural,

and so are old age and death.

Though this is how their nature is,

ordinary people feel disgusted.

If I were to be disgusted

with creatures whose nature is such,

it would not be appropriate for me,

since my life is just the same.

Living in such a way,

I understood the reality without attachments.

I mastered all vanities—

of health, of youth,

and even of life—

seeing safety in renunciation.

Zeal sprang up in me

as I looked to extinguishment.

Now I’m unable

to indulge in sensual pleasures;

there’s no turning back,

until the spiritual life is complete.”

Many of you will be familiar with my own development of the contemplation of
sickness, disease

and death:

This body is subject to disease.

This body of a nature to fall ill.

This body has not gone beyond sickness.

This body is subject to ageing.

This body has not gone beyond ageing.

This body is now in a process of ageing.

This body is subject to death.

This body has not gone beyond death.

This body will die.

A.N Book of the sixes

20. Mindfulness of Death (2)

Translated by Thanissaro Bhikkhu

I have heard that at one time the Blessed One was staying at Nadika, in the Brick Hall.

There he

addressed the monks, “Monks, mindfulness of death—when developed & pursued—is of great fruit

& great benefit. It gains a footing in the Deathless, has the Deathless as its final end. And how is

mindfulness of death developed & pursued so that it is of great fruit & great benefit, gains a footing

in the Deathless, and has the Deathless as its final end?

“There is the case where a monk, as day departs and night returns, reflects: ‘Many are the [possible]

causes of my death. A snake might bite me, a scorpion might sting me, a centipede might bite me.

That would be how my death would come about. That would be an obstruction for me. Stumbling,

I might fall; my food, digested, might trouble me; my bile might be provoked, my phlegm...

piercing wind forces [in the body] might be provoked. That would be how my death would come

about. That would be an obstruction for me.’ Then the monk should investigate:

‘Are there any evil, unskillful mental qualities unabandoned by me that would be an obstruction

for me were I to die in the night?’

If, on reflecting, he realizes that there are evil, unskillful mental qualities unabandoned by him that

would be an obstruction for him were he to die in the night, then he should put forth extra desire,

effort, diligence, endeavour, undivided mindfulness, & alertness for the abandoning of those very

same evil, unskilful qualities. Just as when a person whose turban or head was on fire would put forth extra desire, effort, diligence, endeavour, undivided mindfulness, & alertness to put out the fire on his turban or head, in the same way the monk should put forth extra desire, effort, diligence, endeavour, undivided mindfulness, & alertness for the abandoning of those very same evil, unskilful qualities. But if, on reflecting, he realizes that there are no evil, unskilful mental qualities unabandoned by him that would be an obstruction for him were he to die in the night, then for that very reason he should dwell in joy & rapture, training himself day & night in skillful qualities.

“Further, there is the case where a monk, as night departs and day returns, reflects: ‘Many are the [possible] causes of my death. A snake might bite me, a scorpion might sting me, a centipede might bite me. That would be how my death would come about. That would be an obstruction for me. Stumbling, I might fall; my food, digested, might trouble me; my bile might be provoked, my phlegm... piercing wind forces [in the body] might be provoked. That would be how my death would come about. That would be an obstruction for me.’ Then the monk should investigate:

‘Are there any evil, unskilful mental qualities unabandoned by me that would be an obstruction for me were I to die during the day?’ If, on reflecting, he realizes that there are evil, unskilful mental qualities unabandoned by him that would be an obstruction for him were he to die during the day, then he should put forth extra desire, effort, diligence, endeavour, undivided mindfulness, & alertness for the abandoning of those very same evil, unskilful qualities. Just as when a person whose turban or head was on fire

would put forth extra desire, effort, diligence, endeavour, undivided mindfulness, & alertness to

put out the fire on his turban or head, in the same way the monk should put forth extra desire,

effort, diligence, endeavour, undivided mindfulness, & alertness for the abandoning of those very

same evil, unskilful qualities. But if, on reflecting, he realizes that there are no evil, unskilful

mental qualities unabandoned by him that would be an obstruction for him were he to die during

the day, then for that very reason he should dwell in joy & rapture, training himself day & night in

skilful qualities.

“This, monks, is how mindfulness of death is developed & pursued so that it is of great fruit &

great benefit, gains a footing in the Deathless, and has the Deathless as its final end.”

That is what the Blessed One said. Gratified, the monks delighted in the Blessed One’s words.

Metta Practice

Make up your own phrases and offer them

to those whom you see frustrating attempts to bring the Crisis to an end

to those working towards bringing the Crisis to an end.

Nibbana

It is the Unformed, the Unconditioned, the End, the Truth, the Other Shore, the Subtle, the

Everlasting, the Invisible, the Undiversified, Peace, the Deathless, the Blest, Safety, the Wonderful,

the Marvellous, Nibbana, Purity, Freedom, the Island, the Refuge, the Beyond. S43.1-44

Reading

Climate Crisis:

This brings in the Discourses and is a very fulsome treatment of the situation.

Mindfully Facing Climate Change by Analayo Bhikkhu

Still the classic for Metta:

Loving-Kindness : Sharon Salzberg

Lots of books about death!

Living in the Light of Death : On the Art of Being Truly Alive : Larry Rosenberg

Mindfully Facing Disease and Death : Analayo Bhikkhu (based of Discourses)

For a thorough exploration of Nibbana and the Path leading there, see:

The Island : Ajahn Passano and Ajahn Amaro

Mind Like a Fire Unbound : Thanissaro Bhikkhu

Expectation, Aspiration and Hope

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 3 min read

In this thoughtful essay, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines three distinct mental attitudes we hold toward the future and our spiritual practice. He begins by exploring expectation as a manifestation of the ego's need for control and security, showing how it inevitably leads to disappointment when reality fails to match our projections. Drawing on the example of the Bodhisatta's own struggles before his awakening, Bhante illustrates how even spiritual expectations can become sources of suffering.

The essay then turns to aspiration, which Bhante describes as having an 'ethereal' quality - a humble movement toward wise and beautiful goals without the presumption of guaranteed success. Unlike expectation, aspiration embraces uncertainty and sees setbacks as clarification rather than failure. This attitude allows for genuine spiritual progress without the burden of prideful attachment to outcomes.

Finally, Bhante introduces a special understanding of hope as 'Dhamma joy' - the mudita that arises from virtuous living and deepens as one progresses along the Path. He traces this hope through different stages of practice, from initial intellectual conviction through direct experience of the Path, culminating in the unshakeable hope of the Stream-enterer who has tasted nibbāna. This teaching offers practical wisdom for approaching both meditation practice and daily life with greater freedom from the suffering inherent in expectation.

Expectation, Aspiration and Hope.

Expectation what suffering there is in that! The self likes to be in control. It likes to know what's going to happen. It needs to feel safe, secure. And there, of course, lies its underbelly of weakness. We expect the summers to be sunny. We expect a pay rise.

We expect to go on holiday. We expect friends to help us. Mothers expect babies. And we expect spiritual progress from our practice. The list is forever. Expectation assumes, presumes, takes for granted. It's a manifestation of arrogance.

Expectation is bound to fail us one way or another for it projects an ideal, a concrete goal

on the future whose parameters we don't know. We simply don't know what is going to happen. So when our expectation fails to materialise we are disappointed, depressed by it.

Suddenly my job's gone. Did I really expect it to last for the whole of my life especially these

days? Did I really expect not to fall ill? Did I really expect this relationship to last for ever?

Unfortunately, if our expectation does come mainly to manifest, then, of course, weI told

you so! I knew it was going to happen! But that just increases our sense of being in control,

being able to predict. More pride, more hubris and then the fall. Consider the dictators of

the last century. The tragic-comic figure of Saddam Hussein. A life that rests on expectation

is forever falling into ditches.

The Bodhisatta also sat dejected by the road. All the practice, all the mortifications he had

done, all had been of no avail. Then on the seat of his awakening beneath the Bodhi tree,

the arrogance manifested. Mara comes with his hoards. Who was he to sit there and find

the end of suffering? Only by virtue of his generosity, that he was doing it also for the benefit of others, was the Great Doubt dispelled. Lucky for us!

Consider how many times weve been disappointed in our lives. Such is the measure of expectation. Enough of expectation, then!

Aspiration is a lovely word. Its root is the same as respiration. s ethereal. Aspiration does

not expect, assume, presume. It does not have a success time or finishing date. Yet it espouses beautiful aims and objectives. It has a nobility, a dignity about it. One aspires to produce art, to assist others, to shape the future. An artist, a nurse, a politician (no cynicism please!). And of course one aspires to be liberated, to be awakened.

Aspiration does not presume fulfilment, does not presume on others. It is simply a movement in the mind, a desire for the wise, the beautiful and the virtuous. An inclination

towards a goal. And thats how the Buddha expressed it. We should . And so aspiration gathers all the necessary qualities and support to move in that direction.

Aspiration is humble. Not the false humility of a prideful self. A cover to prevent the humiliation of failure in others eyes. Genuine humility is that groundedness that comes with

seeing life not as success and failure, but as trial and error. If things dont work out, well, at

least I know what is not for me. It clarifies future action. Many westerners join the Sangha

with great commitment and faith, only to find it is not the right lifestyle for them. Their time

in the order will not have been wasted.

Hope, I am using here in a special way. It is usually a humbler word than expectation.

It expresses an uncertainty, a hesitation. It is often a well-wishing, a prayer. But here I am pointing to something more certain. To a Dhamma joy. It is a quality of mudita often translated as sympathetic joy, but this misses the point of joy in oneself, such as the joy that comes from knowing we live virtuous lives.

Here hope is the joy of knowing there is a future arrival, a completion, as when the doctor

tells us that the illness will pass. This hope in future liberation comes even when we become

intellectually convinced of the Path. Everything seems to make sense. Life is profoundly meaningful. There will be a fulfilment. But this hope is poor hope compared to the joyful

hope that arises in someone who, through the practice, begins to experience the path and

sees clearly how it leads out of delusion into the light of wisdom, out of the quagmire of suffering and dissatisfaction into the meadows of happiness and contentment. How deeper

then is the soft joy of hope in someone who has entered the Path, the Stream-enterer, the

One Who Knows by direct experience the bliss of Nibbana! Such hope of future liberation

is unwavering, undilutable. They know that some day they will join the legion of arahants.

There hope will meld into the contentment and happiness of one who has lived the Holy Life

and reached the true goal.

Extending the Limits of Good-Will

Noirin Sheahan · 2 min read

Noirin Sheahan offers an honest and relatable examination of how good-will (mettā) can be compromised when we encounter difficult people or situations that 'push our buttons.' Through the vivid example of a neighbourly visit gone wrong, she illustrates how quickly irritation can infiltrate our well-intentioned actions, leading to self-righteous anger and interpersonal conflict.

The essay demonstrates how meditation practice provides crucial insight into these emotional patterns, showing how the body's wisdom can guide us toward shame and forgiveness rather than defensive pride. Sheahan explores the kammic consequences of ill-will and the challenging but necessary work of recognizing our own role in creating suffering through self-centring and rigid attachment to 'my way.'

Practical guidance emerges through three key strategies: examining the untested assumptions that skew our good-will toward self-interest, strengthening sati (mindfulness) to catch irritation before it solidifies into defensive patterns, and cultivating the courage to turn away from familiar territories of self-justification toward the unfamiliar freedom of genuine openness. This teaching offers valuable insight for anyone working to develop authentic loving-kindness that can withstand real-world challenges.

Extending the limits of good-will.

People who push my buttons show me the limits of my good-will and I find this very humiliating! For example - good-will suggests that I visit an elderly neighbour. It's a lovely day, I just know she would appreciate being taken for a drive and walk, maybe lunch in a café. (In retrospect I might see that I didn't know this at all – I just assumed so!) Instead I find her morose, not particularly welcoming, and am quickly saddled with sheets that needed washing and ironing. Into the heart of good-will, irritation insinuates itself quietly.

Oh that I could simply be aware of the irritation, or that my heart would go a step further

and choose compassion instead! Compassion for myself, in my disappointment and injured pride. Compassion for my neighbour trapped in bad humour. From that a gracious willingness to help may emerge, and in all likelihood we would both cheer up naturally.

But what if irritation sets itself up as master without my noticing? A supposedly helpful suggestion comes out as a barked order: „Don't do it that way“. My neighbour snaps back: "You're doing it all wrong, let go and I'll show you" and we both tighten into our respective knots of „my way“, glowering at one another. The kamma of ill-will has been set in motion and how hard it is to stop! Angry, self righteous thoughts storm through "She has no right to make me do this work... no wonder she gets so few visitors ... she hasn't a clue how to look after herself..." Somewhere in the midst might be a sinking shame for having let the visit deteriorate into a dog-fight. A recognition that I have let myself be caught in the powerful bind of self-centring. Once caught, how much effort it can take to refuse to tighten the smug binding of my way, my opinions versus her ridiculousness, her hopelessness. By comparison, shame's suggestion feels humiliating: that my neighbour is simply someone who I am rejecting in anger?

Sitting in meditation, memories like these come up. Letting go of thoughts, the body finds it easier to relax into shame than to tighten into self-righteousness. Perhaps that's what we mean by „body wisdom“ – our body can lead us to truth which our logic can deny. In time shame eases into forgiveness and a deeper commitment to good-will. Then,

when it comes to neighbourly visits that degenerate into dog-fights, I can no longer pretend there is no option but to stew in self-righteous anger. Eventually I might summon the energy for an embarrassed smile and an apology for having made a fuss. Very often this is rewarded by a kindly response, and we might both be relieved to find ourselves back in the happier, easier realm of friendliness.

Three ways I can extend the limits of good-will: Spot the untested assumptions which so easily creep into the heart of good-will, skewing thoughts towards my happiness rather than my neighbours. Strengthen mindfulness so that I spot irritation before it creates a tight familiar world of my way, my opinions etc and from which all intruders must be repelled. Turn away from that familiar world whenever I find myself defending it, groping my way towards an unfamiliar freedom where there are no intruders and nothing to defend.

Investigative Eating

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 12 min read

This extensive teaching uses eating meditation as a profound method for investigating the nature of desire, attachment, and suffering. Bhante Bodhidhamma explores how indulgence in food—and by extension all sensual pleasures—leads to five forms of suffering: attachment and compulsive behavior, frustration, grief, anxiety, and boredom. Drawing from the Brahmāyu Sutta (MN 91), he presents the Buddha's approach to eating with awareness but without greed.

The essay provides detailed practical instructions for tea and biscuit meditation, emphasizing three key distinctions: between body and mind (sensation versus emotion), between desire and action (the role of will), and between enjoying and indulging. Through careful attention to the processes of tasting, chewing, and swallowing, practitioners learn to experience pleasure without the overlay of excitement that characterizes indulgence.

The teaching includes specific reflections used at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat for mindful eating, along with traditional contemplations on gratitude, impermanence, and the support of spiritual practice. This approach transforms ordinary eating into a vehicle for developing wisdom, contentment, and freedom from the psychological dependencies that fuel suffering in all areas of life.

Eating Meditation

How bad can greed get?

Erysichthon, the Greek King of Thessaly, had the temerity to build a banqueting hall over the shrine

to Demeter, Goddess of Earth's fertility and protector of harvest.ⁱ She cursed him with insatiable

hunger. First, he ate everything there was to eat. Then he started on his people and even ate his own

family. Still famished he ate himself!

While I was staying at Kanduboda Meditation Centre in Sri Lanka, a man told me that once when out

in the wilds, he had got lost and over a period of a few days became so hungry that when he finally

caught a pigeon, he ripped it open and ate it raw. He was a meditator!

Hopefully, we will not have to suffer such extreme conditions.

Even so there are other good reasons to investigate of the process of eating:

To distinguish between enjoying and indulging

To distinguish between the body and mind, ie sensation from emotion/thought

To distinguish between a desire and an action: the role of will.

Distinguishing between enjoying and indulging.

We will want to distinguish between enjoying and indulging when we come to realise the suffering that

indulgence causes.

The first complication that arises from indulgence is attachment and compulsive behaviour. When we

indulge some unwholesome but pleasing habit, it means that we are using something to create a certain

mental state that we enjoy. It's not the biscuit we want, but the mental state it produces, be it happy or

comforting. But this also produces a dependency and just like any addict we are compelled to raid the

biscuit box. Only a strong act of will and refusal to have biscuits in the house can break the habit. It is

precisely at the time we renounce the biscuit that we suffer the strength of that habit and the hold it has

over us. But, of course, the potential is always there. Just as the person who gives up smoking and after a

long time thinks they are immune to becoming habituated, on surrendering at a party to have 'just one',

finds themselves buying a packet. That is, attachment is none other than a dependency on something or

indeed someone to create a mental state of happiness

The second suffering is frustration. Anger rises when we can't get what we want or what we have is denied

us. We live at a time of almost immediate gratification. Consider fast food! Amazon has spent millions on

delivery, knowing that to satisfy a customer as quickly as possible is to ensure their loyalty. 'You want some

beer (non-alcoholic!). We'll get it to you tomorrow morning!' We can even be angry with ourselves for

forgetting to buy tea or coffee. We get angry if the bus, the train, the taxi is late. We get angry if someone

doesn't turn up for a meeting. Frustration doesn't help. It just burns us.

The third is grief. The misery we feel if we have to diet! The shock we suffer when we

lose our mobile. The distress of leaving an expensive hat or bag behind at the restaurant, only to find it has 'disappeared'. But although we believe in possessing things, in reality we can only use them. If a thief has run off with our mobile, for all intents and purposes it is their mobile, no matter how much we keep moaning and complaining about the loss of 'my' mobile. And grief takes on a different intensity when we lose a spouse, a partner, a family member, a friend.

Fourthly, anxiety always sits beneath everything we possess. The run on flour, pasta and bewilderingly toilet paper at the start of lockdownii is driven by fear of what may or may not happen in the future. The more we possess the more we fear loss. And the more we have to possess to cushion any blow. A billion pounds to a billionaire are never enough. They must cushion it by moving to towards a trillion. We are afraid of loneliness so build up a coterie of friendships and lots of things to do. We feel insecure so we accumulate excessive insurance or power which manifest in controlling and bullying. Finally, there is boredom. If you remember, Mara, the Evil Tempter, the sensual life personified, sent his three daughters to inveigle the Buddha to return to the 'good life' – sensual pleasure, sexual pleasure and boredom. Boredom is that state where what once gave such pleasure and excitement is now stale, over-indulged and unpleasing. It is an aversive state and to escape it we seek some other pleasure. Variety is the spice of life is the basic motto of the consumerist. Consider the foodies' who chose their holidays depending on variety of restaurants. And just as all the other consequences of indulgence can become mental illnesses, boredom can drive you into depression. Indeed, what would be the purpose of living when there is nothing or anyone who can raise any degree of excitement. Here lies the distinction between happiness and excitement. True happiness is based of contentment.

Excitement that passes for true happiness is based on an insatiable appetite for the new and the thrill. This excitement is what fuels consumerism. The underlying engine is boredom, caused by a lack of excitement, that drives the consumer to seek relief in more excitement. This is none other than the psychology of addiction. Just as a drug addict feels normal when under the influence and abnormal when in need, so the consumer feels they have to buy something and go somewhere, do anything that excites no matter how little in order to feel 'happy'. Retail therapy is no therapy at all. It's an addiction. 'The Second Noble Truth of the Cause of Suffering is the insatiable thirst which generates moment to moment becoming, accompanied by obsessive indulgence, finding fresh excitement now here, now there, namely the insatiable hunger for sensual pleasures, for continued becoming and non-becoming.'

So what do we have to do?

Firstly, we need to make a clear distinction between the body and the mind, between on the one hand sensations and physical feelings and on the other hand the heart-mind - emotions and moods, thoughts and imagination. This is part of the endeavour to undermine the sense of self. That is the sense we have of being one entire, undivided integer; a single uncompounded being, whole and absolute. By drawing apart what the body does through the senses and what the heart-mind does, is to begin to realise that we are but a compound, made up of many pieces all depending on each other to create an embodied 'person'. We being to undermine this delusion: I am what I feel or think I am.

Secondly, we need to distinguish a desire from an action. This will give us that chink of freedom where we can change the conditioning we don't want to a conditioning we do want. Remember our personality is but a collection of habits and will always be so. Our work is to rid ourselves of habits that bring any degree of suffering and dissatisfaction and develop those that bring a sense of well-being. So long as there is only a desire, nothing has actually happened. It remains an idea

laced with the energy of
wanting. It arises out of a state of discomfort and is itself uncomfortable till gratified. If
we are fully aware
of a desire we will not be caught up in its demands, but will have the occasion to ask
whether it is
wholesome, whether it is beneficial to myself, to another or both myself and another. If
we determine it is
unwholesome, all we have to do is bear with the desire until it burns itself out. In so
doing, the habit that it
expresses is weakened and will eventually lose all power over us. If a desire is judged to
be wholesome,
then we empower it. It produces an act of body, speech or mind. This reinforces the
habit. In this quite
simple way we can change ourselves, though as we discover, it is not easy. We need a
highly alert
attentiveness, or we are quickly gratifying those habits we don't want and so
developing them.

Brahmayu Sutta MN 91.14 (Bhikkhu Bodhi) A passage describing how the Buddha
receives food and eats it.

Here is described what he experiences.

He takes the food experiencing the taste, though not experiencing greed for the taste.

In other words, just the pleasant sensations.

This is on occasion chanted by monastics at mealtimes:

The food he takes has eight factors: it is neither for amusements or for intoxication
(indulgence) or for the

sake of physical beauty and attractiveness, but only for the endurance and continuance
of his body, for

ending discomfort and assisting the holy (spiritual) life; he considers, 'Thus I shall
terminate old

(unwholesome) feelings without arousing new (unwholesome) ones and I shall be
healthy and blameless

and live in comfort.

(My brackets)

Attitude

An attitude is a way of relating. It is not specific to a particular object. So as we
undermine greed around

food, we are undermining all indulgence for the same psychology applies to everything
that delights us.

Whether it is a sensual pleasure, art, nature, even people and animals, the same problem of attachment arises. Once we have understood, I repeat, that attachment is a psychological dependency on some object or other for 'happiness', we begin to be more aware of other dependencies and slowly begin to let go of all obsessiveness.

The Buddha tells us 'The taste of Nibbana is freedom'. Freedom from unwholesome desires.

A warning! I once sat next to a monk whom by the look of him, you would presume a true ascetic – hollow cheeked and gaunt. When the delicious fruit salad and buffalo curd was offered, he placed it before him.

And while the other monks continued to eat, he simply stared at the bowl. As we were finishing, he picked up the bowl and as quick as lightening spooned it down his throat.

Now, of course I may be judging him very wrongly, but it seemed to me that he was afraid to enjoy the food for fear of indulging. Such an attitude if taken to all we enjoy would turn life into a sour grape. As

always in our spiritual practice we have to tread the narrow path between direct enemies and subtle

enemies of virtues. Here between indulgence and self-mortification. The pleasures and joys of life are a

human birth right. But they come and go like everything else. What are we actually holding onto?

In conclusion

Since our personality is made up of a compendium of habits, our psychotherapeutic task is to liberate

ourselves from their control, but not the habit itself when it is wholesome. After all we have to eat! So our

task when it concerns anything which is pleasurable and enjoyable, is to begin to experience what it is like

to enjoy and not indulge. Just enjoy!

Our insight task is to see clearly how we create suffering. Suffer the renunciation of unskillful desires. Arrive at unalloyed joy.

The Practice

Tea Break

The process of drinking a cup of tea and eating a biscuit. This is where biscuits can be a path to liberation

from all suffering! Noting words are suggested.

Distinguishing between the body and the mind

Sit with the tea and biscuits before you and feel the desire.

Remind yourself of how the food has come to be in your hands. Raise gratitude.

Intending to drink.

Take it slow and raise the cup to your lips. Lifting, lifting. Take a sip and hold it in the mouth to taste.

Tasting, tasting. Bury your attention into the taste, the feel of the tea.

Intending to swallow. Swallowing, swallowing. Stay with the whole process.

Then feel the afterglow. That's the mental state as a learnt reaction to taste of tea.

Comfort, comfort, or,

joy, joy.

Distinguishing desire from action

Take the biscuit. Holding, holding. What are you actually feeling? Hard, hard. What do you see? Round,

buff, beige?

Remind yourself of how the food has come to be in your hands. Raise gratitude.

Thankyou.

Feel the desire to take a bite. Stay with it. What is the feel of a desire? Desiring, desiring.

Know you could put it away into the tin. But don't give in to the desire for austerity! In this case eating the

biscuit is wholesome, a spiritual exercise.

Intending to nibble. and be aware of that moment of decision when the power of the will activates the

desire. Raising, raising (biscuit to the mouth)

Tasting, tasting. Follow through just tasting. The texture, the taste.

Become aware of the mental state. Happiness, happiness. Gratifying, gratifying.

Wait till the pleasant taste has all but gone and there is but a sloopy mush in the mouth.

What's the reaction? Disliking, disliking. Disgusting, disgusting.

Intending to swallow. Decide to swallow. Feel the afterglow. Happiness, happiness. ?

Distinguishing enjoying from indulging

Repeat until such times as there is just tasting, just swallowing. All the overlay of 'excitement' has gone.

Stay with the afterglow. Stay with whatever feelings arise?

Reflection

When finished, ask yourself – as I lost the excitement and equanimity replaced it, was I enjoying it as much?

Don't be surprised to find yourself saying you did not 'enjoy' as much. Therein lies Mara. The excitement comes from indulgence, but that brings the suffering.

The more we practice, letting go of indulgence, the more we will begin to appreciate just eating with equanimity. The more we will come to feel those indulgent feelings are gross.

A young man came to meditate with us at the Birmingham Buddhist Vihara. He returned the next week to tell us he couldn't listen to heavy rock anymore!

Seeking excitement is more often than not seeking the same experience that made us excited. If we had an amazing pizza, we would want a pizza that will give us the same 'wow factor'. It will distort the experience of the pizza we are eating. We will be laying on to the present pizza that memory of the 'amazing one'. We will both be disappointed, and we will fail to appreciate the pizza we have – which may have been an even better pizza. I remember this happening to me with sticky toffee pudding.

Mealtime at Satipanya

Reflections

Wisely reflecting, I eat this food not to indulge sensual pleasure or to seek comfort. Being mindful of every mouthful, I shall undermine unwholesome habits and develop appreciative joy. I eat only to sustain and nourish the body, thinking thus: I will allay hunger without overeating so that I may continue to live blamelessly and at ease.

This offering brings me health, long life, strength and happiness.

May the merits of my practice support the happiness, health, long life, rebirth in the heavenly realms and ultimately the Awakening of those who have kindly provided this food.

Mealtime Investigation

Reflection before eating:

the preciousness of human life : the singularity of the body
image passage of food – the tasting : the swallowing, the digesting and - the evacuation
how this is an opportunity to eat with appreciation and joy and not to indulge

Consider the food on your plate:

Mother Earth and her fruitfulness : the farmers and labourers

The distribution and workers : the cook and the donors

Food tastes so much sweeter for the honey of gratitude.

Continuing Investigation

Clear distinction between the physical process of tasting, chewing and swallowing from mental process of emotional feelings, comments, judgements – and desire.

Clear distinction between desire arising from natural appetite and desire arising from greed – seeking to develop a happy mental state dependent on tasting.

*Clear distinction between indulging and enjoying.

Reflections at the end of the meal.

Let gratitude arise again for the gift of food.

Goodbye! I shall not taste this food again ever.

This is one less meal I shall have to eat in this life.

Tips

Go slow! Relax! Take your time. The slower the more we see.

Do everything gently. Treat plate and cutlery as precious items.

Slowly : Gently : Quietly

The Buddha ‘takes his food experiencing the taste, though not experiencing greed for the taste’ M91.14

From Sutta Central : A.Sujato

When receiving rice, he holds the bowl neither too straight nor too bent, neither too close nor too loose.

So odanaṃ paṭiggaṇhanto na pattaṃ unnāmeti, na pattaṃ onāmeti; na pattaṃ sannāmeti, na pattaṃ vināmeti.

He receives neither too little nor too much rice.

So odanaṃ paṭiggaṇhāti nātithokaṃ nātibahuṃ.

He eats sauce in a moderate proportion, and doesn’t spend too much time saucing his portions.

Byañjanaṃ kho pana bhavaṃ gotamo byañjanamattāya āhāreti, na ca byañjanena ālopaṃ a tināmeti.

He chews over each portion two or three times before swallowing.

Dvattikkhattuṃ kho bhavaṃ gotamo mukhe ālopaṃ samparivattetvā ajjhoharati;

But no grain of rice enters his body unchewed, and none remain in his mouth.

na cassa kāci odanamiñjā asambhinnā kāyaṃ pavisati, na cassa kāci odanamiñjā

mukhe ava

siṭṭhā hoti;

Only then does he raise another portion to his lips.

athāparaṃ ālopaṃ upanāmeti.

He eats experiencing the taste, but without experiencing greed for the taste.

Rasapaṭisaṃvedī kho pana so bhavaṃ gotamo āhāraṃ āhāreti, no ca rasarāgapapaṭisaṃvedī.

He eats food thinking of eight reasons:

Aṭṭhaṅgasamannāgataṃ kho pana so bhavaṃ gotamo āhāraṃ āhāreti—

‘Not for fun, indulgence, adornment, or decoration, but only to sustain this body, to avoid

harm, and to support spiritual practice. In this way, I shall put an end to old discomfort and

not give rise to new discomfort, and I will live blamelessly and at ease.’

neva davāya, na madāya na maṇḍanāya na vibhūsanāya, yāvadeva imassa kāyassa ṭhitiyā y

āpanāya, vihiṃsūparatiyā brahmacariyānuggahāya: ‘iti purāṇaṇca vedanaṃ paṭi-
haṅkhāmi

navaṇca vedanaṃ na uppādessāmi, yātrā ca me bhavissati anavajjatā ca phāsuvihāro
cā’ti.

i The Romans also honoured her as Ceres (cereal).

ii For a deeper reason concerning the connection between faeces and death: The Denial
of Death by Ernest Becker

Nibbāna is Close at Hand!

Noirin Sheahan · 2 min read

This essay examines the Buddha's initial reluctance to teach after his Awakening, revealing profound insights about the nature of liberation. Noirin Sheahan draws on the Buddha's own experiences to challenge romanticized notions of transcendence, showing how even after Awakening, the Buddha remained fully human—concerned about frustration, aging, and physical pain. The essay explores how true wisdom manifests not as detached bliss, but through the brahmavihāras (divine abodes): mettā (loving-kindness), karuṇā (compassion), muditā (appreciative joy), and upekkhā (equanimity). Rather than delivering us from worldly concerns, liberation deepens our sensitivity and connection to others. The Buddha's equanimity when facing rejection of his teachings, and his joy (muditā) in witnessing others' spiritual progress, demonstrate how Awakening transforms rather than eliminates human experience. The essay concludes with the powerful insight that Nibbāna is not separate from ordinary life but represents 'ordinary life known for what it is'—a knowing that accompanies us through daily decisions and life's inevitable changes.

Nibanna is Close at Hand!

As you may know, when the Buddha became enlightened he first thought that there was no point in trying to teach others how to follow in his footsteps. He felt that the enlightened understanding he had achieved was so subtle, so hard to see, that nobody would be able to understand him and teaching would only be frustrating. It was the Dhamma teacher Rob Burbea (now sadly deceased) who pointed out the irony – the Buddha's first thought as an enlightened being was to avoid getting frustrated!

This irony challenges simplistic notions of transcendence. The Buddha's wisdom protects him from suffering because he knows better than to identify with his body or mind. But this does not make him careless of what happens to his body, indifferent to the contents of his mind. Carelessness and indifference don't appear to be options for an enlightened being. Transcendence only manifests in some form of goodwill – friendliness, compassion, appreciative joy or equanimity.

The latter quality, equanimity, comes to our rescue when life disappoints or frustrates us. The Buddha only undertook the hard work of teaching after being persuaded that there were some who would understand and follow in his footsteps. Disappoint-

ment at those who rejected his teaching could then be offset by knowing the immense value of his work overall. And so the Buddha could remain equanimous when people disputed, dismissed or scorned his teaching.

The joy of seeing that some people were able to accept, work with, and at times even to understand his teaching would also have been an enormous support to the Buddha's mission. This is a form of *mudita*: appreciating the potential for liberation as he sees it manifesting, taking shape, affecting change, in another being.

Going back to his earlier reluctance to tire himself out by attempting the seemingly hopeless task of teaching: The incident reminds us of the humanity of the Buddha. He never claimed to be anything other than a normal human being and as we see here, took care to minimize distress for himself even after enlightenment. As an old man, close to death, the Buddha describes his body as wracked in pain from morning to night. He says this in response to Ananda's request that he prolong his life for the sake of all those he could help. This story too shows us that the Buddha was not superhuman and was deeply cognizant of his aging body and physical limitations. He was not operating from a lofty blissful plane outside of his feeble and painful body.

These incidents from the life of the Buddha remind us not expect that liberation will deliver us to a state of bliss where we're oblivious to the problems of the world. Instead we grow ever more sensitive, feel our connection with others more keenly.

It also reminds us not to imagine Nibanna as separate to ordinary daily life. Nibanna is close at hand! Perhaps we could imagine it as a knowing which is in intimate contact with humanity, accompanying us through decisions on how to live and what livelihood to follow and when to relinquish our hold on life.

Ordinary life, in other words. Known for what it is.

Quench all Resentments

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 3 min read

This essay draws from Buddhaghosa's 5th-century masterwork, the Visuddhimagga (Path of Purification), to offer systematic methods for dissolving resentment and anger. Bhante Bodhidhamma presents nine progressive techniques beginning with cultivating mettā (loving-kindness) toward those who have hurt us, recognizing their good qualities, and developing compassion for those who seem to lack redeeming features.

The teaching explores deeper contemplations including reflection on kamma—understanding that all beings inherit the consequences of their actions without need for our punishment—and considering past-life connections through rebirth perspective. When gentler approaches fail, the essay introduces analytical meditation techniques that deconstruct the object of resentment through elemental analysis, revealing the insubstantial nature of what we resist.

Grounded in the Kakacūpama Sutta's radical teaching about maintaining loving-kindness even when 'bandits brutally severed limb from limb with a two-handled saw,' this practical guide acknowledges the challenging nature of forgiveness while providing concrete steps for transformation. The essay concludes with the powerful practice of generous giving to former adversaries and emphasizes applying these same techniques to self-resentment, offering a comprehensive approach to emotional purification essential for meditation practice.

Resentment burns. Old wounds smoulder in the heart. Fantasies of revenge fan to flames. And the desire for vengeful acts, retaliation, becomes more and more violent. Sometimes we shock ourselves at the fierceness of our imaginations and then quickly suppress them and with them the blazing. And this malevolence begins to manifest in more subtle ways, such as the passive aggression of sarcasm. The Path of Purification was written by Buddhaghosa in the 5th Century CE. My teacher told me I had in my hand the whole of Theravada Buddhism[i]. It is considered one of the great spiritual manuals of all religions. It is not a book you would want to read from page to page, but to dip in when needed. This is a summary of an extensive section of how to dissolve resentment at Chapter IX 14[ii]. The first remedy is to develop metta towards the person who has hurt us. This would begin perhaps by not dwelling on the person's negative characteristics. In this way we can undermine the anger and develop patience, which is the willingness to bear with the unpleasant and not to react with ill-will. 'If bandits

brutally severed limb from limb with a two handled saw, he who entertains hatred in his heart on that account, would not be one who carries out my teaching' M i 129 Tall order! If that approach fails to dampen, then bring to mind the person's good qualities. I remember my niece when she about five telling her father how she could not stand her brother. He reminded her that he makes her laugh. There was a moment of recognition and she went away happy! Everyone has a good side that can be appreciated. But writes, Buddhaghosa, failing all that, if the person has no redeeming qualities, then they are deserving of our compassion. If this approach fails, then consider the damage resentment is doing to us. Such negative mental states, when we dwell on them as feeling, are very unpleasant – hot agitation. And, of course, the chemicals produced are not doing the body any good either. Seemingly it takes 90 seconds for the chemicals caused by anger to dissolve once we are patient. Hence count ten ... slowly! Failing that, then the reflection on kamma: All beings are the owners of their actions (kamma), heirs of their actions, born from their actions, related to their actions, and have actions as their refuge. Whatever action they do, whether good or evil, they will inherit its results. In other words, we suffer the consequences of all our actions – good and bad. There is no need to punish. And, of course, this leads to a reflection on our own past unkind, perhaps callous behaviour. We would not want people to bear grudges against us. From a rebirth point of view, that person may have been a parent of ours in a past life. The Buddha says we would not repay our parents even if we carried them on our shoulders throughout our lives, such are the gifts we have received from them. According to rebirth theory, groups have been revolving around each other throughout countless lifetimes. If even now, resentful feelings are not soothed, then bring to mind the blessings of Metta, Loving Kindness, one of which is good sleep. How exhausting it is to wake up in the middle of the night, the heart burning with resentment. Still finding it difficult to let go, a more subtle contemplation is to ask what is it I actually resent? Breaking the person up into parts – is it the hair? The knees? And so on. Seeing the person through the Elements of Earth (solidity), Water (fluidity, elasticity), Fire (heat and cold) or Air (movement). In other words, by dissecting the person, one finds there is nothing solid, substantial to be angry with. When all has failed, finally, most difficult, buy the person a present! An act of generous forgiveness is a powerful way to douse the flames. All these techniques can be used where we see resentment towards ourselves. [iii] An exercise: list all resentments towards others and ourselves. Work your way through them. It takes time. May all our resentments dissolve into generous patience and caring benevolence! [i] [i] there is also Venerable Sariputta's advice: Getting rid of Resentment and the Buddha: Getting rid of Resentment. [ii] This essay complements Towards the End of Forgiveness [iii] A poem on self-forgiveness by Dilruba Ahmed: Phase One

Sacrifice: The More We Give, the Greater the Return

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 2 min read

This teaching examines sacrifice as both a universal spiritual principle and the heart of the Buddhist path to awakening. Bhante Bodhidhamma traces the concept from its Latin origins through various religious traditions to its profound meaning in Buddhism, where true sacrifice transforms from personal renunciation into selfless offering for all beings.

Drawing on the Buddha's own journey, the essay explores how the future Buddha's Great Renunciation became the Great Sacrifice when his quest shifted from personal liberation to awakening for all humanity. The teaching emphasizes that it was the pāramī of generosity (dāna-pāramī) that gave the Bodhisatta the spiritual authority to seek full liberation, as witnessed by the Earth Goddess during his final confrontation with Māra.

The practical application begins with encouraging small sacrifices for worthy causes—spiritual charities, social welfare, animal protection, and environmental care. These prepare us for the ultimate sacrifice: relinquishing hope of lasting happiness in the sensual world. The essay connects everyday acts of giving, including family sacrifices, to the spiritual path, showing how generosity and letting go cultivate the courage needed for complete renunciation and the greater happiness of Nibbāna.

Sacrifice comes from two Latin words – sacer : sacred and facere : to make. One sacrifices to a god to propitiate the deity or to ask a favour. At the time of the Buddha, there were huge ritual slaughters of horses and cattle in the King's sacrifice. Abraham offered his son to the harsh desert God who softened. Christ is said to be the 'blood of the lamb', the sacrifice of his own life for the benefit of all human beings. Sacrifice then is an offering of something we treasure for a higher cause. It is the point where generosity demands great courage and conviction. 'No greater gift has man than to offer his life for another'. It is said of arahats, those who are fully liberated, that they engender an inestimable field of merit. The power of their goodness is limitless. This is the meaning of puñña, merit. Just the very fact that they have arrived at that station of non-suffering, Nibbana, makes real the aim for all. Once Everest was conquered, it becomes climbable. To become fully liberated we have to give up everything - eventually. And we are asked to give up everything on a promise. We don't know what the outcome will be. We trust on hearsay. However, we do gain confidence as the Path becomes clearer through our practice. But it is always going to be in the end a leap of faith. A faith that sacrificing

everything we treasure will bring a boundless return. Few have the qualities it takes to go give up everything immediately as did the Bodhisatta when he left home. This is why it is called the Great Renunciation. And it is so called because it was a personal quest. However, at the point of the Great Doubt, as it is put metaphorically, Mara, the Evil One, approached and asked him who he thought he was to seek such a goal as full liberation. When the Bodhisatta then called upon the Earth Goddess to witness his right, it was the Parami, the Perfection of Generosity she says that gave him the right to seek full liberation. What had been Renunciation now became Sacrifice for he was no longer doing it for himself but for all humankind. So let's start small. There are so many causes in the world that we can give something up for. There are all the spiritual charities that aim to heal our deepest dis-ease. There are all the social charities to alleviate suffering. There are all the charities that try and do something about the enormous suffering we cause animals by way of greed. And there's mother earth. What will we sacrifice for her? Letting go of something we really treasure is hard. It may be wealth or time. Even the situation we are in at present may call upon us. Parents are often called upon to make sacrifices for their children. Children called upon to look after ageing parents. These are also paths to liberation. Every time we give something that demands a sacrifice we are preparing ourselves for the greatest of all sacrifices: letting go of any hope of achieving a lasting happiness in the sensual world. Only when we have accomplished this can the greater happiness arrive. There's a saying in Italian 'che va piano va lontano' – who goes slow, goes far. Bodhisatta in Theravada Buddhism is someone who determines to become a fully self-enlightened Buddha. There are said to be four such monks in Sri Lanka at this present time.

The Years – Where Do They Go? New Year Encouragement

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 2 min read

This contemplative essay explores the profound spiritual significance of endings, drawing parallels between the close of a calendar year and the cessation of breath in meditation practice. Noirin Sheahan examines how we typically avoid acknowledging endings, rushing instead toward what comes next, and suggests that conscious awareness of cessation can become a doorway to deeper understanding. The teaching connects breath meditation practice – particularly the moment when breathing stops and dissolves into stillness – with the Buddha's instruction to observe the transient nature of all conditioned phenomena. The essay addresses the challenge of remaining present with 'gone-ness' without immediately filling that space with mental commentary or conceptual understanding. Drawing from the traditional Vipassana verses about the happiness found in cessation, this reflection encourages practitioners to discover peace in natural endings, whether in formal meditation or in life's seasonal rhythms. The practical application extends to finding rest and acceptance in winter's quietness rather than constantly projecting forward to future plans and activities.

The years – where do they go? December - short days, darkness, winter solstice. Pull on a woolly hat, draw the curtains. Another year is coming to its end. We tend to ignore endings. We're probably thinking more of Christmas and New Year than of 2019 drawing to a close. But we're ignoring a hidden treasure. All the effort we had to make during the year – getting through work deadlines, projects, smoothing out relationship troubles, working through the budget – all these are drawing to a close. Shouldn't we take a moment to savour that? If we make an effort to let 2019 go, then we'll be much more conscious of what to take up again in 2020. The Buddha asks us to be conscious of endings. In formal practice we endeavour to track the breath to its end, to that moment when the movement vanishes into stillness. At the most obvious level, there's nothing to this. It's just that a movement has stopped. It doesn't signify anything. But when we follow the breath closely, detect each sensation, notice them getting fainter and fainter till they disappear, it can be a different matter. That 'gone-ness' can appear highly significant, mysterious. We were looking at sensations, now what are we looking at? It's the same as looking back over the years and thinking "Where did they all go?" Nature abhors a vacuum and our tendency is to fill that mysterious emptiness with thoughts, distractions, musings. But if we can still the mind towards around the end of the breath, we find that part of us wants to rest, to explore whatever remains where sensations

stopped. The trouble is that we can't name it. Even the word 'absence' misses the mark. The name attempts to capture its essence, make it known. But in the process, destroys it. The name injects sensations, feelings, thoughts where there were none. Frustrating! The mind wants to know what it's dealing with, give it a name. But with practice we notice something within us settling, accepting non-ownership. We learn to allow experience to vanish without casting our mental net of thoughts and words and ideas around that vanishing. The last line from the Vipassana verses starts to make sense: "Truly all conditioned things are transient ... once arisen they disappear; their cessation is happiness." We can discover peace in endings at other levels in life. Like now, December, the ending of the year. Instead of filling all spare moments with Christmas plans, thinking about the New Year, looking forward to spring, we can savour the dark evenings, bare trees, notice the quietness, see nature at rest. Could we follow her lead, let ourselves rest for a moment, our work for 2019 done?

There is a Body: Exploring the Mind-Body Relationship

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 3 min read

This essay by Noirin Sheahan explores a specific meditation exercise from the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10) - noting 'there is a body' during formal sitting practice. What might seem like stating the obvious becomes a profound investigation into the nature of embodied experience and our relationship with the physical form. Through detailed exploration of her own meditation experience, Sheahan demonstrates how this simple noting practice can lead to profound insights about identification, ownership, and the complex interdependence between mind and body. The essay traces the journey from initial questioning through uncertainty, tension, and changing perceptions, revealing how the body can be experienced as both intimate and other; familiar yet not truly 'mine.' This practice from the Buddha's teachings offers a practical method for healing our often troubled relationship with our physical nature. Rather than taking the miracle of biological existence for granted or trying to escape into mental fantasy, the exercise cultivates objective awareness and gratitude for the body's stability and function. The essay speaks to both the challenge and necessity of our embodied existence, showing how mindful attention can transform our understanding of the mind-body relationship and point toward freedom from the suffering caused by identification with what is ultimately impermanent and not-self.

One of the exercises given in the Satipatthana Sutta (often considered the most important of the Buddha's teachings because it guides us along a 'direct path' to liberation and is suited to both lay and monastic practitioners) is to note: "There is a body" while sitting in formal meditation. This might provoke the thought "Of course there's a body, I'm sitting here, what's the point in stating the obvious?" A perfectly reasonable question. But remember we're in formal meditation, so questions are just another thing to be aware of. So we note "questioning ... questioning" and explore the experience of questioning. What flavours do we find here? The flavour of uncertainty perhaps? That's one I find quite easily in meditation – at least one thing I can usually count on! Changing the noting word to "Unsure ... unsure..." I get a new view of experience. I notice a pinch of tension in my neck. Focussing there, the tension relaxes showing me uncertainty's nebulous aspect. Clouds of doubt may seem to be puffing out of the body. Where am I in all this strangeness? Sometimes I seem to be centred in one or other of the puffing clouds. Sometimes I seem to be lured back inside the tissues of the body. The noting words might change to "heaviness ... heaviness ..." as I register the earthy nature of the body.

The closer I get, the more certain I feel. Something seems reliable at last. For a moment...For a moment I know the hardness and heaviness of the bones in the arms, the back, the legs, the skull, and then uncertainty creeps in again: Whose arms? ... There seem to be arms hanging from my shoulders as usual. And if I try, I can lift them. But the notion 'my arms' doesn't seem to fit. The phrase "There is a body" comes back to mind and now finds resonance. This no longer seems to be stating the obvious, but a lifeline, a way of making sense of a strange and unsettling situation. Knowing the body objectively as fostered by the phrase "there is a body", I sense gratitude for its stability, its powers of movement; for the life it offers, moment after moment. And yet it is, in this moment at least, quite obviously not me, not mine. Another question arises: How can something so close, so intimate, so necessary, be other than me and mine? In answer, fear and aversion displace gratitude, compete for dominance, struggle to proclaim their story. But neither can get a lasting grip on the situation; the body simply breathes through them. It takes no notice, bless it! The body-mind relationship is complex. At times we identify with the body, at other times with some aspect of the mind: feelings, perceptions, habits, consciousness. Its like being made up of a squabbling committee! And yet all our complex mental life, our hopes, fears, ambitions, dreams – all depend on their being a body breathing away quietly in the background, heart pumping, stomach digesting, feet walking. In our delusion, we take this miracle of biology totally for granted. Not a healthy way of relating to our earthly nature. The Satipatthana exercise of noting "there is a body" gives us a practical way of healing the mind-body relationship. Like all intimate relationships, the mind-body one is a challenge. Who likes being totally dependent? And yet here we are, till death do us part, tied up within an unreliable body, full of blood, sweat and tears, liable to pain at any moment, prone to illness, growing older and less able day by day. No wonder the mind tries to deny such an unedifying relationship, escape into fantasy! Luckily the body holds no grudges. And luckily, greed, hatred and delusion are no more permanent and reliable than any other state of mind. Within the gaze of mindfulness, the body is the perfect partner. It puts a limit on fantasies of hope and fear, allows delusion free reign to express displeasure at the chains of mortality. When the storm abates, its there, ready to get on with the practicalities of life. Try the exercise sometime: sit in meditation and note "There is a body". Let the reflection take you on whatever merry-go-round it likes, trusting this as the Buddha's suggestion for how we find freedom from suffering as we heal our mind-body relationship.

Building a Raft to Cross the Floods of Sensuality and Views

Noirin Sheahan · 39 min

In this retreat talk, Noirin Sheahan presents the Buddha's teaching of the raft as a vivid metaphor for spiritual practice in challenging circumstances. Drawing from the Alagaddūpama Sutta (MN 22), she explains how the four floods—sensuality, becoming, views, and ignorance—sweep us away from spiritual stability, and how we can construct makeshift rafts from the Noble Eightfold Path to reach safety.

The teaching offers practical guidance for working with difficult emotions and situations both in meditation and daily life. Noirin provides detailed examples of how to apply mindfulness, right speech, and the brahmavihāra when caught in heated debates or struggling with low moods during retreat. She emphasizes that we don't need to be spiritual experts to begin practice—we simply gather whatever 'grass, twigs, and branches' of Dhamma understanding we possess.

The talk beautifully illustrates how temporary periods of ease in practice represent reaching the 'far shore,' while our identification with body, personality, and life story keeps us trapped on the 'perilous near shore.' Noirin's teaching is both deeply practical and inspiring, showing how even our most undignified spiritual struggles can become opportunities for liberation when approached with wisdom and compassion.

Last night, we spoke of the spiritual faculties, which are the strengths that develop from our spiritual practice and which help us combat difficulties in formal meditation and daily life. The teaching known as The Raft is related to this theme, and that's what I'd like to talk about tonight.

While the spiritual faculties help us reflect on and value the strengths we're building up, the teaching on the raft suggests how to put these to work in tricky situations. So it's a different perspective. In fact, all the Buddha's teachings are saying the same thing from slightly different perspectives. This one tackles the dynamic and powerful challenges we come across in life and gives us a vivid and quite undignified image for how we might somehow scrabble our way through.

The Sutta describes someone following a path that leads to a shore that is perilous and risky, owing to a great flood of water. Across the water he sees another shore where the ground is safe and secure. The Buddha then says, "The thought would occur to him:

What if I were to gather grass, twigs, branches and leaves, and having bound them together to make a raft, were to cross over to safety on the other shore, independence on the raft, making an effort with my hands and feet?" So he builds the raft and makes it to the other shore.

Then there is the question of what to do with the raft. He's tempted to take it with him, but according to the Buddha, that's a mistake. After pondering the question for a while, he has the thought, "Why don't I, having dragged it on dry land or sinking it in the water, go wherever I like?" That, according to the Buddha, is the right decision.

In another Sutta, the various symbols are explained. The great expanse of water stands for the fourfold flood. The raft stands for the noble eightfold path. The near shore stands for self-identity while the far shore stands for unbinding.

Identifying with our normal limited sense of self is our problem on the near shore. When we believe we're confined within our body and mind, and expressed by a personality and described in our life story, then we're on perilous ground. At any moment our body can fall ill or die. Our personality can let us down when we get a shock or get depressed, and can wither away altogether through Alzheimer's or other diseases. We might suffer some calamity which makes a mockery of all we achieved and so our personal story becomes one of failure.

On the far shore we know we are not confined within our body, mind, personality or life history. So we can look on our physical, mental or social troubles with tender compassion but without distress. The ultimate unbinding happens when we're fully enlightened. But for the moment, we can think of the far shore as those temporary periods of ease in our practice, when we've worked our way through some hindrance and are now at ease.

To get to the far shore, we have to cross the expanse of water, the fourfold flood. In essence, these are the hindrances again, but from a different perspective. The hindrances describe the energetic manifestation of our troubles, without reference to any background story that may be prompting desire, aversion, restlessness, etc. This is an especially useful way to view these in meditation, where we're looking at moment-to-moment experience.

The floods describe these same troubles but in broader terms rather than momentary energies. They describe what we identify with in life. Thus, the floods are related to the *khandas*, and the first flood, termed the flood of sensuality, overlaps with the first *khandha*, termed the body.

The *khandhas* describe our identities in terms that encourage us to tease things out at the deep level we can sometimes achieve within the steady focus of *vipassanā*. It's often termed a deconstruction of our sense of self. This microscopic focus is powerful, but can seem puzzling or academic from our normal perspective. In order to facilitate our practice at times when we don't have so much calm objectivity, we have the image of a fourfold flood as a way to tease out the problems that come from identifying with aspects of our life.

The first three are the floods of sensuality, becoming and views. Underlying these three, we have the fourth one, the flood of ignorance.

We get swept away by the flood of sensuality whenever we indulge sense pleasure mindlessly, whether it be for food, sex, music, material goods, intoxicants, whatever the material world can offer by way of pleasure and escapism. This flood also drowns us when we are upset by the unattractive nature of the material world. Hunger, thirst and physical pain are our primary fears here, but we also deplore noise, ugliness, stinks and so on.

We might not think of ourselves as sensual. Perhaps we're more cerebral, easily absorbed by computers or books or abstract ideas, but not very interested in food or music or sex or whether the house is painted red or green or what the wallpaper looks like. Thus, we might think that sensuality is one flood we don't have to worry about. But our cerebral function depends on being warm and healthy and having food to eat. If we're cold or hungry, we won't be able to think straight or with any pleasure. It's only when we get a meal inside us and are tucked up in front of a warm fire that we'll feel like ourselves again, able to engage happily with our book or computer.

So even if we don't take much notice of sense pleasures, we're depending on them to let our minds pursue their cerebral pleasures and there inform that all-important sense of me. As such, we're at risk from the floods of sensuality whenever our basic needs for food and warmth are not met, when any of our senses fail or when our body is wracked with pain.

The next flood, termed becoming, sweeps us away when we identify with our personal history and its projection into the future. It seems so obvious that we were the child we remember from our school days and that we will be the older person who will bear our name and passport tomorrow. In the steady gaze of *vipassanā*, this illusion can sometimes be seen through. We sense a mass of changing sensations, thoughts, moods, but no central control headquarters to call me.

But the belief in ourselves as a personal identity has been taken for granted throughout our lives and forms the basis for almost all our thoughts. And so the illusion of self returns again and again, both on and off the cushion. We are then prey to floods of regret for the past as well as worry about the future. How will I get everything done? Will I succeed in my career? Will people respect me? Does anyone love me?

That's not to say we can ignore our personal history and its likely course in the future. Life is a precious opportunity for liberation and unless we look after the unenlightened person we appear to be just now, we won't be able to liberate that person from suffering. That can mean looking after our career, our good name, our family and so on. The raft formed from the *anattā* perspective lets us do all this without worrying and obsessing over our future or regretting our past.

Another flood comes when we attach to views and opinions. How many of us can have a completely calm, rational discussion about politics or religion, abortion or euthanasia? If we've no opinion, that makes it easy. But perhaps we've chosen non-committal as a way of avoiding hurt if our views were rejected. And even if we can ignore these somewhat abstract questions, we'll probably have a cherished opinion on how to hang wallpaper or how to cook the best Christmas pudding. So the flood can sweep us away when someone dismisses our opinions on these matters and we feel small, hurt and disrespected.

Finally, and underlying all of these, we have the flood of ignorance. That term is often used insultingly, but here it means that we don't know how to make ourselves happy. Happiness comes when we live from the perspective of the Four Noble Truths. While ignorance means that we don't fully understand these, so we're looking for happiness in all the wrong places. We're assuming the next romance will make us happy or becoming a millionaire. That should do the trick. Basically, we get swept away by the first three floods because we're already drifting in the flood of ignorance.

It's worth reminding ourselves that we don't have to know everything in order to be free from suffering. We only have to understand the four noble truths. We can be quite ignorant about biology, music and gardening and still be perfectly happy. We might not know the best way to organise people or the best decisions to make in our life.

The Buddha's first sermon was a complete failure. The person walked away after the Buddha's attempt to describe his enlightened state. So the Buddha wasn't omniscient. He could make mistakes. He had to experiment and see what worked. The only mistake he could never make after enlightenment was to let desire cause suffering.

Unlike the Buddha, here we are on our perilous shoreline. One moment it feels secure, the next it's collapsing like quicksand. The water in front of us is treacherous. But in the distance we see another shore that's stable and secure. This gives us the spark of faith we need to get started. It gets us looking around for materials that could make a raft.

And to be honest, they don't look promising. Grass and twigs and branches and leaves. The grass I can only imagine is long reed-like stems that could be used to bind twigs and branches together. Flimsy, makeshift, rickety fragile. That is the image the Buddha is giving us for our raft. It takes courage to set out at all. This means that we don't have to be experts before we start practising. We just use whatever bits of information or skill we have and get stuck in.

And don't expect the ride to be easy. It's not a cruise ship we're on. It's a very flimsy raft. We're spread-eagled on it, just barely clear of the floodwaters, paddling through these using our hands and feet. I think this is a great image to console us for the very unedifying picture we get of ourselves as we scramble our Dharma practice together in the midst of a crisis.

At times we'll probably lose sight of the far shore. To tell us whether we're still going the right direction, we have another water metaphor the Buddha gives for spiritual practice: swimming upstream. We're always going against the current of the floods, against the habitual desires of our conditioning. Whatever we don't want to do, that's what we need to do. If we want to gobble our dinner, we need to slow down. If we want to sink into despair, that's when we need to find some reason to be hopeful. Even when we can't see where we're heading, we can detect the direction that desire is sweeping us and work against that strong current.

Somehow we make it across. We're on that wonderful beach, safe and sound. Our little raft has done its job. We're naturally delighted with it. We might also be attached to it, thinking we might need it again, for who knows what the next shoreline will look like. And we might be justifiably proud of it and want it as a trophy, to show people how clever we were in getting across the stormy sea. So we're tempted to hoist it on our shoulder and take it with us on our journey. But according to the Buddha, this isn't wise. We're to leave our beloved raft behind.

This tells us that we can't cling to any aspect of the Noble Eightfold Path. Just because we practiced right speech in a tricky situation, we shouldn't think of ourselves as experts. It is so tempting to think, okay, I've learned that lesson, I'll never make that

mistake again. But then to our utter dismay, we fall back into the same trap. The conditioning that pulls us into the floods goes deep and we have to relearn the Dharma, make a new raft in each new situation.

But it's also fair to say that we get better at finding materials for our raft and more skilled in binding these together, more sensitive to the flow of the current. Also our muscles develop so we can paddle more vigorously. And we gain more and more confidence that we will, at some stage, make it to the other shore. So we're willing to venture out in ever more skimpy rafts.

Let's look at a practical example. Suppose you had a really rough morning's meditation here at Satipanya. You've lost any confidence you ever had regarding meditation. All morning your mind kept wandering. By the 11 a.m. meditation you were totally fed up. Again and again you woke up to find yourself in the middle of a long moan about how hopeless things are. When the bell goes for lunch, you just want to gobble it all up and dive into bed for an hour.

What floods are at work here? We're unhappy and don't know how to make ourselves happy. That summarises our basic problem in life. Unhappiness at base stems from not understanding the Four Noble Truths. So we're adrift in the flood of ignorance. Lunch and bed represent sense pleasures. So the flood of sensuality is flowing over the flood of ignorance. And with a bit of luck, the pleasures of food and being stretched out on a warm bed will let us forget our troubles for a while.

But at what cost do we enter this flood? One episode of laziness might not do too much harm. But the trouble is that the next time you're feeling low, you'll want to gobble your lunch twice as fast and sleep for twice as long. If this goes on, then pretty soon you won't return for the afternoon shift at all. And then you'll feel even more rotten and depressed. Basically, the current starts off gently, but pulls us into ever faster currents that sweep us further and further from the shore.

So where can we find materials for our raft? First and foremost, we have mindfulness. We can acknowledge that we're fed up and miserable. Sounds easy, but the temptation to ignore our moods can be strong. We need a steady practice to work mindfully with bad moods such as this.

To start making a raft, you could resolve to spend a few minutes in mindful acknowledgement of the bad mood. In theory, this is what you've been doing all morning, but sometimes we lose sight of the broader picture in our effort to still the mind in medita-

tion. As we relax when the bell goes, and as we're walking toward the lunchroom, that broader awareness might actually be the first real acknowledgement of how low your mood has descended.

Acknowledging the bad humour changes the situation radically and with this broader awareness it is worth re-entering the gaze of *vipassanā* for another few minutes. You could do this while sitting at table after serving yourself your lunch, noting the mood and feeling the bodily sensations associated with it. Even one minute will make a huge difference. Although you might still feel low, you will feel much better for having taken the time and trouble to acknowledge the mood mindfully. You might even make it all the way to the far shore and feel hopeful about your meditation practice again.

Vipassanā practice will always make a really good raft. But suppose you can't muster the energy for this. Just like it was doing all morning, your mind gets sucked into negative thoughts the moment you decide to do a minute's practice at the dining room table. Instead of *vipassanā*, you could choose mindful eating as the framework for your raft, noting all the physical sensations.

For extra buoyancy, you could pick up some *mettā*. You could wish yourself well as you cut up a potato. As you're chewing this, you can wish that the meal will cheer you up. If your mood lightens, you could add in *muditā*, appreciating the meal and congratulating yourself for having looked after yourself well in a tricky situation.

Now suppose wishing ourselves well seems forced and contrived and puts us in even worse humour. In that case, compassion could be more appropriate, starting off by acknowledging that we're having a really bad time. It often helps to express sympathy with a gesture, perhaps a hand on the heart. The phrase, "may I be free from suffering," or "may I be free from anger and ill will," could feel more congruent than *mettā* good wishes. This is to work very tenderly with ourselves. If we can also be patient, not expecting ourselves to cheer up anytime soon, we can be assured that this is a very genuine part of our spiritual practice.

But if it's one of those times when we're too low or fed up for self-compassion, we could try to pick up some equanimity for our raft with a phrase like, "may I not make things worse for myself?"

If that stems the flow of negativity for a moment, we could add some other bits of wisdom. A phrase like "this too will pass" reminds us of *anicca*. No matter how we decide to work with bad humour, we've avoided the temptation to gobble and dive into bed. So we're buoying up our raft with renunciation.

When the Buddha first thought of a life of renunciation, he noticed, "my heart did not leap up with joy." We find it much easier to be enthusiastic about *mettā*, compassion, mindfulness and so on than renunciation. Deferring pleasure isn't easy, especially as we've no control over when and if any rewards will come through. But I'm sure you'll agree that you would feel immeasurably better for having worked mindfully with a bad humour than if you'd given in to all its demands.

Although the thought of renunciation doesn't make our hearts leap with joy, the practice of it brings a freedom. We realise we don't have to be controlled by our moods or obsessions. Such a relief. A soupsong of *Nibbāna*.

But if the flood of sensuality sweeps us off our feet and we're already gobbling our dinner, we could try making a supreme effort and note "indulging, indulging." Can we feel any of the pleasure this is giving? If so, can we focus on this as we eat? You could call it mindful gobbling. A rickety raft for sure, but if it keeps us present, it's doing its job.

It's also possible that when we note "indulging, indulging," we are immediately recaptured by our negativity. We remember our bad humour and now there might be a good dollop of shame added to this as well. Shame can be used skilfully because it tells us we're going astray. We've been reacting, indulging in food as a means of escape. Although we might feel even worse after noting indulgence, that very discomfort can prompt us to look around for a few materials to start making a raft. It's never too late to start. Even if we're on the last bite, any of the options suggested above are still available, though we might now have to start with self-forgiveness and the resolve that we can mend our ways.

These are the times that it really helps to remember the image of being spread-eagled on a rickety raft. We don't have to look good to practice the *Dhamma*. In fact, the shame of knowing we've been acting unskilfully is always a good place to start building a raft.

I know one man who had earlier in life suffered from alcoholism. After one bad bout he was nursing a hangover and sitting in the kitchen feeling really miserable. He was watching his wife doing some housework, too sick and depressed to offer any help. As she passed him by, she gave him a look of total disgust. He had the thought, "you're right, I am a louse, but I can do better." He gave up drinking completely from that moment, went on to form and run a very successful business, and when I met him years later, he was regularly going to ten-day Vipassanā retreats. When we register guilt or

shame mindfully, they can stir us to find a way to mend our ways. No matter how many break periods we've wasted gobbling and snoring, we can choose the thought, "I can do better than this," and make faith the first component of our raft.

Let's now look at a practical example of the flood of views. Suppose we've got ourselves into a heated debate about the refugee crisis. Our adversary is fiercely arguing for border closures while we are stoutly defending the refugees' rights to asylum. We're feeling threatened by the situation and getting agitated. It's a complex situation. On the one hand, we're expressing compassion for refugees, so we're developing one of the *Brahmavihāra*. On the other hand, we're in danger of ill will.

Mindfulness would be the main material to frame our raft. Unless we're aware of the anger rising within us, we could easily snap at our opponent, insult them, scorn their lack of compassion or taunt them with sarcastic comments. If we're a clever debater, we could find ways to ridicule their arguments and belittle them, unconscious of the irony that we're using cruel words to argue for compassion. If we're not good at debate, we could find ourselves on the receiving end of cruelty. If we take their scorn to heart and let it wreck our confidence, we might end up sowing seeds of enmity, unable to think well of that person again. We'll have been carried far away by the floods without any awareness of this, insisting that we're doing the right thing, standing up for the rights of refugees.

With mindfulness, we'll feel and acknowledge anger and be aware of the floods threatening us. Once we have the frame of mindfulness in place, the most useful material for this particular raft would be right speech. Here's the definition the Buddha gives: "And what is right speech? Abstaining from lying, from divisive speech, from abusive speech, and from idle chatter. This is called right speech."

In another teaching he puts it in positive terms: "It is spoken at the right time. It is spoken in truth. It is spoken affectionately. It is spoken beneficially. It is spoken with a mind of goodwill."

We're not likely to be able to sift every word through the Buddha's filters while we're in the middle of a heated argument. But the more often we reflect on these lists and let them influence our speech in less conflicting situations, the more easily we'll be able to attach right speech to our raft when we really need it.

So let's see how our communication is measuring up to the Buddha's standards in this particular situation. We're certainly not engaged in idle chatter. Our intention is beneficial and we're not using divisive speech. So far so good. Hopefully also we're being truthful, though this will be compromised if we're exaggerating facts and figures to score our point.

Another consideration, according to the Buddha, is whether our speech is timely. If we can see that our adversary is completely closed to our point of view, then our words are a waste of time. All we're doing is letting that person sow their own seeds of hatred, as well as putting ourselves in danger of the flood of views. Out of compassion for self and other, we should put an end to the argument.

We also need to ask ourselves whether we're speaking with a mind of goodwill, and whether our words are gentle or harsh. These are obviously related. If we're speaking with goodwill, we won't be shouting or letting sarcastic or insulting remarks slip out. At times we might believe we're speaking with goodwill, unaware of how anger has escalated in the heat of the moment. If we hear ourselves using harsh words or a scornful tone, we have the feedback we need to acknowledge that anger is getting the better of us. In that case, we have to scrabble around to find a way of binding the raft together again.

One of the *Brahmavihāra* might do the trick. *Upekkhā* is often the most practical place to start, with a wish such as "may I not do harm on account of my anger." If that steadies the raft, you could add a dash of *mettā*, for example, "may this conversation be beneficial to us both."

It's tough work though, trying to bind a rickety raft together on stormy waters. So should we withdraw from the conversation as soon as we feel anger rising? That depends on how well we can trust ourselves to work with anger in a conflict such as this. If we're mindful of anger, we're not being controlled by it. We can feel angry but maintain an attitude of no harm or even of goodwill. This is the great benefit of working with the difficult person in our *mettā* practice. So long as we can maintain the no harm attitude, we can safely continue to argue our case no matter what fury might be firing through our veins.

In fact, engaging with the argument will be an excellent spiritual practice. We're mindfully watching anger and letting it transform into compassion, which is hard enough to do on the cushion, never mind in a social situation. If we can somehow make it to the other shore, we should give ourselves a major *sādhū* for steering our raft through such a flood.

Mindfulness and right speech are the primary materials we need when the flood of views threatens. It can also help to remember the Buddha's usual method of engaging people in debate. He would listen to their views carefully and then question them, drawing them out so that they eventually saw the weakness in their argument. Only then would he give his own view. If we could use this model, we would be doing a lot more listening than we usually do during a heated argument. This will also help keep us calm and give us a much better chance of controlling any anger. In order to ask useful questions, we will have to consider their point of view seriously, which in itself is an act of *mettā*.

You might rarely get into controversial discussions like this. Perhaps you don't have strong views on many matters. Those of us in this category might therefore think that at least we're free from the flood of views. But if someone bullies us, it's hard to resist the view that they are horrid and cruel. Or if our partner repeatedly omits to do their share of housework, we'd probably be rehashing thoughts like "he's so mean and lazy," or "she's so thoughtless." These views can bind us, and so we might never appreciate how much attention our partner pays to the children, for example.

If we're sharing responsibility for a project, it's easy to get into arguments about how things ought to be done, convinced that our view is right. Even if we don't have strong political or religious views, we have opinions on almost everything we do. And if someone disagrees with these, we'll feel angry, hurt or threatened. Thus all of us, even the meek and mild, are at risk from the flood of views.

You can explore this flood here on retreat. Even though we're not talking out loud, how many arguments do we have in our heads, insisting over and over again how right we are and how wrong our imaginary adversary is? To make a raft, we use body awareness. Feeling the sensations generated by all those strident thoughts, we paddle our way through the flood. The far shore might come into view as a thought like "what does it really matter who's right or wrong" slips through the turmoil.

The more often we negotiate our way through this flood in Vipassanā, the more easily we make a raft when the tsunami comes our way in a heated conversation during daily life.

Another very good practice to prepare us for this flood is to reflect on the Buddha's list for right speech and ask ourselves whether we often transgress these unwittingly. Idle or untimely speech would be a danger for many of us. This doesn't mean we should only speak when we have something really important to say. The Buddha was always happy to exchange pleasantries. These are just a socially acceptable way of saying "may you be well and happy." So they are a *mettā* practice and to be cherished.

But conversations easily fall into moaning about our woes or giving out about third parties. In that case, we're being swept away by the flood of views. Our moans reflect the view that the world should not have done this to me or that the third party should have behaved differently. For example, "the car broke down and I had to get it towed away, cost me £300 and then my boss decides to dock me an hour's pay for being late."

If that's said mindfully, as a factual statement, or with clarity in our distress and need for sympathy, then no problem. We need to be able to tell others our bad news. It's part of the way we help each other to deal with the truth of *dukkha*. But if we're spitting the words out in anger and injecting swear words about our boss and the car, then we're caught in the flood, proclaiming our view of how rotten the world is and especially our rotten car and boss. We're not so much looking for sympathy, more interested in having our view of the rotten world confirmed.

Suppose we've spat out that much and then suddenly remember our *Dhamma* practice. We need to start building a raft pronto. Mindfulness would be the best start, acknowledging anger. We then need to acknowledge this to whoever we've been talking to and apologise for having dumped our bad temper on them. This would be an example of right speech. The apology relieves some of the burden we've placed on them. So it is beneficial speech. All of this might have calmed us enough for some self-compassion, acknowledging in a sympathetic way how rotten we feel. *Upekkhā*-style good wishes such as "may I take care of myself wisely" would help us bear the burden until our anger dissipates.

In general, right speech is an important aspect of any raft to take us across the flood of views, as this flood will be at its swiftest when we're expressing our views to another person. The more often we take care to practice right speech in simple situations when we're not threatened by the flood, the easier it will be for us to build our raft when we need it.

We'll continue with this teaching on the raft tomorrow night and give some examples of working with the other floods. For the moment, let's remind ourselves that we don't have to despair when we find ourselves in a tantrum and acting as if we'd never done a moment's mindfulness practice in our lives. The moment we see our tantrum is the moment to start looking around for any branches or twigs that could make a raft. It's never too late to start.

The present moment never condemns us or shuts us out from its infinite store of wisdom and compassion. May this reflection help us build and trust our rickety rafts and paddle them swiftly to the far shores.

Retreating and Re-engaging: A Year of 'Special Effort'

Noirin Sheahan · 7 min read

In this deeply personal reflection, Noirin Sheahan shares her transformative experience of a year-long retreat practice consisting of three separate 3-month retreats at different centers. The essay chronicles her journey from initial trepidation about leaving her responsibilities to the profound insights gained during intensive vipassanā practice. She explores key themes including the arising and passing of doubt, the direct experience of impermanence as expressed in the traditional chant 'anicca vata saṅkhārā,' and breakthrough moments in mettā (loving-kindness) practice where she encountered unconditional love. The account honestly addresses the challenges of re-entering ordinary life after retreat, including attachment to pleasant meditative states and the shock of losing easy access to peace and clarity. Sheahan's narrative demonstrates how intensive practice can transform one's relationship with difficult mental states like fear, anxiety, and self-doubt, while also revealing the ongoing work required to integrate retreat insights into daily living. The essay offers valuable guidance for practitioners considering extended retreat and provides realistic expectations about both the profound benefits and practical challenges of intensive Dhamma practice.

Retreating and Re-engaging; A Year of 'Special Effort'.

Several years ago Bhante suggested I make a year-long retreat. The idea was exciting but

also daunting. How could I just disappear? What about my teaching? What about my mother? For a long time I could hardly think about it, but eventually plucked up the courage to commit to Sep 2011 as the start of my 'year of special effort'.

That was about 3 years ago and once I'd made that first step, the rest evolved. I started telling people at the hospital where I teach Mindfulness that I wouldn't be available for that year. Every time I said the words, my commitment grew. Although Bhante had suggested a full year retreat in the East somewhere, I eventually decided 3 retreats of 3-months each separated by a month at home was as much as I could undertake, given my situation with respect to my mother.

I started with the annual 3-month retreat at the Insight Meditation Society, in Barre, Massachusetts. Then I spent December in Dublin and joined Bhante and three others for

the Satipanya winter retreat till March. The final three months were spent in Gaia House,

Devon, which has a separate wing for up to about 20 yogis doing personal retreats.

There is nothing like an ambitious program to show up delusion! Now that it's all over and I struggle to take up the threads of life again, I remember the delightful relief of not having to fill my diary with dates for meetings etc. last autumn. The freedom of it – a whole year with no responsibilities, no roles, not having to be somebody! All I was expected to do was to breathe and walk and let the Dhamma filter through – and that's my favourite pastime anyhow! I was in such giddy delight that, before I even met them, I

loved everybody on the IMS retreat! What a come down then, to find myself confused and tongue-tied during most of those first few days when we were encouraged to chat and

get to know one another. The first Dhamma teaching filtered through as a painful lesson in over-expectation - it was a relief to enter the silence.

Naturally there were many ups and downs during each retreat. Doubt, especially self-doubt is perhaps my mind's favourite dead-end, and I found myself hammering away at the walls of this prison again and again, protesting my need to know exactly what was going on and what would happen if ... until eventually I would relax as a crack in the wall appeared to reveal the open space beyond where no assurances were needed. For a

while I would breathe easily in a gentle universe where I don't need to know so much, and that which I do clearly know e.g. sensations and feelings, dissolve willingly into the unknown moment after moment. As the year went on, it became easier to discern this opening into freedom, and to accept it gratefully when it came my way. A few lines from

our morning chant sometimes floated through as a reflection on the experience:

Truly all that is conditioned is transient;

It is their nature to arise and pass away;

1 My mum, Maire, is now 86 years old and still living independently at home. But, since the death of my

brother, Conor, and my father, Maurice, I am her main support. Happily she also has support from others in

the family as well friends and neighbours, but still ... the deep mother-daughter attachment is hard for both

of us to bear, and even harder to let go!

Once arisen, they disappear;
Their cessation is happiness².

It was the last line especially, that become clearer, more heartfelt: cessation is happiness

As one who is usually so attached to precise definitions, I began instead to relish this possibility of release from definition. The analogy of birds in the air leaving no footprints

in the sky seemed apt, and the soaring joy of this traceless existence captivated me so completely I could willingly forgo my usual preference to mull over truth in my mind. These moments confirmed the Dhamma as my deepest love in life, my escape from the limitations of what I already know and understand. But the walls of the prison would rebuild themselves and less noble thoughts pull me back to ‘reality’ – worries or regrets perhaps – and my lofty idealism would have to do battle with guilt and fear and the host

of emotions which limit and darken our view of ourselves and the world. The battle would rage within me: my recent insight into freedom, peace and stillness insisting on my

own and others’ potential for goodness, the opposing emotions denying this vehemently,

until some compromise would emerge and I would find myself more willing to forgive myself and others our past misdeeds, our present limitations. Thus, from those few precious moments of feeling myself at ease within a peaceful universe, a new level of confidence and optimism established itself in my psyche, undermining that old rogue - doubt – until the next challenge!

Looking back through the year, I can see how those moments of peace became more frequent and prolonged and even ordinary. Having gone through many years of intense fear and anxiety, it was a wonderful relief to be able to relax and enjoy watching the bees

at work in the vegetable garden at Gaia House. The joy of simplicity! I am so grateful to have had this opportunity to let the Dhamma work its way into my heart, reassuring me

of the possibility of total release from suffering.

Fear had cast a particular shadow on metta practice, with just the thought of metta being

enough to send me into a spin of self-conscious performance-anxiety. Once, sitting with the anxiety of the comparing mind, I noticed a quiet radiance between the polarities of ‘good enough’ and ‘not good enough’. The radiance gently reassured me that it wasn’t remotely interested in whether I was good enough or not good enough. It was equally at

ease with either scenario, or neither. I recognised this as the experience of unconditional love. It was pouring forth quietly, unobtrusively, demanding nothing in return. This was perhaps the most beautiful experience of my life, and yet the ‘doing’ mind soon wanted to turn away and get on with the next thing. The fact of being in a universe where unconditional love flows freely was so hard to assimilate – what did that imply for all my anxious ‘doing’? Was it all unnecessary? My mind went into a quiet stupor for a day or so, numbed by the immensity of the revelation, until I found myself gazing into the branches of a great maple tree, murmuring “I’m not separate from all this”. The relief of knowing I was truly part of the universe broke through with tears. After the tears, I felt a lazy, hazy, satisfied attachment to this great prize – wanting to pack my bags and go home! Thus, happily for the ‘doing’ mind, it recognised there was a lot more work to do!

2 A stanza from the Vipassana Verses: Anicca vata sankhara, Uppada vaya dhammino, Uppajjitva nirujjhanti, Tesam vupasamo sukkho.

But from then on metta arose more and more frequently and this helped me to bring confidence to the formal metta practice, quelling the demons which habitually insist ‘you can’t do this’ – or at least giving them a good run for their money!

The most challenging aspect of the year has been the re-entry into ‘ordinary life’. There were three such re-entries after each of the three retreats. In all cases the loss of easy access to pleasant mind-states came as a shock. On retreat they feel so simple, so obvious, and I fail to acknowledge the multitude of fortunate conditions which support these e.g. the silence, the space, the inspiration from teachers and other retreatants, the way good food appears on my plate without me having to shop and cook and worry about the cost!

Back in the world, it’s been disappointing to see how easily I am captivated by sense pleasures like food and TV, how deep is my attachment to ideas of how life should be. But when I’m not being too deeply challenged, it has been wonderful to feel a new level of heartfelt goodwill for friends and family, and more compassion for the disappointment of things not going entirely my way. And when the deeper challenges come, I can more easily resist the temptations of the old rogues of fear, anxiety, doubt, jealousy etc. and

choose a more hopeful scenario to fasten onto while I get through the mire. Or if the rogues capture me I can relax more deeply into their tight embrace, searching for the nugget of wisdom or kindness at their core; after all they are just deluded aspects of my mind trying to keep me safe in a world they do not understand or trust. Who could blame

them for such fierce love? Again, we come to some compromise and I breathe more freely, letting freedom trickle through all the rogues which accompany me in life.

My resistance to life outside of retreat highlights an attachment which, although it has the

benefit of enticing me into the practice, is also an obstacle. It means I am clinging to the freedom and wisdom gained from this. To undermine this attachment I can endeavour to

share these goodies I so dearly cherish! I can do this at the mental level, by wishing others the peace and bliss of nibbana. I am also in the privileged position of being able to

embody this wish by teaching at Satipanya and elsewhere. Thanks to all future retreatants

who thus help me along my path. May we all experience the peace and bliss of Nibbana. Finally, may I express my gratitude to all those who helped me in this year of special effort. Sincere thanks to my mother for bearing with loneliness and all other challenges that came her way (including a leaking roof!) without disturbing my retreats, and for her

warm welcome on each return. Heartfelt thanks to all who supported Mum in my absence. I am grateful to my friends for their kindness, their interest in my ramblings, and

for helping me engage with life outside retreat. I am also indebted to my teachers at IMS

and Gaia House for their skilful guidance and compassion.

My especial thanks to Bhante Bodhidhamma for suggesting, encouraging and supporting

this retreat. For this and all his teachings and guidance over the years, may he be greatly

blessed!

Noirin Sheahan

Silence

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 2 min read

Bhante Bodhidhamma examines our relationship with silence in a world overwhelmed by constant noise and stimulation. The essay begins by observing how modern culture drowns us in the sounds of traffic, music, and digital devices, noting how even our minds perpetually chatter, silenced only in deep sleep. While the outer senses can find rest, the ears remain alert even during sleep, and shutting out external noise often reveals the inner tumult of mental and emotional disturbance.

The teaching explores how concentration on neutral sensations like the breath can draw us into stillness and the 'delightful joy of silence.' For experienced practitioners with sufficient ability and time, deeper states of absorption offer 'sheer stillness, peace and absolute silence.' Yet even simple moments of quiet reflection with a cup of tea provide profound refreshment and nourishment.

The essay beautifully describes shared silence among friends as 'communication of being' - experiencing others in their essence before personality constructs emerge. This leads to the deepest teaching: a silence beyond conventional silence, transcending all comparative sounds, described as 'the resting place of the Buddha Within.' This progression from outer noise through inner stillness to ultimate silence reflects the meditative journey from worldly distraction to the unconditioned peace of our deepest nature.

Our world, the culture we live in, is drenched in noise. The sounds of traffic, of transport. The music, often making it difficult to speak, in cafes. Even in the Quiet Coach someone has to speak so everyone else can hear. On the streets, in the offices, in the parks, people walk with their smart phones on high alert. Forever communicating, listening, looking. Deaths on the roads are caused by the enchantment of smart phones. Every sense has its mode of rest. Smelling and tasting are the more sensitive the less they are put to work. Sight is rested easily in closed eyes. Touch softens in rest. But even in sleep, the ears are awake. How amusing it is to see a dog's ear straighten on a sound. And the mind! is for ever chattering, silenced only in deep sleep. Sounds are neutral. But some we hear as music to the ears and others as thorns. Music, whether of human or nature, is health giving. But there comes a time of too much. Noise brings tension and if constant ill-health. There comes a craving for the end of sound. The succulent pleasure of silence. But the mind won't stop so easily. In the quietest of meditation rooms, the mind blasts out. Not just the chatter, but the emotional noise too. All the

aversions, all the anxieties, all the lusts. Shutting down the outer world with its music and noise, only opens up the inner world – for most – a purgatorial video. We can draw the concentration down to the neutral sensations of the breath and listen to it. Feel it. Let it draw us into a stillness. The delightful joy of silence. For those with ability and time, there is a state of absorption of sheer stillness, peace and absolute silence. But even to sit in silence with a cup of tea, brings a deep refreshment. Whatever the depth of silence, there is always nourishment. Even more so among friends. To walk, to sit, to eat in silence, aware of the presence of the other, is a communication of being. It is the experience of the other in their essence, before their becoming somebody. It can be as shocking as death, as astonishing as birth. And there is a deeper silence still. It is a silence beyond silence, for there are no sounds to compare it with. Here is the resting place of the Buddha Within.

1st, 2nd & 3rd Noble Truths: Dukkha, its Cause & Cessation

Noirin Sheahan · 37 min

In this teaching, Noirin Sheahan presents the Buddha's core discovery following his Awakening - the Four Noble Truths, focusing particularly on the first three. She explores the First Truth's definition of dukkha as encompassing birth, aging, death, separation from the pleasant, and connection with the unpleasant, culminating in the insight that "the five aggregates of clinging are dukkha." The teaching examines how we mistakenly identify with body, feelings, perceptions, mental formations, and consciousness, creating the suffering of false selfhood.

The Second Truth reveals taṇhā (craving/desire) as dukkha's root cause - our wanting things to be different than they are. Through mindful observation rather than suppression, we can learn that desire truly causes suffering. The Third Truth points to the cessation of suffering in moments when desire fades, creating space for peace. Noirin emphasizes cultivating appreciation for these often-overlooked moments of absence and quiet.

Drawing on practical retreat experiences and everyday examples, she shows how understanding these truths transforms our relationship with life's inevitable changes and challenges, moving us from delusion toward wisdom and preparing the ground for following the Noble Eightfold Path toward complete liberation.

Four Noble Truths.

Soon after his enlightenment, the Buddha decided to teach others how to follow his lead. He first sought out his earlier spiritual companions and told them of four observations that had led him to liberation. These later became known as the Four Noble Truths and are the cornerstone for all schools of Buddhism.

All truths concern *dukkha*, a Pali word usually translated as suffering or sometimes as stress, distress or unsatisfactoriness. Dukkha spans the full range of negativity we experience from minor irritations to rage, terror and despair.

The Buddha told his companions that liberation involved seeing for himself that this is suffering. This is the cause of suffering. This is the cessation of suffering. This is the path leading to the cessation of suffering. The word "this" refers to something close at hand. It's not an abstract idea to think about. It's something we can see or feel or experience here and now. This cup, this foot, this thought.

We learn the Four Noble Truths from direct experience. We feel how suffering feels, discover what causes it, realize that suffering can stop, let that guide us along the path that reduces suffering, brings it eventually to a complete end. As we learn the Four Noble Truths, we move from delusion to an understanding of what causes suffering, what makes us happy.

We often think of understanding as a purely intellectual, rational process. We think we should only have to learn the Dhamma once and then have this as a skill we can call upon any time in the same way as we learned how to drive or fix a puncture. But the understanding we need for liberation is not purely cognitive. We have to take the Dhamma fully to heart until we're fully liberated. We'll be continually relearning the Four Noble Truths, feeling the dukkha in experience, searching for the cause.

The First Noble Truth is basically the Buddha's definition of dukkha. Birth is dukkha, old age and death are dukkha, sorrow, lamentations and despair are dukkha. Being connected to what one dislikes is dukkha, and being separated from what one likes is dukkha and not getting what one wants is dukkha. In short, the five aggregates of clinging are dukkha.

Birth is dukkha. We usually think of birth as joyous, but in fact, physical birth is a painful and perilous process for mother and baby. It's when both are pronounced safe and well that the joy arises. Before that, it's touch and go between hope and fear.

We also get a flavour of this when we look closely at the start of any process. A new job, for example. Again, we think of it as good news, something to celebrate, but there is that awkward first day in the office, not knowing anyone or where things are kept or how not to be a nuisance, having to learn a lot of new procedures, watching our P's and Q's, taking care to make a good impression. It's not something we would want to do every day of our lives. It would be too stressful.

Now, some of us love new beginnings. There's a sense of potential. Anything could happen. If we're the optimistic type, we project all kinds of wonders into whatever it is, a new job, a new partner, the start of a holiday, the first few hours of a retreat. Everything is going to be perfect. We'd be enlightened in no time.

This over-the-top optimism is one manifestation of delusion. The truth is that we don't know what's going to happen, whether things will turn out well or not. And that experience of not knowing is so uncomfortable for us that we concoct lovely fantasies rather than feel the experience. But after a year or maybe only a week of the new job, new partner, perhaps only a day or two into the holiday or retreat, we realise that it's not all a bed of roses, that the reality doesn't match up to the fantasies.

And if things do turn out well and our expectations are all met or even exceeded, there will be a time when it all comes asunder. We'll someday have to retire from the job. The holiday will come to an end, as will the retreat. Our partner will die or else we will die and leave it all behind—the job, the holiday, the loving relationships, all our retreats. Everything we know ends at death.

Death is the second example of dukkha which the Buddha gives. Our own physical death is indeed the big one. Unless we can say goodbye to all we hold dear, death will surely be a time of anguish.

We can practice our goodbyes by paying attention to the ending of any activity or event. These can all be seen as mini-deaths. We often make light of them by thinking ahead to what's to come, but that won't be an option at our real death, so we might as well pause at endings now, acknowledge that the holiday or the party or some particular task is coming to an end.

There may be relief, a sense of something accomplished, a job well done. The sentiment is to be treasured. If we can feel the same way at our own death, it will be a great gift. We might also detect grief, knowing that something we were enjoying is now stopping. There can be a surprising amount of grief, even at the close of relatively trivial events, when we pay close attention.

On retreat at Gaia House one time, I was following the usual Mahasi single biscuit in the evening practice, but all the while envying the other retreatants their bowls of soup. I looked forward so much to the final day when I could have that evening treat. Sure enough, the day came and the soup was delicious. I savoured every mouthful until I noticed that the bowl was no longer even half full. A big wave of misery emerged and got stuck in my throat. It was my first real recognition of the truth that all pleasures come to an end. I got the Buddha's full whammy of sorrow, lamentation, pain, grief and despair. I couldn't even finish my treasured bowl of soup, but went to my room and howled in misery.

Having realised the emotional impact of delusive over-expectations, I never built such high expectations out of sense pleasures again. This is the benefit of paying attention to ending. We move from delusion to wisdom, and instead of being continually disappointed by the world, by other people, we grow to accept that neither the world nor other people can bring us lasting happiness. We grow more forgiving of our own and others' limitations, more appreciative of whatever does happen to go right.

The Buddha summarizes dukkha by saying the five aggregates of clinging are dukkha. These aggregates of clinging are what we mistakenly assume to be our true selves. That essential element of me, which has been with me since birth and will remain with me to death and perhaps hereafter. In Christianity, we would call this our soul.

The Buddha searched ardently for his essence and on the way discovered a series of false identities which ensnared him in dukkha. He used this discovery as the basis for his teaching on *anattā*, or not self. To find our true essence, we must first see through all the false identities we assume.

At times we identify with the body, feeling proud of our strength or beauty, ashamed of our pimples and wrinkles. This is dukkha. The Buddha points out that such inconsistency is not worthy of being thought of as an essential part of our identity.

At other times, we identify with our feelings, get deeply wounded when these are hurt, yet more dukkha. Sometimes we identify with perceptions, swear that the earth was created in seven days, are ready to die for our belief.

Then again, we can identify with character traits. Perhaps we assume kindness or generosity are essential components of our true self. But this means we have to suppress any suggestions of unkindness or meanness, pretend they aren't happening. More harmfully, we can identify with negative characteristics like self-doubt, thinking "I'm useless, I always make a mess of things." Though the identity is painful, it's also comforting as we never get disappointed because we never expect much of ourselves.

The final aggregate is consciousness, where we assume our essence as the knowing of all our experience, thinking "I am the one who sees and hears and smells and tastes and thinks and experiences the joys and pains of life."

Buddha examined all of these areas but found all such identities to be inconstant, unreliable. Traits like generosity arose depending on conditions, feelings changed when circumstances changed, as did perceptions, and so on. None of these provided a stable foundation upon which he could declare, "this is my true self." He also found that there was great pain, dukkha, in discovering each identity to be false.

We cling vainly to our delusions, saying, "I am feeling miserable," or "I am useless," refusing to believe that these experiences come and go depending on conditions. The Buddha realised that peace came only when he relaxed all attempts to cling, to let go of any attempt to define himself. His teaching on anattā, not self, asks us to recognize that clinging to identity causes suffering, prevents us adapting to circumstances, flowing with life's vicissitudes.

Note that the Buddha never denies that we have a self, an ultimate identity. He just says it cannot be defined or captured in any way that satisfies our craving for sense pleasure, our craving to be someone or to escape it all, be nobody. Any identity we find is temporary. It will eventually break up. But we can use every temporary identity wisely. He repeatedly asks us to look after our long-term happiness by practicing the Dhamma.

We can have and encourage a healthy sense of self, so long as we know this as a friend on the path, a temporary gift, not our ultimate essence.

In summary then, the first truth describes dukkha, tells us that we must fully understand dukkha. We can look for dukkha in any new beginning and in every ending, parting, saying goodbye when we're in sorrow, pain or despair. We can turn towards there as an opportunity to learn more about dukkha and its causes. Similarly, when we're getting over-identified by a role or job or believing "this is me" or "this is definitely not me," these are again perfect opportunities to study dukkha.

The second truth the Buddha wants us to learn is what causes dukkha. We think that the problem lies with the world or other people or the laws of nature. But the Buddha discovered that the cause was within ourselves. Desire, *tanha* in Pali, caused him to suffer. Tanha includes what we usually call aversion, the desire to be rid of something.

We suffer because we want more of the nice stuff, cakes and ale and rock and roll, praise, adulation, fame, beauty, health, youth. And when life gives us instead dry bread and blame and loneliness and old age, with its wrinkles and decrepitude, we don't know how to cope.

The Buddha's wonderful discovery was that when he stopped wanting things to be anything other than the way they were, suffering also stopped. Even physical pain did not have to cause suffering. Once he accepted the pain, stopped making it a problem, suffering stopped. He was at peace.

But as we all know, we can't command ourselves to accept pain or whatever other dukkha life is presenting. That would be to suppress dukkha, not to uproot it. Luckily, we have the capacity to learn that desire causes suffering. As that understanding sinks deeper, desire loses its grip.

On the way, however, we have to learn to work skillfully with the many deluded desires that arise every day. For this, we have mindfulness. We watch ourselves longing vainly for things to be different. We're not suppressing desire. We're using the experience to learn the second noble truth. Is desire really the cause of suffering? With this curiosity in mind, desire loses some of its edge.

Say it was the desire for fame. We've been looking at Celebrity MasterChef and envying the winner, wanting everyone drooling over our crème caramel. If we turn away from the screen, use this opportunity to study tanha, we're halfway there. Desire might fade as soon as we spot it, and we realise how silly it was to be thinking that way.

Other desires run too deep to stop on recognition. In that case, we feel the stresses and strains of longing. Watched mindfully, the desire at first grows very strong, but eventually burns out. The energy of desire usually drives thought and fantasies, which in turn feed that very desire. But now all that energy is contained by mindfulness. It's as if we've put ourselves into a pressure cooker. For a while, the energy might tense our jaws, our throat, our chest. We might be panting with unfulfilled desire. But after a while, desire exhausts itself, fades away.

If we're lucky, we sense a moment of peace as desire fades. The absence of desire is a very beautiful experience, which the Buddha recognized as his third noble truth, the end of suffering.

We're so lucky that the Buddha did the hard work of pinpointing this because otherwise few of us would take any notice of that moment of peace as desire fades. Unless we examine it, bring deliberate attention to it, peace is easily overlooked. It doesn't call attention. It's not a loud experience of joyous bliss that shouts, "this is wonderful." It's simply the absence of any trouble.

Our whole psychology and physiology is designed to be on alert for trouble and for enticement. It's part of our animal nature. We need to survive, so we have to be on the lookout for danger and also for food, shelter, our pals and whatever will help us survive. We're not biologically designed to make a big thing out of peace.

That's why it's so easy for us to miss that brief moment when desire fades, to instead notice the next thing to grab our attention, then a new desire form around that. To sensitise ourselves to the third noble truth, we need to cultivate a taste for peace. Instead of booking one party after another, we spend some time in quietness, meditating perhaps, or walking in nature, sitting by the fire, listening to birdsong.

This might not always feel so peaceful. We may have to combat our cultural conditioning to be always busy, always achieving something. So we might feel anxious or guilty sitting down doing nothing for an evening. Peace is actually not that easy to tolerate for long.

The self, the me I presume myself to be, needs a role, a purpose. It wants to be getting something or getting somewhere, overcoming problems or doing good, affecting the world in some way. In perfect peace, there is nothing for me to do, no problems to solve. Most of us simply doze off after a minute or two, or else we grow restless, start to create problems just so we can solve them.

What we're seeing here is the dukkha of identification. We want to be someone. We want definition. The self is born from reactivity, reacting against what we dislike, busily trying to get rid of it, reacting with desire for what we like, busy planning how to prolong the pleasure, get more of it, be someone important.

To practice with the third noble truth, we can use any moments of peace wisely, let them be felt, acknowledged, notice the tendency to burst out of it with some new identity and just keep relaxing all of that, telling ourselves it's fine to be redundant, to take it easy, have no role to play in life. Quite a practice.

Another way we can practice with the third truth is to start appreciating absences. We usually associate absence with grief, but rarely acknowledge that many absences are very beautiful. We easily notice pain, but we can also start to look out for parts of the body that are not in pain.

The Buddha also advises us to notice when we're not angry, for example, not feeling greedy. When we're feeling uptight and frustrated, we can reflect that dullness and lethargy are absent. We can notice when others aren't irritating us or demanding anything.

A retreat is an especially rich time for this. I used to think of my mother as very demanding, always asking me for something or other. It was quite an eye-opener to reflect that while I was on retreat, she was looking after herself, not putting me under any pressure. At first, I actually resisted the thought. My locked-in image of her as demand-

ing was so strong it could not be budged. But gradually, I learned to acknowledge and be grateful for the fact that she was looking after herself quite well while I was away. I began to see her more realistically, admire and respect her strength of character.

Our relationship improved and I'm very thankful that in her last years when she was more dependent on me, I didn't see this as a burden. Much of the time it was so easy and natural, I hardly thought about it at all. Something I had dreaded throughout much of my adult life turned out to be no problem and on the contrary, a source of quiet joy.

If there is someone in your life who you see as oppressive in some way, it might really pay off to reflect that while you're here on retreat, they aren't oppressing you. We can also notice physical absences.

When an ugly shed was demolished in this garden, the Dhamma teacher Stephen Batchelor spent days looking out the window, noticing the absence of the shed. In a similar way, we can notice that wherever we walk, there is space letting us pass through. We can look for the gaps between houses in the city, see the sky beyond.

As we attune to space and absences and quiet, peaceful moments when life isn't troubling us, we deepen our understanding of the third noble truth, which the Buddha usually describes very simply as the end of suffering.

To give a bit more flavour, we have these analogies from the monk Nāgasena. Just as space is not produced, does not age, does not suffer death, cannot be carried away by thieves, rests on nothing, is the pathway of birds, presents no obstacles, is endless, so also *nibbāna* is not produced, does not age, does not suffer, cannot be carried away by thieves, rests on nothing, is the pathway of the noble, presents no obstacles, is endless.

The great ocean is all in blossom with the flowers of waves, mighty, various, unnumbered. Precisely so, Nibbāna is all in blossom with the flowers of purity, knowledge and deliverance, mighty, various and unnumbered.

Even a brief taste of the peace that comes as desire fades will stir the skillful desire to find our way to Nibbāna, which is exactly the concern of the fourth noble truth, known also as the noble eightfold path.

I had been meditating for a while before it eventually sank in that meditation wasn't the whole of the spiritual life, that the eightfold path described many other areas of life that counted too. That gave me great joy and continues to do so. If I'm feeling glum and demotivated about work, I can reflect that my work is part of right livelihood, one of

the strands of the eightfold path. That lifts my spirits, helps me to take on the work more willingly. Everything can be lifted from the dull and ordinary when we reflect that this is also leading towards liberation.

The path is divided into three sections: wisdom, morality, and the cultivation of our mind and heart through meditation. Each of the eight strands is described as right—right understanding, right attitude and so on. This can make the path seem like a set of rigid rules to follow. Disentangled is perhaps a better translation. It's a good description of what happens as we follow the path. We sense our thought processes straightening out, our emotional life disentangling. We become more straightforward in our dealings with others.

In meditation, we can often feel ourselves getting into knots of tension as the hindrances show up and then feel the relief as those knots loosen in the light of awareness. Because disentangled is a bit of a mouthful, I'll follow the convention of calling each step right this or right that. But bear in mind the gentler and more evocative sense that we disentangle ourselves from the binds of *dukkha* as we develop our path.

The first section is right understanding. We suffer because of not understanding what causes suffering and what prevents it. Reflecting on the four noble truths starts us on the journey from delusion to wisdom. Experiencing these truths in moment-to-moment awareness lets them sink in deeply so that we take the Dhamma to heart. This naturally changes our attitude so that we become more kindly, generous, compassionate. This is what we mean by right attitude, the second strand of the eightfold path.

We can also cultivate right attitude by practicing *mettā* meditation. *Mettā* is usually translated as goodwill or loving-kindness. We wish ourselves and others to be well and happy. This undermines habits like anger. In our gardening analogy, you could say it covers over the weeds, preventing them from getting any sunlight. They can't thrive and sow more seeds.

When we feel our own pain or see that someone else is in physical or mental pain, the friendly attitude of *mettā* takes on the hue of compassion. We're sensitive to the suffering, careful not to make it any worse, ready to do whatever needs to be done to make things easier. At heart, we wish ourselves and others to be free from suffering.

When something welcome happens, *mettā* shades into *muditā*, often translated as appreciative joy. We are gladdened by good news. We're ready to congratulate ourselves for any achievement, no matter how small. Even getting out of bed can be an achievement some days. When we hear of another's success, we feel happy for them.

Mettā cultivates friendliness, while compassion helps us bear suffering, and muditā lets us appreciate our many blessings. All of these need the support of equanimity. Without equanimity, mettā easily overshoots into attachment and we become more dependent on our friends for our own sense of worth. With equanimity, we learn to accept that friends have separate lives, other responsibilities, other affections.

Without the balance of equanimity, compassion slides into pity. We see ourselves as the stronger party, caring for the weaker one. It can become an addiction—needing to be needed. Equanimity restores the balance, lets us see the strength at the core of the other's being.

Muditā easily overshoots into excitement. We celebrate madly and go to excess. When the bills come in, we're shocked. Equanimity helps us recognize joy as a temporary gift, while knowing that all earthly joys are bound to fade.

The Mettā Sutta is a beautiful description of right attitude. We chant this every morning in Pali. Here's an English translation read by Mark Arthur, another teacher here at Satipanya.

So this is what should be done by one who is skilled in goodness and who knows the path of peace. Let them be able and upright, straightforward and gentle in speech, humble and not conceited, contented and easily satisfied, unburdened with duties and frugal in their ways, peaceful and calm and wise and skillful, not proud or demanding in nature.

Let them not do the slightest thing that the wise would later reprove. Wishing, in gladness and in safety, may all beings be at ease. Whatever living beings there may be, whether they are weak or strong, omitting none, the great or the mighty, medium, short or small, the seen and the unseen, those living near and far away, those born and to be born, may all beings be at ease.

Let none deceive another or despise any being in any state. Let none through anger or ill-will wish harm upon another. Even as a mother protects with her life a child, her only child, so with a boundless heart should one cherish all living beings, radiating kindness over the entire world, spreading upwards to the skies and downwards to the depths, outwards and unbounded, freed from hatred and ill-will.

Whether standing or walking, seated or lying down, free from drowsiness, one should sustain this recollection. This is said to be the sublime abiding. And by not holding to fixed views, the pure-hearted one, having clarity of vision, being freed from all sense desires, is not born again into this world.

Right understanding and right attitude combine as wisdom, the first section of the eightfold path. The next section, termed *sīla* in Pali, concerns the expression of wisdom in daily life. *Sīla* is usually translated as morality or ethics. I'm going to use the Pali word *sīla* because we often associate morality with a strict, joyless approach to life.

Family photos from Victorian times illustrate this. No one smiles. The children look miserable in their heavy, awkward clothes. An austere father towers over them while his wife sits demurely at his side, laced and buttoned to within an inch of her life. Desire finds no expression in this picture of morality.

But we need to remember that desire can also be wise. The desire to be happy is perhaps our most basic drive in life. It only gets us into trouble because we don't rightly understand what allows for happiness, what causes suffering. The Buddha promises us that if we follow this path, we will be content and therefore happy. Morality in this teaching is seen as a step toward happiness.

Sīla is not an easy matter. For each of us, there will be difficult ethical questions to face at many stages in life. We need a clear mind to find the appropriate response in complex situations, along with a stout heart to meet the challenge. We also need to be patient with our many mistakes, not torment ourselves about them. But remember, we can learn to do better.

The Buddha divides *sīla* into three sections: right speech, right action and right livelihood. Here are three areas of life where we can tailor our behaviour so as to promote our own long-term happiness. Tomorrow's talk is on daily life and as *sīla* is so relevant to this, I won't discuss it further here. Tomorrow I'll give suggestions as to how we can develop *sīla* as we go about our everyday business.

The last section of the eightfold path concerns the cultivation of mind and heart in meditation practice. And as we've been engaged in this all week, I'll only briefly mention it here. The Buddha describes three aspects to cultivate: right effort, mindfulness, and concentration. So here we have again, the leading trio in our wild geese—mindfulness, energy, concentration.

To see their interrelation, we have the analogy of three children wanting to pick fruit from a tree. None of them is tall enough to reach the fruit, so the strongest one, right effort, bends over to let the tallest one, right concentration, stand on his back while the steadiest of the three, right mindfulness, provides a shoulder to lean on. Supported by right effort, balanced by mindfulness, concentration can then pluck the fruit.

Again, I'll say more about this and all aspects of the eightfold path tomorrow as we look at how we can maintain and strengthen our meditation practice in daily life.

In summary, the four noble truths concern dukkha and how to bring it to an end. The Buddha said that his own liberation came from fully understanding dukkha, from seeing that desire was the cause. As he let go of desire, he realized that dukkha came to an end, simply stopped happening. To bring it to a permanent close, he followed the eightfold path.

Lost in the jungle of ignorance, we ponder the four noble truths to get an inkling of what causes suffering and what relieves it. As the truth sinks in, our attitude grows friendlier. The sword of wisdom cuts through some tangles of delusion to form a clearing. Sila blossoms in the form of right speech, action and livelihood to be rewarded by the law of *kamma* so that we become happier. The jungle no longer seems so threatening and we rest a while in the clearing to cultivate our mind and heart in meditation.

Supported by effort, led and balanced by mindfulness, our mind focuses on the diamond and the four noble truths sink in even deeper. This sharpens the sword of wisdom, which cuts through another thicket of delusion. Step by step, we form the path that leads from the jungle of ignorance to the freedom of enlightenment.

In what is termed his victory verse, the Buddha uses the analogy of a house builder to describe the delusive desire, *taṇhā*, that drives us to seek our essence within the world, build castles in the air. The ridge pole for these castles is ignorance, our lack of understanding about dukkha and its cause.

Here is the Buddha's victory verse:

Seeking but not finding the house builder, I have travelled through the round of countless births. How painful is birth over and over again. Oh house builder, you have now been caught. You shall not build a house again. Your rafters have been broken. Your ridge pole demolished. The unconditioned consciousness has been attained and every kind of craving has been destroyed.

I hope this overview of the four noble truths has been helpful. May all beings come to the end of suffering.

2020 Lockdown Christmas

Noirin Sheahan · 2 min read

Written during the COVID-19 pandemic, this essay offers compassionate guidance for handling the uncertainty and stress of disrupted holiday plans. Noirin Sheahan draws on Buddhist understanding of anattā (not-self) to explain why uncertainty feels so threatening - our constructed sense of self doesn't know how to respond when we can't categorize experiences as pleasant or unpleasant. She explores how the same confusion we encounter with neutral feelings in meditation mirrors our struggle with unpredictable circumstances.

The essay introduces a practical mantra for difficult times: "try not to make things worse than they already are." This approach emphasizes realistic expectations over spiritual perfectionism, acknowledging that we'll likely experience irritation, frustration, and other challenging emotions. Rather than adding guilt about our reactions, the teaching encourages self-care through honest preparation for difficulties.

The piece demonstrates how Buddhist wisdom applies to everyday challenges, showing how mindful action - even without solutions to our problems - can lift spirits and build resilience. It concludes with the possibility of transforming the initial survival mantra into "let's make the best of things," illustrating how acceptance can create space for unexpected joy.

2020 Christmas Mantra “Try not to make things worse!”

How can we prepare for Christmas this year? We might not know till a week beforehand whether we will be able to meet friends and family. Should I book a flight home? Will there be twelve people for dinner, or will it just be me and the dog? Would it be irresponsible to visit my gran? How will she feel if I don't? And don't even start thinking about New Year and Brexit!

Uncertainty is hard to bear. We sometimes see this in meditation when we explore neutral feeling. Because we can't decide whether the sensations are pleasant or unpleasant, we also can't decide which of our habitual reactions to choose: Should I be grasping at this, trying to hold on tight? Should I be pushing it away? The 'self' we construct in our attempts to navigate the world is in a dither! It can feel very threatened. Sitting with the fear, we learn the difficult but liberating truth of anatta 'not-self'. That we can stop constructing a belief 'this is me'; and when we stop this construction process, we stop grasping at pleasant feelings, struggling against unpleasant ones, getting into a dither about neutral ones. Such relief!

Then we get up from the cushion, remember Christmas, Covid, Brexit, and another

self gets constructed in a flash, asking the same old questions, demanding answers! Until we're fully liberated uncertainty will be hard to bear. It brings out our habitual demons like irritation, depression, even total panic. These are made ten times worse because the expectation is for happiness at Christmas. On top of all that our lofty spiritual ideals might add in hefty doses of guilt and shame for every transgression. Because of living such a quiet life here at Satipanya, I'll be spared this turmoil. But if I was out in the world, I would start practicing my favorite mantra for hard times: "try not to make things worse than they already are!"

I'd take time to sit down and envisage what the 'festive' season will really feel like - probably more stressful than joyful; that I'll have to expect to be irritated, frustrated, exhausted much of the time; that I'll probably see myself shooting second and third arrows – grumbling & blaming and mulling over how unfair it all is. The motivation here is not to depress myself. It's self-care. If I'm expecting my demons, I'll be in the best place to look after myself wisely when they arrive.

I've heard the spiritual life described as one of ever decreasing expectations! Delusion easily persuades us that we can be good-humored and serene in all circumstances. But this makes any fall from grace extra painful. With practice we learn to embrace our shortcomings. The mantra "try not to make things worse" provides a reasonable goal – not too lofty, but very practical.

When the demons appear I would recite my mantra, summon all my willpower to resist their temptation, find something purposeful to do, do it mindfully. Even when we have no practical answers to all our pressing questions, its amazing how a few moments of mindful action can lift the spirits, make us feel more hopeful,

stronger. With that I would change the mantra to "let's make the best of things". Wishing for the best, preparing for the worst, it's entirely possible that we might have a happy Christmas after all!

4th Maxim (i): Opportunity Knocks

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 3 min read

This essay examines the fourth of the Six Maxims for climate resilience, presenting dukkha as a gateway to spiritual development rather than mere suffering. Drawing from the Upanisa Sutta, Noirin Sheahan maps seven practical entry points into the spiral of conditions leading to liberation: faith, wise investigation, virtue, restraint, dedication/care, mindfulness, and inspiration. Each response transforms climate anxiety into skillful engagement with present reality.

The teaching shows how ordinary reactions to environmental crises—from overwhelm to restlessness—can be redirected through these traditional Buddhist pathways. Whether through ethical action, mindful presence, or seeking inspiration, practitioners learn to use dukkha as fuel for growth rather than despair. The approach complements formal meditation with everyday applications, making the spiral teachings accessible in daily life.

This practical framework helps develop resilience not only for global challenges but for personal difficulties. By recognizing our natural strengths and learning to 'play to them' during difficult times, we transform unavoidable suffering into opportunities for deepening wisdom and compassion.

I'm again looking at Dhamma links for the Six Maxims designed to fortify us for the challenge of climate change. Instead of being horrified at the thought of the inevitable hardship for humans, wildlife and environment, the fourth maxim tells us we are to look on this as a golden opportunity for personal and spiritual growth. One parallel in the Dhamma is the Upanisa Sutta which places dukkha (suffering / dissatisfaction) central to a list of conditions leading to enlightenment. The first steps show how we create dukkha by believing we can make ourselves happy in a world which is unstable, uncontrollable, inherently unsatisfying. Ironically the dukkha we feel when our plans fall apart spurs us to find a way out of the endless round of false hope, and the final links show how we can liberate ourselves from suffering. I recently attended a Tricycle online course entitled "The Spiral to Freedom". The teachers, John Peacock and Akincano Weber, stress that all the links from dukkha to liberation can be seen in ordinary daily life. This compliments the practices in previous tips which focussed on formal meditation. Let's imagine ourselves in a state of anxiety or misery because of news of another huge wildfire. The 'spiral teachings' suggest a range of responses which form entry points to the spiral of causes and conditions leading to liberation. For some, faith is the

easiest way to counter the pull into negative thinking. This could be the bright faith of the beginner, or the mature trust that grows with long practice. Every time another dark thought takes us back into the pit, we place our trust in the Dhamma to claw ourselves out. For others, news of a wildfire stimulates doubt rather than faith; we are flooded by questions like ‘What is life all about?’ where the only answer is ‘I don’t know’. If we’re willing to explore the experience of “I don’t know” this is Wise Investigation, a second entry point to the spiral. Although we don’t have the answers, we have access to teachings that can point us in the right direction. Thus, bewilderment is the catalyst that motivates us to learn about suffering and how it can be transcended. At other times, investigation may seem irrelevant, we want to do something, anything, to relieve suffering. In this case Virtue becomes the link from dukkha to the spiral. We respond with ethical action – we might donate to a charity supporting those affected, sign a petition or write to our local council. We find some positive action aiming to minimise further harm and pain. But sometimes we can’t find the energy, the goodwill needed to sign yet another petition or make that donation. Everything in us just wants to turn away from the world, forget all its horrors. This impulse contains the wisdom of Restraint, which is another entry point to the spiral. We let ourselves turn away from activity, withdraw to some quiet place, give ourselves the silence and rest we need to heal. The opposite can happen too, news of the wildfire leads to restlessness; we don’t want to turn inwards, we want something to occupy us. In this case we can use the entry point of Dedication / Care. We could wash the dishes as if this were a sacred ceremony, the most important task in the world, taking care of all the little details. Although we can’t fix the wildfire, we can take care of what is at hand, and this is a very worthy response to dukkha. At other times, the thought of caring for anyone or anything seems an impossible burden. Perhaps anxiety is overwhelming us with thoughts of who to blame. In this case, Mindfulness often provides the best entry point. We don’t have to follow the breath, but use phrases like “walking to the shops”, “making the dinner”, “driving to work” to keep us present, alert, mindful. Although news of the wildfire might still be tempting us to blame and worry, we are choosing present reality as an antidote to those dead ends, and this is a valid way to lift ourselves out of dukkha. Sometimes we can’t even muster the energy to be mindful. Everything seems hopeless, the world is doomed, we might as well give up. In this case we need to look outside ourselves, let Inspiration lift us from dukkha to the spiral. Who or what will draw attention away from misery, persuade us that life is worth living? For some it’s a weekend camping, others might sign up for a study course; it could be as simple as meeting a friend, listening to a dhamma talk. Next month I’ll look at some of the following links in the spiral. In the meantime I hope you will try out some of the entry points, get to know your strengths, learn to play to them when dukkha is getting you down. Here we’re allowed to be biased, seek out and amplify feelings and mind-states

that lift us up. But we keep mindfulness in the background, noticing what works, what doesn't, when we're pushing ourselves too hard, when we need to step back, take it easy, try again when we're ready. Thus the dukkha of climate change becomes the catalyst to develop resilience, which will help us through all manner of personal sorrows as well as to the global challenge we face at this time.

4th Maxim (ii): Spiral to Freedom

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 3 min read

This essay examines the fourth of the Six Maxims for climate resilience, which reframes hardship as opportunity for spiritual growth. Drawing primarily on the Upanisa Sutta, it traces the 'spiral path' of dependent origination that leads from dukkha (suffering, unsatisfactoriness) to liberation. The teaching reveals how our attachment to an inherently impermanent world creates disappointment, which paradoxically becomes the catalyst for awakening.

The essay provides practical guidance for recognising the sequential steps of this upward spiral in daily life: gladness arising when we find a way forward from suffering; rapture experienced as genuine interest in activities; tranquillity emerging as the 'cooling phase' when initial excitement settles into deeper peace; and happiness naturally flowing from recognised tranquillity. Each stage creates conditions for the next, ultimately leading to samādhi and insight.

Rather than avoiding or dreading difficult circumstances, practitioners learn to use any form of dukkha—whether personal struggles or climate anxiety—as entry points into this transformative spiral. The teaching emphasises paying careful attention to subtle shifts in heart and body, particularly noticing the physical relaxation that accompanies tranquillity even when the mind feels disappointed. This practical approach makes the profound Dhamma teaching of dependent origination accessible for contemporary spiritual development.

Following on last month's tip, I'm again looking at Dhamma links for the fourth of the Six Maxims designed to fortify us for the challenge of climate change. Instead of dreading what's to come, the fourth maxim asks us to see all such hardship as an opportunity for personal and spiritual growth. The supporting Dhamma teaching that I've been looking at is the Upanisa Sutta, which traces the causes and conditions for liberation. The first steps show how we create dukkha (suffering, stress) by investing our hopes in a world which is inherently unsatisfying. When our hopes are dashed, disappointment, rage, despair - any shade of dukkha - becomes the catalyst for spiritual renewal, and the final links trace what has been termed 'the spiral path' from dukkha to liberation. In a recent Tricycle course, John Peacock and Akincano Weber examine the Upanissa Sutta and related teachings, stressing that all the links in the spiral path can be seen in ordinary daily life. To pull ourselves out of dukkha and into the spiral we

have a number of 'Entry Points' which I looked at in last month's tip. Here are some of the following links:

Gladness: A moment ago, we were stuck in dukkha, now we've found a way forward. This naturally gladdens the heart. But surprisingly, gladness is easily overlooked. The 'entry point' required effort e.g. to do some good deed, to restrain angry speech. We can be so intent on these that we don't notice the change of heart. We need to be on the lookout for gladness, even if its only momentary, to deepen our faith that there is a path leading from suffering to liberation.

Rapture: The background mood of gladness helps us engage, be interested in whatever is happening. This is what we mean by rapture. The word suggests an over-the-top joy, but rapture can be experienced quite simply as interest. Look out for this at the start of any activity you enjoy – as you step into the shower, take the first bite of dinner, meet a friend. Sometimes it can feel a bit giddy, we're over-excited, expecting too much, sometimes mild, like a gentle uplift or refreshment.

Tranquillity: Rapture sets up the conditions for tranquillity. This was one I struggled with until Akincano described tranquillity as that cooling phase in every activity, when the initial fizz goes out of it. True enough, once I investigated that slight deflation when some new activity lost its sparkle, I detected an inner relaxation underlying the more obvious surface layer of dullness. I needed to bring attention to the body for this, the mood of deflation still predominated in the mind, but within the tissues of the body, particularly the limbs, I sensed a quiet peace and ease. I realised that I had become more grounded, more settled within myself. So keep an eye out for any slight 'downer' when a new activity starts to feel hum-drum. Ask whether, deep down, peace has descended. I never knew disappointment could hold such treasure! But don't go straight for tranquillity and skip over the rapture stage thinking it's silly to be getting excited by things. For tranquillity to have any depth, we need to put our heart into the activity while it still strikes us as novel and interesting. The energy of enthusiasm lifts us up, and that is the same energy which transforms to tranquillity when the novelty wears off.

Happiness: Tranquillity sets up the conditions needed for happiness. Once I had detected and assured myself that tranquillity was really present, the mood of disappointment evaporated, and instead the heart softened. I realised I was content, happy. While tranquillity, for me, could be described as a bodily form of happiness, the recognition of tranquillity allowed the happiness to spread from body to mind. Unless I had looked for tranquillity within that deflationary phase when the fizz went out of an activity, the mood of disappointment would have remained. Note that nothing had changed in my circumstances to make me happy – only that I'd noticed and paid attention to the physical relaxation that happened as an activity turned from novel and exciting to hum-drum.

Happiness sets the stage for concentration, samadhi, which in turn brings forth the many fruits of the spiral path, starting with insight and leading onwards to full liberation. There isn't space to discuss these here, but I encourage you to investigate the earlier steps in the spiral, trust the fruits to ripen in their own time.

When dukkha brings you low, find your easiest entry point to the spiral. Notice the gladdening of heart that happens as you lift out of dukkha; notice the rapture (interest / uplift) that comes with any new activity and the tranquillity that settles in as the initial buzz dies away. Steadying your attention on tranquillity, notice the quiet happiness that it promotes. Trust this happiness to lead the mind towards stillness and hence to a deeper understanding of the dhamma. Thus all forms of dukkha, personal or due to climate change, can spur us into the spiral path to liberation.

AI 'Art'

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 3 min read

In this thoughtful reflection, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the fundamental difference between authentic art and AI-generated creations. Drawing from personal experiences at Gaia House and contemplating Van Gogh's 'The Olive Trees,' he explores how genuine art serves as what T.S. Eliot called an 'objective correlative' — a means of sharing deep human experience and understanding between artist and viewer.

The essay argues that while AI can produce technically impressive works, it lacks the essential quality that makes art meaningful: authentic human experience and intention. True art creates communion (communis) between human beings, allowing us to connect heart-to-heart through shared feeling and understanding. When we engage with machine-generated art, we lose this fundamental human connection and risk increased alienation and loneliness.

Bhante connects this technological challenge to Buddhist understanding, identifying our attachment to body and mind as the root cause of dukkha — our frustrating inability to find lasting happiness in the sensual world. He warns that relying too heavily on AI art and entertainment may deepen our separation from authentic human experience and our true inner nature, potentially making us more robot-like ourselves as we seek distractions from life's fundamental realities of aging, sickness, and death.

Bhante Bodhidhamma Art, in all its forms is a creative act. So are many areas of creativity such as science, technology, artifacts and so on. But Art is what TS Eliot called 'objective correlative'. When the artist wants to share an experience, they find a common metaphor or way to relate to the viewer or listener. It is about communicating experience or understanding in a way that the other not only understands but feels. I was teaching at Gaia House in May. It was bursting with spring. I stood beneath the oak in the front lawn with friends and we marvelled at its size, its strength and vitality. Its huge presence dwarfs us. Suppose the oak tree were made of plastic by an artist expressing his feelings about how people don't connect with nature? Or the same manufactured by a 3D printing machine at the command of an AI 'artist'. Machines don't do meaning. A few days later, I came across a painting by Vincent Van Gogh, called 'The Olive Trees'. If you google it, you will see it has little to do with olive trees as such. There is a swirling, undulating movement throughout the painting and the sombre blue mountains and churning clouds gives me the feeling of apprehension. It brought up the

feelings of foreboding I have about the Polycrisis. Van Gogh has shared with me the mental state he was in when he painted the picture. And I am grateful he has evoked these feelings in me. They motivate me to do the little I can to limit the Crisis. Suppose someone asked AI to produce a picture in the style of van Gogh of a football crowd. I have no doubt that it would be interesting, but it will lack experiential meaning. The 'artist' has done nothing and intends nothing but inane play. It may indeed evoke similar feelings, but I will be communicating with a machine. I will have lost that essential reason for art – communication – communis – as if one, in common. I won't be able to make a heart connection with another human being. It will just be lonely, little me, hugging my feelings. Of course, I might share the experience of a poem, a song, a picture with a friend, but there would still be that feeling that it is a machine, without care or ethics, that has induced these sentiments in me. All art forms with their various concerns such as erotic, social, political, personal and healing and religious, are communications between human beings. Imagine if all you had around you were robots who behaved exactly as human beings, but you knew they were devoid of inner purpose of life. How would you feel if in distress you were hugged by a cyborg? You may feel comforted, by what? It must be by way of a projection of a human onto a 'humanoid'. Surely, at some point, there must arise a feeling of separation from humans, an alienation, a deep loneliness. But why is this possible in the first place? Because we identify with the body and mind – the root cause of our dukkha, the frustrating inability to find lasting happiness in the sensual world. So we seek distraction. This has, of course, always been so, but now made more acute by relying on technology that further separates us from each other and from our true inner being. The real danger is that we become like robots – drowning out any feelings of meaninglessness, of sickness, ageing, sorrow and death with entertaining 'art' empty of human experience. Having said all this, no doubt artists will arise who can use AI to produce real art. Please send me your thoughts. This article inspired the Tip and is worth reading for the social and political consequence: The Trouble with AI art isn't just lack of originality. It's something far bigger. Eric Reinhardt 'Deep Bach' is an algorithmic program that uses machine-learning to analyse Johann Sebastian Bach's compositions and then produces its own variations. The results are convincing enough that many people can't distinguish between Deep-Bach and the real thing. Futures Centre The Threat of Computed Creativity Creativity here refers to Art. Letter by Nick Cage read by Stephen Fry

Affectionate Awareness

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 2 min read

This essay explores how to skillfully work with challenging emotions like fear, anger, guilt, and shame that arise during vipassanā meditation. Bhante Bodhidhamma introduces the concept of 'affectionate awareness' - a heart-centered approach that combines objective noting with tender loving care (TLC). Rather than pushing away difficult mental states or using noting as a weapon against them, practitioners learn to create distance through noting while simultaneously embracing these states with warmth and compassion. The teaching uses the metaphor of a physiotherapist working with a patient in pain - being both firm and gentle in the healing process. The essay provides practical guidance on how to deconstruct emotions by investigating their constituent sensations, emphasizing that this compassionate approach should not be used to get rid of emotions (which would be aversion in disguise) but to develop ease and acceptance. This balanced method helps prevent difficult mental states from hijacking one's meditation practice and daily life, ultimately supporting their natural dissolution through the process of liberation.

Affectionate Awareness in Vipassana

When we practice vipassana, the importance of equanimity cannot be overstated. Equanimity

supports the investigation of the Dhamma. In order to investigate impartially, without aversion, fear,

preference or expectation and clarity, we need to establish a very open-minded, open-hearted

attitude. This we can call pure vipassana.

However, sometimes while sitting, stuff comes up which is scary or very painful. Fears, anger, guilt,

shame and so on. Our normal reaction is to shy away from them. We try to push them away by using

the noting word as a pointing finger, stabbing at them. Or we simply bounce off them into happy

daydreams. Or we push them down by falling asleep. If these mental states are too much to bear, we

become very restless and go for a cup of tea.

Here is one way we can help ourselves bear with these heavy emotions and moods. We bring the heart

into play. Imagine yourself as a physiotherapist with a suffering patient who needs to stretch and exercise their limbs after a severe car accident. The excruciating pain is a necessary part of the healing process and the physio has to be firm, but also kind, gentle and encouraging. So it is within ourselves. Should an intense emotion or mood arise, we note it, and create a distance from it. The noting word, e.g. fear, fear, helps us to create that distance. Once that objectivity is there, not matter how tenuous, raise that old TLC, tender loving care, and as it were, hold the mental state in a warm embrace. You might even imagine your hands surrounding it. If you find this difficult, don't stop trying. At first it may even feel false, but eventually the willed intention will move the heart. Then once that feels stable, move towards the feeling of fear or nausea in order to explore its qualities. What subtle sensations are involved in such emotions or moods? We do this to deconstruct an emotion and in so doing it loses its solidity. When we see that emotions felt in the body are 'just' sensations, it helps us to lose our fear and aversion towards them. If you find you still cannot stay with the mental state, then pull back again and gently breathe that TLC into the emotion and saturate it. It is most important not to do this to get rid of it. That is just a manifestation of aversion and it will only subtly suppress it. Do it in order to undermine the reaction of aversion and fear and begin to feel at ease with the presenting mental state. Needless to say if it all gets too much, change posture, go for a walk, have a cup of tea. Remember we're not trying to defeat a mental state! When we become adept at doing this, these mental moods and emotions will stop hijacking our lives. We shall still have to deal with them in vipassana, but now they are truly beginning to burn out. Over time they will not be so painful, so insistent and so long lasting.

Eventually, of course, come the moment of liberation, they will disappear for good.
That's the
Buddha's good news!

Aim and Objective in Present Time

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 2 min read

This teaching addresses the fundamental challenge of living authentically in the present moment while navigating the practical demands of daily life. Bhante Bodhidhamma explores how our conventional understanding of linear time—past, present, and future—can become a barrier to experiencing reality as it unfolds moment by moment. The essay reveals how we often live disconnected from the present, either compelled by past decisions or driven by imagined futures, missing the immediacy of what is actually happening.

The core teaching introduces a transformative distinction between 'aim' and 'objective': while our aim might be future-oriented (such as arriving at an appointment on time), our objective can always be present-moment awareness—staying mindful of what is happening right now, including any anxiety, thoughts, or physical sensations that arise. Through practical examples like opening doors, brushing teeth, or traveling, the teaching illustrates how frequently we miss present moments by mentally projecting ourselves elsewhere.

This approach offers a middle way between the necessity of planning and scheduling in daily life and the cultivation of genuine present-moment awareness. Rather than abandoning the useful concept of time, we learn to hold it lightly while maintaining contact with immediate experience. The teaching provides a foundation for developing continuous mindfulness that supports both vipassanā meditation practice and awakened living in everyday situations.

Our concept of time is linear. We believe we are coming from a past, stop for a moment in the present and head off into the future. Historically speaking this is true. We can point to a past happening and we can predict to some extent what will happen in the future. These views can be considered as conventional. From a personal point of view, time is a way we structure events. If I said to you, I went for a walk yesterday afternoon, you would be able to position that walk in time – about so many hours ago. Not today. Not tomorrow. All this is useful for daily living, but it can be a barrier to experiencing time in a liberated way. In what way do we liberate ourselves from time? First of all it is to acknowledge that time does not actually exist. It is a concept whereby we organise past, present and future events. It's not that we want to get rid of the concept. If we did, we would be utterly disorientated. But we need to recognise the disconnection with actual present events that may come with it. This moment is sandwiched between what I think happened in the past (memories are never absolutely accurate)

and what I presume will happen in the future. So I am either being compelled to act in a certain way determined by a past decision or I am acting in a way dictated by a future I imagine or expect. In this way, I am never living in the present moment as it is right now. When I am behaving like this, I am not in contact with the way things really are. In fact I find myself often in conflict with what is actually happening or manipulating what is happening to realise a future event. I'm neither living in the future nor experiencing the present moment as it is. One way we can bring ourselves into present time is to make a distinction between aim and objective. Supposing we have to go to the dentist. (I prefer uplifting examples.) When I set off the aim is to get to the dentist on time. The objective is to stay mindful of what is happening every moment of the way. This may also include any anxiety about being late or thoughts about what may happen. This way we are always living in the present even though we may be experiencing the consequences of past action and the effects of future action. In other words, it is to live in the immediacy of the present moment. Catch yourself opening a door. Are you already in the other room? Catch yourself brushing your teeth. Are you in a hurry to get it over with, so you can launch yourself into bed? How many times have you set out on a journey and arrived at where you are going whether driving or public transport without any awareness of the journey? How many times have you 'misplaced' your keys? If we see how frequent is the number of missed present moments, we'll want to do something about it.

All in the Mind

Noirin Sheahan · 2 min read

In this insightful essay, Noirin Sheahan challenges the common dismissive attitude toward problems that are 'all in the mind,' revealing instead that all suffering is fundamentally mental in nature. Drawing from her meditation experience, she demonstrates how physical pain and mental reaction are entirely separate phenomena - the broken leg simply heals while the mind creates the drama of suffering around it.

Through vivid examples from walking meditation, Noirin illustrates the Buddhist teaching of the six sense spheres (āyatana), showing how sight, sensation, and mental awareness operate in distinct dimensions of experience. This direct insight reveals that while the mind weaves these separate streams into a coherent narrative, each sense door offers an alternative refuge from mental reactivity.

The essay culminates in a powerful personal account of working with anxiety, where Noirin discovers the voluntary nature of thought and the courage required to step away from mental proliferation. Her experience demonstrates how attention can be redirected from anxious thinking to simple sense contact, offering immediate relief from suffering. This practical wisdom shows how understanding the six sense spheres provides multiple doorways to freedom, making meditation not just an academic exercise but a direct path to liberation from mental turmoil.

Its all in the mind.

Noirin Sheahan

If we suffer a physical disease, a broken bone, a bereavement, we might get sympathy and attention. But if people suspect our problems are 'all in the mind' they usually want to get away as fast as they can!

And yet suffering is 'all in the mind'. The pain of a broken bone is physical. True we might writhe in agony, convinced our leg is where suffering is located. But the leg just gets on with the business of tissue repair. It's only the mind that panics, thinks 'this is unbearable', gets us moaning and contorted in an effort to sooth ourselves.

When the mind is still in meditation, we can sometimes see that physical sensations are separate from mental reactions like emotions and thoughts. In fact all of the six senses (five physical senses plus the mind which forms the sixth sense in Buddhism) occupy distinct 'spheres' within experience. I first saw this during walking meditation. I noticed that the sight of the foot swinging forward was totally separate

from the sensation. It was as if they occupied separate universes, different dimensions. One contained colours and shapes, the other sensations. There was no possibility of communication between the two, and it was a third dimension, the mind, that put the information together and decided they both described a foot moving forward. I was amazed that I could walk so easily even though my legs, eyes and mind were confined to separate dimensions!

This isn't just academic. The Buddha's only purpose in teaching was to point us along the path to the end of suffering. In meditation we begin to see for ourselves that suffering 'is all in the mind'. The fact that we can also experience other dimensions, where there is no suffering, allows us train the mind to stop causing us to suffer.

I learned this one time when my mind was afire with anxiety and I was only vaguely aware of sounds and sights in the environment. They seemed irrelevant by comparison to questions like - what was going on? Why couldn't I get on top of this anxiety? But for one blessed moment, attention came to rest on the sound of a bird singing. My mind relaxed momentarily but as soon as I noticed this, I went back to the more urgent business of fretting. As I did so I felt the voluntary nature of thought. I sensed myself choosing to indulge anxiety in much the same way as I might have chosen to pick up two heavy suitcases.

Now I was forced to make a choice. Would I continue burdening myself with anxious questions? It felt scary beyond words to stop, to accept the reality of not knowing what was going on, or how to get on top of anxiety. It was like taking a step over a cliff. And yet, something deep within commanded that I stop fretting, accept that I did not know any answers. With my heart in my mouth, I surrendered to that truth. Next moment, anxiety disappeared without trace!

Luckily, suffering is 'all in the mind'. And we have access to five other dimensions of experience which show us the way out. At each and every moment we can rest attention in sense contact, learn to recognize the possibility of not reacting, not picking up heavy suitcases of anxiety, depression, woe and misery. We can choose

sense contact rather than thought as our guide, step over our mental cliffs, fall into freedom.

Anattā — Not-Self

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 25 min read

In this profound evening retreat talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the third and most challenging of the Three Characteristics of existence: anattā, or not-self. Unlike a philosopher seeking mere intellectual agreement, the Buddha was a mystic whose aim was for practitioners to directly experience what he had realized.

The talk explores three methods the Buddha used to deconstruct the illusion of selfhood: the five aggregates (khandhas), the six sense spheres (āyatana), and the four foundations of awareness (satipaṭṭhāna). Through practical examples—from cars and airplanes to the process of eating—Bhante shows how everything we experience as 'whole' is actually a collection of interdependent parts.

Drawing from the Anattalakkhana Sutta, the Buddha's second discourse to his five companions, the talk demonstrates how we have limited control over body and mind, undermining the self's presumed authority. The ultimate paradox is revealed: Nibbāna possesses the eternal qualities we attribute to an eternal self, yet it is not-self. Through moment-to-moment awareness in Vipassanā practice, we can glimpse this reality where 'in the seeing, there's only the seeing'—pure awareness without the observer.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samasambuddhasa Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samasambuddhasa Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samasambuddhasa

Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble and Fully Self-Enlightened One.

We've now discussed two of the three characteristics that the Buddha taught to be the fundamental marks of all existence. The first, *dukkha*, unsatisfactoriness, pertains to any sentient being and especially human beings, how they contact and make sense of the world, and how a delusive relationship to sensual pain and pleasure causes suffering. We manufacture our own suffering because we believe that happiness is to be found in the sensual world. Then there was the quality of *anicca*, transience, the fact that everything is in process. As we also know from our science, there isn't actually any thing as such in the universe. It's all energy changing from one shape or form into another.

Both of these two characteristics aren't difficult to grasp. The only small difficulty I think we have is to see how indulgence in pleasure always brings dissatisfaction in its wake. The third characteristic, however, *anattā*, or the doctrine of not-self, as it can be

translated literally, is more difficult for us to grasp. But nonetheless, we can begin to intellectually understand the Buddha's position that nothing in the universe has substance, and the self, this person, that I feel and experience myself to be, is but a phantasm. It doesn't really have any real, substantial, essential existence.

First of all, we need to see the Buddha was not a philosopher. He was not a philosopher if what we mean by that word is someone who is concerned to convince someone else of an idea, someone who is simply concerned to prove a given premise. For the philosopher, it is satisfying enough to have someone agree with them. For instance, if a philosopher states that happiness is the goal of life, their concern is to prove that premise by various arguments. It matters little whether the philosopher themselves actually lives a happy life or not. It's an ideal, an idea worth striving for, even if the philosopher at heart doesn't really know whether it's possible or not. What is necessary is that they are convinced by reasonable argument.

But in this sense we're all philosophers to a degree. We prefer enticing logic. There's a part of us that feels satisfied that we've understood, accepted, and have faith in a statement. Believing in something is so much easier than coming to know by one's own personal experience. That's what we mean by realization, making it real for ourselves. But this demands effort, a lot of effort.

The Buddha was well acquainted with all the philosophical viewpoints of his day. As the discussions he has with various Brahmins and wandering ascetics show, he was able to do more than hold his own. But he knew where arguments stopped. What he saw was that these Brahmins and *Samaṇa* were caught up in simply trying to win arguments. They were, he said, ensnared in a jungle of views and opinions.

The Buddha had no reason to win arguments for winning's sake. His aim was not simply to convince people that his understanding was correct, but, and here's the difference, he wanted people to experience what he had experienced. In this sense he was a mystic, not some new age spaced out psychic you understand, but someone who has understood the deeper mysteries of life, someone who has realized, actually experienced for themselves, something beyond the world of apparition, the world of things, the world of sense-data and thought, beyond the phenomenal world.

The Buddha referred to himself as the *Tathāgata*, which translated literally means thus gone, or perhaps arrived there, but it was his way of saying transcendent. The Buddha's concern was to get people to have the same supramundane experience. Hence everything he said had the purpose of getting those convinced to do the practice, to

work at the practice in order to experience what he himself had attained. Unlike the philosopher, he really did know that happiness was the goal of human endeavour because he himself lived in perfect contentment and peace.

So now we come to this difficult teaching of *anattā*, not self. The primary confusion is that this is one of those philosophical premises that we can argue about. That *anattā* means there is no self, no soul, no eternal spirit, and so on. This is quite understandable. Even people in his own day accused the Buddha of being an annihilationist, that is, someone who didn't believe in an eternal self and that the human simply vanished in total at death. There was no afterlife, and even if there were, as some annihilationists believed, in the end it would just fizzle out when *kamma* had completed its momentum.

But the Buddha insisted he was not an annihilationist, and that the only annihilation was of greed, hatred and delusion. The Buddha's position was grounded in his present state, which he referred to as *Nibbāna*. Everything was to be measured against that living experience. Perhaps he would have been on easier ground if he had used an expression as not-*Nibbāna* for everything that the unenlightened person experienced.

In fact, there is a discourse where greater and greater pleasures are described, beginning with the delicious sensual pleasures and rising to the highest bliss of *jhānic* absorption. And he says that all these states are not the highest happiness, that is, not *Nibbāna*.

Although the Buddha's choice of the word *anattā* did and still confuses, he had good reason for choosing this word instead of others. He wanted to undermine the belief that anything a person experienced, whether through the five senses or the mind with its thoughts and images, or the heart with all its emotions and moods, in any way constituted something solid or everlasting.

To do this he would deconstruct the human being, and he did this by looking at the human being in various ways. We shall look at three of them, by way of the aggregates, the spheres, and the four foundations of mindfulness. By this process of deconstruction, the idea of something, anything, being whole, entire unto itself, an integer, a one, is undermined.

It is natural for the discriminative mind to see things as individual objects, to see objects as isolated, to cut up the world into this and that, and it's necessary we do so. Can you imagine not being able to tell the difference between a cup of tea and a cup of water? Heaven forbid. There's nothing wrong with seeing the world like this so long as we also see it isn't the way things really are. This ability of the mind to create concepts is not destroyed by enlightenment. It is simply put in its proper context.

There's a good example of this in art. Artists are forever trying to show us how the world really is. The Impressionists made us see that objects can only be fully understood within the environment they stand. A tree colours into the countryside. The Expressionists showed us that what we see is coloured by our emotions.

Now let's take a car. That's an object. We see it quite distinctly as separate from its environment. We see it moving as a separate object, and we know if we get in the way it's going to hurt. At an ordinary, conventional level of understanding, a car is hard and solid and is one thing, but we know it's made up. If we laid out all the pieces of a car on the floor, we wouldn't say that's a car. We'd say they're all the parts necessary to make up a car. Then, when we put it together, something quite magical happens. It propels itself. Definitely more amazing is an aeroplane. Tons of metal and what have you just lift so easily, so gracefully into flight.

And what we come to realise is the whole is always greater than the sum of the parts, even at a basic level. Take a few bits of wood and put them together, and hey presto, a chair, a table, a bed, and so on. When we look at the universe, we see it as a collection of wholes, forming greater wholes, until we arrive at the whole which is the cosmos itself.

When we look at a human being, it's the same. If you're a materialist for whom only matter exists, then there's the wonder of consciousness. When all the bits and pieces are put together and functioning, there arises this mysterious capacity to be conscious, to be aware, and in higher primates and human beings to be self-aware. This is something extra that arises inexplicably, accidentally, incidentally. This by-product is called by philosophers an epiphenomena. Once we label something, we think we understand it.

Now it's this very by-product that confuses us. Something that's made up of lots of other things produces a new function. The car made up of bits propels itself, the plane flies. And we see it as a whole, an integer, a one. We forget it's made up of parts. It's only when the car won't start, or the plane drops out of the sky, that we're suddenly pulled up short. It's only when a part of the body hurts or becomes ill that we suddenly realize that wholes are made up of parts.

Now the most common deconstruction device in the discourses is the aggregates or collections or heaps, the *khandha*. You will notice here links with the dependent originations. The Buddha divides the human into five different aggregates: the physical base, perceptions, feelings, volitional formations and cognition.

The physical base or *rūpa* is again divided into four primary elements we've mentioned before: earth or solidity, fire or temperature, air or movement and water or cohesion. These four great elements are the way that the mind first experiences matter. At that basic percept there is only the object, the sense faculty, and cognition, a knowing. Sound, for instance, at this level, is experienced simply as pressure on the eardrum. Heaviness or lightness, that's the earth element. It's not that the other elements are not present. All the elements are present in any one given percept, but one always predominates. Fire or temperature would predominate in sight. Where there's light, there's heat, and vice versa.

So the whole experience of sense contact can be deconstructed into these elements. Now whether these elements actually exist outside the mind is not relevant, for these are simply the way the senses sense the world out there. And in our meditation, we can do it in a more obvious way by experiencing the different parts of the body from this point of view. Bones can be felt as solid, just the quality of hardness. The heat or cold we feel can be seen as just temperature. The sponginess of muscles and flesh can be experienced as elasticity, cohesiveness. The feeling of movement caused by breathing can also be isolated.

Why do this? Simply to break down the concept of wholeness. For with the concept of wholeness comes the concept of substance, real independent existence. The me, the I. Such as, I feel, therefore I am. I think, therefore I am. And of course, I suffer, therefore I am. And that's the delusion.

Then there are all the perceptions that the mind produces every moment. This is the second aggregate, *saññā*. From this basic contact we get our perceptions of taste. Whether something is salty, sweet, bitter, astringent or sour, that's why I like to stress the importance of eating, because we get in touch with this ever-present flow of perceptions and we can begin to see how they build up into the concept of a particular dish. If we were blindfolded, we'd still be able to tell it was spaghetti and not curry. But when we eat mindfully, we become aware of the different tastes that go into making up the supposed one taste, such as the hardness of spaghetti, the sweetness and saltiness in the sauce, and so on. It again breaks up for us the delusion that there's only one taste in the taste of spaghetti.

Then there's feeling, the third aggregate, *vedanā*. What is meant here is the secondary response to sensations. Feelings arise when we experience all these perceptions as likeable or unlikeable, pleasant or unpleasant. This also includes how we experience the feelings in our body caused by emotions. Again, when we concentrate inwardly, we

can see that we divide our experience of life into pleasant and unpleasant. Although we also talk about neutral feelings, if we get close up to them, we will discover some delicate shade of liking or disliking there.

These three *khandha*, aggregates, are the materials upon which the fourth *khandha* works, the *saṅkhāra*, the volitional formations. It's here that self steps in and tries to take control. A world is created out of all the percepts, perceptions and feelings. Our whole emotional and intellectual life springs out of this. And it's all manufactured by self for the pleasure of self, when we're deluded. And the creator is our will, which empowers all the intentions we make throughout our life. It's with these *saṅkhāra*, volitional formations, fabrications, creations, that we go out and do things. For the enlightened person, of course, it becomes a way of expressing wisdom into the world by way of compassionate action and service.

And finally there are the acts of cognition, *viññāṇa*. This is a discriminative consciousness. It sees everything as separate, whether it be by way of contradiction or comparison. *Viññāṇa* is the mind's ability to hold a frame up that is then understood. It's like a mirror which holds all the images together as a whole and gives us the impression that we live in a solid world. We simply couldn't function if all we were aware of was the storm of perceptions coming through the sense doors. It is the primary knowing, it is the faculty that tells us there's a bell ringing and it's lunchtime. It's not to be confused with the understanding or the intuitive intelligence, *satipaṇṇa*. That, as we shall see, is something else.

So this is one way the Buddha deconstructs our experience of the world by way of the *khandha*, the aggregates of form or matter, basic perceptions, feelings in the body caused both by the body itself and the mind, volitional formations which are all our emotional and thought life, manufactured by our power of will, and finally cognition or a primary knowing.

And we can use this in our practice. We can simply note things from this point of view. We note movement in the breath, heat or cold, a fire element, pressure, the earth element or the tightness we feel, the air element, the sheer movement, the lightness of joy, the warmth of love, and so on. Perceptions we note as images or thoughts. Feelings we feel directly, experience intimately and note. The *saṅkhāra* are all our intentions that manufacture the fantasies and thoughts, both consciously volitional or habitual, throughout the whole day. And cognition can be recognized in the act of noting of any object, no matter what it is, as the object we come to note.

The second way the Buddha deconstructs the human experience is by way of the avenues or spheres of cognition. Each avenue or sphere being distinct, exclusive and discrete. The five senses and the mind itself. When it comes to the five senses, we can't mix them. We can't smell with our eyes and we can't see with our ears and so on. They are quite different avenues of consciousness or spheres of experience and this is what the Buddha calls them, the *āyatana*, the spheres.

The mind itself is seen as the sixth sense in this case, for it makes sense of all the other incoming data. What is actually received into the mind is quite minimal. The mind has to work hard to put it all together. But it is quite discrete from the sense-bases, for if all the five senses were to disappear, the mind would have nothing to do but mess around in the library of its own images, thoughts, moods and emotions.

Now when we experience an event, it is experienced again as a whole. At the cinema or watching a video or TV, it's all one experience. We see the film, hear the dialogue, the music, we taste the popcorn or biscuits. It's all one big experience. It's only when we start concentrating on the moment that we realize there are a myriad of mental processes going on. In fact, there can only arise one act of cognition at a time. The mind can only perceive one piece of data at any one given moment, but it's all going so fast and cognition is so good at manufacturing pictures out of that data that we experience life as one continuous whole, not as a series of discrete perceptions.

Can you imagine watching TV, where at one moment you see the picture, that goes out, and then you hear the dialogue? You put a biscuit in your mouth, and on the taste you lose both the vision and the hearing of the program. It would be impossible to live like that in a sort of stroboscopic universe. Thanks to the speed of cognition, it's all magically formulated into one piece. But there lies our delusion, because we believe that's the way things really are.

The point of insight meditation is to see beyond the apparent and to see that everything is only a compendium, a collection. There's nothing real or solid about any experience whatsoever. As the Buddha says, it's all like bubbles in a stream. By noting our meditative experiences along these lines, the avenues of consciousness, and realizing how discrete they are, we get in touch with how we fabricate the world and undermine the delusion of wholeness or substance. And this, of course, rebounds upon the concept of the self, of the me. What is this me? Where is this me to be found if everything I believe to be me is nothing but a collection of sensual and mental data?

Now there is another way the Buddha deconstructs our experience by way of the elements, the *dhātu*. I want to mention it briefly here because it tells us how far this deconstruction can go. The last two of the 24 elements are called the mind object and the

mind cognition elements. These go into a moment to moment detail of how the mind manufactures a single thought. And believe it or not, this can actually be experienced. That's how profound this meditation can take us into seeing how the mind works to generate a world and ultimately how we come to be deceived by it.

Now apart from this process of deconstruction, there is another way in which we can see that the self is a false identity. The self likes to think of itself in control, the agent, to have power over. It wants to do my own thing, in my own way, in my own time.

The Buddha, after he became enlightened, sought out his five companions. He found them in Isipatana Park. There, he first talked about the Four Noble Truths, and one of the company attained the first level of enlightenment, stream entry, *Sotāpanna*. But when he gave his second discourse, they were all fully awakened. This discourse is called the discourse on the characteristic of not-self.

Here's the gist of it. Meditators, the body, form, the sense bases, are not-self. If the body was a self, it would not lead to suffering. For one could say to the body, let the body be healthy, let the body not be sick. But the body isn't like that. It is because we can't tell the body what to do that suffering arises.

We feel we have control over the body, don't we? I mean, we can make it walk and talk and eat and so on. But this is like the driver of a car who can make the car start and stop, turn left or right. But what control has the driver over the car in itself? And how much does a driver know about the workings of a car? We find ourselves in a similar position with the body. On closer inspection, we experience little of the internal workings, never mind know about them. Indeed, the body, for the most part, takes care of itself.

What do I experience of the digestive system? What control have I got over it? What about the circulatory system? I haven't a clue in terms of real experience what my blood is doing. I've read about it, but I've never experienced hemoglobin turning red when it meets with oxygen in the lungs. I feel my abdomen and chest moving when I breathe, but I've never experienced the blood exchanging carbon dioxide for oxygen. The whole thing just works altogether without me interfering. In fact, it's when I don't recognise that I'm not the body that I'm in danger of doing it harm, when I push the body too hard or overeat and drink intoxicants and so on.

In other words, although we have a certain amount of control over the body, it's quite superficial. I can make it walk and talk but I can't make it grow one way or the other. Or make it beautiful. I can't will myself to become a great athlete. I can't stop it growing old and I can't stop it dying. My control over the body is superficial. And yet I'm utterly dependent on this body for my existence on this planet. A humbling thought.

In the same way, we can go through the other *khandha*, the aggregates, and see that it's the same with the perceptions we have, the feelings, the emotions, and the thoughts we have. Eventually, we have very little control over the type of personality we have. Even when we become fully enlightened, we don't change the flavor of our personality radically. The Buddha was still recognizably Siddhartha Gautama. His five companions recognized him as such, but that personality was then purified of all malevolence.

This lack of power can be seen even in the way we perceive the world. Humans can see only a particular band within the whole spectrum of colour, and each of us has our own experience of colour. Some of us are colourblind, some of us have poor sight. Our emotional life is also conditioned, and our thought life too. For instance, certain types of music will affect us, other types won't. Our thought is bound up with the language we speak and the culture that's produced it. European people, for instance, have very different cultural values to people in the East. With insight, of course, we do begin to create a better interior life. But it will still be greatly conditioned by our culture and environment.

We've now discussed two aspects of how the Buddha undermines the self-delusion. By deconstructing a seeming whole and by questioning the power that self presumes to have. In this way, the Buddha tries to undermine the belief that the body and mind are some sort of eternal person, soul or spirit.

But our delusion doesn't stop there at the obvious, so to speak. He also wanted to undermine the belief that beneath these attributes, the body and mind as we experience them, lies any other real self whatsoever, something which is eternal. Take a hand, for instance. Let's look at it and feel it. We see it has certain colour, a certain shape. We feel it has soft parts and hard parts, and so on. Let's presume that we've seen and felt a hand to an ultimate degree. We know all its attributes. We realise it's made up of bits and pieces. But let's say this isn't the real hand. To discover the real hand, we must, as it were, slip these attributes away. Can you imagine taking off your hand as you would a glove to reveal another hand which was real, substantial, unchangeable, eternal, indestructible, and so on?

It was this sort of idea that the Buddha also wanted to undermine. For this was the more subtle meaning of the word *atta*, self, in his time, as it is today for people who believe in an afterlife, namely that there is a subtle body beneath or within the material body that is substantial, immortal, and will go on to live forever.

At the time of the Buddha, the scriptures of the Brahmins, now called Hinduism, had been developing along similar lines, but in the general understanding of things, the *Atta*, the Self, had come to mean both the empirical Self and the Eternal Self, the capital S. The empirical self is how we experience ourselves now as personalities, as persons with thoughts, emotions, sensations, relationships and so on. But the eternal self posited some self beneath or transcendent of this, like the real hand beneath the apparent hand.

Whatever later Hinduism came to believe, it was all confusion in the Buddha's time. So the Buddha simply swept that confusion aside by telling everyone that anything they conceived of, an eternal soul, spirit or self, was but wishful thinking. Put another way, anything they experienced by way of the body, heart and mind was not self, *anattā*. Whether physical, psychological or ethereal, whatever self a person experienced themselves to be, that self was a construct and had no real, substantial or essential existence.

Now let us remember that the Buddha is concerned to get us to experience this, to come to know this for ourselves. We have to have practical, direct, personal experience. Remember, to be convinced of all this by way of thought, by way of a philosophical proposition, just won't do. We might be able to write deep philosophical books about it, but that won't bring us to the end of suffering.

So the Buddha now deconstructs the human being, this psychophysical organism, into yet another division in order to lead us to an experiential understanding, a direct realization of not-self. He now teaches us to look at ourselves from the point of view of the four foundations of mindfulness, the *satipaṭṭhāna*. They can be seen as four frames of reference, whereby we can experience this psychophysical organism I call me, break down its illusion of wholeness, and discover indeed that there is no other reality beneath them, within them, above them, or anywhere around them.

You will by now be familiar with all the terminology but it's looked at in a slightly different way. This is important because up till now we've looked at ways of deconstructing the human being but they've had an intellectual bias. With the *Satipaṭṭhāna* the Buddha is being immediate and practical. This is the way we can note, observe, feel and experience and so come to understand the way we really are by the direct path of Vipassanā.

The first is *Kāyānupassanā*, investigating the body. It means we need to be mindful of all our daily actions, standing, walking and so on, and to see that no action is one thing. It's made up of a myriad of movements. This includes the action of breathing. At its most profound level is to see how the mind contacts the body. That's when we experience those four great elements of earth, fire and so on we discussed earlier.

Then there's a whole area of feeling in the body. That's *vedanānupassanā*. These feelings, remember, can be caused by the body, as when our knees hurt, or by the mind, as when an emotion comes up.

Then there's *cittānupassanā*. Here we note, feel, observe, and come to know our states of mind, all the moods and emotions, thoughts and images, whether it's concentrated or not, suffering or not, and so on.

And finally, there's *Dhammānupassanā*. This refers to certain teachings which are specific to the Buddha Dhamma. The five aggregates, the five hindrances, the six sense spheres, the seven factors of enlightenment, and the four noble truths, which include, of course, the three characteristics of existence, impermanence, unsatisfactoriness, and not-self. We have, of course, touched upon all these during the last few days.

These *satipaṭṭhāna*, establishments of awareness, are the frames of reference by which the intuitive wisdom, *paññā*, can investigate and come to see, to realize the human condition from an enlightened point of view.

In meditation, through the process of *vipassanā*, we can begin to experience directly this doctrine of *anattā*, not self. The most obvious way is through the noting technique. Whenever something comes into our attention, be it the breath, a sensation, a feeling, a thought, we mentally point to it as it were. We note it. We say, rising, falling, itching, anger, joy, and so on. This pointing at it distances us from it. What we are really saying is, there are the feelings of the breath, rising and falling. There are the feelings of itching, and so on. There, over there, not here. Not here within the knowing. We are objectifying the inner world in the same way as babies and toddlers we began to objectify the outer world by pointing. At the inner objects, the sensations, feelings, thoughts, we're distancing ourselves from them, and the noting technique helps us to do that.

As our meditation deepens, then thought disappears, the noting stops, and we learn to perceive that what we experience within ourselves is not the same as the knowing which is experiencing it. At this point, the true nature of the knowing begins to dawn upon us. What is this awareness? What is this intuitive intelligence? What is *satipaṇṇā*? Now that's the question, and this meditation is leading us directly to that answer.

Now here's the paradox. Why is it that the Buddha says that *Nibbāna* is just as we would want any eternal self to be, but it is not self? Unlike everything in the phenomenal world, which is *anicca*, transient, *Nibbāna* is *nicca*, not transient. It doesn't arise and pass away. It is the deathless, immortal, just like an eternal self. Unlike the enlightened state where everything is eventually unsatisfactory, *Nibbāna* is a state of complete contentment, perfect peace, yet it is not an eternal self.

This is expressed most clearly in the three verses we chant every morning. All conditioned things are impermanent. All conditioned things are unsatisfactory. But all conditioned things and the unconditioned are not self. When this is perceived with wisdom, one becomes disenchanted with what cannot satisfy. Just this is the path of purification.

When we think about it, is there ever a time when the idea of me doesn't come up without a self-awareness? Indeed, isn't that what we mean by a self? The feeling of a me. Is there a self in deep sleep? We just presume it, don't we? I presume that since I went to sleep feeling myself to be me, and wake up feeling the same, my self must have been there all through sleep. But it's an inference, isn't it? An assumption. How can we prove it?

In meditation we feel ourselves to be an observer. There seems always to be somebody watching, doing, experiencing. In pure *vipassanā*, this feeling vanishes entirely. Yet there is still the watching, the doing, the experiencing, but no sense of a self doing it. That's why the Buddha says, In the seeing, there's only the seeing. In the hearing, there's only the hearing. In the cognizing, there's only the cognizing.

Can we, unenlightened beings as we are, get a taste of what that selfless state might be? Yes, indeed we can, but again a paradox. We can't do it by an act of self-will. It's not within the power of self to go beyond self. All we can do is set up the conditions whereby we might have a not-self experience. And here is where the Buddha shows the depth of his gift as a teacher. He asks us only to be concerned with establishing right awareness, not to bother about experiencing *Nibbāna* or not-self, which we simply can't achieve by an act of will.

So what is right awareness? First of all, it's not intellectual knowledge. If everything said in this talk has been fairly new, you may very well be confused by the five of these and the four of those. Well, don't worry. If you're interested in it at all, then after this course you can read and study it all. But here in meditation, it's not even necessary to know it. So I go on about it because through these arguments we can at least become intellectually convinced of our insubstantiality. Being convinced intellectually, hopefully we have more faith in *vipassanā* and more eagerness to see if it's really true. In other words, it's about getting a right attitude.

Now, presumably we have it now. So we can concentrate just on the practice, which is simply to be aware of all that arises and passes away. As we begin to centre in on what we are experiencing, let's say the sensations caused by the breath, using the noting to keep the thinking mind from making us lose our focus, *sati*, awareness begins to concentrate on, gather around a smaller and smaller event, a smaller and smaller unit of time, drawing itself into the immediate present moment. And at that point there is no time to think, no time to reflect. The thinking mind has no time in which to think. The noting stops.

As the interval of time decreases, so the time interval is so small we can experience single sensations arising and passing away. This *sati* awareness doesn't even have the time to recognize its own presence, seeing itself, feeling itself mirrored within the mind like a shadow. It constructs an image of itself. That image we experience as self-awareness. But as this awareness sits simply in the presenting instant, even that feeling of self-awareness disappears.

And there is the experience of just observing, just watching. The feeling, the idea, the belief that there is a soul, a self, a spirit, disappears. For that moment, and for longer periods of time, if the practice is good, the meditator experiences pure awareness, unadulterated by the view or feeling of a self.

We can see now that the *Anattā* teaching is not saying there is nothing, but that whatever ultimate reality is, it is not a self or a feeling of a self. In ultimate reality, just as in the phenomenal world, there are no things. And the feeling of self-awareness is the feeling of a thing, but the subtlest of things, and therefore the most difficult of things to perceive as insubstantial and not self.

So how do we get a glimpse of this? By doing the practice according to the Buddha's instructions. Forget about *Nibbāna*. Forget about trying to have a spiritual experience. Forget about the *vipassanā* insights. Forget about achieving anything. Save a moment-to-moment attentiveness. Just place all our energy into observing the presenting object, be it a sensation, emotion or thought. Ultimate truth is to be experienced in the presenting event, the here and now. Hence, our whole effort is simply to be present. Ultimately, we will have that glimpse.

The Buddha says there is a consciousness which has no characteristics, no attributes, beyond the realm of scientific measurement. A consciousness that is without boundary, in all directions, lustrous, full of light, awake. Just this is the end of suffering.

Let's pause here for a moment. Whenever we look at something, that becomes an object. Being an object, it cannot be the subject. The knowing cannot be what it knows. Even the feeling of a self, when we are self-aware, self-conscious, must also be an object. It cannot be that which knows. Grasping this, at first a fear and anxiety may arise in us. Who are we if we're not this body, these emotions, these thoughts, this personality? But when we begin to see things as they really are, and where our true nature actually resides, then a real peace, a real happiness begins to flower.

And where does our true nature reside? It resides in our ability to discover a relationship to the world without and the world within, wherein we find intimacy without identity, where we are utterly engaged, utterly involved and yet detached. Such paradox can only be solved by that knowing the Buddha within. So we have to keep working

As Winter Approaches

Noirin Sheahan · 2 min read

In this contemplative piece, Noirin Sheahan weaves together personal memories of her mother with profound Dhamma reflections on the changing seasons. Using November's transition into winter as a starting point, she explores how our dependence on physical conditions like warmth and light reveals our deep attachment to bodily experience. The essay offers an accessible introduction to the four elements teaching—earth (solidity), water (cohesion), air (movement), and fire (temperature/light)—showing how these fundamental aspects of our embodied existence provide a gateway to understanding the nature of attachment and aversion. Sheahan demonstrates how seasonal changes, particularly the 'November blues' many experience as daylight fades, can become opportunities for deeper practice rather than sources of suffering. She encourages readers to move beyond the mind's commentary and preferences to develop intimate awareness of direct physical sensations—the cold of toes, the warmth of hands—as a foundation for insight. The essay beautifully illustrates how embracing rather than resisting challenging conditions can lead to a 'welcome counterpoint to the unending chit-chat of the mind,' ultimately pointing toward our capacity to find peace even in darkness and discover the 'vibrant stimulation' in what we typically label as unpleasant experiences.

As Winter Approaches.

Traditionally, November is the month of the dead, the 'Holy Souls' in Christian understanding. It's a time to remember those we have lost. My mum died in January and I am remembering her and how she used to love this time of year - closing the curtains early and looking forward to long evenings by her fireside. For many people November has the opposite effect. As the days get shorter and the sunlight fades a gloomy depression mounts. It's humbling to see our dependence on physical basics like daylight and sunshine for optimism and good humour.

It's also an opportunity to reflect on the teaching on the elements – earth, water, air and fire – the basis for bodily experience. Earth represents solidity; we sense this as pressure, hardness, softness, weight. We experience the water element when it spatters into our face as rain, lets eyelids skim over the delicate surface of the cornea. The air element represents movement – we sense this when we turn our head, when the legs swing forward while we walk. The fire element is responsible for the November blues; changes in temperature and light tell us that this element, like the others, is not to be taken for granted, not ours to have when we want it to discard

when we want something else.

We're very attached to bodily experience! As a baby it was our main source of pleasure and pain. Later the mental world became more prominent – the pleasure of reading, socializing, achieving, the pain of misunderstanding, rejection, failure.

Delusion allows our mental life to take over the show; like James Joyce's Mr.

Duffy, most of us live "at a little distance from our bodies".

The fading of heat and light at this time of year provides a wake-up-call. Warmth is the vital sign of life while light has spiritual as well as physical significance – near death experiences often report moving through a dark tunnel towards light. No wonder we are so deeply attached! To go to the root of the problem we need to rediscover the pleasure and pain of the embodied life, rest attention on cold toes or warm hands. There's the simple physicality of warmth or coolness; there's also the overlay of commentary, liking, disliking, desire & aversion. As we watch, the overlay simplifies down, and when conditions are right, stops. What a relief! An easy intimacy grows, but so delicate! It shatters with any grumbling for more heat, brighter light ... Slowly and painfully we learn to drop our preferences, be grateful for whatever sensations the body offers. These sensations provide our footing in reality, a welcome counterpoint to the unending chit-chat of the mind. With our feet planted firmly in reality, our true nature can take shape.

I like to remember my mum's November evenings when she gladly turned away from the hustle and bustle of life to rest by her fireside, read her books. I can follow her lead, retreat into my body, let it become my focus for winter evenings, curl up with the book of Dhamma – the real-life one printed on direct experience. The chapter on the elements is always a good place to start. What better way to greet the cold, dark days of November than by learning to love the vibrant stimulation we term 'cold', discovering peace in darkness?

Thanks for the memories, Mum.

Assisted Suicide

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 9 min read

This essay examines complex end-of-life ethical issues—including assisted suicide, euthanasia, and abortion—through the lens of Buddhist teachings. Bhante Bodhidhamma explores the third pārājika rule from the Vinaya, which prohibits monastics from intentionally depriving human beings of life or encouraging death, establishing the foundation for Buddhist medical ethics.

The essay emphasizes that human birth represents a precious opportunity for spiritual development within saṃsāra, referencing the Buddha's analogy of the rare turtle surfacing to strike a floating log. Drawing from both Theravāda understanding of the nibbānic element and insights about the Tathāgatagarbha teaching, Bhante presents life as a complete training ground where even suffering offers opportunities for wisdom and compassion.

Practical applications include the doctrine of double effect in medical decisions, discontinuing life support, and patient autonomy in terminal care. The essay distinguishes between legal and ethical considerations, emphasizing how Right Understanding must inform Right Intention to produce skilful action. Through the lens of kamma and anusaya (underlying tendencies), it explores how even well-intentioned actions can carry unwholesome consequences if based on delusion rather than wisdom.

Abortion, Suicide, Euthanasia, Assisted Suicide and Murder

I think the title just about covers different words we have for purposely bring to end a person's life,

whether it's one's own or another's. The argument around this area boils down to what is called in

religious circles the sanctity of life or the preciousness of human birth. Murder, the wilful taking of

another's life out of greed, hatred and delusion, would, I think, be considered clearly unethical by

most of us. The others present a variety of ethical dilemmas. The purpose of this essay is not to go

into the intricacies of all the arguments. Here I wish only to lay the platform of ethic upon which we

can base our actions, specifically around the recent topic of assisted suicide. Approaching these

issues by way of the Noble Eightfold Path, with clarity around Right Understanding, the Right

Attitude or Intention arises and so Right Action should then follow suit.

We need to establish the meaning of life and death according to the Buddha's teaching and then to

understand the law of kamma. Rarely is any decision to be made a simple choice between right and

wrong since ethical decisions are tempered by circumstance and context. That is why the Buddha

states the ethical law not as commandments but as 'training rules' sikkhapada, literally 'footsteps of a trainee'.

The Vinaya, the rule established for the Sangha of bhikkhus and bhikkunis, is not something the

Buddha thought out, but practical and wise as he was, it was only when someone acted unskillfully,

did he declare a rule. Some rules are to do with the definition of an institution and others with moral

law. The first four are a group known as parajika, end of life or defeat. Should a monastic transgress

these rules they are no longer a member of the order whether they confess or not. Even should they

continue to live deceptively in the order, they will know in their hearts that they are no longer a

bhikkhu or bhikkhuni.

The rule that is of interest here is the third parajika:

Should a member of the Sangha intentionally deprive a human being

of life, or search for an assassin for them, or praise the advantages of

death, or incite them to die saying for instance, 'Friend, what use is

this wretched, miserable life to you? Death would be better for you

than life,' or with such an idea in mind, such a purpose in mind, should

in various ways praise the advantages of death or incite them to die,

that is a defeat and they are no longer in communion.

Please note: life according to Buddhaddhamma begins at conception.

This Rule states the highest form of moral rectitude and is expected of a monastic. What then would

be the arguments against abortion, euthanasia, suicide and assisted suicide? The answer lies in the

meaning of life.

A young man came to see me once and told me his partner wanted a child, but he saw no reason why he should bring another being into samsara, a world of dukkha, an ever ongoing becoming that cannot deliver any real happiness. I reminded him that the Buddha spoke of human birth as the most advantageous of all in order to make spiritual progress because here we have that mixture of joy and woe and the intelligence to see where the escape lies. In which case I said to him, in my opinion, apart from attaining one of the four spiritual paths and fruits, there was no greater act of compassion than to bring another being into this life and educate them in the Buddhadhamma. I didn't see him again! I dare say it was a bloke thing about commitment to marriage. The Buddha gave an image to show how rare a human birth is. He asks us to imagine a vast ocean with one log floating on the surface. Every hundred years a turtle rises to the surface. What would be the odds of it hitting its head on that log? Although I am a Theravada monk, I warm to the later Mahayana teaching of the Tathagatagarba Discourse for the accent here is on that which seeks its liberation, called rather mysteriously in

Theravada the Nibbanic element, nibbana dhatu. It gives a positive spin to our quest. It points not to the experience of Nibbana, which admittedly is the Buddha's own preference in teaching, but what it is that experiences Nibbana. The Buddha referred to himself as the Tathagata which translates as Thus Gone or Thus Arrived. He refers to Nibbana as the 'other shore'. The Buddhas and the arahants are the ones who have arrived 'over there'. They are the ones who have transcended this life form. And what is it that has transcended this life form but that which knows, our intuitive awareness, sati-panya. Therefore, when we really grasp that this life, the whole of this life from the moment of

conception to

the moment of death is a training ground, where not a moment is wasted so long as we understand

there is always something to learn – even in the most severe pain, in the most terrible depression,

despair and anguish – all of it offers us an opportunity to grow in wisdom and compassion. It cannot,

therefore, be seen as a skilful act to end one's life prematurely or to help another do so – even at

conception.

Now that's the ideal! But the relative world rarely offers an easy, straight forward situation and I am

sure you can think of many occasions where a persuasive argument could be made for abortion,

euthanasia, assisted suicide and suicide. It is important here to understand that unskilful does not

mean evil in the way that word is commonly used. It is evil to murder someone, but hard to call it evil

to assist someone in their suicide – someone, for instance, who may be driven to distraction with pain

or perhaps to put an end to a so-called vegetative state for we cannot know that person's inner state.

Yet it is still unskilful to terminate a life for whatever reason for it takes away the potential for

spiritual understanding to arise within the person's lifetime and who knows when such an

opportunity may arise again. This may seem very harsh when our dominant purpose is compassion

and indeed the wholesome result from compassion may outweigh any unwholesome result from

ending life whether it's our own or of another. It may be a case of a willingness to bear any

unwholesome results out of compassion for another.

So from our understanding comes our intention that imbues an act with wholesomeness or

unwholesomeness. And according to the law of kamma, if we think, say or do something

unwholesome, then we will reap some unwholesome result. The same law applies, of course, to

wholesome acts. It is, then, up to us to be very clear as to our motivations should we find ourselves in a situation where the premature ending of life seems to be an answer. It may be a smoke screen for other subliminal intentions to argue for the alleviation of suffering, such as not wanting to suffer pain or unable to be with someone in pain. Just because we are not aware of underlying intentions doesn't mean they will not affect our conditioning. We know from Western psychology that suppressed or repressed wishes cause psychological damage. In Buddhaddhamma these are our anusaya, proclivities, inclinations, tendencies. And should we think our intention is benevolent, but is in fact unwise and morally wrong, that will also produce unwholesome kamma. For instance, I knew someone who was a-when-it-suits-me-communist – any way he took to Proudon's declaration that that all property is theft with fierce logic. He built up quite a library, thieving books and for some reason never saw the irony! But then any unskilful act that is seen as skilful by the perpetrator reinforces their delusion. I lost contact so I don't know if he was ever caught or suddenly seeing the self-deception under which he was amassing volumes had pangs of conscience and felt obliged to pay for them. So we need to make sure that our main intention is ethically correct. Often it is only through insight meditation, vipassana, that we become aware of our anusaya, subliminal intentions and the strength of these ignored conditionings. Nor would it be right to think that in committing suicide or assisting someone to do so that thereby they escape the consequences of the act or of past actions. At the Birmingham Vihara one of our members committed suicide and I asked Ven. Dr. Rewata Dhamma, our resident teacher, what happens to such a person. He said he would go on committing suicide through a hundred lives.

‘Rubbish!’ was my first reaction – not out loud of course. But after some thought, I realised to commit suicide was a very strong act of will that would produce a very strong conditioning. It was plausible to say that every time that being came across great difficulty that would continue to be their escape. Only when they turned around on that conditioning and refused to obey would the real escape manifest – calling for courage and patient endurance.

These days there is often confusion between illegal and immoral. In a liberal society more and more ethical decisions, more of personal than those of wider social effect (or so it is thought) such as divorce, abortion, suicide, all of which were once criminal offences, are laid at the door of the individual. Unfortunately in making unethical behaviour legal, it takes away the social stigma and such actions soon become normal and ordinary – and easily accepted as ‘moral’. The consequence of this is to blind people to the effect of harmful behaviour especially within themselves. In denial of shame and guilt, there is no possibility of remorse. This turbulence in the heart is repressed by self-righteousness which becomes ever more callous. Witness the philosophy supporting eugenics that lead Nazis to justify killing people with mental and physical disability. So should we find ourselves in a position of advising someone or indeed having to make such decisions for ourselves, we must be rigorous in honesty and not fool ourselves. Let us for the sake of discussion take three cases: those that involve the doctrine of double effect, those that terminate life by turning off a life support machine and those that involve a patient’s desire to die. The doctrine of double effect concerns in the main doctors, but the patient and relatives may be part of the decision making. A patient is in a terminal condition. A doctor administers medicine to

alleviate suffering of a dying patient knowing it will kill the patient. The patient may have asked for this or may not know it. Should the medicine be administered with the purpose to hasten death that would be unskilful – and a criminal offence. Should it be to ease the condition of the dying that would be skilful.

In the case where a family is asked permission to turn off a life support machine, they have to be sure that the advice given is clearly one of no hope of survival. If there is hope of survival, then it would be unskilful to end that person's life, no matter what their situation. Here, of course, the questions around so-called 'vegetative states' and artificial life support machines loom large. It is well to remind ourselves that there are no absolute moral laws in a relative world. Each case will have to be dealt with according to the circumstances. And 'best intentions' have to arise out of Right Understanding.

Where a person is terminally ill, should they wish to die out of aversion, depression, sense of pointlessness to suffering and so on, it would be unskilful to stop taking the medicine or sustenance or receive other life supportive measures. However, should they see the futility of further treatment, even though they want to live, to ask that no further life supportive measures be taken, that would be skilful.

Now we all know that such situations can be far more complex than this. But hopefully such clear standpoints give us a basis from which we can act as skilfully as the situation will allow us.

I have here tried to point to the highest ideals of Buddhadhamma. I aspire to them, yet hope I am never tested. And should I fail, there will surely arise another opportunity for growth! In the teaching of the Buddha, even unskilfulness, fully acknowledged, can become a cause for spiritual advancement.

If you want to find a good web based source for discussion the BBC has a very readable site on all the

important ethical issues www.bbc.co.uk/ethics

The site that best covers ethical issues from the point of view of Buddhadhamma is:

www.buddhistethics.org

At the End of the Day (2)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 2 min read

This teaching explores how to transform mundane bedtime routines into meaningful spiritual practice through the cultivation of sammā sati (Right Awareness). Bhante Bodhidhamma guides practitioners to approach ordinary activities like washing, undressing, and preparing for sleep with the same reverence given to precious possessions, recognizing the body as the sacred vessel for awakening.

The essay addresses common patterns of rushing through evening routines mindlessly or in semi-consciousness, offering instead a path of mindful attention that honors the body's role in spiritual development. Through practical examples, it demonstrates how Right Intention can transform even natural bodily functions from sources of aversion into opportunities for equanimity and acceptance.

Key themes include overcoming the dualistic thinking of taṇhā that categorizes experiences as pleasant or unpleasant, developing genuine care for the physical form, and cultivating gratitude through awareness of our comparative fortune. The teaching concludes with an invitation to extend mettā (loving-kindness) to those less fortunate, connecting personal practice with universal compassion. This approach exemplifies how Theravāda practice can sanctify every moment of daily life.

Spiritual practice demands that we make every moment absolutely important, not just because it is actually the only moment we have since past and future moments don't exist, but because it is only in the present moment that we can effect change. How then to bring that sense of importance into everyday routine tasks, the ones we repeat often mindlessly. Preparing for bed is a prime example. The toiletry, the undressing, nestling into the mattress. Often done at speed to get it out of the way. Or hurled through the process by the longing for oblivion. Or in a sort of semi-consciousness, exhausted from the day's stresses, sleep walking into bed. But there is a way we can make spiritual capital out of habitual rituals, and that is to turn it into a meaningful ritual. And by ritual here I mean to imbue our actions with spiritual purpose. Immediately, Right Mindfulness is brought to bear and with it the Right Intention and so on to Right Action. It's time to care for the body. To remind ourselves of its preciousness. Herein is housed the enlightened-being-to-be. It is through the body that this awakening will take place. So let's care for it. Let us appreciate it as our most valued vehicle. Let's treat it with the same reverence we treat our cars, our mobiles, iPods and jewellery. To bring the same attent-

iveness to those actions that we often care to disregard. To urinate and evacuate, such Latinate words disguise our disgust. But good old Anglo-Saxon - to piss and to shit – often reveals our true relationship. How can we overcome such negativity to what are natural and therefore neutral actions of the body unless we attend to them. When we attend to them with the Right Intention to care for the body, we can see the role of tanha - that deluded distinction we make between pleasant and unpleasant where we indulge the one and annihilate the other. But there is a transcendent way to be with both the pleasant and the unpleasant and that is the equanimity we find in open acceptance – this is the way it is. And the joyful discovery is that the pleasant and the unpleasant still exist and they are ok. To bring our mindfulness to bear to the feel of things. The feel of warm water on our hands and cheeks. The taste of the toothpaste. The comfort of the mattress. And so, to wash the face with the care a mother washes her baby. To brush our teeth as if we really treasured them, knowing how much we don't want dentures! To undress and dress for bed, treating our clothes as if they were the only ones we had. To lie on the cuddling mattress and for a moment bring to mind how lucky we are to live in such comparative luxury. How many are the men, women and children who, this night, have no soap but a stone, no clothes but rags, no bed but a pavement! Let us send them our metta.

Balancing Lay and Spiritual Life

Carl Fooks · 4 min read

Drawing from personal experience during the COVID-19 pandemic, this essay addresses one of the most pressing challenges for lay practitioners: how to balance the rigorous demands of spiritual practice with the realities of work, family, and daily responsibilities. The author honestly describes feeling 'tired and frazzled' while juggling key worker duties, dharma teaching preparations, and personal obligations, yet still trying to maintain diligent practice.

The essay explores the seeming contradiction between seeking peace in Buddhism and encountering the Buddha's repeated exhortations to be 'diligent, ardent, and resolute.' Using Professor Peter Harvey's framework for skillful action, the author presents three key criteria: examining motivation (greed, hatred, delusion), assessing harm to self and others, and considering whether actions incline toward or away from liberation. Importantly, the essay suggests that even spiritual practice itself can become unskillful if approached with excessive force or aversion.

The central message emphasizes gentleness and sensitivity to one's present needs, arguing that sometimes 'sitting at the window, watching the rain fall gently on leaves' may be more skillful than formal meditation. This perspective reframes the Buddha's guidance in the Mettā Sutta as gentle encouragement rather than harsh demands, offering a compassionate approach to spiritual development that honors both dedication to the path and genuine self-care.

As I write this, I have just completed another long week of work. I am a “key worker” and the last 10 weeks of the COVID-19 lockdown have been long and hard. The work that I do is literally to help keep the country running; to help people get through this crisis. I write 40 hours on my timesheet, but I know it's more. I'm tired and a little frazzled. I have this to write, send to Bhante, Noirin, and a few close friends for feedback, and update accordingly, and so on. I'm planning for a Zoom call tomorrow which Noirin and I are holding for our upcoming retreat. Next weekend (today as you read this!) is the inaugural Satipanya Urban Southeast Saṅgha (Zoom) meet-up which I'm thinking about, and I'm also thinking about recording my talks for the retreat so that I can just play them, and not have to worry about if I'm called to work instead. On top of that, the grass and weeds keep growing. The bills still need paying. The dog needs walking. The family need tending to. Life goes on. Oh, and the very last thing that happened

at work last week was that I had my first meeting with my new boss who started off by telling me that at his last place he fired all the people in my position. Did I mention that I was tired and a little frazzled? The point of me saying all this is that lay life is hard! So we come to Buddhism to get some peace and ease, some joyful release from the rigours and hardships of life, and what do we find? Phrases like “diligent, ardent, and resolute” (MN p. 497). We go on retreat where we have to get up at 3:30 in the morning, meditate until at least 9:30 at night, and stay mindful—no, not just mindful, but “diligent, clearly knowing, and mindful” (Anālayo 2003, p. 4)—from the moment we wake up until the moment we fall asleep. Oh, and we have to find a noting word to label each and every experience as we go. To top it off, after a week of slog comes *adhiṭṭhāna* day ... a day of “resolute resolution” where we “strive” for a full day of moment-to-moment mindfulness. And let’s not mention the dreaded “C” word. OK, let’s! “Concentration”. I’m old enough for a teacher to have whacked me across the knuckles with a ruler for “not concentrating hard enough!” When Bhante reads us the *Mettā Sutta* every night, the Buddha says how we should behave like this and should do that. More things we should do! [Edit: Bhante’s softened it now.] I mean, to cap it all, the Buddha’s last words were literally “strive diligently for your liberation.” (DN p. 270). “Strive diligently ...”. You would be forgiven for thinking this isn’t the kind of peace and ease or rest and relaxation I had in mind when I signed up! Where’s the Spa?! So, the question is, how do we balance the demands of our lay life with the demands of the spiritual life? How do we reconcile our needs with the exhortation of the Buddha to “strive diligently for [our] liberation”? The Buddha, of course, had the answer to this: Skilfully! But, what amounts to ‘skilful’, and how do we apply it to our lives and practice? Professor Peter Harvey (Harvey 2000, p. 46) whittled the Buddha’s criteria down to: 1) Is the motivation based in greed, hatred, or delusion? 2) Is the action to my harm or that of others? And 3) does it incline away from liberation? So, if an action affirms any of these, the action is unskilful, and we should abandon it. Ultimately, all unskilful action can be said to be to our harm because it does not incline towards liberation. Now, to be controversial. This can include practice! If we’re up to our eyeballs in stress and worry and feeling particularly aversive to practice, and go and do it anyway, it can be that all we do is build up further resentment and aversion to the practice, never to practice again. Of course, it can also be that we find a wonderful place of peace and calm in the thick of it, but you get the point. We need to connect with our needs right now. Sometimes, sitting at the window, watching the rain fall gently on leaves is a more skilful thing to do than formal practice. Sometimes, getting up at 3:30am to practice diligently, ardently, and resolutely is exactly the right thing to do. Basically, it boils down to this: we should be gentle and kind to ourselves; we should be sensitive to our needs at the time and skilful in our response to them; we need to have a skilful orientation to the path that does not result in harm to ourselves or others, is not based in greed (which implies not indulging laziness!),

hatred, or delusion, and does not incline away from liberation. We need to gently nurture our practice, doing those things that are most nourishing for us at the time. Notice all the “should”s and “need”s in that last paragraph? If you feel the gentleness of these, this is how we “should” hear the Mettā Sutta that Bhante reads each night. I implore you to read it again with exactly this in mind. Rest is not idleness, and to lie sometimes on the grass under trees on a summer’s day, listening to the murmur of the water, or watching the clouds float across the sky, is by no means a waste of time. (John Lubbock, *The Use of Life*.)

Barriers or Boundaries

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 2 min read

This essay examines the crucial distinction between barriers and boundaries in our relationships, expectations, and self-identity. Bhante Bodhidhamma explores how the ego creates rigid barriers around our preferences, political views, and social groups, leading to disappointment and reactivity when reality doesn't match our fixed expectations. Using everyday examples from dining experiences to political opinions, he illustrates how these mental barriers generate dukkha through our aversive reactions to change.

The teaching then shifts to boundaries as a healthier alternative—fluid, flexible guidelines that maintain dignity and appropriate conditions without creating the hardness that barriers impose. Through personal anecdotes about monastic protocol and living arrangements, Bhante demonstrates how boundaries can be adjusted mindfully without compromising our integrity or well-being.

This practical wisdom directly relates to vipassanā practice, where Right Awareness allows us to observe our defensive reactions and choose creative responses rather than automatic protection of our positions. The essay encourages readers to examine their own patterns of creating barriers versus establishing healthy boundaries, offering insight into how attachment and aversion operate in daily life and relationships.

What is it about the self that creates such a mess? Is it not the hard lines it draws around things, people and events? We go to a restaurant and we ‘know’ what apple pie and custard should taste like. When we taste the one we have bought, we are disappointed. Now it may be that the pie is not so good. I once had apple pie, years ago now, and when I put my fork into it, the crust was so hard it broke into pieces and some flung themselves off the plate. I didn’t think the cook would appreciate my pretend interest by asking how much cement went into the crust. But it was difficult to enjoy. Looking back, if it had been the first apple pie and custard I had tasted, I no doubt would have thought it should be like that and thoroughly enjoyed it. What about our politics? We draw hard lines around our views. I would never vote for ... Now we may not vote for that party. But what point the hardness around it. It stops us acknowledging that there is some good in all parties. The undecided floating voter is considered weak and no political party likes them. Relationships too. Do we not draw comfort lines around our friendship group. Closed groups are cosy, but they are closed and self-serving. Such can be viewed as barriers. It suggests hardening, inability to change even

though change is all around us. How do we know when barriers are being breached? When threats arise to the status quo, fear and aversion arise. We react to protect, maintain. Unless we can be mindful of our aversive reaction, there cannot be a creative response. We defend our positions sometimes at great cost. Boundaries are more fluid. The beach is sometimes the land and sometimes the sea. It's not that boundaries allow everything. They don't have to be porous. One can create conditions, but they allow us to be flexible. How do we know when boundaries are being breached? An amorphous discomfort. A feeling of invasiveness. At worst a loss of personal dignity. When I became a monk, I kept up my friendly, easy going relationship with people. This was fine, except when someone became 'familiar'. Suddenly it was a slap on the back and 'how are you doing, Bodhi?' I felt I was at fault by trying to be a 'mate' and it was not quite in line with the dignity the Buddha would have his monastics behave. So that's when I asked people to address me as Bhante. This keeps a respectable distance between myself and the person I am talking to. It also stopped me behaving sloppily - at least in public! I was lodging with a friend and I told him I expected a phone call at a certain time. Just before the allotted, he received a call. As the allotted time came for my call, I called out to remind him. Unfortunately he heard my reminder as a command. I got an earful which reminded me that hosts have their boundaries and I needed to respect these. Barriers or Boundaries - is it just human nature? Have a look!

Basics for Insight Meditation 01

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 42 min

In this foundational talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma presents the essential principles underlying insight meditation practice. Drawing from the Buddha's core teachings, he explores the three characteristics of existence (tilakkhana): impermanence (anicca), unsatisfactoriness (dukkha), and not-self (anattā). The talk emphasizes how meditation helps us develop an 'observation post' within ourselves, allowing us to witness the arising and passing away of bodily sensations, emotions, and thoughts without identification.

Bhante explains how our fundamental delusion lies in seeking happiness through sensual experience, creating the very suffering we wish to escape. He discusses the five hindrances (pañca nīvaraṇa) that obstruct clear seeing: sensual desire, ill-will, restlessness, sloth-torpor, and skeptical doubt. Rather than suppressing these mental states, practitioners learn to come off thinking, enter the body, and allow emotions to express themselves as felt sensations until they naturally dissipate.

The teaching emphasizes that liberation comes through direct seeing rather than intellectual understanding. Using the Mahasi noting technique, meditators cultivate the childlike quality of pure observation, discovering that true peace resides not in emotional states but in the awareness that observes them. This practice extends beyond formal sitting into daily life, requiring moment-to-moment awareness and the courage to bear the consequences of our past unwholesome actions.

So this is just an opportunity really to just revise the principles of our meditation, why do we do it and how do we do it. I'm aware that there are people in the hall that haven't heard anything about this or very little, and also that people have been at it longer than me, so I'll try and get a balance to what we say.

The Buddha himself, remember, began in a position that we are in, searching for happiness. That's basically what we're trying to do. We're trying to be happy, for heaven's sake. And at the time when he finally broke through what he called the delusion, the basic ignorance that we live under, he was able to point to three ways in which we can investigate our experience and to correct the way we are looking at things. You could say that our basic problem is one of relationship. He talked about them as the three characteristics of existence.

So in the meditation practice, the first thing is to really begin to get close to this idea of impermanence and what that actually means in terms of a direct experience. It's not as though that comes as a great shock to anybody that things arise and pass away. It's not as though, generally speaking, people are not aware that the seasons do change. But it's really turning that inward towards ourselves and to recognise that we are in a process of change, and that the change is not simply something that's changing shape like you might take a piece of clay, turn it into a saucer, screw it up and then turn it into a cup. It's actually radical. Things are dying and passing away, and the great exemplar of that, of course, is our own bodies.

Every cell is arising, dying and passing away. We don't experience that, at least I haven't. I haven't experienced the death of a cell. But I'm quite aware that in fact cells are arising and passing away. And it's that ability to really go into ourselves and see that all the experience that we're having is in this process of coming into being and then passing out, and that the mind with its conceptual ability draws us into an idea of continuity. So there is this feeling in me that I've always been me since the day I was born. My body changes but not me. I mean, my thoughts have changed. I don't think like a three-year-old anymore. But I haven't changed. I don't have the same emotions as a child, but I haven't changed. There's always this feeling that there's a me inside all this, which isn't changing. It's absolutely steady. And somehow I anchor myself to that.

When I actually investigate it, and I begin to describe what this me is, what do I end up experiencing? So I'm turning into myself, and I observe that everything I'm experiencing is passing away. But I still have this sense of me, the observer. Somehow I've retreated out of the body, out of the emotions, out of the mind, and I've found this other place within myself that I experience as the feeler or the experiencer or the knower, and sometimes it's very strong that oh, this is me, I'm the one who knows. Now from that position we're quite privileged because we can at least abstract ourselves from these other identities that we've had. So we've had the identity of the body.

Now these days it's very difficult to go back to that very early childhood state where you are the body, but we do occasionally get that. For instance, when was the last time you trapped your finger in a door? For that one moment you are the body. It's like a wonderful complete moment of pain. There is only pain. Then, of course, you shoot out of it and suddenly there's somebody feeling the pain. There's an objectivity comes to it. But at least there we can grasp what it is to be a self that is just the body, as a baby is supposed to be. I can't remember, you see.

Then there's the emotional self, which is much easier to get lost into. Suddenly I am angry. There's no separation. I just blow it, bang the doors and all that. Or I panic and I just become that fear. Or I'm depressed. I associate with, I identify with in a total way that this is me. Occasionally I'm happy, which is wonderful. And being happy, being joyful, you then of course get that sense of loss when it disappears.

But there's this self which attaches itself to an emotion, which defines itself as I am happy. I and happiness are the same. I and anger are the same. But here in meditation what we discover is that there is anger, there is depression, there is happiness. Somehow I've detached from it. Now this word detachment, that's what you'll get in the literature. It gives it a certain coldness. Another word that you might find used is non-attachment, which gives it a sense of not just wanting to push away or a coldness to it. It's just there's a sense of separateness from the emotion that you're feeling.

And then with thoughts, these are even more difficult as we discover in our meditation. Suddenly I'm thinking. There's no objectivity to it. I'm just lost in a dream sequence. I'm just lost in a whole flow of thoughts. And suddenly I come out of it by which time I can only note what has actually happened. I can't note it while it's happening because I'm lost in it. And in that moment I've become the intellectual self, the thinking self.

So we're constantly moving from these definitions of a self. And in meditation, we're finding this other place, which one writer happily called the observation post. I'm trying to think of the name of the book now. It's Nyanaponika. The Heart of Buddhist Meditation. It still remains a classic, that book. And we're finding this other place within ourselves from which we can observe these things and we're observing that they're arising and passing away. But in so doing we've also found a space, there's also a space between, a sense of distance from what we're actually experiencing within ourselves.

And that sense of space is the not-self, not me, not mine. So often you get this confusion in the teaching where we think the Buddha is making some metaphysical statement, there is no self, there is no body. But when you look at his actual teaching in the scriptures, it's just a way of beginning to realise what or who or whatever it is that we really are, and we're doing it by pushing away, by making an object of everything within us. Now as soon as something becomes an object, it obviously can't be the subject.

When I look at my hand, I'm still attached to it. But that objectivity means that it can't be me. It can't be that which knows. And I'm taking that objectivity into myself so that when I feel an emotion, I'm feeling it, I'm looking at it, I'm experiencing it. And there's that separation. Every time I separate from something, I'm disidentifying. I'm relocating. I'm relocating where I think I am.

So I've got to relocate out of the body, relocate out of the sensations, feelings, emotions, relocate out of thought. If I were going for this election next year, I'd be saying, relocate, relocate, relocate. So this constant relocation, I'm finding another place in which I can find, shall we say, a different identity. And this identity I experience as being the observer, the feeler. It's a very strange place to be because here I know what's happening. I feel an emotion. I can feel it. I can feel a sensation. I can know it. And yet somehow I'm not it.

Now that's all the Buddha's pointing to when he's saying, not me, not mine. This is not me, not mine. And the fact that it arises and passes away is also pointing out it can't be me or mine because one minute it's here and then it's gone. How could it be me? The idea of a me is something permanent, substantial, something that doesn't change. So the first position that we take in our meditation is that observer, that feeler. We lift ourselves out of the body-mind complex in order to discover this observation post.

All the noting we do, all the techniques that you come across in *Vipassanā*, and the technique I myself am teaching is known as the Mahāsi technique, but there are many others. And if you go into Zen, or you go to Dzogchen, the Tibetan tradition, all these techniques are always trying to get the meditator to find this position, that's all. And from this position, you can get this objectivity. And these three characteristics, we've mentioned the two at the moment, this idea of impermanence and the fact that it's not me, not mine, becomes more and more apparent the more you practice it.

Now, even though we get to this position of the observer, the knower, that's not your final position because there's still something there that knows itself. Now, if I have a sense of presence, this is me, it's also an object, so I can't be that either. Everything that I'm aware of can't be the awareness that's aware of it. So even at that point, which we can get to by an act of will, we can put ourselves into the observation post, is not the end point. The end point is even when that sense of self disappears.

And occasionally that may happen to you in little bits when you fall into an absorption, an absorption state where there's a sense of loss of a self and yet when you come out of that state you know that there has been a process of knowing, a process of seeing, a process of experience. These I like to call little Nibbānic moments. Even whether they're actually Nibbānic or not, let's not get into that discussion. But they're Nibbānic moments in the sense that just for that one moment, we've lost the sense of self.

Now, you might say to yourself, well, I do that when I watch a good film. When you sit and watch a good film, that's it, you're gone. You wake up two hours later and you say, that was a fantastic film. But you weren't aware of yourself watching the film while you were watching the film. There was a loss of self. But unfortunately, we enter into

those absorptions with an intention which corrupts the actual process. And the intention is, I, me, I'm going to enjoy myself. And as soon as you do that, you form a relationship with films. The film now becomes something that your happiness is dependent on. So after you've seen one film, there comes, in not too long a space afterwards, a thirst, a craving, an addiction to get another DVD. Or else life becomes meaningless. This is what I found.

So it's a case of recognising that we're talking about two different levels of consciousness. There's a level of knowing, a level of the way we relate to the world, which is seeking happiness in the world. Now, this is where we come to the other of the three characteristics, which the Buddha called *dukkha*. *Dukkha* translates as a hard place. So we're in a hard place and it's a hard place because we've made this wrong relationship. And this fundamental delusion that we suffer from expresses itself in a search for happiness in the sensual world. That's how it expresses itself.

Having identified ourselves with the body, having identified ourselves with our emotional life and our thought life, we're now trying to make this inner environment the happiness that we seek. That's all. So when I'm feeling well, when I'm feeling really fit and I'm walking up a hill or something, then that's happiness. I've made it, finally. Then I get to the top of the hill and I've got to come down, and it all dribbles away. The body feels weak and tired, and I've got to have my orange juice.

Emotionally speaking, I can create a situation. I try and find the right person who makes me happy, the right situation. And I find myself in this beautiful emotional euphoria. Nature, sex, drugs, rock and roll, it's wonderful. But unfortunately, as soon as I've got it, this emotion corrupts it, disappears it, falls away from me. But I still think that as long as I can just get the right thing, right job, right relationship, right house, right car, I will be definitely perfectly happy.

So this search for happiness in the world is producing that stress that we are suffering. Because we constantly want to be happy in a world which cannot deliver, if only because it passes away. Now, to let go of that is the process of renunciation. To begin to let go of that as a place to find happiness is the process of renunciation. Now, renunciation isn't self-mortification in the sense that we're not trying to beat ourselves up. For heaven's sake, we're suffering enough. What we're trying to do is to let go of our attachment to things. And we do that by, through this meditation, beginning to realise what desire is.

So the Buddha's Four Noble Truths, he begins with a very simple statement. Life is *dukkha*, it's a hard place. And the reason it's a hard place, he says, is because of a certain type of desire. It's a desire based on seeking happiness in the sensual world.

And then he says, if you can get rid of that, you will actually come to the end of this *dukkha*. You'll actually come to a position in yourself where there is no more unsatisfactoriness, no more suffering, and you live, in his words, contented and with it happy.

When somebody complains to him and says, look, this training is very difficult, he says, well, it is difficult, but then people achieve this wonderful state, *Nibbāna*. And the guy says, *Nibbāna*, so what? So he's very serious. When you get there, he says, you are contented and with it happy. He's describing himself.

So remember that the enlightenment or the liberation is not a destruction of what we have, but a refinement of what we have. When the Buddha is finally liberated, he doesn't turn into this amorphous blob, sitting under a tree with enlightenment, glowing but unable to speak, like he's lost in the Nibbānic bliss forever. He gets up, he walks, he talks, he relates. And the Buddha's heart is these immeasurables, which we'll practice this afternoon: love, compassion, joy and peace. That's his heart.

And his intellect, what had been such a barrier to actually seeing things the way they are, and that's why remember in our meditation we're constantly dragging ourselves down into the body to get back to basic experience away from conceptual thinking. Remember that concepts always hold our history. So whenever we experience something, we're always dumping our history on what we're experiencing. That's why whenever you eat an apple, it's always compared with the last apple or the apples you ate. And it's either rubbish or brilliant or whatever. But actually, the apple is just an apple. And to taste the apple, this apple, this apple that I'm tasting, in its individuality, I have to forget all history. And to do that, I place my attention just in the eating, just on the tongue.

So now, this liberation, when it came, did not take away his intellect. He used his intellect to express the Dharma, to express his teaching. So everything that we're doing is not an annihilation of anything. In fact, he says the only things that are annihilated are greed, hatred, and this fundamental delusion. Everything is returned to us in a purified form.

So this *dukkha*, this unhappiness, this unsatisfactoriness, meaninglessness that might come about our lives, is all resting on this delusion that somehow we can find the happiness in this human form. And we make the mistake of thinking we are human beings. But all we mean by human being is a conventional coming together of carrots and apples, isn't it? And then thoughts and images. When you get it all together and it's all working properly, we call that human being. But when you take it apart, what is there? But it's just a combination of objects, which the Buddha calls aggregates. He calls them

the five aggregates, the physical aggregates, the perceptual aggregates, the feeling aggregates, all the aggregates that we call our emotions and thoughts, and these acts of cognition, these acts of consciousness.

And our process is to begin to see that all that actually is, as it says in the scriptures, just bubbles in a stream, just like a flame which is constantly changing, just burning fuel, but in a constant process of change. But the flame looks one, it looks whole, it looks entire, but actually it's just made of a constant flow of energy.

So these three characteristics are what it is we're trying to experience directly. And to directly experience these three characteristics is to liberate us from this essential delusion.

Now, you might think, therefore, that having been liberated from that, you just end up in a sense of annihilation, like there's nothing left. But the Buddha points out, keeps stressing the fact, that he's not teaching annihilation. He's actually teaching that there is an experience which is beyond the phenomenal experience of ordinary daily life. And he points to that by calling himself the *Tathāgata*. And the *Tathāgata* translates best as the one who's transcended. The one who is transcended.

So every time we move into the position of the observer within ourselves, we're transcending the body. We're transcending emotion. We're transcending thought. We're finding a very different position within ourselves. And when occasionally in your meditation there is that loss of self, there is that absorption into what we're observing, and with the loss of self you'll lose a sense of time, we're catching just moments of *Nibbānic* bliss. And the problem with that for us, because we associate bliss and happiness with emotions, is that there are no emotions there.

So when Sāriputta is asked, you talk about the bliss, the happiness of emotions, but there are no emotions in *Nibbāna*. He says, yes, he says. It's the very absence of emotions which is the bliss in *Nibbāna*. So there's a real conundrum for us.

So, as in your meditation, when you can stabilise at some point this observer within you, when you can stabilise that position of just being within the phenomena of your own body, heart and mind, feelings, emotions, images, when you can stabilise that position long enough, for those of you who work at it, ask yourself, what is the mood, the emotion, of the one who's observing? What is the mood of it, right? Just reflect on that for a moment. And that will draw you more and more to want to be in that place because that's where the peacefulness resides. It doesn't reside in the emotional life, it doesn't reside in the intellect or the body.

Now, having done that, you might think to yourself, well, are you therefore denying the body, heart and mind? No, not at all. Because then, as it were, from that insight, you have to re-enter the whole psychophysical process. So the Buddha talks about right understanding, but then you have to draw yourself with right intention into the heart. And that right intention moves outwards into relationship, which is right speech, right action, right livelihood. And that mirrors back to you your wisdom or probably the lack of it and that's how you gain, that's how you begin to understand that oh yes in sitting yes I consider those lovely and impermanent you know I can feel pain in my knee and I'm perfectly equanimous with that, that's absolutely wonderful you see. And then you're waiting for the tube and somebody stands on your foot.

To hell with meditation.

So that's what we're trying to do in this, through the process of insight meditation, *vipassanā*, right? We're trying to see these three characteristics more and more clearly. And it's in the seeing that the liberation comes. When you see something, then it rebounds back upon your attitude. You know, why do I want to keep doing this if it's making me unhappy? Right? It's very simple. So the seeing is the first point. It then moves, as I say, into right attitude. And this we develop through the practice of *mettā*, loving-kindness.

Now, those three characteristics, the characteristic of impermanence, the characteristic of how we create suffering for ourselves, the process, the role of sensual desire, and this teaching about not me, not mine, that's what we're trying to see. Now, what stops us seeing that are what the Buddha called these hindrances. And these hindrances you can split basically into two types. There's those types that excite the mind and keep it busy and take you away from this observing. And there's those types that drop you into the black hole. Dullness and lethargy, given a moral twist by calling it sloth and laziness and all that.

So as these mental states grab you right, the meditator has to know well this is what it is and this is what I have to do to counteract it right. And one thing that I think has been quite confusing to some people from some of the emails I get is that when something comes up which drags you away, so for instance some planning, you're planning a new business or something, so you're planning to go on holiday and there's an excitement comes when you're planning, planning, you see right. You come into the body, this is why it's so important, you come into the body and you get in contact with the excitement and you're allowing the excitement to express itself right, express itself and to burn away.

When you have a depressive thought and you're feeling depressed and the mind goes off about, you know, the world's in a terrible state, we're all doomed, and I'm horrible, and all that stuff. You see, you come off the thought, you come into the body, and you contact the feeling of depression, and you go into it, you feel it. You're allowing the heart to express itself.

If you find yourself arguing and you're getting very angry about something, you see, and you're strangling them. Then you say, oh, stop the anger, anger. You come back into the body. You find where, if you can, you can find where the anger is expressing itself. And you bury your attention into the heat. So you're not pushing anything away. You're not trying to run away from anything.

Pushing away, running away are the usual way we suppress stuff. When something comes up we don't like, we either push it away with aversion, don't want to see it, or we run away from it, we turn away, we ignore it. All that produces psychological problems for us. Here we're not doing that. Here, when something comes up, we come off the mind and we bury ourselves in the emotional state and we give it the time to burn out. Some stuff takes a long time. You can expect to see true improvement over a period of something like twenty-five years. I don't want to give the impression that this happens overnight.

What you're beginning to realise is that the emotional states that we've created have not been caused by the obvious object. So when somebody has annoyed us, when somebody has annoyed us, they've not caused the anger. It's really important. What's happened is we ourselves have come from a position of this. This person has disturbed this position and we've reacted from inside towards them with anger. The anger is caused by us. So therefore, seeking happiness by destroying the other is not going to help. You can annihilate everybody else in the world and you'll still end up angry and lonely. It doesn't... because they haven't actually caused the problem. The problem lies within our own hearts, which remember is always trying to seek happiness in the sensual world.

Nobody has frightened us. Fear has arisen because of something in me has reacted to a situation. Nobody can cause us psychological pain. It's all been caused inwardly by ourselves. It's really difficult, if you're new to this, to really grasp that. And don't worry about it if you disagree. Nobody can cause us psychological pain. Now, the disappointment in that is that you can no longer blame somebody else. This is a real disappointment, because up until now it was great. Society, my parents, the dog, they were all to blame. But now, it's just you. But the liberation is that if I cause this, if I cause these

awful mental states that I have to bear, I must be able to undo them. And that's where the liberation comes, that we are actually, we can become in charge of our own psychic life, our own psychological life.

Now, given these hindrances when they come, so we've talked about the negative stuff, well, there's been a bit of excitement there. So there's excitement, there's depression, there's lust, there's romance, there's all the beautiful stuff too, I don't forget about that. And then there's all this other stuff, the anxiety, the depression, etc. All that, you see, has been caused by me.

Now, what can I do about something which is already conditioned? If I try to destroy it, all I do is push it down. If I push it away like this and not want to see it, we know from our own psychology, that it just makes more and more psychic problems for us. If I turn away from it, I know that it's just there within the psyche waiting for its little moment to appear. So what can I do? Hmm?

The answer, of course, is to bear it. We have to suffer the consequences of our past unwholesome actions. And that's exactly what we're doing when we sit in meditation. We're allowing this stuff to arise and burn away. That's all. That's all we have to do, is to have the courage, the fortitude, the resilience to stay with the mental states and to allow them to rise and pass away. But to stay with them as felt sensations.

As soon as they slip into the mind, as soon as we allow that moment of unmindfulness to come, and it slips into the mind as a dream, as a film, as a process, unwittingly we're developing the very same state. Because that's how the emotions develop themselves. Consider. You know in the morning somebody said something a little bit off and you've just dismissed it. That's the way they are. And then tea time comes, eleven o'clock something, and you get a cup of tea. Bloody say that to me. And then at lunch it's raving. By the time you get home you don't want to see them in case you kill them. And all that's been created by us, by me. They only insulted me once, but I've had them insult me thousands of times before I go to bed.

So, it's recognising the role of the mind in developing our mental states that needs to be really perceived. And this business of, in meditation, of noting what's happening and coming back into the body, that's not just meditation. We have to do that throughout our lives, from the moment we wake up to the moment we fall asleep. Every time you see your mind wandering during the day, there has to be that effort to stop, note it, come into the body, allow the emotion to dissipate a bit.

So all that I'm describing here is how to generally attack four of these hindrances, those to do with happiness and pleasures and all that, those to do with angers, depressions, all the negative stuff about life, those to do with just general restlessness, where the mind is just busy all the time or there's a feeling of restlessness in the body, just to relax into it and feel it and just allow it to expend its energy. And doubt.

Doubt here is sceptical doubt. The Buddha wants us to be in a state of wonder. He wants us to actually doubt his word in that very positive way of saying to ourselves, now, is this true or not? Because it's an investigation. It's the investigation that draws us to liberation. It's no good believing in the Buddha and what he said. That's not going to, I mean, it's not going to help at all. Faith is something different. It's confidence. And the confidence is there to make it easy for us to investigate the teachings. And sceptical doubt is something else. Sceptical doubt is always based on fear. It's fear of commitment, isn't it? An aversion to commitment. You don't want to go there.

And when sceptical doubt enters into our ordinary lives, it can be absolutely crippling. Because you can't, is this the job I should be doing? Is it not? Should I do it? Should I not? And the job goes. Is this the person I really love? Should I love? Should I be married? Should I not? Before they've gone off, they've gone off to somebody else. So sceptical doubt is a real undermining thing. And in your meditation, really, if that comes up, you know, everybody else can do it, I can't do it, I'm no good. Really come off the thought, come off the thought, go into the feeling of that doubt and let it express itself, the fear, whatever.

The final one is the business of dullness and lethargy. And it's a big hindrance. I mean, you know, falling asleep in our meditation all the time. And of course, when you look back into the way we've used sleep to escape problems. You know, every time we feel a bit depressed, well, you just, you know, it's like head for the bed, you know. Big neon lights, head for the bed. Or you just lie down on the couch, fed up, and off you go. Great, isn't it? I mean, oblivion, there's no suffering. And then you wake up, which is unfortunate. But if you would say completely oblivious, see, I mean, if death is complete annihilation, what's the problem? So unfortunately, we keep waking up out of this.

But what we're doing is we're creating that inner habit of falling asleep. And it comes up as these feelings of heaviness, sloth, torpor, etc. And there's also, of course, the fact that being in that gentle subliminal state on a Sunday morning is really nice, isn't it? You know when you wake up and you turn over and you're just wandering in that pleasant dreamy state or get back into bed and you just keep wandering in that lovely

subliminal state of not being quite asleep and not being quite awake. And developing that is developing sloth and torpor, dullness and lethargy. So we shouldn't be surprised when we come to sit that we're always bobbing up and down, falling asleep.

So all these things that we're experiencing here in our meditation in terms of these negative mental states, we have to bring that practice into our daily life. Every time you feel sleepy during the day, ask yourself, now is this real tiredness? Or is it just this dullness and lethargy? In which case, stay awake. Every time you see your mind wandering, you have to note it and bring it back. So the practice of *vipassanā* is something that we have to take into just every daily life. And remember that the thing that really helps the process, the spiritual process, is to relax. So if you find your life too busy, try and do something to make it less busy. Try to experience this standing meditation that we did in the morning as a constant throughout the day, every so often just to stop.

It's a really powerful word, you see. Just stop. Stop. I think I've stopped too.

So, what we've described is these three characteristics which we're investigating, the sense of impermanence, the sense of not me, not mine, and the role of sensual desire, all based on some fundamental delusion within us that we're seeking happiness in the wrong place. And while we're doing that, these hindrances draw us away. Old habits of thought, old addictions, little hatreds, depressions, they're all drawing us away into this dream world. And all we have to do is to come off the dream, re-establish that awareness within the body and let these things express themselves as feeling. That's all, as feeling.

And when occasionally there does descend upon you some blissful peacefulness, see, be careful you don't sink into that as you would ice cream. Try to still maintain the fact of observing it as something which is very pleasant, very beautiful, but also impermanent. Don't get drawn into beautiful states of mind. And use it. Those are really good moments to really draw the attention into the breath and begin to experience impermanence and to develop that sense of laser beam concentration. Laser beams, stillness and attention.

And finally, just to bring an image to your mind of the child. So when somebody before the age of seven sees something they don't know, you see in a child, what do they do, you see? They become locked onto the object, don't they? Their eyes don't move. They're just locked onto the object, a beetle that they've never seen before. Everything goes absolutely still.

The body relaxes. The jaw relaxes. They look gormless. And the good parent gives them a clip on the back of their head. They look gormless. The jaw's completely relaxed, which means there's no thought. That's why in your meditation, always make sure your jaw's relaxed, your tongue's relaxed. And they're just watching.

And then after a moment or so, they stop and they ask, what is it? Now all that learning has gone on in just that watching. And all we're trying to do is get back to that state. Just that state of the original child. And that's why in Zen they'll often talk to you about original mind.

So if you keep that image in your mind as a child, and that's what you're trying to get back to, a non-thinking state of pure observation, and having the trust—it really depends upon faith—having the trust that there is within us a superb intelligence which will see the way things are and liberate itself. That intelligence is constantly saying, get that meditator out of the way. Will that meditator please go home and just let me look?

So that's your big problem. That's our big problem, is to get this meditator out of the way. And we do it in a very simple way. We just relax, we place the attention on the breath, we raise the interest to observe these three characteristics, and we just watch. We just feel. We just experience whatever draws the attention within the field of awareness. Voilà.

So, thank you very much. What we can do now is some walking meditation.

Beauty

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 2 min read

This contemplative essay examines the complex relationship between beauty and the spiritual path, drawing from the Buddha's own appreciation of beautiful places and objects. Bhante Bodhidhamma references the Mahāparinibbāna Sutta, noting how the Buddha delighted in the shrines around Vesāli and took care that monastic robes should be aesthetically pleasing. The teaching explores how beauty can uplift the heart and create pure aesthetic mental states, while warning that beauty alone is not a reliable guide to truth or virtue. The essay addresses the philosophical question of whether beauty exists objectively or is created by our consciousness, concluding from a Buddhist perspective that it arises through the interaction of awareness with phenomena. While acknowledging that external beauty is not necessary for liberation from dukkha - one can achieve Awakening even in harsh conditions - the teaching suggests that a mind appreciating beauty that highlights truth and virtue reflects a wholesome mental state. The key insight is that beauty should support rather than replace our central aim of liberation, serving as one of many skillful means rather than becoming an end in itself.

The Buddha said of the Dhamma that it was beautiful in the beginning, beautiful in the middle and beautiful in the end. In the Parinibbana Discourse where the last of his days are recounted, it is recounted that 'the Blessed One getting ready in the forenoon, took bowl and robe and went into Vesali for alms. After the alms round and meal, on his return, he spoke to the Venerable Ananda, saying: "Take up a mat, Ananda, and let us spend the day at the Capala shrine." Indeed, he rejoiced in the beauty of shrines: "Delightful, Ananda, is Vesali; pleasant are the shrines of Udena, Gotamaka, Sattambaka, Bahuputta, Sarandada, and Capala." In the early days, monastics would take leftover white cloth from the corpses in the charnel grounds and stitch them together. When he saw a group of them, the Buddha must have thought they looked scruffy indeed because he then asked order members to cut and sew the pieces together so the robe when stretched out looked like paddy fields – and to dye them in areca nut which gave them a brownish hue. All religions make great efforts to build beautiful places of worship. They fill them with beautiful decorative art, statues and music. But evil can also be beautiful. Mythologically, Lucifer was the most beautiful of angels. Leni Riefenstahl glorifies the Nazis in her propaganda films such as *The Triumph of the Will* (1935). The martial parades of Communist Russia were a marvel to behold. The mushroom of an atomic bomb is beautiful. Beauty then is a category of its own. Just because something is

beautiful it does not mean it is true or good. How then do we experience beauty? It has a certain emotional feel to it that uplifts the heart. There is a pure aesthetic mental state when we see something such as a beautifully wrought iron gate or a dry stone wall. But more often than not something beautiful excites conjoining emotions of love, wonder, simple joy, devotion and so on. Whether beauty is in the eye of the beholder or out there in the world, is an eternal philosophical debate. But in Buddhist understanding, it is the body-heart-mind complex that is creating the world we are actually experiencing. Nature may have all the ingredients that make beauty, but without awareness it may as well not have them. So, it is back to us. A mind full of beauty, when that beauty highlights truth and virtue, is a mental state we can presume the Buddha himself would delight in. But if beauty or the beautiful feeling is our aim, then we have lost the path. Beauty has to be one of the many objectives that gather around our central aim to liberate ourselves from dukkha. And external beauty is not necessary. We can liberate ourselves in a stinking slum, with raggedy clothes and only pap to eat. Even so ...

Beauty

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 2 min read

This teaching examines the Buddhist perspective on physical beauty and its role in perpetuating suffering. Bhante Bodhidhamma uses the metaphor of fading flowers to illustrate the impermanent nature of physical attractiveness, connecting this to the monastic rules in the Vinaya that restrict cosmetics and ornamentation, as well as the Eight Precepts observed by lay practitioners.

The essay reveals how our attachment to beauty stems from craving admiration and the illusion of power it provides. This attachment inevitably leads to suffering as beauty fades, creating damaged self-image, dependency on others' approval, and the acid burn of jealousy when attention turns elsewhere. The teaching encourages practitioners to examine their own relationship with appearance, noting how even those who don't consider themselves beautiful often engage in beautification practices.

Drawing on traditional contemplations of bodily impermanence and the reality beneath the skin, the essay guides readers toward a healthier relationship with the body—one focused on actions rather than image. This shift from seeking admiration for appearance to being valued for character represents a movement away from superficial attachments toward genuine liberation from the suffering caused by vanity and self-obsession.

Flowers are true teachers of the foolish vanity of physical beauty. Even now in late spring, the radiant golden lilies fade, curling into a crispy, tanned rigor mortis. The obsession with physical beauty is not new by any means, though hyped to impossible heights by Hollywood, Bollywood and CGI[i]. The Vinaya, rules for the ordained Sangha, rules against any indulgence in beauty. There is a long list of cosmetics and ornaments not to be used. Even in the Eight Precepts lay people take when staying at a monastery, physical beautification is avoided. I undertake [to observe] the rule of abstinence from dancing, music, visiting shows, flowers, cosmetics, the wearing of ornaments and decorations. It does seem as though the Buddha has a grudge against physical beauty! But in fact, these undertakings are based, not surprisingly, on alleviating suffering. For what is it we are trying to achieve when we try to make ourselves look beautiful in others' eyes? It makes us feel good to be admired. But does it not also give us a sense of power, even the ability to manipulate? Both of these have their downfalls. As beauty fades, the comfort and joy of the admiration of others is a mask that falls away to reveal a self-admiration based on the admiration of others, which, as it corrupts, leaves a damaged

self-image and a realisation that admiration is, after all, not love. Worse! Beauty's power, based on admiration, is now trapped into a relationship, where it is forced to prove over and over again that it controls the admirer and not vice-versa. Should the admirer look elsewhere, the underlying dependency, which we term attachment, manifests as the acid burn of jealousy. Physical beauty has its time and place. But as far as the cause of suffering is concerned, it is the constant concern of how one looks that is the underlying cause of dissatisfaction with our bodies. So the Buddha advises us to get real. To awaken to our skewed perceptions and establish not just a healthy relationship with our bodies, but one that leads to liberation from suffering. Physical Beauty is only skin deep. So let's begin there, by peeling off the skin. No-one would find a flayed body beautiful. And if we take apart all the different parts and pour all liquids into bottles, that old saying takes on a deeper meaning. Whatever this sense of 'me' is, surely it is foolish to consider itself as a body. In the same way, imagining what happens to the body after death, is another way of undermining that part of the sense of 'me' that defines itself as beautiful. At this point, you may be saying to yourself. This essay does not concern me. I don't think of myself as particularly beautiful. But look again. You may be surprised as to how you are concerned with how you look in company. What special measures do you take when you go out? And what do you wear when alone? Do you bother with perfume and aftershave if you're not going to meet anyone? And if you do, why? And what about those romantic daydreams? One of the discoveries that some people have made in these lockdowns is how these fineries have been dropped. How baths and showers became less frequent. (Often also because of Climate Crisis). There is a distinction to be made between cleanliness and beauty. Becoming more concerned with what the body does, our actions, rather than what it looks like, our image, we can turn away from caring how people see us towards how people value us. Craving to be valued, of course, creates other sufferings. But that's for another Tip!

Computer-Generated Imagery

See Values in mine own eyes.

Being Good rather than Being Good At

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 2 min read

This teaching examines how modern culture has shifted from valuing character to valuing achievements, creating a competitive mindset that pollutes the heart with envy and inadequacy. Bhante Bodhidhamma draws on the Maṅgala Sutta to highlight the Buddha's emphasis on inner qualities like generosity, ethical conduct, humility, contentment, and patience as the highest blessings, rather than worldly success.

The essay explains how focusing on our underlying attitudes and intentions transforms both our actions and our sense of self-worth. When we prioritize wholesome attitudes over skillful performance, our deeds naturally enhance our feeling of goodness without carrying negative undertones. This connects directly to the Noble Eightfold Path, where Right Attitude (sammā saṅkappa) leads to Right Action (sammā kammanta).

The practical guidance offered is simple yet profound: before any action, examine your underlying attitude. If it's negative, consciously replace it with a wholesome intention, even if it initially feels forced. This practice cultivates genuine happiness and worthiness from within, independent of external validation or comparison with others.

It seems as though obituaries have changed. Where once they would talk of a person's qualities with examples, they now only mention what the person 'did'. Achievements rate the person rather than character. The consequence is that we come to believe that those who have been successful in the world – fame, riches and power – are necessarily good people. Yet we know today's culture favours the bully, the callous entrepreneur, the ones who can muscle their way to the top. Whether we like it or not, it will affect the way we think about ourselves. If we have to judge ourselves by our achievements, the work we do, our status, then I should think very few of us are satisfied. We are into the game of comparison. This leads to great effort to 'prove oneself'. This, in turn, leads to envy and jealousy of others. In all, we may end up being successful in the eyes of the world, but our hearts will be in turmoil. If our hearts are polluted with all the negativity that comes from aggressive competitiveness, keeping up with the Jones' and so on, this cannot be conducive to happiness, to an inner sense of worthiness. We never feel ourselves to be quite good enough. In the Discourse on Blessings, the Maṅgala Sutta, as well as such social qualities such as being 'well educated and skilled, a highly trained discipline', the Buddha lists such qualities as: generosity, ethical conduct, blameless actions, reverence, humility, contentment, gratitude, patience, gentleness self-discipline

... these are the Highest Blessing. Whose mind does not flutter by contact with worldly contingencies, theirs is sorrowless, stainless, and secure. It's not that what we do doesn't matter. Far from it. What we do is an expression of our attitudes and the intentions that arise out of them. However, if we put the accent on our attitude and intention, making sure they are wholesome, and then do the deed, that deed will enhance our feeling of goodness. And the deed, no matter how well done, will not carry negative undertones. If a person is skilful in doing something, and yet they carry about with them a negative attitude, they may very well be chosen to do the jobs, but they won't make many friends. So if we want to feel good about ourselves - and want people to feel good about us - all we need do is get the attitude right. Next time you are doing something whether for yourself, for a friend or at work, just stop before you do and ask yourself, 'What is the underlying attitude that is accompanying the work?' If it's negative, put it to the side. Park it. And put a wholesome attitude into your heart. If it feels false, that's ok. It can take a while for the emotional heart to catch up. Then do the work. Hum the old song - 'Tain't what you do, it's the way that you do it. (Ella Fitzgerald) Right Attitude leads to Right intention, leads to Right Action, leads to a feeling of goodness within which is also a form of happiness.

Being Human

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 4 min read

Drawing from the Upaḍḍha Sutta (SN 45:2), where the Buddha tells Ānanda that having admirable friends is not half but the whole of the holy life, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines what it means to be truly human in relationship. The essay addresses contemporary challenges that fragment human connection—from neoliberal atomization to social media divisions, climate crisis denial, and institutional breakdown—while offering Ubuntu philosophy ('I am because we are') as a complement to Buddhist understanding of interdependence.

The teaching explores how our humanity is fundamentally relational, manifesting through the dance of wholesome connection or the brawl of corrupted relationships. Bhante connects the Eightfold Path's foundation in Right Understanding and Right Attitude to practical cultivation of kinship with all beings, even those we find difficult. He offers a walking meditation practice using Ubuntu phrases to develop genuine human solidarity.

This essay bridges ancient wisdom with urgent contemporary needs, showing how personal spiritual development and social healing are inseparable aspects of the holy life, while acknowledging the sobering reality that fear often motivates change more than wisdom in saṃsāra.

Ven. Ānanda said to the Blessed One, “This is half of the holy life, lord: having admirable people as friends, companions, & colleagues.” “Don’t say that, Ānanda. Don’t say that. Having admirable people as friends, companions, & colleagues is actually the whole of the holy life. (See below [I]) We are our relationships. This is a dynamic between ‘me’ and other. It is constantly changing. When that dynamic is wholesome, it is a dance. It brings all the benefits of community. When it corrupts, the dance morphs into a brawl. Everyone suffers. There are now so many forces that militate against our togetherness as human beings. Even our togetherness within individual nations. The neoliberal ideology that atomises us into individual entrepreneurs each vying against the other for a piece of the pie; the neoliberal economies that have created a gargantuan gap between the multitude of poor and the very few rich; the disastrous effect of Social Media in exacerbating the divisions in our society and proselytising conspiracy theories; the political powerlessness to tackle Climate Crisis and callous disregard of this existential threat by Corporations in the service of shareholders and by Deniers; the loss of confidence in our institutions – the Health Services, the national broadcaster, the police, the government; the zeitgeist, world mood, that is moving us towards ‘illiberal’

democracy and dictatorships; the growing threat of war (nuclear?) between China and the US, and even Russia. Not to talk of Covid and future pandemics that manifest the selfishness of richer nations and racial disparity. I'm sure you could add to the list. In all, it adds up to a foreboding that there has to be a crash of some sort. It can leave us feeling paralysed. Apart from becoming involved in a charity or cause that moves us, there may be something we are overlooking. We must do all we can to re-establish our sense of community. There were neighbourly awakenings during the lock downs, but once the pandemic ends, I dare say it will be back to 'normal'. The word Ubuntu^[ii] comes in many forms throughout all the countries of Southern Africa. It is a part of their view of life. Ubuntu (Zulu pronunciation: [ùbúnt'ù]) is a Nguni Bantu term meaning "humanity". It is sometimes translated as "I am because we are" (also "I am because you are"), or "humanity towards others" (in Zulu, umuntu ngumuntu ngabantu). In Xhosa, the latter term is used, but is often meant in a more philosophical sense to mean "the belief in a universal bond of sharing that connects all humanity". (Wikipedia) This is also included in Dhamma understanding of interdependence, but to say: I am a human because you are a human, is to cement it in a relationship of equality. As always, change begins within the individual. The Eightfold Path begins with Right Understanding and this manifests as Right Attitude which in turn manifests in how we speak and act. Here we have a practice. Just as in Metta we have phrases to establish good will to all beings, so we can develop that desire for kinship with all other human beings – even those whose actions and philosophy we detest. I am because you are – bring to mind all categories of people. How does each category effect you? I am because we are – My being a human depends on you being a human. I practised this while walking around Shrewsbury and there was growing sense of kinship. If you try it, do send me your experience. Please send me other phrases if you think of any. This talk is the inspiration for this Tip: What do We Want to Sustain? Thinking about Faith and The Climate. Dr Carmody Grey: Hook Lecture 2021 PS: Without doubt the best possible way through all catastrophe is through personal responsibility and a sense of common purpose, driven by a solidarity that comes from caring for one another. However, sadly, and I confess I am a little cynical; what will eventually drive most is the experience of danger. As all dictators know, fear is also a great motivator! But it comes with destruction. Such is the nature of Samsara! ^[i]Half (of the Holy Life) Upaḍḍha Sutta (SN 45:2) I have heard that on one occasion the Blessed One was staying among the Sakyans. Now there is a Sakyan town named Sakkara. There Ven. Ānanda went to the Blessed One and, on arrival, having bowed down to the Blessed One, sat to one side. As he was sitting there, Ven. Ānanda said to the Blessed One, "This is half of the holy life, lord: having admirable people as friends, companions, & colleagues." "Don't say that, Ānanda. Don't say that. Having admirable people as friends, companions, & colleagues is actually the whole of the holy life. When a monk has admirable people as friends, companions, & colleagues, he can be expected

to develop & pursue the noble eightfold path. “And how does a monk who has admirable people as friends, companions, & colleagues, develop & pursue the noble eightfold path? There is the case where a monk develops right view dependent on seclusion, dependent on dispassion, dependent on cessation, resulting in relinquishment. He develops right resolve... right speech... right action... right livelihood... right effort... right mindfulness... right concentration dependent on seclusion, dependent on dispassion, dependent on cessation, resulting in relinquishment. This is how a monk who has admirable people as friends, companions, & colleagues, develops & pursues the noble eightfold path. “And through this line of reasoning one may know how having admirable people as friends, companions, & colleagues is actually the whole of the holy life: It is in dependence on me as an admirable friend that beings subject to birth have gained release from birth, that beings subject to aging have gained release from aging, that beings subject to death have gained release from death, that beings subject to sorrow, lamentation, pain, distress, & despair have gained release from sorrow, lamentation, pain, distress, & despair. It is through this line of reasoning that one may know how having admirable people as friends, companions, & colleagues is actually the whole of the holy life.”[ii]

Ubuntu – you may know the word as open source software, part of Linux. There are various definitions of the word "Ubuntu". The most recent definition was provided by the African Journal of Social Work (AJSW). The journal defined ubuntu as: A collection of values and practices that people of Africa or of African origin view as making people authentic human beings. While the nuances of these values and practices vary across different ethnic groups, they all point to one thing – an authentic individual human being is part of a larger and more significant relational, communal, societal, environmental and spiritual world. Wikipedia

Beset by Perceptions (Madhupiṇḍika Sutta)

Noirin Sheahan · 43 min

In this retreat talk, Noirin Sheahan unpacks one of the more challenging suttas in the Pali Canon - the Madhupiṇḍika Sutta (MN 18), known as the 'Honeyball Sutta.' This discourse reveals how our attachment to perceptions creates the mental proliferation (papañca) that underlies all conflict and suffering.

The talk traces the Buddha's encounter with Daṇḍapāṇi and his cryptic teaching that 'perceptions no more underlie that brahmin who abides detached from sensual pleasures.' When the disciples seek clarification, Mahākaccāna provides a detailed explanation of how sense contact leads to feeling, perception, thinking, and ultimately mental proliferation - the endless chatter that besieges the mind.

Noirin skillfully relates this ancient teaching to modern vipassanā practice, showing how we can observe the arising of perceptions, notice our attachment to them, and discover the peace that comes when we stop delighting in mental elaboration. The talk emphasizes how 'perceptions fade as clinging is released' and explores what it means to experience reality without the constant need to categorize and solidify our experience through the lens of self-hood.

Tonight I'd like to discuss the sutta titled The Honey Ball. In parts of India, cakes baked from flour and honey and oil are still called honey balls. When Ananda, the Buddha's cousin and attendant, heard the discourse, he said it satisfied a spiritual seeker in the way a honey ball satisfies a famished man. So what we're getting tonight is some high calorie spiritual nourishment.

Now high calorie foods can also be heavy going on the system and I'd certainly rank this sutta as a difficult one to digest. Even in the original story, as you will see, the Buddha's disciples need three separate attempts to explain the matter before the penny drops.

Let's go through all three levels of explanation before looking at any one of them in detail. It all starts with the Buddha going into a wood for his day's abiding. A man named Dandapani is walking in the woods and seeing the Buddha approaches him and asks about his spiritual beliefs and practice. The Buddha replies:

"Friend, I assert and proclaim a teaching such that one does not quarrel with anyone in the world with its gods, its Maras and its Brahmas, in this generation with its recluses and Brahmins, its princes and its people, a teaching such that perceptions no more underlie that brahmin who abides detached from sensual pleasures, without perplexity, shorn of worry, free from craving for any kind of being."

In many of the suttas, the Buddha finds the exact teaching needed for whoever he is talking to, and that person becomes completely enlightened, though we 21st century seekers might be baffled by the Buddha's words. But Dandapani seems as perplexed as us modern-day dullards, and is described as shaking his head, wagging his tongue, and raising his eyebrows till his forehead was puckered into three lines, after which he departed, leaning on his stick. As an aside, Dandapani wasn't a recluse, and was wandering round the wood for exercise. Perhaps the Buddha's response irritated Dandapani enough to spur a spiritual quest at some later stage.

One way or another, Dandapani departs in a huff and the Buddha settles back to his meditation for the afternoon before later rejoining his disciples and telling them about his exchange with Dandapani. It seems the disciples were also puzzled by this summary of the *Dhamma* and one of them basically asked the Buddha what he is talking about.

So the Buddha offers this explanation: "Bhikkhu, as to the source by which perceptions and notions tinged by mental proliferation beset a man. If nothing is found there to delight in, welcome and hold to, this is the end of the underlying tendency to lust, of the underlying tendency to aversion, of the underlying tendency to views, of the underlying tendency to doubt, of the underlying tendency to conceit, of the underlying tendency to desire for being, of the underlying tendency to ignorance. This is the end of resorting to rods and weapons, of quarrels, brawls, disputes, recrimination, malice and false speech. Here these evil, unwholesome states cease without remainder."

Having said this much, the Buddha then leaves his disciples and retires into his dwelling. I imagine you will be relieved to hear that this explanation hasn't done much to satisfy the disciples, who then go to seek out a senior teacher to pick out the meaning of the Buddha's words. They chose Mahakaccana, who at first demurs, saying that they should have asked the Buddha, whom he likens to heartwood in the tree of Dhamma, while he, Mahakaccana, represents only the branches and leaves of that tree. But after a bit of persuasion, he agrees to give them his interpretation, which goes like this:

"Dependent on the eye and forms, eye-consciousness arises. The meeting of the three is called contact. With contact as condition there is feeling. What one feels that one perceives. What one perceives that one thinks about. What one thinks about that one men-

tally proliferates. With what one has mentally proliferated as the source, perceptions and notions tinged by mental proliferation beset a man with respect to past, future and present forms cognizable through the eye."

He goes on to say the same about all the other sense doors: hearing, tasting, smelling, body sensations and mind objects such as thoughts and perceptions. He then continues: "When there is the eye, form and eye-consciousness, it is possible to point out the manifestation of contact. When there is the manifestation of contact, it is possible to point out the manifestation of feeling," and so on until "When there is the manifestation of thinking, it is possible to point out the manifestation of being beset by perceptions and notions tinged by mental proliferation."

Likewise he says the same about all the other sense doors and then concludes with: "When there is no eye, no form, and no eye-consciousness, it is impossible to point out the manifestation of contact," and so on until, "when there is no manifestation of thinking, it is impossible to point out the manifestation of being beset by perceptions and notions tinged by mental proliferation." And as usual, he says the same about all the other sense doors.

This, I'm sorry to have to tell you, is the end of the line as regards explanations. The bhikkhus, we are told, were delighted with Mahakaccana's words. But they went and checked them with the Buddha as Mahakaccana himself advised them to do. The Buddha praises Mahakaccana and says he would have said exactly the same thing if he had been pressed for a further explanation.

It's at this point that Ananda describes the sutta in terms of a honey ball, saying: "Just as if a man exhausted by hunger and weakness comes upon a honey ball, in the course of eating it would find a sweet, delectable flavour. So too, Venerable Sir, any able-minded bhikkhu, in the course of scrutinising with wisdom the meaning of this discourse on the Dhamma, would find satisfaction and confidence of mind." The Buddha seems pleased with Ananda's analogy and tells the assembly they should remember this discourse as the honey ball.

So let's nibble our way through the honey ball and see can we detect any of the sweet delectable flavour that Ananda found here. First, we have the Buddha's synopsis of the Dhamma for Dandapani which starts with the description of a world without conflict and follows with the description of being free from attachments with their burden of worry and strife. He describes freedom as a state where perceptions no longer underlie that brahmin who abides detached from sensual pleasures. He is linking internal and

external conflict with being attached to and somehow founded upon our perceptions. His Dhamma, he declares, cuts through all that so that we find ourselves at peace with the world.

He describes this peace as applying to the worldly level of princes and men. All our worldly concerns fade away. We are also at peace with the heavenly realm of gods and the hell realm of Mara. In an age so dominated by science and technology, it's not easy for us to think of heaven and hell realms. Instead, we can think of these as temporary mind states, heavenly bliss and hellish rage. We no longer quarrel with whatever we come up against in the external world or in any of the internal worlds we experience within our minds.

I don't think any of us would quarrel with the notion of inner peace and making peace with the world. It's the phrase, "Perceptions no longer underlie that brahmin who abides non-attached to sensual pleasures," which stumps us, and like Dandapani, be causing our brows to furrow into the three lines and tempting us to stomp off.

And sure enough, when his disciples ask the Buddha to explain himself, he expands on the issue of perception and how they can lead to grief. Perceptions, if you remember, are the labels we place on whatever sense data comes to us. If our eye falls on some green grass, our mind sorts through its memories of stuff that is shaped and coloured like this and comes up with perceptions "green" and "grass." We might then quietly add a perception like "unimportant," as we move on to label the next bit of incoming sense data.

In this explanation of his message to Dandapani, the Buddha basically says that if only we can stop delighting in the source of perceptions that beset us, then we'd be freed from underlying tendencies to lust and other afflictions. There's a lot to think about here. He is saying that we delight in exactly that which is causing us to suffer. Although our perceptions beset us, cause us grief, the only reason they are doing that is because we delight in the source of these perceptions. We're in a mess, it seems.

Let's look at a possible example. Suppose I'm fretting about my neighbour's dogs who I hear growling in her back garden. There may be many levels to the mental disturbance. Concern that the dogs might start fighting, grief at the thought that they are possibly being neglected, instinctive fear at the sound of growling. All of these can set off chains of thought. Is there going to be a fight? What should I do? Will I get hurt? Each of these thoughts involves a long string of perceptions. Even the basic sound had to be perceived as growling and with that perceptions like "danger" would have emerged.

Although I'm getting stressed out by all my thoughts about the dogs and what might happen, the Buddha is saying that the only cause for my distress is that I'm delighting in, welcoming and holding on to the source of these perceptions. What is the source of these perceptions? This is the question that Mahakaccana addresses when pressed for his understanding of the Buddha's words.

He traces the source back to the moment of sense contact which involves in my case the sound of growling, the sense of hearing and the faculty of consciousness. If I'd been deaf or unconscious the dogs could growl all they liked but I wouldn't be upset. But given those three conditions the growling sound made contact within my psyche.

Mahakaccana then says: "With contact as condition, there is feeling." We might think of feelings as purely physical. In my case, the growling might have impacted as a rough, low-pitched vibration on the eardrum. Although the sensations are physical, our mental system gets involved immediately, categorising the sensation so as to work out whether it is a threat or an opportunity. This gives us a feeling for the sensation as pleasant, unpleasant or neutral. In the case of the growling dogs, my system feels the sound as unpleasant.

Mahakaccana then says: "What one feels, that one perceives." Many of those who have commented on this sutta note the grammatical change here. When describing the link between contact and feeling he used impersonal language: "With contact as condition there is feeling." But this changes once perception comes into the picture: "What one feels that one perceives." The language is now personal. This implies that the mind which categorises the sensation as growling also identifies itself as the one who feels this unpleasant sound and perceives it as growling. We have solidified both the external world and the internal world. We believe ourselves to be separate, a person who existed in the past and will exist in the future.

Although Mahakaccana doesn't spell out all the links of dependent origination for us, we can take it that we have at least gone through the links of desire and clinging when we form these perceptions based on feeling, to which he is referring here. Mahakaccana's linking of perception and clinging is very interesting to reflect upon. The vibrations resonating on the eardrum are my only real point of contact with the external world. Once the mind puts the label "growling" on these vibrations, it can split itself off from the raw experience. Unless I can hold the label very lightly as a tentative possibility, needing constant reaffirmation from each new sound, my subjective experience freezes around the label.

Fluidity is lost. A sense of self emerges in that abstract frozen world of this and that, me and you, growling and danger. If any of you have read Rob Burbea's book, *Seeing That Frees*, you'll probably remember the strong emphasis Rob also gives to the link between perception and clinging. Say we're lost in a temper tantrum. Our sense of self is strong and our perception of our adversary hardens into enmity. Later, when we calm down, we no longer feel so identified with our view and might also start to see the other person in a kinder light. The perception of enmity fades as clinging is released.

In general, Rob says, perceptions fade as clinging is released. This is a very useful phrase to contemplate and fits very neatly with Mahakaccana's teaching. Perceptions fade as clinging is released. In the case of the growling dogs, we're seeing the opposite side of the coin, how perceptions and clinging get intertwined and lead to *dukkha*.

Some innocuous vibrations on my eardrum have conjured up a sense of self around the perception "growling." The tendency then is to stop attending to the basic vibrations and instead to withdraw into an abstract internal world where my mind can build around that label. Many commentators say that there can be feedback loops within the 12-step process described by dependent origination, and we can see a perception-based feedback loop here. The perception "growling" can now become a new input at the doorway of the mind. And if we attend to it, we have another sense contact which deepens the unpleasant feeling, tightens the clinging and goes on to generate another perception like "danger."

As Mahakaccana says, "What one perceives, that one thinks about." Thus my mind spins through a few feedback loops and finds the perception "dog" fits neatly alongside the perception "growling" and the perception "neighbour's dogs" fit with both until the jigsaw completes and the thought and image of the neighbour's dogs growling at one another establishes itself in my mind.

Now there's nothing wrong with this. It's an aspect of human intelligence to be able to build a picture of what might be happening based on snippets of sensory information. The Buddha might have interpreted vibrations on his eardrum in a similar way. We need these interpretations in order to engage with the world. The only difference between the Buddha's approach and mine is that his piecing together of perceptions would have been done out of goodwill, as a deliberate, conscious decision to engage with the world. My picture, on the other hand, was built as an automatic reaction to unacknowledged aversion for the growling sound.

Putting the pieces of the jigsaw together gives me the illusion of control. And my problem is that I get hooked on the jigsaw. I want to find new pieces to fit, see what new picture will emerge. It's this delight in jigsaw making which, according to the Buddha, keeps rekindling lust and aversion, which then underlie our quarrels with the world.

In Mahakaccana's words, "What one thinks about, that one mentally proliferates." The jigsaw grows from the thought of the neighbour's dogs growling into thoughts like, are they going to start fighting? Why do they keep two dogs? What should I do? The string of thoughts based on that initial perception "growling" are now besetting me. I fitted so many jigsaw pieces together that I'm encaged by my own creation.

This process of mental proliferation is termed *papañca* in Pali. That's what this sutta is addressing. The endless chatter of the mind. The way it complicates any simple idea, elaborates on it, examines it for defects and builds a world around it. The way it fixates on an idea and projects a happy future around that. The enmity it projects onto whatever gets in the way of that idea. This is the source of all our quarrels with the world.

But all is not lost. Even though we're trapped within our monstrous jigsaw, we can train ourselves to see that we're making and remaking the jigsaw moment after moment. Mahakaccana assures us of this when he states: "When there is the eye, a form, and eye-consciousness, it is possible to point out the manifestation of contact," and so on until "When there is the manifestation of thinking, it is possible to point out the manifestation of being beset by perceptions and notions tinged by mental proliferation."

It's the last statement which we spend most of our time working through. Being beset by perceptions and notions tinged by mental proliferation. For those of you who, like me, are impatient to get to those intriguing links between consciousness and contact, contact and feeling, I offer this analogy. Imagine the honey ball has a very sweet centre but is encased in a thick hard crust. We have to patiently nibble away at the crust before we can taste the sweet fruit at the centre.

Can we find in the thinking process the sense of being beset by perceptions and notions tinged by mental proliferation? To go back to my experience of fretting about the neighbourhood dogs, if I had stopped to ask myself, are these thoughts making me happy? I would have had to admit that they were not. Why then do I keep thinking these anxious thoughts? The answer is that I feel compelled to think them. They seem important, as if the act of thinking will protect me from harm. So the description of

being beset by my own thoughts is apt. When we notice thoughts in *vipassanā* and acknowledge that compulsion to keep thinking, we are nibbling at the hard crust of Mahakaccana's honey ball.

If I become aware of the thought stream about the neighbours' dogs and bring attention to the moment-to-moment experience, I will sense myself insisting on my point of view, that the dogs are growling, that this is a problem, that something awful might happen, and so on. These are the perceptions and notions that are besetting me.

The practice, as we know, is to bring attention to the body, letting the thoughts come and go without latching onto them. The growling sounds, my basic point of contact in the world, might seem distant, behind an impenetrable barrier, inaccessible. It's as if there's an explosion of energy keeping me away from that basic sense contact. I feel frightened, fragmented, in my head, separate from my bodily experience, from hearing and all sense contact. This is hardly surprising, as the self I believe myself to be is just one piece of the jigsaw being created from these perceptual feedback loops.

For example, the thought "this is a problem I need to fix" could be very true and pressing. How is the thought experienced? Sometimes thoughts seem very light and fleeting and an analogy often used is that of clouds passing through the sky. But as I attempt to look at a very pressing thought like this, the cloud refuses to pass by. Instead, it envelops me. My mind fixates around it. It becomes gospel. It's as if myself and the thought are enclosed within a bright bubble, defending ourselves against a hostile world. It's a very uncomfortable experience, both physically and mentally, being stuck in this bubble.

As I let attention dwell on the experience, the bubble starts to dissolve and emotions like anger or sadness may emerge. Various components of the thought come more to the fore. At one stage, it may be the concept "problem". I might feel myself insisting that there really is a problem. At another stage the notion "I need" might become predominant as I feel the anxiety behind neediness. Or it could be the notion "fix" that looms large in imagination as I feel myself grasping after a perfect world.

At this stage I can acknowledge the truth of what Mahākākaṇa says about being beset by perceptions and notions tinged by mental proliferation. Notions like "fix" and "need" have my life history of self-chatter embedded within them. Every time I repeat a thought like "I need to do this or get that", I'm adding to the pressure inside all future thought bubbles with the phrase "I need". Whenever I paint a picture of how rosy the world will be once I get this or that right, I'm also adding to this pressure. The notions

"need" and "fix" and all other components of the thought are like landmines I create by mental proliferation. They lie waiting in consciousness till tread upon by some innocent bit of sense contact.

This is what the Buddha was pointing to when he explained, "Bhikkhu, as to the source by which perceptions and notions tinged by mental proliferation beset a man, if nothing is found there to delight in, welcome and hold to, this is the end of the underlying tendency to lust, aversion and so on."

It is the fact that we delight in mental chatter that causes all our problems. Each chat solidifies our hold on whatever notions and perceptions underlie it. Notions like "this is a problem" and its partner "I must fix this" would be favourites for most of us. You could probably name your own top ten notions which underlie most of your internal chatter.

We do, however, get moments when the emotional turmoil burns out and we feel less beset by thoughts. Instead of just saying "phew, I'm glad that's over" and drifting into a dreamy state of relief, we can maintain our investigative stance and see can we tease out any deeper nourishment from our honey ball. Can we look at the process of thinking from this calmer perspective to see how it comes about? Can we detect the desire to link perceptions together to form thoughts?

In my experience, perceptions are accompanied by a bright bubble of light in my mind and I get a little pop of satisfaction when a small mental bubble merges with another one. What was a vague notion now becomes more defined and the sense of self more solid. This is to study Mahākāka's statement: "With the manifestation of perception, it is possible to point out the manifestation of thought."

If I watch carefully, I'll notice that the pop of satisfaction is short-lived. The bubbles keep deflating. The sense of certainty dissolves with them. Seeing this over and over persuades me to resist the urge towards certainty and definition, to try to make peace with a world that is constantly changing, undefinable. Many emotions may surface as I come to terms with truth in this exercise. Grief, anger, fear, shame. But the draw towards truth holds the inquiring mind in situ, and faith helps me relax deeper into the experience, trusting that the path to peace is being formed as I bear with these emotions.

Say, for example, I identify my emotional state as fear. Bringing attention to the body, I register unpleasant physical sensations and tensions. Alongside these, I might detect pulses of intense fear which push a description of what's happening into my head, insisting that the situation is horrid. What I'm experiencing according to Mahākāka is

the manifestation of perception. "When there is the manifestation of feeling, it is possible to point out the manifestation of perception." Unpleasant feelings are there as a background and those little pushing sensations, the fleeting insistence that the situation is horrid, are momentary manifestations of perception. My mind splits itself off from what is thought of as horrid.

In time, though, my psyche relaxes from this insistence and attention dwells more continuously in the body. Although the sensations haven't changed, if I had to describe them, I might call them rough, pinching, jagged, stinging. But these labels no longer seem relevant. The mind stops bothering to categorise experience, to take meaning from it, to complicate it. It lets the roughness be rough. It lets the stinging sensations sting. Although these are still recognised as unpleasant, feeling them fully like this is less stressful than the continual popping of mental bubbles and the effort to separate off from experience to find myself as somehow outside of it all.

Sometimes this less stressful experience is so puzzling that it brings up the deeper fear of living in a world I cannot comprehend. But if conditions are right, I'll be able to trust to this unusual view of experience and start to make sense of it. I'll notice that the decreased stress is due to the fact that my interpretation of reality isn't centred around the notion of being a separate person. Sensations and feelings are known, felt, but there's no interpretation of these as happening to some entity called me. They're just coming and going of their own accord. The knowing of them is not centred around any point where I usually locate me, the knower. Its origin and extent are outside of experience, beyond the range of perception. Acknowledging the vast unknown within which my small world spins brings a deep sense of peace.

Linked to this, we have the final part of Mahākākaṇa's teaching: "When there is no eye, no form and no eye consciousness, it is impossible to point out the manifestation of contact. And so on until, when there is no manifestation of thinking, it is impossible to point out the manifestation of being beset by perceptions and notions tinged by mental proliferation."

This parallels the Buddha's advice from the *Satipaṭṭhāna* Sutta when he asks us to notice the mind without lust, the mind without hate and so on. We are to notice what is not happening. This is not usually our habit but a very rich practice indeed. Again, we have to start by nibbling at the outer crust of this honey ball, acknowledging times when our minds are not beset by perceptions and notions tinged by mental proliferation. Whenever you feel yourself somewhat calm, interested in the sensations of breathing or walking for example, acknowledge how the absence of thought is contributing to that sense of calm.

A word of warning. Absences can be hard to acknowledge. It is said that nature abhors a vacuum and as soon as the mind notices an absence it tends to fill it with lots of thoughts. No need to worry. This is part of the purification process. It's a manifestation of our fear of living in a world we cannot fully comprehend. Rather than work through that fear, we attach ourselves to thought. We even love thinking about our woes. What would become of us if we couldn't remember our failings and regrets, our disappointments and our worries? When that gets too much, we change tack and start thinking out new plans, new strategies for making ourselves happy. These and other mental habits often surge in to fill the gap we notice at that blessed moment of not being beset by our thoughts. Bearing with this and reflecting on the possibility, and occasional reality, of not thinking, loosens our attachment to these stories, encourages us to live a more embodied life.

In deeper meditations we may get the chance to study the other absences Mahākākaṇa mentions and see that thoughts cannot form without perception, that perceptions only form when there is feeling and in the absence of sense contact that feelings cannot form. At the most profound level we might even get a glimpse of sense contact emerging as we bring attention into one or other of the sense doors to detect a signal from the outside world.

At one level the exercise seems academic. Who cares whether feelings can only register based on sense contact? How does that help me cope with the challenges in life? One answer to this is that the exercise itself is purifying. Contemplating the possibility of living for even a moment without perception shows us how deeply attached we are to our way of seeing the world. We purify ourselves as we bear with the pain of attachment, the anger and grief that shows up as our minds probe this border to our understanding.

But do remember that there's nothing wrong with perception. It's a vital part of our intelligence. It's only attachment to perception that does the damage. When we dare to let go of needing to always see things my way we slide into a mysterious harmony. Our being is content and at ease as within an indescribable universe. We lose our desire to describe ourselves in any way that can be contained within the phenomenal world.

These moments also help us understand the Buddha's somewhat puzzling phrase in his address to Daṇḍapāṇi: "Perceptions do not underlie the Brahmin who abides detached from sensual pleasures." In these moments of peace we are experiencing a fluid world where categories like "this" and "that" are not absolute but changing, dissolving, reforming in line with the constantly changing sensory stream. The sense of me is not

defined by our present mood or our roles or by any measure we can make of our skills or behaviour. We don't bother defining what is indefinable. To use the Buddha's phrase, perceptions do not underlie our being.

We become more willing to experience life at the level of sensation and feeling and may even see how these come into being moment after moment. The beauty of this simple, fluid level of reality shows us that our dreams and worries are irrelevant, burdensome, unskillful. Although these moments of deep insight are only temporary, they give us hope. Our faith in the Dhamma is strengthened and when the self comes back to impose its will on the world, it is not quite so dictatorial, more ready to listen, to negotiate, to appreciate the kindness and wisdom on offer from the world. With a lighter heart we can pass over many grievances and see the wisdom of accepting the imperfections of the world, working with people, not against them. Eventually the Buddha assures us we will come to the end of quarrels, brawls, disputes, recrimination, malice and false speech. "Here these evil, unwholesome states cease without remainder."

In summary then, the Honeyball Sutta describes the Dhamma in terms of its ultimate goal of perfect peace. This is a broad-sweep overview of the Buddha's vision for his followers. The Sutta also pinpoints why we don't experience this peace, describing how we delight in and attach to our perceptions and especially the perception of ourselves as a separate substantial entity at the centre of our world. Attachment to perception leads on to thoughts which eventually weave a net to ensnare us within a painful, confining world of self-definition.

The ultimate peace comes when we no longer attach to perceptions, no longer get fooled into finding our essence within anything that can be pinpointed, named, defined or in any way bound within the confines of the mind and body.

So let's use our meditation time wisely. Now and again we might be troubled by the barking of the dogs nearby or other sounds. Can we feel any underlying emotions? Can we feel the urge to *papañca*? To embroider and complicate every idea, go over and back on it, defend its flaws, embellish our point of view. Can we sense how we create a world out of all this *papañca*? Similarly, if you're captivated by the dragonflies hovering over the pond, can you detect the urge to amplify the experience, to tell someone about it, to dig a pond in your own garden? Does all this thinking add to the beauty of the experience or detract from it?

In moments of ease, can we acknowledge the absence of thinking? Can we see how perceptions fade as clinging is released? Can we detect the peace on offer when we are not blowing up so many mental bubbles? Is that peace founded upon perception? Is it mine? Is there even a me?

May our meditation help us to break through the tough crust of *papañca* and be nourished by the honey ball of the Dhamma.

Breakfast at Last!

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 2 min read

This teaching explores how the simple act of mindful eating can become a profound spiritual practice that supports our journey toward liberation. Bhante Bodhidhamma emphasizes the Buddha's teaching that this 'fathom-long body' is our world, where we can discover both the causes of suffering and the path to freedom. The essay presents a practical reflection adapted from the Buddha's guidance to the Saṅgha, encouraging practitioners to eat 'not to indulge sensual pleasure' but to nourish the body wisely while developing appreciative joy.

The teaching provides detailed instructions for a mindful eating practice that can be done even with just a cup of tea, making it accessible to busy practitioners with families. Through careful attention to the arising and passing of hunger, thirst, taste, and satisfaction, we learn to distinguish between the body's genuine needs and the insidious arising of greed (lobha). The practice helps develop self-discipline and contentment while undermining unwholesome habits around food consumption.

This approach to mindful eating serves as both a daily meditation practice and a means of generating merit through gratitude for all beings who contributed to our nourishment. By learning to recognize when 'enough' arises and allowing greed to pass without acting, practitioners strengthen their capacity for wise discernment and move closer to the contentment that leads toward Nibbāna.

If you have a young family or for some other reason you cannot practise this mindful eating, then do make sure you have that quiet cup of tea, just by yourself, you with your body. And of course, it can be done whenever we have a drink or eat, though that first break-fast is a special time for it sets the attitude for the day. Consider the importance of the body especially so that the Buddha pointed to this form of existence as the best to attain liberation. Here we have joys and woes and the intelligence to seek and find the escape. Let us remind ourselves that we cannot be here without a body, that through the body we come to receive knowledge, that we can communicate, relate, take part in society, create good kamma and practise meditation. To feed the body is to nourish a space, sacred specifically to ourselves. The Buddha says that this fathom long body is the world, and it is here we can find the causes of suffering and the end to it. So, having made your cup of tea and holding it before you, now is the chance to reinforce your commitment to the Path of Dhamma. Here at Satipanya we have devised a reflection based on the one the Buddha gave to the Sangha. Wisely reflecting, I eat this food not to

indulge sensual pleasure or to seek comfort. Being mindful of every mouthful, I shall undermine unwholesome habits and develop appreciative joy. I eat only to sustain and nourish the body, thinking thus: I will allay hunger without overeating so that I may continue to live blamelessly and at ease. This offering brings me health, long life, strength and happiness. May the merits of my practice support the happiness, health, long life, rebirth in the heavenly realms and ultimately Nibbana of those who have kindly provided this food. The final paragraph is a grateful acknowledgement of the efforts of thousands of people and plants, and the sacrifice of animals if you are not a vegetarian, that have brought this food to our table. Even if we only do the following exercise once a day and that with just a cup of tea, it will keep alive within us the spiritual practice around food. To continue: Closing the eyes, contact the body and get in touch with feelings of thirst or hunger. Acknowledge that some of those feelings will be natural appetite, the body manifesting its needs. But that insidiously intermingled are those feelings of greed. Making a very clear resolution to nourish the body, take the first sip or bite and simply sit back within yourself and observe, feel and experience the arising and passing of different tastes, the action of tasting and chewing, all the while mindful of arising delight. Purposefully intend the action of swallowing, follow the beverage or food and stay with whatever feelings arise. Momentary satisfaction of appetite insidiously intermingled with the gratification of greed! Wait till 'More!' arises and repeat the process. At some point there will be feelings of 'Enough' coming from the body and here it may be that greed steals quietly from its hiding place. Go on, just this once. Just that one more piece of toast! Just sitting till that sensual desire passes, means we have got the better of the habit of indulgence. Our self-discipline has been strengthened. Our body is healthier for putting its needs first. When the 'More' passes, there may arise contentment – the heart without greed. Discerning the difference between contentment and gratification is crucial. One leads to Nibbana, the other to Realm of Hungry Ghosts! And that realm is right here manifesting as a feelings of unsatisfactoriness, of never enough, nagging compulsions and dictatorial addictions. Buon appetito!

Buddha Day Address — The Life, Teaching, and Path to Nibbāna

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 44 min

In this Buddha Day address, Bhante Bodhidhamma reflects on the profound significance of the Buddha's life and revolutionary teaching. He traces the Buddha's journey from leaving household life through his failed attempts at extreme asceticism to his breakthrough under the Bodhi tree, emphasizing how the Buddha's compassionate motivation — seeking liberation not just for himself but for all beings — provided the courage needed for Awakening.

The talk examines the Buddha's systematic teaching approach to laypeople: beginning with generosity (dāna) to undermine selfishness, progressing through moral virtue (sīla) to purify relationships, discussing the heavenly realms as reflections of wholesome mental states, and warning of the dangers of sensual indulgence before finally presenting the Four Noble Truths. Bhante explores dukkha as the fundamental unsatisfactoriness of conditioned existence, explaining the three types of craving (taṇhā) that perpetuate suffering.

The discourse culminates in a detailed exploration of Nibbāna — described through the Buddha's various metaphors as an island, an unconditioned sphere (āyatana), and boundaryless consciousness full of light. Through the analogy of child development and the practice of vipassanā meditation, Bhante explains the progressive stages of letting go: first separating from the external world, then from the internal world of thoughts and sensations, and finally transcending even the observer itself to realize the deathless element of Nibbāna.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa - Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble, and fully Self-Enlightened One.

We are gathered here today to commemorate the life and work of the Buddha himself, our founder. I'm going to talk more about his teaching, but remember this was a pivotal event in the life of humanity. There's no reason to believe that he was the first one to experience Nibbāna - he talked of it as an ancient path. But he was definitely one who came along and began to teach it in a way that was very open to even different cultures.

In terms of world religions, complete world religions that have spread through different cultures, really you've only got the three: Christianity, Islam and Buddhism. Remember that his discovery was such that he was able to step out of the culture of his

time. So he stepped out of the Brahminical tradition of the Vedas and was able to establish his own teaching. The Jain leader also was able to do that, so it wasn't as though he was unique in that. But definitely the manner of his teaching and the perception of his insight was such that we don't find anything deeper than that in any other religious form.

So we've come to really celebrate that, the fact that we are receivers of that teaching. And remember that he himself had to discover it. It's not as though he was born with that innate understanding - he went through the whole process of the purification of the heart and the insights necessary for liberation.

Most of us know the story. The pivotal points were leaving the homely life, the household life. So this must have been quite a break for him, especially since his only child had just been born. But that shows you the manner of his state of mind at the time, which we have to be compassionate with. These days we can't understand why anybody should leave their family like that. But then, of course, it was an extended family. It wasn't as though she was left high and dry. And he must have been in a state of severe inner turmoil, what we would call an existential crisis. And it was that that really drove him.

Remember that he tries all the forms that the age was able to offer him, all the yoga forms that were there, the development of mental states that we call absorptions. And he found that wanting only because they came to an end. So these are still belonging to the phenomenal world, the world of the mind.

And then he tried self-mortification. So this was based on that basic understanding that the body itself was a manifestation of bad karma, manifestation of unwholesome actions that we'd done in the past, in the past lives, and that it was holding the soul down. So the whole process was letting go of the body, by which we mean letting go of the appetites of the body. In a sense, blaming the body for the problems that we have. So if we had no appetite, then we wouldn't be suffering from greed. It was that mentality.

The Buddha tried that, especially severe mortification in terms of food. He said he could hold his spine through his stomach. So if you try that, you'll see how thin he was. And then he gave that up because he discovered it simply to be more suffering. It didn't seem to be getting him anywhere.

And with that, of course, he leaves his companions. And we find him on the roadside, feeling, I should think, pretty miserable for himself. And along comes a woman, gives him some sweetmeats. And this revives him. And he has that memory from childhood

where he's watching his father doing a ploughing ceremony. And that memory gives him an inkling as it turns his whole practice around. Instead of trying to achieve happiness, he then turns upon himself and tries to investigate the cause of his suffering. And it's with that inspiration that he sits under the tree.

But even then, under the tree, there's this huge doubt about whether he, in fact, has any right to continue this, to achieve anything beyond the human state, whether there is anything beyond the human state. And in the mythology that surrounds it, he touches the earth to ground himself, and the earth goddess arises and says that he's every right to do this because he has the perfection of generosity. So in other words, he's not doing it just for himself. And it was with that feeling that he was doing it not just for himself, but for everybody he knew, perhaps for the whole of humanity and all beings, that he found the courage to break through that delusion, and then he experiences Nibbāna bliss.

In that process, we say he has three knowledges. The first knowledge was that he has completely transcended, well, completely purified the heart. So there's no more aversion and all the aspects of aversion, fear, etc. There's no depression or anything like that. There's no greed whatsoever. And there's no more delusion about who he actually really is or what that is beyond this phenomenal form, this form of a human being. There's no doubt in his mind after that.

Shortly after that, he then thinks about teaching and he gets this doubt as to whether anybody can understand the subtlety of what he's just discovered. And then again, it's put mythologically that this great god, Sahampati, came down and said, "Look, there are some people with only a little dust in their eyes." So he reflected on it and he thought, "Well, I'll give it a go."

And then he thought of his six companions, whom he then goes in search of. But on the way, he meets Upaka, another ascetic, and Upaka says, "Oh, you look very bright, you've got this lovely serene feeling about you. Who is your teacher?" And the Buddha announces himself as the fully liberated one, the fully enlightened one, "I don't have a teacher," etc. And Upaka shakes his head and says, "Oh, very good, okay," and then moves on. So I think he learns very quickly that's not quite how you get the Dharma across.

Remember that just because he's fully liberated doesn't mean that he actually can teach. It's something that evolves. And you can see it in his teaching. The first teachings are not so rigidly formulated into four of these and five of those. In the scriptures you can see very early on it's coming out spontaneously. And then over time it becomes very formalized: Four Noble Truths, Eightfold Path, and so on and so forth.

And then he spends the rest of his life, as you know, wandering around North India teaching the Dharma.

Now the reading today begins with the way that he used to teach lay people, which may be of interest to you. And it was said that he always gave them a step-by-step discourse. And the first thing he talked about was giving, was generosity. So I'll go back to his particular experience. His whole courage, you might say, was based upon the fact that he wasn't just doing it for himself. He found that extra energy that he needed to stay under that tree and continue his investigation.

Now, although it doesn't say this in the scriptures, in the commentary it points out that giving itself is a path to liberation. Just giving itself, just generosity itself is a path to liberation. Now, why is that? When you give something, you necessarily have to renounce it. Something that you might have used for yourself - so much money that you might give to a charity, you could have given to yourself for your own benefit, for your own enjoyment. Time. You could have spent the time on something that you particularly like, but you're giving it up in order to help somebody. So that process of renunciation is also a way of undermining this selfishness, this constantly looking after ourselves, which is a product of that basic delusion that we have about who we are.

And this giving is always easier when we have it on a base of gratitude. So when you consider all the gifts and blessings that you've received in this life, and that some of them have come without your asking - just the very fact of being born was a gift. How our mothers and fathers looked after us, this was all a gift. We never paid for it. Perhaps we should, but anyway, we never paid. It was just given to us and we received it. And when you consider the education system and friends and all these people who at times have come to help, that sense of gratitude allows us to let go of things.

And in letting go of our wealth - not all of it, of course - and in letting go of our time for the benefit of others, we're undermining the way that we tend always to think about me, me, me, instead of we, instead of actually joining the community at some level or other.

So giving, that was the first thing he said. And he said everybody could be generous, even a thief. So a thief can steal something from you and then very generously give it to somebody else. So it was a universal virtue that anybody and everybody could actually practice. So that's where he began.

And he began there because, of course, the development of giving is already undermining that hard sense of self. The sense of self creates barriers. It likes to enclose itself with safety. Remember the self at its deepest level is very fearful, it's very unsafe. For a

start it knows it's going to die, which isn't a very happy thought. And therefore it feels safe, it feels grounded, it feels strong, it feels solid when it has lots of money and lots of friends and lots of power. And that's why we collect these things around us as best we can.

And in letting go of that, we're undermining that sense of solidity about ourselves. And of course the advantage of that is letting go of all the problems that come with holding on to things. So remember there's a consequence to indulgence in life. While we are very rich and very powerful and very famous and all that, that's fine. But, of course, it's afterwards when the things begin to decrease, whether just naturally by aging. Then we feel those consequences, the frustration that we feel when we can't get what we want and the grief at loss, the fear of loss anyway, that underlying anxiety.

And in our society, which is so separate, so lifted away, you might say, from the ground of nature - I mean, this whole place is dependent on electricity. It's nothing to do with ordinary nature. And during winter, occasionally, the lights will go out. Everything just blows out for some reason. And suddenly you realize that you couldn't run this plant. In fact, I don't think I could live without electricity. So there's that point where we've created a certain safety, but we know that underneath it, it's a very shallow safety. It can suddenly disappear from us.

And of course, if you live in certain parts of the world, such as now in Nepal, there you are, you're on that tower, perhaps a tourist, and you're enjoying the view, and the whole thing starts to collapse around you. So it's not as though we're not aware of that somewhere within the psyche. And that is an underlying pressure in our lives. And to undermine that, you begin to let go, begin to let go. So that's where he would begin. He'd begin by expressing the importance of generosity.

And then he would talk about moral virtue. So in Buddhist psychology, all our unwholesomeness is based upon a wrong understanding. And we have to have a certain compassion for ourselves there because we're born into the human state and we presume ourselves to be human beings. I mean, that's pretty straightforward. And in that presumption, we are depending upon this physical form in order to gain happiness. Because that's all we want. We just want to be happy.

But in so doing, we are creating that basis of unreliability. And because of that, we have this relationship to life of gathering things around us to make us feel solid, getting rid of anything which is going to undermine that. That's the aversion. And when something is too big, you run for it. So there's your fear. So there's your three basic attitudes to life because of this wrong understanding: acquisitiveness, aversion and fear.

And this immediately leads us into wrong actions, wrong relationships. And that's where the problem comes, because then, of course, we're building up habits which are unwholesome. And when we act upon unwholesome habits, we get that second tier of unwholesomeness, which is to do with shame, guilt, remorse, etc. So it all tumbles upon itself.

And what he's saying is if you begin to really look at your moral life, your ethical life, and begin to chip away at that, you're also undermining this wrong understanding as to who we are. So that would be his second point to get across to people, the importance of *sīla*.

Now, I've talked about the negative side. It's the opposite too. The better word is ethics, really, rather than morality. Morality we tend to limit to avoiding what is unwholesome. But ethics is just about relationships. So our relationship has its negative side, but remember that we've also got to develop its positive side. And that's these il-limitables: love in all its facets, compassion, sympathetic joy, and so on. So that's what he would be talking about.

And then he would tell them that, in fact, in so doing, they would be entering the heavenly worlds. Now the heavenly worlds are simply mirrors of what we experience as human beings. So in actually developing love within ourselves, in developing joy within ourselves, that's mirrored in some cosmological heavenly state.

These days, for a lot of people, rebirth and being born in other states is a bit difficult to understand. And it's not necessary, of course, to believe it. But generally speaking, I think the better position is not to come to a conclusion. Because if there happens to be other worlds, then we're in for a bit of a surprise or a shock one way or the other. So it's best just to leave that on the back burner, as they say. And it may or may not happen.

And the Buddha, of course, came across the same skepticism. And that's exactly what he says. He says, "Look, if you practice the Dharma now, you'll get the benefits now. If there is a future life, then you'll get the benefits also." So it's not as though you have to believe these things. But it's good to know that the Buddha himself definitely did know about them because that was the other two knowledges that came to him at his liberation.

The first was being able to go back to all his past lives and see very clearly that it was the ethical decisions he made which had the greatest effect on his future life. Now that's a breakthrough for the age, I'll explain that in a minute. And secondly, he saw other beings moving from one realm to the other according to the same law.

So remember that at the time of the Buddha, the old Brahminical system, which was widespread in places like Rome, Greece, Mesopotamia, Egypt, it was this polytheism. It was this idea that there was a whole realm of gods that ruled the world. And that your job as a human being was to appease the gods, was to pray to them, to ask them for favours, etc. And so in the Vedas and the Brahmins, even the Brahmins of that time, you would do these massive sacrifices to get what you wanted from the gods. And the sacrifices became really very refined rituals and you had to get everything right or else the god wouldn't respond. And of course these rituals weren't really delivering everything that they were expected to deliver. So there was a general losing of confidence in that whole process of polytheism.

So it's to do with power. It wasn't to do with being good or bad. It was to do with you making the sacrifice to a particular god and getting what you wanted. So you can see the whole shift towards ethical life was quite a revolution. Where the Buddha's saying, "No, if you want to get reborn in a happier place, it's to do with your ethics. It's not to do with these gods. It's not to do with the power of other deities."

And then he would talk about the dangers of sensual indulgence.

So we've mentioned that really, every time we indulge, what we're actually doing is creating a psychological dependency on something for our happiness. That's the problem, you see. If you just indulge and then you could let it go, that'd be fine. But when we indulge, we're actually placing a certain commitment to whatever it is that makes us happy at a psychological level. That's why it's so painful when it disappears. It doesn't matter what it is.

So he's pointing out the dangers of that and the advantage of renouncing them. Here there's sometimes a confusion about what this renunciation means because it's not the same as what he was practicing when he was doing the self-mortification business because that was based on a completely different understanding. The idea of the soul being trapped in the body and letting go of the body meant that the soul could escape and rise to heaven. This was more in the sense of renouncing in order to undermine that psychological dependency that grows with our indulgence.

Remember that if you look at even the basic things, like on retreat here, we often look at this whole process around eating. That attachment to porridge, for instance, I'm very attached, is translated. You see, it's the same psychology. That's the point. It's the same psychology no matter where you become attached, whether it's to art or nature or to a person.

So when we undermine that, we think that we're actually also undermining our ability to enjoy pleasure and our ability to love. Because that's how it feels. Losing excitement feels like a loss. And we won't want to lose it unless we see the aftermath. See, that's our problem. In a society where pleasure is just there at hand, you just turn the TV on for heaven's sake. We don't make the connection between the aftermath of indulgence with the actual process of indulging. So when we're indulging, what's the problem? We're enjoying life. It's the business that comes afterwards that we've mentioned, the frustration, and also the sense of boredom because the happiness that an object gives us, whether it's a person or food or whatever, has an inbuilt obsolescence. It begins to lose its flavour, you know, like chewing on the bedpost. And it just loses its flavour. So you can't keep scraping the chewing gum off and chewing it.

So what you have to do is begin to accept that there's a loss of excitement and you have to wait for the letting go. And when you've let go of something, you really do have to experience that moment of liberation. And it's catching the moment of liberation when you let go of something where you'll catch the deeper joy. See, what we do is we tend to let go of something, but we don't hang on and wait for it to completely drop out of the system. And then you get that moment of liberation.

Now, that moment of liberation is a taste of Nibbāna. That doesn't mean to say that the old habit doesn't come back. Of course it does. It's not that easy. But it's just letting go of something. Just try it. Anything that you are attached to at some level, just keep not feeding it and just wait for that moment when you feel it's just left the psyche, just gone like that. And it's that moment of liberation which has to be tasted. And once we begin to get a taste for that, you see, then it becomes easier and easier and easier to just let go of all the rest of it. But if it's always this struggle for letting go and then you fall back into the old habit, then it just becomes miserable. So make sure that if you are going to practice renunciation at any time, and you can do it at any time, just wait for that moment when you feel the release, the relief of it. That's very important.

So that's the advantage of renouncing them. And then it says, when he felt that the mind was ready, open, without hindrances, inspired and confident, then he expounded to the listener the elevated Dharma teaching of the Buddhas: *dukkha*, its origin, its cessation and the path.

So in other words, this teaching that he had to give, he felt he had to prepare. He couldn't just go bang on in and say, look, life's suffering. You need to do something about it. He just slowly prepares it. And he prepares it by pointing out that the path of liberation also has its joys. See, so we've talked about the joy of generosity, that very subtle joy of letting go. And the consequence of the ethical life, the feeling of the beauti-

ful heart within us and the possibility of future beautiful rebirths. So with all that, you see, he's got the person, he's whetted their appetite, and then he tells them the truth. Life is suffering and horrible. Life is unsatisfactory. There is unsatisfactoriness.

And so we'll also be reading the opening discourse that he gives about dukkha. Dukkha, remember, is that essential concept upon which the whole of his teaching is built. Dukkha. It means hard to bear in its basic meaning. Unsatisfactoriness. So it's always recognising that life itself, although it brings its joys and pleasures, life itself holds its own level of suffering – aging and death. We can't escape that. And to make the distinction between the given, which is pain, and our reaction to it, our relationship to it, which is the suffering.

So the Buddha always talks about two darts. See, the first dart is given. So you have a headache. That's given, you see. Now, how you react to your headache is an option. So you can either be very patient with it, or you can get angry with yourself for having a headache. So he tries to make that distinction. And he talks about, he begins by first of all pointing out these two extremes, by not falling into the error of these two extremes. So we've explained that. The one is to do with indulgence of pleasure and the other one is self-mortification. So he's pointed that, the middle way. The middle way is actually not in between these two, it's transcendent of it. It's something that rises up above and is showing a particular path. And that, of course, is the Eightfold Path.

He then goes on to the dukkha, this is painful, it'll be read out, but I'm sure most of you have read it. Birth is painful, aging is painful, separation from what is liked is painful, not to get what one wants is painful, and so on. Then the reason for it, the unsatisfactoriness, is this craving. Now the craving is both for these sensual pleasures that we've been talking about, but it's also a craving to keep rebirthing ourselves.

So when people ask me about rebirth, I say, well, if you actually see what's happening now in this present moment, from moment to moment, you won't have that much problem with the process of rebirth after death, because it's happening now. For instance, this body seems to us very solid, seems to us the same body that I woke up with this morning, for instance. But we all know that every seven years, every atom is completely changed. So next time you look at your face in the mirror, just remind yourself you weren't there seven years ago. You know what I mean? It's like recognising that the body is constantly dying. It's constantly dying and being reborn.

The mind, thoughts are constantly dying and being reborn. You get new thoughts every time. No thought is ever the same. Even if you were to say the same thing twice, it's not the same. If I said banana, banana. The second banana is not the first banana. It's completely different. It's another word, even though it means the same. Our emo-

tions never stop. They're constantly gurgling up from the depths. They can't be the same. You can't repeat anything in nature. Even though they might feel the same from a perceptual point of view, they're always different. This whole form is constantly re-birthing, moment after moment. And what keeps pushing that whole process is this attachment to this form. It's the belief that I am this human being. I am Bodhidhamma. And anything that undermines that just makes me crazy.

And then there's this craving for annihilation. Now, that's a completely different – that's the other process. That's the aversion side. That's when things get too much, you want to just get rid of yourself. When you've had a hard day or something, when you've been depressed, what do you do? You launch yourself onto the couch and disappear for a while. And that's a process of self-annihilation. The worst, of course, is suicide. So this whole process of getting rid of ourselves because we're fed up with ourselves at one level or another is the self trying to get rid of itself. Unfortunately, you always wake up. It's just one of those things. And remember that the seeking of oblivion is there because in oblivion there's no suffering. That's the relief of being in a deep sleep.

So this craving is on these three levels. The level of sensual pleasure, the level of constantly becoming me in one form or another, constantly taking on different roles throughout the day, throughout my life, and at times just not wanting to be me one way or the other. So these are the cravings.

And Nibbāna, he doesn't actually say Jesus is the end of suffering, is exactly the end of that craving. The complete fading away and cessation of that same craving, the giving up and the relinquishing of it, freedom from it, no longer any reliance on it, this craving. But remember, what sustains the craving is that sense of self, is a sense of me.

Now when it comes to Nibbāna, he has various ways of explaining it, various images that he gives us. One is of an island, completely separate. One is of an island. So Nibbāna is the island that we're making towards. He talks about an āyatana which is a sphere. A sphere in his language is a level of experience which is entire and complete unto itself. So for instance, there are six spheres dependent on our senses. So the eye, our visual capacity, is a sphere of experience. And you can't hear through it. You can't hear through your eyes and you can't taste through them. So all these senses are quite separate and they create certain levels of experience. And he says there is a level where none of this happens. There's no tasting, seeing. There's no earth, there's no moon, there's no coming, there's no going, there's no staying still. You can only stay still if you're coming and going. So it's a place which is completely transcendent. He talks about it as the unborn, the undying, the unconditioned.

And the word he uses there is *ati*. *Ati* means, when they ask him this quadrilemma, this is the big logical positions of the age, does the Buddha exist after he dies? Or does he not exist? Or does he exist and not exist? Or does he neither exist nor not exist? That's a killer. You can't go beyond those four. That's your logical proposition. Now the word in Pali which is used for that is *ati*. There is another word for is which is *hoti*. And *hoti* is like a joining word like when we say this is a clock. But he actually says *ati*, so there exists that which is not born nor died.

But his most clear statement arises in one of the discourses when somebody approaches him and asks him, where is the end of the world? In other words, where is the end of the phenomenal world? Now, in those days, which is different from us, the world and consciousness were both the same thing. We are under the illusion that when we look at the world, we're actually seeing it as it is. That's to do with our upbringing and our so-called enlightenment and science, that we think that when we're looking at a tree, that's the way the tree really looks. But actually, it's totally dependent upon our eyes, our perceptual faculties, what our brain and minds do with it. And so if we were all to look at the same tree, we'd all be looking at a different tree. In this room, we're all in this room. Nobody would deny the room exists, but we all experience this room in our own particular way. So the world and consciousness were the same thing.

Now what this man is asking is where does the world come to an end? Where does consciousness come to an end? And the Buddha says this question is not put properly. The question should be where does this world not find a footing? So our process is not the destruction of the world. It's to find this island. And then he says there is a consciousness which is not coloured by any of the senses. So in Buddhism there are six senses. There's the five that we normally count and also the mind, the process within the mind. None of those can be found in this consciousness. He says that it is without boundary consciousness. Now, a boundary can only be created by phenomena, can only be created by objects, by things. So there's nothing there. And in all directions full of light, awakenedness, just this is the end of suffering.

So this *Nibbāna* is not something which is some sort of idea. It's something to be personally experienced by us. And so how do we get to that experience? And this is the process of *vipassanā*, you see.

Now, so when you're sitting, when you're sitting and you're feeling and you're observing what's happening within you, unwittingly, we're making the inner world an object. I don't know whether you know this, but there was a woman called Margaret Mahler. She was a student of Freud. And she studied babies, babies until the age of three. And she made these wonderful discoveries, which have been all reinforced since

her. For the first four months, there's no objects. All it is is a bath of information coming in, and the baby lives seemingly in a two-dimensional world. It doesn't have any depth. And that's why you get babies reaching out for rattles. They're actually creating a 3D world in doing so. And then round about four months, the first object looms out of all this information. And it's usually your carer, your mother. And then very slowly, all this information coming in is turned into this outer world. And it takes to the age of three. It takes three years for that child to come to know themselves as an individual separate from the world around them. That's why they're very clear about whether they're a boy or a girl and all that. It's like, that's it.

Now, what we do then is we fall into that error of saying, well, look, that's the world out there and I'm me the way I experience the world. What we're doing is we are finding a position in ourselves to observe the inner world with all its information, which is the sensations in the body, all the emotions coming out from the heart, all the thoughts that are coming out. All of this we're actually pushing out just like that baby did with all the actual outer world. The inner world we're also pushing away from us. It's becoming an object to observe, to feel, to understand. And in so doing, again unwittingly, what is it that's pulling out? What is it that's pulling out? And that's when we begin to experience the observer within us very clearly. The one who knows. The observer, the feeler.

And the observer is a mirror image. Because when you're in that state of clear observing, you're aware of yourself being the observer. Am I correct? So, if you're aware of yourself being the observer, you see, you can't be that, can you?

Now, that's when you have to keep looking with an eagle eye, because at some point, whatever is in us, that is this Nibbanic element, to use the language of the scripture, of the Abhidhamma, the element of Nibbāna, to get that, to have it, to that experience, is being able to go beyond even the sense of the observer, the feeler.

So there's these three, shall we say, backward movements which take us into a Nibbanic experience. The first one is, as a child, we separate out from the world and become this individuated little being. Through our meditation, we're separating out from the inner world to become this individuated sense of the observer, the feeler, the one who knows. And it's just one step beyond that. Even now, we could just step behind and that'd be it.

So that's the process of liberation. The process of liberation is simply letting go of these three worlds.

And remember that when the Buddha was fully liberated, he didn't disappear. He didn't sit by the roadside there with a sign saying, "Fully liberated, do not disturb." He re-entered the world. He re-entered the world, the phenomenal world, and was able to pass on his message to others.

So what do we lose in the end through this process? When the Buddha, because of the negative way he would talk about *Nibbāna*, was often accused of being an annihilatist, he insisted, "No, the only thing that's annihilated is greed, hatred and delusion. All the rest is given back purified."

Now that, I think, is a joyful message.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you, by your fierce determination to achieve liberation, finally arrive at that heavenly place sooner rather than later.

Celibacy

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 2 min read

Bhante Bodhidhamma examines celibacy not as deprivation but as a skillful means for developing universal love (mettā). Drawing parallels with Churchill's famous phrase about greatness, he explores how some are naturally celibate while others grow into it through practice. The essay addresses Western misconceptions about celibacy, explaining that sexual desire, while natural, is not a necessity like food, and that freedom from sexual craving can bring profound relief and redirect energy toward spiritual pursuits.

The teaching distinguishes between particular loves—romantic, familial, and friendship bonds—and the Buddha's ideal of universal love that extends to all beings without preference or hatred. While acknowledging that particular loves aren't evil, they are understood as unskillful (akusala) due to their limiting nature and the psychological dependency they create. True universal love can only arise through relinquishing particular attachments.

The essay offers practical guidance for developing what might be called 'momentary celibacy'—giving full attention to whoever we encounter without the hindrance of erotic, romantic, or preferential love. This involves cultivating affectionate awareness while observing our internal reactions and responding from goodwill. The teaching concludes with reflective questions about why the Buddha maintained celibacy after his Awakening and established the monastic Saṅgha, inviting contemplation on how celibacy might be practiced even within relationships.

To coin a Churchillian phrase: some are born celibate, some have celibacy thrust upon them and some grow into celibacy. (Churchill had said this of greatness.) In more religious times and even now in Buddhist countries, a woman may boast she is still a virgin. And a man is not considered any less a man who joins the Sangha as a child or young teenager and never has any sexual encounter throughout their lives. How strange to a Westerner. Sounds even perverse. A life without sex! But we fail to remember that the 'sexual revolution' of the 60's is not that long ago. And such has been the sexualising of our society – with easy pornography – that even children are caught up in lust – and themselves lusted. No one needs sex. It's not like food. And since sexual desire is probably our greatest driver, can you imagine the relief when you are no longer hounded by sexual cravings as someone with OCD may feel when relieved of their compulsion. And can you imagine the energy released for other purposes? For those who find themselves temporarily celibate, take the opportunity to find out how it feels when

you let go of lustful thoughts. As with all acts of renunciation, you have to resist the fantasies and suffer the desire, feel it in the body, till the compulsive need exhausts itself completely to feel the release, the relief and the joy of liberation – even if only once! And there is romance which blossoms often into an intimate relationship. This is also forsaken in celibacy. To someone seeking a greater love, such love is confining. There are also all the other loves - parent and child, friend with friend, even spiritual friendships and so on – all will have some psychological dependency. This ‘attachment’ is not to be seen as evil, but unskillful. It has unwanted consequences. Such loves cannot be universal by definition. True universal love arises when there are no particulars. And this can only be arrived at through relinquishing particulars. The Buddha says our love should go out to the whole world, ourselves included, without any hatred or preference. In other words, whoever we meet within that given moment, whether we like them or not or whether they like us or not, they are focus of our goodwill. Such will not be perfectly possible to do till the delusive sense of self which creates fences is taken down. But we can begin the process of dismantling them. When we are with someone, let us give them our full attention with the desire to know where they are coming from, how they feel, what they are saying. And at the same time to be aware of the background of reactions and responses that arise within us. To develop an affectionate awareness. And respond from the heart of goodwill. In this way we can all in given moments, unhindered by erotic, romantic or specific loves, be ‘celibate’. For this is the reason for celibacy – to develop unhindered love. Difficult! Ponderings: Why do you think the Buddha did not return to his family and the household life after his Enlightenment? Why did he create a celibate institution, the monastic Sangha? How might you practice celibacy within a relationship?

Coming Down to Earth

Noirin Sheahan · 2 min read

In this deeply personal essay, Noirin Sheahan explores her relationship with the earth element as part of Buddhist contemplative practice. Drawing from her experience with the 'Back to Beginnings' program by Tara Rokpa, she examines how awareness of the five elements (mahābhūta) can cut through the delusion of a separate self and provide a gateway to truth beyond opinions and prejudices.

The essay chronicles Sheahan's initial resistance to earthly, physical reality and her preference for the mental realm. Through honest self-examination, she discovers her tendency to dismiss concrete experience as 'beneath her,' preferring the energizing challenge of uphill struggles over the relaxing descent that 'promised nothing.' This resistance mirrors a broader pattern of clinging to ideas, dreams, and ideals while avoiding direct embodied experience.

As the author learns to acknowledge and work with her aversion to the earth element, she begins to trust physical reality and discovers the 'peaceful experience of non-opinionated flesh.' The essay beautifully illustrates the interconnection between mind and body, showing how mental resistance manifests as physical tension and how acceptance allows both to soften. Concluding with the Buddha's teaching about finding the entire universe within the body, this piece offers valuable insights for practitioners seeking to integrate meditation wisdom into embodied daily life.

Coming down to earth.

It helps me see to through the delusion of a separate, isolated self when I let go of thinking and instead notice how experience can be felt in terms of the five elements: earth, water, fire, air and space. This provides an exploration of life which is not so easily clouded by my opinions and prejudices. Ironically, this more immediate encounter with the world is showing me unacknowledged prejudices and testing my most cherished opinions! It's a gateway to truth.

Earth is perhaps the easiest element to notice. Right now I can feel my feet pressing into the ground and the hardness of the table that my elbow leans on. Sometimes I am more aware of the earth element within myself – heaviness becomes very obvious as I race up the steps at Connolly Station, and (especially if I miss the train) tension in my jaw!

But my relationship with the earth element began badly. As part of a therapy program (the „Back to Beginning’s” program offered by Tara Rokpa – see www.tararokpa.org and the book “Restoring the Balance” by Dr. Akong Tulku Rinpoche) some years ago, we were asked to spend a month exploring each of the five elements, starting with the earth.

We were encouraged not only to feel heaviness, touching etc, but also to immerse ourselves in the physical earth e.g. gardening, hill-walking or literally mucking about! Although I could feel my feet touching the ground, I found I didn’t much like to be cognitively aware of the ground beneath my feet – even quite beautiful parkland. It seemed somehow alien, even threatening, and I found myself dismissing it quickly as „beneath me”. Once I was running along some open ground and, despite being tired, found I preferred the uphill struggles to the downhill stretches! I enjoyed the mental energies generated by the uphill challenge e.g. a sense of power, determination, anticipation of the summit. The easy run downhill called only for relaxation, promised nothing. It felt like loss.

As I began to acknowledge my relationship with the physical earth I saw my preference for the mental world and my disdain for more concrete reality. As always, acknowledgement heralds change, and I am slowly coming down to earth! As I let go of clinging to opinions and dreams and ideals, and feel my way through the fear and sadness of their loss, I find it easier to relax physically, trusting the earth to support me instead. I am more and more willing to explore that within me which is devoid of ideas, and I’m beginning to appreciate the peaceful experience of non-opinionated flesh! The links between mind and body become more fascinating e.g. if I get a fright I can feel a wall of tension solidifying in my jaw, as my mind pushes away from the body saying „No,

not this, no, no, no!”. And then I feel waves of sourness chipping away at the wall as I acknowledge my aversion. Eventually I sense the quiet joy of acceptance as I relax and let

the wall crumble. In meditation there is the whisper that the softness of relaxing flesh might be an experience of truth more trustworthy than all my heady visions. I begin to appreciate the Buddha’s words: “Within the fathom long body can the entire universe be known”.

Committing to the Path

Noirin Sheahan · 2 min read

In this deeply personal reflection, Noirin Sheahan explores the second factor of the Noble Eightfold Path — Right Intention (sammā saṅkappa) — through the lens of her own Lay Ordination ceremony at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat. Drawing on Gregory Kramer's framework, she examines three levels of practicing Right Intention: moment-to-moment mindful attention to our actions and thoughts, episodic intentions set before specific activities, and overarching life commitments that serve as guiding principles.

The essay centers on Noirin's experience of taking formal Lay Ordination on Buddha Day, publicly committing to the Three Refuges (Buddha, Dhamma, Saṅgha) and the five precepts as the cornerstone of her spiritual life. She explores how public vows strengthen our commitment through healthy social accountability, while cautioning against rigid literalism that can lead to paralyzing perfectionism. Instead, she advocates for holding our aspirations gently, allowing the natural tension between our ideals and habitual tendencies to become a pathway for growth.

The teaching emphasizes how formal commitment can transform ordinary difficulties — tiredness, despondency, life's inevitable dukkha — into opportunities for spiritual development. Through her spiritual name 'Puñṇanandi' (Rejoicing in the Power of Goodness), Noirin illustrates how choosing a quality to cultivate can balance personal tendencies and connect us to something greater than ourselves. The essay concludes with an invitation for others to consider taking formal Refuges and Precepts as a 'safety rope' supporting their journey toward the end of suffering.

Right Intention is the second strand in the Noble Eightfold Path. In his book “A Whole Life Path”, Gregory Kramer distinguishes three levels at which we can practice Right Intention: moment to moment, bringing wise attention to each footstep, gesture, thought; episodic, where we make a good wish for a specific activity – e.g. before we go to a meeting, or open our emails; and overarching intentions, which are our guiding principles for life. Marriage vows are an example of overarching intention. So also is Lay Ordination, which I took last Sunday, on Buddha Day, confirming the Buddha, Dhamma, Sangha as the cornerstone of my life and pledging harmlessness according to the five precepts. I did this to affirm that my life is dedicated to the Eightfold Path. While I’ve had that as a background motivation for decades and recommit every morning when we chant the Refuges and Precepts, it strengthens commitment to make the vows

in public, at a formal ceremony witnessed by friends. We don't like to let people down! The Buddha ranked guilt and shame as beneficial mind-states. They keep us within societies norms. Sadly, these same forces can be used to perpetuate prejudice, war, racial hatred. But when we chose wise friends, align ourselves with a tradition we trust, then our social instincts of guilt and shame foster traits like friendliness, compassion and generosity. One danger with making any vow is that we take the words too literally, get paralyzed with fear lest we make a mistake. It is painful to see ourselves fail to live up to our own expectations. That pain, when examined mindfully, persuades us to let go of tight definitions of right and wrong, trust that just being mindful of that tension between our aspirations and our habitual tendencies is to step along the path. Taken gently like this, the vows give a background frame to support us through life's challenges. Feeling tired and despondent this afternoon, I remembered my ordination and 'drudgery' took on the hue of nobility. Life is dukkha after all, tiredness and despondency are only to be expected. What matters is that we embrace them willingly. Remembering the broader aspiration for my life allowed me to value each plodding step. Though the sensations and feelings reflected despondency, the heart saw in these the first noble truth and embraced them with curiosity and tenderness. After a retreat at Satipanya there is the option to take the Refuges and Precepts formally, and also chose a particular quality you would like to develop, such as equanimity, wisdom or patience; this quality then becomes your spiritual name – traditionally its translated into Pali. My name is Puñyanandi which means 'Rejoicing in the Power of Goodness'. This balances my tendency toward over-effort and grasping; reflecting on 'the Power of Goodness' brings me beyond myself, helps me trust the wider world, develops gratitude for all the goodness I receive, joy that I can contribute to Satipanya and all that I perceive as beneficial. Lay Ordination is one aspect of 'The Power of Goodness'. It reminds me to practice Right Intention, direct my life toward the end of suffering, resist habits that drag me into whirlpools of misery. It's a safety rope. I hope you too will grasp that safety rope, take the Refuges and Precepts formally, make those vows in public, choose a name that calls you home, to the stillness and peace of your true nature.

Compassion: To Care

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 4 min read

This teaching examines the Buddhist understanding of compassion (karuṇā) through the lens of both empathy and action. Bhante Bodhidhamma explores the Pali term anukampā—the Buddha's trembling heart that resonates with others' suffering—as the foundation for compassionate response. He distinguishes between the passive mode of compassion, where we simply accompany those who suffer (particularly valuable for the dying), and the active mode of skillful intervention.

The essay addresses common pitfalls in compassionate action, particularly the 'Do-Gooder Syndrome'—the compulsive need to help driven by ego rather than genuine care. Through practical examples, it emphasizes the importance of asking what others actually need rather than imposing our own ideas of help. Key qualities for authentic compassion include patience (khanti), tolerance when facing others' anger or frustration, and commitment to sustained care.

Drawing from both Buddhist wisdom and contemporary insights, this teaching offers practical guidance for developing genuine compassion that serves others rather than our own need to feel useful. It reminds us that compassionate action naturally flows from recognizing the support we ourselves have received, leading to what the author describes as the paradox of the profoundly happy compassionate heart.

It all begins with empathy. I was going to write sympathy, but these days it has a touch of pity or insincerity about it, but I would like to use the word to say that even if we have not had a similar experience, we can imagine what it is like. The root words add up to feel-together. Whereas empathy means you have had a similar experience, the word can be used by someone who is actually imagining what the other is experiencing. I've never been a refugee. I can only imagine what it's like. The Buddha uses the word, anukampa. Kampa means to tremble or quiver and anu a sense of movement towards. So the Buddha says that out of this anukampa, the trembling of the heart resonating with someone, he has done all he can for his disciples. Karuna (rk karma), the word we usually translate as compassion, comes from a root Vedic word which means a holy action, a sacrament. So here we have the passive state of sympathising or empathising anukampa and then the action, karuna. If there is no action, no follow through, it is compassion unfulfilled which can leave you feeling ashamed of yourself and guilty, grieving even that you did not follow your heart's desire. Compassion then is a response

to the empathic or sympathetic connection with another's suffering. And there are two modes, a passive and active mode. In the passive mode we are able to simply be with, accompany the one who is suffering. That can be a great solace to someone, especially if they are dying. This can be difficult for us because we always want to do something, understandably. I heard a story of an elderly woman in a hospital who late in the night asked a nurse to come and stay with her while she died. So, it takes a moment of reflection to accept our powerlessness – I can't do anything for this person in their suffering, but I can accompany them. Beware the Do-Gooder Syndrome! There are situations where we can do something, and this can lead us into the error of over-doing. So, it's important to ask the person what they want of us. We can make a suggestion, of course, but be accepting if they don't want it, even when we know that it would better their situation. Otherwise, we fall into the error of the compulsive do-gooder. That's when we do the good we want to do for the other whether they want it or not! Such a compulsion comes from the need to be loved, to be wanted, to be useful, connected to self-esteem. We may visit someone who is temporarily incapacitated with offers to cook them a meal, only to find someone else has been, leaving food. How do we react if the person then says, but there is something you could do for me. 'I'd be really grateful you would clean the toilet.' The do-gooder in us also has a tendency to volunteer help without reflection. A sort of reflex compassion and then we regret it. A friend says they are ill and you volunteer to do their shopping on Saturday morning. And then you find yourself grumbling that the last thing you want to do on a Saturday morning is go shopping! All sorts of excuses leap into the mind. 'I really don't feel well.' 'My mother is sick and I'll have to go and help her.' 'I can smell gas and have to wait for the engineer.' All to be preceded by profuse apologies. I had such an occasion, but out of friendliness to help someone decorate their flat. I decided there was a lesson to be learnt here and made myself keep my promise. It stopped me being so impulsive in the future. Patience is often called for - patient forbearance, that willingness to bear. My mother was suffering the first signs of dementia caused by little capillaries bursting in her brain. One day I had reason to visit the elderly lady who lived next door and she told me my mother would come every day to talk and say the same thing! I thanked her for her kind patience. If the person turns their anger towards us because we didn't do this or that, or we did but we didn't do it properly, or we're more of a hindrance than help, then patience takes on a hue of tolerance. We are often angry with ourselves for being ill or incapacitated. Reminding ourselves of that helps us to bear with a certain amount of abuse, that is until we see the person is not just expressing their anger, but actually indulging it. And, of course, it takes commitment that demands a certain dedication to helping someone. Compassionate action arises more easily when we consider the assistance and support we have received throughout our lives. And it is a seeming paradox that the compassionate heart is a profoundly happy heart. Pope Francis puts it beauti-

fully."Rivers do not drink their own water; trees do not eat their own fruit; the sun does not shine on itself and flowers do not spread their fragrance for themselves. Living for others is a rule of nature. We are all born to help each other. No matter how difficult it is life is good when you are happy, but much better when others are happy because of you."

Conditionality and Kamma

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 7 min read

This essay provides a comprehensive introduction to two fundamental Buddhist principles: the Law of This and That Conditionality (idhapaccayatā) and the Law of Kamma. Bhante Bodhidhamma begins by examining the Four Noble Propositions that explain how phenomena arise through both immediate contingency and causal continuity, avoiding the extremes of pure randomness and rigid determinism.

The teaching explores how kamma operates within a matrix of five natural laws (niyāma): physical laws (utu), biological laws (bīja), psychological laws (citta), ethical laws (kamma), and spiritual laws governing liberation. This framework demonstrates that not everything we experience is personal kamma - natural disasters, hereditary conditions, and intellectual abilities arise through various causes beyond individual ethical choices.

Central to the discussion is the distinction between kamma (intentional action) and vipāka (consequence), emphasizing how our interior life of thought, speech, and deed creates volitional conditioning (saṅkhāra). The essay clarifies that Buddhist ethics transcends simple moral categories, addressing how even 'natural' attachments can cause suffering. Through understanding conditionality, practitioners can skillfully transform unwholesome mental habits into wholesome ones, creating the foundation for spiritual progress toward liberation from the very sense of separate selfhood.

Conditionality & Kamma

A Basic Introduction.

The law of kamma (karma in Sanscrit) is fundamental to the teachings of the Buddha.

We find it right

at the point of enlightenment, enveloped within the Three Knowledges (tevijja) that came to the

Buddha on liberation. The first was that his heart and mind were clear of all defilements; the second,

that he could review his countless rebirths and see they were driven by his ethical decisions; and

third, was his ability to see beings moving from one plane of existence to another driven by the same

law.

What was at first a law that pertained to him alone became a universal law. And the

law was

inexorable.

But before we go into this area of ethics, we must understand the Buddha's explanation of why things

happen the way they do. This is the Law of This and That Conditionality (idhappaccayatā). Just as a

five-letter equation, $E=mc^2$, belies enormous scientific knowledge and potential, so these simple

propositions explain at the fundamental level how things come to be:

When this is, that is.

When this is not, that is not.

From the arising of this, that arises.

From the cessation of this, that ceases.

The first two propositions tell us why things happen simultaneously by way of immediate

contingency. For instance, at Satipanya, people come from various trajectories to form a group. The

opposite of this is that if they didn't come, there would be no group. This is an immediate

interdependency. Our bodies are alive because certain functions work together at the same time. If we

stopped breathing or the heart stopped, then the body would stop.

If we take these propositions at a universal level, then we have a situation where everything happens

only because it arises or doesn't arise in this present moment. Presumably, it would be quite chaotic:

where would order come from save in the occasional, haphazard arrangement? From a kamma

viewpoint, thinking that good arises from good and bad from bad would be no use. There would be no

perceptible consequences from actions, since every happening would be entirely random. The reason

for a moral code or ethical understandings would be missing. We would live in an amoral society.

The final propositions tell us that events now happen because of an effect coming from the past, no

matter how near or distant. It has some original beginning. A group forms at Satipanya because

various people have made a decision in the past to come here. Their arrival is a present

consequence

of past decisions and consequent actions. And the consequence of the ensuing present actions will

have some effect on future actions. This is a linear cause and effect law. Our bodies are alive because

of past feeding and caring for them. If we stopped feeding the body, at some point it would stop

functioning.

On a universal level, if everything happened as a direct consequence of something in the past, then

the future would be pre-destined. In this scenario, how would creativity manifest?

Presumably, the

universe would be repetitive. Again from a kamma viewpoint, we would experience everything as fate.

If everything is fate and pre-determined then again there would be no need for ethical laws and moral

standards. Indeed a teacher in the Buddha's time, Ajita Kesakambali,

(http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Ajita_Kesakambali)

said that if one were to go down one side of the Ganges creating mayhem and up the other performing

great acts of compassion, it would not make the slightest difference. We would again be living in an

amoral society.

The Buddha says present contingency and past conditionality operate in unison. So we have some

order within creativity, some creativity within order. In art the order is represented by technique

which underpins all creative arts. It is much the same in sport.

Apart from the basic Laws of Conditionality, we are embedded in more obvious laws of nature. These

Niyama come together to create any given moment. There are five which equate fairly well with our

modern way of seeing the world. The first is the Law of Heat (utu). Heat or Fire was understood to be

the primal energy of the world. It equates to our physical sciences. The Law of the Seed (bija) equates

to our biology. The Law of the Mind (citta) equates to our psychology and from this we can infer

sociology which is but a society of minds. Then there is the Law of Kamma. Finally there is the

Spiritual Law which equates to the Buddha's teaching on the end of suffering and the transcendent

state of Nibbana.

These Laws tell us that not everything that happens to us is our personal kamma. We don't 'deserve'

everything that happens to us. When it comes to natural disasters, to be caught up in a tsunami or

earthquake doesn't mean we deserved to have all our property destroyed or lose our lives. If a person

is born with a hereditary disease, it doesn't mean they did something terrible in their past life. Our

genetic history is governed by our forebears. When it comes to the mind, our intellectual abilities

don't mean that we did something wonderful in the past life to end up a genius or something terrible

because we were always bottom of the class. When we enter the Path of Dhamma impersonal laws of

kamma and all the teaching implied in the Four Noble Truths govern our progress towards liberation.

So what does the Law of Kamma refer to? In terms of the process of liberation from suffering it has

little to do with the consequences of our actions as they affect the world. Our goodwill actions support

the process of purifying the heart and leading us to liberation, but they may not have their desired

effect on the world. For that we need to know the matrix into which our action is being thrown. And

we can never know that in its entirety. A charity that collected clothes to send to a poor country

unwittingly destroyed the local tailor trade which in turn had a knock-on effect. They had to stop

sending clothes. Many people argued and still argue against the Iraq war. But perhaps in the fullness

of time, it might be seen as a catalyst that released the Arab Spring: a country could be free of its

dictator and could move towards democracy.

So the kamma that pertains to liberation is that which pertains to our interior life. In

Pali, the language of the Theravada scriptures, the word, kamma, strictly refers to the intentional act, and the consequence is properly termed vipaka. As used to Kamma refers to a conscious act, whether by a deliberate act of will or by way of habit, which occurs when it has an ethical dimension. The intention can be either wholesome or unwholesome. And when we empower such an intention, an act is performed. It can be a mental act of interior thought and emotion such as when we get lost in an angry or exciting daydream, or it can be an act of speech or a deed. (This is to be distinguished from the present day meaning of karma which signifies fate.) Now once an act, a kamma, is completed, it will go on to have an effect, vipaka. Vipaka is not unalterable fate, for on recognising the consequences of an act, a person can change them. For instance, if we upset someone, we can apologise. So when we allow the mind to wander into unwholesome daydreams, we are developing the attitude that drives it. Anger will drive hateful scenarios; love, affectionate scenarios. When thoughts are expressed in the spoken word, the same is happening. And when an angry thought leads to banging

doors, shouting and worse, the underlying attitude of anger is being developed. In the same way, a caring action will develop love and compassion. Such kamma of thought, word and deed, are creating, because they are willed, our volitional conditioning, saṅkhāra. This is where we store all our wholesome and unwholesome attitudes.

It is important here to make a distinction between what we might term moral behaviour as a contrast to unskillful behaviour. When we talk of immoral behaviour we usually refer to actions that are grave such as stealing or hurting someone, no matter how small. But there are actions which

come from attachment, that cannot be called 'evil', but nonetheless cause suffering. For instance, the attachment a parent has to their child is 'natural'. It would be difficult to imagine otherwise. But this attachment is a cause of suffering for the parent and a catalyst for the suffering of the child. How do we know when attachment is manifesting? Whenever we feel disappointed, angry, overly fearful for the child, and so on. Such reactions are good indicators. It is also important to understand that we do not know fully the consequences of our thoughts, words and deeds on our internal life, since we don't know the strengths and weaknesses of our own conditioning. In certain circumstances, heroic actions can come to people who would never have thought themselves especially courageous. And the opposite is true, of course. Road rage, computer rage and other such rages often take people by surprise. In other words, as we do not know an action's outcome when performed in the matrix of the world out there, we don't know what an intentional act of thought, word or deed, will have upon the internal matrix of our heart and mind. So, from the laws that express conditionality, we can see that we will never know the consequences of our decisions. Even in the Buddha's case, he had to sometimes adjust rules that he had previously made because of an unforeseen consequence. We live both outwardly and inwardly in an uncertain world. But the Law of Kamma tells us that the effect of a goodwill action whether of thought, word or deed, will have wholesome effects. Inwardly, we will be rewarded with wholesome habits and a growing beautiful heart. The opposite, of course, should we behave unwholesomely. This tells us we can change ourselves. The Buddha does not deny the self. He simply says it has no intrinsic reality. It is dependent on inner and outer circumstances. So we can begin to change the self away from one that is unhappy and lacking in self-esteem to one that is happy and high

in self-

esteem. It is from the basis of a beautiful self that spiritual progress, which includes the loss of this

very sense of a separate self, can be realised. For our unwholesomeness is a measure of our delusion.

Wisdom arises as purity of heart grows. This leads to a compassionate engagement with oneself and

the world. All this is the result of understanding and accepting the Law of Conditionality

(idhapaccayatā) and the Laws of Nature (niyama) within which the Law of Kamma is embedded.

Constant Curiosity Carl

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 3 min read

This practical teaching addresses one of the most common questions retreat practitioners face: how to continue meaningful practice in everyday life. Rather than trying to replicate formal meditation instructions while rushing for buses or in business meetings, Bhante Bodhidhamma emphasizes understanding the heart of vipassanā practice—what Thai lay teacher Upasika Kee calls 'unentangled knowing'—the ability to observe whatever arises without controlling, judging, or interfering.

Drawing on the Buddha's First and Second Noble Truths about dukkha (suffering) and taṇhā (craving), the essay explains how our constant dissatisfaction leads us to manipulate our experience. The solution offered is developing a curious, investigative attitude toward our reactions and clinging. Using the example of anger, Bhante demonstrates how to dig progressively deeper—from surface blame to underlying fears of worthlessness and needs for acceptance.

This approach transforms daily life into continuous dharma practice. Whether reacting to advertisements, tension in meetings, or any positive or negative stimulus, practitioners learn to investigate what they're clinging to and what they want to be different. The formal sitting practice then supports this ongoing investigation, making it easier to catch reactive patterns before they manifest as unskillful speech or action. The beauty of this method is its accessibility—it can be practiced anywhere, anytime.

At the end of a retreat, it's common for people to wonder how they can continue the practice once they return to normal life. It's also common for people to observe that the instructions don't easily map to daily life, I mean, how are we supposed to go slow and note everything while running for the bus or negotiating a business deal?! For me, though, this is to mistake the form of the practice for the heart. The instructions while we're sitting are to watch whatever arises within the field of awareness in a way that does not control or manipulate, judge or question and, without any interference whatsoever, simply allow it to arise and pass away. The great Thai lay teacher, Upasika Kee, calls this "unentangled knowing". This is the heart of the practice. When we have a difficult emotion arise, we contact it in the body - feel the feelings in the feelings—and then watch it in this way of unentangled knowing. The Buddha's first two noble truths tell us that there is suffering (dukkha), and that this is caused by craving (taṇhā). We are constantly dissatisfied with our experience and feel a compulsion to fiddle and faff

about with it, trying to make it somehow better. We want things to be other than they are. The instructions, on retreat, are to simply watch this as described above, but the problem is how to do this in normal daily life. By this, I don't mean on the cushion, where the instructions are exactly the same, but when walking down the road, or immediately after a verbal collision with an ornery work colleague. The way to bring the heart of the practice into everyday life is to nurture a curious, investigative attitude that takes interest in how we are suffering, to see what we're clinging to so that we may then observe it from this place of unentangled knowing. When you find yourself struggling with a difficult emotion, ask yourself what you are clinging to; what do you want to be different, to be other than it is? Don't just accept the first answer, dig in. Imagine you find yourself angry with someone. Ask yourself, "What's causing this anger?" Your answer may be "They're an unsavory character!" Nope! Keep digging! Remember, nobody can make us feel anything; we 'choose' how we respond. "Okay, it's because their attack brought about a feeling of injustice." Better, but dig in further! "Okay, this feeling of injustice is because I feel unrecognised and disrespected." Even better, but you can go further! "Feeling unrecognised and disrespected makes me afraid that I am worthless." Excellent, but how does that make you feel? "This feeling of worthlessness, that I resent, has an underlying feeling of needing to be appreciated, liked, accepted and loved." That's brilliant! Get in touch with that feeling, feel it in the body, and then try to just accept it being there, allow its energy to dissipate without any interference whatsoever. Of course, all of this is hard. You may find yourself unable to dig all the way to the bottom. That's fine, just find the answer that feels the most real to you and sit with that. Of course, the sitting with it is hard too. This is where the sitting practice pays dividends. It's why it's called practice! The more we practice, the easier this becomes, and the mindfulness we develop helps us to catch these moments without the angry re-tort in the first place. As you develop this, keep it going at all times; be constantly curious! When you find yourself reacting strangely to an advert, investigate. When you find yourself tightening in a meeting, investigate. Positive or negative; seeing lovers kiss, babies cry, dog poo on the floor, flowers in bloom, strewn rubbish, children happily playing, whatever it is, investigate. Dig in and see if you can come to an equanimous and compassionate accommodation with whatever it is you uncover. The wonderful thing about this is that you don't need to be on the cushion to do it. You can do it at anytime, anywhere.

Could I be a fundamentalist, even a terrorist?

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 3 min read

In this provocative essay, Bhante Bodhidhamma explores how anyone might develop fundamentalist tendencies by examining the Buddha's teaching on the three psychological components that create rigid ideological positions: diṭṭhi (wrong view), māna (conceit), and taṇhā (attachment). Drawing from the Nipāta Sutta's warnings about becoming caught up in debates, he shows how even right views can become dangerous when held with conceit and attachment.

The essay analyzes the three forms of conceit identified by the Buddha - feeling superior, inferior, or equal to others - and how attachment gives these views emotional power, leading to 'righteous anger.' Bhante examines how constrained love and fear of cultural annihilation can drive fundamentalist thinking, citing historical examples from Buddhist countries including Sri Lanka and Myanmar.

Through honest self-reflection, Bhante demonstrates how to recognize fundamentalist tendencies within ourselves by observing our thoughts and emotions when encountering opposing views. He suggests viewing our opinions as partial perspectives rather than absolute truths, requiring us to release conceit and attachment. This practical approach offers a path toward greater tolerance and genuine dialogue, moving beyond the adversarial positions that characterize fundamentalist thinking.

Could I be a fundamentalist
even a terrorist?

The Buddha talks about views and opinions as a 'thicket, a wilderness, a contortion, a vacillation and a fetter'. In an early collection, the Nipata Sutta, he is for ever telling his followers not to get caught up in debates. If you win you suffer from the conceit that, therefore, you must be right. (Gandhi warns that truth can be in a minority of one!) And if

you lose you feel humiliated - even though you may be right.

To take up this position of 'I'm right you're wrong', we need to have three components: ditthi, mano and tanha. Ditthi is the wrong view. However, even when a right view is held

with mano and tanha, then it can still be dangerous.

Mano is conceit. The Buddha points us to three conceits: I am better than; I am worse than;

and, at a more subtle level, I am equal to. The bigheadedness of 'I am better' is the most obvious. 'I am worse' often masquerades as false humility. Humility is being content with

just the way we are. Why compare? Indeed 'all comparison is odious!' With 'I am equal to', we feel more comfortable, but then the group we join is either superior or inferior to

another group. It is a collusive conceit. As a fundamentalist, of course, mine is THE truth -

and I have the support of others who believe likewise.

Tanha is the attachment. Whereas ditthi and mano tend to be heady, it's the attachment that gives them stuffing. The heart clings to it. Here is the spring that torrents righteous anger.

So to be a good Buddhist fundamentalist, I will need to have a wrong view, (it could simply

be that my view is exclusively right), the conceit that I or we are right and everyone who disagrees with me or us is wrong and the attachment that supports my position with 'righteous anger' and often 'cold hatred', righteously justified.

But there needs to be more, I think. Love! A constrained love, a exclusive love, no doubt.

But none the less love. A love of one's religion which one can even interpret to support killing. A devotion to an ideal which would make the world a heaven if I make everyone

everyone believe and follow. If I were to take the next step and do away with the enemy, I

would also need a good dose of courage and believe in the reward- whether it be Nibbana or

a heavenly rebirth.

But there is also a darker side. It would seem that fundamentalists fear annihilation. They

experience the dominant culture of modernism with its commitment to cold rationality, 'pure

science', disregard of past 'holy texts', libertarian morals and a selfish capitalism that supports hedonistic materialism as not only deeply offensive, but an overwhelming enemy.

Buddhism is not immune from such tendencies. There have been many cases of fundamentalist thought and action. To mention only one. In the early years of independence

in Sri Lanka a senior Buddhist monk, Talduwe Somarama Thero, thought with other conspirators that the government was undermining Buddhism and Buddhist culture.

He

shot the Prime Minister, Hon S.W.R.D. Bandaranaike, who later died of his wounds. Even today, in Sri Lanka, there are monks who have established a political party and won seats

in Parliament on the platform nationalism and fundamentalism. And there are still dreadful

things going on in Myanmar for similar reasons.

For myself, I have not found it difficult to catch some ingredients of fundamentalism within

me. I need only catch my thoughts and attendant emotions when I hear, see or read something I disagree with or when I find myself in conversation with someone who holds

opposing views.

The trick, perhaps, is to see one's views and opinions more as perspectives. By doing so, we may be able to accept even opposing views and come to a fuller picture and an easy compromise (a foul word to fundamentalists, whether religious or secular). For personal

views and opinions are, by definition, never the full perspective. And this demands we let go

of conceit and attachment. No bad thing!

I dare say it may mean the end of adversarial politics and the antics of Parliament. Pity?!

Courage, Fortitude and Resilience

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 2 min read

This teaching addresses the universal experience of life-shattering moments—job loss, relationship collapse, illness, or death of loved ones—and how our response determines whether we descend into despair or begin the difficult journey of rehabilitation. Bhante Bodhidhamma explores how such crises require courage to examine our role in events, fortitude to accept what cannot be changed, and resilience to forge new directions in life.

The essay draws a profound parallel between worldly catastrophes and spiritual crises that arise when we confront the delusions of our worldview. Just as the Buddha faced his darkest hour under the Bodhi Tree when Māra generated the Great Doubt, practitioners too must navigate periods of groundlessness and bewilderment with inner conviction and determination.

Using the Buddha's example of rooting himself to his seat and finding support in his perfected virtue of generosity, the teaching emphasizes that spiritual awakening often emerges from our deepest suffering. The essay concludes with the Buddha's fundamental insight: there is an end to all suffering and unsatisfactoriness—Nibbāna—which remains our ultimate destination and source of hope through life's inevitable trials.

It is a common experience that at least once in our lives everything seems to collapse around us. And we are left desperate. It may be failure to get the qualifications we need to do the work we have set our heart on. Or indeed the loss of work we love. It may be the collapse of a relationship we have become so dependent on. Or the death of someone close. It may be an illness that demands a radical change in our lives. Our first reaction is one of shock and disbelief. And as the reality of the situation looms through, the feeling of utter desolation. The future seems bleak. Hopeless. This is a crucial moment. We can either descend into the hell of depression and even suicide or into purgatory where we begin the process of rehabilitation. The suffering involved in purgatory is equal to hell, but for the change of attitude. We have reinstated a reason for living, a meaning for life. This takes courage. For our first task will be to ask why such a catastrophe has happened. It may be for reasons beyond our control; it may be the outer circumstances of the economy; it may be that the other has been unfaithful; it may be the nature of the body to fall ill. In such cases, there can only be acceptance and the turning into oneself to work with the emotional and mental reaction. And to explore potential. However, if it was a case of overconfidence, of being very much part of the

cause for the ending of a relationship, of carelessly putting the body into a dangerous situation, then a deep trawling of our attitudes needs to be undertaken. This takes patience, fortitude and perseverance – resilience. The situation may demand a completely new change of direction in our lives. It may call for continuing as we were, but with a very different attitude. It may mean a radical acceptance of a situation that cannot be altered. Once this decision has been made, no matter how dimly we see the potential outcome, we are on the road to rehabilitation. In many such cases, there is also a spiritual awakening. For in the misery, there also arises the question as to the purpose of life. Such occasions may also happen in our spiritual lives. In fact, I would say it has to happen to some degree or other. The world view we hold is, according to the Buddha, a delusion. When we come face to face with that delusion, it is bound to cause a disruption. And that dis-location can be as painful as any mundane one. There may be the sense of groundlessness and bewilderment, yet the inner conviction, no matter how dim, supported by the writings, experience and example of others, gives us the courage to commit and the determination to persist. In the Buddha's own darkest hour when Mara generated in him the Great Doubt – Who am I after all to seek the end of suffering? He had to ground himself. And the Earth Goddess rose to remind him that that his task was not just for his own benefit but for the benefit of all. And that he had perfected the virtue of generosity and so had the virtuous power to complete the task. Rooted to his seat beneath the Bodhi Tree, after six hours, came the insight into the end of all suffering, the direct experience of Nibbana. There is an end to suffering, to all unsatisfactoriness. It is our destination. Our only real destination.

Cultivating Mettā for Future Generations

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 4 min read

This essay explores how to cultivate mettā (goodwill) for future generations in the context of climate crisis, drawing on the Metta Sutta's call to extend care to 'those born and to be born.' Noirin Sheahan addresses the challenge of directing loving-kindness toward beings we cannot clearly imagine, using a teaching from the Saṃyutta Nikāya where the Buddha suggests that sometimes it's better to identify with the body rather than get lost in mental formations. When visualization of future generations proved overwhelming, she employed this embodied approach as a refuge, allowing natural gratitude for physical existence to arise. This led to connecting with past generations through memory of grandparents, which then enabled mettā to flow forward to future beings. The practice demonstrates how grounding awareness in bodily experience can serve as a stable foundation when meditation becomes difficult, offering a practical method for sustaining compassionate action toward environmental challenges without burning out. The approach honors both the temporary nature of identification with form while using it skillfully as a stepping stone toward broader loving-kindness practice.

Noirin Sheahan Following from last month's tip, I want to explore additional Dhamma supports for last of the six maximssuggested as ethical preparation for climate catastrophe. The final maxim challenges to think beyond our close circle and act for the future generation of all species. There are many ways we could do this - caring for the soil, for ecosystems, for political structures promoting long-term social well-being over short term gain. But unless we can do this with good will, we risk burning out, overwhelmed by the immensity of the task, demoralised by the cultural habits that fuel climate change and blind us to the coming catastrophe. To sustain our efforts we need to develop a metta (goodwill) practice which can encompass future generations. Last month I described how the teaching: "The whole world can be found in this fathom long body" allowed me to use news and documentary images of climate related suffering to become an embodied aspect of 'my world' – the world of present experience – for the purpose of opening the heart to those beyond my immediate circle. But when I tried applying this to developing metta for future generations, it didn't work as I couldn't imagine who or what I was directing metta towards. Because the Metta Sutta asks us to extend goodwill and care to 'those born and to be born', I guessed the Buddha would have provided some help with this aspect of metta practice and started looking for anything relevant. The teaching I found particularly helpful is from the Saṃyutta Nikāya: "It

would be better, bhikkhus, for the uninstructed worldling to take this body composed of the four great elements as self rather than the mind. For what reason? Because this body may last for ten, twenty, thirty, or forty years... But that which is called mind, intellect, or consciousness arises as one thing and ceases as another, both by day and by night."In other teachings the Buddha clarifies that he does not want us to identify with the body, because it cannot provide a reliable basis for happiness. At any moment the body may get injured or fall ill; if we live long enough it will grow frail and eventually will die. Beautiful sights and sounds, thrilling or tender touches – all these give temporary pleasure and we can use such pleasure to lift the heart: relaxing in a bath, having a massage, gazing at the sunset, sipping tea. But if we keep chasing one sense pleasure after another we'll exhaust ourselves. None of them can ever satisfy our natural desire for lasting happiness. In this teaching however, the Buddha tells us it would be better to identify with the body rather than the mind, because the body is a more trustworthy source of stability. He says this applies to 'an uninstructed worldling', someone who doesn't know the Dhamma. This is true of all of us at times – when we're on autopilot or caught in an emotional storm or getting fixated on an idea or somehow stuck in meditation. Our Dhamma knowledge has temporarily deserted us, we need to relearn it in this presenting moment. What I really like about this teaching is that it gives us permission to make a mistake. For those of us who tend towards perfectionism, this is gold dust. We know it's a mistake to identify with the body, but we do it anyway, assured that it's the lesser mistake than following our current line of thought. Relaxing into the body, enjoying the temporary illusion of identity, some wiser thoughts start to appear in the mind. I used this approach to develop metta for future generations. I pictured a cousin's grandchild, tried to imagine him getting older, with his own children and grandchildren and the kind of world they might be living in. But trying to hold this in imagination along with goodwill was a step too far. The images kept collapsing and I began to feel resentful at being asked too much. I took the Buddha's advice and let myself sink into identity with the body. It was a great relief to let go of the imaginative effort and lots of joy arose at simply being able to sit and breathe, to think of this as 'my body, my breath'. Recognizing the relative stability of the body brought forth gratitude for the enduring nature of physical form in general, the house I was in, the earth itself, nature, the bodies of others. Gratitude that my own body had already lasted several decades triggered memories of my grandparents. It occurred to me that although I wasn't able to imagine future generations, I could remember past ones, which seemed like a good way to ease back into the metta exercise. I recruited my grandparents in the flow of goodwill, imagining them wishing me and all their grandchildren well. It then became easy and natural for this metta to flow onwards to future generations. At intervals thoughts and images suggesting future climate catastrophe brought the metta stream to a stop. Gripped by horror I again accepted the Buddha's invitation to relax, let mental

images fade, identify with the physical body, take the comfort it offered from being at this moment, safe, comfortable, well. This reminded me of the physicality of future generations – the bodies of people and animals that would be living then, the ground around them, the buildings or shelters they would inhabit. I sensed in all these the potential for strength and care and the basic blessing of survival. Metta flowed again, strengthened in fact, for having worked through the challenge. The practice of identifying with the body whenever I feel stuck in meditation or lost in daily life has since proved a refuge on many occasions. I hope it will also prove a refuge for future generations facing challenges we are spared and that the intricate web of physical life on earth can continue to link beings with the Dhamma and hence with liberation.

Dealing with the Stories that Make Us Suffer

Carl Fooks · 3 min read

This practical teaching addresses one of the most common sources of everyday suffering: the stories our minds create when people disappoint, betray, or upset us. Carl Fooks explores how our mental narratives about events—whether accurate or distorted—often cause more pain than the events themselves. The essay bridges formal meditation practice with daily life application, showing how the same investigative awareness we use on the cushion can be applied to emotional turmoil off the cushion.

The teaching offers two complementary approaches: first, using mindful investigation to discover what is actually disturbing us beneath the surface stories, then applying gentle noting practice to the wounded feelings that arise. Second, when pain is too intense for direct investigation, the essay suggests undermining our certainty in our interpretations by recognizing that multiple explanations could be true. This uncertainty becomes a doorway to freedom from clinging to particular views.

Rooted in the fundamental insight that attachment to views leads to dukkha while letting go brings release, this guidance helps practitioners develop the habitual wisdom of questioning all mental stories. The teaching emphasizes how this practice gradually liberates us from our inner critic and moves us toward greater freedom in both formal practice and daily relationships.

A common question I get goes something along these lines: “A friend has done something that has upset me. I feel betrayed. I thought I could trust them. I’m suffering. How can I stop?” The person varies, what happens varies, the feeling varies, but it all boils down to the same archetypical cause: something happens that we want to be different. Sue got a pay rise but I didn’t! Jim cheated on me! Billy stole from me! Mary doesn’t like me. Tara has asked me not to make a cake for the party; I’m convinced nobody likes my cakes! Etc. When things like this happen, a big part of our suffering comes from the stories we tell ourselves about these events. The stories might be accurate and justified, but often they’re distorted and hypercritical, and we believe them as if they are true. We think we’re useless, unloveable, gullible, unlikeable, talentless chumps! The instructions for practice boil down to watching whatever arises within the field of awareness in a way that does not control, manipulate, judge, question, or interfere in any way whatsoever. How does this help in daily life, though? When something like this assails us, how do we apply the practice? One thing we can do is use mindfulness to delve into

what's happening to discover what's really disturbing us. On the cushion, we investigate our experience: what is this? The same is true off the cushion. We delve into the experience: what am I actually experiencing here? What's troubling me? On the cushion, we do this non-discursively, we simply watch and wait for it to show us what it has to tell us, but off the cushion it often first needs a bit more interactive analysis. We delve deeper and deeper asking what's the matter, what's bothering me, what am I struggling with? Get an answer, test it, and ask again. Eventually we find something fundamental, possibly an unloved, unappreciated, betrayed little mini-me, sitting wounded in the corner of our minds, wailing at the terrible things "that nasty person has done to me". It is there that we apply the practice. We simply watch that wounded feeling, allowing it to be there without any interference whatsoever, noting gently: "wounded wounded". I wrote about this approach in last October's Newsbyte if you would like to read more. Sometimes though an alternative approach is needed. Perhaps the pain is too much and we have to first get ourselves into a better place before we can investigate. When something like this happens to me, I undermine the certainty I feel in what I believe has happened. If somebody's said something to me that makes me feel terrible, I think of how I "know" that it's True, and then think of alternatives that could be true instead. I come up with two or three alternatives that are genuine possibilities, and I convince myself that I can never know which one of the different possibilities are actually true. If I asked the "perpetrator", they may tell me a lie so as not to offend me. Or they may tell me the truth. Unless I could actually get inside their mind, I have no way of telling. Even lie-detector tests are fallible. So, I just can't know. Right there, in that realisation, is freedom. The moment you see that any of them could be true, the attachment to one of them simply does not make any sense, and the mind is much less inclined to cling to it. Seeing this, we should soak ourselves in the realisation that clinging to an idea, a view, leads to suffering, while letting go of it leads to release and relief. When this becomes a habitual pattern of the mind, it starts doing it with everything. Is my view of anything more right or wrong than anyone else's? No! Of course not! There are just views. Seeing this, we unpick our belief in the stories the mind tells us, slowly liberating ourselves from our inner-critic, and inching our way towards freedom.

Deconstruction: The Five Khandhas and Dependent Origination

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 1h12

In this teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma explores the Buddha's systematic deconstruction of human experience to identify where suffering arises. He begins by examining the five khandhas (aggregates): rūpa (body/form), vedanā (feeling), saññā (perception), saṅkhāra (volitional formations), and viññāṇa (consciousness). Through careful analysis, he shows how these heaps of experience are impermanent, insubstantial, and not-self.

The talk then moves to the six sense bases and how consciousness arises at tremendous speed, creating the illusion of continuity. Bhante emphasizes that true freedom lies in recognizing the sankharic processes - our habitual reactions - as the point where we still have choice.

The second half explores paṭicca samuppāda (dependent origination), the Buddha's revolutionary insight into how suffering is created moment by moment. Starting from avijjā (ignorance/not-knowing), he traces the twelve links that lead to dukkha, highlighting that the critical point of escape lies between vedanā (feeling) and taṇhā (craving). Through mindful awareness, practitioners can break this chain and gradually empty the saṅkhāras that perpetuate the illusion of selfhood.

This teaching offers both newcomers and experienced practitioners a clear framework for understanding how liberation occurs through the systematic observation and objectification of all inner experiences.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sambha Sambhu Dasa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sambha Sambhu Dasa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sambha Sambhu Dasa

Homage to the fully self-enlightened one.

I've observed that laziness or sloth and torpor is a state closely related to one's intentions. The road to hell is paved with good intentions. There's a distinction between sloth and torpor and laziness to be made. It's a vocabulary distinction. Sloth and torpor are products of past laziness. Laziness as I see it is where you make a decision not to put energy into something, being lazy. That could come from just not caring or just because you're fed up or whatever, but laziness is more to do with an attitude. Rather than when we're talking about defilement, sloth and torpor, they're referring to the con-

sequences of laziness. So that heaviness in the head and the heaviness in the body and all that. So when it comes to laziness it's definitely to do with your intentions. Don't be lazy.

Could you please say a little about developing equanimity? I find I can't let go and not react to things. Equanimity comes with an attitude from a position of not knowing, not wanting to engage. So when something comes up and you find yourself unable not to be drawn into it, try and sit back within yourself to see that resistance or the desire to engage. It's one of the two - it's either a desire to indulge or a desire to push away. Just try to get in contact with that. As soon as that becomes an object to you, it's more like an energy more like an energy than an emotion or anything.

As long as you can keep that there, you must have moved back into an equanimous position. It arises naturally. You don't have to worry too much about equanimity as such. What you have to be concerned about is being able to make that compulsive wanting, that compulsive indulgence, or compulsive rejection, the object. You've got to come back on yourself.

A couple of times I've said the body becomes extremely heavy while the mind remains completely wide and awake. Can you say something about this? These conditions just arise, that's it. So sometimes the body, that heaviness is in the body, which means that the mental state is in the body. And yet you're bright and awake. Now, you may find that even in the head, when you feel really dull, and it's like porridge in there, and you can feel yourself constantly falling into that sleepiness, and you don't feel you're awake within it. If you really make the effort to keep moving around and feeling it and feeling it and experiencing it, you'd be surprised. You'd wake up like a light bulb in the midst of that fog. But it does take that effort. Very good.

So, this evening I just wanted to talk about the way the Buddha deconstructs our experience. So I'm especially aware of people who are new to Buddhism, so I'll try and keep it fairly straightforward. The first thing is he talks about - the first thing he gives us cross-sections, so you take a moment and split the human being into various parts, and then he does that in two ways, and he does it in terms of a process. The process we call dependent origination, and the cross-sections are the *khandhas*, the aggregates, and the six consciousnesses. So these are three that we can look at.

When it comes to the *khandas*, which means a heap or an aggregate, or a mountain - see, a mountain is just a collection of stuff. So if you can imagine, there are these five collections. The first one is to do with the body. Now, at a gross level, it's the physical body that we've got. But at the more subtle level, it's how the mind contacts the body.

And when the mind contacts the body, if you go right down into a feeling, you'll find some combination of these four great elements. So that's your earth element, fire, water, and air.

The earth element is the weight, the heaviness of it, or the lightness. The fire element is the temperature you feel. Cool all the way to boiling hot. The water element is the elasticity that you feel. Sometimes when you're watching the breath, perhaps you can feel an elasticity in it, a cohesion. So that's the water element. And the air element, of course, is movement. And when you go into something like a pain in the knee, for instance, when you go in there, you may begin to see that actually what you're experiencing are movements, little movements, fire elements, some heat. When you change your posture and you keep your attention in the knee, you might just find that stretching, that elasticity.

So any combination of these brings you a feeling. And it's understood that whatever combination it is, we then perceive it as pleasant and unpleasant. We give it a name. It gets a bit more subtle with the eyes, which would be seen as more of the fire element. The ear, of course, as you know, is just pressure. It's just the earth element. A movement. When it comes to taste, of course, it gets even more subtle in terms of trying to describe it with these four elements, but you can obviously feel the toughness of the food, the heat of it, the coldness of it, and so on.

So that's the body element, the body heap. And all that is a given. You're entirely dependent upon your body for what comes in through the senses. There's virtually no control over that process. I mean, you can guard yourself, you needn't put yourself too close to the fire, but the fact is you can't stop the body feeling heat as you approach the fire. It's just a given. That's not under our control. Now that's to be contemplated.

So think about your body. Do you know now what your liver's doing? Can you feel red corpuscles being made in the marrow of your bones? Do you guide them through your bones into the bloodstream? Have you any idea that as you grow older, the grizzle on the end of your nose is growing? I doubt you might. There's a whole load of stuff. When you look at your body, you presume that you are the body, that this is you. But actually when you investigate your relationship to the body, you find you know nothing. And you can't do anything about it. Not after a certain age, anyway. I'd have loved to have been tall, lots of hair. You're just given it, you may as well be happy.

So that relationship is to be - and what it does, of course, if you suddenly realize that, there is this consciousness, there's this awareness, and it's an alien within this body. Weird. So that contemplation around the body is well worth it. And of course, that takes

you into the sickness of the body, how the body falls sick, whether you like it or not. And eventually it's death. Eventually it's collapse. So all that contemplation is all around the heap that we call the body, *rupa*.

The next is to do with feeling. So from the body we get these feelings. And feeling is a point where we determine something to be pleasant, unpleasant or neutral. And there are two types of feelings that we've experienced. The first one is coming from the body. So obviously, pain in the knees. And the other one is coming from our mind, the heart. In Buddhism, the body and mind are not the same. They suffer from the same qualities. They are impermanent. They're insubstantial. You can pull it all apart. They're just energy forms. But they're two different energies. And although it doesn't fit in with our modern materialist science, at death they separate. And whatever is separated out as the mental part, that is the bit that goes on to be reborn into the next moment, whatever it is. Luckily you don't have to believe this to become fully liberated. So don't make it a clause.

So, feeling, when we experience feeling, that also is a given. You know power over changing a feeling as it arises. You can make yourself feel things, you can stick a pin in your hand if you like doing things like that. But it's not as though you can stop feelings and sensations arising. That's also a given. And it creates a heap, you can say, a heap of all sorts of different types of feelings and sensations. Some coming from the body, some coming from the heart.

When I say heart-mind, unfortunately in English we've lost this word which connects them. The old word was soul. The old split, the old way that we looked at human beings was soul. Body, soul and spirit. But now soul has become spirit. And since our wonderful enlightenment. And we moved into the mind. And we lost in a sense contact with the heart. We now have to say heart mind. But when you go to the east. And often when they talk to you. And they say what do they think. They point actually to here. They don't point up here. Whereas for us the heart is something else. But I am here. I think, therefore I am. That's a bit of a problem for us.

So we've lost that, I mean it's good to have lost that connection in a sense because it allowed us to make all our discoveries and technologies all come from that objectivity. But unfortunately we've lost contact with the fact that the heart and mind are actually one and the same thing. The one is firing off the other all the time. So the feelings that we experience are determined by the body itself, over which we have no control. The body will give us these feelings when we do these sorts of things. And the heart will give us these feelings when we act in a certain way.

The next one is all to do with perception. Now, perception is this amazing ability of the mind to make photocopies. And what we do is we see something, like an apple for the first time, and it registers. It registers as a perception. And then, as we eat more and more apples, our definition of apples grows. So some are red, some are green, some are soft, some are hard, some are sweet, some are not so sweet, etc. So that by the end we end up with a concrete definition, concept of an apple. And all these belong to our memory. And these perceptions, of course, become very fine in terms of our freedom and democracy and all that. All these are perceptions which have grown into concepts, our concepts. And all that is another heap, another collection of bits which are all to be separated. They don't all form one composite. One thought comes. It disappears. Another thought comes. It disappears. That's another heap. And they're not the same as feelings. And they're not the same as the body. These are three quite distinct heaps.

Now the fourth one is *Sankhara*. Which translates as volitional conditioning. That would be the old regular way of translating it. Other people have tried various things like concoctions and stuff like that. But I think we get close to what we mean by that when we talk about habits. Now this is where - the Buddha's trying to separate out for us where the problem lies. Remember he's only - his only concern is to teach suffering and the end of suffering. That's it. When he's asked what does he teach? Does he teach about God? Does he teach about the universe? He says, no, he says, I only teach about suffering and the end of suffering. Unsatisfactoriness and the end of unsatisfactoriness.

So, the reason why we are deconstructing ourselves is not just for the fun of it, it's to find out where the problem lies. The problem lies right here in *Sankhara*. *Sankhara* means volitional conditioning. So, it's the volitional bit which is the important bit. It's the bit where we're making decisions based upon wrong understandings that are causing *Sankhara's* habits. Causing certain habits which include both the emotional feelings and the thought feelings. And it creates a habit. A way of expressing ourselves. And some habits that we have are beautiful and some are not so beautiful.

But the important thing about this particular heap that's in us is that it is being created by our will. This is what we can take control of. When we say we can take control of it, the bit that's already been created, you can't do anything about. That's what we're suffering when we sit here. All the sadness and the anger and occasionally a bit of joy. So all that stuff that's come up, that's a consequence of past decision making and all we can do with that is bear with it and make sure we don't indulge it because every time we indulge it we empower it again and that's the process of will.

So when you're doing your standing meditation for instance and you're standing still and you're saying to yourself intending to walk intending to walk - stay there for a while with that intending which is another way of saying desiring. So intending to just feel the energy there. Feel the energy and how the body wants to move. And then suddenly there's a decision and the foot moves. What is it that's brought something out of potential into an actual? That's the will. And you can't separate the will from the action. So the Buddha says, what I call *kamma*, an act, is the will. It's a bit like, as far as I know, and I stand to be corrected of course, it's when you throw a stone into the air, you can't separate the force from the stone. And what is it anyway? You can't separate force from the object that is moving. Interesting. Am I right? Is there a scientist amongst us? If I've made it up, forgive me. I read it somewhere years ago. The thing is in science it changes so much you don't know where you're at.

So you've got that *sankhara*, that heap, that aggregate. The last one is consciousness and consciousness is the ability of the mind to hold an image for us. That's what consciousness is, like a screen and it holds the image and that image is multi-dimensional and that image holds feelings, it holds everything and it holds it long enough for it to be registered. If it's not registered, we hardly know it, we hardly see it, we're hardly aware of it. But when it registers, it's there for the moment, and then it passes away. And consciousness is arising at tremendous speed, and it's giving us the impression of continuity.

So, for instance, when we are watching, say, a film or something, we can hear the conversation, we can see what's going on. We're drinking coffee and tea, or popcorn, or whatever it is, and we can taste it. All that seems to us to be happening at the same time. But in Buddhist psychology, what's happening is, moment after moment, consciousnesses are arising at some tremendous speed, and it gives us an experience of continuity and the closest we can as a good image for that is the old film where it was 26 frames or something or 25 frames a minute and it gave us the impression of continuity. And as soon as it slowed down you realise actually it was just these moments of flashing images on a screen and that's how consciousness works.

Now, when you pull yourself out into the position of the observer, all that is becoming an object. Before we came to meditation, before we came to this, we would have just presumed ourselves to be this human being. You wouldn't have made an object of yourself. You'd have been aware that, for instance, you've got a pain in the knee or a pain in the head, but there wouldn't have been that separation of the knowing from what's being known. And there would have been a real attachment to your body in terms of its illness and whatnot.

Now, in the meditation, what we're doing is, we are pulling something out of these five aggregates. And we're making these five aggregates objects to observe. That which is pulling out is your intuitive awareness. Now that doesn't mean to say that once we've begun to practice this and see this that suddenly we become totally equanimous and content and you can stab me in the back and I'll be fine. No it's not. But at least there is within us this inkling of a knowledge that there is something which doesn't belong to the five *khandhas*. That is this human being. So that's one way that the Buddha deconstructs our experience.

I'm going to connect all this to Dependent Origination. Oh heavens, it's ten past seven. I've only just started. I might have to... I'll finish with this because I hate going on and on. And then tomorrow I'll sort of go into dependent origination. Yes, that's what I'll do.

The next way that he deconstructs our experience is looking at our sense bases. And the sense bases in Buddhism are six. The five that we obviously know, and the sixth is the mind.

In the psychology of Buddhism, when you hear something, actually what is being received at the sense door is pressure. There is no sound, right? There's no sound in the universe, okay? And there's no light in the universe, right? You have to have these senses to hear something. And you have to have these senses to see something.

So when the air waves begin to touch upon the eardrum, they are little messages, little stimulus going in. And that's all the ear actually does. From then on, it's taken into the mind, and there's a process of recognition. So, bell. Yeah, bell. Just the sound of a bell. Then when the process of the bell is completed, there's the understanding of what a bell means. Right? Then the bell is put into a time slot where you understand that it's an awakening bell. And then, only then, at the end of that process, does the mind come in and say, I've got to get up. Right?

That whole process is one after the other. And believe it or not, you can actually experience that. That can be experienced, but you've got to... you've got to really get down to your meditation today. You've got to be really on the ball. But that's how deep you can go. You can actually see these momentary consciousnesses and how the mind actually creates everything from this original, very simple stimulus.

Now it's the same with seeing. I'm sure you've seen these diagrams which show you that when we look at a picture, the eye is darting all over the place. It's never still. It's quite amazing to see how the eye is just moving. But we don't experience that. What we

experience is the picture. And of course we can focus on different parts of the picture. And we still are not aware of the fact that even then the eye is moving at tremendous speeds all over it, picking up little pixels.

And even that can be seen. Even that, you can actually be looking at something and it all frazzles up into a sort of... you know these pointillist paintings? You know these where they paint with little dots? Shimmering like that in front of you. And then it congeals into a picture. And that means that this mind, the actual perceiving mind, is right up against the sense door.

Now, the purpose that the Buddha again points this out is that each sense door is individual and discrete. You simply cannot smell through your eyes. And therefore, the way that we experience the world is in these discrete moments: seeing, hearing, smelling, touching. And somehow the mind, at a deeper level of its processing, can put it all together into an experiencing.

Here we go. Say your prayers. It's just pressure. Just pressure. Yes. It's just pressure waves.

So that's a specific way that the Buddha also deconstructs our experience. So here we have two ways of deconstructing. And what's the purpose of it? It's to take away the sense of substance. It's to take away the sense of me. Me.

And again, in that process of observing what's coming in, of actually being at the process of hearing. So when you're outside, just to stand there with that spacious awareness, putting your attention entirely upon one of the ears. You see? And just hearing, hearing. And just keep it there, steady. When you're looking, just keep your eyes steady on the flower and just watch the perceptual process. Watch the eye doing.

So you're always, as it were, standing one step behind yourself to see process. Nothing remains. Remember that. Everything's in a process. Everything's changing. And it's to be able to stand still enough to be able to see that. And in our meditation, we're trying to constantly access that point of stillness within us. The observation post, the observer, the knower. See, so that constant effort to come off the thinking mind and to bring ourselves back to the direct experience at the sense bases of this particular moment. Always feeling, always in the body. Ground yourself in the body.

And in this way, the sharpness, the discriminative faculty of this intuitive awareness becomes finer and finer. So, in a sense, if you really want to deepen your practice, you've got to make that effort of continuity. So you can't be... you have to give up cups of

tea for a start. You've got to make the effort to, from here to the walking place, right? There's your objective. Your objective is the walking place. You bring yourself back here and every footstep is known. Every footstep is felt.

And then you stop and you do your walking meditation, right? And you might start with a bit of an exercise, just going up and down quite rapidly to get the energy up and just to relax. And then slower and slower and slower, you see? Very, very slow, watching every movement, you see? And then when the bell goes, to come in at a speed where you don't lose that collectedness.

Now there's the true meditator. This afternoon I walked out there and there were two meditators sunbathing. I thought, well that's the pits. They're obviously not suffering enough. Because if you're suffering enough, you want to get rid of it.

So I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. I will, of course, carry on deconstructing tomorrow. And by your fierce and determined effort, I'm sure you will make plenty of insights that will bring you to your liberation sooner rather than later. So if you'd like to take a break.

I have to apologise. Yesterday, when I looked at the clock, it was ten past seven. And I should have gone on, it was nearly quarter past, and I should have gone on until half past. But I was working on the time that we keep at Sati Panya, where everything's half an hour early, and where we rise at 3:30, which is the proper time. So, I've got... I got confused, so maybe I'll just extend a little bit if I don't finish what I need to say.

So we were talking about this whole process of deconstructing. Remember that even in objects, you take a car. When you're driving, for those of you who drive, there are times when you and the car are one. You don't experience yourself as separate from the car because you're totally involved or absorbed into the action of driving. Especially when there's a tricky corner or somebody's doing something nasty to you. And then you wake up and there you are in the car. And you still think you have control over the car. And then suddenly it stops. And then you realise that actually your control is superficial. You can move it this way and that way. You can back it up and back it into somebody. But you can't actually do anything about the inner workings of the car.

So that's the situation that we find ourselves within this body. We can move our arms about and wave them and all that. You can't make your arm grow any longer. You can't do much with the body as it is. And when we look into the workings of a car, especially a modern car, it's quite mystifying, at least to me. I once thought of myself as a bit of a mechanic because I pulled engines apart. And about four or five years ago, a friend of

mine stopped. The car just stopped. And I was with him. And we opened the bonnet. And I said, oh, it sounds to me like it's the distributor. And I pointed to the distributor; you see. I said, you know, we'd better call the RAC.

So the RAC came over, and he looked in, and it was just a fan belt. And mysteriously, the distributor had moved to the other side of the engine. So I don't quite know how that happened. Anyway, so you see how delusional he is.

So it's that business of recognising that we're in this very strange situation of being in the body, but not of the body. And what is it that's in the body that's not of the body?

So through the process of deconstruction, the Buddha's trying to make us investigate the way it really is, not the way we presume it to be, through our delusion. The delusion is, I am this person, I am this body. Now, as I think I've mentioned before, you know how deluded you are about your body when the doctor tells you you've got six weeks to live. Then there's freak out. And that level of paranoia and fear around death is the measure of our identification with the body. See?

So, in these five aggregates, these five heaps, he's trying to separate out, and he's telling us, in a sense, what's the given. The body's the given. Perceptions are given. It's part of that whole psychological process. Feelings are given. But in the *saṅkhāra*, these conditions, here we have a measure of control.

Saṅkhāra are conditions, and they are conditioning. So when you have, shall we say, the habit of getting really excited about something, as soon as that something that you get excited about comes up, the excitement will come, because that's how you've trained yourself. You've trained yourself to be excited. But in the coming up of the excitement, the excitement itself is developing itself.

So all these habits that we have, whether it's the fear of things, anxiety, depression, joy, falling in love, all that is something that we've conditioned ourselves and when it becomes active, it is conditioning. So conditions are not stable. And our understanding is to catch where the intentionality is because it's at that point we still have a choice. We can either indulge it or let it go. Or, in some cases of course, develop it. If it's something beautiful, then we should develop it.

So he points to the *saṅkhāra* as the place where we have to really look as to where suffering arises. Pain arises in the body. Pain arises from the *saṅkhāra* in the body. That's where you get emotional disturbances within us. That's a given. But what do we mean by suffering? Suffering is our relationship to what's happening. And that's all within the *saṅkhāra*.

When these *saṅkhāra* go into the memory, *saññā*, that's when they produce this lovely word, *papañca*, proliferation. The Buddha points out when these *saṅkhāra* arise, they go into your memory and they start producing a story. And it's through the story that they develop themselves. That's why in *vipassanā* we're constantly coming off the mind. Coming back into the body.

And the final one of course is this consciousness. So there's your five *khandhas*. And then we talked about the five sense bases. And how each consciousness is confined to a sense base. In Buddhist understanding, an eye consciousness arises. And that's all. And then a hearing consciousness arises. And that's all.

So although we... because of the speed of these consciousnesses, we get the sense of it all being one. And all being continuous. That's the delusion. So in our practice, we're constantly moving down deeper and deeper. What we mean by deeper here is less and less time slot.

How long is a moment in time? How long do you experience a moment? Interesting question, no? I mean, how long is it? Is it half a second? Is it a second? How long is a moment, you see?

And what we're doing is, we are bringing our attention slowly and slowly. See, there's a noting and the attention. The noting of the attention. And then we're locked into the moment. The noting stops. That's if you develop that concentration well enough. And then in that moment, it's as though time collapses into that actual present moment. And that's when you realise that actually these moments are infinitesimally small.

Even there, even there, will have some measure because you're not actually seeing the arising and passing away of individual consciousnesses, see. So that's our practice is to... the Theravāda approach you might say is not so much the spaciousness but the minuscule, you know. What is it? The universe in a grain of sand. It's actually going down to the minuscule moment. And that's where we're constantly driving the attention. Okay?

Now, those two ways of looking at this deconstruction process are cross-sections. You can take any moment in a human being's life, draw a line, and you'll find the five heaps, the five aggregates, and the five consciousnesses. One or the other, I mean.

Now, when he tries to deconstruct the timeline of how we create suffering, that's what he's interested in, remember, just suffering, we have Dependent Origination. And this seems to have been completely new to the age. There's nothing like it, seemingly, before the Buddha. This is what the academics tell you. So it's a real deep insight into how we create the world that we're living in and where the mistakes come.

Now, if you look at that chanting sheet, you'll be able to follow me because I'm just going to go through the Dependent Origination. So that's in the middle of the *pūjā*, middle of the *pūjā* sheet, the morning *pūjā* sheet, that's what you want. And it's in the middle of it. And you'll notice that it starts off with the Buddha's victory verse.

Victory verse, you see, he says, let me get my goggles on. Can't wait for summer when I get my other operation. I'll be able to see anything.

Now then, he says, "Seeking but not finding the house builder. Okay, so this house builder is this I, this self. I have travelled through the round of countless births. How painful is birth over and over again. Oh house builder, I have now caught you. I shall not build a house again. Your rafters have been broken. Your ridge pole demolished."

Okay. So there he's talking about this self, this construct of a person. And what does he come up with? What does he attain through that? He attains a consciousness which is unconditioned. We should go into that a bit later. And all craving, all the defilements have gone. So that's the process that we're into now. We're into this process of finding out who the house builder is, what the house builder is, getting rid of it, destroying the house, and ending up perfectly happy and wonderful. It's worth it, isn't it? All this suffering.

So it begins with this word *avidyā* and it's often translated as ignorance. But it's not a culpable ignorance. We've just landed into a place of not knowing. So if you think of a baby, you see, when we're born, there we are, we scream a little bundle of cells. What do we know?

So go back to that moment of being born, you see. We don't know anything. From then on, the information starts coming in, and we start building up the world.

As you know, well, some of you might know, the wonderful worker Margaret Mahler, who was a student of Freud, studied children up to the age of three. And later studies, of course, confirmed her findings. For up to the age of four months, all we experience is a bath of sensations. There's no depth to it. There's no 3D. That's why you see children reaching out for things. They're actually creating a 3D world.

And then from four months onwards, it seems, the first object, something looms out of this... this... I mean, there's no concept of me, this me that I'm experiencing, and it's usually your carer, your mother, usually. And slowly, that outer world gets pushed out. And it's not until the age of three that you're actually clear that I am me and everything else is not me. I'm a boy, I'm a girl. You know, that's the moment, round about three. That's how long it takes to separate the outside world.

Now, all we're doing is the same inwardly. We're just pushing the inner world out to make it an object. Now, the ignorance is to think that we are this inner world with its emotions, thoughts, etc., etc.

Now, that *avidyā*, be careful, it's not a culpable ignorance, right? We're not guilty, right? Which is a relief, I think, for all of us. We're not existentially guilty, right? We never did nothing wrong before becoming ignorant. We just didn't know. I did find a word which means not knowing. The word is nescience, but nobody knows it, so I don't... I only point out that there is a word for not knowing.

So this *avijjā paccayā saṅkhārā, saṅkhārā paccayā* — so all he's saying is: be out of this, out of this position of not knowing, we've created these conditions. These habits, right? That's all he's saying.

And then, *saṅkhārā paccayā viññāṇaṃ*. Now, it's out of the body-mind complex — remember — there arises this ability to hold things on a screen. Now, if there was nothing there to be held on a screen, there'd be no screen. So, for instance, when in deep sleep, there's no obvious consciousness because there's nothing coming up, awakening, as it were, on that screen. But it's because of these *saṅkhāra* that the screen is, shall we say, brightened up. And this screen is consciousness.

And consciousness — remember — English words don't really catch it because these days academics and scientists are studying consciousness. I mean, that's the end of clarity for about a hundred years. So it's basically... in Buddhist understanding, if you think of consciousness like a three-dimensional hologram which you can see, and in it there are feelings, images, thoughts, the whole damn thing is there, can be held within that consciousness.

So it's not to be confused with *sati*. See, this is the important thing. That there is something which can see what's on the screen of consciousness. And that's what you're experiencing every time you see a pain in the knee and you say, "There's a pain." The pain must be held somewhere for us to be able to acknowledge it, to see it. And there's something that acknowledges it. See, that's separation.

So there you've got your *avijjā paccayā saṅkhārā*. So dependent on these *saṅkhārā*, this consciousness arises. And depending on consciousness, the body and mind. So here he's, as it were, taken consciousness out of those five aggregates that we talked about. So *nāma-rūpa* — body-mind — he's taken it out and he's pointed out that these two things are like — in those days — two sheaves of wheat leaning against each other. You can't have consciousness — you can't have that ability of consciousness — without the body-mind complex, and without consciousness you wouldn't know that there was a body-mind complex.

So the two come together. But what he's saying here is that these are two different processes. That's the point. Constantly deconstructing. Constantly deconstructing.

Now when it comes to the — where are we now? So now we've been through the five heaps, which is the consciousness and the body-mind. The next step is to see that actually the way we contact the world is through the six senses. And that's your next thing. Dependent on this body-mind complex, the six sense bases arise. So that's the five that we obviously know. And the other one is where the brain and mind contact to create the inner percepts and then eventually concepts. See? So that's the point where the ability to contact the world out there and the world in here arises at the six sense bases.

So when an image comes, it's on the sixth sense base. When an emotion comes in the mind, it's on the sixth sense base. And then dependent on the *saḷāyatana*, we have this *phassa*, we have this contact.

Now, contact is the moment where we experience something. What has to be there? There has to be a sense base. There has to be some sense base. Either the five or the mind. Emotions, thoughts, okay? There has to be an object which is being sensed. And there has to be this consciousness. That's the moment of contact.

Now, when I describe to you what to do with pain in the knee, and your first noting is "pain, pain," and all that, and "aversion, aversion," and then you get that equanimity with it. I say go into the pain. And that's when you go beyond the concept of pain. Into where the mind and the body meet. And that's when you're noting changes to things like heat. Pressure. Stinging. All that — which is the four great elements that we talked about. The fire, earth, water and air. Which stand for pressure, temperature, elasticity, cohesion and movement. So you're right there at the point of contact. When you get down there, you can't go beyond that. That's it. And it's upon those sensations that we're building the world. See?

Now dependent on *phassa*, *vedanā* arises. So what's *vedanā*? *Vedanā* is the five feelings. The five feelings of painful, pleasant — painful and pleasant physical feelings, and painful and pleasant mental feelings, which we would call emotions. And neutral. Neutral feelings, both physical and mental.

Now what's happened there? We have defined what we're experiencing as either pleasant or unpleasant. And that's when you get the concept of pain. See? Now the world lives — we have to live in that dual world. Because everything we experience will either decide it's pleasant or unpleasant. Right?

Now at that point, something happens. Something happens which is arising from this fundamental base of ignorance. Now, that not knowing, it's produced a delusion. What is the delusion? The delusion is, "I am a human being." What a terrible delusion. I am a human being. And therefore, we are seeking happiness in the form of a human being.

Seeking happiness in the form of a human being manifests as acquisitiveness, because I want to feel safe. Greed, acquisitiveness. The more I have, the safer I feel. It manifests as aversion. Anything that threatens what I have, I want to push away and destroy. Murder. And if it's too big, I run for it. At worst, suicide.

So there's my relationship to the world from the position of delusion. The delusion is, "I am this human being. I want to be happy. This is what makes me happy." And I collect all the money, all the friends, all the whatever. And anybody who takes anything from that is my enemy, is my rival, and must be destroyed. And if the rival and the enemy is too big, I've got to run.

So those are my attitudes that are arising from this delusion of thinking, believing, identifying with this psychophysical organism. That fundamental delusion is running underneath every moment we live. Okay?

And when something comes into consciousness which we perceive as pleasant, we'll immediately go up and grab it and try to hold on to it and try to develop it. And if in consciousness something unpleasant comes — that arises from this delusion — the desire to get rid of it, to destroy it, or to run for it.

That's the point of *taṇhā*. That's what we're doing every time we fall into the error of — it's translated as craving, but you can see that word doesn't capture the meaning of it. It's the desire, it's the greed, it's the hatred, it's the aversion, etcetera. And the anxiety — that's coming from the pressure of not being able to handle a situation. And that's when it arises.

So everything up to now has been a given. Even the Buddha experiences that. He experiences sensations coming in. He experiences them as pleasant or unpleasant. He experiences emotions. He experiences the four great *brahmavihāra*. Love, compassion, joy and peacefulness. He's not a callous and cold heart and pure wisdom. I mean, it's like the wisdom and compassion arises naturally, is it? He's huggy-wuggy. Out of compassion. "Whatever a teacher can do out of compassion for his students, I have done for you." He doesn't say out of wisdom, he says out of compassion.

So up until then, it's natural to all human beings. But from an enlightened point of view, there's not this other relationship because that fundamental delusion about who we are has disappeared.

Now, every time we make in our meditation an object of what we are experiencing, we're undermining that delusion of a self. Because this self is saying, "I am this body." So when you get a pain in the knee and you say, "There's pain," you're undermining that delusion that I am this knee, or this knee is mine. Every time you have an emotion — anxiety, depression — every time you push it away inside, creating an outer world of the inner world, and you say "There's depression," you're undermining this fundamental delusion about who you are.

And that's the release. That's the process of liberation. That's the process of awakening. Same with thoughts. Thoughts are a bit quick, but definitely with images. You can hold an image and say, "Well, there's an image." And in that way, that objectification of the inner world is the process of liberation.

But whenever we fall into this *taṇhā*, we've lost it. We're back into the delusion. Now, that's the point of desire. And that's what we're doing all the time in terms of noting intentions. Some intentions of course are powered not by ignorance but by wisdom, so they're obviously ones to be developed. But when it's coming from this centre of a self, then, of course, you have to be careful. Then it becomes something which is negative, undermining.

But at that point, remember, nothing's happened. That's what we're trying to really grasp by noting intentions. Nothing happens at the point of intention. Now, the next step, as you'll see, is... what is it? Where am I? Oh, dear me. *Upādāna*. *Upādāna* is the actual holding of the grasping. And that's the point where you say, "This is me." That's the identification.

Now, you can catch it in your meditation. You can be there, holding that pain separate. And you're noting "pain, pain, pain." And then it just gets a bit too much. And then you say, "I can't stand it." At that point, you see, the identification's gone in. And that's the point of suffering.

So long as you can hold in your attention pleasant, unpleasant feelings as objects, you're not suffering. Make sure you can clearly see that. The separation of the consciousness, of that awareness from what it's being aware of, should be clearly acknowledged. There's pain — fine — but there's not suffering. Then this aversion comes. "I don't want it. I don't want it." Making that your object, making it very clear, you're still not actually suffering. It's not a pleasant place, but you're not suffering. And as soon as you say, "I can't take it," that's it. You're in there, and you're suffering. See?

So the point of suffering, as the Buddha points out, as opposed to pain, is at the point of identification. Now, the next step is the bit where the horror begins. Because *up-ādāna paccayā bhava*. Now, *bhava* is the point where you act. That's the point where the will goes in. And you create an act dependent on the delusion.

Now, he uses the word *bhava* because *bhava* means becoming. What's becoming? The self is recreating itself all the time. The self isn't static. It feels static. You know, you wake up in the morning and you say, "Oh, it's me again." Or, "Oh, not me again." It's one or the other. So it's like you wake up and you suddenly realise, "Oh, it's me." You wake up to yourself. That me, that me, you see, is the essential delusion that's underlying all this. And as it comes up and identifies, it empowers that intention.

And so the *bhava* is referring to a few things. It's referring, A, to this self reproducing itself as the one who's doing the action. It refers to the act of will that has gone into that process to take it from an intention into an action. And it's produced an act. See?

And that's the next bit where he says, from that point of becoming, that's the point of the birth of your action. And from the birth of your action, you complete the action and it comes to the end. So that birth and death refer to the process of the action that you've determined. And you can't stop the consequence once you've put that out into the universe and into the inner universe. You can't stop what's going to happen. You can ameliorate it, you can mitigate its effects, but you can't actually stop that energy from flowing outwards and inwards.

So for instance, if you're sharp with somebody, you can't stop the effect of that. You might have lost a friend forever, even though you might apologise. Inwardly, you've developed more of that nastiness.

So that's a run-through — dependent origination. The underlying ignorance about who we are, creating certain attitudes — the acquisition, the aversion, the fear — and how it manifests in a process, which is completely opposite to our language. So, "I want, and I scream, and I buy it." But the psychological process is, "I scream, want, I buy."

Now, if the I was first, there'd be no escape, would there? If the identity came first, you'd never be able to break through the process of desiring. It's the very fact that it comes after the process and therefore you can see the process of desiring that you can break the chain. You can see how amazingly deep the Buddha's insight was into our psychology. He saw exactly where the problem was.

And it's like anything... when somebody climbs Everest... like it's done... it's possible... up until then it's not possible... and then somebody climbs Everest... and every man and his dog can get up there... you see what I mean? It's like he's opened the gates of the deathless.

So that's dependent origination. Now... on the way back... whenever you stop... that process of wrong desire... unwholesome desire... the end of that process doesn't happen. It just fizzles out right there at *taṇhā*, at desire. And that's the cure. That's the emptying of those *saṅkhāra*, those conditionings which are running underneath every day of our lives. And underneath that is the ignorance.

So you've got this underlying energy of the not knowing, the essential delusions and all the habits that we've created by it, just running underneath every moment. Every moment there's some stimulus — a greed, something that we greed for, or hate, or afraid of — and it comes into our consciousness, and something from below rises up to grasp it. If we can catch that rising, it'll just go and then plop, and that's the end of it. It just disappears. And that way we empty these *saṅkhāra*, that way we undermine this fundamental delusion.

That's the point of escape between *taṇhā* and *vedanā*. *Vedanā* and *taṇhā*. That's the point of escape. And every time we're pushing something away to make it an object, we're actually cutting deep down into that sense of self. And there will come a time, be assured, when that sense of self is completely cut and the whole house of cards completely tumbles. And that's the point of total liberation. Maybe by Saturday noon. We'll have a bit of luck.

So that's the process that he's pointing out when he goes backwards on it. It's not so much backwards, it's more like the negative qualities. Undermining that *avijjā*, undermining that wrong understanding, the whole thing starts to collapse.

And do remember that often because of the way he would explain things, it came out quite negatively. And so he was accused of annihilationism. So there's the not born, the not dying, the unconditioned. We say some of these things in one of our pūjās. But he said, no, he said the only thing that's annihilated is this — is this acquisitiveness, aversion and fear. Everything else is given back, renewed.

So remember, once he was fully liberated, there immediately arose within him that desire to help other people. It's not possible for wisdom to arise without that connection, the connection with other people. And as he is teaching, his teaching grows. There are early parts of the scriptures — some of you might know the Nipāta Sutta — where he's getting his thoughts together, because it's conversations with people. Then the middle part, it's all been formalised. Four of these, ten of those, twelve of them. He goes on like lists upon lists. And it's like he has to learn how to teach.

I think I mentioned it on Saturday, where he rises from his seat with the idea of offering people this teaching, and he meets an ascetic on the road who says that, you know, "You really look brilliant, you look absolutely shining." He says, "Who's your teacher?" And he makes this amazing declaration: "I need no teacher, I am the fully liberated one," and all that, you see. And the fellow says, "Very good," and walks off.

Which you would do, wouldn't you? Somebody stood here and said, "I am the great guru, I am the cosmic Buddha." So I think he learned that you don't quite approach the process that way.

So the last thing I want to add to it is *kamma*. *Kamma*. By the way, I've done the dependent origination as a moment-to-moment process. Remember that there's also the teaching that this refers also to lifetimes. So that when we come into this life, we bring with us our past delusion and bad habits, our potentialities, and depending on the situation we're in, they'll be somehow developed.

So we know this from children, that early childhood, often a child will react to things which are completely innocuous, but because of the delusion or unresolved feelings in them, they'll see it in a certain way, and it becomes possibly a trauma. And then there's this business of false memory syndrome, where you get false memory and all that.

Well, just to reinforce that, I had one myself. Because in the early part of my meditation, when I was practising Zen, I was just resting and I lay on the bed and this huge fear came up. Every cell of my body was electric with this fear. And a very clear image that I walked into the room to my grandfather. And I mustn't have been more than two years old because he died shortly after that. And I shook him and I said to myself, he's dead, they've killed him. They happen to be my parents.

I went to my father, luckily he was still alive, and I said to him, "Dad, I found grandfather dead in the front room." He says, "No, he died in bed, I was with him." Now, if he wasn't there, I'd go around telling everybody, you know, I had this terrible trauma, caught my grandfather dead in the chair. Now, the point is, it's true, in the sense of that's how I interpreted what I saw, but it wasn't true historically.

Now, the interesting thing about that particular experience was that when it came up, I had a backflow, a forward flow of all my relationships to show me how that particular trauma had cancered every relationship. And from that moment on, my relationships changed. That's how deep our delusion can lie. Not everybody has these things, by the way. It's not necessary to have a trauma.

So that for me was a great teaching about karma. So somehow, I put credence in the whole idea of past lives, but even if you don't, just the idea of a young child who is feeling vulnerable. So you know children react. They think that if the parents are arguing, they're the problem, etcetera, etcetera. So whatever that decision was, remember the child is filled with that complete delusion that I am the body. And so that remains in the system. And you can see the karmic flow of it.

So karma, in terms of—I'm using karma in the more common sense of, you know, your comeuppance. Karma is to do with your inner world. It's not to do with your outer world when it comes to the process of liberation. And when something happens to us, there can be a multitude of reasons for it.

In Buddhist understanding, there are five laws. Most of them equate to our own modern laws. The first one is known as the law of heat or energy—that's all the physical laws. So these poor people in Nepal, I mean they've had another terrible earthquake up there—that's not because in their past lives they crushed a hundred thousand ants to death. I mean, it just happens because you happen to be on the earth. So you can't say that an earthquake or a flooding is your personal karma. It's ridiculous.

So it's the same with *bija*, the seeds. That's our genetics. You can't say the body, you know, you deserve the body you've got. It's a given through that whole genetic line. So that's not your personal karma. It's not the karma that you're looking at when you want to be liberated.

Then there's the whole law of psychology, the *citta*. The whole psychology, which includes our perceptual process, etcetera, etcetera. And a lot of that is dependent upon the brain that you were given. And then number four is karma, which is to do just that point of willing things and creating habits. There's your karma. And it's that karma that

will make you do things which then reverberate back on you. Like just getting angry with somebody, then you find they're getting angry with you for heaven's sake. So it's that understanding that it's really only around ethics that we have personal karma.

And go back to the original experience of the Buddha there upon enlightenment—those three knowledges that we talk about. The knowledge that he has no more defilements in him, that he sees all his past lives driven by his ethical decisions. And he sees beings being born from one realm to another also driven by their ethical decisions. So it's ethics.

And then finally, of course, there are the spiritual laws, which include the Four Noble Truths, etcetera, etcetera.

So karma, dependent origination and karma, are to be seen as one and the same thing. He's actually describing how we create karma for ourselves and how we can overcome it.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance and it has not brought more confusion. And that by your careful investigation, discrimination of all your experiences, you may finally reach that pure liberation from all suffering, sooner rather than later.

Destruction of Craving: Examining Each Link in the Chain

Noirin Sheahan · 47 min

In this exploration of the Mahātaṇhāsaṅkhaya Sutta (MN 38), Noirin Sheahan guides us through each of the twelve links of paṭicca samuppāda (dependent origination), showing how understanding these stages can undermine craving and lead to liberation from dukkha.

The talk begins with the Buddha's teaching on the six types of consciousness (viññāṇa), then methodically examines each link from avijjā (ignorance) through saṅkhāra (formations), viññāṇa (consciousness), nāma-rūpa (mind-matter), salāyatana (six sense doors), phassa (contact), vedanā (feeling), taṇhā (craving), upādāna (clinging), bhava (becoming), jāti (birth), to jarāmaraṇa (death/suffering). Practical examples illustrate how each stage manifests in daily experience and meditation practice.

Noirin emphasizes that wisdom gained through direct knowledge of any link can halt the cycle at vedanā (feeling), preventing the arising of taṇhā (craving). She explains how mindfulness allows us to recognize these processes and how intuitive awareness can skillfully navigate even unskillful mental formations. The talk concludes with insights into how understanding dependent origination creates a 'tipping point' where the system binding us to suffering begins to collapse, leading toward ultimate liberation.

I want to continue with the discourse on the destruction of craving, the Mahātaṇhāsaṅkhaya Sutta. Here we find the Buddha countering a disciple's view that we have just the one consciousness that speaks, feels and experiences. The Buddha debunks this and reiterates his position that there are six distinct forms of consciousness. When we're seeing something, we have visual consciousness. When we're feeling hot, we have body consciousness and so on. Only one of these can operate at any moment, and it needs certain conditions to be present for that consciousness to arise.

As an aside, I'd like to clarify that the Buddha is talking of worldly consciousness here, termed viññāṇa in Pali. There is ongoing debate about how we can describe awareness which transcends the world, Nibbāna. Let's not get into that. But remember that when we're speaking of consciousness starting and ending with each sensory experience, we're only referring to ordinary human consciousness here.

The remainder of the sutta gives us a methodology that lets us experience the world in the same way as the Buddha. In the first place, we are to learn to see experience as a series of happenings. The phrase he uses to describe this perspective is "this has come to be." When we get angry we can reflect "anger has come to be." When we cool down and become peaceful we can reflect "peace has come to be." Our whole life can be seen as a series of experiences arising one after the other.

Normally, we use a broad-based understanding to negotiate the world, where we're aware of multiple things: the walls, the furniture, the conversation on the radio, the twinge of pain in the back. This broad understanding requires conceptualisation. It's a cognitive miracle, but it doesn't reflect ultimate reality.

To experience ultimate reality, things as they really are, we have to be prepared to delve beneath thought to let awareness rest on the raw data that is coming through our sense doors moment after moment. With this intuitive awareness, we realise that we can only focus on one thing at a time. Whatever has just come to be, that is all we know. It's the limit of cognition. When we're seeing, we're not hearing. When we're hearing, we're not aware of the twinge in our back.

At times we become painfully aware of how unsatisfactory this is to our normal sense of self, how little the self likes this stop-start world where certainties crumble. The pain of this insight, however, gives us an extra incentive to see how we can reduce the stress, learn to live peacefully with uncertainty, with the inability to control experience.

Having persuaded ourselves that experience can be described as "this has come to be," the Buddha next wants us to learn about the causes and conditions for experience. Essentially, he says, all conditions have craving at their source. It's a sobering thought. Craving is obviously a very powerful force in the universe. Luckily, wisdom is an even stronger force.

So we don't have to tackle craving head on, suppress every urge to want things to be different, accept every misery without reaction. This would be impossible. The Buddha discovered that craving can be undermined and eventually destroyed altogether by learning from direct experience about all the causes and conditions that underlie it. Just knowing these is to reduce and eventually eliminate craving. The power of knowing. It is amazing.

By knowing is meant direct present moment conscious experience. It's because we don't fully know this, we skim over it, ignore so much of it, that we unwittingly allow craving to hold such sway in our lives. To the degree that we're skimming over, ignoring, we are, using Buddha's terminology, ignorant.

In this sutta, the Buddha traces the causes and conditions for craving down to ignorance, this imperfect, imprecise knowing. He then recaps on the sequence, working back up from ignorance to *dukkha*. It's generally accepted that all the links up as far as sense contact occur simultaneously with the remaining ones following sequentially. At the deepest level of concentration we might see the final links from feeling onward to *dukkha* following one another in a flash. So the full sequence may be happening thousands, perhaps millions of times during every second of our lives.

Although our concentration isn't sharp enough to follow each individual link, we can get to know each step when we focus attention. For example, we could focus on craving, looking within experience for pushing or pulling sensations, for rushes of energy, for the mind's tendency to narrow down on what it craves. In time, we'll be able to recognise craving and make a rational decision about whether or not to follow its suggestion.

Similarly, we can learn by bringing attention to any stage in dependent origination. Eventually, intuition will use this knowledge wisely. We'll use that as a theme for the rest of the talk, asking how understanding each stage might release us from suffering.

We get to know the first stage, ignorance, *avijjā*, when we watch our relationship with not knowing, the little question mark in our minds that sometimes becomes evident as we sit in meditation. Not knowing isn't itself due to ignorance. There are real limits to cognition. For example, we don't know what's going to happen tomorrow. When we're hearing, we're not seeing. Appreciating how little we know is wise. It's the degree to which we're disturbed that gives a measure of our ignorance.

There's a lot of purification to be had by learning to steady the mind around the sense of not knowing, if ever that comes up for you. Bearing with any agitation, restlessness, doubt or whatever hindrance comes up, the mind gradually makes peace with not knowing the future, not even knowing a sensation that passed a moment ago. The pause between breaths is sometimes when the sense of not knowing looms large.

As we learn to steady the mind around that, we also get a sense of there being a potential for something to be brought into consciousness, to become known. This allows us to learn about the next stage in dependent origination, *saṅkhāra*. Focusing on this sense of potential, we sense the somewhat ghostly nature of *saṅkhāra*. All our usual av-

enues for experience are there, but being held back. *Saṅkhāra*, remember, are the habits we've developed through our previous thoughts, speech and actions. They're the fruits of *kamma* and exist as a potential for their own repetition.

What we want to avoid doing is repeating unskillful habits based on greed, hatred or delusion. When ignorance is strong, it's easy to identify with that question mark and fall prey to the hindrance of doubt. Then there might be temptation to rush into something, to choose any old course of action, rather than live with doubt and uncertainty. Better to recognise doubt and learn to dwell more peacefully within that state of wonder and potential. Bringing wisdom to these crucial early steps in the chain allows intuitive awareness to bring forth the most appropriate *saṅkhāra*.

Saṅkhāras take three forms. Mental formations, which reflect our habitual feelings and perceptions. Verbal formations, which reflect our habits of thought and evaluation. And bodily formations, such as the in and out breath, which is the bodily habit we're most aware of in formal meditation.

Let's look at some examples of working skillfully with *saṅkhāra*. As we sit in meditation and things quieten down, during a pause between breaths, the little question mark of wonder might grow strong. We sense the tempting potential to think about what might be happening, what we should do. We also sense thinking being held back, recognised as a form of greed, the greed for understanding and control. In that case, body *saṅkhāra* might be the wise route for conscious experience. Consciousness of breath gets stronger and stronger, steadying the mind against the temptation to indulge thought. Here, intuition has chosen bodily *saṅkhāra* as the basis for conscious experience and our habitual urge to think is undermined.

At other times, feeling and perception may be the most skilful habit to come into consciousness. If the uncertainty has brought up strong aversion, the habit of *mettā* would help us bear with this. If we've been practising *mettā* in the past, then a perception of friendliness with associated pleasant feelings might emerge from nowhere, so to speak, to balance the aversion. In this case, intuition chose the mental habit of *mettā* as the basis for conscious experience. We begin to trust that this strange, uncertain world is, at base, a friendly place.

Verbal *saṅkhāra* can also be the skilful choice, especially when that sense of not knowing brings an almost chaotic bewilderment, as if we're an alien not understanding anything about the world. At such times, I found the phrase "this has come to be" surprisingly calming and consoling. It puts some sort of sensible framework around exper-

ience, reminding me that I'm just a human being in a state of bewilderment. In these cases, intuitive awareness has chosen to work through verbal *saṅkhāra*, allowing the thought "this has come to be" to become conscious.

Saṅkhāra, the habits that emerge because of ignorance, form the basis for the next link, *viññāṇa*, consciousness. To get to know this link, we could try to verify the Buddha's insight that there are six distinct types. For example, while listening to a piece of music, look at some visible object. Can you really hear and see at the same time? Or does one or other tend to predominate? In standing meditation, can you really feel both feet on the floor? Or does attention keep switching from one to the other?

Consciousness is coupled together with the following link, *nāma-rūpa*, mind and matter, like two sheaves of wheat balancing one another. *Rūpa* refers to the matter which, in subjective experience, corresponds to four elements: earth, air, water and fire. *Rūpa*, though physical in origin, is brought into mind through sense contact. Remember the first six links up as far as sense contact occur simultaneously. Here we can see how intertwined are the links of dependent origination. Sense contact forms a component of the mind that allows for sense contact to be made. It's not a neat linear process. It's more like an ecosystem with everything intertwined.

Other constituents of mind include intention and attention. Intention, otherwise called will or volition, is the basis for *kamma*, which we create at a much later stage in the cycle, the stage termed becoming. Intention arises at this early stage, *nāma-rūpa*, and then does its business, so to speak, at the much later stage of becoming. If a *saṅkhāra* of greed underlies consciousness, it is this mental factor of intention which allows greed to be acted out in the world and also be carried forward into the future. It's not the thought, act or speech themselves which create *kamma*. The key is the will with which this has been done. Exactly the same thought, speech or action could have been done out of goodwill, resulting in a *saṅkhāra* of *mettā*, starting a new round of conscious experience in the world.

To incline our lives in the direction of freedom, we need to get to know what our motivations are, pull ourselves away from situations if we find they are unskillful.

Attention is another mental factor which we can learn to use skillfully. We are constantly being bombarded with sensory information. Attention is the mental factor that selects out some portion of this to focus on. When we're not being mindful, we're letting *saṅkhāra*, our old ghosts, tell us what to notice. Greed gets us to look for pleasure. Aversion lures attention towards whatever frightens or irritates us. Delusion persuades us to ignore incoming sense data so that we can prioritise daydreams, worries and plans, all of which bolster the concept of me.

By contrast, mindfulness teaches us to bring attention to what will support our spiritual life. For example, the neutral sensations from the breath, which promote tranquility.

Mind and matter form the necessary basis for the next link, the six sense doors. We have the five physical senses plus the mind itself as another sense door. The eyes are sensitive to light and can act as a doorway for visual consciousness. Similarly for the ears and sound, nose and odours and so on.

Let's look in a bit more detail at the sixth sense, the mind as the doorway for mental consciousness. When we're looking at mind as part of *nāma-rūpa*, we were looking at what you might call central headquarters, the aspects of mind that display and process information via feeling and perception, and control experience through attention and intention. The mind door, on the other hand, represents the receptive aspect of mind. It's the mind as a sensor, sensitive to its own activity, much as the eyes are sensitive to light and the ears to vibration. A detector which detects itself.

When we listen to our own thoughts, we are using the mind as a sense door. It's mind-boggling to think about. No wonder we're in such a state of confusion. The mind can act like an echoing chamber or an infinity mirror, detecting its last thought, reacting in the same way, escalating worries till we're a nervous wreck.

Training ourselves to use the mind door wisely is our pathway to freedom. We can learn to stop echoing information unnecessarily. Stop trying to persuade ourselves that the past is still present. Persuade ourselves that thoughts represent reality. This shows us why so much emphasis is put on awareness at the physical sense doors in Vipassanā. The more often we rest attention on physical sensations, the less chance we're giving the mind to go round in circles, thinking a thought, detecting the feelings and perceptions generated by the thought, reacting to them by generating another thought.

We recognise the value of closing down the echo chamber effect of the mind when we stop rehearsing our woes, going over and over our plans, stop the daft daydreams. It's a relief. At times we detect a deeper silence. We might lose the sense of being an individual, a subjective entity to whom experience is happening. Sensations need no further embellishment, no interpretation beyond the experience of them arising and fading. Gradually we start to trust the Buddha's insight that *dukkha* results from ignorance, from constructing a false version of reality because we are not seeing it clearly.

The sense doors provide the opportunity for the sixth link to be made, sense contact. This happens when a sense door is open and has consciousness at one end and a sense object at the other. We've already mentioned sense contact, which can be confusing till you remember that all the first six links are experienced simultaneously.

At the moment the vibrations fall on the ear, a mental image of sound appears on the screen of consciousness. The vibration is only known as its mental component within *nāma*. The bird may be singing in the tree, but the sound I hear is within my own mind. The thought "there's a bird singing in the tree" is a thought. It's a construction we're putting on reality to explain that sound.

Sense contact forms the necessary basis for the next link, feeling, or *vedanā*. We're hardwired to interpret whatever comes in through the sense doors. Our biology is designed to detect whether the environment is safe or threatening, whether there are opportunities out there we should avail of, like food, shelter, company. Once sense contact is made, the mind processes this to produce a feeling. Comparing this sense input to previous ones, it works out whether to signal pleasure or danger. If a match can be made with a good memory, a pleasant feeling is generated. If it's a bad memory, an unpleasant feeling results. If it matches up with memories that were not in any way special, then a neutral feeling is generated.

Feelings, *vedanā* in Pali, are also part of the mind. They're not out there in the world. They're internal, peculiar to each individual. We easily overlook this. We believe "this person is terrific, beautiful, good fun." What we're doing is to project our internal feelings onto the person, embellishing them, concocting stories based on the good feeling we get when we meet them. But then we feel horribly let down if the person is in a bad humour. Our expectations aren't being met. Perplexed, we might add all manner of daft stories to the unpleasant feeling of disappointment. That they must be ill, that something terrible has happened, that they're rejecting us, that we've done something horrible to deserve a snub.

If we can sensitise ourselves to our feelings, we can stop creating unnecessary stories around these. It helps undermine the reactive stories to let attention rest on feelings, discerning whether they are pleasant, unpleasant or neutral, whether they are associated with worldly concerns or with the spiritual life. This is a practice the Buddha specifically recommends.

As we all know, however, this is not so easy. Our habit is to indulge feelings by forming the next link called *taṇhā* in Pali, translated as craving or desire. This, according to the Buddha, is the cause of all our suffering. We crave more of whatever gives us a pleasant feeling. We crave to get rid of unpleasant feelings. We crave to ignore neutral feelings.

Unlike contact and feeling, craving isn't a basic constituent of mind. Contact, feeling and other elements of *nāma* can be likened to atoms of experience. They can't be broken up, explored in more depth. We can be aware of these as entities in themselves, just as sensation, just as feeling tone, just as a mind state. Craving and all the links beyond craving aren't so simple.

Remember, the cycle from ignorance to *dukkha* can happen thousands of times a second, so there is time for a thousand different *saṅkhāras* to underlie a thousand feelings, sensations and perceptions in even one second of craving or clinging. It's like putting atoms together to form molecules, putting molecules together to form a cell, and so on, till we have a new being.

When we're paying close attention, we can start to deconstruct the monster. We'll see that the experience of craving can be analysed down to several moments of sense contact, each with its own feeling tones. Physically craving is often felt as pulling or pushing, lack of force within the body, a strong flow of energy. Mentally, we might sense a willful focusing of mind. We get tunnel vision, all attention being drawn toward what we want or don't want, pushed away from what we want to ignore.

Even though craving is the cause of suffering, we shouldn't repress it in *vipassanā*. We need to get to know the experience. If we find ourselves rushing towards the dining room for dinner, that's a great time to slow down, bring attention inward, feel the mental and physical energies that are compelling you to rush. Often, there will be a mixture of craving and the next link, clinging, at this stage.

Clinging, *upādāna* in Pali, is sometimes called grasping. This generates a sense of self. It's as if many molecules of craving fuse together to create a central headquarters for this new activity, getting what I want, getting rid of what I don't want, ignoring what I deem irrelevant.

Let's look at how we might recognise grasping, *upādāna*, resulting from reacting with desire at the thought of buttered toast. Desire might have been felt as a rush of physical energy when the mind suddenly zoomed into that thought. A second later, those energies have coalesced into an empowered feeling of me. This is grasping. It

might be felt as a solidifying within body and mind. A moment ago, experience may have been nebulous. Now it seems I'm a whole entire person with a very definite agenda.

If we've previously trained ourselves to take an interest in the experience of craving, then *saṅkhāras* of mindfulness could also be underlying consciousness, making us aware of greed. *Saṅkhāras* of restraint could prompt us to think again, to hold back from indulgence. It often seems as though we have multiple selves, all pulling us in different directions. Again, it's important to allow the experience of clinging become fully known within *vipassanā*, rather than suppress this.

Some of these selves we construct are wise. For example, the mindful, restrained aspects of our character can hold us in check while the greedy aspect is yelling for buttered toast. So we can welcome each experience of grasping. These give mindfulness a chance to learn how to grasp onto whatever safety hook might be available in times of trouble.

Every greed will have its moment in the sun. For example, there may come a time when we're curled up in fear and dread of a scary world. At that moment, intuition might well choose a *saṅkhāra* of greed as the wisest basis for conscious experience. We grasp onto anything pleasant. Could be a thought like, there must be something better than this. It's wise to grasp this glimmer of hope with all our might until the spectre of fear has dissipated. With mindfulness, we learn how to grasp wisely till the need to grasp is over.

If we're not being mindful, however, greedy *saṅkhāras* will easily get the upper hand and we're on to the next link. This is termed becoming, *bhava* in Pali. This is the moment when will becomes action. We start moving towards the toaster. What was a possibility, a potential, now becomes reality. It's sensed as a release. All those tensions stirred up by desire and grasping now have somewhere to go. At this moment, we create *kamma*. Acting on *saṅkhāras* of greed strengthens this habit in our character, makes it more likely that greed will haunt us in the future.

It could happen, of course, that we were mindful at the point of grasping, and instead of rushing towards the toaster, we've decided to act on the *saṅkhāra* of restraint. We make a firm decision not to make toast. It's often a good idea to make some physical activity here as well, so that the energies stirred up by the earlier stages have somewhere to go. For example, walking to a window, looking out, whatever will help reinforce the decision. Thoughts also involve will. And so when we make the decision, we also create *kamma*, making it more likely that we'll be able to restrain ourselves in the future.

But if we've been snared by greed, we run to the penultimate link, termed birth. We're making the toast, buttering it, eating it. We now have ten minutes or more where greed can have a field day. We might be daydreaming, worrying, thinking of a thousand different things throughout the process, hardly even noticing the taste of toast when it hits the tongue. Each thought, each mindless body movement sows more *kamma*, getting us ever more hooked on greed, mindlessness, daydreams, worries and restlessness. If greed had prompted the birth of, say, a night in the pub getting drunk, the potential for harm would be even greater.

This penultimate link, birth, sets our life on a certain trajectory which reinforces whatever habit prompts the activity in the first place. But even here, mindfulness might prevail, giving us a chance to limit the damage. We could decide to slow down, to relax and enjoy the treat of buttered toast. You might even decide to forego the last morsel, give it to the birds, as a symbolic step towards restraint. And of course we can take wholesome births, for example, going on retreat. Each step in dependent arising can be used wisely once we know what we're doing.

And keep reminding yourself that the whole process is happening in any moment. So even if, at a gross level, we've taken birth as a toast eater, we can pause at any moment to feel the desires and clinging underlying this. As an aside, let's remember that dependent arising is occurring at many, many levels in life and we've all taken birth in various forms as a parent, a sister, an engineer. We took birth as a human being at our physical birth. All of these births are being acted out moment after moment.

Back to our mini birth as a devourer of buttered toast. Once the last crumb has disappeared, we have the final link in the chain, termed death. The Buddha describes this also as sorrow, lamentation, pain, grief and despair. The pleasure is over. All that's left are sticky teeth, a bloated tummy, dirty dishes and the need to buy more bread. The term death sounds melodramatic but as practice deepens we get more sensitive to the miseries we can experience when delusive pleasure comes to an end.

On retreat some years ago I had been looking forward eagerly to the evening meal on my last day. With great relish, I sat down to a bowl of steaming soup. But as the bowl emptied, it was as if my world came to an end. Deep grief, believe it or not. Worldly pleasures don't last. Delusion gets us to ignore that obvious reality. We can pin all our hopes on the next meal, the next party, the next activity. Once they're over, discontent rears its head again, intensified because our latest hopes for happiness have been dashed. We might feel painfully disappointed. Usually, we skip quickly over this final link, busy ourselves with some new activity. But we'll never escape *dukkha* that way.

Don't underestimate the value of mindfulness at this final stage of *dukkha*. If we're willing to feel our disappointment, this is a powerful teacher. In fact, many people start their spiritual journey because of some form of death. It might be a physical death, the loss of a loved one. It might be a relationship breakup, losing our job, failing an exam, seeing the first wrinkles appear. In some way or other, we are suddenly jolted into the more painful realities of life. Not knowing how to cope, we look for wisdom, for some alternative to a life based on temporary pleasures.

So even if we've missed every single cue and ended up with toothache, bellyache and never want to see another slice of toast, it's possible to learn from this *dukkha*. Each and every mini-death we go through mindfully eats away at ignorance, our basic problem. I never again pinned so much hope on an evening meal following that grief-filled bowl of soup.

We undermine ignorance with wisdom. The better we know any of the links in dependent arising, the more wisdom we are gaining. So pick whichever one is most obvious at any time, or whichever naturally attracts your curiosity. The Buddha clarifies that we can halt the process at *vedanā*. We can become completely convinced that reactions of craving only lead to suffering. In tandem, we develop the taste for equanimity and tranquillity, for not allowing ignorance drive us to *dukkha*.

With that, we can resist the allure of pleasant feeling and aversion towards the unpleasant. We don't have to suppress these reactions out of fear or judgment. Instead, we relax, trust wisdom to do the work. When we can dare to trust, intuitive intelligence can start to tease out ways to protect us from repeating the cycle. It can be fascinating to watch how the intuitive intelligence rescues us from our unskillful habits. What I sometimes find is that it uses some other habit to pull me back from the current of danger.

For example, I might be watching anger and on the verge of strong condemnation. Many of the final links can be felt within experience. *Tanhā*, craving, can be felt as a tense pushing within my body and my mind almost splitting in two. Grasping expresses itself as a solid sense of me, the righteous one. There's a feeling of power associated with this image of myself and it's almost as if my body is being shaped as a large fist which is clasp tightly around the mind state. All the earlier links are embedded within the experience too. The sensations of grasping include unpleasant feelings of tension, sweetly pleasant feelings of self-righteousness, the habitual formation of anger and so on.

I teeter on the cusp of the next link becoming. This is sensed as if a dam is about to burst. I know that all my powerful, self-righteous energies could burst through the dam and be released into a torrent of angry thoughts. At times the dam bursts. This feels like a relief and pleasant feelings become more apparent. But because of mindfulness, these pleasant feelings might also get associated with perceptions of friendliness. This can change everything. Self-righteousness cools a bit, remembering the value of friendship. The *saṅkhāra* of doubt might then become conscious, giving me pause for thought.

This, I find, is a really interesting aspect of the whole process. A *saṅkhāra* of doubt is normally unskillful, but can be used skillfully by intuitive awareness in many situations. In this case, it's not arising out of ignorance. Mindfulness is present, and intuition senses doubt as my best route out of the mess I've created. This shows why we need to allow all our various habits be expressed in *vipassanā*. The more we get to know their expression, the more readily they can be used to rescue us from situations. Anger could be a wise route to stabilize us against fear, for example. Greed could help us move on from despair. There is hope, even within all our unskillful habits.

At other times, the transition from craving to equanimity might be quite smooth. In fact, we might not even understand exactly why, but our attitude has changed. One moment we were fretting, doing our best to keep mindfulness afloat, but in constant danger of identifying with thoughts and feelings. The next moment we're okay with the experience. The sensations and feelings are the same, but we're no longer identifying with these, no longer troubled by them.

The teacher, Thanissaro Bhikkhu, puts this down to the complexity of dependent arising. As for an ecosystem or almost any aspect of modern society, the system has feedback loops which, in normal circumstances, positively reinforce the system, making it robust. But complex systems run into trouble when the environment changes. There are tipping points where the system becomes vulnerable. Once the tipping point has been reached, negative feedback starts to predominate and the system starts to fail and can even disintegrate, just as a bridge might suddenly collapse and as the financial system collapsed in 2008. Nowadays, we greatly fear ecosystem collapse. But within the sphere of dependent arising, collapse is welcome. We want to move towards that tipping point where our behaviour starts to change radically, where the whole complex tangle that ensnares us in suffering starts to unravel.

The environment for dependent arising is wisdom. While this is at a low level, while we're ignorant, the system flourishes and binds us tightly into unskillful habits. But mindfulness chips away at ignorance, drives the system towards its tipping point. Once we start to see how dependent arising works, intuition can use our understanding to

undermine the process and bring about the conditions which favour collapse. The system will collapse totally and forever at the moment of enlightenment. But we sense many disintegrations along the way.

I mention these because we should welcome them but the sudden change might leave us perplexed. One example would be the abrupt attitude change from fretful to equanimous. Resistance can suddenly evaporate. At other times we might suddenly see through the fallacy of our thoughts, as if a veil had been lifted from our eyes. We wonder why we hadn't been able to see what was so totally obvious. At other times, it's as if we can feel threads of delusion snapping as we relax. One moment we're blowing up a bubble of thought, the next moment the bubble has burst.

We can welcome all these abrupt changes as evidence that the system that binds us to *dukkha* is starting to crumble. Each moment of mindfulness undermines ignorance, drives the system that bit closer to its tipping point. I hope this talk encourages you to increase your understanding of dependent arising, getting to know whichever of the twelve links seems most apparent, trusting that this knowledge is bringing you closer to the end of suffering.

Destruction of Craving: Tracing Back to the Origin of Dukkha

Noirin Sheahan · 43 min

In this retreat talk, Noirin Sheahan explores the Mahātaṇhāsankhaya Sutta (MN 38), the 'Destruction of Craving' discourse. The teaching begins with the Buddha correcting the monk Sāti's mistaken view of consciousness as a permanent entity that travels from life to life. Through careful analysis of dependent origination (paṭicca samuppāda), we examine how consciousness arises conditionally through the six sense doors, not as one continuous stream.

The talk traces the chain of conditions underlying dukkha: craving (taṇhā) supported by feeling (vedanā), which arises from sense contact, dependent on the six sense bases, rooted in mind-and-matter (nāma-rūpa), consciousness (viññāṇa), and habitual formations (saṅkhāra), all stemming from ignorance (avijjā). Through practical meditation instructions, we learn to observe experience as 'this has come to be' - seeing the arising and passing of phenomena rather than assuming permanent selfhood.

This teaching offers both theoretical understanding and practical guidance for undermining the conditions that support craving, showing how mindfulness can reveal the dependent nature of all experience and gradually liberate us from the delusion of a permanent, unchanging self.

Tonight I want to look at the teaching known as the Destruction of Craving, the Mahātanha Sankhaya Sutta.

The teaching is given because one of the Buddha's monks, Sati, believes that there is just this one consciousness that runs throughout all our life and was with us in our previous lives and will accompany us throughout our future lives. Just this one and no other, he claims, thinking he's teaching the Dhamma correctly and according to the Buddha.

The other disciples try to dissuade him, but Sati insists on his view and is summoned by the Buddha to discuss the matter. The Buddha starts by asking Sati about his one consciousness understanding. And when Sati repeats this, the Buddha then asks him to define consciousness.

Sati says, "It is that which speaks and feels and experiences here and there the results of good and bad actions."

To Sati's dismay, the Buddha dismisses this vehemently, saying, "Misguided man, to whom have you ever heard me explain the Dhamma thus? Misguided man, in many discourses have I not stated consciousness to be dependently arisen, since, without a condition, there is no origination of consciousness. But you, misguided man, have misrepresented us and by your wrong grasp and injured yourself and stored up much demerit."

We are told that on hearing this, poor old Sati sat silent, dismayed, with shoulders drooping and head down, glum and without response.

Now, I'd say we could all have sympathy with Sati. It certainly seems that our essence, call it consciousness, is that which speaks and feels and experiences, and that this essence has been with us all our life. And, if we believe in rebirth, it's hard to see what else within us might survive other than that which speaks and feels and experiences the results of good and bad *kamma*. Obviously, we're badly mistaken here. We're suffering from the same delusion that got Sati into trouble.

It is interesting that the Buddha gets Sati to explain his understanding before he so emphatically refutes this. This reflects the fact that we need to be clear about our delusions before we can see through them. We put them forward into the gaze of mindfulness, trusting that this will filter out the falsehood from the truth.

The Buddha then reiterates his own teaching. Firstly, consciousness is of six kinds. For instance, if our eyes are open and there's a visible object in front of them, then eye consciousness can arise. If our hearing works okay and sound waves fall on the ears, then ear consciousness can arise. He gives the analogy of fire: a log fire, a grass fire. We name the fire depending on what fuel it is based upon.

He then goes on to question the audience on three points. To start with, he asks whether they are clear that "this has come to be." They all chorus in unison, "Yes, venerable sir." It is very irritating when we're scratching our heads wondering what on earth he means. But these short, often perplexing statements from the Buddha give us something to investigate in vipassanā.

It would be worthwhile, when you next sit in meditation, to ask yourself whether your experience could be described by the phrase, "This has come to be." Once our mind settles in meditation, we find ourselves in a sea of sensations and feelings, reac-

tions of desire or aversion, emotions, thoughts and images. This can be incredibly confusing until we notice that only one of these is happening at any one time. It simplifies things to track each passing experience rather than try to make sense of the totality.

Each experience could be labelled as "this." We might be watching the breath. We feel glad to be watching the breath. What the Buddha is asking of us is to notice that gladness has come to be. After a while, we don't feel so glad anymore. We feel a bit glum, thinking something better should be happening. Again, what's asked of us is to notice that glumness has come to be, that discontent has come to be. In general, whatever takes our attention, we're being asked to notice that this is our present moment experience.

To follow this to a deeper level, if our gaze lands on a green field, eye consciousness gives us an image of greenness. Concentration is rarely sharp enough to see individual moments of consciousness in this way, and so we see the world as a multitude of separate objects which all exist simultaneously: green fields and trees and sky and so on. But when we calm the mind enough to allow moments of deeper clarity, we see that only one sense contact can be registered at a time—for instance, greenness, blueness, greyness—and that we're building an overall picture by joining the dots.

While it's an amazing feat of intelligence to be able to join the dots and negotiate the world based on the overall picture we get from this, we also need to see the underlying process. I had a glimpse of this one time as I was eating lunch on retreat. I saw the knife and fork moving slowly toward the potato. My attention was taken by something else for a moment. Then visual consciousness came to the fore again, only this time the knife and fork had moved closer to the potato. I realized I had just seen two visual stills within what I normally interpret as a continuous video of visual consciousness.

Because of mindfulness, I wasn't joining the dots in the usual way. Instead, I knew that in between the two stills, I had no idea where the knife and fork were, or even whether they existed. There was a complete blank and absence of information. For those moments, visual consciousness had ceased.

The Buddha never suggests that the world stops existing when we're not watching it. He doesn't attempt to describe reality in terms of objective science. What he describes is the cognitive process upon which we build our picture of reality. He wants us to see that our access to the world, our ability to know it consciously, is unstable, conditional. A portal opens, gives us a little snippet of information, then closes. As the Buddha teaches, consciousness arises and then ceases.

Getting a direct experience of this undermines the delusion Sati describes so succinctly—that there's just one consciousness that sees and feels and experiences the results of good and bad kamma and that this same consciousness has been with us all our lives and will be with us the next life too. Sati's description mirrors our delusion but it doesn't bear scrutiny under the watchful eye of mindfulness.

Seeing this stop-start nature of cognition is not simply academic. It might rock a person to the core of their being to realize how limited is our knowledge of reality. As we learn to live with this uncomfortable news, the insight gradually opens the heart. It helps us loosen our grip on certainties we cling to, entrenched opinions about who and what we are, how we should behave, how others should behave, etc.

Knowing how little we actually know makes it easier to forgive mistakes, to be grateful that anything at all can actually work out right in the midst of such a paucity of real information dependent on so many unproven assumptions. We realize how much we're taking for granted and what a miracle it is even to be able to take a footstep or make a cup of tea.

Having ascertained that his disciples understand experience from the viewpoint of present moment awareness, which can be summarized as, "this has come to be," the Buddha then goes on to ask whether they're clear that its origination occurs with that as nutriment. Conscious experience depends on certain conditions. It doesn't arise from nowhere. It needs support, nutriment.

All of these nutriments, he declares, have craving as their origin. Craving is another word for sensual desire or *tanhā* in Pali. This, the Buddha had discovered, was the basic drive underlying all worldly experience. It's because we want something from the world that we become conscious of it. That's quite a thought to reflect on.

Now of course the Buddha was conscious and could see and hear and think. He was living within the world of sense contact. So there's obviously a way to experience the world that doesn't depend on craving.

The word for craving is *tanhā* in Pali. It comes in three flavours. The desire for sense pleasure is one. Another is the desire to become, to be someone special. And finally the desire not to become. This is when we want to annihilate ourselves. In the extreme it means suicide, but in minor ways this desire arises out of embarrassment, for example, when we want to become invisible. *Tanhā* or craving refers to all of these three flavours of desire.

There is a related word, *chanda*, which describes skilful desire. *Chanda* also supports consciousness. We see this when we use *chanda* to develop traits like mettā, for example. We start spotting opportunities where goodwill is needed. We become more conscious of goodwill in others. It's like we've opened a door into a whole new aspect of life, an area we were previously not conscious of.

The Buddha doesn't describe the workings of an enlightened being as we don't need to know this before we get there. But my guess is that *chanda* plays a part in maintaining their consciousness within the phenomenal world. But that's an aside. What the Buddha is keen for us to understand is that within our unenlightened state all nutriment for conscious experience has craving as its base. Whatever is our present moment experience, this has come to be because we crave sense pleasure, we crave existence to become someone special, we crave non-existence to be invisible.

The third question the Buddha puts to his disciples is whether they are clear that with the cessation of that nutriment, what has come to be is subject to cessation. Let's say what has come to be is a feeling of happiness. This will have been born from certain conditions. It could have been the thought of a job well done. If we can steady attention on the feeling, the thought will fade and sometime afterwards the feeling also fades. This shows us that the feeling of happiness needs certain supportive factors.

In fact, everything we experience fades away after a few moments, once the supporting conditions give way. We see this in gross terms. An animal dies without food. A plant dies without water. Snow melts when it gets too warm. Machines break down when they're not maintained. Everything depends on its supporting conditions and fades away, ceases to exist once those conditions fail to appear.

Mostly we hear this as bad news. We dread change and loss. But of course it can be used to suit our purposes. If we want to stop something undesirable, it's usually easier to undermine its supporting conditions than to tackle the problem head on. If a child is crying, we find out what is the problem. They might be hungry, so we give them something to eat. What we're doing is taking away the cause of their distress, rather than preventing them from crying.

It's the same within us. We might sense anger as a big problem in our lives. Instead of trying to suppress every emotional flare-up, we can look for the causes of anger, work to undermine these. Same for any of the hindrances, any unskilful tendencies we find within ourselves. The more we undermine the conditions, the more the unskilfulness loses its grip on us.

This is essentially why the Buddha lists all the factors that support craving. The better we understand these, the more options we find for dismantling the whole structure.

Having set the big picture, the Buddha then goes on to list the chain of factors that support craving. These are the first seven links in the chain known as dependent arising or dependent origination, a twelve-link process that leads from ignorance to dukkha.

The immediate support for craving, its proximate cause, is feeling, *vedanā* in Pali. We crave to get more pleasant feelings, to get rid of unpleasant ones, to ignore neutral ones.

What underlies feeling, he asks. The answer is sense contact. Feelings are generated only as a result of some snippet of information that has come through the senses. The feeling tells us whether this is pleasant, unpleasant or neutral. Feeling is a biological adaptation which aids survival. Any organism needs to be able to detect threats, to seek out food or other nourishment, to filter out sensory information that's not relevant to survival. So our biology is set up to filter sense contacts into these categories, giving us a feeling tone for each bit of sense data.

The process happens so quickly, so automatically, we're rarely aware of our feelings. We simply react automatically. However, as the Buddha points out, feeling is the proximate cause for craving. And so we need to learn to tune into the feeling tone of experience.

To recap on these three links, craving is based on feeling. When we experience a pleasant feeling, we crave for more of the same. When we experience an unpleasant feeling, we crave to get rid of it. We crave to ignore neutral feeling. In turn, feeling is only generated when a new bit of sensory information is registered by sense contact.

What underlies sense contact? The six sense doors. One of these is forming the portal, allowing that snippet of information to come in. The sensation of warmth requires the body's tactile system as a door to consciousness. A bird song needs the hearing system. The thought of buttered toast needs the mind as a sense door.

When we acknowledge the crucial role of the sense doors, we also see that one way to reduce craving is to withdraw from as much sensory stimulation as possible. We go somewhere quiet, shut the eyes, make the body comfortable. With a bit of luck, the only challenging feelings we have to deal with are those that enter via the doorway of the mind.

What underlies the six sense doors? Mind and matter. *Nāmarūpa*. The sense doors are built from the cells, blood, neurons in our bodies, animated by mental phenomena such as attention and intention. *Nāmarūpa* translates literally as name and form. Form refers to the body, the world of matter; blood, bones, neurons. What gives this a name, a meaning, is *nāma*, the mind.

As an aside, it's generally understood the dependent arising describes how we experience the world. It's not a description of scientific reality, but of our inner cognitive reality. It's also generally understood that the first six of the links, up as far as sense contact, all occur simultaneously. It's not that we become aware of mind and matter, *nāmarūpa*, and then become aware of one of the sense bases and then the snippet of data from the outside world. Instead, we become conscious of all of these in the one moment. The usual way to say this is that they all arise simultaneously. We can't separate them in time, but we can examine our experience at any one time and tease out these various strands within the experience.

Curiously, sense contact and feeling are also part of *nāma*. A simple mechanical understanding of dependent origination would suggest that since *nāma* supports contact and feeling, it can't also contain them. But the reality in which we live isn't so simple.

Think of an ecosystem. The top predators, let's say owls, depend on there being mice to prey upon. The mice depend on there being seeds to eat. The seeds depend on there being plants to develop them. The plants depend on the soil. The soil needs the nutrient from owl and mouse droppings to be fertile. The dependence is intertwined rather than linear. Everything depends on everything else. If the owls disappear, the mouse population would explode, eating all the seeds, resulting in famine and devastation. So the owls, in one sense, support themselves, support the system by feeding off it.

In the same way, contact and feeling support themselves because they are part of *nāma*, the mental component underlying the sense bases. The sound that I'm hearing forms part of the mind that listens. Although the sound vibrations come from, for example, a bird singing, the sound I hear is internal and subjective. It's a purely mental phenomenon, an aspect of the mind that listens. Looked at from the point of view of experience, sound isn't external. It occurs within the mind, within consciousness.

Similarly, the evaluation of the sound as pleasant, unpleasant or neutral is a mental process. It forms part of the mind that listens to the sound, feels it as pleasant.

While this complexity might seem daunting we can use it to our advantage. For example, it helps to lessen our sense of separation from the world. If sounds are within me, forming part of my basic mentality, why not try to live more peacefully with them?

If they sound pleasant to my ears, it evokes gratitude to reflect that the pleasant feeling is forming part of my mental make-up at this moment, helping me to see the world in a more positive way. If it's the grating noise from a jackhammer that I'm hearing, I'll have more compassion for myself when I reflect that the unpleasant feeling is coursing within me, affecting me at my core. If it's the background hum of the fridge I'm hearing, its evaluation in neutral tones forms part of the quietness in my own mental background. Noticing this invites me to time off from busyness and spend a few moments in refrigerator-humming meditation.

What I'm saying, basically, is that knowing sense contact and feeling are in here, part of our subjective mental world, as opposed to out there, helps to draw attention inwards, steady the mind on these very sensations and the feelings they evoke. The more we can steady the mind, the more we foster positive qualities like mindfulness, compassion, gratitude, tranquillity. At the same time, we're letting go of our usual urges towards reactivity, restlessness, doubt and other hindrances.

The Buddha then asks what *nāma rūpa* depends on and answers that consciousness is their proximate cause. Consciousness, *viññāṇa* in Pali, describes awareness at any one point of the six sense doors. A useful analogy is a mental screen. Consciousness is the screen itself, while sense contact, *vedanā* and the other components of mind, such as attention and intention, are the images that appear on the screen.

Imagine you're in a cinema. If the screen suddenly disappeared you wouldn't see the film. The light from the projector would pass on through, disappear into blackness. Similarly the ears could be ringing with the vibrations from a rock concert but because we're fast asleep the sounds disappear into the vast silence of unconsciousness.

Although in this sutta the Buddha describes consciousness as the condition upon which *nāma rūpa* rests, in another sutta the two are described as interdependent. Consciousness depends on *nāma rūpa* as much as *nāma rūpa* on consciousness. Sāriputta, one of the Buddha's foremost disciples, gives the analogy of two sheaves of wheat resting against one another. If you take out one, the other collapses. Likewise for consciousness and *nāma rūpa*. The screen of consciousness is needed to play the film of *nāma rūpa*. The film contains mental factors like intention and attention which are needed to beget the screen. You could call it an eco-friendly screen. It only comes into being when there's a film to play. It decomposes instantly when it's not needed.

The Buddha then asks, what is it that underlies consciousness? The answer is habitual formations. As the term suggests, these are the habits we develop as we repeat patterns of thought, speech and behaviour. A river cuts a channel through rock as it rushes from its source to the open sea. Similarly, as ignorance rushes toward *dukkha*, our

thoughts, speech and actions cut out a *saṅkhāra*, a channel through which our mental and physical energies can flow. The more often we repeat a pattern of thought, speech or action, the deeper that channel cuts, making it ever more likely that ignorance will choose that channel in order to flow to *dukkha*.

Saṅkhāra comes in three categories. One relates to the mental formations of perception and feeling. We tend to see and feel the world in habitual ways. For example, we speak of people with a negative disposition, choosing fearful perceptions, detecting hostility in the most innocent remark. This is all stemming from a *saṅkhāra* of unpleasant feeling, perceptions of danger. Others have an optimistic disposition, seeing the best in people and situations. Insofar as this is based on ignorance, what we're looking out for is worldly happiness. We see the best, not because of admiration or appreciation, but because we're used to feeding off the best that the world has to offer. When we walk into a party, we see the drinks counter, the food buffet, the most attractive people. A person with a negative disposition would have seen the messy, half-finished plates of food, heard insincerity in every peal of laughter. The deluded optimist usually manages to get the best out of situations, never notice the mess they're leaving for others to clear up.

Then, there are those who habitually choose neutral feelings and the perceptions of indifference which support neutrality. When they walk into the room, they see neither the drinks cabinet nor the dirty plates. None of that matters very much. They might sidle into the first group that they see, accept whatever food and drink they're offered, play safe in conversation, quickly forgetting the names of whoever they're introduced to. The whole evening leaves only a vague impression on consciousness, makes little or no impact on their lives. Thus, the channel leading from ignorance to *dukkha* cuts a bit deeper, into the groove of neutrality and indifference.

You might recognise these crude portraits of optimism, pessimism and indifference as the Buddhist description of the three personality types based on greed, hatred or delusion. It's interesting to reflect that underlying the will which drives us along roots of greed, hatred or delusion are habits of feelings and perception.

It gets a bit mysterious here because *saṅkhāras* underlie consciousness and *nāma rūpa*, implying that they exist outside the world of mind and matter. *Saṅkhāras* are bound up with another somewhat mysterious phenomenon in Buddhism, *kamma*. *Kamma* and *saṅkhāra* are usually illustrated by analogy to seeds and fruit. Whatever desire we choose to act upon sows a seed of *kamma*, which will later ripen as a fruit, a *saṅkhāra*, which prompts us to fulfil that desire again. While a seed and its fruit are

directly linked in a material way, the link between our deeds and the *saṅkhāra* that result from them is immaterial. The Buddha warns us that the workings of *kamma* are beyond human understanding.

Ultimately, *kamma* and *saṅkhāra* lie in the realm of mystery, but one way to picture the link is to say that the doing of any deed results in a potential for its own repetition, a potential which underlies consciousness. We could use the analogy of a ghost. We are haunted by our past actions, speech and thoughts. But this isn't just a horror story. Many of these ghosts serve us well on the spiritual path. Thoughts, words and deeds stemming from wisdom and *mettā* also want to impress themselves into consciousness and strengthen with each moment of mindfulness.

So far we've been looking at the *saṅkhāra* of mental habits, the ghostly image of feelings and perceptions we've developed through favouring certain feelings and perceptions, the optimist favouring pleasant feelings, happy perceptions, the pessimist favouring unpleasant feeling, fearful or hostile perceptions and so on. Another variety of *saṅkhāra* concerns verbal formations, our habits not only of speech but of directed thought and evaluation. Thoughts reflect how we conceive of the world. They rely on concepts, ideas.

A baby doesn't think about what they're going to have for dinner. They just know when they're hungry and whether or not they like what's coming into their mouth. They live in immediate reality. Sensations, feelings, impulses of wanting and not wanting, simple perceptions like blueness, warmth, ease, unease. Gradually perceptions bundle together to reveal patterns. A lot of whiteness with some yellowness at one end turns into warm sweetness on the tongue and a filling of the belly. The concept of a feeding bottle starts to form as a very desirable pattern that is much more likely to happen if I cry loudly. And so we slowly learn how to manipulate the masses of sensory information that impinges on us each moment so as to get more of what makes us feel good and avoid what makes us feel bad.

To manipulate the world like this, we need concepts. We need to stand back from immediate experience and make sense of it. We take a multitude of passing sensations and weave them into a concept. Feeding bottle, mummy, blanket. As we grow older, the level of abstraction increases so that we can think about governments, human rights, Buddhism. All of this mental activity happens when verbal *saṅkhāra* underlie consciousness.

The ability to abstract, to conceptualise, allows us make sense of our lives, choose a career, affect the world for good or evil, follow a spiritual path. We obviously don't want to destroy that ability. But we don't want to be enslaved by it either, unable to follow a

single breath without spinning off into a stream of thought. We don't want to be forever haunted by the ghosts of our past thoughts, forever rehearsing what we'll say, repeating our opinions about this and that. We do this by sitting in meditation, again and again dropping the latest line of thought, choosing instead to let awareness dwell in that more immediate, non-conceptual reality of sensation and feeling.

This is to strengthen the habitual formation in the third variety of *saṅkhāra*, bodily formations. These are our physical habits, the way we walk, our facial expression, our nervous twitches. As we sit in meditation, the most predominant habit is the breath. Breathing forms the basis for biological life. When we stop breathing, we die. Of course, other functions like heartbeat are also essential, but the breath is the one under voluntary control. It's a habit we initiate at birth and continually repeat until death.

The Buddha places great emphasis on mindfulness of breathing. It's the first exercise in the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta. After a rains retreat, when a disciple asks him about his meditation, the Buddha responds that he spent most of the time being mindful of breathing. With three flavours of *saṅkhāra* to choose between, verbal formations, mental formations and bodily formations, the Buddha chose the latter as the basis for consciousness during retreat. The *saṅkhāra* of directed thought would have been unnecessary. He'd long since figured out the Dhamma. He didn't need to reflect on anything. The mental formation of pleasant feeling and perception would have allowed consciousness to establish itself in jhāna, a very restful state of deep concentration. We might think he would choose to spend his retreat in the freedom of Nibbāna or one of those sublime states of jhāna.

But no, he deliberately chose to spend the months of the rains retreat being conscious of the in and out breath. Who knows why? My guess is that it strengthened his will to live to the ripe old age of 80. I like to think of him allowing the ghosts of his previous breaths draw the infinite wisdom of Nirvāṇa into his human form. I'm speculating here. All we know is that the Buddha places great emphasis on the use of this *saṅkhāra* to build mindfulness of breathing and that he chose to spend the months of the rains retreat doing this himself. So it's certainly a *saṅkhāra* that can be used wisely and perhaps, who knows, is a way to strengthen our life energy, our will to live.

The Buddha then asks what underlies *saṅkhāra* and answers that they are born and produced from ignorance. It's only because we don't fully understand how suffering is caused that we let *saṅkhāras* come out of potential and into consciousness. Ignorance is our basic problem. The Buddha never lists anything else, original sin or whatever underlying ignorance. We eradicate ignorance by gaining wisdom. We gain wisdom by experiencing reality directly, not through the filters of conceptual thought. Mindfulness

educates us as to the true nature of the world. Each up-close, touchy-feely encounter with experience shows that craving is feeding dissatisfaction, *dukkha*. The deeper we let this truth sink in, the less we allow our *saṅkhāra* ghosts to haunt us. We learn to hold off till an inkling of wisdom becomes conscious, cutting out new pathways for our speech, actions and thoughts. Pathways that reflect the Dhamma, that take account of the fact that everything is in a constant process of creation and decay.

Having followed the Buddha's analysis of our problem down to its base, ignorance, let's recap. To undermine delusion that Sati described so well, but I think we all have to admit to, the Buddha first asks us to drop below the level of conceptual thought and see experience as a series of happenings, a dynamic sequence of events. Secondly, he wants us to see that events are being continually nourished by craving. Ultimately, everything we experience on this side of enlightenment, anyhow, has craving as its source. The third thing he wants us to clarify is that things die away naturally once the supportive conditions are removed. This is good news. It means that we can put an end to our foolish craving. We don't have to tackle craving head on, stop ourselves desiring this or resisting that. Instead we can find out what conditions allow craving to come about in the first place. As we undermine these, craving dies out quite naturally.

That's the point of teaching us about the chain of conditions underlying craving. The better we get to know these, the more skilled we get at removing the supportive structure within us that binds us to suffering. If you're looking for a very practical place to start, why not investigate the first point that the Buddha puts to his disciples? When the mind quietens in meditation, ask yourself whether your experience could be described by the phrase, this has come to be.

May our practice liberate us from craving and bring us to the end of suffering.

Divine Abiding, d. Appreciative Joy, Muditā - read by Therese Caherty

Noirin Sheahan · 40 min

In this fourth talk on the brahmavihāras (divine abidings), Noirin Sheahan explores muditā - appreciative joy or sympathetic joy. Drawing from the Mahāmaṅgala Sutta's list of blessings, she shows how muditā allows us to celebrate the happiness of others and appreciate the good conditions supporting our Dhamma practice.

Noirin addresses the misconception that Buddhism dismisses worldly joy, explaining how the Buddha himself remembered the 'blameless joy' of his childhood meditation under the rose apple tree. She distinguishes between pīti (joy as a factor of awakening that arises from pursuing truth) and muditā (joy that responds to life's beauty and goodness).

The talk covers muditā's enemies: jealousy and denigration (far enemies) that shut out joy, and excitement and excess (near enemies) that cling too tightly to it. Noirin offers practical guidance for cultivating muditā toward ourselves and others, emphasizing how appreciating our own good deeds builds the self-confidence needed for liberation while avoiding the trap of vanity or self-attachment.

For the past few evenings, I've been talking about the Brahma Vihara, the beautiful states of mind and heart expressed when we're in harmony with the world. The basis is *metta* or goodwill. We wish all beings to be happy, but *metta* doesn't make us smile with delight in all circumstances. The intelligence we cultivate in Vipassanā is also very much to the fore and we are acutely aware of the ever-present potential for suffering and the need to take care that we don't unwittingly get the wheel turning.

As we learn to acknowledge and bear with our emotions in Vipassanā, we are better able to tune into the emotional tone of various situations that we find in our daily lives. Then we can tailor our goodwill towards compassion, *mudita* or equanimity so as to fit in with different circumstances.

Suppose you're meeting a friend for coffee. You're feeling bright and breezy and giving silent good wishes to everyone in the restaurant. Then you see your friend coming and, to your surprise, you see them looking weary and glum. The simple *metta* wish, may you be happy, just doesn't fit. It doesn't show any sensitivity to the situation. You might prefer if they'd feel bright and breezy to match your own mood, but that wish is out of kilter with their present reality.

So you have to be prepared to let go of your bright and breezy mood and instead take into consideration that something may be amiss. As you let your mood change from brightness to concern, your goodwill can take on the hue of compassion. This more sombre form of goodwill fits when you're aware of witnessing some degree of suffering. The phrase, may you be free from suffering, acknowledges both the suffering and your friend's potential to find freedom. Forming this good wish while you watch them approach means your tone of voice and body language will express empathy and care for whatever's troubling them.

To take another example, suppose you're walking down a street wishing strangers well as they pass by, but something catches your eye and in a dark alley you see someone squatting on the pavement injecting drugs into a vein. Again, the straightforward metta wish, may you be happy, just doesn't work here. It would be glossing over the reality, refusing to engage with the human tragedy you're witnessing. The wish may you be free from suffering fits better as this is certainly a situation of suffering and it's possible that the person is suffering very deeply. But it doesn't acknowledge the kernel of the problem that as far as we can judge the person is making things worse for themselves by drug addiction.

Equanimity is the Brahma Vihara which allows us to cope with what we don't want and judge as wrong. It accommodates both good and evil. The understanding of *kamma* provides a channel for equanimous good wishes, such as, may you be able to bear with the kamma you are creating. Or it could help to phrase the wish in more mundane terms, such as, may you stop harming yourself. Or may you learn to cope with your challenges more skillfully.

Now let's say you've made your good wishes for the person shooting drugs and have recovered your good humour and are back to wishing well to strangers as you pass them by. Then you spy a couple with their arms around one another, obviously deeply in love. Once again, the metta wish, may you be happy, doesn't fit as they're already so obviously happy. So they don't need your good wishes on that account. In this case, you need to form your good wishes in a way that acknowledges and honours their existing happiness. This brings us to *mudita* or appreciative joy which is the Brahma Vihara I want to talk about tonight.

Mudita tunes into our natural human capacity for joy and gives us a skillful way to build on that. The classic phrase to cultivate *mudita* is may your happiness continue, may your happiness increase. If your *mudita* channels are open you'll be delighted for them and get a little shot of joy yourself into the bargain. And as you pass them by and

continue wishing well to those all around your good wishes will have an extra animation. With *mudita* happiness is multiplied. The happiness of the couple became your happiness. *Mudita* is all about appreciating the good things in life.

Buddhism tends to have a bad reputation in this department because of the emphasis on the first noble truth of *dukkha*. But joy is also very much part of the Dhamma. It will certainly be there when we're fully developed, as described in this verse from the Dhammapada: "Happy indeed we live, we who possess nothing. Feeders on joy we shall be, like the radiant gods."

But joy isn't only when we've reached such an exalted state. After spending years doing mortification practices and deciding they led nowhere, the Buddha then remembered his joyful experience as a child under the rose apple tree watching his father ploughing. The mortification practices had dismissed joy as worthless but now the Buddha questioned himself on this. He realised the joy he had experienced wasn't to do with attachment to the world but was what he described as a blameless joy. He decided he'd no longer dismiss that and instead would actively cultivate it as an aid to meditation.

Thus we have joy as a factor of enlightenment. The Pali term for this is *pīti*. In this case, joy emerges from fascination with the pursuit of truth. We're glad to be seeking out and sensing the path to freedom. It's not linked to anything specific in life, like seeing a couple in love. *Mudita*, on the other hand, arises when we are touched by the beauty of life. Young love, the birth of a baby, the smile of a friend. It's the response of gladness to the good things in life.

It can be a bit confusing. In meditation we rejoice in freedom, letting go of our attachments in life. In *mudita* we rejoice in life itself. Is there not a contradiction? To embrace both sources of joy is part of our path to freedom. For example we need families to help us through infancy and childhood. We need some level of education to be able to hear and understand the Dhamma. We need a stable society to give us the possibility of retreat centers where we can practice meditation. And of course we need food, clean air, water, medicine to keep us alive until our moment of enlightenment when we fully understand that which goes beyond life and death.

Although freedom, *Nibbāna*, is not dependent on education or families or a stable society, we can only find our path to freedom in the midst of all these. At one level, *mudita* can be seen as a thank you to all the conditions that allow for ourselves and others to tread the path to freedom.

Mudita builds on our natural *joie de vivre*. As babies, we took delight in seeing faces we recognised, playing with whoever and whatever came our way, in food and comfort and being able to explore and learn and so on. This delight only led to *dukkha* because of attachment, the mistake of believing we could control and own all the lovely stuff. But the delight itself animated us, let us develop confidence and trust, help to smile and make connections and learn to communicate.

Mudita cultivates delight with all its benefits for our psyche and perhaps also for our bodies without the delusion of attachment. Our baby's capacity for delight is still there, even though it might by now seem buried under tons of depression and anxiety. To recapture our *joie de vivre*, we need to reflect on what really nurtures us and make a deliberate attempt to appreciate all these.

The Mahamangala Sutta, which we chant last thing at night, gives the Buddha's list of things we can rejoice in. He places associating with wise companions first among the list of great blessings. If you have a meditation group, you're really lucky. Not only does it get you onto the cushion regularly, it also gives you the chance to discuss the Dhamma and how it applies to the many challenges in life. Trying to put our understanding into words really helps it sharpen. It can be uncomfortable as we only notice all our confusions when we try to put our vague notions into a string of words. But every attempt is worthwhile for both you and your friends. Together you can help each other sort through some of the confusions and let each person's unique perspective become part of the group wisdom. Try making the wish, may our happiness continue, may our happiness increase, whenever you meet up with your group.

The next on the list is residing in a suitable place, meaning somewhere that encourages and supports us in our practice. So certainly Satipanya fits the bill. But your own home can be conducive to meditation practice too. For some people, making a small shrine helps or setting aside a room for meditation. For me, the main thing has been to establish the habit of a daily practice. Over the years, this became more and more central to my life, a deep source of refuge. After a challenging day at work it was such a relief to know that in the evening I could close the door behind me and let meditation clean out the layer of fractious energy that had built up over the day.

So if we're lucky enough to have a home we have a deep reason to rejoice. Caring for our home, keeping it clean and tidy, and adding touches of beauty are also part of mudita practice, a way of saying thank you for this precious gift. Beauty might seem unnecessary. After all, we're cultivating equanimity, so why should we care whether things are drab or pretty? But that line of thinking is drawing us towards indifference

rather than equanimity. It encourages a don't care, doesn't matter attitude to the world, whereas true equanimity only exists within a deep care for the world. Beautifying our surroundings is a way to express that care.

It also shows sensitivity to the way the human body and psyche thrive on pleasure. The feelings we recognise as pleasant *vedanā* have a soothing effect on our bodies and mind. I imagine various hormones are released to calm our nervous systems. Why not give ourselves every opportunity for such benefits?

The Buddha appreciated beauty. In the Parinibbāna Sutta, which tracks the last stages of his life, we find him wandering from one shrine to another. Along the way, he says to Ānanda, "Come, Ānanda, let us go to Vesāli. Pleasant, Ānanda, is Vesāli. Pleasant are the shrines of Udena, Gotamaka, Sattambaka, Bahuputta, Sārandada and Cāpāla." In fact, he repeats this a number of times as he moves from shrine to shrine, as if the memory of their beauty meant a lot to him.

You can imagine the effort it would have taken for a dying man of 80 years to walk from place to place, and yet this is how he spent his last days. The way he kept repeating the list of beautiful shrines suggests their memory gave him energy for the journey. We can take this as encouragement to adorn our homes and whatever we value as supporting us in life.

And of course our home wouldn't exist if it weren't for all the supporting social structures around. Roads, shops, sewage pipes and electricity, as well as courts of law that uphold our right to lock the door behind us and meditate. Every aspect of the society we live in contributes something to the fact that we have time and space to practice, Dhamma books to read, Dhamma talks to listen to. Think of the enormous web of conditions that allowed Buddhist teachings reach our Western ears. Seeing things this way, any contribution we make towards society can be done in the spirit of *mudita*.

Say the water pressure drops and we have to get onto the local council to get it sorted. Generally, we think of this as a real pain in the neck. But just think of what a gift it is to have fresh water on tap. It was my mother's 90th birthday recently, and as part of this, she decided to write up the story of her life. When she was young, the family water had to be drawn from a spring in a boggy field a good distance from the house. And if you wanted it heated, it was a question of lighting the fire and pouring the buckets of water into a cauldron for a few hours.

Reflecting on how much extra time we get because of not having to walk miles to collect water from a well each day, this might bring a sense of gratitude into our dealings with the council. We might even take little shots of hope and joy away with us every time we get a helpful response.

Now of course you could argue that rejoicing in your local council and your home and meditation group is only going to lead to dukkha when these go the way of all earthly phenomena and eventually fall apart. That line of thinking represents fear of attachment, not wisdom. Our problem is that we're already deeply attached to our possessions, friends, activities, as well as to our social status as householders and therefore deserving of running water in our taps. Deciding not to rejoice in these won't help matters at all.

We only learn the art of non-attachment by experiencing the pain that comes when these things fall apart. So we might as well go through that pain for the sake of worthy attachments, like all those the Buddha suggests. And, as we get more and more involved in the meditation group, we'll find our buttons being pushed left, right and centre. All this shows us our attachment to personality styles, ideas of how the group should be run, interpretations of the Dhamma, preferences for meditation techniques and so on.

If we didn't put any effort into bonding with the group, we could just float in and out of the meetings, congratulating ourselves on our equanimity and raising our eyes to heaven when we hear squabbles among the more established members. But this is to mistake indifference for equanimity. We only learn true equanimity by putting our heart into our activities, making deep connections and bearing with any reactionary pain as part of our learning curve. Mudita helps us open our hearts to form those essential connections.

Next on the Buddha's list is the joy at having done meritorious actions. We easily miss this source of mudita. Say, for example, we help an elderly person cross the road. It would be very easy to dismiss this with words like, that was nothing, anyone would have done the same thing. But according to the Buddha, we are to rejoice at every good deed. We need to say well done to ourselves for any small act of kindness or generosity.

I found this really helped with my recovery from laryngectomy. I couldn't find any joy in my new state until it occurred to me to think of my role in life as someone who cared for a laryngectomy. I started to see every little thing I had to do, cleaning the various tubes, taking medicine, doing exercises, as acts of kindness for someone who had suffered laryngectomy. This gave me a new source of joy, and with that my self-confidence started to recover.

And when I recovered enough to be able to do a few things for others, these really meant a lot. It might just have been that I cut the veg for dinner or sorted through the recycling bins. Before the illness I wouldn't have paid much heed to these but after a long spell of being totally dependent I saw how much joy was on offer from being able to play a role in society.

Now of course we can get attached to our roles and get very uptight when we're not appreciated. But if we keep reminding ourselves that our motivation is kindness and congratulating ourselves for that kindness, this undercuts the attachment. Reflecting on the law of kamma helps with this. We shape our future happiness or unhappiness depending on the motivation for our actions. Acting out of kindness sows seeds for future happiness. Acting out of anger or meanness, sow seeds of unhappiness. Kamma is our only real possession in life. Everything else will fall apart in time. So we're looking after our future self really well when we do things out of kindness. And we can definitely congratulate ourselves for every good deed.

Further on in the Maṅgala Sutta, the Buddha includes supporting our families as a blessing in which to rejoice. There's so much involved in family life. All the daily chores of cooking and cleaning, educating children, caring for older parents. Can we make a practice of joy out of all this? For that, we have to spend quality time with our family, rather than let it all become a burden of hard work. Eating together is one way of expressing value for one another, and activities like sports, playing cards, scrabble, crosswords, going for walks, whatever pastimes your family enjoys.

If we're not careful, TV can be a mind-numbing escape from interaction. But we can also make it a focus for shared enjoyment, chatting about the programme like they do on Gogglebox. Remember, kamma is about motivation, not the activity itself. If our motivation for watching TV is to have some relaxing and enjoyable time with our family, we're on the right track.

To help with this, we can inject little *mudita* wishes every now and again. "May our happiness continue. May our happiness increase." Having said that, we have to take care that our activities don't violate the precepts. We can't justify watching pornography or sadism by saying, "May my happiness continue, may my happiness increase." So we have to choose forms of entertainment which stimulate wonder, for example, or humour, or understanding of human nature, or appreciation of skill, and so on.

So the Buddha isn't asking us to neglect our families, homes or society for the sake of enlightenment. Instead, we bring all these within the definition of what is our path, by appreciating them and adding to their beauty or joy wherever possible, while we remind ourselves that they cannot be relied upon for lasting happiness. So we can find

any number of occasions for *mudita*, but it can be quite a challenge because earthly joys don't last forever and because we can't own them or control them to any meaningful degree. It can be quite poignant. This is why *mudita* can be quite a challenging *brahma vihara*.

I sometimes find myself preferring funerals to weddings, for example. There is some comfort in knowing it's okay to feel and express sorrow, whereas there can be a confusing disconnect when sadness is felt but it's not the appropriate emotion to express. At a wedding, for example, if we're feeling depressed, the effort to keep smiling and making small talk can be quite wearying.

The ephemeral nature of joy means that like all phenomena, it fades away moment after moment. Unless we have a background level of peace within ourselves, the experience of joy fading away can be so hard to bear that we find ways of excluding it altogether. This process underlies the far enemies of *mudita*, which centre around jealousy for other people's happiness and disparaging our own sources of happiness.

Many myths and legends illustrate the destructive power of jealousy. In the Bible we have the first record of murder when Cain killed his brother Abel out of jealousy for the favour God showed to Abel. And a bit later, Joseph is set upon by all ten of his elder brothers who are jealous of the love their father showers on his younger son. And Snow White, remember, was cast out of the palace by the jealous queen who couldn't bear to be judged less beautiful than her daughter. All these stories go on to illustrate how jealousy destroys the one who harbours it. Cain becoming an outcast, Joseph's brothers suffering famine and imprisonment, and the wicked queen having to dance herself to death in red hot slippers at Snow White's wedding.

Shakespeare gives a graphic illustration of the self-destructive power of jealousy when Iago warns Othello: "O beware, my lord, of jealousy. It is the green-eyed monster which does mock the meat it feeds on."

These epic stories show jealousy in the form of murderous rage, but its power can also drive the drip-drip destructiveness of peevishness. In fear of their success, we denigrate our rival's achievement as worthless. Caught up in the throes of jealousy, their success implies our failure and the only way to relieve our pain is to belittle their achievement. To the extent that we're identified with our skills and talents, we're in danger of jealousy when another exhibits a similar talent.

If you read *Little Women*, you'll remember the night Amy burned her sister Jo's precious manuscript in a fit of jealousy. The 1950 Nobel Prize was said to have been offered to Thomas Edison and Nikola Tesla for their work in electromagnetism, but they both

refused to accept it if the other person was to be included. Jealousy can destroy any partnership, be it artistic, scientific, business or even religious. Devadatta's attempt to kill the Buddha being a prime example. Jealousy also ruins personal relationships. We want our partner to be totally bound up in us. If they enjoy someone else's company, we take it as betrayal. And of course, if they leave us for another, we're in an agony of hatred for both parties.

Practicing *mudita* for ourselves is a powerful antidote to jealousy. We build self-confidence by appreciating ourselves and especially every effort we make to create good *kamma* for ourselves. As we build our own sense of self-worth, we're less threatened by the talents or good fortune of others. Congratulating ourselves is in itself an exercise in *mudita*. It stirs joy and creates a healthy sense of ourselves as worthwhile. We need this healthy sense of self to sustain us on the path.

Sometimes we mistake the teaching on *anattā*, not-self, to mean that we shouldn't have any sense of self. So whenever we feel a sense of self, we condemn ourselves saying, "I shouldn't feel like this" or "I shouldn't be here." But the Buddha often uses the word "self" in a very positive way. For example, he says that if we truly care for ourselves we will practice the Dhamma. Let's face it, the teaching on *anattā* can be very confusing.

I like Bhikkhu Thanissaro's interpretation that sometimes the sense of self is appropriate and helps us along the path, and other times it leads to suffering. Our job is to get better and better at recognising whether we should let our sense of self help us do what we need to do, or whether it's one of those times when the sense of self is curling itself around some habit based on greed, aversion or delusion. In which case, of course, we need to let it go.

When our judgment tells us that what we're doing is wise, we strengthen the sense of self needed to follow through on the activity. But when we've done the activity and the self wants to do it again, and again for no good reason, then it's time to accept the truth of *anattā* and let that sense of self dissolve.

So the self is something to care for, according to the Buddha. The only thing we have to worry about is making the mistake of expecting it to give us permanent happiness. Like everything else in this phenomenal universe, it is temporary and contingent. But of all the temporary contingent entities we find here, the self is the most important, the one we must cherish most deeply. To practice the Dhamma is to care deeply for oneself. We give ourselves the gift of mindfulness moment after moment, asking nothing in return.

As you all know, this is a tough challenge. We fortify ourselves for this challenge by appreciating every good deed we do, thanking ourselves for every effort we've made to practice, congratulating ourselves for everything we do well. This is strengthening the sense of self that does wise actions. Just as an ideal parent would praise and encourage their child, we must do the same for our poor, downtrodden selves.

Denigration is less dramatic than jealousy, but also powerfully destructive. In fact, it's such a quiet form of negativity, we hardly notice it. What's happening is that we see the joy as too little to bother appreciating. So we disparage our incredibly good fortune of living in a peaceful society, having shelter and enough to eat. We rarely remember to be grateful for the gift of the Dhamma or having friends to practice with. We only appreciate our health when it's gone.

Denigration also destroys relationships. Belittling a child or partner is a powerful form of bullying. It keeps the other from flourishing. The belittled party comes to believe in their worthlessness. Their personality and talents wither. Lucy illustrated this perfectly in a Peanuts comic strip, saying, "The trouble with you, Charlie Brown, is that you're you."

Apart from the interpersonal level, we regularly extend our disparaging remarks to collective aspects of human endeavour, remembering only the failures of institutions, politicians, technology and society. This bespeaks bitterness, resulting from our repeated attempts to shut joy out of our hearts.

For some strange reason, we're often encouraged culturally to denigrate ourselves. "I'm no good at this. I always make a mess of things. I can't ever get things right." In one sense, it's a form of appeasement, a way of saying, "I'm not a threat to you." It defines us as one of the gang. If we see it in that playful way, just a form of social pleasantries, then it's not harmful. But to the extent that we're really convinced of it, we're damaging ourselves.

None of us would like to be thought of as a bully, and yet the self-disparaging remarks we make to ourselves are actually those of a bully. We are shaming ourselves rather than seeing the liberating truth of anattā, that I cannot be expected to get everything right because conditions are always beyond my control. We can start to undo the habit of self-denigration by practising mudita for ourselves, saying, "Well done," even just for putting on our shoes mindfully, of course.

The near enemy of mudita is excitement and excess. It's natural to get excited when there's something to celebrate, but indulging this only brings the inevitable downer when the party's over. Think of the excess around Christmas and weddings. The same

for other supposedly religious celebrations. In Ireland many families go into huge debt over First Communion outfits, for example. Even when we invite a friend to tea, we can go over the top in preparations.

We mistake the daft excess for *mudita* because we're so happy about the celebration. But the joy goes to our head and escalates. In this heady exuberance we lose all sense of proportion. And in the frenetic excitement things can go badly wrong. Rivalries flare on matters of style and taste and who should sit where. For all these reasons, celebrations can be more stressful than happy.

Excessive exuberance turns sour very easily. Think of the riots that can follow football matches. I know one sister who hasn't spoken with her brother since an incident at her daughter's christening. In some forms of illness such as bipolar depression, the high stirred up by the celebration can lead to depression afterwards.

The far enemies of jealousy and denigration shut out joy, while the near enemies of excitement and excess cling to it. For *mudita*, we need to find the middle way, opening our hearts to the good things in life, while also relaxing, taking it easy, not building things out of proportion. It's a tightrope. One moment we're singing someone's praises, next we've exhausted all our goodwill and we're hoping they'll get their comeuppance. Just being aware which side of the tightrope we've fallen off tells us what needs to be cultivated just now.

In formal meditation, we start off by thinking of someone who has something to celebrate. For example, become a parent or grandparent, got a new job, won a prize. We then wish that their happiness will continue and increase. One variant on the classic phrase that I like is, "I'm happy that you're happy." This usually makes me feel happy. You could also try a simple, "Well done." Or in some cases, "Thank you" might fit the bill. Use whatever phrase best sustains your sense of appreciation when you think of that person.

It doesn't matter if you can't think of a reason for celebration. Imagine them smiling at a joke or enjoying a book or having coffee with a friend. The simplest daily joys can form the basis for *mudita*. As with all the *brahma vihara*, the self can be a particularly challenging category. Remember that any way that your life is going well—family, professional, social, hobbies, physical fitness, meditation practice—has taken hard work and commitment and deserves appreciation.

Sometimes a very simple image works best for me. I picture myself petting the dog or scattering breadcrumbs for the birds and I say, "Well done."

If, when you offer mudita to yourself, you feel vanity surface, just note this. We need to learn to take a healthy pride in our achievements. Once we're mindful of vanity, it won't spiral into self-delusion. Similarly, if you feel yourself contracting in jealousy or heady with excitement, just note these, set them aside and continue. Take a few breaths between good wishes to help you keep a balance and perspective.

If jealousy becomes overpowering, try turning attention to your own successes instead, murmuring, "Well done" to yourself for these. An alternative that I often find helpful is to encompass the jealousy within a good wish such as, "May our competition bring out the best in us both," or if the jealousy is about a personal relationship I've used the wish, "May your love for others help me to love them too."

And as usual, if the near or far enemies or any other hindrances get so overwhelming that none of the remedies works, take a *vipassanā* break and only return to mudita when you feel more balanced.

I want to finish off with a few words about working with the near and far enemies in daily life. For example, we easily get overexcited about celebrations, especially if we're involved in the planning stage. Noting this is the first and at times the hardest step. We can be so caught up in our plans that we forget to be any way mindful. They just take us over. Sooner or later, we'll notice that we're going over the top. Then we have to find strategies to calm ourselves. Mindful breaths, mindful footsteps, mindful actions, all these help.

Also, take a moment to think of the event you're celebrating. Ironically, we easily forget this in the midst of all the fussing. If it's a birthday party, take a moment to bring the person to mind and wish them a happy birthday. Very often, this brings us back down to earth for a while.

Often we fuss about the arrangements because we want to impress people. If you think that could be the case, take time for some self-directed goodwishes as a means of bolstering a healthy sense of your own value and protecting you from going into great excess.

While excitement shows particularly during the planning stage, the far enemies tend to show up during or in the aftermath of the celebration. As host, we might feel peeved that people aren't more appreciative. As guest, we might be fed up pretending we're happy. And as the door closes, both parties may be thinking, "Thank God that's over." Celebration isn't easy.

Often problems come about because we feel we ought to be happy. This puts us under pressure, which in itself quells a lot of happiness. So remember that we don't have to feel happy to practice mudita. The fact that we've taken the time to mark the occasion is enough. We can keep reminding ourselves of this whenever we feel jealousy, boredom or irritation setting in.

Say we're at a graduation party. After an hour or so we get fed up hearing about all the courses and exams they passed and wish they had just dropped out after the first day. Any effort to be happy on their account sets our teeth on edge. Our practice has to start with the small stuff.

Although our heart has closed down at the thought of our friend's great achievement, we might still be able to enjoy the food or see the beauty of a flower arrangement, or we might get a little lift by listening to the music that's playing in the background. Ironically, even our misery can be a basis for mudita, as we say, "Well done" to ourselves for every moment we endure in our efforts to celebrate our friend's achievement.

I hope this talk has helped clarify the importance of joy in the spiritual path. In meditation we have the joy of *pīti*, which results from interest in the process leading to liberation. It's what keeps us coming back to the cushion, back on retreat, despite all the *dukkha* we witness there. In daily life we're sustained by mudita, by the joy that arises naturally when things go well for us.

We cultivate mudita by paying deliberate attention to anything that makes life pleasant, inspiring or easy and getting into the habit of saying thank you and well done many times every day. An especially important aspect of mudita is to rejoice in our own good deeds and every attempt we make to practice meditation and incorporate the Dhamma into our lives. Congratulating ourselves for all these builds up the self-confidence we need to follow the path to liberation.

May our efforts to cultivate mudita bring joy to our lives and to the lives of those we love.

Divine Abiding: Compassion

Noirin Sheahan · 43 min

In this exploration of karuṇā (compassion), Noirin Sheahan examines how mettā (loving-kindness) naturally transforms when encountering suffering, becoming compassionate goodwill without anxiety or aversion. Drawing on moving examples from the Buddha's care of sick monks and contemporary situations, she illustrates how true compassion maintains inner peace while responding with appropriate tenderness to suffering.

The teaching carefully distinguishes compassion from its near enemies—pity (which creates separation between helper and sufferer), grief (which paralyzes through overwhelm), and self-pity—as well as its far enemy of cruelty. Through personal anecdotes and practical guidance, Noirin shows how aversion underlies these obstacles and how mindfulness practice develops the non-reactivity essential for genuine compassion.

Offering practical methods for both formal meditation and daily life application, this talk provides essential guidance for cultivating one of the four brahmavihāra (divine abidings) with wisdom and skillful means, recognizing that opening the heart naturally brings up defensive patterns that can be worked with rather than eliminated.

Tonight I want to look at the way *metta* shades in tone when we come across difficulties. Metta itself remains intact. Our basis is wishing ourselves and others well. But the goodwill is expressed in compassionate terms with sensitivity to the particular situation.

Compassion is sometimes described as the trembling of the enlightened heart in response to the suffering of the world. There is deep sympathy with the suffering being and the wish that their suffering may come to an end. But there is no anxiety about the situation. This can be very difficult for us to understand. The enlightened being is in touch with a level of peace that is untouched by the suffering and can sustain a calm tenderness even when the heart is breaking or the body is being torn apart. Within the context of peace and tenderness anything can be born.

This is what Julian of Norwich learned when in revulsion at the sufferings of the world she heard the words "All shall be well. All shall be well and all manner of things shall be well." Compassion is the manifestation of wisdom in the face of suffering. It allows the suffering to elicit a response of tenderness and care without any hint of anxiety.

ety or aversion. Sustained by compassion, the enlightened person does not get in any way flustered by the situation and can respond appropriately. For example, caring for an injured being, finding words to comfort.

The Vinaya, the book of monastic discipline, includes a story of the Buddha and Ananda coming across a monk who had acute dysentery and was lying in his soiled robes. You can imagine the sight and the stench. The Buddha and Ananda cleaned the monk and his robes. Afterwards, the Buddha addressed the sick monk's fellows, clarifying that it was their duty to look after one another in case of illness. "Monks," he said, "if you don't tend to one another, who then will tend to you? Whoever would tend to me should tend to the sick."

Another part of the scriptures describes the Buddha finding a monk who had been abandoned by his fellows because of the sores oozing all over his body. His robes were sticking to him and again just imagine the stench and the sight of this man as he lay there abandoned and dying in agony. The Buddha boiled water and washed the monk with his own hands to clean off the pus. He similarly washed the soiled robes and waited until these were dry. Once the monk had been comforted, the Buddha talked to him of the Dharma, and as you can expect, the monk became fully liberated.

In both of these stories, the Buddha modelled a steadiness of heart that allowed compassion to flow where most people would retreat in alarm and disgust. At other times, compassionate action could take the form of warding off an aggressor. Sharon Salzberg tells the story of being attacked while in a rickshaw in India. She was badly frightened when she told her teacher Munindra-ji about the incident. He replied, "Oh Sharon, with all the goodwill in your heart, you should have taken your umbrella and whacked that man with it."

Compassion does not mean passivity. We can oppose injustice vigorously so as to prevent suffering. At other times there may be no appropriate action, no way to prevent or minimise the suffering. In those cases, just to stay nearby and witness the suffering is our only option and is a very precious gift. Simply staying with a suffering person, refusing to abandon them though we can offer no practical help, gives them the best possible opportunity to let their suffering open the door to wisdom. If we can take to heart the first noble truth that there is suffering, this opens the door to the other truths which liberate us from suffering.

Whether we are caring for a sick person, vigorously opposing injustice or witnessing some suffering we cannot prevent, we need to be able to resist the reactivity which comes up in the face of suffering. Such non-reactivity is learned every time we sit with difficulties during *vipassanā*: even a slight pain in the knee, the noise of machinery,

someone fidgeting nearby, a worrisome thought. All these are forms of suffering. As we learn to bear with these types of disturbance in meditation and their myriad spin-off thoughts and anxieties, we are cultivating the skills we need to respond compassionately in the face of deeper suffering in our own lives and in others.

True compassion has this non-reactivity as its basis. Even though we may be speeding around in an effort to cope with the reality, a compassionate hurry is motivated by care rather than alarm and is completely at ease with the situation. Barriers to compassion, as with all forms of *dukkha*, come back to reacting to our feelings. In the case of suffering, there will be an unpleasant feeling at the core and the automatic urge to get rid of this. In many real life situations, we won't have the level of calm concentration needed to recognise this very simple level of our being. We will be spinning such a complex story around the unpleasant feeling that we get hooked by the myriad emotions that the story generates.

The stories we tell ourselves at times of distress emanate from the perceptions of self. The notion that there is a substantial entity lodged somewhere in our body and mind. This self is, or should be, in control of matters.

Imagine you have a pet goldfish who swims quietly around in a tank in your living room. Today when you sprinkle some food into the tank, Goldie doesn't dart around after these nibbles as he usually does. He stays put at the bottom of the tank. Taking a closer look at him, you notice he's lost some of his lustrous colour and there are some whitish spots amongst his scales. By this stage there will be unpleasant feelings stirring, causing your face to frown and perhaps stiffening much of your body in tension. What happens next will depend on your habitual tendencies in the face of a perceived threat.

Let's say you're a leap into action type. A sense of yourself as powerful and resourceful will be established. A determination to save Goldie from peril. Although you have hardly given Goldie a thought for months beyond tossing a few grains of food into the tank from time to time, he's fast becoming your nearest and dearest and a sense of enmity is forming around those white spots on his scales. Your eyes narrow as you examine them. "Aha! Fungus!" Dear Goldie, attacked by rotten spores of horrid fungus, outrage and indignation. It's you and Goldie versus the microscopic world.

"Don't worry, Goldie," you whisper into the fishbowl before making a dash to the computer to search for solutions to goldfish spots. You pace about in consternation as it goes through its infuriating start-up routine. "Everything's going to be fine," you call, banging the keys furiously to get "white spots goldfish" into Google's search line. "Mummy's looking after everything."

What's happening is that compassion has got entangled with one of its near enemies, pity. Pity lets us feel superior to the suffering person. Goldie has been reduced to a pathetic entity that you must rescue and restore to health. There's a clear separation between me, the valiant saviour, and Goldie, the poor creature who needs me. In pity, we can also be suppressing our fears that exactly the same kind of suffering could be visited on me. Thus we can quietly despise a drug addict while outwardly sympathising with their plight. The experience of compassion, on the other hand, unites us with the suffering person. Our own heart trembles in resonance with their plight.

Pity so easily masquerades as compassion. It doesn't help that pity is listed as a virtue in many Christian texts. But in the context of the Christian virtue, the word pity is being used to mean compassion. The difference between the two is that pity includes aversion. We have generated a sense of enmity around the unwelcome sight of those white spots, which in turn evokes a sense of self to combat this enemy.

In our rush to rescue, everything that gets in our way is seen as the enemy: computer delays, an incoming phone call, the rest of our agenda for the day, the cat crying for her saucer of milk. These are all irritating demands on our time which is urgently needed for poor little Goldie. And when our trawl through the websites convinces us that most fungal problems result from unclean water, we ourselves become the enemy. We berate ourselves angrily, trying to remember the last time we changed the water. Later, as we scrub and scour the tank, Goldie, in his replacement bowl, can also become the enemy. "That good-for-nothing fish putting me to all this trouble."

While compassion has goodwill as its basis, pity adds a big dollop of aversion to the mix. It's very easy for compassion to slide stealthily into pity when we are caring for someone who is ill. With compassion we can see the sick person's strengths as well as their illness. We respect them fully and value their friendship despite their reduced state. When compassion slides into pity we sense ourselves as strong and resourceful, the other as needy and weak depending on us. Whenever there's a very clear dividing line between yourself and the person you're caring for, it's likely that pity is emerging.

Like attachment, pity is a normal aspect of human relationships. It gives us energy and motivation to look after vulnerable people. But it's destructive in the long term. In subtle ways, we might even be preventing the other person from recovering. We fuss over them, trying to anticipate their every need. We sympathise profoundly with every complaint. We counsel against taking any risks, never mind what the doctor says. "Doctors don't understand." All of this excessive caring drains our energy. In our low mo-

ments we resent the sick person and we see ourselves as the victim of their neediness. The aversion has now found a different outlet. Instead of the sickness being the enemy, the sick person has turned into the enemy.

To complicate matters, the sick person often reacts against the aversion underlying our pity. They resent being reduced to the role we are creating for them, the needy person. In their low moments they hate us for so clearly showing them their dependent status. Pity breeds resentment in both parties.

When we see ourselves as the injured party, self-pity is a common reaction. Suppose we valiantly scrub out Goldie's tank and replace it with sparkling clean water. We do this daily for a week. But still Goldie isn't recovering. The spots are getting bigger and the food is still untouched. What started out as aversion to the spots now grows to encompass aversion to all the work I'm doing for no reward. "It's all so unfair. It's not just Goldie who is injured." We've joined him and feel ourselves as the injured party. The only comfort is to sympathise with ourselves.

We run through the story from our point of view and insist again and again that we're doing absolutely everything right and how unfair and awful it is that there's no good coming of our hard work. Sympathy feels pleasant and we cling to it, unwittingly prolonging and deepening the injured party role and nursing a victim mentality. We start telling all our friends about our plight, eliciting their sympathy. Goldie, who for months went quite unnoticed, becomes the centre of our lives.

Instead of being the spring-into-action type, let's suppose your habit when faced with suffering is to crumple in grief. So when Goldie refuses his food, you stare at him in dismay. When you notice the white spots, your worst fears are confirmed. "He's a goner." Your head hangs in misery until someone or something helps you snap out of it, leaving Goldie to his fate. While pity can spur us into action, grief takes the suffering so deeply inward that it paralyses us. We mistake grief for compassion because we want the suffering to stop, but we overlook the role aversion is playing, distorting our perceptions, overstating the problem.

I remember one time when I was sitting on a park bench watching a group of pigeons pecking at some food on the ground. I noticed that one of the pigeons had lost his toes on one foot. That leg ended in a bulbous stump and rather than walking he was hopping from place to place on the other foot. "Oh no," I thought, "how awful." Inwardly I was writhing and my face was wincing. I would have sworn that I was feeling the pigeon's pain. I had noticed that before, the belief that I could feel the pain of other beings when I saw their physical wounds. But I had never questioned this belief as my attention was always so fixed on thinking about the awfulness of their situation.

However, this time I registered the belief and started to wonder about it. How could I possibly be feeling the pigeon's pain? It didn't make any sense. I don't have any special powers of that nature. I closed my eyes, took a few deep breaths and vowed to let mindfulness sort it out. It took a while and I went through a lot of fear and confusion. But after a while it was as if a veil lifted and I realised the pain was in my own body. It was simply an unpleasant tingling at the base of my spine. Once I could locate the pain, it became quite bearable. My mind stopped amplifying it and projecting it onto the pigeon. After a few moments, I hardly even noticed it.

I opened my eyes again, and this time when I looked at the pigeon, I noticed how well the pigeon was coping with his lameness, how he was managing to hold his own and get at some food. I saw that he was actually quite plump and healthy looking. Within this more hopeful scenario, my spirits lifted and with this came a simple wish that he come to no harm on account of his injury. Instead of feeling awful about him, I felt respect for his plucky attitude and grateful that he had taught me a worthwhile lesson. Since then, I've never been quite so overcome when seeing a person or animal with a physical injury.

When we are grief-stricken in the face of suffering, aversion is colouring the whole scene. We can only think in negative terms about the suffering person, about ourselves, about the future. We've taken one instance of suffering and magnified it out of all proportion, just as I was doing in the case of the pigeon. This paralyses us. We've become so bound up in suffering that we have no resources left to add anything positive to the situation, not even a good wish. A child stands by in mute misery as their sibling is punished by an enraged parent. We look away from our bereaved neighbour, feeling anguish on their behalf but not knowing what to say.

When grief gets overwhelming, we can go into a state of shock and even denial. A friend told me of her meeting with her cardiologist. When he told her she would need open heart surgery, she looked around to see who he was talking to because she knew it couldn't possibly be her.

C.S. Lewis's book *A Grief Observed* gives a very honest and poignant account of the moment to moment experience of grief. The book was written from a journal he kept during the first weeks and months after the death of his wife. It opened with the statement, "Nobody told me grief was so like fear." His perceptive inquiry showed him the fear underlying all the thoughts and emotions resulting from her loss. He needed company but dreaded when the spotlight was turned on him. "Why can't they just talk to

one another but not to me?" His book gives many insights into the development of compassion and equanimity by means of his scrupulous and honest track through the suffering of bereavement.

To develop compassion we need to learn to feel our fear without buying into the thoughts and perceptions it suggests to the mind. It can motivate us to sit through knee aches and itchy noses when we remember this. As we learn to disentangle the knots of confusion that emerge in reaction to these, we are freeing our capacity for compassion in response to the inevitable sorrows of life.

Grief, pity and overwhelm are examples of the near enemies of compassion. We sympathise with the suffering person and wish to relieve the suffering. But the very thought of suffering gives rise to these reactions. At the opposite extreme of reactivity we have cruelty which is the direct opposite or far enemy of compassion. Cruelty shows up in circumstances where we feel threatened and need to defend ourselves. Anger arises and energises us to overcome our enemy. But then the anger sticks around even in victory, compelling us to twist the knife. Cruelty prolongs the other's suffering and enjoys the power that enables us to do this.

Cruelty can take the form of bullying, where the more vulnerable person is physically or emotionally abused by the bully. We regularly read of abuse of animals, children, the elderly and those with mental and physical handicap. A recent academic review reported that if a physician was seeing 20 elderly patients a day, then at least one of these was likely to have been abused in the previous year.

A recent probe into abuse of mentally handicapped adults in a care home in Ireland showed patients being treated with quite casual cruelty, refusing their requests to be taken to the toilet, being made to sit in their own urine, being slapped when they made a disturbance. And a few years ago, the UK Secretary commented that cruelty had become the norm in some health and social care institutions.

Lots of cruelty is not from willful glee in the suffering of others but because we neglect to examine what is happening. As a society we tolerate widespread abuse of animals in factory farming and when they are transported on long journeys for slaughter. Even as vegetarians how often do we think of the suffering of cow and calf separated from each other so that we can enjoy our dairy milk and cheese. If fish could cry out, would we still be fishing as a peaceful recreation?

As against so many instances of cruelty in our society, there are also outstanding individuals and institutions that oppose cruelty and treat the vulnerable with care and respect. Many voluntary organisations look after animal welfare. There are hospitals and

care homes which don't hit the headlines but do quiet, often heroic work to care for the sick and the handicapped. Web-based pressure groups get millions of signatories daily in an effort to prevent injustice. All such efforts bear witness to the innate human quality of compassion, the antidote to cruelty.

Hopefully none of us seriously committed to the Dharma will be involved in overt brutality. But cruelty can show itself in subtle ways. Does a sarcastic remark slip out now and again? Do we indulge daydreams where the boss gets his just desserts? When someone we dislike is losing an argument, are we secretly gloating, cheering on the opponent? When caring for a vulnerable person is our tone of voice at times chosen to show how idiotic we think they are? Or do we take it out on ourselves, chiding ourselves savagely when things go wrong?

Because most of us are conditioned to view cruelty as appalling, it's very hard for us to admit to cruelty. It helps to remember the Buddha's assertion that the basic problem is ignorance, not understanding the nature of suffering and how to bring it to an end. Because of this, we make all kinds of mistakes in trying to shield ourselves from pain. One of these mistakes is cruelty.

After the fall of Nicolae Ceaușescu in 1989, the media probed into conditions in many Romanian orphanages. I remember one image in particular, a little boy of about two, hitting his head repeatedly against the bars of his cot. His face was cut and bruised and someone was trying to restrain him, but the moment they let go of his head, he would bang it forcefully against the bars again. I think he gave us a graphic image for the innocent mistake at the basis of cruelty. As I see it, he senses the world as awful and naturally tries to find a way out. Because he can't change anything else in his environment, he turns on himself. Banging his head against the bars gives him a sense of control. The sense of control is gratifying, probably his only source of pleasure, so he keeps it up. This is self-inflicted cruelty. But the child is not inherently cruel. He just can't find any other way of asserting himself.

Similarly, our moments of cruelty do not make us a cruel person. For that moment we take the only pleasure we can envisage in the situation, delight in prolonging suffering. When conditions change, we can be kind and caring.

Because we tend to judge cruelty as appalling, we find ways of denying or justifying our subtle cruelties. For example, the phrase, "there is no other way to deal with them," can quickly dismiss the person and cover over our harshness. That kind of blanket justification is what allows institutional abuse to flourish. A culture of brutality can grow

around such simple slogans. Such thoughts harden our hearts against whoever we are dealing with. In the stress of the situation, we are denying their humanness and vulnerability, their need for understanding and love.

When we are being cruel, we delight in the misery of the suffering person or animal. By contrast, pity and grief lock us into some identity with the suffering state. The challenge is to find a balance, to open our hearts to suffering without taking on the role of perpetrator, heroic saviour or victim. At times compassion flows naturally. But then the suffering touches a deep core within and we sense ourselves taking one of the reactionary roles. We're suddenly flooded with aversion or overcome with anxiety and can't find any way back to the easy flow of compassionate goodwill. We need to be patient with our repeated encounters with the near and far enemies and find ways of working alongside these rather than expect them to disappear.

To cultivate compassion the classic phrase is, "May you be free from suffering," but vary this if it helps. For example, "May you have a peaceful death. May you not despair. May you not be troubled by little things." Use images if these work better than words. Some people like to visualise a healing light flowing into a person. Others like to imagine the healing as emanating from their own breath. Remember, it doesn't matter if you don't feel anything. What matters is the wish that suffering will stop.

In formal meditation it's best to start with someone who you know is having a hard time and then go through all the various categories of people, not forgetting yourself and ending by radiating in all directions. It helps to take a few breaths so as to relax between each good wish.

Directing compassion at the difficult person is often a challenge. Don't be surprised if the far enemy emerges and you find yourself thinking, "Well, they deserve it," and gloating gleefully at their plight. This is part of the purification process. Even if we don't behave in overtly cruel ways, the practice of compassion can show up our deep fears where cruel retaliation seems like our only defence. Glimpsing our underlying savagery can be quite dismaying.

One teacher told me that the deeper we go in meditation, the more clearly we see that we have the seeds of all things within us. The child molester, the schoolyard bully, the rapist, the murderer. Our job is to recognise these urges, see them in the calm light of wisdom and decide not to follow them because they lead to suffering. Our usual reaction of self-judgment is a second arrow which deepens the suffering rather than relieves it. The more practice we get at letting go of the second arrow, the more easy it will be to feel the enticement towards cruelty and contemplate this calmly.

Where do these urges come from? In my own experience, I sense cruelty as a refusal to forgive. Deliberately shutting my heart to myself or others gives me a self-righteous glow. But if I look carefully at that glow, there is a shadow side, the sneer of the tyrant.

To give an example, I ordain when I come here to Satipanya, but then go back into civvies when I am at home in Dublin. I also wear a wig to cover up my bald head. I haven't told many people in the family as many of the older generation were brought up in a strict form of Catholicism and I reckon they wouldn't be cheered up by the thought of having a Buddhist nun, even just part-time one, in the family.

As you can guess, the inevitable happened. My aunt came to visit for a few days. I was in my room getting ready to go to bed. I had taken off the electrolarynx and the wig when I heard her knocking at my door. I couldn't tell her wait a moment because the electrolarynx was at the other side of the room. I just managed to grab the wig when I saw the door open and her head appearing around to ask whether she could take a sandwich. For a second she gaped at me in horror while I glared at her in fury.

I was infuriated at the invasion of privacy, leaving my bald head suddenly exposed and my own powerlessness to say anything in protest. I barely managed a curt nod to indicate she could take all the blasted sandwiches she wanted so long as she got out of my room fast.

Although I was very angry, mindfulness let me watch the process play itself out and after a while I was able to giggle at the humour of the situation and see that she had meant no harm. When I could manage to forgive, I felt the welcome relief of friendliness and the wish to meet with her and explain all.

But then a deeper tangle showed itself. How to explain my attraction to ordaining as a Buddhist nun within what I anticipated as her abhorrence at the idea? In an instant friendliness was replaced with an image of myself fully wigged up, haughtily asking her not to enter my room until I answered the door. It would have been so easy to ignore the note of cruelty in this, painting it over with a thought like, "That's what she deserves for being so rude."

But because I could sense the glow of power as I clung to that haughty image, I recognised the underlying cruelty and had to admit that this wasn't exactly in keeping with my aspirations as a Buddhist nun. With that, the journey towards forgiveness resumed, and the following morning I was able to explain that I was now enrobing when I'd come to Satipanya. The conversation went through a few ups and downs, but ended with her telling me of a sorrow she bears in regard to her own religious life. Thus we ended with a sense of mutual understanding and compassion.

One great advantage of being able to recognise and work skilfully with our own urges towards cruelty is that we can start to understand and forgive cruelty in others. We can practice compassion even for tyrants whose cruelty has caused horrendous suffering in the world. No longer so horrified by our own feelings of cruelty, we can imagine their world and feelings and the feelings that drove them. We can take them to heart and wish that they find forgiveness for their deeds.

Sometimes when we feel our own cruelty, the second arrow of self-judgment brings on anxiety. This is the flip side of cruelty, fear. Suppose a bully is taunting his victim. The glee comes from the thought, "This is happening to you, not to me." But bullies can't maintain their superiority forever. Sooner or later, perhaps in sickness or in old age, they have to admit their vulnerability. Knowing what can happen to vulnerable people, they are petrified. Think of how much reassurance you would have to give that person before they would dare to trust you. That is the amount of reassurance we need to give ourselves when we catch a glimpse of our underlying urges towards cruelty and shrivel back in fear of ourselves. If we can keep reassuring our inner bully that they will only meet with kindness and forgiveness, then any urge towards cruelty can be transformed to the response of compassion.

Before finishing this section on working with cruelty, let me say a word about self-judgment. We have to be careful just to note this impartially rather than reacting and thinking we shouldn't be so judgmental. When we can calm down and see things impartially, such judgment can even become an ally. Guy Armstrong, a renowned Vipassanā teacher, tells how he found it impossible to forgive someone for their behaviour until he saw the element of cruelty in his anger. His self-image revolted against the notion of himself as cruel and this persuaded him to forgive the person. So in this case, his conditioning to censure cruelty served him well. Within the light of wisdom, all our emotional habits can be transformed so that they can help us along the path.

At other times when you bring a suffering person to mind, you might find yourself being pulled towards pity. For example, getting lost in plans or worries about how you could help. Or you could find yourself getting overcome by grief. Recently, a meditator described how he would become saturated by a kind of horrified anxiety when he was practicing compassion for the refugees trying to find their way into Europe. Or your mind may just go blank and refuse to engage. This is another example of grief. In this case, grief has led to overwhelm. These are all instances of the near enemy of compassion.

Try to simply acknowledge and continue knowing that the emergence of the enemies near or far just indicates that we are ploughing new depths in our heart. So we don't have to be discouraged by them or start judging ourselves because of them. Smile at them if possible and soldier on. We're not interested in how we feel, remember, but in the wish that suffering be alleviated. So we can put these feelings to one side and focus on the good wish. Similarly, for any of the hindrances, acknowledge and then re-engage with the compassion practice.

If self-judgment, pity or any emotions become overwhelming, experiment with self-compassion. "May I be free from self-judgment. May I be free from pity. May I be free from grief." Or add in some *mettā*. "May I be happy and confident and free from self-judgment." And so on.

Radiating compassion is quite a challenging practice. In ordinary life, our hearts have so many clever tricks to stop us from acknowledging suffering. In compassion practice, we do the opposite. We ask ourselves to think about the suffering of our friends, our benefactors and all other categories of people.

We need to remind ourselves that in compassion, as for all Brahmavihāra practice, we always try to make things as easy as possible for ourselves. Look for the route of least resistance in the heavenly direction and be prepared to experiment. For example, it often helps to switch back to *mettā* regularly and think of the person in happier circumstances. Or try putting a hand on your heart to steady yourself.

I often prefer to work on compassion while walking rather than sitting and when the going gets tough it often helps to look around, not at people but at surfaces and furniture and to touch surfaces as I pass them by. This practice, remember, deliberately brings suffering to mind. So it can bring up deep fear. Looking at surfaces and touching them helps reassure me of the basic goodness of the world.

If the emotions become overpowering, then I take a Vipassanā break, acknowledging the emotion without any attempt to generate goodwill.

Finally, let's look for a moment at how we practice compassion in daily life. Any effort to alleviate suffering is also a practice of compassion. For example, feeding the birds, looking after a sick friend, contributing to good causes, campaigning for human or animal rights, safeguarding the environment. If we have hurt someone, we could apologise and see if there's any way to make reparation. To practice self-compassion, we could make time for an activity we enjoy like swimming, yoga or music.

The near and far enemies will also surface in daily life. The attempt to engage with vulnerable people may show us how callously we feel towards them, how easily we get exasperated by their limitations. As in meditation, acknowledge and continue. Remember, the opening of the heart naturally brings up these defence mechanisms. The experience of callousness could indeed be welcomed as a sign we are moving beyond our comfort zone.

At the other extreme we might be fussing anxiously about them. Here we need to restrain ourselves and if we feel overwhelmed by the situation we need to extend compassion inwardly. This may mean simply wishing ourselves well or we could reinforce the wish with a caring gesture.

May we find ways to comfort and encourage ourselves through every obstacle as we develop true compassion.

Divine Abiding: Equanimity

Noirin Sheahan · 45 min

In this retreat talk, Noirin Sheahan introduces the brahmavihāra (divine abodes) meditation practices, focusing particularly on equanimity (upekkhā). She explains how these sublime states complement vipassanā practice, with equanimity serving as the wisdom-based foundation that prevents attachment in our cultivation of mettā, compassion, and sympathetic joy. Drawing from traditional Buddhist teachings, Noirin distinguishes equanimity from its near enemy of indifference and its far enemy of reactivity. She offers practical phrases like "all beings are owners of their kamma" and "may we each find our own paths to peace" for formal practice and daily life application. The talk explores how equanimity allows us to maintain loving relationships while respecting others' autonomy and bearing life's inevitable changes with grace. Noirin emphasizes that equanimity, rooted in wisdom rather than feeling, enables us to acknowledge difficult emotions without being overwhelmed by them, creating the spaciousness needed for genuine compassion and appropriate responses to life's circumstances.

So far in this retreat we have been discussing Vipassanā meditation, especially as described in the *Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta*. For the next few days I want to talk about another approach to meditation described by the Buddha. This is termed *Brahmavihāra* practice. The term *Brahmavihāra* can be translated as a sublime state or more poetically as a heavenly abode.

Here is a passage from the Buddha's teaching on the *Brahmavihāra*: "Here monks, a disciple dwells pervading one direction with his heart filled with loving kindness. Likewise the second, the third and the fourth direction. So above, below and around. He dwells pervading the entire world everywhere and equally with his heart filled with loving kindness. Abundant, grown great, measureless, free from enmity and free from distress. Here monks, a disciple dwells pervading one direction with his heart filled with compassion, likewise the second and so on as before." The next verse repeats this for a heart filled with appreciative joy and the final verse repeats it for a heart filled with equanimity.

So in this form of meditation we are not simply observing our experience but deliberately filling our hearts with kindness or compassion or joy or equanimity and radiating these throughout the world.

Some teachers argue that there is no need to practice Brahmavihāra because Vipassanā naturally cultivates these sublime states. In support of this approach there is the fact that the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta does not include a contemplation of the Brahmavihāra. So this form of meditation is not a necessary component of the direct path to enlightenment.

Other teachers put great emphasis on cultivating goodwill and the other sublime states as the attitude needed in order to practice Vipassanā. In support of this there are many teachings the Buddha gives on the importance of goodwill and I'll mention some of these over the coming days.

So how can we bring these views together? Very often the attempt to fill the heart with loving kindness will show us how difficult this is. And so we have to cope with frustration, perhaps a sense of failure, confusion or anger and other ways the hindrances show up when we find our wishes are being thwarted.

When this happens, I found a great relief in the fact that Brahmavihāra meditation isn't included in the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta. So I feel perfectly justified in relaxing any effort to generate goodwill. Instead, I sit back and let Vipassanā acknowledge and explore these negative reactions.

But I've come to value reflections on goodwill and the other Brahmavihāra as a way of softening my Vipassanā practice. The two approaches complement each other well. The more often we make the effort to cultivate the Brahmavihāra, the more often this new habit will be expressed quite naturally in Vipassanā. Thus the observer is often watching goodwill, compassion, *mudita* or equanimity being cultivated quite naturally and without any deliberate effort in this direction. Vipassanā becomes a relaxed kind of Brahmavihāra practice.

In formal Brahmavihāra practice there is the extra effort to bring about wholesome states of mind but running parallel with this is the observation of whatever emotions are coming up. Then the effort can be softened or stepped up so as not to be overwhelmed by the negative states. Thus the two practices support and complement one another.

Coming back to whether or not we need to practice the Brahmavihāra in addition to Vipassanā, I follow the approach taken by Bhante and other teachers and think of Vipassanā as my main practice, but augment this with short stretches of Brahmavihāra practice, just as we do at night here on retreat. In daily life, the main emphasis is on putting the Brahmavihāra into action. This effort being supported by mindfulness and continually tailored to suit the particular situation.

The Brahmavihāra describe the enlightened heart's relationship to others. Goodwill, *mettā*. Compassion, the Pali term is *karuṇā*. Appreciative Joy, *muditā* in Pali and Equanimity, *upekkhā* in Pali. For this talk I'll use the Pali term *mettā* since that is so widely understood and also *muditā* instead of Appreciative Joy as that's a bit of a mouthful in English. But I'll just use the English words for Compassion and Equanimity.

The Brahmavihāra are the orientations of mind and heart needed to respond appropriately to the ups and downs of human relationships. If we can summon these states at will, we can always be in perfect harmony with others and with whatever circumstances we find ourselves in.

As a basis, we have *mettā*, or good will. We want all beings to be happy and well. This is the default. Goodwill applies in all situations. If we find a friend in any sort of difficulty, goodwill takes on the shade of compassion. We empathise and wish their suffering will end. On the other hand, we can find them bouncing with good news. Goodwill takes on the hue of *muditā*. We are delighted for them. If they get involved in another relationship and don't have much time for us, goodwill takes on the form of equanimity. We respect their boundaries and their independence and wish them well in their new life.

The first three have the effect of opening our hearts to others, while the latter provides the balance required to prevent a slide into over-attachment, dependency and other dangers of close relationships. I'll be saying more about each of the Brahmavihāra later and over the next days but first I want to go over the formal meditation practice which is identical for all four.

Here again is the Buddha's description: "He dwells pervading the entire world, everywhere and equally, with his heart filled with loving kindness, abundant, grown great, measureless, free of enmity and free from distress." This is a very exalted state he is describing, which can inspire us deeply. But there is a danger. We will let our imagination be transported to a heavenly realm in a delusive way, clinging to a notion of heavenly bliss which has me as the source of all, as I liberally bestow my good wishes on all around.

To make the practice more real and grounded, we usually start with wishing well to real individuals. These are the various categories of people we think of in our regular *mettā* practice. Ourselves, a benefactor, close family and friends and so on. We start with whoever most easily stirs our friendly feelings.

For many people, this is someone who you think of as a benefactor. This could be a parent, brother, sister, uncle, aunt or grandparent. It could be a teacher or a friend. It could be a favourite pet. Or you could focus on a public figure you admire like Gandhi, Nelson Mandela, Aung San Suu Kyi. It could be an author or poet whose work you love. Or you could use a spiritual figure, the Buddha, Kuan Yin, Jesus, Mary or any of the saints.

You can use different benefactors for different Brahmavihāra. For example, the person who best evokes *muditā* might not be the person who best evokes compassion. For *muditā*, you would want to be thinking of someone who has something to celebrate. while compassion is most easily stirred when we think of someone going through a tough time.

Then there is the often tricky business of offering ourselves good wishes. Sometimes we think of this as selfish, but this is a misunderstanding. Selfishness means clinging tightly to whatever we desire. In Brahmavihāra practice we are generous with our good wishes. We are giving without expectation of return. So too we wish ourselves well without building that into an expectation of what form the future will take for us. It's like the marriage vows, for better and for worse, for richer and for poorer. We are developing an attitude of unconditional support for ourselves in all circumstances. This is not selfish, it is the essential psychological basis for living a good life.

Often we feel we don't deserve any good wishes, that we only deserve to be miserable. What's needed here is self-forgiveness. We can remind ourselves that whatever wrongs we've done they've happened in the past. They don't have to shape our future. We can't become the good person we feel we ought to be unless we are willing to believe in our potential for goodness and encourage ourselves in that direction. Paradoxically the times we feel most unworthy of good wishes are the times we most deeply need them.

At other times we might feel all buoyed up and confident about wishing others well but that it's a waste of time wishing ourselves well. We're fine, we don't need any good wishes. What's actually going on is that we're denying our vulnerability. We're running on willpower, suppressing any suggestions of neediness or frailty. What's needed here is a combination of self-compassion for the underlying feelings, the *muditā* for the streak of self-confidence that is keeping us going.

All in all, the self can be the hardest of all categories for Brahmavihāra practice.

When we come to the category of close friends it's best to choose someone with whom we have a warm relationship but don't feel a romantic or sexual attraction. The problem with those attractions is that they easily stir strong emotions that swamp our simple goodwill. I'm saying simple because it needs to be a pure giving without expectation of return. It's a straightforward good wish like, I hope all goes well for you.

If we feel romantically, sexually attracted, we're very likely to want the person to think only about us. We're not that interested in the rest of their lives. So our good wishes are a kind of net we're trapping them inside. Though our minds might be saying, may you be happy, our heart is secretly whispering. May you love and adore me because I have your best interests at heart and no one will ever love you as I do. Though we may be able to sustain this focus for a long time, all we are doing really is to strengthen the bonds of attachment, not of goodwill.

This is one of the toughest aspects of Brahmavihāra practice. To keep our good will simple and pure with no strings attached. The particular divine state that helps us with this is equanimity. And I'll talk more about that later this evening.

For the moment, let's leave this category of close friend by saying that if you sense that a pure, more disinterested attitude of *mettā* has established itself in your mind, then at that point you could start to include those for whom you feel romantic or sexual love. You'll then be able to feel the shift towards possessiveness and know the danger.

The difficult person category presents a different challenge. This time the emotions being stirred up are of the aversive type. Anger, condemnation, irritation, fear, hatred. It's best not to start with our worst enemy, but practice on someone who we find irritating for some reason. It could be easier to start with equanimity style good wishes such as, may you not harm yourself or others, before switching to *mettā* style wishes like, may you be happy.

When we've gone through the various categories of people, we then start radiating spatially as the Buddha suggests. Again to keep this grounded in reality we usually start with our immediate surroundings like all of us under the same roof. Then we gradually widen the circle to our neighbourhood, country, continent and the whole world before encompassing all beings in all directions.

Each Brahmavihāra is associated with what are termed its near or subtle enemies and its far or direct enemies. The far enemy is the polar opposite of the divine abode, hatred, cruelty, etc. The near enemy can easily be mistaken for the truly divine abiding, attachment being mistaken for *mettā*, pity for compassion.

Much of the challenge in Brahmavihāra practice involves learning to recognize and work around these enemies as well as all the usual hindrances, wandering mind, aversion, sleepiness, etc. While Vipassanā asks us to turn attention directly on the hindrance, Brahmavihāra practice asks us to try to minimize their disturbance. For example, if we get uncomfortable, we don't try to sit it out as we might in Vipassanā. We just make ourselves more comfortable. Similarly, we switch back to the least challenging category whenever we get swamped by an enemy. In a sense, we dodge around the challenges and look for the line of least resistance, and we trust that perseverance will eventually establish the good habit as our new default.

Let's explore the difference between Brahmavihāra and Vipassanā meditation practices a little further. In Vipassanā, the ultimate aim is to cultivate wisdom. We're following the Buddha's quest to find a way to live happily in a world that includes the decay and death of all we love. We're looking for an escape from stress and suffering. So in Vipassanā we look directly at whatever takes our attention in order to see its transient unsatisfactory nature and that it's not within our power to control. It is not me or mine. This way of seeing gradually undercuts our habitual attachments. As wisdom deepens the heart is purified of greed and hatred. In a natural, unforced way, the Brahmavihāra are strengthened. It also gives us glimpses of what might not be transitory or unsatisfactory. We're learning to escape moment by moment from the limitations of being bound up in the world. To the extent that we have loosened the bonds of attachment and aversion, we are free. And freedom, we find, allows a natural friendliness to emerge whenever we think of ourselves or others.

In Brahmavihāra practice we are taking a different tack. We are letting our current level of wisdom be expressed in the form of good wishes for ourselves and others. Think of a lake from which a river flows to the sea. The lake represents wisdom and the river represents goodwill. In Vipassanā the lake is being filled with streams from the mountains. The lake is open, receptive. It doesn't matter whether the streams bring down muck and rocks from the mountains as well. The water lets them all pour in and that's all that matters. In the clear open space of the lake the rocks do their rocky thing and sink to the bottom. The muck floats around for a while, releases some of its water before the solid particles filtering down into the bed.

In Brahmavihāra meditation the lake is overflowing its boundaries and pouring itself into the river. At the boundary of the lake and the river there is a bank of rock and muck. At times the lake waters are high and overflow this bank effortlessly. This is when goodwill emerges naturally and easily without any opposing emotions. At other times the bank is showing through but the lake waters are powerful enough to be sweeping through the muck and rocks in its way. This is when we are putting an effort

into our Brahmavihāra practice, refusing to let ourselves be overcome by whatever emotions are emerging. We're breaking down the banks separating the Lake of Wisdom from the River of Goodwill.

After a while the water level drops to where the bank is more entrenched and firm. The lake waters have to be patient and find little chinks in the bank through which they seep through to keep a trickle of river flowing. This is where we're working very sensitively with our emotions in Brahmavihāra practice. We're dodging around the tight knots of aversion or desire, loosening them a chink here and there. Although it's hard work, we're eating away at the foundations of the solid bank, separating the lake from the river, separating our wisdom from its natural expression of goodwill.

When the lake can't get any flow at all through the bank, it has to wait till it fills up again from the mountain streams. This is when we decide to take a Vipassanā break in our *mettā* practice to get some clear space around whatever emotions have been thrown up.

In Vipassanā, we are receptive and open, exploring everything without judgment. Anything goes. In Brahmavihāra practice we're on a mission. We're putting all our energy into goodwill. We're not interested in the shape and texture of what gets in our way. We're only interested in finding a way around it.

Let's look for a moment at some of these rocks that can block up the channel between the lake and the river. Our minds keep wandering or we fall asleep or the enemies keep showing up. The temptation is to compound the problem by thinking, I'm such a rotten person, I can't even wish my best friend well. This is a dead end. We're unwittingly undermining our goodwill by self-criticism.

The teaching on *anattā* can help here, which says that there is nothing permanent or substantial in what we normally think of as our individual being. Our feelings, emotions, etc. shift and change with circumstances. So the wandering mind, the emotions of the various enemies that emerge, none of these are mine. None of them constitute me. They come and go depending on conditions.

So instead of blaming yourself, think about the conditions and whether anything could be changed. Would it help to look at a flower, a candle flame, an image? Does goodwill flow more easily when there is a chant playing in the background? Maybe it helps to lie down. Can a gesture help, like putting a hand on your heart? Don't be afraid to experiment. This is another form of *mettā* practice, learning to be kind to ourselves during the frustrations that show up in Brahmavihāra challenges.

One of the conditions that undermines goodwill is fear of failure. The term divine abode can set up high expectations that in themselves bring up the fear of failure.

We forget that what we are doing is a practice aimed in the direction of divinity. I suffered from that problem for many years until I accepted that working tenderly with fear of failure was in fact a fully acceptable *Brahma-vihāra* practice. *Mettā* took on the shade of compassion as I turned toward the fear and found some way of expressing support. The very simple gesture of stroking the back of my hand helped enormously. Although I was feeling small and incompetent, the *Brahma-vihāra* was being expressed as willingness to accept and work with that. An image of petting a scared puppy also helped.

Remember, we don't have to feel friendly, compassionate, joyful, equanimous to practice the *Brahma-vihāra*. As the saying goes, it's the thought that counts, or at times the gesture, like stroking the back of our hands. This simple gesture gradually reassured me that my own goodwill was genuine and reliable and that I didn't have to feel inadequate. *Brahma-vihāra* practice became much easier when I knew I could turn fear of failure into a practice of compassion.

So far we've been looking at the formal practice, but of course relating to others is a huge component of daily life. So we need to let our *Brahma-vihāra* practice on the cushion find its way into everyday situations. Again, the default is *mettā*. We can make friendly good wishes in all situations. Watching or listening to the news is usually an opportunity for *mettā* to shade towards compassion. If we're stuck in a crowd of cheering football supporters, we can wish that their happiness will continue, even through gritted teeth. This is *mettā* in the shade of *muditā*. If a friend refuses to listen to our advice, we can remember that they are free to choose their own path in life and wish them well with whatever they choose to do. This is *mettā* in the shade of equanimity.

We can also monitor our mood and respond appropriately. In all situations, we can wish ourselves well. When our mood turns sour, we can take a moment to acknowledge and comfort ourselves as best we can. This is a practice of self-compassion. When we do anything well or someone compliments us, we can take a moment for *muditā*. If we find ourselves worrying unduly about someone, we can remind ourselves that they have their own lives to live and that they have all the resources they need within themselves for perfect happiness. This is the practice of equanimity.

We can also bring our activities into our practice. As we're switching on the TV, we can wish that this will help us feel more connected with the world or help us relax and let go of the stresses of the day. If we're taking a snack, we can wish that this might uplift us and give us the energy and joy we need to carry on. As we're going to meet a

friend, we can wish that the encounter will help us both feel happy. Before we go into a meeting, we can wish that the business will benefit all concerned with our work. Whether we are cooking, teaching, repairing machines, emailing or visiting a friend, all of these can be dedicated to our own and others' welfare.

That has given a general introduction to *Brahma-vihāra* practice. For the rest of this talk and over the next evenings, we look more closely at each of the four divine abodes. I want to start with what's usually left to last, equanimity. The reason I'm starting here is because it's the *Brahma-vihāra* most closely associated with *vipassanā*. Also it helps with overcoming the enemies of the other *Brahma-vihāra*. We've already met with equanimity in the factors of enlightenment. In our wild geese analogy, equanimity was the bird with the wide open wingspan, steadying the rest of the flock through the ups and downs of the journey. When we're looking at *Brahma-vihāra*, we're seeing how that steadiness can come to our aid and be expressed in our relationships with others.

In everyday language, equanimity is described as mental and emotional stability and composure, even under duress. Equanimity is born of wisdom. It is the imperturbable balance of mind that follows from insight into the true nature of reality. When we understand that letting go of reactivity to pleasure and pain brings peace, we will no longer be so foolish as to react angrily to disappointments or excitedly to life's enticements. In the face of interpersonal relationships, equanimity sustains us through the loss of loved ones, rejections, insults, seduction and so on. With equanimity, we can acknowledge evil and danger and take appropriate care without blaming whoever is presenting the threat. Similarly, equanimity lets us enjoy all the benefits of knowing intelligent, delightful people without idolising them or clinging to them in a needy way, fearful of rejection.

Equanimity is often confused with tranquillity, which is a felt sense of calm and peace. But equanimity itself is rooted in wisdom, not in feeling. With equanimity we might feel angry, upset, confused, but we will not act from these feelings. We will bear with them, knowing that just bearing these feelings is the path to deeper wisdom and therefore deeper happiness and peace.

Equanimity develops as we learn to let go. Consider any of the major steps in life. A child's first day at school, graduation, 21st birthday, marriage. In all these, a new phase of life opens while the previous one is lost. Often the grief of loss goes unacknowledged in all the excitement and so the father still nags his 50-year-old son about spending too much money and the 60-year-old daughter worries whether her mum will like the dress she plans to wear for her retirement party. Equanimity allows the sorrow within each milestone to be acknowledged. Our grip on our old parent-child roles loosens. The

child finds parenting skills within themselves. The parent discovers their own childlike joys. Each sees the other in a new light with more gratitude and respect and less expectation.

Just as we need to let go of parent-child roles and demands, each relationship in life requires us to adapt to ever-changing circumstances. Our best friend moves abroad. Our sister dies. Our spouse asks for a divorce. These are harsh examples, but in minor ways the bonds of friendship are tested every day. Equanimity provides the spaciousness of heart and mind needed to accommodate all the hurts, misunderstandings and disappointments inherent in human relationships.

Equanimity also keeps us calm throughout the ups and downs of our internal life. It gives us a wider perspective on our needs, fears, ambitions and dislikes. We can feel our moods going down without shrinking into despair. And if we wake up soaring with confidence, we are delighted. But don't zoom into ambitious plans and firm commitments, assuming this is the real me and that we'll never have a moment's misery for the rest of our lives.

The analogy of space is a good way of picturing equanimity. The space doesn't react when daggers and bullets fly through it. Neither does it curl up around sweet cakes, hoarding them against the intruders. Space accommodates pleasant and unpleasant, good and evil. The far or direct enemy of equanimity is reactivity. If equanimity is like space, reactivity is a hard surface that things collide into, exploding on impact. We want things to fit in with the expectations and patterns we feel safe with. When this doesn't happen, the external world hits our wall of reactivity. This hurts. Shrapnel flies all around and others get hurt too, often setting off a chain reaction.

We build walls of reactivity in an attempt to shut out people who push our buttons. We dismiss, ignore or belittle their approaches. They resent this and poke at us again and again in retaliation. With every hurt we reinforce the walls. We're tense even when they are miles away because the thought of them isn't miles away. We carry our enemies around with us. Likewise, when we idolise someone, we unwittingly build walls of reactivity around them. Every word they say, every move they make impacts us deeply. This ends up stifling the relationship. Neither party can breathe freely.

The near or subtle enemy of equanimity is indifference. We mistake indifference for equanimity because we don't feel any way disturbed by others. They can be in a rotten temper but we are able to shrug it off. What they say doesn't matter to us. We barely notice them. Indifference is actually another wall we build in an effort to shield ourselves from the potential for hurt in human relationships. Although things pass us by without impact, others feel our indifference as coldness and rejection. We can't em-

pathise with people who are bereaved or having a relationship break-up. We wonder why they can't just forget it and get on with life. And when a major calamity strikes us, we can't relate to our own confusion and upset. We keep all the emotional turmoil hidden with denial. We can't reach out for help because we don't even know we need any help. Indifference in its quiet way can be just as destructive as anger both for ourselves and for our relationships.

The classic phrase used to develop equanimity is all beings are owners of their *kamma*. An understanding of the law of *kamma* forms the basis for wise relationship. Ultimately, happiness is a habit of mind, the fruit of good *kamma*, meaning speech, actions and thoughts motivated by kindness and wisdom. The *Brahma-vihāra* cultivate happiness, while speech, thought and deeds motivated by ill-will, greed, delusion cultivate unhappiness. An angry retort or spiteful remark can give us a temporary feeling of power but the long-term price is a damaged relationship and a guilty conscience. Happiness rests on a clear conscience and universal goodwill.

The aim of repeating the phrase all beings are owners of their *kamma* is to give us a wise perspective to see that happiness is each person's own responsibility. But *kamma-saka* is a very loaded phrase. It could help to break it down. May I accept the fruits of *kamma* to help us bear with the difficulties and we can wish the same for others. On the positive side we could wish may I sow only good *kamma* for the future to help us develop new habits leading to happiness and we can wish the same for others.

If the whole notion of *kamma* seems foreign or confusing, here are a few alternative suggestions. May we each find our own paths to peace. I find this helps, especially when I'm anxiously worrying about a friend. Perhaps they are, in my view, taking a wrong turn. They have ignored my perfectly reasonable and wise advice and are going to do things their own way. Damn them. To counter the mix of anger, indignation and anxiety, I repeat, may we each find our own paths to peace. Till I can smile at my deluded insistence that I know the way out of everyone's troubles.

Very much related to this is the phrase, May my wisdom guide me and your wisdom guide you. It's especially useful after a disagreement. When I find myself repeating my opinions to myself over and over again, I switch to that phrase. It helps me acknowledge the wisdom of my viewpoint in a healthy way that leaves room for the very tiny possibility that the other person might have some wisdom too. In time, I again begin to smile at my arrogance and might even begin to see the other person's point of view.

When someone pushes a button and I feel myself rising up in anger, the phrase, may I not react to your behaviour, saves me from making the situation worse. It pulls attention back to myself on what is in my long-term interest. Anger, on the other hand, pulls

my attention outwards towards the other person and all that I find horrid about them at that moment. By repeating, may I not react to your behaviour, I am reminded that my primary business in life is to follow the Eightfold Path, and saves me from making a whole lot of unnecessary bad *kamma*.

When there isn't any particular difficulty that I'm trying to combat, the phrase, may I trust my Buddha nature, helps me generate equanimity within myself. I then extend this to others with, may you trust in your Buddha nature. All of these phrases evoke the understanding that we are each responsible for our own happiness and we each have all the resources needed for perfect happiness.

At times, very simple reassurances like, it's all okay, take it easy, give us a measure of tranquillity to help us through a challenge without making things worse. Later we can try some of the wisdom phrases suggested above, so as to distil the wisdom from the difficulty.

In the case of formal equanimity meditation, it often works best to start with *mettā* for one of the easier categories and then switch to whatever phrase evokes equanimity. If you're feeling somewhat emotional or out of sorts, it may be easiest to generate equanimity in the categories we usually leave to last in the other *Brahma-vihāra*. For example, all beings, everyone in the world and gradually work towards home. It's a question of experimenting to see what works best.

If grief, anger or other forms of reactivity show up, don't be surprised. This is a natural part of the purification process. We're experiencing the *dukkha* of close attachment and the difficulty of letting go and acknowledging the other as an independent being. If possible, continue with the practice, simply noting the reaction without giving it any close attention. If it gets overwhelming, switch to an easier category for a while. If the reactivity persists, try self-equanimity. For example, may I find my own path to peace? Or, it's all okay. If your mind won't focus and keeps getting lost in thought without any strong underlying emotion, then it means the near enemy is surfacing. Switch to *mettā* until you again sense a connection with the other person. Then return to the phrases for equanimity. And if the disturbances continue to overwhelm, switch to *vipassanā* to acknowledge whatever emotion is emerging. When the storm abates somewhat, it might be possible to go back to wishing equanimity for yourself or others.

Finally, let's look at some opportunities to develop equanimity in daily life. If a friend lets us down, our partner takes us for granted, our child refuses to listen to advice, a phrase like, may I not be disturbed by your behaviour, prevents us digging a pit of anger or self-pity and reminds us that we need to protect ourselves from bad *kamma*, which would follow from reacting unskillfully.

Any parting requires equanimity, if it is to be properly acknowledged. Making our small goodbyes meaningful prepares us for the major leave-takings in life. Likewise, new beginnings need equanimity. When we start a new project or relationship, we can easily get lost in a sea of false expectation. The phrase, this too will come to an end, gives us some perspective.

We can also practise equanimity in regard to our moods. May I bear this *kamma* willingly? Could help us through the lows. While may I enjoy this without expecting it to last? Can help us through the highs. We could reflect to see what things we get very uptight around. Work, family, some project or hobby. To develop a sense of balance around these, we can tell ourselves, take it easy whenever we feel ourselves going into overdrive. We support equanimity when we let go of busyness in favour of relaxing activities. For example, going out for walks in the open air, cups of tea, stretches, bathing, looking out the window. Whatever gives distance and perspective supports equanimity. *Vipassanā* practice naturally cultivates equanimity. So we should definitely find time for a daily *vipassanā* meditation.

In summary, *Brahma-vihāra* meditation allows the wisdom we gain through *vipassanā* to be expressed as love and care for the world. Three of the *Brahma-vihāra*, *mettā*, compassion and *muditā*, work on our natural desire to connect with others. However, until we are fully enlightened, our love for others will be mixed up with our own needs for security. To help disentangle the knot we have the *Brahma-vihāra* of equanimity. This divine abode rests on the knowledge that each being is responsible for his or her own happiness. We cannot live other people's lives for them. We must keep remembering to let go of others and prioritise our own spiritual needs. This focus on our own path makes us more open and honest with others, which is in itself a very important aspect of kindness.

With equanimity, we allow more space in our close personal relationships and we can bear to take the sufferings of the world to heart without being overwhelmed. May our work with the *Brahma-vihāra* let our wisdom transform to loving relationships with all beings.

Divine Abiding: Goodwill, Mettā

Noirin Sheahan · 41 min

In this retreat talk, Noirin Sheahan explores mettā (loving-kindness or goodwill) as the foundational practice among the four brahmavihāras (divine abodes). She examines the Buddha's teaching that mettā should embody the unconditional care of an ideal mother for her only child—altruistic, universal, and free from expectation.

The talk addresses the far enemies of mettā (ill-will, anger, self-blame) and near enemies (attachment, neediness), offering practical guidance for working with these obstacles in formal meditation and daily life. Noirin discusses the integration of mettā with vipassanā practice, emphasizing that the sincere intention matters more than feeling states.

A significant portion explores the Buddha's teaching on kalyāṇamitra (spiritual friendship), where he tells Ānanda that admirable friendship constitutes 'the whole of the holy life.' Noirin examines how dharma community supports our practice and the challenge of recognizing and emulating virtues in our spiritual companions. She concludes with guidance on devotional practice—developing a personal relationship with the Buddha as the ultimate spiritual friend.

I want to continue the exploration of the four divine abodes, which in Pali are known as the *Brahma Vihara*. The focus tonight is on *metta*, which is the basis for all the *Brahma Vihara*. *Metta* is often translated as loving kindness, or more simply as goodwill. It can also be described as inoffensiveness and non-harming. In positive terms, it describes an open-hearted attitude, warmth, friendliness, benevolence, care.

The analogy the Buddha gives is the ideal mother's love for her only child. She's totally devoted, giving attention and affection without expecting anything in return. She forgives misbehaviour instantly and harbours no resentment. That is the ideal we have to aim at. Quite a challenge.

True *metta* is based on altruism rather than mundane self-interest. It is universal, applying to strangers, animals and other beings, as much as to ourselves and our closest family and friends. To those who have wronged us as much as to those who have cared for us. When the heart is filled with *metta*, it brings out the best in us and others. Life seems simple. We smile, we're interested in the other person, we're easily pleased, we speak and act benevolently in any company.

Fall from grace only comes when we perceive others or the world as threatening. All of our spiritual practice is aimed towards understanding that our essential nature cannot be threatened. When we are fully enlightened, *metta* will be our natural state. Till then, *metta* practice helps us coax and cajole ourselves in this direction.

So we don't have to feel happy and benevolent to practice *metta*. It's the kindly thought or act that counts, not the feeling. We can feel miserable, but still do our best to make things pleasant and easy for ourselves and others. It is said that the Buddha taught the *Metta Sutta* to monks whose forest dwelling was also the home of evil spirits who were trying to frighten them away with noises, visions and stinking orders. So when the monks started practicing *metta*, they were probably feeling scared stiff rather than any way kindly. Nevertheless, the spirits began to calm down and eventually to worship the monks as their benefactors. *Metta* softens not only our own hearts, but also the hearts of those around us.

The far enemy of *metta* is ill will, which can manifest in many different hues and intensities. Mild irritation, impatience, exasperation, despising, fear, blame, hatred and all the way up to murderous rage. Its expression depends on personality and circumstances. Sometimes there is an explosion of anger. Sometimes anger is more contained. Coldness, withdrawal, sulking, refusing to cooperate. It can be expressed openly or more subtly. Sighing heavily, grimacing, speaking ill of the person behind their back, undermining them.

All expressions of anger, open or subtle, endanger our relationships. Well-meaning friends become wary of us and may lose touch altogether. On the other hand, anger attracts people with a negative disposition, who then further exacerbate our own ill-will. Negativity escalates as tit for tat reactions spark between quarrelling parties. It can spread like wildfire and turn into chronic feuds and gangland violence. On a large scale we end up with the atrocities of war.

Ill will can also be directed inwards towards ourselves. We blame ourselves for our lack of success, our financial problems, our poor health and all the other *dukkha* in our lives. This might not get us into trouble that goes with outwardly directed anger, but it can be equally destructive for our well-being. As there is no effective opposition, we can hammer ourselves black and blue without any reprimand. Over time, habits of self-blame can lead to chronic anxiety and depression. We are afraid of our own judgement and feel completely hopeless about life.

The near enemy is attachment. In this case, we are clinging to the other in a needy way. It could be great passion, the beloved becomes the centre and meaning of a person's whole existence. It could be a mother over-protecting her child. At a simpler level, most human relationships involve some degree of anxiety about keeping the relationship on friendly terms.

Attachment can manifest in a variety of ways. We might worry about our beloved's relationships with other people, jealously guarding our own share of their time and affection. We buy them gifts, delightedly anticipating their gratitude. If they go on holidays, we secretly hope they'll miss us. We chatter inanely, anxious for their interest and approval. While attachment is a normal aspect of human relationships, we need to be careful not to foster it. If it gets out of control it damages the relationship. The needy person neglects their own development, projecting all their inner goodness and strength onto the other, who in turn feels burdened by those projections and needs.

Metta meditation is a powerful antidote to all the miseries described above. Here we wish ourselves and others well in four areas of life. Basic safety, physical health, mental well-being and social working family life. The phrases are some variant on may you be safe, well, happy, living in harmony with the world. We direct these toward all the categories described last night.

If the phrases don't work for you, then try to imagine the person in a happy situation. Alternatively, the breath may carry an embodied sense of goodwill. Almost as if you're blowing up a balloon of goodwill with each breath. Again, this is completely valid as a *metta* practice.

All the hindrances we experience in *vipassanā* can emerge in *metta*. Wandering mind, dullness, doubt. In the first instance, we just acknowledge these and bring our attention back to generating *metta*. Remember what we said yesterday about dodging round the hindrances. Some of these dodges we've already learnt in *vipassanā*. Opening our eyes, standing up for dullness and lethargy. Calming ourselves for a few breaths for the wandering mind, restlessness and worry. If the hindrance persists, we switch attention back to the easiest of the *metta* categories and re-establish goodwill before re-connecting with the more challenging category. Basically, do whatever you can to make things easy for yourself.

Perhaps the greatest challenge is when all our grudges reappear the moment we think of a person. Even our best friend, or else we start worrying what they think of us. This is quite natural. It's part of the purification process. Keep reminding yourself that there doesn't have to be a feeling of loving kindness. It's the willingness to keep trying

that counts. If you keep getting carried away into angry, anxious thoughts, direct *metta* towards yourself in the shade of compassion. Example, may I be free from ill will or may I be free from anxiety? Stay with this for the full session if needed.

What is more troublesome is when the near enemy goes unnoticed. We're wishing everyone well, heart soaring with goodwill, but subtly identifying with that sense of goodness and friendliness. We might only notice the problem afterwards. We're beaming radiantly at our family over breakfast. But when someone makes a snappy response, our bubble bursts. The fall from grace can be very sore and bring out the worst in us. Suddenly we hate everyone. If you notice this pattern, try taking it easier during *metta* practice. Allow a few breaths between each good wish and be sensitive to feelings of friendliness. Acknowledge and appreciate them. Then they can energize and strengthen your *metta* without leading you into delusion.

It helps to keep in mind that we're not practicing *metta* in order to feel good. Feelings come and go. What matters is that we're willing to gently nudge our attitude towards goodwill in all circumstances.

On the opposite end of the spectrum, we can judge our goodwill to be so paltry that we believe we're not really practicing at all. This is self-doubt, doubting our own powers of goodness. It underlies the fear of failure we spoke of last night. In the first instance, just carry on regardless of any belittling comments you hear. Perhaps you can smile at them or insist, this is enough, I will not despise my goodwill offering. Try putting a hand on your heart or any gesture you find supportive.

If that doesn't work, try self-compassion, reassuring yourself over and over of your essential goodness. Just as the ideal mother would reassure her only child. Alternatively, shade the goodwill towards equanimity, encouraging yourself to take it easy and don't believe self-doubts belittling judgments. Instead, see this meditation session as a deep purification.

If none of the suggested remedies for the near or far enemies is working, then switch to *vipassanā*, acknowledging whatever emotion is coming up. And don't think of any such session as a failure. It's a very central and necessary part of *metta* practice to know when to call a halt and switch to *vipassanā*. A successful explorer will often say that their most precious quality wasn't determination or strength, but the ability to turn back when things were too dangerous.

Metta practice is a deep exploration of the heart. It shows us how threatened we feel deep down, due to our confusion about ultimate reality. When our *metta* can no longer dodge and dive around the demons we've unleashed, we need to respect their power and listen to their story in *vipassanā*.

In daily life we cultivate *metta* in acts of friendship, making someone a cup of tea, taking time to visit, or we could join a local club, donate towards a community project. In all cases we need to keep reminding ourselves that our actions are for our own and others' welfare. Otherwise we can easily slip into attachment, being friendly so that we'll feel good or that people will like us and then getting a shock when our expectations aren't met. That shock can lead on to resentment and other manifestations of ill will. Altruism is quite a tough practice.

I remember my first clear seeing of this. I was on retreat and noticed a hammer had been left in the garden. Probably someone forgot it after doing some work. I picked it up and brought it back to the tool shed. I noticed how strongly I wanted to leave a note explaining where I'd found it and what I'd assumed. But I also felt the neediness underlying this. Basically, I wanted them to know how caring and kind I was. It seemed like such a waste just to leave the hammer back without getting any recognition for my good deed. But luckily, I had the sense not to encourage my neediness, and I sadly left it back with no note and no mark of recognition.

After that it was easier to spot the bonds of attachment in almost every so-called good deed. Just seeing was the really important thing. Then I had a choice. I could cut out whatever aspects of my good deed were really about getting praise and recognition. I could acknowledge the sense of loss in all this and I could make the good wish even though this was usually with a tight grimace. This is an example of how *metta* brings up the near and far enemies.

If we find ourselves anxiously anticipating our friend's next words, we need to acknowledge that this is attachment and step back to regain our equilibrium. Perhaps we just go quiet for a while directing *metta* towards ourselves. Or we might need to remove ourselves physically to avoid the temptation to seek reassurance or otherwise burden them with our needs. Caring for ourselves builds up the confidence needed to overcome emotional dependency. We do this in a very deep way when we devote time to meditation. But every activity, washing, dressing, eating, working is part of caring for our human life. But we need to remind ourselves that our motivation is kindness. Otherwise, these easily slip into autopilot and emotional self-neglect. May I take care of myself happily is a good phrase to remember as we go about our daily activities.

This can bring up another shade of the far enemy. For myself, the practice around eating has shown up a lot of guilt. If I find myself looking in the cupboard for a snack, I prefer to do this without any reflection rather than say, may I take care of myself happily. The reflection brings up all kinds of questions like, do I really need this? Should I be having this? Isn't this self-indulgence? At first, the only way I could deal with the situation was to close the cupboard door and go without that little perk. And I'd feel pretty bad for having even tried to take a snack. But then half an hour later, I'd be munching my way through the biscuits anyhow. The desire would have slipped through and got me to the cupboard.

After a bit of reflection, I started experimenting with mindful indulgence as a way of working more skilfully with the desire and guilt cycle. I needed to plan a few treats, which were obviously not just for the sake of nourishing the body, like cheesecake and ice cream. I would eat it slowly, pausing whenever the guilt surfaced, letting it ebb away into a good wish for my own happiness. And when the treat was over and the guilt would be persuading me to be very judgmental about my unnecessary indulgence, I would instead thank myself for having given myself this little perk to cheer myself up. Gradually, this has undermined the automatic guilt which surfaces around pleasure. I can more willingly resist unnecessary treats and feel grateful that my better judgment overcame the habit of desire. And I can more easily admit that if I'm feeling a bit low, a biscuit or maybe cheesecake and ice cream will cheer me up.

So in daily life we need to find skilful ways of working around the patterns of ill-will that so easily manifest. Rather than expect too much of ourselves in the *metta* department, in daily life the attempt to practice *metta* can also get twisted around to ill-will when we identify with the feeling of *metta*. We want so much to think of ourselves as kindly and benevolent. But when people who push our buttons show us that we're nothing of the sort, then we fly into a rage at the most petty remark. So now we have a new reason to hate them. It's the old problem of identity. If we start bringing me, a benevolent person, into the equation, we end up in trouble. We need to keep reminding ourselves that until we're fully enlightened, we will become all kinds of different characters depending on the situation.

The rotten-hearted, fizzling with rage me is our reminder to cultivate self-care. When our nearest and dearest have managed to push that button and we are on the verge of a blazing row, for example, it's usually best to beat a hasty retreat before we say anything to worsen the situation. If we say something nasty, which of course seems perfectly justified in the heat of the situation, it ends up making things an awful lot harder for ourselves. The Buddha put right speech amongst the three steps on morality in the Eightfold Path. This may be because most of us involved in spiritual development

would think carefully before thumping someone or doing any physical deed that would harm them. But harmful speech comes out so, so easily when we feel threatened. It can slip out before we've had time to think. The tongue like a sharp knife kills without drawing blood is an ancient Chinese proverb.

It helps to have a stock phrase in mind like, I can't think clearly about this right now, I'll get back to you later. Then we go off somewhere quiet to let ourselves fizzle out. When we've calmed a bit, we often feel the sorrow underlying our bout of rage. Often this is linked to the truth of *anattā*, showing us how little control we have over others and even over our own emotions. Although the facts are, as you have heard a thousand times before, the feeling of not being able to control that which we care about always challenges us to the core. Rather than give out to ourselves about our limitations, we need to learn to offer ourselves *metta* in compassionate terms. For example, some comforting gesture like stroking our hand and reassuring ourselves that it's all okay. Eventually we may be able to tune into the basic humanity of whoever it was that angered us and wish them to come to no harm.

Let's come now to look at the Buddha's teachings on the value of spiritual friendship, or *kalyāṇa mitra* in Pali. One teaching starts with Ananda remarking that this is half of the holy life Lord, admirable friendship, admirable companionship. Buddha replied, don't say that Ananda, don't say that. Admirable friendship, admirable companionship is actually the whole of the holy life. When a monk has admirable people as friends, companions and colleagues, he can be expected to develop and pursue the noble eightfold path.

At first sight this seems a bit odd. The Buddha is more often heard advising people to withdraw to some secluded place to meditate. Now here he is telling Ananda that friendship, companionship is the whole of the holy life. Sounds great, doesn't it? Maybe we can just hang about chatting while the Dharma somehow filters in. But the Sutta doesn't end there and in the next paragraph the Buddha is back to his more usual form. And how does a monk who has admirable people as friends, companions and colleagues develop and pursue the Noble Eightfold Path? There is the case where a monk develops right view dependent on seclusion, dependent on dispassion, dependent on cessation resulting in relinquishment.

Right view is the first part of the Noble Eightfold Path and he says the same about all the other parts. So we still have to do all the usual hard work. But the point being made here is that the work is done in the context of friendship. This emphasises the humanity

in the Buddhist teaching. Too often we hear words like seclusion, dispassion and think of the path as a solitary, antisocial, lonely affair. But here he is placing human friendship as the essential frame for all our work.

He describes a friendship we need for spiritual life as admirable and gives this definition. And what is meant by admirable friendship? There is the case where a lay person in whatever town or village he may dwell spends time with householders or householder's sons, young or old, who are advanced in virtue. He talks with them, engages them in discussions. The language gets complex from here on, but the gist of it is that the person emulates the best in each of them, copying the generosity of the generous friend, the wisdom of the wise friend and so on. Basically, we are to seek out virtuous friends, find the best in them and copy that.

If we are lucky enough to have a Dharma group, we already have a source of admirable friendship. This is such a wonderful gift. I found a meditation group in the mid-1980s and over the past 30 years they have become my best friends. When we chat about our various challenges and inspirations in life, we end up framing this in the context of the Dharma. So quite naturally our attitudes, speech and lifestyle have become better aligned with the Dharma just by spending time in each other's company.

Now let's look at his specific advice to seek out the best in each of our friends and copy that. At one level that happens naturally. In any group you get norms for behaviour. So if getting drunk every night is a badge of honour in your friendship group, then you'll probably feel odd, even a bit ashamed if you're not a drinker. And the Buddha counsels against making unwise friendships like these, saying they are a drain on our resources. But amongst our wise friends, generosity, caring for others, going on retreat or daily meditation practice might be badges of honour. So our own behaviour naturally tends to move up towards the group norm. So our goodness rubs off on one another at a subconscious level.

Can we also bring that to the level of conscious choice? Can we actively seek out what's most admirable in our friends and copy that? Certainly we can. Though we might often run into obstacles on the way. Ireland, for example, has been described as a nation of begrudgers. We seek for the downside in every success story, the cloud behind the silver lining. To the extent that a begrudging cultural norm rubs its way down to each of us, we find it hard to trust and value goodness in our friends and even in ourselves. So the Buddha's advice is of valuable balance in any cultural tendency to suspect the worst in everyone.

To take an example, I have some wonderful friends who have a greater capacity than me to smile at human weakness, not get too hung up about it. My own tendency is to get depressed when I hear someone's making a mess of things. And when I see my friends smiling, I can find myself wondering, Do they have no sympathy? We've talked about this at various stages and I completely trust that their smile is based not on a lack of sympathy but having a wider perspective on the situation. To put it in Dharma terms, you could say that they see the first noble truth in action, that life involves suffering, but trust that the other three will eventually save the day.

The effort I've had to put into understanding and trusting their perspective illustrates how hard it is for us to value virtues that we haven't developed strongly in ourselves. Much easier to ignore these or even quietly dismiss them as a vice rather than a virtue. For example, my tendency to interpret their smiles as lack of sympathy. Recognising a virtue that we haven't developed strongly ourselves is hard enough, but copying it is even harder.

My laryngectomy operation was a case in point. My friends were better able than me to see in perspective. A huge loss, yes, but not a major disaster. This allowed them to care for me very effectively and incredibly generously throughout the whole episode. At times, though, my sense of the situation was that all the goodness had gone out of life. I just couldn't understand how they could be happy. It felt like treachery.

In meditation, as I tried to bring their smiles into consciousness, a knot of tension would gather and I would recoil in agony. All my aversion was projected outwards onto them, seeing them as uncaring and even cruel. But with the practice of dropping the thoughts and noting each emotion, I would eventually unwind into compassion for my sorry state. In the kindly gaze of compassion, I could admit that the basis of all this turmoil was nothing to do with my friends at all. Instead, it was aversion to having lost my voice.

With that admission, I could begin to see the value of moving on, accepting this new situation, working with it as best I could. At that stage, their smiles were seen as friendly and encouraging, and in my mind's eye, I could stretch out my hand gingerly towards them, let them lead me into my new life.

So the Buddha's advice, find the best in your friends and try to copy it, is extremely valuable but very challenging. It brings up vanity, the way we cling haughtily to, I'm better than you, as our inner begrudger dismisses their virtue. Or as we collapse into the despair of I'm worse than you and we curl up into a ball of jealousy. Or we cling tight to the pleasant notion of we're just the same as our imagination pulls them into our gang. People we can understand and feel easy with.

All of these, the Buddha says, are forms of vanity clinging to the notion I am. But this clinging doesn't do us any justice. We're trying to define who we are, fit ourselves into a box when in fact we're continually evolving and changing. We're on our journey to the end of suffering. It doesn't matter whether our friends are more or less developed, only that they're willing to help us along our path and we're willing to accept their help. And vice versa. That we're willing to help them. Any practical help must start with goodwill. Otherwise we'll end up trying to impose our supposed wisdom on them. So we bring them into our hearts in *metta* practice. The basis for spiritual friendship.

I want to close with the final part of the Buddha's conversation with Ananda. And through this line of reasoning, one may know how admirable friendship, admirable companionship is actually the whole of the holy life. It is in dependence on me as an admirable friend that beings subject to ageing have gained release from ageing. He goes on to say the same about death, sorrow, lamentation, pain, distress and despair. Before concluding, it is through this line of reasoning that one may know how having admirable friendship, admirable companionship, admirable camaraderie is actually the whole of the holy life.

Here the Buddha is inviting us to reflect on his life and the many people who have benefited from his teaching, and thus to develop gratitude and admiration for him. This is a bit hard to put with his teaching of not-self. If nothing in his phenomenal being had any permanent substantial essence, what is it we are admiring and being grateful for? Although we can't identify a permanent essence with anything tangible about the Buddha, we can acknowledge that his dedication to finding an escape from *dukkha* and teaching others what he discovered had an enormous impact on the world. As a result, here we are on our own path to enlightenment.

We can admire and be grateful for his dedication, energy, patience, compassion and all the other qualities that fuelled his spiritual life. Chief among these are his wisdom and awareness, *satipaṭṭhāna*. Using these faculties he discovered that which is unborn, undying, the end of all suffering. And while we can't paint a mental picture of whatever in him enjoys the perfect piece of *Nibbāna*, we can each in our own way attempt to take that mystery to heart.

For myself, this would mean allowing myself to wonder, what is it in him that is unborn, undying, the end of suffering? Of course, I have no answers. Sometimes my mind conjures up a bright light and I feel myself basking in its warmth. Often the initial pleasure turns to some form of *dukkha*, perhaps grief that I can't grasp onto that light,

hold it forever in my heart. But the grief is sensed as healing, teaching me to let go of attachment to any image or notion of what enlightenment might be. Recognising this, gratitude comes up and a deeper commitment to this contemplation.

Now of course our begrudging attitudes show up here too. Who does he think he is asking everyone to adore him? Does he think he's God Almighty? But we know the drill. Know thoughts as thoughts. Feel the feelings. Trust things to evolve in the light of awareness.

As I take on this practice what happens is that I feel myself developing a personal relationship with the Buddha. For example, my imagination can be drawn towards the details of his life, remembering his shock when he realised the futility of his princely life, for example, seeing him say his last goodbye to his wife and son, creeping out of the palace to take up the life of a wandering ascetic. Later on, after years of hardship, accepting the rice milk from Sujata. That's a very inspiring image for me. I would see it as the moment he recognised that his humanity and bodily needs form part of his spiritual path.

Another very touching moment for me is during his last temptation before enlightenment, when Mara, his inner begrudger, sneers. What makes you think you could be enlightened? What have you done to merit that? Who do you think you are? This is the hindrance of self-doubt, a challenge for every human being. In all the other temptations, he was able to sit still and not be swayed. But here his resolution is shaking. He feels the need of support. He stretches his hand down to touch the earth, calling it as witness to his right to come to the end of suffering.

As I contemplate these and other stories from the life of the Buddha he becomes a more tangible presence in my life. Imagining his serenity under the rose apple tree I feel serene. Imagining his courage in leaving home I feel myself grow in courage. Seeing him reach down to the earth in his moment of self-doubt I feel myself as part of the earth reassuring him, encouraging him to press on. This growing sense of friendship, companionship, camaraderie makes it a bit easier to contemplate his enlightened state. The touch of friendship extends beyond my understanding, encouraging me to make peace with the mystery of the unborn, undying, the end of suffering. There is a growing trust that whatever it is or isn't, there is nothing to fear.

This is the practice of devotion. Those of us brought up in Christianity will be familiar with the approach. Contemplating the life of Jesus, as we say the Rosary for example, devotion is a way of opening the heart. It's a form of *metta* practice, where we make the Buddha the object of our *metta*. One teacher calls it falling in love with the Buddha.

Now, of course, falling in love is not plain sailing. It can evoke inner, great inner turmoil. We can fall in and out of love at a great rate. Wandering mind, dullness, restlessness, aversion, all the hindrances come up as we bring the Buddha to mind. At times we'll be able to simply note these and then come back to the main focus, the Buddha. At times we have to give our full attention to whatever hindrance is uppermost, trusting that it will eventually burn itself out in the light of awareness. So we can switch between devotion and mindfulness as appropriate. It's like any relationship. At times we can be completely focused on the other. At times we need to withdraw and tend to ourselves, maybe to lick our wounds.

This retreat is an ideal opportunity to follow the Buddha's teaching on *kalyāṇa mita*, our spiritual friendship. If it weren't for the people around us, we wouldn't be spending so many hours a day in meditation. So everyone here is our spiritual friend. We could devote a portion of our meditation practice to bringing each other into our hearts. Being grateful for our connection within the group. Let's vow to look for the best in one another and copy that.

And for those of you who like falling in love, then give in to the temptation. Fall in love with the Buddha. Or you might prefer a somewhat more Buddhist phrase, become the Buddha within.

Downers

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 2 min read

In this deeply personal teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma distinguishes between ordinary life 'downers' and clinical depression, sharing wisdom learned from his mother's resilience through love and humor. He explores how resistance to difficult emotions—getting 'depressed about being depressed'—often transforms manageable low moods into serious suffering.

Drawing on the Buddha's instructions to 'feel feelings in feelings' and experience 'mental states in mental states' from the Satipaṭṭhāna teachings, Bhante demonstrates how vipassanā meditation offers a radical alternative to avoidance strategies. Rather than seeking distraction through entertainment or consumption, the Buddhist path invites us to meet dark emotions with radical acceptance, equanimity, and patient forbearance.

This teaching reveals how non-aggressive awareness allows difficult emotions to express themselves fully and naturally exhaust their energy, preventing them from hijacking our lives. Bhante shows how this mindful relationship with suffering becomes a doorway to understanding the Buddha's fundamental teaching: how we create dukkha for ourselves and how we can bring all suffering to an end through the transformative practice of Dhamma.

There was a time when depression was not so psychologised and medicalised. People talked of being 'under the weather'. It was seen as part of life. Sometimes you were 'a bit down'. You were told to 'pull your socks up' and 'get on with it'. These downers are to be distinguished from mental illness. So long as we are feeling 'a bit depressed', the big problem is we get depressed about it. Or angry about it. Even anxious about it. That's what can drive 'a bit depressed' into a serious depression. My first teacher was my mother. She would now be considered to suffer from some degree of clinical anxiety driven depression. She ended up with a concoction of pills so beloved of doctors. But she that age group and complained of lacking energy, an anxious stomach and headaches. She told me later in life that what kept her going was her mothering of four children. That was the first lesson. Just keep doing what you have to do - and do it with love. She was a sanguine type and enjoyed a slapstick type humour. She'd stick a needle in your bum while watching TV. And she transformed when she was with friends. No matter how she felt, she engaged and found happiness and fun in their company. That was the second precious lesson. You've got to laugh! These two strategies I believe kept me from going under, but they did not tackle the problem at root which was my rela-

tionship to my 'downers'. It was not until I began to meditate that I was able to really grapple with them. The Buddha asks us to really confront these feelings. Not in an aggressive way, but in a welcoming, kind, open-hearted way. He has a way of expressing this intimate embrace. He instructs us to 'feel feelingsinfeelings', to experience 'mental statesinmental states'. In other words no barriers caused by aversion or fear. For when we do not want to feel them, we seek distraction. Anything will do. Watch TV. Eat chocolates. And worse! And if these poor strategies fail, then we truly begin to go under. It takes a lot of trust to open up to these dark whirlpools. At times we may feel overwhelmed. That's when we need the teacher or the therapist. But as we persist we see we are creating a different relationship towards aching states of mind and harrowing emotions. This is one of radical acceptance: this is the way it is; equanimity: open-hearted, open-minded, no resistance; and patient forbearance: a willingness to bear with mental pain. When we discover this new relationship of non-aggression and non-fear, something magical begins to happen. It is as though all that dark, oppressive turbulence is allowed to express itself fully and in so doing exhausts itself. Slowly these moods no longer hijack our lives. They become less dense and don't hang around so long. Then we begin to realise we have found the way not simply to bring depression to an end, but all suffering. This is the gift of Dhamma the Buddha gave to humanity - the understanding of how we create suffering for ourselves and how we can bring it all to an end.

Dukkha: Unsatisfactoriness and the Path to Liberation

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 50 min

In this dharma talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma unpacks the Buddha's central teaching: "In this world there is dukkha and there is the end of dukkha." He explains the three levels of dukkha - ordinary suffering (dukkha-dukkha), suffering from impermanence (viparinama-dukkha), and the subtle suffering arising from conditioned existence (sankhara-dukkha). Through examination of the five aggregates (pañca-khandha) - form, perception, feeling, mental formations, and consciousness - we discover how we actively create our experience of the world.

The talk reveals how the fourth aggregate, saṅkhāra (mental formations), contains our power of will (cetanā) that generates karma through our responses to pleasant and unpleasant feelings. Bhante emphasizes that while we cannot control the first three aggregates, we can transform our relationship to experience through Right Awareness practice. He distinguishes between intention and will, showing how vipassanā meditation creates liberating distance from our identifications.

Drawing from the Dhammapada's opening verse that "everything is mind-made," Bhante clarifies that while Buddhism isn't idealism, we can only know reality through our consciousness. This understanding empowers us to take responsibility for our psychological suffering while developing the wisdom that naturally flowers into compassion. The talk concludes with guidance on balancing insight practice with loving-kindness to avoid spiritual indifference.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

One of the phrases that the Buddha uses is "In this world there is *dukkha* and there is the end of *dukkha*." And this word *dukkha* is difficult to translate well—difficult in the sense that there's no single word that covers its meaning. *Dukkha* in itself just means a hard place, so we're in a hard place.

It also seems to have been used at the time for various ways of describing things. But one of them was an axle in a cart which didn't quite fit right, and so it scratched and made noises and went along. And that's an image of the way we are in the world. We haven't quite got it right.

This *dukkha* is not only described as just the ordinary pains and suffering of life—all the stuff that we experience here, for instance, the emotional stuff—but also remember the suffering that comes from attachment. And all that he calls *dukkha-dukkha*—that's the unsatisfactoriness of ordinary suffering, ordinary pain, ordinary unsatisfactoriness.

And then there's a suffering that comes from the idea of impermanence, the fact that we can't hold on to anything, that everything is disappearing, a lack of control. With certain things it doesn't really matter to us, but when it comes to our bodies, old age, sickness and death, then it gets a bit close to the bone, as you might say. So there's a whole suffering around impermanence simply because we prefer things not to change, especially when you've got it just right. You know, the perfect day, ice cream, it's all there and you just don't want it to move.

And then there's the more subtle suffering that arises because things are compounded. And what the Buddha means by that is that nothing has any self-reality, nothing exists of its own. Everything is dependent on something else. And that's this interdependency.

So even here now, we're breathing, we're dependent on the breath, we're dependent on the air in this room. And when you actually begin to just contemplate how dependent we are on the world around us, not just simply in terms of food and air and stuff like that, but companionship, relationship, transport—every part of our lives is always something dependent on something else. And that dependency shows that actually what we experience ourselves to be, how we define ourselves, is always in terms of a relationship, a relationship with something else. And that's the part of it that is compounded.

It goes deeper than that in the sense that everything within us is also compounded. There's parts of our body that give up before other parts. You'd think the whole thing would just go all together but it doesn't, so then you realize that actually parts of the body also have their own little life form and are doing their own little things. When you look into the body and you ask yourself what is it you know of the body, I think it can be quite surprising how little we actually know of the body.

Just, we've been talking about air and breathing. Have you ever experienced the exchange of oxygen for carbon dioxide? If nobody told you that, would you know? Skin—all the cells in the body have their own little life form and they're all dividing and dying and whatever. Do we ever experience that? Have any control over it? Your toenails, what about that? That's growing, it's growing right now. You have any idea it's growing? You have any idea what your liver's doing?

So there's a whole—once you begin to ask yourself, what do I actually know about the body as an organism? Quite surprising, we know very little. We can move it about. You've got to go up and down, smile, make it laugh, all that. But actually what we know, what we directly experience with the body is quite minimal. And it's minimal because the only thing we can know is through the mind.

Now, that goes back to this earlier statement: "In this world there is suffering and the end of suffering." So what the Buddha is saying is that this relationship that we have, it can be straightened out. We can actually get to a point where we don't suffer anymore. There's always going to be pain. The body's always going to deliver pain. But it's not going to make us suffer.

Now, this word that he uses, "in this world"—when he defines "in this world," he defines it as the five aggregates. And that's the way he split up the organism that we experience. So first of all there's the body, and we'll come back to that because it's not the body in the way that we just explained it. Then there are all perceptions, all the perceptions that we have. Then there are all the feelings that we have. Then there's what he calls these *saṅkhāra*. *Saṅkhāra* are the emotional and thought life that we experience. And then there's cognition, the act of holding something to know it, an act of cognition.

And the reason he splits it up like this is because he's always pointing to where the problem lies. The problem doesn't lie in the body. The body does its own thing. It's an organism, it feels, it sees, etc. It doesn't lie in perception. Perception meaning those first things that we cognize in the mind. So color, shape, sound, before it takes on a particular meaning. So when I look at the statue, what I see as the beginning percepts are just its shape and color. And it's an internal process that tells me it's a statue and it's a statue of the Buddha. What he's talking about when he talks about this perception process is just that beginning process where the mind is like a sense base.

And then there's feeling. Feeling, as we discover in our meditation, is just sensation. In his language, there's only one word for feeling. We've got sensations, feeling, emotions, moods. But as far as he's concerned, it's just all feeling. This word *vedanā*—and these feelings he splits into two kinds: they're either pleasant or they're unpleasant. There is a neutral—he also points to neutral feelings—but when you actually really go

into a neutral feeling you'll see it sides slightly with being unpleasant or slightly with being pleasant. And there's a further split in the sense that he says that some of these feelings are coming from the body, what we would call sensations, and some are coming from the mind, what we would call emotions, emotional feelings.

So this *vedanā* is simply telling us that those first three are telling us that there's a contact with the physical world, and this physical contact allows us to create percepts in the mind. These percepts are also memory—it's a memory bank as well—and it creates a certain feeling tone to the world, pleasant and unpleasant. All that is given. That's part and parcel of being a human being. But as you know, depending on our faculties—if we're blind, that's one avenue of experience that's not open to us. And we can develop certain senses. A painter, an artist would develop the sense of sight, a musician, a sense of sound, of hearing.

The fourth one—these *saṅkhāra*—he separates that out as the point where we create, because in the midst of that *saṅkhāra* we have this power called will. And the core thing about *saṅkhāra* is will, *cetanā*. Now will is not intention. So this is something that you can investigate yourself when you're doing standing meditation, for instance. Just to stand still and establish that stillness, and then allow the intention to arise.

Sometimes when I say intention, people think it has to be some big emotional thing, like intending to walk sort of overpowering me. But actually, it's just an intention. It's just like, I want to open the door. It doesn't have to be a big emotional explosion. And you know it by simply saying "intending to walk"—that's the intention. So when you say to yourself "intending to walk" you can feel a push in the body as it were, you feel a certain energy coming up: intending to walk. But nothing happens. Just try it yourself. You can stand there forever saying "intending to walk," nothing ever happens. And then something quite magical moves you—something happens, the foot moves.

So something has brought an idea, a wish, out of potential into the actual. It's actually produced an action. Now that power is what the Buddha calls the will. And it's through that power that we create these *saṅkhāras*, which is our emotional thought life. And he equates this will with *kamma*, with action.

Now, I'm not using the word here as it's normally used, in the sense of karma, like your comeuppance. This is what you deserve. *Kamma* here just means an act. And the technical word for the comeuppance, for what you get as a response to what you do, as a consequence to what you do, is *vipāka*. Those are the two words. So it's cause and then the effect or the result.

And then there's this act of cognition, which you can take to mean—the way I visualize it or the way I understand it is all the electrons hit the screen of a television. Before it hits the screen of a television it's completely nonsensical, but when it hits the screen of this television you've got a picture. So all this information is coming into the brain mind complex and it's somehow being held as a picture which we then know. So when you are—when in your mind you're seeing these images—though to see them, that primary knowing of those images, that's the act of cognition.

Now this is where we begin to understand the Buddha when he's in the opening verse of the *Dhammapada*. So the *Dhammapada* is a little collection of verses which is like a—in the Buddha's Bible you can say—that it's something that everybody reads. They're just little verses pointing to certain truth. And the first one is that everything is mind made and mind is the forerunner.

Now what this means is in the Buddha's understanding is that everything we're experiencing is created by the mind's contact with the outside world and of course with what it has engineered within itself. So you have to be careful here because Buddhism isn't an idealism. It moves towards that way in later Buddhism in the sense that nothing exists, it's all in the minds of people as it were. The Buddha doesn't deny the reality of the trees that you're looking at. What he's saying is you can only know the trees in your way. You can't get beyond your own consciousness. It's you who are actually creating the tree that you know.

Now when we take this into the problem of suffering, the problem of unsatisfactoriness, the problem of a certain lack, a certain existential angst, whatever we're suffering from. When you take that into—then you realize that actually it's not being created by the world. It's being created by the way we are relating to what's coming in and to our lives. So all our suffering is made by us. Nobody can make us suffer. So this is a real breakthrough when we actually realize that nobody can cause us psychological pain. They can give us a hell of a lot of physical pain, but they can't actually cause the psychological pain. That psychological pain is being produced by an internal mechanism which we have learned within ourselves. We've probably been taught how to do it by our parents etc., but it's something that we're creating in ourselves.

From a process of awakening point of view, if we weren't creating our suffering and it was somebody else who was doing it, then you'd have to get rid of that somebody else. And if there was anybody in the world whom you thought was creating suffering for you, before your suffering would end you'd have to get rid of them. So there'd be no way really to full liberation until you annihilated everybody. If somebody out there can cause you suffering, then there's always that potential of suffering.

What the Buddha is saying is that he attained a state where, as he puts it, the world argues with him, he doesn't argue with the world. He's not in contradiction with the world. It's not that people didn't hate him. Devadatta, the dastardly fellow who was a monk, he went to the Buddha and thought he was getting a bit old and he was getting all loose and losing his grip. So he said, what we need to do is get back to the originals, back to the original order—living in a forest, vegetarianism, just rag robes, sleep under a tree, back to the old hard stuff, because they've all gone soft. So the Buddha actually allowed it. He said, well, if you want to do those—they're called *dhutaṅgas*, those extra special exercises like never taking a lying position—he can do it. But I think Devadatta had in his mind that it was his time now to take over the order. He was a cousin actually. So he tried to kill him, didn't he? Three times, for heaven's sake. Rolled a boulder down a hill, caught his toe.

So it wasn't as though the Buddha didn't create enemies, but his relationship to Devadatta, we can presume, was not angry, hateful, vengeful, etc.

So, if we now take the position that the world I'm experiencing is the world that I'm creating—the world I'm experiencing is the world that I am actually creating—this allows us now, gives us a way of, if I'm creating this world and I'm not experiencing happiness, I'm not experiencing peace, then I must be doing something wrong. So we then have to look at the mechanisms within our own psychology to see how is it that we're creating this suffering. And that's what we're doing with *vipassanā*—that's the purpose of *vipassanā*—is to see how we create suffering and how we begin to undermine that suffering.

And there's two ways in which we better our situation. The first one is dealing with the suffering that we have, and the second one is increasing our bank of joy, love, compassion and peacefulness. And the two go hand in hand.

So what we're practising is allowing any feelings that we perceive as being unpleasant—downright painful and horrible—we're allowing them to just manifest. When they're mental feelings we can begin to realize that just in their manifestation, just in their expression, is their healing. And this is a real radical way of looking at therapy, because normally speaking we would be trying to do something about our psychology. Whereas what the Buddha says, all you got to do is endure it, all you got to do is sit in the midst of the flames and have the patience to allow them to burn out.

Now if it were just that, it would only be psychology, it would only be something that might help people to become a bit calmer, less stressful, all the usual stuff. But in seeing the mechanism, in actually perceiving how the flames were built in the first place, allows us to undermine that whole process of continuously making further flames, further bonfires for ourselves. And that process is this business of desire.

Now it's sometimes translated as craving, which is sometimes a bit over the top. Desire—in English, of course, has a good meaning. The desire to be compassionate, what's wrong with that? So this *taṇhā* is the desire which is coming from a wrong understanding of seeking happiness in the wrong place. It's a specific desire. It's a desire based on believing that we can create some sort of permanent happiness—permanent emotional thought happiness—by using the world around us: tea, biscuits, all that. And that desire is coming from this misunderstanding—a misunderstanding of where we can seek this happiness.

And what that does is, the misunderstanding creates the idea, creates the notion of a me. So this is where we get a bit—shall we say, it confuses people, this teaching about not-self. And often people turn it into a metaphysics like there is no self. But the Buddha never says that anywhere. He's simply using it as a tool, as a way of exploring what is real about what I'm experiencing.

So all he's saying is whatever arises and passes away necessarily can't be a self, because what we mean by a self is something substantial, something that continues, something that doesn't arise and pass away, isn't born, doesn't die. It's the same definition as somebody might call a spirit or a soul.

So in our meditation, when we are looking at what we're experiencing and we're creating that distance and we're seeing that it's arising and passing away, whether it's an intellectual reflection or not, we're actually experiencing the process of not me, not mine. As soon as you distance from something, as soon as you make it an object that you're looking at, then it can't be that which is looking.

And that distance, that separation is a liberation, no matter how small it might be. It's a liberation at some point from the notion of the self as feeling, the self as an emotion, the self as thought. I think therefore I am, I feel therefore I am. Every time we say something like "Oh, I'm really depressed," you're lost. You are depressed. What can you do about it? Now you're in there, you've defined yourself as being depressed. But as soon as you distance from it within yourself and you say "there is depression" through this technique of noting, just being able to distance yourself from it, you're liberated from it. That doesn't mean to say it's not painful — it's still depression — but there's something missing from "I am depressed."

The I that identifies with something falls into a hell state, and that's what, if you define a hell state, what is it apart from thinking that you are the suffering you're experiencing? When you come out of that and it becomes an object and there is depression, then we can say that's purgatory. I've always believed in Catholic doctrine. Hell is hell, whether it's a place or not, is immaterial. Hell is a place where you don't see an exit. That's it. If you get completely panicked, that's it, you're in hell. Whereas purgatory is where it's all very painful, but at least things are going to come to an end.

So our position in *vipassanā* is to allow things to arise, but also to create that distance so that we know that this is not me, it's not mine, and itself is not a self. An emotion is not a self. Does an emotion know itself? I mean, does an emotion go around saying, "I'm depressed"? Does a knee know it's hurting? Does a knee know anything? My knees don't know anything at all. So there's something in us that knows this stuff and then makes this wrong relationship.

So at fundament, you could say, the basic position is that our relationship to the world is wrong. It's all to do with relationship, and what I discovered is that everything that I'm creating now, no matter what it is, whether it's beautiful or sad or whatever, is actually being created by me. And if I can get that relationship right, then I should end up somewhere different. I should be experiencing the world in a different way.

So that's what this whole process is about — it's about changing our relationship to the world. And when the Buddha awakens from that delusion, his first thought is "Who can I help? Who can I tell this to?" — the good news. So it's not as though the meditation, this process of purification, the process of insight, is actually isolating us. It's not that it's drawing us into this little cave where we can be happy by ourselves. We're a horde of little peanuts and things like that. It's something which immediately reconnects us with the world. And this is really important for us to do because that's the practice of *mettā*.

And the *vipassanā* has a danger to it. The danger is that in finding this position of the objective observer, that objectivity which in its virtuous form is equanimity — it's the ability to receive, to bear without reaction — turns easily into a sort of disinterest. I'm looking for the other word, not callous. No, no, you're jumping ahead of me there. Indifference. Thank you very much. It's an indifference.

And I always like to tell the tale about these two little experiences I had. I was in one monastery with this monk, and there was a cat, and it was playing around with a mouse, which it had obviously killed. And I just said, "Didn't you stop that?" And he said, "No," he said, "cat karma and mouse karma. I mean, it's just the way it is, that's life, you can't stop it." So I said, "Fair enough."

And I was in another monastery where we were sitting on a bench, a couple of monks, a few monks. And suddenly this cat jumped out and jumped on this bird. And this monk, a flash of lightning, got up and gave this cat one hell of a kick. And got hold of the bird, but its lungs had been punctured. And very, very beautifully, he just held it up with its wings sort of splayed out, and chanted the verses that we do when somebody dies: "All compounded things arise and pass away."

So he didn't believe in cat karma and bird karma. And the distinction there was of course the relationship, that connection, that connection which comes through love, compassion and joy.

So you must make sure that whenever you do *vipassanā*, there's always some point at the end where you reconnect with the world. And that's in the Eightfold Path. So the right understanding begins with reflecting about our lives, and the *vipassanā* takes it into an experiential understanding of the way things are. But somehow that has to reconnect, and that's done through the second of the Noble Eightfold Path, which is this right attitude. And you build up your attitude through your intentions. So as soon as he'd understood what he'd experienced, the intention arose just naturally: "Who can I help? Who can I teach this to?"

So if we can do that at the end of a sitting and translate what we've understood into an attitude, then it's easy for it to be translated further into the next three steps of right speech, right action and right livelihood.

Now what we find is that these steps also, as it were, turn back on themselves. So what in *vipassanā* we come to understand — this relationship, this interrelatedness of things — so long as it stays as some sort of understanding, even at an experiential level, although you can argue that once it's become experiential it's got to move into an attitude. The Zen would say that: with wisdom, compassion arises naturally. You don't have to play at it. You don't have to work at it.

But even so, if it remains at the level of just an understanding of interrelatedness, it doesn't actually affect the world. But when it moves into the heart, the expression of interrelatedness is love. That's what love is. It's knowing that interrelatedness. And when that attitude is set, then it moves easily into right speech, right action and right livelihood.

Now having said that the world we experience is within this little bubble that I call my awareness, the fact of the matter is that this little bubble does have a relationship with all the other bubbles and with the big bubble that we call nature. There's some connection there which we have. So that when we look into ourselves and want to

know what our karma is — meaning what is our conditioning — that conditioning manifests in us as emotions and thoughts and feelings. But of course this resonates back out into the world, and that's why the world begins to mirror back to us our conditioning. So if a person is an argumentative type, then he shouldn't be too upset if people don't go near him. If a person is a loving type, then she shouldn't be surprised that people congregate around her. And that's pretty straightforward.

But you have to be careful here, because once we put an action into the world, it doesn't necessarily mean that it's going to have the effect that we wanted it to have, because it goes into a set of situations over which we have no power whatsoever. So even though you might do something out of the greatest charity of your heart, don't be surprised if somebody hates you for it, because in doing so unwittingly you've stood on their toes.

Because what we're doing is we're putting an action, we're putting an action of thought — even of thought actually — but especially of speech and action into a situation over which we do not know the consequences. So it wouldn't be right to think that things that happen to us are entirely to do with our karma, are entirely to do because of my past actions. But we can say that the way I am inside myself is the product of my own karma, is the product of my own manufacturing.

When the Buddha talks about "in this world there is suffering, in this world there is the end of suffering," he's actually talking about the karma which is to do with our state of happiness or lack of it.

So I turn the light on and begin to talk to ghosts. Now I think you have to press one of those, the middle one. The middle one. I sit and turn it. Hey. Enlightenment. Just like that.

So we started off by understanding that the Buddha has defined or deconstructed this human being into these five different areas, three of which we have no control over because it's a given. So the body is a given, and our contact with the body is a given. You can't do anything about that. It's the way that the mind contacts the physical world. So for instance, even when as you go around you might hug a tree — now the feeling that you get of a tree, the feeling you get of wood, is something that the mind is making up from its contact with wood. It's not necessarily true that the wood actually feels like that. Somebody else might come along and think it's soft or hard. It doesn't really matter. But even in basic percepts, we're always creating the world that we are living in. And somewhere along the line we're making this mistake.

And we create these conditionings within ourselves, this emotional thought life. And then we project this onto the world. And that's where our contact is. And because we're projecting it onto the world into an unknown, we don't know the consequences of what will happen if we do something. What comes back to us may seem to be unjust. Or it may seem to be just pure luck. Like when you buy a lottery ticket. I mean, why should you win? Why you? Why not me?

So you don't know what the effect of an action will be, but you can know about it within yourself. And that's the important thing, because it's within ourselves that we either create this happiness or unhappiness. If we move from an intention which is wholesome, it will have a wholesome effect upon our inner life. And that's the important thing. And if we move from intention which is unwholesome, it will have an unwholesome effect upon our inner life. And it's our inner life that we're actually experiencing. It's our inner life which is either causing us pain or causing us joy.

So the meditation is actually taking us inward to find these mechanisms, to find the way that we're creating this world. And hopefully we begin to undo them. And the positive side is the development of the seven factors of enlightenment: the calmness, the steadiness of attention, the curiosity to want to know how things happen.

But you'll notice that in the seven factors of enlightenment, love is not included. Love is not, because love is to do with the secondary part as to the relationship the enlightened mind has with the world. In order to get that, there must be this purity. So that purity is partly to do with the state of the heart in terms of getting rid of all these impure emotions, allowing them to burn out. But it's also to do with the way we see things, to see things as they really are. And so in a sense you might argue that love or compassion for oneself underpins the whole process, because in a sense we're having compassion for ourselves in wanting to get out of suffering.

But it's not as though in order to be enlightened we have to develop *mettā*. *Mettā* is the word for love. That's something we do afterwards in order to cement, you might say, the new understanding we have into a new relationship.

So that's the process, that's the spiritual process. We are inwardly looking to see where we're doing things wrong. Part of that process is to bear what is already wrong, to allow it to burn out. And then when we come out of that, to re-establish or to try to refine our relationship with the world on a more positive level. As simple as that. Just like that.

If Buddha said that mind creates the nature of the world outside, what does Buddha say? Well, no. Now, the thing about the Buddha is that he doesn't get into metaphysics. So if you were to ask the Buddha, "Is the world eternal?" or "Is it finite?" or "Who creates the world out there?" — he's just silent, because it's not something that you can directly know. He's only interested in what you can directly know. Everything else must necessarily be inference. And remember that the Buddha's — the arrow, the point of the arrow of his teaching — is simply this word *dukkha*, this word that we translate as unsatisfactoriness. That's all he's concerned with. He's quite clear about it. He says in the Pali, in the language, he reduces his teaching just to three words: *dukkha*, *dukkha nirodha* — suffering, unsatisfactoriness, and the end of it.

So trying to — I mean in later Buddhism it does become a bit more metaphysical and stuff. But in the Buddha's own specific teaching, as it comes through in our tradition anyway, it's always grounded in individual psychology. It doesn't really move off that.

So even when he's asked what happens to him when he dies — what was known as the quadrilemma. In the West we only have a dilemma, but in the East they have a quadrilemma. So does he exist? Does he not exist? Does he both somehow exist and not exist? And does he neither exist nor not exist? It's a killer, isn't it? And he's silent. And wouldn't you be?

No, there's no God. He won't go into that. He doesn't answer questions like, "Who created the world?" No, he doesn't. No, there is mind. What are you going to do with it?

So does he see mind as separate to what is not mind? Well, now that is the question about what is the definition of *nibbāna*. And our tradition tends to be very coy in describing it. And he tends to follow the Buddha's pattern of saying what it's not. I think in the religious tradition it's called the apophatic. Not this, not that. So he's not born, he doesn't die, he's not compounded, and he's not conditioned. But what it is, well, who knows?

But he definitely says that is not annihilation. Now the Buddhist at his time — or his teachings was often confused with annihilation because there were nihilists at that time, there were materialists, nihilists. I don't know whether they were socialists, but there was all sorts of beliefs. And when he's approached, he says, "Well, you're just teaching a form of nihilism." He says, "No," he says, "the only thing that's annihilated is greed, hatred and delusion." And it must have got very confusing for people who listen to these other teachers who would either say "Yes, there is" or "No, there isn't." And the Jains have a lovely comment on Buddhism. He says, "Well, these people say that there is no soul and there is no afterlife, and we say there is a soul and there is an afterlife, and the Buddhists can't make their mind up."

So was Buddha alive around the same time as the beginnings of, say, Judaism, as an example? Yeah, Moses. Around the same time? I think it was Moses. I'm not sure what the right word is.

Well, it was the Axial Age, wasn't it? Moses, Socrates, Lao Tzu. Out of interest, what's her name, the writer? *The History of God*. Karen Armstrong. She's written a wonderful book on the Axial Age. It's worth reading.

Well, that's this business of rebirth. And yes, there's rebirth. We understand rebirth when you understand what's happening now. What's happening now is that we're being reborn every moment into the next moment. And we're not different from the past moment, but we're not the same. And all Buddhism says is that upon death it's just the body that goes and the mind gets reborn, seeks another place to be reborn. And from the Buddha's point of view, it's this rebirth, this constant going on, this *saṃsāra*, which is the product of this misunderstanding.

Buddhism does split off into two different ideas when somebody is fully liberated. In our tradition nothing is really said. It's more like nothing can be said. The *Tathāgata* - that's how he referred to himself - translates as "the transcendent," the one who's transcended. And he himself doesn't say much. There is a passage where he hints at what happens to him after death. Unfortunately, it doesn't come to mind, so I'll look it up one day. But you don't know. I mean, it's very nice to think about those things because it comforts, but actually we don't know.

Well, the word soul has a lot of meanings. It's best just to think of it as mind. When we say mind here we mean the whole everything that we talked about - when I was talking about the five *khandhas*, how the mind contacts the physical world, perceptions, feelings, our volitional conditionings caused by acts of will and cognition. All that's reborn. And it's being reborn now.

So mind in the Buddha sense is actually different to how we would describe it in the literal sense in English, in the sense that mind in English means brain, intelligence, intellect. It's the heart, it's the heart-mind, it's the whole psychic - it's the psyche. You see, in the old definitions, in the Greek definition, there was *soma* the body, there was *psyche* which did not split mind off from heart - it was one thing - and there was *pneuma* which was the unknown, it was spirit, the unconditioned. This was translated into Christianity as *corpus* the body, *spiritus* and *mens*, mind.

And it's only, I think I'm right in saying, Descartes who split the mind off from the heart. "I think therefore I am." And we've been stuck with that split. So often in the East, when somebody says to you, "I think this is so," they don't point here, they point here.

They point to the heart. It's easy once you've separated the mind from the heart to realize or to begin to believe that animals who don't have a mind must be machines. You divest them of any soul, soulness or whatever. So that's how we got to this position with nature, you see, abusing it.

I was trying to say that it's a sort of tautology really, but you can only know what you can know. You can't go beyond your own awareness. So if you want to understand the result of hunger, you have to experience it. Really. Otherwise it remains a conceptual idea, doesn't it? Everything. And what we do is, we presume that because we have a concept of something that we actually know it. We often make that mistake. If you can describe it, if you can give it a sentence, you think that somehow you know it.

We do it on very basic things. Like you might pass, say, one of these flowers and you might name it Primrose. And you think that because you've named it, because you've recognised the Primrose, that you've actually experienced that Primrose. But you haven't looked at it, you haven't smelt it, you haven't felt it. So you haven't a clue what that Primrose actually is. You've simply deposited your concept on it and have been satisfied with that as an experience of that primrose. And that's why you'll find all Buddhist insight meditations are always trying to ground people back into the body. To re-contact our physicality.

Well, as I say, it remains in Theravāda Buddhism: *Nibbāna* is only described in its negative form. But interestingly enough you do find in our own scriptures a definition of something which is full of light, awareness, no boundary. And remember that although we talk about this experience as being full of unsatisfactoriness and that it's changing, and *Nibbāna* is described in the opposite - there is no unsatisfactoriness and there's no change - but it's still not a self.

That usually throws us, because we still think there's going to be some sort of being, some sort of something that you can describe in *Nibbāna*. So, for instance, when Sāriputta is asked, "How can you talk about the bliss of *Nibbāna*, the joy of *Nibbāna*, when there's no emotions there?" He says, "Well, it's the very absence of emotions, which is the bliss of *Nibbāna*."

Now how can we begin to understand that? When you're in a good meditative situation within yourself and you've become the observer and you're observing emotions and you're observing thoughts and you're observing feelings in the body, and when everything drops to a calmness and you can still feel these things as objects - ask yourself what's the mood of the observer? What's the mood of the observer?

So I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you be liberated from all your suffering sooner rather than later.

Dullness and Lethargy: Our Two Very Good Friends

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 3 min read

In this candid retreat reflection, Bhante Bodhidhamma explores the familiar experience of dullness and lethargy that often arises during meditation practice, particularly in the early days of retreat. Drawing from his personal experience at Satipanya, he examines how these mental states typically begin in the mind through paying unwise attention to mental contents, gradually spreading to physical lethargy that can feel like "the energy supply has been disconnected."

Rather than viewing dullness and lethargy as enemies to be fought, Bhante reframes them as "our two very good friends" - conditioned strategies the mind uses to deal with difficult situations, disinterest, or boredom. He shares practical approaches for working with these states, including maintaining physical alertness through keeping eyes open, standing, and walking, while cultivating the curious perspective of a child toward meditation objects like the breath.

The essay demonstrates how apparent obstacles in meditation can become fertile ground for vipassanā insight. By investigating the impermanent nature of dullness and lethargy - how one can be "lolling about in stupor one moment, and then wide awake and fully engaged the next" - practitioners can develop direct understanding of the three characteristics: impermanence, unsatisfactoriness, and not-self. This transforms what might seem like meditation "failures" into valuable opportunities for deepening wisdom and Right Awareness.

I'm at Satipanya as I write this, on the second day of a two week retreat and, as is usual for me during the first few days of a retreat (at least!), dullness and lethargy is the prevalent state. I'm used to this. It doesn't seem to matter what I'm doing, when I switch from one mode of being to another, dullness and lethargy arises. That can be from work to retreat or retreat to work, it doesn't matter. Holidays are the same. Any major change in behaviour results in the same thing: dullness and lethargy! Bhante calls them "our two very good friends" as they're always trying to help you be more comfortable, to rest, to take it easy, and always for good and compelling reasons: you deserve it, you've worked so hard, and so on. It's interesting to watch. For me, dullness and lethargy typically starts in the mind. Often, what happens is that I notice a warm and comfortable aspect of experience which envelopes me, and before I know it I'm nodding off! As the

dullness develops, it can migrate from mere sleepiness to a full-on (off?!) physical lethargy, like the energy supply has been disconnected! It lulls you in like that. Dreamlike thoughts/images grab at you, trying to pull you down into the depths of sleep. This is, of course, exactly how sleep starts normally. Typically, I'll close my eyes and reflect on something from the day, this quickly turns into a weird hypnogogic semi-dream and I'm gone. The feeling and character is just like dullness and lethargy, though. Stuff going on in the mind "takes over" and drags you down into sleep. So, the "problem" definitely appears to be the mind and, by that, I mean paying unwise attention to the contents of the mind. When mindfulness is present, and we're diligent with watching physical sensations in the body, it's much harder for dullness and lethargy to get a foothold. From a meditative point of view, I pretty much equate getting lost in thought with dullness and lethargy. I know that if the mind is thinking a lot, dullness and lethargy is sure to follow. While meditating, there's an apparent conflict with our "friends", though. We want to be alert, but they can make for an unpleasant and unsatisfactory experience. Dullness and lethargy is not the enemy, though. It's not a "problem". It's the mind's conditioned strategy for dealing with difficult situations, disinterest, disengagement, boredom and so on. As such, it's automatic, so I try not to fight it any more. Instead, I try to gently feed in the conditions for interest and alertness to arise. I try to stay awake, I'll keep my eyes open, stand up, walk, and so on. That is, all the usual instructions for dealing with dullness and lethargy, but I also look for something interesting, that is, I'll try to encourage my "perspective" to be that of a curious child. There's something amazing about the way the breath feels when it breathes itself. What makes it breathe in long sometimes and short others? Sometimes it's steady, sometimes it huffs. Oftentimes it feels like I'm not getting enough air, but the breath carries on like that anyway, and I don't keel over! What?! Also, the feeling of standing back and watching the body running on without "my" input is remarkable. It really shows that this body is not-Self! Also, when dullness and lethargy has grabbed me, it's fascinating to be lolling about in its stupor one moment, and then wide awake and fully engaged the next! That happens of itself, too! So, far from being a "problem", dullness and lethargy is actually fertile ground for great investigation and insight. Impermanent, unsatisfactory, and not-Self, our two very good friends, dullness and lethargy, turn out to be a great vipassanā teacher!

Equanimity

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 2 min read

In this engaging reflection, Bhante Bodhidhamma shares his recurring insight about identifying the 'single ingredient' that makes vipassanā meditation work, focusing this time on equanimity (upekkhā). He explores the etymology and meaning of equanimity as 'calmness and composure' and 'fairness of mind,' contrasting it with his definition of suffering as 'wanting things to be other than they are.' The essay examines the subtleties of different ways to understand equanimity—from contentment to allowing—while acknowledging the limits of our control over experience.

Drawing from the Vipassanā Guidelines used on retreat, Bhante explains how meditation instructions encourage us to observe experience 'without any interference whatsoever, simply watching' without controlling, manipulating, judging or questioning. This non-interfering awareness directly addresses the habitual dissatisfaction (dukkha) that arises from our needy manipulation of experience based on greed, ill-will, or delusion. The essay demonstrates how developing equanimity through mindful observation naturally reduces suffering, while playfully concluding that perhaps mindfulness itself might be the 'one key thing' after all.

I have a recurring conceit that amuses me. It is that I have identified the single ingredient that makes vipassanā “work”. It becomes the topic of my thoughts for a short period until I notice some other aspect which then becomes the one key thing. Recently it’s been equanimity. Equanimity is defined in the Oxford Dictionary as “calmness and composure, especially in a difficult situation”. Apparently, it derives “from Latin *aequanimitas*, from *aequus* ‘equal’ + *animus* ‘mind’” and also has the sense of “fairness, impartiality” as we would expect of a Judge presiding over a trial. If you’ve done a retreat with me, you may remember me defining suffering as “wanting things to be other than they are”. This is the opposite of equanimity; it’s the disturbance of the mind trying to make experience fit the ideal, the rejection of the present. Another way of defining equanimity, then, might be as “contentment with things being just as they are”. But this appears to carry the invalid suggestion that we should be content with things like poverty and hunger, ecological collapse and war. So, maybe, instead of “contentment” it should be “allowing things to be just as they are”? But the problem with “allowing”—with its connotations of “permit” and “let”—is that it suggests too much control. We see from meditation that we are not in control. If we were, we would choose not to have incessant destructive thoughts and strong emotions like fear and anger arise. Equanimity is some-

thing of all of these, though. In the Vipassanā Guidelines we read on retreat, we are encouraged to examine our experience “without any interference whatsoever; ... simply watching” in a way “that does not control or manipulate ... judge or question”. What this is really pointing out is the kind of needy manipulation of experience we habitually make. Whatever our experience, we interfere because we want it to be different; we control and manipulate because we want it to go a different way; we judge and question from a place of imagined superiority or inferiority. This wanting things to be other than they are is the fundamental dissatisfaction the Buddha labelled “dukkha”. The work of meditation is finding a way where our relationship with experience isn’t one of habitually interfering like this, isn’t automatically wanting things to be other than they are. It’s clear that there is something in the relationship we have with experience that makes it dissatisfying. When this relationship is based in “greed” (wanting something to bolster our sense of self), “ill-will” (wanting something to diminish our, or somebody else’s, sense of wellbeing), or “delusion” (not caring), it results in dissatisfaction, in-dukkha. We know that when we don’t react to difficult situations, when we give ourselves time to calm down, to get perspective, we generally handle them better. It is this same mechanism that these vipassanā instructions develop. They contain all we need. We simply watch, without any interference whatsoever—without controlling, manipulating, judging or questioning—whatever arises in our experience. It is in this way that we develop equanimity, and with more equanimity there’s less dukkha. So this is why my topic of the month is equanimity. But as I write this, it occurs to me that, without awareness, without mindfulness, we would find it difficult to develop equanimity. Hmm, so maybe mindfulness is that one key thing then ...? 😊

Everyday Mindfulness

Noirin Sheahan · 3 min read

This essay explores the Buddha's teaching on 'full awareness' (sampajañña) in daily life, moving beyond formal meditation practice to integrate mindfulness into ordinary activities. Noirin Sheahan examines the Buddha's specific instructions for maintaining awareness while 'going forth and returning' and 'looking ahead and looking away,' showing how these simple practices can transform routine activities like commuting to work or shopping for groceries into opportunities for insight.

The essay demonstrates how broad-brush noting techniques differ from detailed Mahasi practice, using phrases like 'going to work' to maintain contextual awareness alongside present-moment sensation. Through practical examples, it reveals how everyday mindfulness can expose hidden emotions and attitudes - such as reluctance about work or the subtle dukkha of transience when activities fail to deliver lasting satisfaction.

Particularly valuable is the distinction between full awareness and self-awareness, clarifying that mindfulness doesn't require constant self-monitoring but rather clear engagement with present activity. The teaching offers accessible methods for maintaining continuity of practice throughout daily life, supporting practitioners in developing consistent awareness that extends far beyond formal sitting meditation.

Full Awareness

The Buddha asks us to act in 'full awareness' when we go about the ordinary tasks of daily life. The first exercise he prescribes is full awareness while going forth and returning.

Say we are walking to our workplace. As we note the sensations of walking in the legs and feet, attention is drawn into the present moment. For full awareness the context must also be born in mind: we are going to work. Full awareness requires a broad understanding of our actions alongside the stream of sensations that accompanies them.

Instead of the detailed note we use for Mahasi practice, broad-brush phrases work better here. On our way to work we can note: 'Going to work... going to work.' Sounds obvious but how easy it is to forget the bigger picture. We go to work on autopilot, so

familiar with every step of the journey that we can devote our time to worrying or day-dreaming. The note 'going to work' lifts us out of the doldrums, lets us feel more purposeful, helps us appreciate our surroundings.

Reminding ourselves of the broader context can expose hidden emotions. We might feel a deep reluctance to note 'going to work', for example, but feel happy later in the days as we retrace our steps, noting 'going home'. This highlights a negative attitude to work. If we do not make the note, that negativity might later sneak out as carelessness, not bothering to finish tasks properly, alienating colleagues and making the situation worse.

However, if we note 'going to work' the weariness or anxiety or depression we associate with work comes to the fore. Although it might feel worse than heading for the job on autopilot, bearing with the feelings means the negativity can be acknowledged. Acknowledging suffering is a form of self-care and has a very beneficial impact psychologically. We are much less likely to act from negativity once we're aware of it. We might note some satisfaction in completing a task, find pleasure in cooperating with colleagues. Imperceptibly, perhaps, the situation starts to improve.

Even for less emotionally charged activities, the experience of going forward can differ from returning. Say I have to nip down to the shop for groceries. I may be bright and purposeful at the outset. My step is light and I look with interest at the neighbour's gardens. Coming home my steps might be more plodding, my eyes downcast. What I am seeing here is the dukkha of transience. Each new activity offers a glimmer of hope that this world can make us happy. But when the choice between carrots and broccoli, biscuits and cake have been made and all the money spent, it becomes clear that my shopping spree has not delivered the goods I was secretly hoping for.

Of course the pattern can vary. For instance, the prospect of meeting friends may find us brighter on the way home than heading out. Worthwhile noting as it helps us appreciate our friends when we see how they lift our mood.

The second task the Buddha prescribes is to be fully aware when looking ahead and looking away. Say we are returning from the shops on autopilot, rehashing our problems, eyes vaguely scanning the pavement. Now and again, we look up and ahead in a semi-automatic health-and-safety check of the broader environment. If we have primed ourselves to see 'looking ahead' as worth registering, that automatic check might remind us to be mindful. Looking ahead reminds us of our destination, so we can return to full awareness instead of being lost in negativity.

While looking ahead is often stimulating, looking away often carries subtle dukkha. A friend practising mindfulness of speech found that when reacting against what another person was saying, her head turned slightly aside. Once she had detected the pattern, she was then able to use this as a ‘wake-up’ call to notice aversion and her communication could then be much more honest and straightforward.

Full awareness does not mean self-awareness. Say we are preparing dinner. We may be cutting carrots, too absorbed in the task to note ‘preparing dinner’ or ‘cutting carrots’. Then suddenly we become aware of ‘me’ who is cutting carrots and worry that we weren’t being mindful because we hadn’t been self-aware. That’s a mistake. If we hadn’t been lost in thought while cutting carrots, then we were being mindful. The sense of self comes and goes and can disappear altogether when we are fully absorbed in an activity.

Following the Buddha’s exercises for Full Awareness supports mindfulness throughout all aspects of daily life. Instead of taking ourselves and our situation for granted we wake up to the extraordinary treasure we call awareness.

Exalted, Unexalted and Other Mind-states as Foundations for Right Awareness

Noirin Sheahan · 50 min

This dharma talk continues the exploration of the third foundation of the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10) - contemplation of mind (cittānupassanā). Noirin examines five crucial pairings of mind-states: contracted vs. distracted mind (relating to dullness/lethargy and restlessness); exalted vs. unexalted mind (connected to the four brahmavihāra); unsurpassed vs. surpassed mind (assessing developmental capacity); concentrated vs. unconcentrated mind (vicarā and vitakka levels); and liberated vs. unliberated mind (freedom from self-view). The talk illuminates how contracted mind gravitates toward pleasant feelings with subjective orientation ("this"), while distracted mind seeks escape from unpleasant feelings through objective searching ("that"). The exploration of exalted mind through metta practice reveals how awareness can expand to pervade space with loving-kindness, while unexalted states teach acceptance of limitations. The discussion of concentrated and unconcentrated mind uses the beautiful analogy of a bee tracking and alighting on flowers, showing how restlessness can paradoxically lead to deeper concentration. The final pairing addresses the liberated mind's freedom from self-identification - moments when experience continues without the constructed sense of "I" or "mine," revealing the characteristic of anattā (not-self).

Tonight I want to continue looking at the third section of the *Satipaṭṭhāna* Sutta, the contemplation of mind. Last night we looked at the first three exercises to know when the mind is or is not under the influence of greed, anger and delusion.

The next line of the Sutta reads: "One understands contracted mind as contracted mind and distracted mind as distracted mind." Contracted mind is understood as being under the influence of dullness and lethargy, while distracted mind is what we normally call restlessness.

We can distinguish this exercise from our work with the corresponding hindrances. When we keep falling asleep we're dealing with the hindrance of dullness and lethargy. The mind will be contracted but we won't be able to discern this because we're too dozy. After working mindfully with the hindrance for a period we may find that awareness steadies and we can observe the state quite closely. We still feel dozy, dull, but we're not asleep. We're aware of dullness. We might also be aware of the underlying feelings. They're usually pleasant feelings.

To rest attention in the third *satipaṭṭhāna*, we focus on the mind that knows these pleasant feelings. Contracted mind describes this very well. It only knows those pleasant feelings. It doesn't know anything else. It's as if we've retreated from the world, locked ourselves into a comforting stupor.

In contrast to this, we have distracted mind. When we're fidgeting or can't keep track of the multitude of thoughts that keep cropping up, then we're dealing with the hindrance of restlessness. Again, after working with this mindfully, awareness may come to rest in the third *satipaṭṭhāna*, and we can then experience the mind that's continually moving, searching for something. It's the same mind state in both cases, but because awareness is now focused on the mind state, those distractions can't get very far. They only disturb us to the extent necessary to register in awareness.

In contrast to the pleasant feelings associated with the contracted mind, the feelings associated with the distracted mind are usually unpleasant. The habit is to resist unpleasant feelings and so the mind moves around trying to get away from the disturbance, whereas in the case of dullness and lethargy the mind contracts around the underlying pleasant feelings.

The two states can also be contrasted in terms of subjectivity and objectivity. In the contracted mind, the mind is subjectively orientated. It's all me. There's no room for anything else, anything objective. If it could summon the energy to describe experience, it might say "this," because we use the word "this" to describe what's immediate, present, within my grasp, mine. This chair I'm sitting on, this idea I'm considering. We use the word "that" to describe something that's external, not part of me, that chair you're sitting on, that idea you're putting forward.

The distracted mind is looking outwards. Its orientation is objective. It's searching the external world to escape its own displeasure. Each moment it lands on something new to call "that." At times we might see the mind transiting between the two states. One moment it contracts around a pleasant feeling, perceives it as subjective, as this and mine. Next moment it detects an unpleasant feeling and bounces away, calling it that.

When awareness is steady enough to see these transitions, we get a chance to see how the mind constructs such radically different versions of reality based on feelings. Pleasant feelings are perceived as here, within our grasp, internal, mine. They are readily labelled as "this." These unpleasant feelings are perceived as external, objective, something that can be pushed away, not mine, labelled as "that."

This and that, subjectivity and objectivity, mine and not mine, they feed off one another. As the Buddha says in the discourse on the destruction of craving: "When this exists, that comes to be; with the arising of this, that arises." The better we can steady awareness around contracted and distracted states of mind, the better we can see how craving causes us to construct two separate worlds. One is internal, contracted around pleasant feeling. The other is external, extensive, allowing the mind bounce from one object to another.

When we fully understand these minute movements of mind, we'll see through the delusion caused by craving. When consciousness stops even for a moment clinging to the idea of this self as the ultimate reference point for the world, then the multitude of "that's" – that person, that challenge, that obligation – also disappear and we're liberated from the stress of false view. It might only be momentary, but it punches a little hole in delusions.

Thus we should welcome lethargy, dullness and restlessness whenever they come our way. Work mindfully with them until the mind can rest in the third *satipaṭṭhāna*. Teach us what is meant by contracted and distracted mind and how we create our world out of pleasant and unpleasant feelings.

The next instruction is: "One understands exalted mind as exalted mind and unexalted mind as unexalted mind." An exalted mind, sometimes termed great mind, is based in one of the four *Brahmavihāra*, the divine abodes, the ways that wisdom manifests in the world. The divine abodes all have goodwill as their basis, wishing ourselves and others well.

Mettā, friendliness, is the form goodwill takes by default, when there is no especially joyful, sad or challenging atmosphere associated with the encounter. If we meet someone who is going through a hard time, goodwill takes the hue of compassion. We wish that their troubles might cease. When there's something to celebrate, goodwill takes on the flavour of *muditā*, appreciative joy. And when we come across limitations or unskillfulness in ourselves or others, the response is equanimity, a tender understanding and acceptance of worldly imperfection.

On this side of liberation, we'll often miss the mark in relationship, believe we're acting with pure goodwill, but in reality hooked by what's termed the near enemy of the *Brahmavihāra*. Friendliness is often mixed in with attachment. We're anxious to sustain the relationship, needing the other person's company, good humour, esteem, and so on. Often we don't even notice the subtle expectations we have of our friends. It's only when we feel let down that we realise how many strings we were attaching to our acts of friendship.

Pity can masquerade as compassion. We overblow the problem, underestimate the person's resources, forgetting that their essence has not been diminished by whatever misfortune has come their way. We think they can't cope without our help, but then get overwhelmed and feel burdened by responsibility.

The near enemy of *muditā* is excitement. We build too much out of the occasion, go to excess in our efforts to celebrate. Finally, we can mistake indifference for equanimity. When some challenge comes up in our relationship we ignore this or shrug our shoulders rather than feel whatever disappointment, fear or anger may have been evoked. Work through those feelings to acceptance of the limitations of the relationship.

To get to know the exalted mind we can practice *mettā* but with a degree of curiosity about our experience. You might experiment with the Buddha's guidance for *mettā* practice: "One dwells suffusing one quarter with a mind filled with loving kindness, then a second, then a third, and a fourth quarter. Thus one abides, suffusing the whole world, up, down and across, everywhere, all around, with a mind filled with loving-kindness, expanded, immeasurable, free from hatred and ill-will."

This doesn't mention any categories of people. In fact, it doesn't mention people at all, not even other beings. It puts aside the usual ideas of self and other that we use in *mettā* practice. Instead, we use the concept of space and radiate loving-kindness up, down and across, everywhere, all around.

Whatever this might involve at an ultimate level, we can also see this as an exercise in imagination. We're training ourselves to imagine a world pervaded with kindness. If we imagine this often enough, it will become our inner reality.

If and when *mettā* seems stable, we can become curious about the mind that practices *mettā*. The Buddha describes this as expanded, immeasurable. Can you sense how imagining space around you requires a mind that itself is spacious? The mind expands to meet the space it imagines.

But of course there will be challenges. Our imagination will reach limits where we cannot conceive of kindness. This shows us the unexalted mind. At times the unexalted mind involves some form of ill will. We project demons into the space around us instead of good wishes. So we get frightened if these demons are angry that they're preventing us practicing *mettā*. Or we might just turn away from the difficulty as the mind shrinks into dullness.

At other times, the unexalted mind may involve greed. We project an exalted, saintly image of ourselves into the space around and then believe ourselves to be this great person with a big open heart. We might also get excited by all the good deeds we could do and all the people we could benefit, in which case restlessness forms the basis for the unexalted mind.

Alternatively, when our imagination reaches its limit, we start wondering what's going on. Is there really all this space around me? Can I really fill it with *mettā*? In this case, the unexalted mind is based in the hindrance of doubt.

Because the Sutta asks us to get to know both the exalted and unexalted mind, we don't have to think of the latter as a failure. In fact, the more curious we can get about it, the better. The positive attitude helps us work through whichever hindrance emerges.

The unexalted mind isn't necessarily based on any of the hindrances. We can also experience this as quite peaceful, the mind as simply knowing. There isn't active goodwill being generated, but there's no ill will either.

The Buddha's pairing of exalted and unexalted mind helps us foster a beneficial relationship between these. At one moment we pervade the space around us with warm good wishes. The next moment we get curious about the mind that practices *mettā*. We sense the expanded consciousness, the exalted mind. Quietly the image of space filled with *mettā* disappears. For a while there is just the knowing mind. Awareness gradually lands on other aspects of the being who meditates. Feelings, body, perception, unexalted mind.

The memory of the vast *mettā*-filled space fosters acceptance of our conditional nature. Gratitude for the Dhamma which allows our being learn its true nature. *Mettā* flows into the being with unexalted mind until it is ready once again to pervade the space around it with goodwill. Thus unexalted mind can provide a skilful break during *mettā* practice, allowing us to rest and recharge our *mettā* batteries.

The next instruction is to understand unsurpassed mind as unsurpassed mind and surpassed mind as surpassed mind. This is often taken as referring to *jhāna* practices where the highest *jhāna* represents the unsurpassed mind.

In his book *Satipaṭṭhāna, a Practical Guide*, Anālayo suggests that this can also be used in *vipassanā*, asking ourselves: has the mind been developed to its maximum capacity for this particular meditation, or can we continue to develop?

The standard *vipassanā* instructions don't explicitly include developing the mind. We are simply to register what we experience without judgment. Within non-judgmental awareness the mind develops of its own accord. The factors of enlightenment strengthen as the mind moves through hindrances towards greater clarity and ease.

When the factors of enlightenment are strong we have the unsurpassed mind. There is mindfulness. We can maintain focus in present experience. We're not repeatedly getting lost in thought or falling asleep. There is concentration. We can focus on some aspect of experience and track this. There is equanimity. We're able to maintain an objective, balanced stance rather than being sucked in by desires identified by views and thoughts. There is tranquillity. Preferring calm to excitement, we keep dropping desires and aversions. There is energy. We have the will and resources needed to maintain mindfulness, concentration and the other factors of enlightenment. There is investigation. The mind is intelligent, curious, discerning. There is joy. We are interested in experience, glad to be learning the Dhamma.

This exercise in the *Satipaṭṭhāna* Sutta asks us to look back into that well-balanced mind, to recognise it as unsurpassed. The word unsurpassed might make the exercise seem impossible, as if we should be looking into the mind of a saint. But we can interpret it to mean that awareness can't detect a flaw that can't be fixed.

If awareness detects grasping, the factors of enlightenment can step up to put this right. For example, we could shift focus, let attention rest in the breath or other neutral calming sensations. Energy could be stepped up a gear in order to resist the pull of desire, the push of aversion. Mindfulness could become more alert to the fading away of experience, moment after moment, which helps us acknowledge the futility of grasping. Equanimity might draw attention back from detail to see the larger picture.

These adjustments happen naturally, organically, without forcing. The factors work together as a team to restore their formation. Paṇḍit's wild geese analogy is very useful here. At times their V-shaped formation gets disturbed, some flying too fast, others going too slow. But then the instinct for coordination comes to the fore. Various birds come forward, others fall back, until order is restored. The flock needs to get to their destination, and each individual is willing to fall into line with that overriding objective.

In the same way, the factors of enlightenment get scattered. For example, when we get too curious and fall prey to the desire to know and understand experience more clearly. Unwittingly, we start forcing our agenda, put ourselves under pressure to hurry towards enlightenment. This is the surpassed mind.

But mindfulness detects the problem and then the adjustments start: changing focus, widening attention, noticing that everything is always slipping away, fading out. Our overriding objective is to maintain the objective observer stance and so traits like curiosity and tranquillity take a back seat as the mind steadies itself to resist the pull of grasping.

If order can be restored, if we again sense awareness brushing against experience rather than digging in, shaping it, then we can again reflect that the mind at the moment is unsurpassed. It knows how to maintain its own objectivity.

Anālayo describes the unsurpassed mind as one which can continue to develop. For example, we can use the unsurpassed mind to develop one of the factors of enlightenment or a virtue like patience. Often we're developing wisdom. We're seeing that sensations and feelings, moods and emotions, thoughts and images, all experience arises and passes away, that any attempt to cling brings *dukkha*. In other words, we're learning about the three characteristics of existence: *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anattā*. Transience, unsatisfactoriness and not-self.

But there comes a stage when we can no longer sustain equanimity. The hindrances are threatening to overpower us, and we sense it best to draw the meditation to a close. Here we have an example of the surpassed mind, one which, using Anālayo's description, cannot be further developed. We've run out of meditative steam, need to let daily life recharge our batteries.

What I often do here is to make the determination to wait until there is equanimity in the movement from sitting to standing. For as long as I feel impatience, the desire to plunge straight into daily life, I keep relaxing, allowing that desire to burn off, reminding myself that this is the surpassed mind, the mind that has reached its limit of development, a worthy *satipaṭṭhāna* for mindfulness.

Aversions and judgments may emerge, but again I note these, reminding myself that this surpassed mind is what I have to work with in daily life, so I might as well make friends with it. At some stage I notice the mind readying itself to stand and the body starting to sway or the eyes to open. Until it happens I never know how the body will actually do the business of standing up. These movements are sensed as an equanimous follow-on to the earlier decision to bring the meditation to a close.

These final minutes of the meditation are an exercise in making peace with limitations, accepting that the mind has done its job and cannot be further developed in this meditation setting. The transition back into daily life is wiser and more peaceful as a result.

Knowing our limitations is a great asset in life, knowing when we need to stop pushing ourselves to achieve some goal, when we need to step back, rest, recharge our batteries. The label surpassed mind can also help us make peace with the mental limitations we detect in daily life. For example, when we sense the mind as dull or stuck or lazy. We might not even have enough energy to work out which of the hindrances is overpowering us. We just know we're not in the most wholesome condition. The phrase surpassed mind lets us put all such states into a box, helps us see them objectively, draw out the awareness which can then start to tease some wisdom out of the situation.

The next pairing is between the concentrated and unconcentrated mind. These refer to the two levels of concentration we encounter in *vipassanā*, termed *vicāra* and *vitakka* in Pāli. *Vitakka* is described as applied thought. Here we're making an effort to focus the mind. We could be trying to follow the breath. Images and fantasies keep intruding, and we have to keep reminding ourselves of our goal. The notes, rising, falling, provide that reminder, like a lasso we throw around our scattered mind, drawing it back home. The image of a bee seeking nectar from a flower is also used.

The flower is bobbing around in the breeze while the bee hovers a few inches away, tracking the flower to and fro, waiting for the exact moment to alight. When that opportunity comes, we have *vitakka*, described as sustained thought. This is a deeper, more restful level of concentration. Just as the bee is now being carried about by the flower, no longer needs to hover and track. We are being carried along by sensations and feelings, no longer needing any effort to maintain mindfulness.

When we're following this particular exercise on the contemplation of mind, we're not so much trying to focus attention on the breath or other object as detecting whether or not we're focused. Are we putting some effort into containing images and thoughts, gathering them in? Or is the mind resting, being carried along by present experience? This is especially useful if we sense poor concentration as a problem in meditation and that we're failing because we don't have good concentration. It takes the pressure off as it no longer matters what the level of concentration is, only that we know whether we have to make an effort or whether we're relaxing.

There are a number of other benefits to this exercise. One is that when we get interested in the unconcentrated mind we find we can now focus on this. So the lack of concentration actually leads to concentration. What I find is that the unconcentrated mind is divided. One desire chases a certain stream of thought, while another desire wants to chase another. The bee is hovering around a big bunch of flowers, can't decide which to alight upon. The general feeling of division is unpleasant, aversive, and thus we easily link this state with a sense of failure. Instead, we should simply recognise it as

unconcentrated mind and see it as a worthy *satipaṭṭhāna* exercise. A level of equanimity and tranquillity develops. This allows us make peace with the tendency towards restlessness, getting scattered.

Focusing on the concentrated mind, we sense the pleasure of tranquillity. Of course, there is the danger of identification with this pleasant feeling, thinking, I am calm, and then grasping to the feeling. So here we are seeing the opposite to restlessness, the mind closing up within a pleasant haze, growing dull and lethargic. The bee has landed on the flower, but is sucking it dry. You do sometimes see a bee going to sleep on a flower, and in the same way we can actually lose consciousness when the mind is very concentrated. We're still sitting upright, but not registering anything consciously.

Curiosity about the concentrated and unconcentrated mind prevents this closure and paradoxically I find I can actually start looking forward to losing concentration. I'm curious to discover what will be lost when concentration moves back to *vicāra*. What I sometimes find is the mind moving from subjectivity to objectivity. If you remember back to the Sutta on the destruction of craving, the Buddha asks us to study the relationship between this and that.

The concentrated mind, I find, is focusing on what it terms this, thinking of sensations and feelings as subjective, which is to be expected, as the feeling of a concentrated mind is pleasant. So we tend to think of this experience as me and mine. As concentration weakens, we notice unpleasant feelings which we label as that, as external, objective. Now we sense a division between the observer and the object. If there is enough equanimity, we can then focus more closely on the unpleasant sensations and concentration returns. We're again in the realm of subjectivity, but making peace with unpleasant feelings that we would normally externalise as some storyline about how badly the world treats us. The bee has alighted again, but on a thorny flower and needing constant encouragement not to fly off, to keep detecting the nectar that is on offer within the pain.

Thus, the pairing of concentrated and unconcentrated mind can develop a very helpful relationship between these two where the unconcentrated mind is recognized as an opportunity to expand our mental horizons to make peace with a world that doesn't satisfy. Rob Burbea, for many years the resident teacher at Gaia House, has a series of Dhamma talks titled *In Praise of Restlessness*, which I find very inspiring. He identifies the danger of overvaluing tranquillity so that we ignore anything that disturbs concentration. He uses Greek mythology to inspire us to value instead the mind that lacks tranquillity, struggles with concentration, seeing this as a valiant, heroic attempt to embrace the tragic, crazy world with all its contradictions.

The final pairing in this section of the Sutta is between the liberated and unliberated mind. Full liberation will only come at the moment of enlightenment. But the Buddha obviously wants us to practice this exercise before then. Anālayo suggests we interpret the liberated mind as one which is liberated from the view of self.

Our usual effort in *Vipassanā* is to be the objective observer, not interfering in any way, just observing. Bhante uses the analogy of a sailor on lookout duty. The sailor climbs up the mast to the crow's nest, a lookout post giving a broad overview of the ship and its surrounds. Without this lookout, the ship could strike rocks or run unprepared into a storm. In the same way, our position as objective observer lets us spot the telltale signs of desire, aversion, grasping. Instead of getting caught up in these, mindfulness lets us steer safely through the storm.

Here we have the unsurpassed mind. The factors of enlightenment are strong. However, we are identifying as the observer and to that extent bound up in the *dukkha* which comes with identification. We usually aren't aware of this attachment till we lose the observer position. As far as we know, we're just watching equanimously, not interfering. But when thoughts begin to get sticky again, we realise we're slipping from our lofty perch on the crow's nest, falling into the bedlam we've been watching from above.

Mindfulness of the *dukkha* which accompanies the fall from grace helps us lose attachment to the state of objective observer. It becomes easier to see the tough times when we get caught up and identified with thoughts and emotions as opportunities to develop compassion for our unenlightened condition.

At times, when the factors are strong and we're in our crow's nest, observing objectively, the sense of ourselves as observer can simply disappear. There are sensations and feelings, perceptions and mental states, but these are just happening of their own accord. They no longer seem to be happening to me. There's no central reference point for it all.

When we say that the sense of self disappears, this sounds like a form of death. But the disappearance is quiet, undramatic. It's not that there's a long struggle and we eventually surrender. It happens at times when we're not struggling, just watching. The sense of self is simply a mental construction. It's a perspective we're putting on experience, using our cognitive abilities. Cognition puts a shape on the millions of sensations, feelings, what we could call atoms of experience, registering each moment. It helps slow things down mentally, makes it all more manageable.

One of the ways we frame experience is through the concept of self. We identify some of the atoms as me or mine and some as yours or his or some other way outside ourselves. But this distinction is learned. As a baby we weren't able to do this so it's not essential to life. It takes effort to frame experience like this, although the process is so habitual we don't notice that it's actually voluntary. We're willing ourselves to see the world as either self or other. At times in meditation the mind relaxes, stops making that effort, and the sense of self quietly disappears.

This is the liberated mind, the experience of not-self, *anattā*. Sensations, feelings etc. continue to appear but we stop dividing these into boxes of mine or not mine. It's a joyful experience. We've dropped the burden of thinking of ourselves as someone with a future and a past and so many roles and responsibilities to uphold. In fact, there's seldom any desire to think. We're so riveted by present experience. Bhante uses the analogy of a baby who's so fascinated by what they're seeing that the jaw drops. They stare open-mouthed at the world in a state of total wonder.

Although we probably won't want to think, the Buddha wants us to reflect that we are experiencing a mind that's been liberated from the view of self. This can actually be a challenge, as the absence of self may not be immediately apparent. We might not be able to work out what's happening. We just know we're seeing things differently. Experience is felt more intensely. There's no interest in anything but present experience. But other than that, everything continues normally.

In her book, *The Experience of No Self*, Bernadette Roberts describes how she knew something had changed during a particular meditation, but couldn't work out what it was. She went about her daily business, she was a mother with teenage children, for a few days, till she suddenly realized that her sense of self had dropped away.

Although the absence of self does not immediately trouble us, reflecting on this may trouble us. We fear what we do not understand and thus the very uptight self might emerge wanting to know what this implies. How can I be absent? How can the world be surviving without me? And so a multitude of contradictory thoughts may surface. Rather than follow these, we should simply reflect that this is the unliberated mind and feel the push and pull of desire and aversion underlying our fears and doubts. As we work mindfully through our fear of *anattā*, we start to appreciate the joy and freedom of the state, trusting that nothing essential is lost when we stop framing experience in terms of I, me, mine.

At times we may be able to study the transition from liberated to unliberated or vice versa. We see the effort of will that goes into framing experience in terms of self. Notice the relaxation as we stop. We might think that the liberated mind is always superior to

the unliberated mind. But on this side of enlightenment anyhow, it is essential to be able to construct a sense of self at times. For example, we can learn to bring forth a sense of self that attaches firmly to notions of restraint in order to resist desires based in greed, hatred and delusion. When that work is done, our knowledge of the liberated mind helps us let go of attachment to the self who has just rescued us from this latest peril.

In summary then, this section of the *Satipaṭṭhāna* Sutta gives us five ways of probing the mind: asking whether it's contracted, meaning dull and lethargic, or distracted, restless, whether or not it's in an exalted state of goodwill, whether it's unsurpassed, can be developed further, or surpassed, has reached its limit for this session, whether it's concentrated. Has the bee landed on the flower, or is it hovering about, trying to track a flower that's bobbing about in the breeze? The final exercise is to ask whether the mind has been liberated from the sense of self, or whether we're identified as the observer.

For each pairing we have the refrain, three variations on the basic exercise. First, we have the option to practice externally, to notice these mind states in others. When we've detected our mind is now exalted, we can reflect others experience the exalted mind. And when we move to the unexalted state we can reflect others experience an unexalted mind. We can do this for all of the five pairings. Realising that these states are part of the general human condition will loosen attachment, help us feel less ashamed of what we're deeming the less worthy states, less proud of those we judge as a terrific achievement. It also strengthens our goodwill and respect for others when we reflect that they can experience states like exalted mind, unsurpassed mind and liberated mind.

The second option is to notice that these states arise and pass away. Again, this helps us let go of attachment. We might feel mightily proud of an unsurpassed mind. But if we reflect that this wasn't here a few minutes ago, we might also realise that this is just a temporary visitor. We should enjoy it while it's here, but not be too surprised when it fades away.

The final option is simply to note there is mind. We're no longer trying to identify whether the mind is concentrated or surpassed or in any of the other states. This final option requires no effort whatsoever beyond focusing on the mind, the knowing aspect of experience. We could use the Mahāsi note, knowing, knowing, to help maintain focus. The mind may pass through many of the states described, exalted, non-exalted, contracted, distracted, etc. We're letting all this happen quite naturally, organically. However, we're not making the effort to note exactly which state the mind is in. We're

getting to know the mind intuitively, rather than by deliberate reflections. This is actually our normal *Vipassanā* practice except that we're focusing on the mind, the knowing of experience, rather than our more usual focus on sensations and feelings.

Let's finish with a verse from the Dhammapada. Mind is the forerunner of all evil. Speak or act with wicked mind, then suffering follows, even as the wheel follows the hoof of the ox. Mind is the forerunner of all good. Speak or act with pure mind, then happiness follows, even as the shadow that never leaves.

Excitement, Boredom, Contentment

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 2 min read

This teaching examines the psychological trap of mistaking excitement for genuine happiness, a confusion that drives endless cycles of seeking and disappointment. Bhante Bodhidhamma illustrates how initial excitement—whether from worldly pursuits or even meditation experiences—inevitably gives way to boredom and restless searching for the next stimulation. He shows how consumerism exploits this pattern, feeding on our constant need for novelty and 'more.'

The essay reveals how this cycle can lead from disappointment through aversion to deeper boredom and potentially despair. Drawing on fundamental Buddhist insights about the nature of craving (taṇhā) and the unsatisfactoriness (dukkha) inherent in seeking happiness through external stimulation, the teaching offers practical remedies.

The path forward involves cultivating contentment through mindful repetition with good intention, practicing renunciation by letting go of constant planning, and developing present-moment awareness in simple activities. This approach transforms routine from a source of boredom into an opportunity for genuine satisfaction, demonstrating how contentment—rather than excitement—provides the foundation for lasting peace and wellbeing in both meditation practice and daily life.

It is when we confuse excitement with happiness that the trouble starts. You can get excited about anything – trainspotting, juggling, tiddly-winks. It does not matter what it is, so long as it excites us. We can absorb quickly into that mental state and for that time it is, well, heaven. There are those who absorb into beautiful states through their meditation and may even mistake them for Nibbana. So long as we can be lifted into that state, all is well. But when we don't get the same gratification, then disappointment sets in. After a joyous meal or party with old friends or family, there is a call for 'let's do it again!' The second time just does not live up to it. How disappointing! Suggestions for another meeting are met with rictus smiles and forced nods. Come the time, excuses abound. But what if you have to do the same thing again and again. Like work that once was so interesting. Or the breath in sitting that once was a haven. That is when the aversion sets in. A type of restless aversion that moves towards listlessness and a feeling of meaninglessness. Then a deeper boredom sets in. A sense of wasted time. Then the driving search for something - anything else. The fidgety swipes through websites. The restless flicking through channels. Scrolling through the social media. The pursuit of

biscuits. The mind in meditation starts to live in its virtual reality. And we find it! Now there is joy. And off we go again, indulging in a new passion. This time it is foraging for mushrooms, playing THE Great Big War Game, scanning up and down the body in sitting. And the whole cycle starts off again. How I save the world from ecological disaster. Consumerism depends on this sort of intoxication. And it is a religion that is onto a real winner, because once it has hooked you, it knows you are always after the NEW. New means good, means excitement. That is greed, of course. But how quickly we are bored. And at the first tweak of boredom, we are off 'seeking pleasures here and there'. Boredom is the underlying engine consumerism depends on. However great the excitement, boredom comes in equal measure. And the more excitement we indulge, the more we raise the bar, the greater the excitement has to be. Greed in all its forms is voracious. More, once an adjective, becomes a noun. We simply want More. Should there come a time when excitements lose their gloss and boredom, feelings of wasted time, of a vacuous lifestyle set in, then there arises the loss of hope of ever enjoying life again – and that beds into despair. That is endgame of course. But for most of us, we can take boredom as a warning. And the cure? Repetition with good intention. Re-establish why you are doing your job. And do it for that reason. Raise a sense of care to be excellent. Interest reappears. Acknowledging that a lot of what we do is useless entertainment and determine to spend the time more usefully. The joy of living returns. Practising renunciation. Let go of all that planning. What are we going to do this evening, this weekend, next month. Do something simple instead. Over a series of weekends, the same walk, the same simple meal. Draw the attention into the present doing, and develop contentment. This is the way it is and it is ok. Contentment is poison to boredom.

Exiting Lockdown

Noirin Sheahan · 2 min read

In this timely reflection, Noirin Sheahan examines the spiritual challenges and opportunities that arise during transitions, particularly as we emerge from periods of enforced withdrawal like lockdown or retreat back into active social and work life. She identifies the common patterns we experience during such transitions: projecting excessive happiness into future experiences, only to face disappointment when reality doesn't match our expectations, or conversely, becoming attached to withdrawal and dreading the return to busyness.

The essay presents mindfulness as the key tool for navigating these transitions skillfully. When caught up in pleasant expectations, Noirin suggests we pause to savor the anticipatory joy itself as a form of muditā (appreciative joy), cultivating gratitude while grounding our expectations in reality. When experiencing dread about re-engagement, she encourages us to fully feel this unpleasantness as a direct experience of dukkha—the unsatisfactory nature of conditioned existence and the First Noble Truth.

Drawing on fundamental Buddhist insights about suffering and liberation, Noirin transforms what might seem like mundane psychological challenges into profound opportunities for spiritual development. She emphasizes the importance of patience with our inevitable mistakes and the value of community support and daily mindfulness practice in navigating life's transitions with 'minimal misery, maximal learning and deeper gratitude.'

Exiting Lockdown

As the restrictions start easing again, many of you will be engaging with social and work life more fully. Similarly for us here at Satipanya, as the winter retreat closes, we start looking outwards, forwards, planning outings, visits, work.

Transitions are tricky. We so easily lose the run of ourselves, expect too much of whatever is on the horizon. You might be dreaming of booking a meal in your favorite restaurant, on retreat we're dreaming of the first breakfast when we can chat. We project too much happiness into these and get disappointed, bewildered, angry when the initial happiness fades, leaving us as grumpy as ever! Or it can be the other way round, we suddenly realise how attached we've grown to the enforced withdrawal of lockdown, of retreat, and dread all the coming busyness. Most of us suffer from both afflictions – expecting wonders one moment, dreading change the next!

The good news in all this is that transitions are also rich opportunity for spiritual

practice. It's where we see our attachments and delusion most clearly, and thereby find a precious opportunity to work with these, find new ways of responding. As always, mindfulness is key. Can we tune into whatever emotions are driving our thoughts, actions, speech? Say we're being fired up by expectation. Stop a moment, acknowledge and explore this experience. Expectation usually has a pleasant, happy flavour. Stopping to savor that is a form of *mudita* – appreciative joy. It is good to be able to look forward to things, to have faith that we can enjoy life. Anyone who has suffered from depression knows what a great gift this is. Stopping to enjoy our anticipation of happiness cultivates gratitude for mental well-being as well as whatever we are looking forward to. Stopping also grounds us, makes our expectations more realistic, lessens any disappointment if things don't go exactly as our dreams predicted.

Say we're being driven in the opposite direction – dreading the thought of going back into society. Can we feel the unpleasantness, allow it to register fully? There is truth here too – going back into society will not bring us lasting happiness. Though this insight is painful, we have the good fortune of knowing that the Buddha saw value in this pain and formulated it as the first noble truth; he told us we must fully understand *dukkha* (the unsatisfying nature of life) to become liberated. Knowing that the pain we are experiencing is also a spiritual insight lifts our spirits. The burden of dread diminishes, and we might even start looking forward to a meal in our favourite restaurant – after all it's another opportunity for spiritual insight!

As we see-saw between these extremes we learn to savor here and now the happiness we're projecting into the future, and to embrace the unhappiness that teaches us the first noble truth. None of this is easy however, and we need to be patient with our many mistakes as we fly up into the sky with false expectations and get rudely dumped on the ground with disappointment and bewilderment. Transitions are precious. Transitions are tough. Good friends and a daily mindfulness practice help us transit from our various lockdowns back into society with minimal misery, maximal learning and deeper gratitude for all that society offers.

Exiting Lockdown

Noirin Sheahan · 2 min read

In this reflective piece, Noirin Sheahan examines the spiritual opportunities inherent in transitions, particularly as coronavirus restrictions ease and retreat participants prepare to re-enter daily life. She identifies the common oscillation between over-expectation (projecting too much happiness into future events) and dread (attachment to withdrawal and fear of busyness), showing how both states reveal our attachments and delusions.

The essay demonstrates how mindfulness becomes the key tool for navigating these transitions skillfully. When caught up in pleasant expectations, we can practice muditā (appreciative joy) by savoring our anticipation while grounding ourselves in realistic awareness. When experiencing aversion to re-engagement, we can embrace this discomfort as insight into the first noble truth of dukkha - the unsatisfying nature of conditioned existence.

Sheahan emphasizes that transitions, while challenging, are 'precious' opportunities for deepening our understanding of attachment, impermanence, and the path to liberation. By cultivating the habit of pausing to acknowledge our emotional states, we can navigate life's inevitable changes with greater wisdom, reduced suffering, and authentic gratitude for both society's offerings and our own spiritual growth.

As coronavirus restrictions start easing again, many of you will be engaging with family, social and worklife more fully. Similarly for us here at Satipanya, as the winter retreat closes, we start looking outwards, forwards, planning outings, visits, work. Transitions are tricky. We so easily lose the run of ourselves, expect too much of whatever is on the horizon. You might be dreaming of booking a meal in your favorite restaurant; on retreat we're dreaming of the first breakfast when we can chat. We project too much happiness into these events and get disappointed, bewildered, angry when the initial happiness fades, leaving us as grumpy as ever! Or it can be the other way round, we suddenly realise how attached we've grown to the enforced withdrawal of lockdown, of retreat, and dread all the coming busyness. Most of us suffer from both afflictions – expecting wonders one moment, dreading change the next! The good news is that transitions are also rich opportunity for spiritual practice. It's when we see our attachments and delusion most clearly, and thereby find a precious opportunity to work with these, find wiser ways of responding. As always, mindfulness is key. Can we tune into whatever emotions are driving our thoughts, actions, speech? Say we're being fired up by expectation. Stop a moment to acknowledge and explore the experience. Ex-

pectation usually has a pleasant, happy flavour. Stopping to savor that is a form of *mudita* – appreciative joy. It is good to be able to look forward to things, to have faith that we can enjoy life. Anyone who has suffered from depression knows what a great gift this is. Stopping to enjoy our anticipation of happiness cultivates gratitude for mental well-being as well as whatever we are looking forward to. Stopping also grounds us, makes our expectations more realistic, lessens disappointment if things don't go exactly as we would have wished. Say we're being driven in the opposite direction – dreading the thought of going back into society. Can we feel the reluctance, dislike, aversion - whatever way unhappiness is manifesting? There is truth here too – going back into society requires effort and will not bring us lasting happiness. Though this insight is painful, we have the good fortune of knowing that the Buddha saw value in this pain and formulated it as the first noble truth; he told us we must fully understand *dukkha* (the unsatisfying nature of life) to become liberated. We won't learn by shying away from life. But if we can embrace the pain as a spiritual insight, this lifts our spirits. We'll reengage with society more willingly, knowing this is part of our spiritual path. The burden of dread diminishes, and we might even start looking forward to a meal in our favourite restaurant – after all the path can have enjoyable aspects as well as pain! As we see-saw between overexpectation and dread, we learn to savor here and now the happiness we were projecting into the future, and to embrace the unhappiness that teaches us the first noble truth. None of this is easy however, and we need to be patient with our many mistakes as we fly up into the sky with false expectations and get rudely dumped on the ground with disappointment. Transitions are precious. Transitions are tough. The habit of stopping to acknowledge our emotional state helps us emerge from our various lockdowns with minimal misery, maximal learning and deeper gratitude for all that society offers.

Extinguishing the Housebuilder

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 16 min

In this profound teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma continues his exploration of the Buddha's victory verse and the nature of the deluded self—the 'housebuilder' identified as Māra. Drawing upon his previous talks about consciousness 'in which nothing is manifest' as a description of Nibbāna, he presents powerful metaphors to understand the liberation process.

Using the analogy of infant development and the myth of Narcissus, Bhante illustrates how we create distance between awareness and its objects, just as a baby learns to distinguish self from world. He explains how sati (intuitive awareness) catches its own reflection in the 'pool of consciousness' and how Vipassanā practice rescues us by drawing awareness out of identification with body and mind.

The talk includes specific meditation techniques for investigating the nature of self-awareness itself, recognizing it too as an object that arises and passes away. Bhante concludes with the inspiring testimony of Mechi Kyo, an ordinary village woman who achieved complete liberation, describing her direct experience of knowing all phenomena while remaining utterly unaffected by them. This teaching offers both theoretical understanding and practical guidance for serious practitioners seeking to uproot the very foundation of suffering through insight into anattā (not-self).

Namo tassa bhagavato hara-hatto samma-sambhodassa — Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed, Noble and Fully Self-Awakened One.

This evening, the presentation is a little difficult because I've actually written something. So it's not going to be particularly verbatim, which is my normal way of presenting.

In the last two talks, we looked at, first of all, the Buddha's victory verse and his naming of the house builder, which is to say that deluded self, which is *Mara*. When we talk about Mara, the evil tempter, that's the self, the deluded self. And then we went on — the next presentation was about a monk who wanted to know where all the world ended. And he tells him that this is badly phrased, that it should be where the world does not find a footing. And then he gives a very clear description, for want of a better word, of a place, of that place where the world does not find a footing. And this is it: There is a consciousness in which nothing is manifest. It has no boundary and is full of light in all directions. So we can understand this to be a description of *Nibbāna*.

Now our task is to find a way to practice in such a way that this might become manifest to us. But before we do that, I'd like to offer these metaphors, these ways of thinking about what we're doing, so we can understand the process of liberating ourselves from self-deception, which is generated by this deluded self, this house builder. Now, some of you who've been to Satipanya to work with me have heard all this before, but I'm hoping that you've forgotten it. And if you haven't forgotten it, you'll excuse my presentation because I just wanted it to be in this medium.

The first metaphor is to recognise what happens to us when we're babies. It has a similarity to the process of insight meditation. For the first four months of our lives, it seems, we're bombarded by sensual information, can make no head or tail of it. But we do know when we're experiencing what is pleasant or unpleasant — that is the dual world that we enter into. Then around four months we start to delineate our first object out of this bewildering mass and in so doing we create the third dimension of depth. And it's usually out of this that we find our first object, our mother, our carer.

So the process continues, it seems, until around the age of three, we're pretty clear that I'm not anything outside my body. My body and my sense of me are separate from everyone and everything. And I know my toys belong to me. They're mine. A very strong sense of possession. There's still a great connection to Mother, but what we've done is we've distanced the outer world from the inner world.

Our practice is to distance this inner world from the intuitive awareness. Every time we experience a feeling or sensation, an emotion or mood, a thought or an image as an object, we're telling ourselves that this cannot be the awareness that knows it. The knower, the feeler, the experiencer experiences itself as quite other to everything it knows, feels and experiences. Now that's what happens when we turn everything into an object, just as the baby creates a third dimension by reaching out and so creating distance. So we're pushing away what we are overwhelmed with, our sensations, feelings, and thoughts. And that distance between the object and the awareness is the inner third dimension.

The second metaphor that I like to use is one of Narcissus. As you remember, Narcissus was a handsome, beautiful young man. And he looked into the pool, caught the image of his own face, fell in love with it, and then went to embrace it and fell in and drowned. This is understood as a myth about self-absorption, pride, vanity, conceit. And water in mythology often represents a lot of things, but life and creation, as well as chaos and purification.

However, we can read this myth spiritually. It is that *sati*, the intuitive awareness — IA notice, not AI — that catches its image on the screen of consciousness. Consciousness itself is that screen upon which the six senses manifest. That is why consciousness is defined by the sense base: eye consciousness, ear consciousness, mind consciousness, and so on.

So every morning we wake up, the first thing we are aware of is ourselves, our self-awareness. I'm sure you'll have had the experience of waking up in an unfamiliar room at a hotel or friends. And for those first few seconds you can't recognize where you are and so who you are. There's a momentary panic till we situate ourselves. So it is that *sati* sees itself, senses itself in the pool of the mind, the pool of the world that the mind is creating, and then we drown in it.

However, the Buddha has come to the rescue and offered us a methodology to resuscitate us, ourselves. We must drag Narcissus out of the water, sitting back on the bank of the pool. And so it is that in *Vipassanā*, we draw our awareness out of the body and mind with its feelings, perceptions and habits, and we experience ourselves as the one who knows.

In this, our basic identity begins to change, where we base our identity. As children, our identity is very body-centered, and we have that experience when we bite our tongues when we're eating. Just for that singular moment of the stabbing pain, we're absorbed into it and become a physical self. We then very quickly bounce out of it and are annoyed with ourselves and so become an emotional self. We then might reflect upon it and counsel ourselves to eat more slowly and mindfully. And so we become a thinking self. But this position of the observer, the feeler, transcends them all. It can be aware of all the experiences the body and heart-mind have.

Then we might acknowledge more and more clearly the distinction between the object and the subject. So this takes us back to the distancing, the disidentifying process of the baby and young child. And this takes us a step further to investigate the nature of this identity of the self as the observer and the feeler. For having accessed within ourselves this inner position, called by Nyanaponika Thera in his classic work, still worthy of a read, "The Heart of Buddhist Meditation," an observation post. And from this observation post, we can see clearly that the body and heart, heart-mind, the emotions and thought life, continue of themselves without the engagement of this self-awareness that we now experience ourselves to be.

Now we have a situation where the self-awareness sees the body as other and that the body keeps on being the body with its sensations and feelings. The emotions and moods still continue to arise and the thoughts and images continue to flit across the mind. None of it needing the direct control of *sati*, this intuitive awareness. So we're left with the question as to the nature of this self-awareness.

Our investigation now turns towards the self-awareness, that sense of presence. Since we're aware of it, that makes it an object. So we can't be it. Worse, we realize that this identity is the very portal into the world manufactured by the six senses — the five physical senses and the heart mind. This is the face in the pool.

Indeed, this primary self is Mara, the evil tempter, inviting us into the pleasures and joys of the world, only to find ourselves entangled, ensnared and imprisoned. This is the house builder the Buddha discovered to be the agent of rebirth, the root of all our discontent and suffering.

So now there's a practice which is pretty specific to this investigation. And I'm indebted, well, we are indebted to the Mahayana school for this. When the body is very still and the heart calm and the mind is silent — now admittedly that's pretty rare in our daily lives, though it does arise on retreat — we can raise our attention into that feeling of presence located in the forehead. We can stay there to the exclusion of everything else and again just gaze. We now know because we are aware of that sense of self, it is an object and therefore belongs to the mind. So it must be arising and passing away, even though it seems to be coexistent with the awareness that knows it. Remember, consciousnesses are flashing at enormous speeds so that they give us a sense of continuity. We need to hold that position as best we can without straining, just gazing with wonder. Is that sense of self arising and passing away? That is all. Just to gaze with wonder. Presume that the awareness knows what it's looking for. So that's one particular technique.

The other one is the one that we usually use when we're practicing *Vipassanā*. And that involves directly investigating the process of impermanence. So whenever we see an object, whether it's a sensation or a feeling, mood or emotion, thought or image appearing and disappearing, the same applies. The *sati*, this observer, this feeler, that experiences the object arising and passing away, cannot itself be arising and passing away. That gap, minute as it is, between the passing of an object and the arising of another, would also constitute a glimpse into our true nature, which is unborn, undying, uncreated and unconditioned.

So we can sum up the techniques by first of all pulling away from the objects we're aware of so it becomes something to observe and feel, remembering that the perceiver cannot be the perceived. This is the first step of not me, not mine, not self. Then the direct experience of the appearance and disappearance of the object allows *sati* to experience itself as other, whole, entire and permanent. Slowly but surely, this intuitive awareness, *satipaññā*, becomes an island unto itself, impervious to the physical and mental worlds. This is where the very world cannot find a footing.

Now fortunately we have an example of someone who describes what it's like to be fully liberated from the delusion of self and this actually warrants a talk but for our present purpose it's enough to quote her. I'm presuming for the time being that you know the categories that the Buddha teaches, the four great elements, the six sense bases and the five aggregates. Meichi Kyo was an ordinary, barely educated village girl who died in 1991 at the age of 90. And this is her statement:

"Body, mind and essence are all distinct and separate realities. Absolutely everything is known. Earth, water, fire and wind. Body, feeling, memory, thought and consciousness. Sounds, sights, smells, tastes and touches and emotions. Anger, greed and delusion, all are known, I know them all as they exist in their own natural states. But no matter how much I'm exposed to them, I am unable to detect even an instant when they have any power over my heart. They arise and cease, they're forever changing, but the presence that knows them never changes for an instant. It is forever unborn and undying. This is the end of all suffering."

I can only hope my little homily has been of interest, and that by your dedication to the practice you will be liberated from all suffering, like Mei-Chi Kiao, sooner rather than later.

Fairness and Equality

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 2 min read

This essay examines the human desire for fairness that begins in childhood and persists into adulthood, questioning what fairness truly means in a world of manifest inequality. Bhante Bodhidhamma explores how Western concepts of equality often assume a level playing field that doesn't exist in reality, whether in education, economics, or social systems.

Drawing from the Buddha's teachings, the essay presents the law of kamma as a fundamental principle of justice that operates equally for all beings. Unlike worldly notions of fairness, kamma represents an ethical law where harmful intentions naturally produce harmful consequences, while wholesome actions generate beneficial results. This process unfolds within a complex matrix of relationships and conditions that are largely unknowable and uncontrollable.

The teaching emphasizes that while we cannot control how karmic consequences manifest, we can cultivate virtuous intentions that gradually improve both our inner and outer worlds. Ultimately, the essay points to Nibbāna as the supreme fairness—a happiness independent of worldly conditions that remains equally available to all beings. This perspective encourages practitioners to navigate life with mindful awareness, ready to use both fortunate and challenging circumstances for spiritual development.

Children often have an acute sense of fairness. 'It's not fair!'. They feel they've been treated unjustly. There's indignation and anger and often tears. And we take this into adulthood. But what do we mean by fairness in a world that is manifestly differentiated. We talk about equal opportunity. But that presumes that we are all starting on the same line. In the hundred metre dash, it would not be 'fair' if the starting blocks were unevenly spaced; if in the 1500 metre race the curves were not taken into account. But that's not real life. We manifestly don't all begin on a 'level playing field'. Consider our educational system; banking system; the pays awarded in the celebrity system and indeed now to CEO's of charities; the whole capitalist system. That's when the doubt gives us some idea that fairness has also to do with some understanding about equality. This morphs into we should all have the same, even though we are not the same. It seems the concept of equality came about in the West with the idea of an all-powerful, but ethical God. Although he made everyone different, i.e. not equal, in His justice we are all equal. And this is enshrined in our law – we take into consideration mitigating circumstances. After all that's only fair. There is something about fairness that strikes true for it is such

an enduring concept. In the Buddha's teaching as to why things happen, there is the concept of unknowability and uncontrollability. Things happen because of causes from the past and in the very present which we could neither foresee nor influence. Life is a series of happenings. A series of events over which we do not have total control, or only minimal control and sometimes no control at all. Sometimes we win a jackpot and at others we get hit by a kipper – out of nowhere. However, the Buddha does point to a fundamental justice, a fairness, an ethical law – the law of kamma. When we think, speak or act with harmful intent, we do harm to ourselves and others and there are consequences. And vice versa – goodness will produce goodness. This law applies equally to all. But this tells us nothing about how consequences unfold. For whenever we think, speak or act, we do send a force into a matrix of relationships both out into the world and inwardly into our interior world. Eventually, though it might not seem so at first, our virtuous empowered intentions will begin to manifest in better inner and outer worlds. But our final goal is a happiness not dependent on these inner and outer worlds, Nibbana. And that also is equally available to us all. Fair enough! But it does mean we have to tread carefully, wide awake and ready to take spiritual advantage of the unexpected, both fortunate and unfortunate.

Faith (Saddhā)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 26 min read

In this evening retreat talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma offers a comprehensive exploration of faith (saddhā) as one of the five spiritual faculties (indriya) in Buddhism. Drawing from the Abhidhamma and commentary literature, he distinguishes faith from mere belief, explaining that faith involves trust and confidence rather than acceptance of statements.

The talk examines faith through three essential components of consciousness: intellectual understanding (cognitive), emotional involvement (affective), and commitment (conative). Using practical examples like climbing Everest or starting relationships, Bhante illustrates how these elements must work together. He traces the development of faith from initial hearing of the Dhamma, through personal reflection, to direct experiential understanding through meditation practice.

Addressing common obstacles to faith—including confusion between faith and belief, imbalanced development, self-doubt, and unrealistic expectations—Bhante emphasizes that faith becomes unshakeable only upon reaching stream-entry (sotāpanna). He concludes with practical guidance on nurturing faith through spiritual friendship (kalyāṇamittā), ethical conduct (sīla), energetic practice, and understanding impermanence (anicca). The talk offers both newcomers and experienced practitioners essential insights into this foundational aspect of Buddhist spiritual development.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

So I thought I'd give a little talk around faith, which in the Buddha's understanding is fundamental. Nothing happens without faith. And I read a rather nice little essay on it by Ñāṇaponika, whom some of you might know—a very famous German monk who started the Buddhist Publication Society up in Kandy. Didn't write all that much himself, but what he wrote was influential. And his main book, *The Heart of Buddhist Meditation*, still remains a classic really on meditation.

The way I would like to tackle it is from these three constituents of an act of consciousness. I'm getting this from the Abhidhamma, but actually it should be pretty obvious to us. Not being too specific about one act of consciousness, but in a series of consciousnesses. You always have the intellectual part, the cognitive part, the understand-

ing. There's always some affective part, your emotional involvement. And for an action, there has to be what's known as an act of will. And you will notice that in my explanation there, I use my hand to point to three centres. So they're your basic chakras, the one in the middle of your head signifying your understanding, the heart in the middle of your chest, and the one in your belly.

And it's interesting that, just a little aside, that if you look at the way Buddhism grew, it was very much a cognitive effort. The Buddha's teaching is very much about, first of all, understanding and everything takes place, everything flows. But that became too rigid, too dry perhaps, so that the next wave through Mahāyāna was raising up *karuṇā*, raising up the heart to the level of *paññā*, wisdom. So *karuṇā* and *paññā* became equal. And if you go over to the Far East, to Japan, their centre is very much in the hara, the will. A samurai. Just a little aside, you understand. Nothing to do with faith.

So these three things I want to just look at from the point of view of faith. And before we do that, I have to make one big distinction between faith and belief. So a belief is faith in a statement. So if you say, there is no God, or there is a God, then that's a statement which, in effect, you can't prove either one way or the other. But if you believe it, then it would come under a belief rather than faith. So when we're talking about faith this evening, it's concerned with an attitude, trust, confidence. That's what we're talking about.

To give us some idea as to what we mean by that, we can take a few ordinary things that we do which demand faith. If you take, for instance, supposing now you decided to climb Everest. So there would have to be these three things, wouldn't there? You'd have to have understood what the actual path of Everest means and what it might take. It has to be that understanding. There has to be the desire to get up there, doesn't there? You might read about it and think that's very interesting but there's no desire to go up Everest. And you might of course have a good understanding as to what it's going to take, you might have an incredible desire, but somehow you just can't get your boots on and that's the lack of will. Lots of times like that in our lives, isn't there?

So somebody came and she was in quite an upset state because she was convinced that she had throat cancer, this particular person. And she had no trust in her doctors. So she wouldn't even go for a biopsy—not an autopsy, she wasn't dead yet—a little biopsy on the grounds that she didn't trust the doctors. And as we were discussing it and seeing what other options were open, it finally of course began to show that what was really undermining her faith wasn't at all to do with the doctors or the profession, it was the fear that in fact she may have throat cancer. So that underlying fear was as it were translated into a lack of faith. I think in this case she actually did eventually go.

But if you think of anything you have to do with doctors, you have to have a primary faith that their diagnosis is correct and that the medicine they prescribe is correct. Now in the old days you would have just had blind faith, the doctor. My parents wouldn't have ever argued with a doctor. If the doctor said this pimple on your nose is a dreadful cancer they would have believed it. It wouldn't have occurred to them to question the diagnosis. These days we're a bit more argumentative. And you want to know why and what happens. Recently I went in to the doctor with a tinnitus which had just arrived out of nowhere. And she said, I'll send you for a blood test. I said, a blood test? I had to squeeze out of her why she was sending me for a blood test.

So this whole business of even taking medicine, even going for an operation, you've got to have that trust in the surgeon. You take another thing that we do in our lives, a job. So if you're taking on a job, especially a job which you know will stretch you, then there has to be these three elements. There has to be, first of all, that you've understood what the job is asking you to do. There has to be that attraction to the job, there has to be a desire to do it. And then finally you've got to sign on the dotted line, or else it just doesn't happen. And that's the act, that's the commitment, the act of will. And there, sometimes what stops us is that doubt, can I do it. So you can see that the opposite of faith is doubt. There's something that stops you from that commitment.

And if we take another one, it's forming a relationship or getting married. This takes us into the realm of a more intimate human relationship where actually your trust is in this other person. They're not going to abuse you or take advantage of you. Take all your money. There's got to be that trust. And again, there is that knowledge that comes of knowing the other person long enough, the confidence that arises with that. Then, of course, that special love that one has with that sort of relationship. And then, eventually, there's got to be that movement towards yes, yes.

So these things are just little examples which we now translate into the spiritual life. So when it comes to the spiritual life, and specifically around Buddhism, faith, the Buddha calls the spiritual faculty. Interestingly enough, he doesn't put it in with the factors of enlightenment. And the presumption is, at least I presume, is that by the time you're actually meditating, the faith must be there, at least some level of faith. Because the factors of enlightenment are put into the *Satipaṭṭhāna* discourse, the discourse on how to establish mindfulness or this awareness which leads us to the awakening. But the five faculties are not there. They're talked about in other places. What's in that particular scripture are the seven factors of enlightenment. So when it comes to the faculty, it seems to me faith seems to me presumed.

So all of you here now, whatever commitment you have towards the Buddha's teaching, the fact is you wouldn't be here were it not that there was some faith. And if we now go back to what faith entails, the cognitive part, the actual part of understanding, so that's pointed out as three different stages. The first one is you hear the doctrine, you hear the teaching, and that immediately, as it were, arouses interest. There's also something that's stirring in the heart, that this is the truth, an attraction. There must be some sort of an attraction. And then after you've heard it and you read about it, there are, shall we say, reflections about it. So that the knowledge which was given, hearsay, read, now becomes your own personal understanding by way of your own reflections. And the more that happens, the more confidence arises, the more faith happens, the more faith arises in us about the doctrine, because now in a sense it's becoming our way of thinking, our way of understanding. So it's my way, not the Buddha's way. I'm slowly turning towards that.

But there's still that missing link between an understanding which is intellectual and the actual experience. So it's all right saying that everything arises and passes away, and I mean, there are very few people in the world who wouldn't grasp that. And when we turn inward and we just look around a little bit, we can see that thoughts arise and pass away, emotions arise and pass away, feelings arise. I mean, it's not a brain twister to actually go into that, but it's actually coming to the point where this I, this me, which feels so solid, is also arising and passing away. So turning inward and really coming to terms with what transience actually means at a deeper level through our meditation, that now becomes a knowledge which is also carrying into experience. But we would never have got there, really, without that initial confidence. That initial confidence.

When it comes to the heart itself, there's that feeling of trust which comes in, to trust somebody, to have confidence in, faith in somebody. And then there's a desire to devote oneself. A sort of loyal service to the Dharma, for as much as it feeds you personally. So if you're devoted to somebody, then you're there to actually help, please, make them happy. A mother and father devoted to their children. So that act of devotion is not just a lovey-dovey thing. It's part of that movement of the heart to give of oneself. A votary offering. It's an offering. And running along with that, there's love, which translates as a sort of lightness, a sort of joy in faith.

And then once those two are there, there comes this point of a commitment. And the commitment is at all different levels. So it might be just the commitment to practice a bit of meditation. And eventually it's a commitment to actually follow the Buddha's path as your centre line. And a total life's devotion to it. So, for instance, when people

take refuges, refuges and precepts, I mean, that's the normal way in all forms of Buddhism. So the refuges are the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Sangha. And then you take the five precepts, which is just your basic morality, not to kill anybody, steal, etc.

But the first part, the taking of refuge in the Buddha Dhamma Sangha, is an act of commitment dependent on the person. So it might be that they are committed to it, just on a level of, a rather superficial level of, the Buddha's teaching is good, and it's part of my spiritual smorgasbord. I've got all this other stuff, and here's the Buddha's teaching over here, and I do a bit of that. That's fine. As the teaching takes a more central position in your life, then of course the commitment comes for more, to give oneself more to that teaching. But there still might be a holding back.

So it takes a long time to actually commit yourself to something, especially if you are converted to it. If you're born into a religion, if you're born into a spiritual way of life, then it's just natural to you because ever since you woke up, you've been cajoled to make that sort of devotion, to make that sort of act of devotion. But for those who have come from other forms and come into Buddhism, then it takes quite a long time before you ever get to that point of actually, if ever of course, that you actually commit yourself in terms of this life.

Now, you only get back what you give. So if you give a bit of commitment, then you get a little bit back. If you give a bit more, you get a bit more back. And if you give the whole thing, then eventually you get the whole thing. It's like in a relationship, if you say, well, I love you a bit, and the other person says, well, I love you a bit. And it slowly builds up until finally there's some sort of connection, which one can call a marriage in one form or another. So that's the same with our relationship to the spiritual path. And that commitment can't be forced, you can't say, oh well, I'm fed up with messing around now, I'm going to devote myself to the Buddha Dhamma Sangha. Not at all, because it's a movement within the heart. And there just comes a time in a person's life when they make these little commitments, so it grows, it grows, it grows.

Now when that happens, or as that happens, then one gets the satisfaction of acts of commitment based on faith. So here's one way of putting it. This is taken from the commentary, but it also turns up in what's known as the Questions of King Milinda, which was written quite a while after the Buddha. And it says, as a water purifying gem of the universal monarch—he has seven of these by the way—thrown into water causes solids, alluvia, water weeds and mud to subside and makes the water clear, transparent and undisturbed. So faith arising discards the hindrances, causes the corruptions to subside, purifies the mind and makes it undisturbed. The mind being purified, and the

aspirant of the noble family gives gifts, observes the precepts, performs the duties of the Uposatha and commences *Bhāvanā*. Thus, faith should be known to have purifying as its characteristic.

So these performs the duties of the Uposatha is in Buddhist countries, the full moon and the new moon and the quarters are times when lay people go to the monastery and make a special day of it, especially the full moon. And commencing *Bhāvanā*, *Bhāvanā* is meditation.

So here we have the purifying of water, transparency. Now all you've got to think about is those times when your life has been full of doubt. Either should you move house, should you go for this job or that job, should you go into this relationship or that relationship. In those times of doubt, as soon as there's a commitment, as soon as there's a decision and a commitment, all the stuff around that disappears, doesn't it? All that disturbance, all the doubt, all the fear, it just clarifies, it just disappears. So that's what this is pointing to, that an act of faith is, or an act of taking refuge in Buddhist language, to take the refuge in, a refuge, is that point where all doubts, finally, about how one should lead one's spiritual life begin to fade away. And one is clear, one is clear. So that's its effect on us.

Talking again just a little bit about the intellect and the affective the emotional thing, if something is only intellective if it's only an understanding coming from the mind and it doesn't have the force of the heart behind it then it remains brittle, it remains quite brittle and it can easily be cracked by another argument. Somebody coming along like for instance later on there's a question on rebirth so if a person thinks well you have to believe in rebirth to be a Buddhist and I can't really believe that then the whole thing shatters. So if faith is only at that sort of intellectual understanding that this is okay I understand it and all that but without the heart behind it it's not going to really penetrate it's not really going to have the effect of true devotion.

If on the other hand it's only the heart, so sometimes one is drawn, a type of person might be drawn simply by seeing, seeing a statue of the Buddha. I know people as soon as they've seen a statue of Buddha they sort of fall in love with it. Something in their memory has clicked and there's this heart connection. And there's that leap of faith. But if that's not balanced with, of course, some sort of intellectual understanding about what they're doing, then we would call that blind faith. And what happens then is an easy falling into belief systems so I believe the Buddha is right whatever the Buddha says it's got to be right and what that does to the practitioner is it undermines their commitment to practice I mean if you have a belief that oh yeah the Buddha is right then why prove it.

The whole point of the practice that we do the *Bhāvanā*, the *Vipassanā* is that question: Is the Buddha correct? Has he got it right? I mean, you're not saying that to yourself when you sit, I hope. But that's the underlying basis of the great doubt. This is not doubt as a sceptical thing. This is not coming from fear. It's coming from a desire to really know personally, as a personal experience, whether the Buddha's liberation is true. And whether once one gets to this point of nibbāna, whether there isn't in fact more. We might get there and we think, no, this isn't it. I've got to keep going. You don't know, do you? And it's that sort of doubt which is better translated as a wonder, a philosopher's wonder, which drives our meditation.

So in your meditation, if you're just sitting there watching, looking, that won't do. It won't do. That's called being lazy. There has to also be that sense of curiosity. If the curiosity is not there, just that simple question mark in the mind, a way of looking, then insight can't arise. So the Buddha is quite clear. Awareness. Without awareness, without placing that attention on something, insight can't arise. So you can't have insight without the awareness. But on the other hand, that insight won't arise unless there is that curiosity in the mind, that wanting to know.

So those two, you have to have them in balance and of course when you say balance there's not some objective balance you can't go on a weighing scale and say well I've got a bit of this and I've got a bit of that it's to do with the individual so that every individual has to have that balance within themselves of an intellectual understanding and a commitment in terms of their devotion in terms of what their heart wants to do.

And that will, it's just like we were saying about not getting your boots on. So there can be always this lovely intellectual understanding. Some people read so much and they can splurge it all out and quote ad infinitum. And sometimes they've got a good feeling behind it, but they don't practice. No practice at all. Don't do any meditation. Now what stops them doing that? What stops them making that little effort to actually climb the mountain? And that's the lack of will, the lack of commitment. So unless there's that too, there can't be progress on the path.

And it's interesting that the Buddha puts faith opposite, or he balances faith in the five faculties, he balances it with insight. So if there's no faith, if there's not that act of devotion to the practice, then insight can't come up. So these two things are intimately linked. And eventually when we have an insight which is an insight into the final goal, which is known as entering the stream, the *Sotāpanna*, at that point this faith becomes unshakeable. It's then known not so much as an *indriya*, which we translate as faculty, it becomes a *bala*, which means a strength. So now that faith now is unshakeable because that person has actually seen the top of the mountain. They know where it is. It's

no longer clouded. It's not that they can't see it because they've actually touched it. And now that faith, which is a strength, of course, must necessarily draw them to the end of the path through the next few stages.

So until, it's understood that until we have intuited this nirvanic moment, faith will always have a little shake in it. There'll always be a little shake in it. And that really brings us to what undermines our faith, what undermines your commitment to the practice.

The first one we've already talked about, this confusion between faith and belief. So you can very easily slip into that lazy place where you say, well, I believe the Buddha, what's the point? And it undermines that practice. So you've got to keep up that sense of curiosity, that sense of wanting to know. And the Buddha laid that out very clearly when he visited the Kalamas. It's a very famous discourse. Everybody quotes it, so I may as well quote it myself.

So he ended up at the village of the Kalamas, and the Kalamas said to him, we're in a state of perplexity. And he said, everybody who comes here tells us that this is what it's all about, this is the truth, and everybody else is wrong. So who are we to believe? Where are we to go? And he says, do not believe anything simply because you've heard it. Simply because it is tradition handed down for many generations. Simply because it is spoken and rumoured by the many. Simply because it is found written in your religious books. And simply on the authority of your teachers and elders. In other words, don't believe anything. And then he says, only when it works for you, only when you've tried it out, only when it's something which is of benefit to you, would you then commit yourself to it. So belief is something which would be contrary to the Buddha's path as such.

The other thing is that we talked about was this balance between devotion or the heart and the understanding. And this is from the commentaries. And it says, for one strong in faith and weak in understanding has confidence uncritically and groundlessly. So that's your blind faith. That's your gullibility. That's believing something. For one strong in understanding and weak in faith errs on the side of cunning and is as hard to cure as one sick of a disease caused by medicine. Interesting, isn't it? We know about the side effects of drugs. One strong in understanding and weak in faith.

So what they're saying here, what he's saying here is that you can have such a good intellectual grasp of Buddhism that you actually believe you've experienced it. And there's a total confusion between something that has been so clearly understood and something which has been directly experienced. And I knew of a monk who actually believed that himself. He did, he had an enormous, wonderful, deep grasp of the

Dharma. And he was convinced that he must be a reborn stream entrant. In other words, he was already, he'd already somewhere in his past life, I mean he had to believe that, he had intuited Nibbāna. Or else how could he have this amazing, wonderful understanding of the Buddha's teaching? And that is such an easy confusion, related to those who have a very strong intellect.

And so it then goes on to say, with the balancing of the two, a person has confidence where there are grounds for it. In other words, it's the balance that we're looking for.

The other one is more to do with self-expectation. The big one about self-doubt. Everybody can do it but not me. That sort of thing. And that can be a real barrier to progress. There's a particular monk in the scriptures who becomes despairing of his practice and commits suicide. Fortunately, when the Buddha comes along and is asked, well, what happened to this monk? Where's he gone? He says, oh, he became enlightened in the process of committing suicide. Now, I'm not suggesting, of course, that. In this case, it was a happy outcome.

But I don't think there's a deeper despair than spiritual despair. To despair of somebody, to despair of your ability to have a relationship, to despair of your ability to earn money and live a good life. All these things that throw people into suicide and jump off bridges. I'm thinking particularly of a young man in Australia who made, and remember this is a piece of news, who made an enormous amount of wealth on property. And when that thing crashed in the mid-90s, he committed suicide.

But when we're talking about spiritual despair, that digs at the deepest level of our being, doesn't it? Because that's what the spiritual life is about. It's about being. It's about who are we at fundament. And to have entered the spiritual path and to have seen the possibility of spiritual advancement and spiritual attainment and that end of suffering and then to despair that one could ever achieve that. I don't think you can get worse than that when it comes to despair.

So don't despair. So that when self-doubt comes up like that, it can often be caused by an over-expectation. You know, you thought you'd be further along the path than this, than you are now. And there's pride involved in that and a loss of self-esteem. I met a man and he said to me, when he first came to meditation, he went to a course, this was back in the 70s, he went to a course of meditation and he went to it as you would go to any old course of calligraphy or basket making or French or something. And he went along and the idea was you got a Nibbāna, you got a certificate and then you left. It was a week on how to attain Nibbāna. He entered the course thinking he'd have a go and at the end he'd know Nibbāna and that was it. That's what he'd come for. Well, of course,

as the course began to end, the despair entered into the heart and it took him a while to realize that it wasn't that sort of course. And that's why you don't get certificates after meditation courses. Nobody hands you a certificate. So this expectation.

So here's the Buddha. He says, I do not say that the attainment of profound knowledge comes straight away. Nevertheless, the attainment of profound knowledge comes by a gradual training, a gradual doing, a gradual course. How does the attainment of profound knowledge come? By means of gradual training, gradual doing and gradual course. As it is, one who has faith draws near. Drawing close, they sit down nearby. Sitting nearby, they lend an ear. Lending an ear, they hear the Dharma. Having heard the Dharma, they remember it. They test the meaning of things they have borne in mind. Whilst testing the meaning, things are approved of. Things being approved of, desire is born. When desire is born, they make an effort. Having made the effort, they weigh it up. Having weighed it up, they strive. Being self-resolute, they realize for themselves the highest truth itself. Penetrating by means of wisdom. Stages.

And you also have to be careful that, so the whole point is that when we practise to abandon all expectation. This is the point. So abandon all expectation. And if you don't, if you don't then you'll get into that failure success. And that's where the trouble starts. And when you get a lack of success, it can be a sort of misunderstanding really. Remember that all spiritual traditions warn us that the spiritual path is full of deserts. Dry places, empty places. And it's surprising how many people when they enter into that place just begin to slag off and disappear and then they reappear about 20 years later.

But those periods when you think you are not advancing are more important than those periods when you think you are. That's the slog, that's the dryness, that's the desert. You've just got to keep one foot in front of the other. And I use the image before the mountain. So mountains are used often in the spiritual literature because they're so close to the experience of the spiritual life. The idea of having this constant... The actual practice is extremely simple. To climb a mountain, all you've got to remember is you put one foot in front of the other and, generally speaking, go up. That's it, isn't it? I mean, you don't need any more instructions than that. Then, of course, there comes all sorts of techniques and ways of handling certain situations. Stamina, commitment.

And the worst thing you can do on a mountain, especially the high you get, is to sit down and have a break which is just a wee bit too long and you start getting cold. And you drink your last cup of tea. And that's it. You're on the way down then. So it's a case of that commitment, especially during those periods where you feel that nothing is happening. It doesn't matter how long nothing is happening. You just keep going. Just keep going. And it's a testing time. You're just looking at the fact of the loss of self-esteem, the

feeling that you're not going anywhere, as if there was anywhere to go, a lack of success. All comes up, and it's the ego. So the dryness, the aridity of practice, is one of the most potential parts to get rid of the ego. And usually it's a time when we give up, which is a sorrow, because it takes a bit to get up there.

So don't worry about lack of success, just keep doing the job. Then of course there are the more obvious things, doubt in the Buddha, doubt in the teaching. The doubt in the Buddha always has felt to me, in a sense, slightly unnecessary. Because as you go along, there are side posts there. You don't have to believe in Nibbāna. You don't have to believe at all in any of that stuff. The whole point about the Dharma is that it's immediate. You either benefit from it now or you don't. That's the point.

But when we're practising we might not see an immediate benefit from it right here and now in this present moment, but when we look back on our practice over a period of years we can see that it's helped us to progress and it's part of our progression and it might even be the fundamental reason for our progression. So it's that ability to see that the doubt that we have in the practice is undermined by not looking too far ahead. It's right here and now. So if we can look back and think a little bit, oh, this is a benefit, then we don't lose that sense of faith in what we're doing.

When it comes to the Sangha, that's really an extension of faith in the Buddha because the Sangha is simply other people who've said that they've actually attained the same thing. And the more people who say that, the more of course it gives other people confidence.

Now these three things have to be, or at least two of them, have to be internal. Even at the end when the Buddha actually becomes enlightened as that doubt appears is this it or is there more and that's when Mara attacks him with all the armies that's how it's put in the mythology and the Buddha touches the earth you've seen the posture the *Bhūmisparśa* posture where he's touching the earth and that was the point where he touched the earth as a witness as it were that he had attained the end of suffering. And the earth quaked and the earth goddess rose, wringing from her hair the water poured as libation to her by the Buddha in previous lives. That's nice, isn't it?

But when we actually take the refuge, it's not simply in that historical Buddha, it's the presumption that there's a Buddha within us, that there's something within us which is to be liberated. And that's what you're taking your faith in. So when the Buddha is dying, Ananda wants to know who's going to take his place. Because Ananda has this overflowing faith in the Buddha. And the Buddha's answer is that he mustn't take faith in him as a person, but take faith in the Dharma, the teaching itself, the practice itself, and in himself: be a light unto yourself, take the Dharma as your light, take

the Dharma as your guide, take the Dharma as your teacher, take yourself as your guide, yourself as your teacher. So eventually this is our journey, that's all the Buddha is saying, and the usual quote is the Buddha's only point the way.

So eventually when we take these when we take these refuges when we make that commitment it's always a commitment to ourselves. And there was only one period in Buddhist history that I know of where there was a collapse of where there was a doubt that there were some human beings who couldn't make it and it's a heresy of course. And these people who couldn't make it were labeled the *icchantikas*. And *icchantika* means forever going on in the world of *saṃsāra*. There was no ending to their rebirth because they were so stupid. But luckily that didn't take on. It remains there as one of these little side schools that believe that. Some sentient beings were really thick. They couldn't make it, even if they tried.

I must tell you, in Sri Lanka it's very strange to us. But they can tell by the shape of somebody's head, or some monks can tell, and nuns I presume, can tell by the shape of somebody's head whether they're going to make it or not. And the teacher at my own monastery, who was an excellent teacher, a direct disciple of the *Mahāsi*, very strict, very demanding, and often wouldn't take on students, but he wouldn't take on certain students whose head wasn't quite right. I say no more. Maybe there are ways of telling things that we're not privy to, that's all there is to it.

So I think I've just about covered all the bits that I wanted to cover. I suppose one thing I might just say is how to make faith grow. We haven't done that really. So first of all, there's the spiritual friendship. That's very important, to be with the right people. To be with people of like mind who are supporting you is obviously I mean the Buddha Ananda says to the Buddha I believe that right relationship good relationship is only half of the spiritual livelihood and the Buddha says oh no he says it's the whole of spiritual livelihood.

When a meditator has a good friend, a good companion, a good comrade, it is to be expected that they will develop and cultivate the Eightfold Noble Path. Also to be clear about one's training. If you're sloppy with your virtue, then it also slips. It undermines your commitment to the path because you cannot separate insight from virtue. You can't have a Buddha who goes around robbing. Wisdom is also an act, when it expresses itself, is virtuous. You have to be careful of your speech especially, it says.

You must be energetic in abandoning what is unprofitable. Remember that every time you attend to something, there's an act of intention. Therefore, it's conditioning. You have to be careful what programs you watch on the telly. And finally, the understanding of impermanence. The more we understand impermanence, the more we get

what's known as *Samvega*, that enthusiasm. I mean, we haven't got that long, have we? And visits to the teacher or to a centre where you get teaching. And also, just as an aside, the group, the evening group, your local group. That's always a nice fillip.

I always remember making that effort every week to go across town in order to join a group had an effect of raising the effort for the whole practice for the week. And if I missed it, I could feel the lack of energy during the week. So remember that the effort you put into a practice is an attitude and the attitude stays with you.

So I think that sort of brings me to an end of my little homily. I'll just leave you with a little final refrain taken from the Sutta Nipāta. Faith, in the way that we've been describing it, is the best wealth to a person of this world. Well-practised Dharma brings the most happiness. Truth is the sweetest of all tastes, and living with wisdom is said to be of the noblest kind.

Faith or Belief

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 25 min

In this exploration, Bhante Bodhidhamma distinguishes between blind belief and authentic faith (saddhā) in Buddhist practice. Drawing from the Kālāma Sutta and other discourses, he demonstrates how the Buddha explicitly discouraged blind acceptance of teachings, instead encouraging personal investigation and verification through reason and experience.

The talk examines four key aspects of the Buddha's approach: his Socratic teaching method that encouraged listeners to discover truth for themselves, his declaration of individual freedom of thought in the Kālāma Sutta, his refusal to make unverifiable metaphysical statements, and most importantly, his provision of the Noble Eightfold Path as a practical method for direct realization.

Bhante explains how true faith (saddhā) differs fundamentally from belief - it is a disposition of the heart that arouses confidence, energy, and willingness to investigate. This faith becomes one of the five spiritual faculties essential for meditation practice, eventually transforming into unshakeable power upon experiencing Nibbāna. The talk concludes with the Buddha's final instruction to Ānanda about taking refuge in oneself and the Dhamma, emphasizing that each person must realize the truth individually while having confidence in the path shown by those who have succeeded before us.

Foundation Course 2, Talk 6, Buddhism, Belief or Faith

I wonder what you think would happen in the world if all the religious systems, ideologies, philosophies, psychologies, all the ismologies, were to disappear. Do you think we'd be any the poorer for it? Or do you think we would somehow start afresh? Or would we return to a barbarism? I suppose the underlying question is, how did we get where we are in the first place?

According to some religious systems, truths are revealed to us by supernatural means, but the Buddha said that all his discoveries were realized through his own endeavour and his alone. That's why we call him the *Sammāsambuddho*, the fully self-enlightened one. Furthermore, he was quite clear that whatever he discovered concerning the fact and the end of suffering could also be discovered by each individual. The truth, the *Dhamma*, is said to be realized by the wise for themselves.

This is a very important point in Buddhist understanding. No matter what the Buddha taught, he was not a saviour. He could not end our personal suffering for us. Each person has to find that end for themselves by their own endeavour. The Buddhas only point the way.

The way, the truth, the Dhamma can be a very subjective thing. If we begin to study the ismologies, all these isms and ologies that have been developed, to the impartial mind it's no easy task to discover the truth as an objective thing. Unfortunately, human beings can't point to something and say, that's it, that's the truth, the ultimate transcendent truth. If it were so, we'd have no disagreement such as whether there is a personal God or not.

To make it easier for us within the scope of this talk, in which we're trying to decide whether Buddhism is a belief system or a theory meditators are trying to prove true for themselves, I'd like to use the Buddha's own description taken from a discourse I shall be quoting more fully later on. Truth is that which, after observation and analysis, agrees with reason and is conducive to the good and benefit of all. This is the Dharma, the truth, the law, and its noble characteristics are that it makes sense, it's reasonable, and that it is to the benefit of all. I'm sure that most philosophers and religious leaders would agree to this baseline definition, but the Buddha, of course, means that it should be the aim of all individuals to come to such realization for themselves.

What has been essential then in the past to the development of all the systems, and essential to any future development, even if there is almost complete wipe-out of knowledge, not so unthinkable in our nuclear age, is the human desire to realize the truth. If a person living now does not have that desire in them, then all the religions, philosophies and so on are indeed of no avail anyway, since without that desire a person simply won't seek.

Marx said that religion was an opium of the people. It put them into a pleasant dream state, a delusion in which they could be easily manipulated. A lot of people would argue that that's what seems to have happened to Marxism and other communist ideologies themselves. The underlying question here seems to be, why do people become followers and never leaders, disciples and never masters? I'm not here suggesting some anarchic system wherein everyone wants to be a chief leader, but more, why do people never become truly individuals? Or as modern psychology would have it, individuated or truly self-actuated.

There are many psychological reasons, I'm sure, as to why this is. But here, I'd like to centre on what happens when we believe something. It seems that when we believe something, we give up the struggle to find out whether what we have come to believe is

really true or not. By belief here is meant to accept without criticism or personal investigation any statement made by another. Once we've taken this belief position, we blindly accept whatever is said to be true.

If you tell young children that Father Christmas is coming down the chimney, they believe it. I did. I wrote letters and sent them up the chimney. If I was still doing that now, people might think me a little eccentric, to say the least. But I've heard other children questioning it. And I wrote secret letters asking for this and that. Since they never came, I realized it was all just a joke. So I stopped believing there was a Father Christmas. But while I believed in Father Christmas, I felt great. I felt really secure that I'd get everything I wanted. I was really happy. But of course, I was living under a delusion.

I personally believe this to be a very healthy thing to do to children. When they find out adults have tricked them, it should create a healthy scepticism. They lose their gullibility. There's no way you can fool a five-year-old who's discovered adults don't always tell the truth.

This happiness in my delusion about Father Christmas, ignorance is bliss, has an unfortunate side effect. For while I believed, that very belief blocked my investigative faculties. It stifled my intellect. Worse, that belief destroyed the fine line between knowing a statement because I believe it to be true and knowing a statement because I discovered it to be true by my own experience. In other words, belief becomes knowledge. By force of my willingness to believe what my parents told me, by force of my own imagination, I believed Father Christmas to be as real as the presents I got from him.

Although this seems rather trivial when talking about a child's belief in Father Christmas, when we look into history, we see so many examples of belief systems and what happens when someone undermines them. We need to remind ourselves that a belief system in Buddhism is seen as a self-definition, the self of opinions, views and judgments. I am what I believe. I am my opinions. If someone argues against what I believe and I win, I feel good. If in the argument I lose, I also lose my temper and call the other a fool. To actually change some of our cherished opinions can be very hard indeed.

In the Middle Ages, for instance, people believed that man was the centre of God's creation, and therefore that the whole universe revolved about the earth, man's dwelling place. If you look up at the sky, that seems to be reinforced by observation. Indeed, the sun, moon and stars do appear to revolve around us. When Galileo discovered through his new telescope that in fact this was not so, he was told by the church authorities to be silent, or else he may find himself burnt as a heretic.

In the Cultural Revolution in China, anyone even suspected of being a capitalist roader, or of believing that communism may not have it all right, meant imprisonment or execution. In our present-day secularist state, any idea of bringing some moral judgment to bear in laws concerning abortion, surrogate motherhood, and so on, are considered contrary to the idea of personal freedom. This idea of personal freedom can be taken to extremes. In America, study after study has shown that pornography is a chief factor in developing sexist attitudes and in influencing men towards sexual violence. A law enabling women victims of pornography to bring civil actions against pornographers was repealed in the federal courts. The pornographers claimed it was against their constitutional right of free speech. They won, even though the courts accepted that pornography was a violation of women's civil rights to equality and safety from violence. The right to free speech, it seems, takes precedence overall, even when it's harming individuals and society. Here in this country, racists consider it part of free speech to go around insulting people. It's now against the law, but not after a lot of damage had been done to community relations.

One of the outcomes of any belief system, religious, ideological, or whatever, is that the believers form a closed system, which not only has an answer to everything, but which has penalties for those believers who begin to doubt. If I didn't believe in Father Christmas, maybe I wouldn't get any presents. What happens to me if I don't believe in God anymore? If I don't believe Buddha was a fully enlightened being? Suddenly, I'm full of fear, and each system has horror tales of what happens to those who dare to leave. This is also true of Buddhism, when it had become an established religion. It's the way we human beings always like to build secure fortresses. But is it what the Buddha wanted? I think we can safely say that this was exactly the opposite of what the Buddha wanted.

First of all, there are a lot of discourses written in the Socratic fashion, that is, the Buddha uses a question and answer format to get the listeners to discover for themselves the truth of the matter. Indeed, he uses this way of teaching in the very second discourse he gives on the characteristics of human existence, the transiency, unsatisfactoriness and insubstantiality of our lives. He asks, is the body permanent or not permanent? If it is impermanent and subject to change, can we say it belongs to a me? Or say it is what I am? Or say it constitutes a substantial soul or self? To all these questions, the listeners answer, no, venerable sir. And so he goes through all the rest of the aggregates, the sensations, perceptions, volitional conditionings and consciousness.

One often gets from the scriptures whole passages where the Buddha is in conversation with one or another individual, usually beginning with a question and answer session. Only when he sees they've got the point does he then give a talk as such to clarify

his own teachings. There is always the presumption that all that needs to be done is to dispel ignorance and wisdom will arise automatically. We are all capable of enlightenment, but we must all make the effort to achieve it. The Buddha's method is to excite a person's intellectual factors, get them thinking for themselves, and then make a clear statement of his own position, allowing the individual room to criticise and question.

The second factor is his direct teaching on belief itself. There seems to have been an oversupply of religious teachers in his time with all sorts of teachings being expounded. A little bit like today, I imagine. The Buddha, while visiting the village of the Kalamas, was approached by them. They complained that one guru came and taught such and such and then another would come, call the other a fool and teach another set of doctrines. The point was that they were all very confused and didn't know what to believe.

The Buddha then gives a talk which can rightly be called a declaration of an individual's right to freedom of thought. Do not believe anything simply because you have heard it, simply because it is tradition handed down for many generations, simply because it is spoken and rumoured by the many, simply because it is found written in your religious books, simply on the authority of your teachers and elders. Not only do we see in this discourse that the Buddha had no desire for people to sell their souls to his teachings in blind belief, but he exhorted them to think for themselves.

There is an incident in the scriptures which reinforces this picture of the Buddha as one who did not want people to be blind adherents. There was a certain Upali who when he had questioned the Buddha and heard him explain the doctrine was immediately converted. He was a major supporter of another important sect at the time and which still survives in India today, the Jains. The Buddha would not accept him as a follower immediately, but asked him to go back to the Jains and stay with them until he was absolutely sure of what he wanted to do. The Buddha knew that often people are caught up in their enthusiasm, only to feel embarrassed once the excitement has worn off. He really did want people to think about things.

The third factor that points to the Buddha not wanting people to have blind belief in what he said is that he would not make any definite statements about matters that could not be verified, could not be proven. He calls such questions undetermined. In a particular discourse named after the wealthy Brahmin he was talking to, Pottapada, he makes it clear the sort of philosophical, metaphysical questions he will not determine or give an answer to. Is the world eternal or not eternal, finite or infinite? Is the soul the same as the body, or is the soul one thing and the body another? Does an enlightened being live on after death or not? Or does he neither live nor not live again after death?

You can see from these questions they are the sort of questions philosophers, both the professional armchair varieties, love to spend a lifetime talking about. To the exasperated Pottapada, the Buddha explains why he expresses no opinion. Such questions, he says, bring no profit and are not concerned with the Dharma. They don't help to refine our moral behavior and develop non-attachment. Nor do they purify the mind and lead to the cessation of desire. Nor to equanimity, nor to supramundane knowledge, nor to the highest wisdom, *Nibbāna*.

In other words, the Buddha would not be drawn into statements that were of no moral worth and did not lead to the end of suffering. In the context of the times these were the sorts of questions any self-respecting religious teacher was happy to give an answer to, although there was a sect who, like the Buddha, would not enter into such discussions. The point is that the Buddha would not enter into useless arguments about things that could not be verified, could not be proved. To have done so would have put his followers in a position of having to believe something they themselves could not verify and this would have led to an element of blind belief.

So if the Buddha did not leave a set of unverifiable beliefs, he did not leave an empty philosophy or psychology either. And this is the fourth point that shows the Buddha did not want blind believers and indeed simply had no need of such support. The fact is that because he had discovered the truth by his own endeavour, he had also discovered the path to the truth. The Eightfold Noble Path is the great discovery of the Middle Way. He doesn't have to say to people, believe me, for I know this is true. He is free to say, this is the truth, now you can discover it for yourselves, whether it is true or not. Firstly, by the use of your own intellectual powers, and secondly, by direct experience, through practicing the Eightfold Noble Path. What is more, through the practice of *Vipassanā* Insight Meditation, you will discover the Absolute Truth for yourself.

In other words, the Buddha is not simply saying that he's enlightened, but that everyone can become so, and he leaves us the actual method by which we can achieve it. He doesn't want meditators to remain disciples. He wants them to become masters.

These four points then, his method of teaching allowing the listener to think for themselves, his declaration of an individual's right to freedom of thought, no doctrine that was not verifiable, able to be proved to be true by each individual, and lastly, the actual method and practice he left whereby individuals can prove all this to be true for themselves. All of this points to the Buddha not wanting to have people have blind belief. But he did want them to have faith.

The difference between belief and faith is crucial in Buddhist understanding. By belief here is meant an acceptance of a statement about something that cannot be proved. Here there are two types of statements worth pondering over. If I discuss a Walkman with a friend, I would be trying to define what a perfect Walkman is. A cassette radio, stereo, light earphones and rechargeable battery and so on. We would hopefully eventually arrive at the perfect Walkman. But this perfection only exists in my mind. It's a concept. The perfect Walkman. And this concept has all the attributes named above.

Now suppose I say to my friend, where have you put my Walkman? We are no longer worried about what a Walkman is anymore. We're worried about where the object is. The object, the Walkman in this case, really exists.

Now if we keep these two types of statements in mind, the question of what is something as opposed to where is something, we can see we come across great difficulties with questions concerning the supramundane, the supernatural. If we say a God is the perfect good, for example, a group of people should be able to come to a good definition. But because they have come even to a perfect definition about a God, it doesn't mean, therefore, that he or she exists. Just because I can build up a picture of the perfect human being doesn't mean that person will actually ever really exist. When we come to the question of where is God, now that's where we have problems, because no one has yet found God anywhere, or at least anywhere where another person can also find that God. If God could be pointed to in the way that I point to a person, no difficulty would exist.

These are the sorts of arguments the Buddha would not enter into. That's why he wouldn't say what happened to a Buddha after death. Such things are indescribable, unprovable, in the way that you can prove that the body rots after death.

So here is the first error that can be made by the meditator if he believes in what the Buddha says. There is a possibility of turning a concept into a fact, of believing that a concept actually exists apart from the mind that has it.

Nibbāna, for instance, is never described. It's a bold statement. The end of suffering exists, and it isn't annihilation nor a heaven. But what a person experiences when all suffering has gone is never described. If *Nibbāna* could be described, then it would still belong to this type of existence. All words and concepts can only describe what is possible in our experience as human beings, no matter how imaginative. That which is beyond sense experience, beyond the experience of this world, is by definition inexplicable, undescribable.

So to have an idea of what Nibbāna is would actually be a hindrance. For I would be trying to experience my idea of Nibbāna. If or when I do experience my idea of Nibbāna, I will only have experienced my idea of it, what I think it is. To come to a point where I believe that my experience of an idea of Nibbāna, say a brilliant or bright light, is in fact Nibbāna, is to be deluded. Therefore, when it comes to such things, the Buddha was silent.

So, if belief simply means saying something really exists which can't be proved, what is faith? Faith has little to do with thinking. Faith is a disposition of the heart. It is a trusting. It is to set one's heart to something. It arouses confidence in us. This confidence leads to an open-mindedness, to a willingness to investigate for ourselves. It arouses energy, courage and determination.

When the Buddha teaches the fact of the end of suffering Nibbāna, he does so by way of argument. These arguments we might find persuasive. Because we are attracted by the arguments, we ask, well, how do we know it's true? The Buddha then gives us a method, a technique, which will lead us to such a personal experience, the Noble Eightfold Path.

Again, persuaded by this argument, we begin to tread that path. At first, because we're not sure, we do it carefully, hesitatingly. But as we tread the path, we find that what the Buddha said is true. As we discover for ourselves that little bits of what the Buddha said are actually true for us personally, so we listen more attentively to what he has to say, and our trust in his guidance grows. As our trust grows, so does our dedication to the path.

This trust, this faith, known as *saddha*, becomes one of the spiritual faculties. Without this faith, the second faculty, energy, could not arise. If I don't have confidence in something, I'm hardly going to give it a go. If I don't have confidence to dive off the high plank, I'm hardly going to climb up to it. Without confidence, faith, no energy. No energy, no concentration. No concentration, no awareness. Without these, no meditation at all. And with no meditation, no wisdom can arise.

The five spiritual faculties of faith, energy, concentration, awareness and wisdom all depend on this ability to set one's heart to something. Interestingly, once a person has experienced Nibbāna, this faculty is now called a power. For one who has experienced Nibbāna, their faith in the Buddha's path is unshakable, for now they know for themselves the third noble truth of the end of suffering.

So what exactly did the Buddha want us to have faith in? During the last journey of the Buddha, while he was making his way to Kusinara, where he passed into *Parinibbana*, total Nibbāna, Ananda, his faithful attendant for the last 20 years, begins to get frightened when he realizes his master is going to die. With great anxiety, he asks the Buddha what will happen once he's gone. What will happen to the order, to the teaching, to him, Ananda? Who will guide them? Who will guide him once he, the teacher, has gone?

Here is the Buddha's reply. Ananda, be an island unto yourself. Be a refuge unto yourself. Seek no external refuge. Live with the *Dhamma*, the truth, the law as your island, the Dhamma as your refuge. Take no other external refuge.

What is the Buddha saying here? He's saying that in the ultimate analysis there is only the individual seeker and the truth. The truth, the law, the Dhamma that he taught has six qualities. It is to be self-realized. No one can realize the truth for us. When we experience the ultimate truth of Nibbāna, the fruits are immediate. We experience the results of that experience at once. The Dhamma invites us to investigate it. It will lead to Nibbāna, the liberation of all suffering. And finally, it has to be understood, to be comprehended by each person individually.

This is where our confidence is to be put. But the Buddha also said, who sees the Dharma, sees me. In other words, there is no separation between the truth and the expression of that truth within the person of the Buddha. To put trust in the Dharma is therefore also to put trust in the teacher of that Dharma, the Buddha himself. But once he had gone into Parinibbana, the only tangible thing left for his followers is the actual teachings. That's why he asked Ananda to make it his island, his island of refuge.

This Dharma, this truth, however, is not something external to a person. It isn't a treasure chest to be found on an island. It is a treasure to be found within a person's heart and being. Therefore, the Buddha asks Ananda to take refuge in himself, to trust himself, to have confidence in himself. All beings are capable of enlightenment. The Buddha is asking us to have faith in ourselves because in the last analysis we can only free ourselves. The Buddhas only point the way. They can't save us from suffering. We have to pull ourselves out of it.

By cultivating this confidence in ourselves, we are also cultivating confidence in all those who've trod the path and succeeded, the noble ones, the *Aryas*, the saints. So it is that by taking refuge in ourselves, we are also putting trust, taking refuge in all those who have achieved the enlightenment, the Aryan Sangha, the community of noble ones.

In this way, Buddhists take refuge in the Buddha, the Dhamma and the Sangha. In this way, they take refuge in themselves. This is all the Buddha wanted his followers to do, not to believe blindly what he said, not to accept the words of the Master without due investigation. He called himself the *Tathagata*, one who has completed the path, the journey. He wants all to follow that path, but with the spirit of investigation, of personal endeavour. He wants us to experiment and discover it for ourselves.

If it stands to reason, if it is conducive to the benefit of all, then put confidence in it, trust it, and most of all, live up to it. The Buddha didn't ask the Kalamas to become his disciples to become Buddhists. If the Buddha's path works for us, then we should work at it.

I hope you found this talk interesting and helpful. May all of you be happy and peaceful. May all of you attain the nirvanic peace within.

Fear

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 19 min read

In this profound evening talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma offers practical guidance on working with fear in both meditation practice and daily life. He explains how fear manifests before we conceptualise it - as uncomfortable bodily sensations that we immediately categorise and react to, creating layers of 'fear of fear' that keep us trapped in reactive patterns.

The teaching emphasises the importance of developing bravery through meditation - the ability to remain steady in the midst of fear without moving or reacting. Bhante guides us to investigate fear not as an emotion with a story, but as arising and passing sensations in the body. He warns against getting caught in psychological analysis, noting that 'it's the deluded trying to find out how they're deluded.'

Key insights include understanding fear as 'mental-physical turbulence' - like weather passing through the organism - and recognising that suffering comes not from the fear itself, but from our reactions to it. The talk explores how to maintain Right Awareness (sammā sati) when fear arises in daily life, distinguishing between appropriate caution and irrational projection.

Bhante concludes with practical advice for maintaining mindfulness outside retreat conditions, emphasising the importance of regular sitting practice, stopping when rushing, and cultivating wide, relaxed awareness. The ultimate goal is losing our fear of fear itself, which naturally leads to fear's complete dissolution.

Fear. What the meditation is trying to do is get you in contact with fear before you call it fear. What's fear before you recognize it as fear? What is it? It's a bit nauseating. It's an uncomfortable feeling in the body. As soon as the mind recognises it as fear, it categorises it, blocks it. And as soon as it's done that, it'll react. It'll start being afraid of fear. And that's how we suppress stuff. We just push it away with fear. Don't want to see it. So you can't get right down there, you've got to go through those little barriers.

So when fear arises, this is in your meditation now, when fear arises, you first of all have to hold steady and just feel that panic. See, the panic's the fear of the fear, which is making you run. You just hang on in there, you wait for it to die down. And then what you're building up is bravery, isn't it? Bravery is being able to stand in the midst of fear, not move. So you stand there. And then as your reaction goes away, you're still shaking

from the fear. So then you get interested in it, not as an emotion. Because that immediately brings up all sorts of concepts and ideas. You can even get into a wild goose chase of trying to find out why you're afraid. Get into a personal therapy.

When you get into a personal therapy, just remind yourself that it's the deluded trying to find out how they're deluded. And the definition of delusion is, you don't know where the delusion is, so you wouldn't be deluded. So when fear comes up and you try and chase some historical moment when all this fear was gathered, then actually all you're doing is not facing the fear. You're trying to get behind it or before it. And even if you did remember the occasion, would it help? So okay, it was when your mother hit you with a banana across the ear when you were three years old. So what? You're still stuck with the fear. You're still stuck with the aftermath.

So one has to get into the feel of it. So then you point your attention to the quality of its feeling, its sensations, the sensations it's calling. And as you go into it, you taste it. You get a feel for fear. And you just sit in the midst of that. And when you sit in the midst of fear, what's happening? It's just a mental, physical turbulence, isn't it? It's like a bit of bad weather running through the organism, isn't it? You're just sat there just with this nausea or something pitting your stomach or you might have it in your chest. You're just sitting there, that's it. You babysit. Just sit with it.

And as you're sitting with it, you might notice that it's a process. You might notice that there's no such thing as, this is fear. It's just a set of arising and passing away of sensations. They're just little sensations. And you might get that feeling that actually, to be in the midst of that isn't suffering. It's only suffering when you start reacting to it. It's only suffering when the fear of fear arises. And then when you get comfortable with the fear, it's okay, you want more of it. You just sat there with it and said, well, come on, let's show your face. It's like a snake, show your face. So we just let it come up, let it come up.

Now, when you let things come up like that, because you're not identifying with it, I am afraid, because you're not pushing it away, feeding the system with fear, with more fear, because you're not turning away in aversion, because you're not trying to seek its origin, because you're not trying to do anything with it, you're therefore not empowering it at all. In which case, like any energy form, it has entropy. It will die away. It dies away. And then you recognize that actually all you have to do with fear is sit with it. Hug it. I don't want to sound too New Agey there, but just sit with it. And then it passes. It passes.

And that's where your confidence comes. And then you translate that to all your negative states. Depression, stress, whatever it is. And you realize you don't have to do anything at all. You just have to sit in the midst of the flames. That's all. And it arises and passes away. And that's it. End of fear. Guaranteed forty years, if you're lucky, because there's a lot down there. It's not as though you're going to get rid of it. So any ideas of getting rid of fear is also subtle aversion. You mustn't have any opinion about it. What you're really trying to discover is just how to be with it in a non-reactive way.

In so doing, you find, as it were, a place within yourself which is aloof. It's up above. Even though you're in it, you're not of it. So that's what the Buddha's teaching. That's the position we have to take. In the body and mind, in the heart, but not of it. So that sense of being aloof, of being an observer, an experiencer, a witness. You can get there by just an act of will, by saying, this is an object. You can point to it and say fear. As soon as you point to something, it's an object. So it can't be you, it can't be me. You're already creating a distance just by recognizing it's there.

That's not the end point to be an observer. The end point is pure observing. Even that sense of somebody observing disappears. But that just arises naturally. You don't have to work at that. So that's fear. I wouldn't worry about it. There's nothing around that in terms of how you meditate with it, how you actually sit with it. The good thing about strong emotions is that you've, generally speaking, got no problems with concentration.

"Can I ask? Would you say that then if you feel fear in a situation which isn't sitting on the cushion in the situation, that that would be the best approach to adopt?"

I'm coming to that in a minute. Fear in action, as it were. Are you all pretty clear about fear when you're sitting? You're getting to know it intimately. So you have to be aware of your reactions to it too. Come off all head stuff. As soon as you start thinking, imaging something, cut. Come down to the body. Because that's how an emotion develops itself, through thought. It's through the technique of imaginative thinking that emotions develop themselves.

You all know that from when somebody says some little thing that upsets you in the morning and then quite unwittingly you keep thinking about it and thinking about it and thinking about it. By the evening you're chucking them out of the window and doing all sorts of nasty things and all day you've made them insult you. And they only did it once. And it's just because that little irritation has grown and grown through the force of our imagination. So imagination, any thought around fear, you just recognize it as fear and then you come back into the body. So doing you stop it. So now that feeling

of fear has only one place to come out, which is through the body as a feeling. So if you think of the mind as an energy system like the weather, this is just a bit of a storm coming up, let it come and let it pass away.

So now, in daily life, of course, it's a different position. When you're meditating, you're at the interface, you might say, between consciousness and thoughts, consciousness and emotions, consciousness and sensations in the body. When you're meditating like that, ask yourself, where's the personality? It's only when you get up and speak and do that suddenly a personality appears, a personal writing. When you're looking inside yourself, what do you see? A thought? An emotion? So this becoming of a personality is a different position. You're in now the flow of your actions and your speech.

So now, when fear comes up, or anxiety comes up in action, then, as it were, we've still got to try to maintain just that sense of knowing it's there. Knowing it's there. And because of that knowing it's there, you've lifted yourself out of it. Even though this is saying, run, run, run, run, you keep walking. Because you've not fallen into the delusion of the fear. So even though the fear is tearing at you and they're saying, run, run, run, run, you keep walking, you keep walking. Because you're above it. And if you feel it's the same thing, when the panic comes, you say, just stop, hang on in there. You can't handle it, run. It's alright. And then when it passes, just reflect on that. Hmm, that's interesting.

And so in other words, you've got to take your meditation, this insight, into daily life. And don't worry if you so-called don't succeed, because all that's shown is the strength of our conditioning. So that takes a little humility. This is the way it is at the moment. But you work gently against it.

Even if you have a very strong fear, like obsessional stuff. One person who worked with me had problems with contamination. Couldn't go near certain areas that had been contaminated with certain substances. And I was just trying really to, through the meditation, to get her to have enough confidence that she could stay within that fear, and then to try to get the person to walk into that contaminated area. So, in this case it didn't work that way. If you take that as an example, so we all have fear, we all have anxieties and this and that, so it's a case of knowing that it can't kill you, it's only an emotion that comes out. And then just building up through your own self, through your own reflection to move towards that area which is dangerous. Hang on in there. Stay there, just keep moving towards it.

Now ultimately, what's the ultimate point? The ultimate point is the loss of fear of fear. And when you've lost your fear of fear, what's going to frighten you? It's at that point that fear drops away. And that's why, through your meditation, you should see that there's a possibility of the end of fear, the complete ending of fear.

"But when is there a situation when you should worry about fear? When you project fear onto a situation which isn't really fearful, it feels so real. So how really to distinguish between real fear and be sensible about it, and what you've projected from your own mind, it's quite hard."

Yes, of course that's difficult. I mean, you can take an absolutist stance and say that all fear is false projection, but obviously there is a level where it becomes inappropriate, shall we say. It's not fixed to the actual situation. As the case that I've just pointed out, this particular person, if some substance or other, if she thought that some substance or other was in this room, she couldn't go into it. And it was irrational. She was irrational. It wasn't as though she was crazy. But she couldn't go into that room.

So often you can perceive that your fear is irrational. For instance, if you have, on holiday, a fear of jumping off the high board at the swimming pool. Fear is irrational, isn't it? So, if you have that fear, you go up there and do it. You keep doing it until the fear, until you've actually, until you've no fear of it. But in so doing it with meditation, you're actually learning how to be with fear and not to let it hijack you.

Now, there comes that shady area where you don't know whether it's fear or not, whether it's appropriate fear or not. In which case, what can you do? You have to test it. You can only investigate a situation and find out whether in fact your fear was correct or not. How else? You don't know. That's the problem with delusion. You just don't know. You have to keep testing things.

"In its biological origin, I mean, I think it's like a... You'd think that it would be programmed to have fear of something, a self-protection, and that you'd actually be quite heightened perception. So it's that you'd have the fear in order to be able to... We're so used to running away from emotions, but you can imagine that the fear was actually a heightened sense in order to deal with something, so that you're actually in a state where you can think all your senses are alert, which is what you should be anyway, but we're so used to negative emotions, like, you've got to run away from the emotion, rather than it has a function or it has, whether its function is present or past, that you're just to use it or stay with it or go through it."

Yeah, absolutely. I mean, there should be, shall we say, that background fear, for want of a better word, whenever we're crossing a busy road, isn't it? It's just that the fear then becomes a guardian, where you never actually feel the fear, but the fear is running as it were in the background because you know if you make a mistake you're going to get run over.

This is much the same as shame, dread, guilt. When we do something which is unskillful, unwholesome, then these emotions arise, these states of mind arise. But what the Buddha calls them, guardians of society. Not in the sense that they are wholesome because we've done something wrong, but when we've done something wrong and we've felt the inner reaction of shame, dread and guilt, then as it were, it's just like that background program. So the Buddha says, you can get sensitive enough so that as soon as an unskillful, unwholesome idea arises in the mind, it recoils, it recoils like a feather from the flame. And that's that inner conditioning about, well if I do this, this is what's going to happen.

And I dare say that there are inbuilt fear mechanisms just in the mind itself, which is self-protective. But that's not the same as what we're talking about, in a sense, because that just arises and passes away when it's pure. Oops, don't go there. That's it, it's gone. It's like the heart telling you there's danger there. That's totally different from the normal fears and anxieties that we feel ordinarily.

"I just think that that would have a different function, a different feel even to the fear. Don't we rush it up by the use of the word fear when it's actually lower than anxiety?"

Oh, well, that's what I meant about as soon as you label it, you categorize it and then all your history comes in and before you know it, you're stuck with an ogre, where in fact it was just a little tickling in the stomach. A little tickle in the solar plexus. Yeah, definitely. That's the problem with history.

I mean, my own personal opinion is that the fully liberated person wouldn't feel fear at all, apart from that fear of just knowing something is dangerous, as a background understanding, you might say. Just on the grounds that there's no association at all anymore, there's no identity or wrong understanding of what this body, mind and heart is. Once it's not you, it's not a big problem, is it? You can intellectualize, you can rationalize and say, well, I know my body's not me, it's going to die, etc., etc. But then when the doctor tells you you've got six weeks to go, you freak out. So there's a difference between intellectual grasp of something, an understanding of something, and actually moving to that level of consciousness which no longer identifies with the body.

But I dare say it's root stuff. I mean, the place where these emotions are kept, the amygdala or something, I think that's what they call it, comes from reptilian life, doesn't it? I mean, it's part of that whole evolution of basic life. The reason that our emotions, it seems, are civilized is because they're all channeled through the front part of the brain, which is new to human beings, it seems. But when they escape, that's when you get the road rage, computer rage, things like that.

"I had the experience last week of leaving the barn for a week and travelling around and staying in different houses and I found it very difficult to keep my meditation practice going and the mindfulness in a sense and I'm wondering if you had any pointers towards maintaining practice on the road."

Yeah, well, that's the big difficulty, isn't it? First of all, you just have to recognize that a place like this, a meditation centre, there are special conditions. People try not to disturb you for a start. Generally speaking, people try to respect your silence and respect what you're doing, which isn't so in the outside world, so to speak. So, you'll never get the same quality in ordinary daily life from what you do in the centre until there's been a real, I would say, a real purge of the heart. So I think it's unrealistic to think that you're just going to walk out of a meditation centre or the barn like this and take it with you.

So it's a case of recognizing that you have to put in some coping mechanisms. So it's very much a case of keeping up the practice morning and evening. The morning is a time when you remind yourself what level of consciousness you want to be at during the day. And the evening, I don't mean just figure a bed, just fall asleep. In the evening, say, after work or before you eat, to sit and just let whatever you've accumulated during the day just arise and pass away. Then, of course, you have a very pleasant meal and a more pleasant evening.

The other thing is just simple things like if you find yourself rushing, stop. Stop. One thing at a time. Breathe. When you're talking to somebody, remind yourself to listen. If you've got the answer ready before they finish, you're not listening. You can't listen and answer at the same time. The brain can't do that. So you're presuming what they're going to say and you've already given them an answer. So it's just relaxing into what's happening. And of course what you find is that when you do that, the other person does it.

Yesterday it was rather funny really. I'd gone to a cafe with somebody to have a little coffee and then we were walking back because we were trying to open another bank account for this trust we had. As we were walking there, the pace lifted and halfway through, Anne, and some of you know Anne Ashton, she said to me, God, you're walk-

ing fast. And I said, I thought you were walking fast. And we were just firing off each other without knowing it. So, by the end of it, I was running to this damn bank. So, it's a case of just recognizing that, you know, perhaps the coffee was too strong. Maybe that's what did it.

If we're sharp enough, if we can maintain that sharp mindfulness and recognize that mindfulness or awareness, it doesn't have to be trapped into one single object. It can be quite wide. Even now, as you're listening to me, and that's where, as you would say, the point of your attention is, you can still be slightly aware of the bird chirping out there, and just the colours in the room. It's like that wide awareness. And to get that, you have to be very relaxed. As soon as you get tight, the whole thing... And so it's that effort just to keep relaxing, feel your shoulders and... just let the breath go for a little while. Then you just have to keep doing it and keep doing it and keep doing it. And just very slowly you... Try to take life easy.

And then little reflections like, does it help to rush? Does it help to get irritated? What does it do? What's the point of it? It doesn't mean that we don't get irritated and we don't rush. It's just that we're trying to slowly work against these old habits which are deeply ingrained and are reinforced by society. This is the problem. I mean, if you were to stay here for, I don't know, a year or so, then it would begin to undermine a certain conditioning. But the effort has to be made because the one feeds into the other. If you meditate, say, for a week or something and then go out and have sex, drugs and rock and roll, then you've had it. You come back and you've still got these headaches and backaches and it's as though you've got to take it into daily life. And don't expect great change, very slow. It comes over a long period of time.

I remember once when I came back from... I'd been out in the east meditating and a very old friend of mine came up who's a long-time meditator and his first question was, is there a quicker way? That was the only thing he was actually concerned with. Is there a quicker way than this? I'm afraid that... Well, I mean, if you find one, come and tell me about it.

Stopping is a very strong technique. If you leave a room, for instance, and you've picked up a bit of irritation there. If you just open the door, close the door, just mindfully, and then just stand for a moment and just recognize what's happening. And then just wait for it to die out a little, then you find it doesn't snowball. You don't take it with you into the next room and off it goes. So you ratchet things up all the time.

"Just a question about right effort, that balance between too much effort and not enough, the technique to find the best way to concentrate too much, but not put too much pressure on it. But, you know, hanging in an easy... Just in particular meditation."

Ah. Well, I've always thought that's pretty easy, actually, to get over that one. Because we are Westerners, we have to achieve. Okay? So, make your achievement just being aware. That is the achievement, to be aware. That's it. You don't have to worry about insights. Just be aware of what's happening. Put the whole of your effort in just knowing what's actually happening now. As soon as you put any expectation to it, as soon as you put an idea to it, then of course you are bringing some extra to that present moment-to-moment awareness. So you're not looking for anything, you're just looking at what's coming up. And to do that, you have to relax. So your posture should be held up to the spine and everything else will happen. So relax on it. You relax on the object.

And to keep the attention there, don't worry about concentration. Raise the interest. Just ask yourself, when did you ever lose concentration if you were interested in something? It comes naturally. If the interest isn't there, if there's boredom, then you have to ask yourself. Well, now that's interesting. Any object which comes, you have to raise that question mark. And it's childlike curiosity. And it's questioning, do I really know? Do I really know?

So I sit there and I think, well, as we were discussing, fear. Do I really, really know what fear is before I name it? Do I really, really know what an emotion is before I conceptualize it? Because that's the process in the mind. First there's a sensation or a feeling, then there's some labeling or perceptual process, and then the history comes in, and that's it.

Even in very simple things like, you might see one of these flowers. So you might name it a rose or something. But do you know it? Do you know that particular rose? Or have you just looked at it and it's just fitted into a pattern of a rose so then you've seen it. But have you gone up and really looked at the colour, looked at the veins in the petals, seen the shape of the petals, have you actually smelt it? But we're happy just to say that's a rose and then we think we know it.

So it's raising that curiosity as to what is actually happening now and recognizing that that is the achievement. That's it. That's all the Buddha's teaching. *Satipaṭṭhāna*, awareness and intuitive intelligence. It's just the establishment of that. And it comes when you have right attitude. You just want to know what's happening now. So you just rest your eye on it.

So you can practice this on ordinary things. So the next time you're just out in the garden there and a flower, just rest your eye on it. So you don't look for anything, just rest your eye on it and see what the perceptual faculty is doing. Observe how the mind observes the flower. Just be aware of where the eyes are going. And that's it.

And when you catch yourself with wrong effort and you know that because you get tight I mean the other side of course is that you lose energy and you fall asleep. That's not so painful. But the other side when you get tight and you start feeling nasty about yourself and all that, then just go into the feelings of it, the sensations of it. There's something crept in there about achieving it, that's all.

So, as you know, the mind's very subtle, it's very... you think you're doing it right, and then you find out afterwards you weren't doing it right. But that's alright. Just to find out that you weren't doing it right is a step forward. And sometimes you find out you didn't do it right, and now you think, well, from now on I will do it right. And a little bit later you realise you've done it wrong again. So, that's alright. That's how slippery the mind is.

"Is it time for tea then?"

Fear!

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 2 min read

This compelling essay examines fear as the fundamental emotion underlying all our defensive strategies and self-protective mechanisms. Bhante Bodhidhamma explores how the fear of death — arising from our attachment to the sense of self — becomes the 'mother of all fears' that drives us toward countless avoidance behaviors, from social media and consumption to anger and control.

Rather than escaping through these familiar strategies, the essay presents the Buddhist approach of facing fear directly as raw emotional material. Through gradual familiarization with fear's sensations — the cold agitation, suffocated breath, and racing heart — practitioners can lose their fear of fear itself. This process reveals how our 'deluded heart' creates horror scenarios and maintains the illusion of a substantial self that needs defending.

As fear dissolves through direct experience, the sense of self diminishes and defensive barriers weaken. The essay culminates in the profound realization that fearlessness naturally leads to an embracing heart capable of genuine compassion — even the willingness to suffer or die for another. This teaching offers both psychological insight and practical guidance for working with one of our most primal emotions on the path to awakening.

Have you ever allowed yourself to feel fear? I don't mean fearful. I don't mean anxious. I mean have you felt fear intimately? The raw emotion? The simple sensation of it? I don't mean sit by the fire. I mean jump into it. So long as there is a self, a 'me', someone there to defend, there will be fear. Because the self, that notion or view of me, that sense of me, that I am someone, knows it cannot exist for ever. It knows it will die. The fear of death is the mother of all fears. Yet who would want to sit still in the midst that experience - the cold agitation, the suffocated breath, the debilitating weakness, the exploding heartbeat, the nausea. Surely there is something we can do about it. Of course there is! We can turn to social media, nothing like talking to others about the weather, the tennis, Brexit, to get away from fear. Nothing like eating, or drinking. Alcohol is such a salve. Or perhaps the primal fear has morphed into other fears. Fear of loneliness or anger or love or spiders. I say morphed, but it's another way of guarding ourselves. To attach a fear to 'something' is more bearable than the fear of death, of annihilation, of total loss. And to guard ourselves well, we need to control. The more we control, the more we feel safe. To guard what we have. To fend off attacks real or imaginary. Yes! And anger too. Anger is good. It empowers us. 'Where there is fear, I shall fight.' Anger

feels good. It frightens others. It protects me from my fear. And I love to see the fear in others. And dominate! But in the worst case scenario run. Hide. Seek seclusion. And there is always shopping, jogging ... and sex. What strategies do you have? The Buddha did not say the path was easy. He said it was gradual. Against the stream. With every fear that arises we are given a chance to feel the raw emotional material. Slowly we become accustomed. The more accustomed, the more we lose the fear of those emotional sensations. Then we realise it is the deluded heart that goads the mind into horror scenarios. And as we gradually lose our fear of fear we begin to see the possibility of fearlessness. For if we lose our fear of fear, what could possibly frighten us? And since fear is the measure of our self-delusion, so the sense of self diminishes until such time as the wrong view of self, the belief that sense of self is substantial and essential, is cut asunder completely. All the while as the materials of fear dissolve, the barriers of defence weaken. The once embattled heart begins to embrace. Then we understand how we might suffer for another – die for another.

Fifth Maxim: Develop the Body and Mind

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 3 min read

This essay examines the fifth of six ethical maxims proposed for preparing for climate catastrophe, focusing on training the body and mind to deal with despair. Noirin Sheahan draws profound connections between these contemporary recommendations and core Buddhist teachings, particularly the Ānāpānasati Sutta's breathing exercises and the doctrine of not-self (anattā).

The essay explores how the Buddha's own journey from despair to awakening mirrors our current need to develop physiological and psychological resilience. It examines how breathing practices can calm body and mind, how maintaining physical health supports spiritual development, and how understanding the illusory nature of ego can liberate us from unnecessary suffering. The teaching emphasizes that clinging to a substantial sense of self creates emotional and physical burdens that manifest as tension, illness, and distress.

Drawing from the opening verses of the Dhammapada and the Buddha's own experiences with asceticism and the middle way, the essay demonstrates how Buddhist practice prepares us not just for personal liberation, but for serving others during times of collective crisis. It suggests that those who can meet despair with Right Awareness will become increasingly vital for maintaining hope and preventing social chaos as climate impacts intensify.

This tip looks at the 5th of the six maxims which have been suggested as ethical preparation for climate catastrophe. The authors, David Schenck and Larry Churchill, believe that we are heading towards social collapse due to the unstoppable consequences of Climate Change and that the trauma of losing so much of what we take for granted – like food, water, social stability – will lead to huge levels of stress and mental illness. My purpose in writing these tips is to tease out some links between these maxims and the Dhamma. The fifth maxim advises us to train the body and mind. Here's what they say: Learn breathing exercises. Develop the physiological capacity to deal with despair. Despair isn't just psychological, it's physiological. Learn skills for getting beyond ego—not just the cognitive limits of ego, which many are at least familiar with pondering, but the emotional and physiological limits of ego. Training the mind is central to the Dhamma. The first verse of the Dhammapada tells us that all our suffering is mind-made: Speak or act with an impure mind - Suffering follows, just as the wheel of the ox-cart follows the footsteps of the ox. Speak or act with a pure mind - Happiness follows, as

surely as our shadow follows our footsteps. Although the body plays a central role in the Buddha's teaching, it is always as a means for training the mind. In a similar vein, the six maxim authors aren't advocating fitness for its own sake, but for the sake of dealing with despair. Thus their advice has many resonances with the Dhamma: Breathing exercises: The Anapanasati Sutta lists a number of breathing exercises. These start with mindfulness, knowing when we're breathing in and when we're breathing out. They include the kind of yogic breathing exercises David and Larry are indicating e.g. using the breath to calm the body and mind, to develop pleasant feeling, to gladden the mind & develop concentration. The need to deal with despair: Despair was what fuelled the Buddha's quest for enlightenment: his early life of luxury was rendered meaningless once he realised that this would end in sickness, aging and death. His whole teaching, he said, could be reduced to a simple statement: there is suffering and there is an end to suffering. Having transcended his own despair we can be confident that the Dhamma will teach us to do likewise. Develop the physiological capacity to deal with despair: The Buddha's first attempts at spiritual development started with deeply concentrated forms of meditation. Seeing these gave only a temporary respite from despair he went on to practice strenuous asceticism. On the verge of death from starvation and hardship he abandoned this approach, accepted a bowl of rice-milk and went on to discover his own path to liberation. Taking the rice-milk indicates the need for physical energy in order to make his spiritual breakthrough. While body building isn't lauded as a virtue in his teaching, he encouraged people to maintain good health e.g. to do walking meditation so as to develop energy, health and aid digestion; to eat healthy food like rice-gruel so as to enjoy health, strength and a comfortable abiding. Ego limitations manifest not only cognitively, but emotionally and physiologically: In Dhamma terminology, we suffer because we cling to the wrong view of self. This suffering manifests as emotional burdens like greed and aversion, which have physical aspects – for some it might be muscular tension, for others headaches, stomach upsets, breathing difficulties. Getting beyond the ego: This is one way of describing the teaching on 'Not-Self'. Believing there is a substantial core to the person we call 'me', we suffer when things go wrong for us – when we get blamed or mistreated, when we fall ill or become incapacitated, when we lose those we love. The Buddha does not deny the suffering, or the fact that it is happening to the person I call 'me'. Caring deeply for that person, he would respond with compassion, while knowing the suffering as unnecessary, based on mistaken identification with body and mind, with the person called 'me'. All our practice is aimed at seeing through this illusion, so as to gain the peace and joy of liberation. This penultimate maxim resonates well with the Buddha's teaching. Despair will emerge for all of us as we witness the increasing impact of climate change on nature, on vulnerable communities as our own food supplies and social structures grow ever less reliable. Can we take the coming storm to heart, prepare ourselves as advised in the 5th Maxim? If we

care for our body as the necessary basis for learning the Dhamma, train body and mind according to the Anapanasati and other suttas, we will be ready to let it become part of our path to the end of suffering. When despair becomes widespread in society, those of us who can meet it mindfully will become ever more important in preserving hope, preventing a decline into chaos.

First Maxim: Work Hard to Grasp the Immensity

Noirin Sheahan · 3 min read

This essay examines the first of six ethical maxims for preparing for climate change: 'work hard to grasp the immensity.' Noirin draws profound parallels between the Buddha's teaching on death contemplation (marāṇasati) and our need to face the reality of environmental and social collapse. Just as the Buddha encouraged followers to contemplate corpses to overcome denial of mortality, we must deliberately expose ourselves to the reality of climate change's consequences. The essay explores how mindfulness practice can help us develop authentic relationships with both nature and social structures we depend upon - food systems, infrastructure, governance - while they still function. Through personal examples of mindful walking in nature, Noirin demonstrates how paying full attention to trees, wildflowers, and birds can become a gentle teacher of impermanence (anicca) and vulnerability. She describes working skillfully with emotional reactions like dread, guilt, and grief that arise when contemplating environmental collapse, showing how mindful awareness can transform our relationship from attachment or aversion toward acceptance. The practice extends beyond nature to appreciating social supports like electricity, water systems, and civic institutions, cultivating gratitude while preparing psychologically for their potential absence.

Preparing for Climate Change - First Ethical Maxim

This follows from the August tip describing six maxims that we can practice to fortify ourselves for

the environmental and social consequences of climate change. The first maxim asks us to “work hard

to grasp the immensity”; this tip won’t discuss the likelihood or extent of the consequences we can

expect (if interested you could read the paper that suggested the maxims) but explore some links

between the first maxim and the Dhamma.

The maxim fits perfectly with the Buddha’s advice that we come to terms with the fact that

everything inside us and outside is in flux, vulnerable, dependent on circumstance. We plan our

career, family, diary, around the presumption that we will continue to have a stable food and water

supply, electricity, public transport, schools, internet, the rule of law, government. All of these are put in jeopardy because of climate change. But their absence is, for most of us, unthinkable. The mind skims over the implications, we might feel blocked or frightened or we might doze off or restlessly seek distraction. Soon we're back to 'business as usual'. This parallels with the way we ignore our own mortality. Intellectually we know we will die someday, but rarely do we think about this. To overcome this reluctance, the Buddha asked his followers to deliberately expose themselves to the reality of death - to look at dead bodies, smell them, see the flesh rotting, the maggots feeding, the residue of bones and dust, reminding themselves "one day this will happen to my body; I am not exempt from this fate." To follow this approach regarding environmental and social collapse we could read relevant articles or watch documentaries. We could talk the matter over with friends or family or look for on-line support in coming to terms with the situation. We should also remember that the contemplation of death is the final exercise that the Buddha lists for mindfulness of the body. He starts with mindfulness of breathing and posture and everyday activities. We get to know the body very intimately in life before we contemplate its death. Similarly, we can become more mindful of the environment and social structures as they now function to fortify ourselves for their impending collapse. We can walk in nature, paying full attention to grass, trees, birds, sky, all the while being aware of our emotions e.g. enjoyment, boredom. Acknowledging our reactions honestly allows us to forge a deeper relationship that will eventually transcend attachment, indifference, aversion. This mirrors Joanna Macy's advice to develop our relationship with nature in order to strengthen ourselves for the challenge of climate change. After reading her book "Active Hope" I

started taking
a deeper interest in nature. My daily walks slowed as wildflowers and grasses and bird-song
demanded attention. After some time I began to dread winter when the verges would
be muddy and
drab, the birds silent. I worked mindfully with this anxiety and dread till one day I
noticed an
underlying guilt, a feeling that I should somehow be able to give each flower the gift of
everlasting
life and was failing in my task! Once I became aware of this delusion I could smile at it
and enjoy my
walks again. I started to appreciate the grasses, flowers and birds as dhamma teachers. Their
message of transience and vulnerability became a gentle way of learning about my own
mortality.
More recently my daily walks help me assimilate the possibility of environmental
collapse. Walking
by a tree I reflect that it might not live out its natural lifespan, that its roots might
already be

detecting degradation in the soil, its flowers noticing the lack of insects. Grief or
anger might emerge
but sometimes these resolve into a bitter-sweet 'hello, goodbye' as we meet on our jour-
neys
through life and death.
I find this next part more difficult but am trying to extend the practice to include social
supports such
as food in the shops, water pouring when I turn a tap, electricity flowing when I press a
switch. I
remind myself to be grateful for whatever services now work – transport, schools,
hospitals, internet
and the social norms that allow me feel safe on my daily walk. The more I value these
wonders, the
better I will be able to contemplate living without their immense benefits.
I also appreciate the support of others in this endeavor. If you think you might similarly
benefit you
could join the Satipanya forum dedicated to practicing with the Six Maxims. Email
Noirin for further
information or to register.

Some resources that are helping me 'grasp the immensity':

Hothouse Earth, Bill McGuire, Icon Books, 2022

This Changes Everything, Naoimi Klein, Penguin, 2014

Climate Crisis and the Global Green New Deal, Noam Chomsky & Robert Pollin, Verso, 2020

What society might look like as its structures collapse:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Lcem_tutbGc

<https://www.bbc.com/future/article/20170418-how-western-civilisation-could-collapse>

Gwen's tip from the September newsbyte contained many additional resources and after our second

Climate and Dhamma Zoom session, Gwen shared Caroline Bird's poem "Prepper":

First Noble Truth: There is Dukkha

Noirin Sheahan · 45 min

In this teaching on the Four Noble Truths, Noirin Sheahan examines the Buddha's first insight: the existence of dukkha (suffering/unsatisfactoriness). Rather than pessimism, this teaching offers the essential starting point for liberation. She explores dukkha's three manifestations: dukkha-dukkha (obvious suffering like illness, death, loss), anicca-dukkha (dissatisfaction arising from life's transient nature), and anattā-dukkha (existential angst from our lack of meaningful control).

Using vivid examples from daily life - holidays ending, meals finishing, books concluding - Noirin shows how anicca-dukkha permeates our experience through beginnings and endings. She demonstrates how our cultural avoidance of unpleasant realities prevents the deep love and understanding that transcends our preferences. Through meditation on breathing and walking, practitioners can explore how attachment to pleasant experiences and aversion to endings creates suffering.

The teaching also addresses anattā-dukkha, examining how the sense of self arises with effort and dissolves in peaceful moments. Noirin explains how perception constructs our reality, including our sense of self, and how understanding not-self doesn't mean annihilation but recognizing when different perceptions serve us wisely. This comprehensive exploration prepares practitioners for deeper investigation of suffering's roots and ultimate liberation.

The talks for the rest of the week will centre on the Four Noble Truths, which was the first teaching the Buddha gave after his enlightenment. He described these as his own insights into the nature of suffering and the process by which it is eliminated. When he gave this teaching, he added an injunction with each truth. These bring the teaching alive for us. We can live the Four Noble Truths.

So what are these truths the Buddha wants us to live by? The first is that life involves *dukkha*. The injunction here is to fully understand dukkha. The second truth states that desire is the cause of dukkha. The Buddha asks us to let go of desire. The third truth is the good news, that there is an end to dukkha. The injunction is to realise the end of dukkha. Finally, we have more good news, that there is a way to the end of dukkha, namely the noble eightfold path. The injunction is to follow this path.

Let's start off tonight with the first noble truth, the truth of dukkha. For people with only a superficial interest in Buddhism, this can be off-putting. It's easy to deride Buddhists as pessimists because of the focus on suffering. Our culture more often encourages us to ignore the unsavoury aspects of life. We don't like to discuss death, for example.

Just this morning, I was listening to a radio interview with four people who had lost their spouses. One man who had obviously had a very close relationship with his wife said his only regret was that they never discussed her death. They both knew she was dying but couldn't acknowledge it openly. He sensed her growing distant from him in her last weeks because of this gap between them. When asked why he didn't broach the subject, he said it was because he didn't know how. They had both tried so hard to be optimistic and positive, and he didn't know how to break through that pattern.

I think this is a good illustration of our cultural difficulty around opening to death and other unwelcome aspects of life. We just don't know how to open. We build up habits of optimism and cheerfulness to try to buoy ourselves up, but then get stuck in these habits and lose touch with our deeper reality. His regrets around not having spoken to his wife about her impending death also shows the trap of our focus on the positive. It prevents the development and expression of a love which transcends our wishes for how life should be.

It is ironic that the path to happiness starts with an understanding of unhappiness, but this was the Buddha's great insight. Once he fully understood the nature of suffering, he became completely free from suffering. He was untroubled, quiet at ease and content throughout all the vicissitudes of life, and even as he died a painful death from food poisoning. He was open and unsentimental about the fact that he was dying, and not a bit impressed with his cousin Ananda for weeping at the news. With characteristic pragmatism, he reminded Ananda that old worldly pleasures fade away. He was willing and able to teach right up to the moment of death, leaving his followers with the words: "All conditioned things have the nature to decay. Strive diligently for your liberation."

He described dukkha as coming in three flavours. Firstly, there is dukkha-dukkha, which is what we normally recognise as suffering: illness, pain, death, redundancy, financial ruin, old age, bereavement and so on. Then there is *anicca* dukkha, resulting from the transient nature of life. And finally there is *anattā* dukkha, the existential angst we can feel because we don't have any meaningful degree of control over our lives.

Dukkha-dukkha is the most difficult for us to deal with. We go through shock, anger, grief and so on before coming to terms with major life challenges. Dukkha-dukkha is inescapable. Even if we live a charmed life, we will someday have to die. And if we're lucky enough to have a long life, we'll have to negotiate our way through the various humiliations of old age along the way. For many people, this dukkha-dukkha is their only encounter with the limitations of life, and they can be really thrown off course by the death of a loved one, for example. The incidence of depression increases with age, and the risk of suicide is highest in the elderly.

As a way of preparing ourselves for the inevitable, we can practise on the milder forms of dukkha relating to anicca and anattā. Let's look at anicca dukkha first – the dissatisfaction we feel because of the transitory nature of life. We have loads of examples of this in our daily life. Take a holiday for example. We can get quite excited at the prospect, looking through the brochures, checking out the hotels, booking time off work. Then we're on holiday. It can take a day or two to settle and relax. If we're lucky, we'll enjoy ourselves and appreciate our stay. But how quickly that final day comes round when we have to pack and go home again. And there's still the hotel bill to be paid. Sometimes we're energised and refreshed by the holiday, chatting to our colleagues and friends about what we've seen, but eventually the gloss wears off and we're back to our daily routine again.

That's the essence of anicca dukkha, the dissatisfaction we feel because the good times just don't last forever. It can be quite subtle and we might not feel it as a major problem, just part of life, we say philosophically. But the Buddha's advice is not to dismiss the problem so readily. Take an interest in the ending and aftermath of the holiday as much as the exciting and relaxing times before and during the holiday.

We often find ways to ignore the slight downer at the end, planning the next holiday for example. The problem with ignoring the endings of all our happy times is that we get addicted to activity or other forms of escapism as a means of keeping our spirits up. We look to the future, the next exciting thing in life, to keep our mind off the fact that something we cared for has just ended. If we persist in this, keeping ourselves buoyed up and cheerful at all costs, then we will have no resources to deal with the inevitable dukkha-dukkha when it comes.

I first noticed anicca dukkha as I was reading a book. I was always a great reader and would never go anywhere without a book for company. At the hairdressers, on the bus, during coffee. So long as I had a book, I was happy. I was pretty well addicted to reading, you could say. And then one day, I suddenly became aware that the number of pages on the right, the unread pages, was less than the number of pages on the left. I

felt quite depressed by this. From then on, I began to dread turning each page. When I finished the book, I felt a real downer and also a sense of shame. I was suddenly aware that the pleasure from reading was transitory, that it ended with the book, and therefore couldn't satisfy me at any depth. I was ashamed of having devoted so much of my life to this false god. This was quite a shock for me, and it was years before I would read a book again.

If we look closely, we see everything is in transit. It arises, shows itself for a moment before passing away again. Take any meal, lunch for example. It can be hard work getting this started. We may have to do some shopping and then the cooking. At least we're buoyed up through this by the prospect of lunch. Then comes the nice bit, eating. And if there are others with us, this can be a lovely part of the day, a time to relax and chat. But how quickly it ends! And there's still the washing up to be done.

Although we prefer to fudge around endings, distracting ourselves with whatever is next on the horizon, the wiser approach is to use this opportunity to get to know dukkha. So how do you experience the ending of lunch? See how you feel before lunch and how eager you are for the first bite. Does your mood lift as your stomach fills? And then the ending. Are you still so enthusiastic when the plate shows those last messy smears of food? Or do you just feel you have to get the job done? Can you rest with whatever emotions might surface as you swallow the last bite?

I remember on the final day of a retreat at Gaia House how much I was looking forward to the evening bowl of soup and it was delicious. But as the bowl emptied my world actually seemed to fall apart. I wanted that soup to last forever. It seemed to hold all the goodness of life for me. How could I let it go? What would there be left in the world? A big gap yawned open inside me. For a moment I was very frightened, and then grief surfaced. The grief was actually a relief, and I began to acknowledge other losses in life. This was a good illustration of anicca dukkha for me, and how opening to it mindfully helps us work with the inescapable dukkha of life and death.

Each breath and footstep teaches us about anicca. Which do you prefer, the in-breath or the out-breath? Do you like to hold your breath? When I am anxious, I tend to gasp at the start of the in-breath and my confidence grows as I inhale. But then comes the moment when I have to let it all go again. I do my best to ignore the out-breath as I look forward to that moment when I can snatch another ray of hope that comes with the in-breath. This is anicca dukkha. Anxiety is prompting me to hold on to what I enjoy, the sense of possibility and hope that comes with each in-breath. But anxiety will not let me relax with the out-breath. Let go of hope? No way! Nowadays when anxiety strikes I can usually let myself feel the fear of letting go and find a thin thread of trust that pulls me

through. This comes from moments during previous out-breaths when I saw that letting go of hope does not mean the end of all hope. It simply releases hope to do its proper job of reassuring us deep down that all is well. In the words of Julian of Norwich, "All shall be well, and all shall be well, and all manner of things shall be well."

What about the footstep? Do you prefer the lifting, the moving or the placing? At first I could only sense the lifting. It thrilled me. I had a sense of soaring with the angels. I didn't notice anything about the rest of the step, so intent was I in looking forward to the next time I could lift my foot. As time went on, I also became fascinated by the moving. This was more wonderment than the soaring of angels. Could I feel anything? What was I feeling? How did I know my foot was moving? But the ending of the footstep was another matter entirely. I felt uncertain, unsteady as the foot came downwards, searching for the floor. And when the toe touched down, the lightness of that touch seemed totally unsatisfactory. Even with my full weight on the floor, I felt unhappy under that lovely moment of the heel rising, the foot peeling off the floor, when all my woes would end for another few moments.

What all this shows me is how addicted I am to new beginnings and how I prefer to ignore the uncertainty that comes with endings. I can see this at other levels of life. I love springtime but find it hard to appreciate the lovely colours of the fall because they represent the end of the summer. I'm a morning person. I love the purity of dawn, whereas I easily get agitated in the evenings. I can be good at getting projects going, exploring new territory, but find it hard to see them through to the end. I used to do quite a lot of hill walking, and to my surprise one day, I found I preferred the uphill climb to the downhill stroll. Going upwards, I had a sense of hope, a promise of some reward to come. Coming down, on the other hand, was literally that, a come down. There was nothing to anticipate.

The years of meditation practice have smoothed me out a bit. Just last year I noticed to my surprise that I was enjoying the ending of the footstep. It felt satisfying to put my foot down on the floor and let it take all my weight. A little bit of progress at last.

The study of anicca has also shown me how much delusion I can have about new beginnings. The sense of anticipation, hope and expectancy can rocket me into the new venture, all excited and thrilled and knowing this is going to be wonderful and that I'll be well able for the challenge. But when I eventually hit the ground, I'm looking around wondering how I got here and what I'm supposed to be doing. Nowadays, I'm better at noticing all those exciting feelings of expectancy and anticipation and steady myself on the launch pad, wait a bit to try to get some bearings before take-off.

I've noticed that there can be a lot of fear around new beginnings. Each one is a venture into the unknown. And I sense how my eagerness to start is a reaction to that fear, wanting to get rid of that scary unknown by filling it with activity. Endings too can frighten us with a sense of the unknown. Take my life and death bowl of soup after my retreat, for example. That ending scared me so. Again, it was fear of the unknown. The soup was known. How could it just end? Can what we know actually disappear, become unknown?

Working with the unknown is such a big part of our meditation practice. As we are drawn into the present moment we lose touch with the certainties sewn into our stories and sense the shifting sands beneath. What do we really know? Just sensations and feelings really and these are shifting and changing so fast it's hard to claim any real knowledge of them. While my body contacts the sensations, my mind is drawn towards a mental image I am making in my efforts to make sense of the experience. I imagine a big space in which the sensations are manifesting. It puzzles me, this space. Sensations seem to twinkle like stars in its vast emptiness. Now, what can we say about that emptiness, that space where sensations appear and into which they disappear? Not a lot, nothing perhaps. It can still frighten me to sense myself so close to such a vast unknown. Fear projects all kinds of monsters into it. But despite my best efforts at suspicion, fear and even panic, all I can say really is it has never lived up to my expectations. It has never, ever threatened me in any way. I am more and more willing to trust that it is truly and deeply non-harming.

In ordinary life, the unknown appears in our minds when we think about the future, the next moment. It's behind the door before we open it. Thoughts also connect us with the unknown. I think of a friend and wish them well. But where are they right now? I might have a nice image of them sitting in a garden, but ultimately I have to admit I don't know. How are they feeling? I haven't a clue. The amount we don't know far outweighs what we do know, where and how our friends and family are, what's going to happen tomorrow, next year, in twenty years. So we have to get used to the unknown if we're going to have any peace. Anicca, with its beginnings and endings, provides the perfect opportunity.

I've been describing the difficulties we experience due to anicca, but the truth of anicca can also be experienced as joyous. The flow of sensations as the foot peels off the floor can be exhilarating. The slight sways of the body as we walk can be fascinating. The smooth ripple of breath can be relaxing. We can watch and wonder as sensations and feelings stream through consciousness like water through a sieve. We can feel truly alive in the shifting flux. And when I worked through my latest bout of fear and anxiety

to make peace with the unknown, then it is delightful to let myself relax and let the breath come and go of its own accord, let emotions emerge and develop and fade away. The transience is thrilling. It's perfectly okay not to know what will happen next.

Intertwined with *anicca* is the experience of *anattā*, usually translated as not-self. This is a difficult truth to come to terms with. Our minds are deeply conditioned to think in terms of me and you and him and her and so on, and we find this shift in perspective to not-me, not-I, not-self quite perplexing. The negativity that can come with being perplexed, frustration, confusion, anxiety, etc., is one manifestation of *anattā dukkha*.

To my mind, the kernel of fear that forms *anicca dukkha* is fear of the unknown. By comparison, I think much of the *dukkha* associated with *anattā* revolves around fear of not understanding.

That can make us feel like small children at school, feeling stupid and ashamed because we don't understand our lessons, frightened the teacher and the other kids will jeer at us. So look out for these kinds of emotions when you're exploring *anattā*, even now as you listen to the talk, for example. If they surface, see can you model the kind of teacher kids love: patient, encouraging, prepared to stop the lessons to have some fun, and especially to notice and resist any tendency to put yourself down, hate yourself because of how slowly this teaching is sinking in, or judge yourself as stupid and so on. If that happens, definitely time to stop the *anattā* lesson and focus instead on those jeering kids or teachers that have popped up in your imagination to taunt you.

Back to the *anattā* lesson now. What do we mean when we say, "I am"? It easily trots off our lips. I am happy. I am cold. I am an engineer. I am meditating. A step closer to the truth of *anattā* would be to say, "There is a being who is happy, cold, etc., and by some magic this being's experience and life story are known." It's so tempting to add "by me" — to say, "This being's experience and life story are known by me." Let's try to bring this closer to the truth of *anattā*. There is a concept of me, myself, I, who knows this being. Our concepts are a mental construction derived from our perceptions of the world. That's essentially what the self is, according to the Buddha: a mental construction.

Perceptions are the mind's attempts to make sense of all the data it receives. We see a certain pattern of yellow colours and perceive a buttercup. We hear a jangling sound and perceive a doorbell. One teacher likens perception to a mental filing cabinet. Each bit of sensory information is put into its correct file. The ability to perceive helps us

simplify the vast amount of data bombarding our senses each moment. If we didn't have our filing cabinet, the paper would be strewn all over the room. It would be total confusion. We couldn't function.

Babies haven't yet learned to categorise experience in this way, and so have endless fun exploring their little world. Everything is new. As adults, we learn to ignore much of our sense input, as it's so quickly stowed away into its correct file, and we gladly believe that much of it can be labelled as unimportant. The ability to perceive is wonderful. We couldn't negotiate our way through the world without this simplification. But it's important to remember that it's a mental classification, a form of data processing that we do. Our perceptions are not inherent to the world but a construction in our minds.

Our perceptions can be wrong. We've probably all had the experience of mistaking a stranger for a friend because of some trick of the light. For a brief moment we see our friend. We may even stop to say hello. Then the scene changes and a stranger's face comes into view. The incoming data went into the wrong file. We can get quite a shock. Sometimes the opposite happens. Recently I was waiting at a station when my eyes were for some reason attracted towards a strange woman's face and I found myself staring at her. She stared back. It took a second to recognise a friend. We both started giggling. We hadn't been expecting to see one another there and the raw data got misclassified as the perception "stranger."

I had a very striking example of this one time on retreat here at Satipanya when I came into the meditation room. It was the original room before the extension and some of you may remember that Bhante kept the prayer plant on its tall table just beside the side door. The pair are now in the dining room so look out for this misperception if you stray into the dining room at night. The table is draped with a red cloth. There was no one in the shrine room and I crossed over in the semi-darkness and switched on the light by the shrine. As I turned back, eyes downcast, I glimpsed the red cloth brushing the floor and in an instant my mind built up a life-size image of Bhante standing beside the door. In my mind, I saw Bhante, gave a startled jump as I hadn't heard him come in, felt embarrassed at my jumpiness and was about to apologise before I realised I was about to address a pot plant.

Our perceptions are our best attempt to make sense of the world. They're influenced by our memories and expectations. They can be wrong. So it is with the perception of self. It can be wrong. At times it's an appropriate perception. It helps make sense of the

world. This is true in much of our daily lives. This being, I call me, is staying in the library so needs to get herself there at times. If I didn't have an ability to perceive myself as different to others who knows where I would end up.

But this perception is not the ultimate truth, according to the Buddha. There are times where a perception of not-self is more helpful. Take those times when we are avidly watching the flow of sensations and feelings. Then things start to feel sticky. We tighten around pleasant feelings, trying to hold on to them. The flow gets choked up. If we can relax and let go, sensations and feelings flow more easily again. If you look carefully, you will also notice that a sense of self arises when things get sticky and is released when sensations are flowing. This is a teaching on the truth of anattā: that the self arises depending on conditions. The particular condition needed to generate a sense of self is a pleasant or unpleasant feeling we cling to. We try to hold, amplify and prolong the pleasant; we try to get rid of the unpleasant.

If you look closely, the perception of self is associated with the pleasant feeling of control. We love to feel in control. It means we can do what we want. We're the boss. We especially want to feel in control of ourselves, our bodies, emotions, thoughts. We want to be in good humour when we're on holiday. We want to think positive when we're going for interview. We want our bodies to be able to move and function normally. When we can't meet these expectations, we can feel quite threatened.

Our language actually contains a hint of anattā when we describe these times as, "I'm not myself today." "She wasn't like herself at all." "He was beside himself with rage." What's actually happening here? When we look closely we see that when things are going well for us there is a pleasant feeling which we perceive as me and believe to be the control centre for our body, mind and life. When things go badly unpleasant feelings are generated which we push away thinking "this isn't me." We're frightened by the fact that things are going against our wishes and especially when we notice the unpleasant sensations and associated feelings are also manifesting in our bodies. Where is our precious control centre now? If you look carefully you will find it's boxed into the opposition to the way things are. Even though the whole world can look black and scary, there is still a tiny, pleasant feeling of holding onto control. So long as I can say no to what I don't want, I can persuade myself I'm still in control.

In general, the feeling of self accompanies any sense of effort. Any time you feel relatively peaceful in meditation, see whether there is a strong sense of self. Compare that to the times you feel yourself struggling. The hindrances come with a strong sense of self. When I'm struggling with physical pain, I feel my body straining away from the painful area, as if it's trying to divide itself in two: the painful part, sensed as not me,

and the part which pulls away, sensed as me. As I make peace with the pain, that sense of division subsides. Thus, physical pain provides one way for us to explore the truth of anattā.

All this can be very bewildering. Am I here? Am I not here? Do I exist? It can be quite frightening. Our sense of self is very precious and we can feel threatened by thoughts of not-self. We imagine we will be annihilated. The Buddha refused to answer questions of the type, "Do I exist? Do I not exist? Will I exist after death?" Patiently he repeated his insight that the sense of self emerges to fulfil our desires. I think of the sense of self as a psychophysical mechanism that energises and sculpts my mind and body to help me get what I want, get rid of what I don't want.

But when we are resting, when there isn't any enticing food to be found or any threats to cope with, we don't need central coordination. All the cells and organs work away themselves, just as they do in sleep. Unless we experience desire or aversion, no sense of self is formed. At these times, we often have no interest in the question, "Do I exist?" It seems irrelevant. Then something disturbs our peaceful flow, and suddenly we're all hyped up, very sure of our existence.

One reason why we don't easily make peace with anattā is because we don't notice the absence of our sense of self during those peaceful times when there are no strong desires driving us. So we don't take those chances to explore and learn to appreciate the experience and perception not-self. Why don't we notice the experience of not-self? Although the thought of anattā is perplexing and we find it hard to imagine the possibility of existing without a sense of self, ironically the experience of anattā is quite mundane and doesn't attract our attention. The absence of self is not a particularly interesting experience. Our world doesn't fall apart. Our bodies and minds function just fine.

One teacher says that the mind state of not-self is far more prevalent than the mind state of self. It's just that it's so unobtrusive, so ordinary, that we don't notice it. I find it comforting to reflect on that. It helps to alleviate the fear we often feel during the investigation of anattā.

We can also investigate anattā as it shows up in our relationship with others. Normally we locate ourselves within our bodies and other people outside. But these perceptions can dissolve when we take another into our hearts in the practice of *mettā*. Again, we don't usually notice this as the experience does not trouble us. Only trouble calls attention. But it can be interesting to explore this when you feel a friendship. Is there a clear sense of separation between you and the other?

By contrast, the boundary between self and other gets amplified by enmity and hatred. When these surface, my face will often be tightening, my jaws locked. A strong sense of me fuels the tension, clenches my jaws. A mental image of the other person is projected around my head. As I let go of angry thoughts, their image blurs and I'm left with a vague but threatening sense of otherness beyond the borders of my body. The world seems to be divided into me, barricaded into my jaws and face, fiercely opposed to the other occupying the space around.

Nowadays, I use the note, "not me," to describe that sense of otherness. This stills my mind and increases curiosity. What is this entity I'm battling with? My mind pushes against the boundary, demanding to know what is out there. But nothing clarifies and my attention reverts to my body, the breath rising and falling. In time my face and jaws relax and the boundary between me and not me blurs. The space around me, once so threatening, seeps inwards, dissolving the sense of enmity. The image of the other person re-emerges and I begin to see the situation from their point of view. A sense of understanding grows.

Exploring our relationship with others in this way helps us to come to terms with the truth of anattā. Perceptions of self and not-self emerge and dissolve in line with feelings of enmity and friendship.

Whenever we start thinking about anattā, we will often be stimulating a sense of self, as the desire to know and understand the truth is operating. Ironically, this desire leads to a sense of self who needs to understand this truth. So it's quite a challenge to combine reflection on the teaching with experiential investigation. We need patience. We can also bring those emotional reactions into the field of investigation whenever they are stimulated. We might sense anattā in our lack of control over those emotions.

Beware also of judging the sense of self as somehow inferior to the sense of not-self. Time and again the Buddha asks us to look after ourselves wisely, to treasure our human life with its opportunity to free ourselves from suffering. There are many wise desires we should fulfil in order to look after ourselves and practice meditation. The desire to learn the Dharma would be one, and then the multitude of desires involved in putting this into practice. For example, the desire to come on retreat, the desire to get the bus in order to come on retreat, the desire to get out of bed in order to get the bus, etc., etc.

Many of these desires will need some effort to fulfil and a sense of self is conjured up to channel our energies into that effort. That's fine. That's the way the human organism accomplishes things. So a sense of self is nothing to be ashamed of. Ajahn Thanissaro, in his very helpful book on anattā entitled *Selves and Not-Self*, says that sometimes the

perception of self is the wiser one. Sometimes the perception of not-self is the wiser one. He adds that as our practice deepens, we get better at discerning which perception is more appropriate for each situation.

To marshal ourselves for actions we deem as worthy, the sense of self should be encouraged and nourished. We can search for any good feelings associated with thoughts like "I can," "I will," etc., and take delight in these as a little treasure trove to help us enjoy work and get us through any challenges. When we've accomplished our task or feel the need for a rest along the way, we can sit back and invite any dukkha stirred up by the activity to manifest. Sometimes as the struggle with dukkha wanes, we can let the perception of "not me," "not mine" sink in to remind us that we don't always have to be acting and accomplishing, that the world can survive quite well without us, that even we ourselves can survive quite well without anyone at the helm.

I want to finish off tonight by recapping on the first noble truth: that life involves dukkha. The Buddha asks us to fully understand dukkha. We can explore it in three forms. Dukkha-dukkha involves the major suffering of our lives and which we cannot escape. To prepare ourselves for this, we can study dukkha's milder forms. *Anicca-dukkha* manifests especially at beginnings and endings and is even contained within the minutiae. Every breath, footstep and meal present us with a lesson on transience. *Anattā-dukkha* shows up at the limits to our control, at the boundary of me and other, and even within ourselves, as we struggle with sensations and feelings we would prefer not to own.

The exploration of dukkha involves finding our way through the hindrances that block our view of truth. As we make our peace with each hindrance, we also come to terms with the limits to our knowledge and understanding. We feel more at ease in a world which is continually slipping through our fingers, beyond our tiny radius of control.

May we and all beings come to understand dukkha and thereby be liberated from all suffering.

Forgiveness

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 30 min read

Drawing inspiration from the story of Aṅgulimāla, the murderer who achieved Awakening in one lifetime, Bhante Bodhidhamma presents a profound exploration of forgiveness through Buddhist psychology. Using the framework of paṭicca samuppāda (dependent origination), he demonstrates how we create our own suffering through our reactions to harm, whether as victims or perpetrators.

The talk examines the crucial insight that others cannot directly cause our psychological suffering - our pain arises from our own internal reactions and conditioning. Through guided contemplations, Bhante shows how understanding this process becomes the key to liberation. He addresses the role of shame, dread, and remorse as natural guardians that can lead to healing when properly understood.

Central to the teaching is recognizing our fundamental innocence - that all harmful actions stem from the primordial mistake of avijjā (ignorance/nescience) rather than inherent evil. This understanding opens the possibility for complete forgiveness of self and others. Bhante provides practical steps for releasing victim consciousness and perpetrator guilt, emphasizing that true forgiveness doesn't mean forgetting or excusing harm, but rather transforming our relationship to painful experiences through vipassanā practice.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sambha sambuddassa Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sambha sambuddassa Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sambha sambuddassa — Homage to the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

This talk came about because a friend of mine, who's a musician, wanted to write music around the theme of Angulimala, as some of you may know. The story of Angulimala is a murdering thief. But he meets the Buddha and undertakes the training and before he dies becomes fully enlightened. So there's hope for us all. And he wanted me to write something which he could attach his music to. Having done that, I wanted to add something to it to explain the psychology as to how somebody so steeped in evil might arrive at the enlightenment even within this very lifetime. So the first part I'll ask you to do some imaginative work and then we'll do some explanation. And then at the end you can try and have a go at practising forgiving all those people whom you've murdered and forgiving yourself, rather, and forgiving all those people who've done you harm.

Just try this one for size, shall we say. You can close your eyes and just, what I want you to try and do, and just catch the process of your psychology. Just imagine now, if you can think of an actual occasion in your life, that might be even better, but just think of an occasion now where somebody says something which hurts you. It might be just a flippant thing, like you're an idiot or something. So if you can imagine that, and just let the insult come. Now, just catch your reaction. So I wonder what the reaction might have been. Irritation? Anger? Indignation? And what might it lead you to once you've left that person? What might it lead you to? A slander? A knife in the back?

So now just try something else on a similar line. Instead of somebody saying something awful to you, they actually do something to you. Perhaps they push you, or they stick their finger into you, or at worst they bop you on the nose. Can you imagine that? Can you see what your reaction might be? I would suggest it's much the same unless they're much bigger than you then you'd probably get a bit fearful. So the question we have to ask ourselves is did that person cause us suffering? Do you think they were the direct cause of your suffering?

So now turn that one around now and just take somebody whom you're going to insult. It might be the same person of course. So as you just make that scene in your mind, offer them your insult and just see how you feel about that. I would suggest that maybe you feel a little satisfied by it. A job well done. Pleased. Supposing they pushed in front of you in a queue or something. You got rather angry about it and you pushed them out. You used a bit of physical force there. Can you imagine yourself doing that? So I would suggest it's much the same as above, only a little more stronger.

Now take that person and let them come back to you and say that they're really upset and you've seen that you've been the cause of their being upset. Now how do you feel about that? A little remorseful, a bit guilty, shame. Let's take an occasion which is much worse. Supposing you've unfortunately had one or two drinks and you knock somebody over on the road. Now what's your first reaction there? Just play it through your mind. Shock, fear, dread of consequences when other people find out, shame when you realize what you've done to the person, remorse.

That's the end of our little escapade of trying to imagine things, just to get you in touch, as it were, with all those emotions, all those states of mind that revolve around those actions where we're hurting somebody or somebody's hurting us.

So now, if we just take the process of that psychology, what we have, of course, is the Wheel of Dependent Origination. And what the Buddha is teaching us there is that whatever, just taking the first instance, whatever somebody does to us, has to stop at the point of reception, at the point where we perceive something. So if somebody called

me, you know, you fathead, that's not very nice, is it? They call me fathead, so what actually happens is that I've just heard these words, fathead. If somebody, then having heard those words, I take them into myself. I take them into myself and I define them as unpleasant. They are, aren't they? So they're unpleasant. So this person hasn't actually made me think they're unpleasant. I'm just defining them as unpleasant within myself. If I didn't speak English I'd probably smile.

So there's something I've done there whereby I've defined this as unpleasant. Now I've taught myself that when something unpleasant arises I have to get rid of it. I want to push it away. So that's my reaction to something unpleasant and again it's done by me within me because of my past conditioning.

So we can see if we look at our psychology very carefully, the person who's called us fathead hasn't actually caused me to suffer. It's the way I've responded to it. If the person who's just called me fathead is reckoned by everybody just to be a bit loopy, then I wouldn't have that reaction. I'd probably just say, oh, well, they're a bit daft or something.

So everything, all the hurt that I get when somebody insults me or somebody says something cruel to me is my own inner reaction. I can't blame them for making me suffer.

If somebody now pulls my nose, or tugs my ears, or gives me a shove, where does that stop? It stops at the physical body, doesn't it? It stops at a sensation on the body. But then, inwardly, I see what the person's done, I feel what the person's done to me, and again, I define it as unpleasant. Again, I respond to it with irritation, with anger, with hurt. But that's all happening in me as a response to what this person has done. I can't say that this person has made me suffer. They've given me severe sensations on the nose, which I've defined as pain, but pain isn't suffering. Pain as such is just sensation, no matter how severe it is. What makes us suffer, what makes it hard to stay with, is our reaction to it, our inability to be patient with it.

So it's the internal reaction we have to these things which is actually causing us to suffer. So those are your links on this wheel of dependent origination which remember is the Buddha's paradigm as to how we cause suffering for ourselves. How we cause suffering for ourselves.

So now you can widen that out and you begin to recognize that nobody in the world can cause you psychological pain, which is hard to accept because until now we've been very happy blaming everybody else. Parents, society, Tony Blair, all these people have made me suffer. But now when I look into my psychology, I can't say that anymore.

If we now turn it the other way, I now say to somebody, you fathead. Now, the same process is happening within them. I can't say that I've caused them to suffer, but I have to recognize what's happening in me. What's happening in me is that I am developing a conditioning of hate, a conditioning of cruelty. Now I might get immediate satisfaction by watching somebody cringe when I call them you fathead, but inside me I have this turbulence, this desire to be cruel, this desire to get my own back, the hatred within me. And of course the effect of that is that, not surprisingly, people start staying away. They don't hang about. They don't want to talk to me. So my cruelty, my hatred, goes into the world and the world moves away from me. And it causes me to be lonely, and if I don't see that, I then blame others for not being friendly, for not being open-hearted to me, and I begin to hate them the more. I'm in a whirlwind, taking me downwards into a perpetual state of hatred and grumbling and whinging, which can keep you awake.

Worse still, if I actually hit somebody or push somebody, then that's a more violent act. And therefore the inner violence is even worse. So here we have a situation where I think I'm hurting somebody, but in fact I'm only hurting myself.

So you might ask, well, what stops you from hurting somebody anyway? Well, when we've contacted the hurt that I feel when somebody insults me or somebody harms me, then even though I recognize that I'm the cause of it, it's out of compassion for the other that you don't, that you are not the catalyst whereby they cause themselves to suffer. So you begin to take responsibility not to enter into situations, not to confront people in such a way that you know you're just pressing their buttons.

So, the whole psychology around doing harm is always centred on us. We ourselves create an inner turbulence when we do harm, and when somebody does harm to us, it's we that create within us our own suffering.

Now, although that may seem at first to land us in a load of suffering, it's the very fact that we create our own suffering that will allow us to escape it in the end. That's the purpose of meditation. That's the purpose of *vipassanā*. So you can see these mechanisms that are causing us to suffer. And then you realize that you must stop behaving like that, which means that in your daily life you have to maintain that sense of sharp mindfulness, knowing your own habits. Even if you respond in an old way, you don't indulge it. Even though somebody says to you, you fathead, it stays right there at the point of hurt. You're prepared to let the hurt hurt because you know that is your own personal response to such a thing. But you don't allow yourself to begin to fantasize to get your own back.

So if somebody insults you once, as you know, by the end of the day, they've insulted you a thousand times. And the punishment for their insult has got worse. At first, you just shouted at them in your mind. But by the time you go to bed, you're hanging them. You're chucking them out of the window. So remember, it's through the process of thinking and fantasizing that we are developing these states of mind. This is how we develop our states of mind, through fantasy, through this process of thinking. And it's not a great distance between thinking about doing something and actually doing it.

So what the *vipassanā* or the insight meditation is teaching us to do is to stay right there with the hurt, to let the hurt die away. Now, when the hurt dies away, first of all, we're stopping it developing, but more important, we're actually undercutting that old conditioning of being hurt when somebody calls us a name or does something which insults us, but actually going underneath it so that there will come a time when somebody might say something which in the past you would have felt to be hurtful but actually it just stops at the sense door. You just hear the word. There isn't that reaction.

So you can see that taking full responsibility for our inner suffering, using the *vipassanā* to allow things to burn out and to heal, is actually the process of psychotherapy, healing the heart, purifying the heart. That would be impossible to do if you think the other person is making you suffer, in which case you'd have to change everybody in the world because a lot of people go around calling other people fatheads.

So even though it's difficult sometimes for us to recognize that nobody can hurt us, actually, that's our salvation. That's the healing. That's the liberation from suffering. Once we've actually realized that.

With that, there's the other side where we hurt people. So it's recognizing that even though we can't cause somebody to suffer, by actually wanting to hurt people, we're creating a turbulence within our mind, which is suffering, and we're creating a habit which eventually begins to push people away from us. So once we recognize that the serpent bites back, the serpent is biting its own tail, then you realize that that behaviour has to stop.

So again the purpose of the *vipassanā* is to sit with it in silence, to allow it to burn away, but then we have to maintain that sense of sharp mindfulness in daily life so that we don't fall into those old habits. And what we discover is that very slowly, over a period of time, those habits of trying to do harm to everybody just fade away. And the opposite, of course, takes its place. Nature abhors a vacuum. We're talking here about transformation. So where there was cruelty, now there's compassion. Where there's hate, now there's love. There's openness. There's open-heartedness. Warm-heartedness.

Just as a little aside, just talking about these things that we suffer. So for instance, we have within us a mechanism that decides whether something is good or bad, skilful or unskilful. We call it our conscience. Now, just because our conscience which is the judge, remember judging us, just because our conscience says something is wrong or something is bad doesn't mean to say we have to accept it, because sometimes this judge is a tyrant, sometimes the conscience is too tight and it creates a life of dread, creates a life of unnecessary shame. On the other hand this conscience can sometimes be very loose so that we don't feel appropriate shame, appropriate dread when we do things. So we haven't got to trust our conscience. There has to be reflection about it and talking to other people whom you trust so that there's a balance in the mind knowing what is good, what is bad, at a basic moral level, but remember that at a more refined level, it's what's skilful and unskilful. And when the Buddha talks about what is skilful and unskilful, he's always talking about that which leads to the liberation and that which leads to suffering.

Those two emotions that we feel, dread and shame. Shame is that feeling of loss of self-esteem we haven't lived up to our own standards, that's why we blush, and dread is the fear of consequences, the fear of consequences.

Now when we do something harmful and we feel shame and dread, in a sense that is not to be seen as a punishment. That's how people would look upon it. It's not to be seen as a punishment, but as warnings. When we accept the factors of shame and dread, and they become part and parcel of our psychology, they prevent us from doing things. Because as soon as you think, well, I'll do that, there comes just that little bite of shame, just that little bite of dread, and it stops you. And it's when shame and dread are behaving like this that the Buddha calls them guardians of society.

You can see from the way, for instance, a lot of the youth behave, that the line they draw about shame and dread is pretty low. They can do certain things which they're not ashamed of, nor do they dread any consequence. So you can see that once these reactions are lowered, you're going to get behaviour which is unsociable. When there's no shame and dread there, then we're talking about psychopaths, we're talking about sociopaths. It's an actual psychological disease.

Remorse, on the other side, is suddenly feeling that compunction, that desire to be rid of all the guilt and the shame and to want to be reconciled with the person whom you've hurt or indeed who's hurt you. So remorse is a natural feeling which comes after we accept that we've done wrong. And in our meditation, we have to sit with that. If

you try and block it out, you'll just harden your heart. You must respond to that desire to be reconciled. To go to the person, if necessary. But in some way, that remorse has to be answered.

And it's going through that cycle of guilt, shame, feeling bad about oneself, fearful of consequences, feeling remorse, and bringing that remorse to an end by reconciliation, that there's not only a process of healing at that particular event, but also undermining that whole conditioning. So eventually we don't get ourselves into those corners.

Now what helps us is that our conditioning is always fairly much the same. This is what we mean by *kamma*. We're always doing the same thing. We're always making the same mistake. If you look back on your life, you'll always see that there's a trait within us which is always popping up, given the occasion it comes up. And it's catching that right before it comes up and letting it go, not responding to it, that undermines that whole trait. And why do we do it? Because we've recognised it leads nowhere but to suffering, to our discomfort.

So now we have to go a little deeper because, in a sense, that tells us how we cause ourselves to suffer, and it tells us how to get rid of it. But the next point on the wheel of dependent origination to investigate is that whole point at the beginning of it, which is *avijjā*. Now, *avijjā* is translated as ignorance. That's how it's normally translated. But in English, ignorance has a feeling of stupidity about it. But that's not really the meaning. The meaning, I came across this word, nescience, which fits it more beautifully. And nescience just means don't know. I just don't know.

Now, in the Buddha's understanding, when consciousness arises, it arises from a base of don't know. And it moves into this body and mind, body mind and heart, and it simply presumes this is what it is. Therefore you form eventually a concept of yourself. I am who I am. I'm here. I'm my personality, my character. I'm my body. I'm my emotions. That little mistake is actually the fundamental cause for all the bit that we've just discussed.

Now if we go back on that and we recognize that right at the very beginning there's been a mistake, it was a mistake, that if it weren't for that mistake we would never have done any harm, then you begin to understand that at fundament we're innocent. It's only because of a mistake, not because of something culpable, not because of something blameworthy. We just made a mistake.

Now, I'll give you an example of that just from one of my experiences when I was in Sri Lanka. They had these very nasty little flies called Ohopatua. They're just little gnats, they fly in the air, and they have a nasty habit of biting you and leaving you with a very

itchy pimple for about three days. And sometimes they even can creep through a mosquito net. So here I am with these little pimples and scratching them, and I'm wondering what to do, and I suddenly realize that a spider has built a web in the hut. So I say to myself, that's it, I've got to get spiders in and that'll get rid of them. So I have little signs up saying, this way please. Well, within a few days, there were hundreds of them. They were everywhere, all around the room. And I thought, well, this is really crazy. And it was getting to a point where I was so bitten and miserable that I decided I've just got to leave. I've got to go up country somewhere. Just get out of these flies.

Happily, just at that time, a friend of mine, a Canadian monk came and I told him, looking really grim that this was it. And I showed him my pimples and I said, look at this. And he looked around and he said, these spiders webs, don't you get rid of spiders, the webs out of your room? I said, no. He said, well, they breed on those.

So here's a wonderful occasion where innocent ignorance leads me into suffering. Now, at fundament, that's all the Buddha's saying. All he's saying is that we've made a mistake. We're never meant to do any harm. And so at fundament, we are innocent. If we weren't, if it was actually part of our essential nature not to be innocent, then how could we ever become enlightened?

Just one reflection on existential guilt. This really refers to people who have been brought up in Christianity or a religion which has a god. Because according to those religions, we are born evil. In Buddhism, evil and all that is a secondary thing, which means that Western people can suffer from what you might call an existential guilt. In other words, they feel themselves to be essentially evil. In so doing, you can see the necessity of having someone to intercede, somebody who can save, can take away that essential evil, and thereby find some reconciliation with God.

Now, if you're a Westerner and you're brought up on that, then that will probably be somewhere in your psyche. So that also has to be suffered and allowed to pass away. And sometimes that goes very deep. And when you couple it with the idea of eternal damnation, then that's bad news. So what we have to do is go underneath that and really accept those sorts of feelings. And they can be extraordinarily nasty, like fear, and dread and all that. But you have to stay there, you have to feel it, you have to investigate it and recognize your reaction to it, which is of course that we don't want to feel that. And eventually as that evaporates, that essential innocence arises.

Now, there is a movement in Christianity where they don't talk about original sin. Most of you will know the myth of Adam and Eve in the Garden of Eden. But you'll also find that there are movements in Christianity that, instead of talking about that, talk about the original blessing. In other words, the fact was that Adam and Eve were born in innocent happiness. So in that sense they come closer to a Buddhist understanding.

So there is an end to guilt, there is an end to shame, and there is therefore an end to forgiveness.

Just two things that always come up whenever I discuss this. First of all, why is it that some people get away with it? I mean, they seem to die. I mean, take Stalin, for instance. He died fairly happily in bed, having murdered 40 million people. And it seems to have got everything he wanted, although he must have been in a dreadful state of mind in a way, because he only worked at night and I think on one trip he had five trains going, all giving the impression that he was on one of them, constantly in dread of being assassinated. But take that to one side and just say, well, some people seem to get away with it.

Well, here, of course, we have to open towards the acceptance of the idea of rebirth, the idea that perhaps this isn't the only life we've ever lived, and it's not the only life we're going to live, and that there is some sort of justice in the process of the world in which individual consciousnesses work their way up towards the enlightenment through a process of being born and being reborn.

However, if a person finds that difficult to accept, it's not actually necessary in order to get the benefits of the psychology that we've just been explaining, because the benefits of that are immediate. Through the practice of insight meditation, to seeing that we cause ourselves suffering, and to see that we cause ourselves suffering when we cause others, when we press other people's buttons, is immediate. We immediately stop behaving in certain ways and we feel happier for it. But in a cosmic sense, this was one of the insights of the Buddha. It was part of his enlightenment, when he saw that people were dying and going elsewhere, and that a great deal of the reason for their going where they were going was because of their bodily behaviour, which creates these dispositions within us.

And finally, there's a real difficult one, which is very hard for people to accept, who haven't come across this psychology before. And that's, of course, the suffering of innocence, especially the suffering of a child. But it is the same. It is the same psychology. What is horrific to us about a child's situation is of course its absolute vulnerability and its inability through language or conceptual reasoning to find any distance or objectivity to the suffering that it's undergoing. But still, the child ends up with a trauma and in

a sense the rest of its life is working out that psychological trauma within itself. And it's very rare, I think, for a person not to have a childhood trauma somewhere. These childhood traumas are not only caused by people who actually mean to do them harm. The very process of birth is a trauma, for heaven's sake.

So, the suffering in the child follows the same psychology, and that's why eventually, as adults, we can empty ourselves of this suffering.

Now, for the person who harms a child, well, now that's something else, because they have to now bear the awful responsibility for that child's suffering. They might not be the direct cause of that suffering, but they were the catalyst that caused it. And just to give you two wonderful examples that bring that home to us, the Moors murderer, Brady, was asked if he ever thought about the child victims that he tortured and murdered up here just in Lancashire. And he said, if I did that, it would drive me mad.

Now, some of you may have come across a book called *The Man Who Mistook His Wife for a Hat*. It's written by a psychologist called Oliver Sacks. And he's interested in brain damage and the way people are. The particular title refers to a man who couldn't distinguish objects. And as he was leaving the office after a talk, he simply grabbed his wife's head, thinking it was his hat.

In that same book there's a very interesting tale which definitely says something to Buddhists. There's a man who murders his daughter in such a vicious way that the facts of the case are not brought out in public in the court, they're just too horrific. This man could not remember a thing. So eventually they had to convict him as insane and they sent him to a secure prison for the mentally insane. This is in America. So they couldn't convict him as a straight criminal. While he was there he acted seemingly quite normal and within a few years the staff had such confidence in him that they let him go out on bicycle rides. On one of these bicycle rides, a car hit him and he fell over and banged his head on the road. This had the effect of awakening, when he woke up from the concussion, of awakening in him what he'd actually done. And so the story goes, it took six months for the staff to restrain and stop him from committing suicide.

So eventually the harm that we do catches up on us and to harm innocence would leave us with an enormous sense of guilt and remorse.

So now we come to, well I'll just give you a final reflection on that concerning harm. There's a very famous simile of the saw which the Buddha gives. And he says, oh monks, even if bandits were to sever you savagely, limb by limb with a two-handed saw, he who gave rise to hatred towards them would not be carrying out my teaching. That's heavy, isn't it?

So now what I'd like to do is ask you to do another contemplation exercise. And the first one is, how do we free ourselves from a victim's suffering? So from the suffering that we feel when we've been victimized or when we've been a victim. And the second one is, how do we liberate ourselves from the suffering of being a victimizer? So I just want to go through these steps and you can close your eyes and just go through them. And then you'll get an idea of how it might work for you.

So the first one is how to let go of the suffering we feel when we've been hurt. So the first thing to recognize is that to forgive is not to forget. You have to be very careful. If you try and forget the hurt that's been given to you, then all you're doing is suppressing it and it's just working underground and it works as grudges and it just sabotages our lives. When we forgive somebody, we're not excusing them either. And sometimes we feel that if we forgive somebody, somehow in a secret way we're condoning what they're doing. So that's not forgiveness either. Forgiveness is just a change of attitude, a letting go of that hurt, letting go of revenge, and establishing within us that sense of compassion and forgiveness towards the person.

So the first thing, if you now take somebody who's hurt you, it can be somebody real, but not the big one. The first thing you have to recognize is that there's no need for us to punish them. They themselves will suffer the consequences of their own actions. That's the karmic law. So there's no need for us to seek revenge. And a Chinese proverb warns us, those who seek revenge should dig two graves.

The second thing is to remind ourselves that that person originally has made a mistake. It's by way of delusion that they've come to behave in this unskillful way. That fundamentally they are actually innocent and they didn't mean to do any harm. Sometimes it's good to have a dialogue with the person in your mind. Having done that, having corrected our relationship to that person, we can then turn inward.

And just get in contact with the hurt we feel. You can run through the occasion. You can bring up the occasion when you were hurt. Now here you've got to be very careful not to be taken away by fantasy. So you've got to keep that attention as much as you can right at the physical base. The feelings around hurt. The anger that may still come up. The desire for revenge. Try and stay as close as you can to the body, to sensation, to feeling.

Now as those feelings begin to decrease, the next step would be to contemplate the other person's better nature. When all the hurt and the desire for revenge begins to decrease you can then begin to reform your relationship to that person. Try and see their

better nature. Give them the benefit of the doubt. Send them good wishes from the heart. And if that's too difficult, well at least an attitude of no harm. That's the base, isn't it? No harm.

So that sets our right relationship with the person, right attitude. Now, in the future, we can resolve not to approach that person concerning this occasion unless we're absolutely equanimous, which means we have to wait for the right time. And then when we decide that we are going to approach them, to almost talk as if you're a mediator. You'll be very careful not to put blame, not to lay it on them, but just to be clear about the feelings we felt. We have to take responsibility for our part in the incident. Takes two to tango. And the next thing is not to expect an apology. That's a presumption on our part. If they do so, well, of course, it's very healing. But it's not important to us that they should express an apology. The healing comes by this inner process.

Now sometimes of course we can't do anything because the person's moved on or they may have died. So we have to work with this process of reconciliation inward. Until all the emotional pain around the memory is just slowly drained away. Don't solidify around it, don't get hard around it, just see it as a process. You can often just sit with an emotion and just say gently, not me, not mine. It's there, I'm looking at it. I'm experiencing it, so I can't be it.

So that's one way that you might try in the future to deal with suffering which comes because somebody has victimized you.

If we now go to the other side and consider some of the suffering that we've been a catalyst to in other people, where we've been the victimizer, then it might be a good start to just reflect on the fact that we are fundamentally deluded, that we've acted primordially out of a mistake, and that we are fundamentally innocent and therefore utter forgiveness of ourselves by ourselves is possible. Then we have to convince ourselves that of course we do have a responsibility. We did play a role in causing that person harm, we were a catalyst. A catalyst in chemistry is something which causes a change, causes a change between two chemicals, but itself doesn't change. So the word I might have said to somebody doesn't change, or it just hits the same space, but it creates within the other a whole sequence of psychological events that causes them suffering. We have to take responsibility for that. Sometimes we know how to press somebody's buttons too. We enjoy doing it. But when we do this we have to be careful not to take on false guilt. We're taking on false guilt if we take on their personal suffering.

So now we make resolutions not to do that again. So I was very careful about resolutions because you know the old phrase that the path to hell is paved with good resolutions. So it has to be realistic. These behaviour patterns are deeply ingrained. They've

come to us over a long time. So we shouldn't be surprised if we keep making the mistake over and over again. So we have to accept that this process is going to be repeated and repeated and repeated. And what we're hoping is that given a length of time, the behaviour lessens, eventually dies away. But we still have to make these resolutions, these determinations. And that determination has to be one of being really awake, really mindful. The alarm bell should go off whenever we enter a situation where we know we normally do something stupid, something silly, something unskillful.

Then there's the usual business of sitting with the remorse, the shame, the guilt which is in our hearts. So that's part of the process of *vipassanā* insight meditation. We can do that. And we can watch them as a process. We can see that if we push guilt away, push shame away, or push remorse away, that causes us more suffering. So there we're catching this process of how we cause ourselves to suffer. We can so distance ourselves from those emotions within us that they become very objective. There's shame. There's the feelings of shame. There's the feelings of guilt. And just watch them as a process. Don't get involved by way of identity or possessing them. They're not me, not mine. These are the things that insight meditation teaches us.

Two of our most powerful reasons for hurting people is jealousy and hatred. All forms of hatred. So jealousy isn't just a simple covetousness. It's not just wanting what the other person has. It's wanting what the other person has and hating them for having it. So the antidote to that is having sat with that for a while to begin to rejoice in the other person's good fortune. This is what we mean by sympathetic joy. And that's a contemplation. When somebody wins the lottery, you rejoice for them. You're happy that a bit of the pound you spent went to their fortune. When your friend who went with you for the same job gets the job, you rejoice for them. This undermines jealousy.

Hatred is undermined by seeing the other person in a different light. As we said before, to actually bring to mind their good qualities, so there's a balance of attitude towards them. And then finally, if it's possible, to meet with the person and express our remorse, express our sorrow. In the *Visuddhimagga* it also suggests that we offer them a gift when it's appropriate.

Now supposing at work you'd had a bit of an upset with somebody and you'd gone through this exercise, when you go to work and you're walking through that door of a corridor and they see you at the end of it. Our ability to tell where people are at is very refined. We know from a person's body language, we know from what's on their face, even at quite a distance, whether they're friend or foe. And this person may be feeling themselves still hardened by what they did, or they may feel remorse themselves, or they may feel a desire to be reconciled rather. Just by having that attitude, it'll show on

our face, it'll show on the way that we walk. So that they know there's a desire in us to be reconciled. So these things are really very important preparatory exercises, so that when we actually meet up with people whom we've hurt, they're open to our apology.

Now the fact is that, generally speaking, unless they've been fortunate enough to come to the Buddha's teaching about pain, they will definitely blame you for

Foundations for Mindfulness (Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta) - read by Finola O'Siochru

Noirin Sheahan · 50 min

In this teaching, Noirin Sheahan presents the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10), described as "the jewel of all the Buddha's teachings." This discourse reveals how to observe our experience directly to gain the insights that lead to awakening, offering what's called the "direct approach" compared to the "indirect approach" of samatha meditation.

Noirin guides us through the four "pastures" where the mind can graze for wisdom: body (kāya), feeling (vedanā), mind (citta), and dhamma. Each foundation offers specific exercises from breath awareness and posture contemplation to the four elements meditation and contemplation of death. The teaching emphasizes the threefold approach within each foundation: focused attention for calming, investigation of transience (anicca), and bare awareness.

Addressed originally to laypeople, this sutta demonstrates that the profound insights necessary for liberation are accessible even amid busy daily life. Noirin skillfully weaves together the seven factors of awakening (bojjhaṅga) and dependent origination (paṭicca samuppāda) to show how mindful investigation can interrupt the cycle leading to dukkha. The teaching concludes with the Buddha's promise that seven days of sincere practice according to these foundations can bring deep insight, perhaps even full liberation.

Tonight I want to talk about the four foundations for mindfulness. In Pali this is the *Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta*. *Sutta* means a teaching or a discourse and the *Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta* is considered the jewel of all the Buddha's teachings.

For the past few days we've been focusing on the Four Noble Truths. These describe the insights the Buddha discovered on his way to enlightenment. The *Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta* tells us how to observe our experience in order to come to these very insights. It's the how-to of the Dhamma.

It's often called the direct approach, by comparison to the indirect approach of *samatha* meditation, which includes an extra step, generating a deep state of concentration and peacefulness. The meditation described in the *Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta* is termed *vipassanā*, while the deeply peaceful states are termed *samatha jhāna*. In this teaching, the Buddha clarifies that we do not need to attain the *samatha jhāna* in order to have the insights necessary for liberation.

This is really good news for lay people because the samatha jhāna are best supported in secluded monastic conditions. By comparison, vipassanā is possible even when we are living a busy life. Perhaps to emphasize this, the Buddha addressed the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta, the jewel of his teachings, to lay people. It was given when he visited the town of Kammāsadamma and was impressed by how diligently the native Kuru people were practicing mindfulness in their ordinary daily lives. Although the Buddha refers to the meditator as a *bhikkhu*, which nowadays only refers to an ordained monk, it originally referred to anyone who practiced the Dhamma.

Let's look for a moment at the word *satipaṭṭhāna*. The Pali word *sati* means mindfulness. The word *paṭṭhāna* is usually translated as foundation, but I like an alternative that Joseph Goldstein suggests: pasture. It evokes a pleasant image of the mind grazing in various pastures. This suggests restfulness, but also engagement. The mind isn't idly sunbathing in the pastures. It is finding and taking nourishment in each. Our journey to enlightenment involves nibbling and digesting the insights on offer when attention dwells in these pastures.

Think of a rural landscape with gently undulating ground. Our mind can rove around here and there, exploring all its little nooks and crannies, its bright patches and its shady copses. There are mucky patches too, and marshes and rocky cliffs and perhaps thickets of briars. Our job is to get to know them all.

Here and there in tonight's talk, I'm going to dovetail this teaching with that on the seven factors of enlightenment and with the wheel of dependent origination. So just a quick recap. The wheel describes the twelve-step process leading from ignorance to *dukkha*. The gardening image is a helpful way to remember the wheel, all the problems starting with the whirlwind of ignorance, carrying in seeds of *saṅkhāra*, which can then implant themselves and grow up to become a bed of weeds, which are themselves decaying and dying when we come to our final step of *dukkha*.

The seven factors are the beautiful qualities we develop in meditation. Remember our wild geese? These give an image for the seven factors. Mindfulness is in the lead supported by two flanks. There is a wide flank eager to push ahead and a slipstream flank calming everything down. If you want to put all three images together, think of our job in meditation being to get those wild geese into our pastures to nibble away at the seedlings before they grow into a thicket of briars and thistles.

Before describing each of the pastures, the Buddha describes the attitude needed for vipassanā. First, we need to be ardent. This indicates a degree of fervour. We speak of an ardent lover. We won't gain insight if we are cynical or offhand in our approach. We need to put our hearts into the practice.

The next phrase can be translated as mindful with clear comprehension. This corresponds with the factor of investigation in our seven factors. The phrase "ardent, mindful with clear comprehension" signifies mindfulness supported by the wide energetic flank of our wild geese.

The final phrase is: "Having put aside covetousness and grief with regard to the world." Thus we need to let our worldly cares take a back seat for the purpose of practicing vipassanā. This doesn't mean we suppress our cares. It means we let them become our focus for meditation whenever they show up. When grief shows up, we know we are grieving. Letting our worldly cares be examined like this helps focus the mind and cultivates calm and equanimity. So here we have the other flank of our wild geese, the slipstream.

The four pastures are body, feeling, mind and dhamma. It's interesting that the Buddha doesn't list these as four nouns as I've just done. Lists of nouns tend to objectify and simplify the world. The way the Buddha puts it tends to draw the world into our inner experience. He describes them within the meditation practice itself. "A bhikkhu abides contemplating the body as a body, ardent, fully aware and mindful, having put aside covetousness and grief with regard to the world. He abides contemplating feelings as feelings," and so on for all four.

Burying the noun within his description of the attitude needed for vipassanā suggests that the type of attention we bring into the posture matters as much, if not more, than the posture itself. The phrases "contemplating the body as a body, feelings as feelings," etc. are also striking. This indicates our attention needs to sink into these four areas to glean the wisdom offered by their contemplation. It is only by experiencing them mindfully with clear comprehension that they can deliver us from suffering.

The sutta then goes on to describe how to practice within each of the pastures. The section on body contemplation starts with the breath, knowing when we are breathing in and when we're breathing out, knowing when our breath is shallow and when it's deep. The next steps describe calming ourselves using the breath by bringing the thought of tranquility to mind as we feel the breath rise and fall. Remember, we talked of the need to calm ourselves whenever the wide flank of our wild geese are rushing ahead and tending to scatter the flock. So here is the Buddha's suggestion for doing just that: noting, calming, calming with each breath.

The next section is described as a refrain because it was repeated again and again throughout the sutta. It describes the various ways insight can arise. By insight, we mean a glimpse of some aspect of the Buddha's teaching, for example, the Four Noble Truths.

It may be an insight into the first truth, dukkha. We may really feel the changing nature of experience, that all experience is passing away like grains of sand slipping through our fingers, and sense that nothing lasts long enough to satisfy our deep needs for security.

Or we may get a glimpse of the second truth, that desire is the cause of dukkha. Suppose a memory of some argument has come up and we are embroiled in indignation and anger, insisting over and over again that we were right and the others were wrong. Every few moments we wake up to what's happening and feel the pain of this experience. Eventually, worn out and in despair, we give up the battle. Lo and behold, the pain disappears. We realise that clinging to the notion, "I was right," was what was causing us to suffer. It wasn't the memory, it was our reaction to it. That's a direct experience of the second noble truth.

A revolutionary thought surfaces. Maybe it doesn't matter much which of us was right or wrong. That moment when the pain disappeared was also an insight into the third noble truth, the fact that dukkha stops. We need to sensitise ourselves to those lulls in our emotional storms, to start taking them seriously. Until we're fully enlightened, dukkha will eventually start up again, perhaps as we start craving that this moment of peacefulness will go on forever. Sad, isn't it? We have to let peacefulness come and go, just as it will. Paradoxically, when we can surrender to that sad fact, we experience deeper peace.

At another time, we may get a glimpse of some aspect of the fourth noble truth. For example, we may be worrying that we're not meditating correctly, feeling nervous and constricted, as if we're going to get thrown out of the dhamma hall any moment. Then, miraculously it might seem, something changes and we decide, "I'm doing okay, this is good enough." Our hearts lighten, we stop worrying. Our attention sinks more easily into our breath and we sense the joy of simply being present, breathing.

In that moment we gain confidence that meditation could show us a way towards the end of suffering and we can see the importance of right attitude. When we were worrying and condemning ourselves, we were caught up in the hindrance of aversion. When we said, "This will do," we were accepting our experience. That's the only thing that changed. This gives us a direct insight into the fact that an accepting attitude is integral to the path.

These are some examples of insights that can happen as we meditate. These insights can happen while we are following any of the exercises described in the sutta. The refrain tells us what to do in order to deepen our insight. There are three subdivisions to the refrain.

Firstly, the Buddha says, "In this way he abides, contemplating the body as a body internally." Contemplation requires full awareness and understanding. We're not just vaguely aware of breathing. The Mahāsi noting of the in-breath and out-breath gathers our mind in this way, calming us down and focusing our attention on the experience of breathing. This first section of the refrain reassures us that gathering the mind and calming ourselves is an integral part of gaining insight. We don't have to be calm and focused for insight. They can be sinking in as we are using the breath to encourage ourselves to calm down.

He then says we can practice in this same way, but externally. The most common interpretation for this is that we contemplate the breathing of another person. It would take very deep concentration to be able to discern when another person is breathing in or out, a much more challenging practice, which may be why it's so rarely taught. The next suggestion is even more challenging, to contemplate the body both internally and externally, following our own breath and that of another simultaneously—maybe in our next lifetimes.

Although I won't labour the point, it's worth knowing that he repeats this suggestion for all other exercises in the sutta, so we can gain insight by bringing awareness to the feelings of others, as well as to their mind states, for example. Although it would take supernormal powers to be able to directly intuit the feelings and minds of another person, it fosters *mettā* to make any attempt in that direction.

For the purposes of this retreat, we'll confine ourselves to our internal pastures. But outside of retreat, we can practice becoming more aware of others in this moment-to-moment fashion. Following their breathing, if we can detect it, their walking, their postures, daily activities and all the other exercises in the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta that we'll go through now. This is a deep form of *mettā* practice. We have the Buddha's assurance that this is also a perfectly valid form of insight meditation.

So that's the first of the three suggestions in the refrain: to bring our full awareness and understanding to the breathing process. The second suggestion directs our attention to the transitory nature of bodily experience. Each breath arises and passes away and within that each sensation of breathing arises and passes away. He describes this as the arising and vanishing nature of the body.

He first directs our attention to its arising nature. Can you sense the breath coming into being each moment? The in-breath is particularly useful here. Can you feel its first manifestation and how it then continues to swell the body?

Next he directs attention to what he terms "the body in its nature of vanishing." One breath vanishes before the next one can appear. The out-breath is most helpful here, following its movement moment after moment until it stops. His next suggestion is to be aware of both the arising and passing nature of the body. Here we sense the full breath, in and out, as a flow of discrete sensations. As one vanishes, the next arises.

These three exercises help us to see the truth of *anicca*, transience. Although our minds project continuity and permanence into the world, the experiential truth is that things are constantly changing. They arise and a moment later they vanish. We can nudge our minds towards this truth by experiencing the breath arising and passing as the Buddha suggests in the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta.

His final suggestion for insight is simply to be aware of our bodies. In the Buddha's words, "Mindfulness that there is a body is simply established in him to the extent necessary for bare knowledge and mindfulness." This suggests a very light touch, bare knowledge. It's quite a contrast to the first suggestion, to abide contemplating the body as a body, which suggests more energetic gathering of our powers of attention and understanding.

So, we have the three suggestions for gaining insight. The first involves calming and focusing the mind on the body. The second explores its transitory nature. The third simply requires bare knowledge of the body.

The first describes the active effort we need to make to calm ourselves and steady attention within the felt sense of breathing. Here we're working on the slipstream flank of our wild geese. Once we're settled, we can afford to open our minds to be more exploratory. So this is where his second suggestion comes in. We explore the transitory nature of experience. This is the particular expertise of our wide flank, the ones that push us ahead.

At times our minds come to a point of delicate balance and we sense mindful investigation carrying on of its own accord. We sense any attempt we make to either calm or probe more deeply as slightly disturbing. So we can refrain from any effort. At this stage, the third suggestion, bare attention, comes into play.

At times this exploration pulls us towards a deep state of peace. Sometimes it's the opposite. We get fearful and all kinds of underlying emotions come to the surface. In both cases the third suggestion of bare knowledge can be applied. Take the emotional storm. This can batter us with wild thoughts and painful feelings. But so long as we're aware of a body that exists in the midst of it all, we're still on the direct path to enlightenment. We're in the pasture and our intelligence is open to insight even in the midst of

a hurricane of anger or lust. We're not doing any deep investigation. It's just the lightest touch of body awareness. The geese are flapping around at a great rate, devouring the weeds.

Bare knowledge of the body also grounds us when the mind is being drawn towards the calm of a *jhāna*. In these states, we can lose touch altogether with our bodily sensations. The danger is that we also lose any degree of intelligence. If we have to keep remembering our physical nature, we would be bringing wisdom into the realm of *jhāna*. Our slipstream geese are lulling us to sleep, but the wide flank have just enough energy to keep prodding us awake.

So no matter what aspect of the four pastures you are examining, you always have three choices for how to attend. You can calm and gather your attention by focusing on any of the exercises suggested in the sutta. When your attention is steady, you can examine the transitory nature of your experience. The final option, bare attention, applies when there is that knife edge of balance between calm and curiosity. It grounds you through temptations to drift into an emotion or *jhāna* state.

The Buddha's final comment in the refrain is that he abides independent, not clinging to anything in the world. This is a reminder not to identify with whatever it is we are experiencing. Remember it's all going to change. If we cling to joy, calm or clarity, we will later be screaming with frustration when these are so unfairly taken from us. If we resist states like confusion and agitation, we unwittingly prolong them. In contrast, relaxing into them shows us that they also are composed of sensations and feelings which simply arise and pass away, nothing to be worried about, just another hillock in our pasture. All states can deliver the insight we need for liberation.

So that's the refrain. The various suggestions for how we look at our experience. The sutta then goes back to describing what it is we look at. First, we had the breath. The Buddha next goes on to describe four bodily postures as foundations for mindfulness: standing, sitting, walking or lying down.

The next section describes more broad-based mindfulness. Being fully aware when we are looking about, moving around, eating, drinking, talking, keeping silent, even defecating and urinating are included. This covers all of our daily life. After both sections the refrain is repeated in full. We might have an insight as we're sitting on the loo.

The next section involves the use of thought or mental images. We bring to mind the various parts of the body: hair on the head, body hair, nails, teeth, skin and all the way through the major organs and down to spittle, snot, oil of the joints and urine.

We don't often dwell on the separate parts of the body. The exercise can stir disgust or fear. But of course these can be experienced mindfully as a means of purifying our relationship with our bodies. We lose some level of deluded identification with our physical body as we go through this contemplation. Disgust changes to humble appreciation as we realise that our path to liberation depends on entities like snot, spittle, oil of the joints and urine as they do their quiet work to keep us alive.

The next section is more appealing, contemplating the body in terms of the four elements: earth, water, air and fire. While the previous exercise involves the faculty of thought and imagination, this exercise involves physical experience. The earth element describes the experiences of hardness, softness, weight and pressure. For example, try this exercise just now. Gently squeeze one hand within the other. Can you feel areas of bony hardness and fleshy softness? Squeeze more tightly. Can you feel the pressure? Try lifting one hand in the other. Can you feel its weight? All these are explorations of the earth element in your body.

The water element is easier to experience externally as you're washing the dishes, for example, or taking a shower. Feel the way it flows around you, always changing its course to suit your shape. It can also be sensed as the fluidity in the movement of joints. Try rotating your wrist. Can you sense the fluidity required for this? Rotate your shoulders. It couldn't happen if the bones weren't separated by layer of fluid.

The air element is sensed in movement. Gently move your hands or arms now. How do you sense movement? Isn't it very subtle? As light as air. You can explore this during walking meditation, especially when the foot is moving forward.

The last of the elements is fire, which describes our sense of temperature. This includes both heat and coolness. Scan your body now to see if any areas feel warm. Try putting your hands on your face. Often there's a difference in temperature and so we feel both warmth and coolness. It can be hard to work out which part is cool and which is warm. Whenever you go outdoors, see can you sense any change in temperature. I find the exercise on the elements helps my attention to dwell on the body for longer periods.

By contrast, the next exercise is more likely to shoot my attention outwards into clouds of thought. This is the contemplation on death. In the Buddha's time, human bodies were left to decay in open areas called charnel grounds. He asked his followers to go there and watch the process of decay. Although this sounds horrific, the purpose is to meet our fear of death and come to terms with our mortality. We can practice this contemplation on death by reminding ourselves that our bodies too will fall ill, grow old and eventually die. If we can bear mindfully with any emotional responses, we may

eventually come round to a deeper appreciation for the body in its present live and functional state, and a determination to make the best of this short stay on earth that we have been offered.

After each of these exercises, the Buddha repeats the refrain, emphasizing that insight can be gained as we do any of these. This brings to an end the section on the body. All of these exercises in this first foundation require that attention rest at the point of sense contact in the wheel of dependent origination, in this case involving sense contact from seeing, hearing, tasting, smelling and touching. Sense contact, the midpoint of the wheel, is where our inner world, our potential, finds an outlet to explore and perhaps express itself in the outer world. If we can ground ourselves at sense contact, the wheel can't turn all the way to *dukkha*. Our wild geese are pecking at the weeds the moment they show their head above ground.

The Buddha then goes on to describe the next foundation for mindfulness: feeling, which, as you may remember, is the next link in the wheel of dependent origination. Once our senses have made contact, we then categorise the sensation as pleasant, unpleasant or neutral. In Buddhism, that basic categorisation is what we mean by feeling. When the mind is tending to wander easily, it is often helpful to ask what feeling is fueling these thoughts. This can draw us towards the root of the problem, as it is our reaction to feeling that drives the wheel to the wandering mind and thereby to *dukkha*.

Often there will be a zone of tension in the body corresponding to the attempt to cling to pleasure or get rid of unpleasant feelings. The emotion underlying the thoughts has its root here. If we can bring attention to that area of the body, we get a sense of ourselves clinging to some feeling at the centre of the knot. At that stage, our thoughts often quieten down.

However, this is not an easy process. Feeling is a more subtle level of experience than sense contact. We need a degree of calm and equanimity to be able to steady the mind on feelings. So have patience with this foundation. Coming back to our wild geese, when emotions run deep, the wild flank tends to go a bit wild when I turn attention on feelings. So it needs constant rebalancing. The body is a great help here. Coming back again and again to the sensations of breath or of posture takes the heat out of the situation. Slowly, slowly, catchy monkey.

After some perseverance, attention may be able to rest in or near the physical sensations associated with the emotion and be able to detect their pleasantness and the tendency to grasp onto this, or their unpleasantness and the tendency to push these away. The third category of feeling, neutral feeling, won't be at the core of emotional tension. We don't try to grasp or push away neutral feeling. The habitual reaction is to ignore it.

We're working with neutral feelings when we're persuading our attention to rest on the breath and the footsteps. Our difficulty in holding attention steady is not that we dislike or are enthralled by the physical sensations, but that we want a more exciting focus.

Although it can be quite a challenge to get our attention to rest calmly in this foundation, the pickings are very rich. We're learning not to identify with our feelings, letting go of the habitual reactions of desire, aversion and ignoring. I'll say more about feelings tomorrow night, but for the moment I just want to mention that in this Sutta the Buddha also points out another distinction in feeling between worldly and unworldly feelings.

Worldly feelings are based on sense contact. Unworldly feelings are associated with spiritual endeavour. For example, generosity, *metta*, compassion, meditative joy are all unworldly feelings. They also happen to be pleasant feelings, and of course there's a danger that we cling to them unwittingly, thinking, "I am generous, I am filled with loving kindness," et cetera. This feels fine until something bursts that bubble. The fall to earth can be very sore and bring out the worst in us. Suddenly we hate everyone. But if we can be mindful of the pleasant feeling, we can appreciate it and use it to fuel our generosity and *metta* and all other beautiful states.

There can also be unpleasant feelings that come from spiritual endeavour. For example, we may feel ashamed or depressed because our minds keep wandering or because we can't understand the *Dhamma*. The big danger, of course, is to identify with these feelings and let ourselves become discouraged. But if we can open to the feelings, they can bring up a tender compassion for our unenlightened state. This is quite a deep degree of self-acknowledgement and self-care. Very healing. Once we sense this, the very unpleasantness locks us into the compassionate response and thereby propels us along the path.

Neutral unworldly feelings are associated with equanimity. If we don't notice these, we can set up a subtle level of clinging, thinking, "I am equanimous." But of course, this bubble also bursts in time. If we acknowledge the neutral feelings, these can release us into a wise appreciation of equanimity.

The Buddha again repeats the refrain after describing this second foundation. Here he is clarifying that we can gain the insight needed for liberation by knowing whether we are feeling a pleasant, unpleasant or neutral feeling and knowing whether it comes from sense contact or spiritual endeavour. Similarly, we can study transience in our feelings, noticing that these too arise and pass away. As for the body, the third possibility is to simply note there are feelings, without any attempt to categorise or detect their transient nature.

The next section of the Sutta involves contemplating our mind. This involves, for example, knowing when we're angry or greedy, and all the variations on these. For example, anger may take on hues of irritation, fear, frustration, jealousy or cruelty. Greed can take the form of excitement, romance, lust, euphoria or passionate attachment. To correlate this with the wheel of dependent origination, we're now focusing on the early stages of the wheel, the stages prior to sense contact. These make up the attitude we bring into being at the point of contact.

We think we see and hear things objectively, but in fact our perception is coloured by whatever mind state is driving us to sense contact. I had a good illustration of this one time when doing walking meditation. It was a big airy room and I had been alone until someone came in and started walking quite close nearby. I felt myself contract in aversion. At the same time I could have sworn the room went dark. I had experienced the darkening of the room and the darkening of my mind simultaneously, and could intuitively sense their connection.

Nevertheless, I couldn't quite believe that my perceptions could be so easily modified. I looked out the window to check whether a big rain cloud had appeared, but it hadn't. The sky was still blue. Reluctantly I accepted that even my perception of light could be influenced by my mood. I was quite dismayed. The outside world wasn't quite so stable and objectively real as I had believed.

When we dwell mindfully in this foundation, we are noting what moods or mind states we're bringing to being at every point of sense contact. Otherwise, we're being controlled by the mind state. It is driving us into thought and action, but we're not conscious of this. We believe the thoughts. For example, something irritates us and we grow tense in indignation, generating thoughts like, "It's not fair." The resulting unpleasant feelings of tension prompt us to think yet again that it's not fair. So we think the thoughts again and again, convincing ourselves of their truth. The thoughts fuel the underlying emotion and so we get more deeply caught in the negative spiral.

The first step is to replace the thought stream with the noting word "thinking, thinking." This takes one level of feedback out of the loop. The body is our great ally in coming close to the root of the problem. We might need to calm for a while, using the breath for example. Then, if we can feel where the body is tensing, this draws our attention towards the underlying emotion. We can simply note "feeling, feeling" here. But sometimes getting the right noting word is like hitting the nail on the head. All the mind state really wants is recognition. The more often we bring attention into this foundation, the better we get at discerning our moods and emotions. In this case, for example, noting "indignation" might bring a palpable release of that pent-up energy.

However, if the emotion runs deep, we must be patient and keep on noting while it eventually burns itself out. A moment's lapse in mindfulness and we will be building up the story of how unfair life is again.

The Buddha's advice is very simple. For example, he notes "a mind affected by anger as a mind affected by anger." There is no judgment required. Simple acknowledgement of our afflicted mind states is all that is required. Judgment tends to contract us further. But of course, we can't undo our habit of judging so easily. So whenever we sense that we're adding the second arrow of self-judgment, we simply let attention graze in the feel of judgment, feeling its physical expression in our bodies as well as whatever emotions show up: disapproval, self-disgust, self-hatred. From the point of view of insight, all these are equally welcome. Wisdom grows as we witness these.

The Sutta also advises us to note the absence of mind states like greed and anger. This isn't something we often do. We tend only to notice our minds when they're troubled, not when they're clear and at ease. But noticing the absence of trouble helps us appreciate those states. We find it easier to let go of excitement, for example, when we learn to appreciate the pleasantness of being calm.

Just now, for example, are you angry? If not, note "not angry, not angry," and get a felt sense of that mental state. Similarly, you could ask yourself if your mind is excited, wanting more stimulation. If not, note "not excited, not excited." We need to get to know these unobtrusive mind states. Our minds like familiarity. What the mind knows and is familiar with, it comes back to again and again.

Apart from the variations on greed and anger, our minds can be deluded, thinking there is a very powerful me in control of all my experience. Again, we can simply note this as "delusion, delusion." The belief and the felt experience may be the same, but they have now been brought within the foundation for wisdom to graze upon. Very gradually the wild geese nibble away at our delusions. Similarly, we can note the presence or absence of sleepiness, restlessness, distraction, concentration, peacefulness and any mind state.

The Buddha then repeats the refrain, reiterating that insight can be gained as we note the presence or absence of our mind states, as we sense them arise and pass away, or as we simply ground ourselves in the knowledge that there is a mind without any attempt to be more discerning than that. The latter is the kind of light touch mindfulness we need when any attempt to probe more deeply would disturb the experience.

The final foundation is called *Dhammas* and there's a lot of controversy about how to translate this. The *Dhamma* is the teaching of the Buddha and is usually spelled with a capital D. But the word *dhammas* here is plural and with a small d. The classical translation is "mind objects." But that's not very helpful since all the other foundations can also be described as mind objects. We make the body, feelings and mind into objects for contemplation in those foundations.

Recently the translation "categories of experience" is gaining favour. But that's not very elegant. It's hard to relate to. Looking ahead to see what the foundation describes, it is actually a number of the Buddha's teachings. The teachings he picks out include the hindrances, the factors of enlightenment and the four noble truths, as well as two more which we'll discuss over the next two evenings. In my simple way of thinking, I can see why we don't call this foundation the *Dhamma*, because here we are in fact contemplating the central core of the Buddha's teachings.

Whatever we call it, this last foundation asks us to let our attention dwell on the moment-to-moment experience of the hindrances, factors of enlightenment, four noble truths and other teachings. This makes it abundantly clear that these teachings are not simply lists of human attributes or philosophical statements. The *Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta* clarifies that we must know and understand these teachings within the realm of our individual subjective experience. We are to let our attention dwell on these teachings as they manifest in our body and mind, ingesting their wisdom moment by moment until we eventually see these from the Buddha's point of view. This is what it means to be a follower of the Buddha.

I'm not going to say any more about this foundation tonight, because all the teachings mentioned here are explored in other talks. Let's just skip to the conclusion of the Sutta, where the Buddha assures us that if we can explore our experience, according to *Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta*, for just seven days, we will have deep, deep insight, perhaps even full liberation. Luckily, there are still seven days left in this retreat. So now you know what you have to do.

Persuade yourself to be an ardent lover of truth. Bring your mindful intelligence to the quest for truth. Put aside your worldly cares, or if they refuse to subside, let them become the focus for meditation. Draw your mind into whichever foundation beckons you. When you're settled, start exploring the transient nature of your experience. Lighten the attention to bare registration of the foundation when you feel that would suit the situation best. That's all. As Bhante would say, "Easy-weezy-peasy."

May your exploration of the four foundations for mindfulness bring you to full enlightenment in this very lifetime.

Fourth Maxim (iii): Path to Transcendence

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 3 min read

This essay examines Transcendent Dependent Arising (paṭilomapaṭicca samuppāda), a twelve-step teaching that shows how suffering becomes the foundation for the path to awakening. Noirin Sheahan explores steps four through ten of this process, demonstrating how initial dukkha can transform through mindful investigation into faith, joy, rapture, tranquillity, happiness, concentration, insight, and disenchantment. The teaching provides a Dhamma foundation for the fourth of six ethical maxims for facing climate catastrophe - embracing our good fortune to live through this crisis.

The essay offers practical guidance for working with climate anxiety and fear through meditation practice. It shows how rapture can arise even when exploring difficult emotions, how tranquillity emerges from careful attention to pleasant sensations within unpleasant experiences, and how happiness naturally develops when we stop defending against impermanence. The author demonstrates how insight arises when the sense of a separate controlling self dissolves, revealing the First Noble Truth not as a problem but as liberating wisdom.

This contemplative approach transforms our relationship with climate grief, anger, and fear, showing how these challenging emotions can become doorways to transcendence. The essay emphasizes that resistance to life's difficulties is futile, and that welcoming our troubles - including climate concerns - opens the path toward nibbāna through progressive stages of spiritual development.

Following on last month's tip, I want to look at a few more steps in the process of Transcendent Dependent Arising, a teaching showing suffering as the starting point for the path to the end of suffering. This gives a Dhamma basis for the fourth of the six maxims suggested as ethical preparation for climate catastrophe. This maxim challenges us to embrace our good fortune to be living through the crisis. There are twelve steps in Transcendent Dependent Arising, starting with dukkha (usually translated as suffering, but including even the irritation of a fly buzzing on the window pane) and ending with Enlightenment; each step lays down the conditions for the next. Last month I looked at the first three steps showing how dukkha, explored mindfully, leads to faith and then to joy. In meditation, joy refines to keen interest in moment-to-moment experience. We may still be aware of fear associated with our changing climate, but now we're willing to experience fear as sensations and feelings. This, believe it or not, is a form of rapture

– often exhilarating and horrible in equal measure! Rapture is a condition for tranquillity. Notice the moments where we are attracted right into the heart of the horror to discover pleasant feelings of relaxation and ease there. Confusing! We might quickly tense up again, but curiosity will sooner or later prompt another moment's relaxation, another taste of the rich concoction of feelings we label as fear. With practice, we get more confident that it is indeed possible to relax and explore the texture of embodied fear. Amid all the unpleasant sensations which we find threatening, we learn to pick out any pleasant ones. As we sink attention into these, we grow tranquil. The mind and body feel calm, at ease. When we've fully convinced ourselves that tranquillity is indeed manifesting, it becomes possible to shift focus, explore the experience of tranquillity itself. This sets up the conditions for the heart to soften as happiness arises. This is not a happy-clappy elation, but a tender glow in the heart. We're happy to be in intimate contact with ourselves despite a fear that still lurks at the periphery of consciousness. With happiness, it becomes easier to focus attention. What usually attracts my attention is the sense of self, the 'me' who watches this show. While happiness is experienced as central, the 'me who watches' hovers around in the periphery. Within the 'me' are prickles of fear as I acknowledge the fragility of the situation, how easily happiness could be quenched. Tensions grow and the breath stops in an effort to hold onto happiness, stave off the dukkha of transience. To my dismay I realise happiness has already gone, swallowed up in my efforts to protect it. With nothing left to defend, I relax and let the breath flow freely. Tensions release and to my surprise I detect happiness again. This time no watcher looks over it or tries to protect it. The sense of 'me' as a separate agent, controlling experience has dissolved. This is the step of insight on the path of transcendent arising. Pleasant feelings associated with happiness intermingle with unpleasant ones which tell of the fragility of happiness, its conditioned nature. This is no longer interpreted as a problem, but as a demonstration of the first noble truth: there is dukkha. Paradoxically, the truth is welcome. It's a relief to know I can stop trying to achieve the impossible. My original fears around climate change can now be included in this contemplation of dukkha. Sorrow, fear and anger circle around the body along with the happiness of being able to carry a share of the suffering being wrought by our changing climate. Though insight brings peace and joy, our habit of resisting what frightens or displeases us runs deep; soon we find ourselves back at stage 1 again, kicking and screaming. But now we know that dukkha, examined mindfully, leads to insight via faith, joy, rapture, tranquillity, happiness, and concentration. Each insight shows us the futility of resisting what life serves up; this provides the conditions for the next step in the path: disenchantment. Our passions cool; we get better at meeting adversity, intuit calm at the heart of every storm. The process doesn't stop there and just three more steps bring us to nibbana – either full liberation or a glimpse that will obliterate any

doubts in the Dhamma. But that's for another day! In the meantime, let's welcome all our troubles, including our worries, anger, sorrow because of our changing climate, as doorways to transcendence.

Fourth Maxim: Appreciate the Amazing and Unique Opportunity - From Suffering to Faith to Gladness

Noirin Sheahan · 3 min read

This essay examines the fourth of six ethical maxims for addressing climate catastrophe, drawing parallels with the Buddhist teaching of Transcendent Dependent Arising (paṭicca samuppāda). Rather than avoiding the distress of climate change, Noirin Sheahan suggests embracing it as an opportunity for spiritual development. The teaching shows how dukkha, when met with mindfulness, can become a condition for faith (saddhā), which in turn gives rise to joy. This process mirrors the traditional twelve-step sequence that leads from suffering to liberation, though here applied to contemporary environmental anxiety. The essay provides practical meditation instructions for working with difficult emotions, encouraging practitioners to develop intimate awareness of dukkha rather than pushing it away through distraction or escapism. By cultivating faith in our innate capacity to work through difficulties, we can discover a life-affirming energy that transforms our relationship with suffering. The teaching bridges traditional Dhamma wisdom with modern challenges, offering both vipassanā practitioners and those facing climate grief a skilful means for finding transcendence within adversity.

Fourth Maxim: Appreciate the Astonishing and Unique Opportunity.

After a break, I'm looking again at the six maxims suggested as ethical preparation for climate catastrophe, teasing out some links with the Dhamma.

Instead of focussing on the horrid side of climate change, the fourth maxim asks us to embrace our good fortune to be living through this crisis. This parallels with the Dhamma teaching on Transcendent Dependent Arising.

"Dependant Arising" refers to a step-by-step process by which one thing leads to another; the first step lays down the conditions for the second and so on. Many of you will be familiar with this teaching, showing how ignorance leads to dukkha (usually translated as suffering but including even minor irritations). Transcendent Dependant Arising completes the process, showing how awareness of dukkha sets off another chain of conditions which culminate in liberation.

This teaching is better known in Jhana schools but also applies in vipassana, though it needs some steadiness of attention to discern the links. I've found it helpful and encouraging at times of distress and thus an apt support for this maxim.

There are twelve steps in the process, though we may repeat these a million times

before we reach the end of suffering. For simplicity I'll focus on the earlier stages. The starting point is dukkha. The anxiety we feel as we contemplate climate change is an 'astonishing and unique opportunity' to cultivate the path to transcendence. This may seem fanciful, naive. How could drought, wildfires, social breakdown and the like facilitate transcendence? And yet there are countless examples of how acute suffering led people to spiritual renewal.

Our usual mistake is to keep suffering at arm's length, fretting about how awful things are, comforting ourselves with food, alcohol, escapism. Transcendence requires intimacy with the sensations and feelings of dukkha. As we explore these mindfully, we find something within us that refuses to capitulate, insists that we will somehow find a way through these troubles.

Thus, dukkha, examined mindfully, becomes a condition for faith in our innate ability to overcome dukkha. This is the second link in Transcendent Arising - faith that we will find a way through difficulty.

Luckily we have access to the Dhamma. Faith can find refuge there, knowing there are teachings, practices, and a sangha to guide us. In these supportive conditions, the determination to overcome dukkha can be experienced as a form of joy – a positive, life-affirming energy that carries an intuition of goodness. Thus, faith is a condition for joy, the third step in the series.

I'll stop here for now, describe some following stages next month. If this teaching is

new to you, I hope you'll examine it, see whether it could be a helpful support for your troubles, whether these centre around climate change or more personal issues. Reflect on your practice with dukkha and whether this has or could stir faith; whether faith could be a source of joy in life.

To help the teaching sink deeper, try to spot these links in vipassana. First settle yourself in meditation, then bring the difficulty to mind; does the distress overwhelm mindfulness, or can you feel the feelings? How might you describe whatever keeps you practicing? Would it be the faith that mindfulness will somehow show you a way through?

Well done if you've managed to make that first link in the path to transcendence. If not, try again tomorrow. If and when you can perceive faith arising from dukkha, explore this. Does faith have an energetic manifestation in the body, are there associated feelings, tensions? Practice meditating on faith itself.

In subsequent meditation sessions, as you get more confident that dukkha, observed mindfully, leads to faith, it may become possible to detect joy within the experience of faith. Not an excited giddiness, but the joy of having the courage to be mindful in the face of dukkha. Learn to relax with this joy, feel its energy within the body, how it affects the breath. We may still seem far from transcending dukkha, but we can enjoy

the path thereto.

Although the problem of climate change remains as a real existential threat to humanity, this teaching helps us make the best of a bad situation, appreciating this astonishing and unique opportunity to forge a path to transcendence.

Fourth Noble Truth: The Path to the End of Dukkha

Noirin Sheahan · 43 min

In this teaching, Noirin Sheahan examines the Fourth Noble Truth - the Noble Eightfold Path that leads to the cessation of dukkha. Using the evocative metaphor of forming a path through dense jungle, she explores how the eight factors work together across three sections: wisdom (paññā), ethical conduct (sīla), and mental cultivation (bhāvanā). The talk begins with sammā diṭṭhi (Right Understanding) and sammā saṅkappa (Right Attitude), deepened through the four brahmavihāras - mettā, karuṇā, muditā, and upekkhā. She then addresses the challenging ethical dimensions of sammā vācā, sammā kammanta, and sammā ājīva, connecting Buddhist morality to the law of kamma and its role in happiness and suffering. The final section covers sammā vāyāma, sammā sati, and sammā samādhi, showing how right effort, awareness, and concentration work together like children picking flowers from a tree. Throughout, Noirin emphasizes that this path cannot be mapped in advance but forms step by step as we walk it, each strand supporting the others in the gradual disentanglement from the binds of dukkha toward the freedom of awakening.

Tonight I want to talk about the fourth noble truth and how it relates to the law of *kamma*.

The fourth truth states that there is a path leading to the end of suffering, the noble eightfold path. Our injunction is to follow that path.

There is a poem by the Spanish poet Antonio Machado that I find helpful in thinking about the eightfold path. Here is a very loose translation: "Wayfarer, there is no way. The way forms as you walk it."

So we can't look ahead and see where the eightfold path is taking us. We can't work out how long till we get to the end or the next milestone. We can only form the path step by step. We can think of the eight strands to the path as different parts to each step.

The path is divided into three sections: wisdom, morality and the cultivation of our mind and heart through meditation. Imagine trying to form a path through a thick jungle. The strands of wisdom cut through the thicket so we can see more clearly. We express our wisdom in the world by our speech, actions and livelihood. This is our step into the clearing we have just hacked out. Rather than hacking away doggedly at the

thicket in front of us, we rest to contemplate our new position, find the most promising route, the easiest branches to fell. This is the cultivation of heart and mind in meditation. These sharpen the sword of wisdom. And so we are ready to cut out the next step.

Each of the eight strands is described as right. For example, the first section on wisdom has two subdivisions termed right understanding and right attitude. The word "right" can stir the judging mind and I think the translations "straightened out" or "disentangled" give a better description of what happens as we follow the path.

At first we get caught in tangles of thought when we try to work out how to live well. But the more we walk the path the more we sense our thought processes straightening out, our emotional life disentangling. We become more straightforward in our dealings with others. In meditation, we can often feel ourselves getting into knots of tension as the hindrances show up, and then feel the relief as those knots loosen in the light of awareness.

Now, "straightened out" and "disentangled" are both a bit of a mouthful, so I'll follow the convention of calling each step "right this" or "right that." But bear in mind the gentler and more evocative sense that we disentangle ourselves from the binds of *dukkha* as we develop our path.

The first section of the path is right understanding. This is the polar opposite of *avijjā*, the ignorance that forms the basis for the wheel of conditions ending up in *dukkha*. While *avijjā* implies not understanding what causes suffering and what prevents it, this first step in the path leading out of suffering implies understanding those very processes.

Hearing about and reflecting on the Dhamma cultivates right understanding. But if understanding is confined only to the cognitive level, it can tighten into absolute judgments. Rules become commands and to break them is treachery. When cognitive understanding filters in the domain of will and emotion, we take the Dhamma to heart. This is what we mean by right attitude. This is the second strand to the eightfold path.

Wisdom thus has two strands: right understanding, which is mainly cognitive, and right attitude, which means a wise heart. We often use the word "attitude" to describe negativity. We say he or she "has an attitude" to mean that they go their own way without much consideration for others. But in fact one can have a friendly attitude and that is what is meant in the second strand of wisdom.

While cognitive understanding tends to tighten the mind, friendliness tends to soften it. Together they make for a balance: enough honest discernment to be able to tell right from wrong, enough friendliness to forgive mistakes.

Right attitude emerges naturally as we practice mindfulness. But we can accelerate the process by also practicing the four *brahmavihāras*. The term *brahmavihāra* translates as "the abode of the gods."

Mettā, usually translated as goodwill or loving-kindness, is the first of these. We wish ourselves and others to be well and happy. This undermines the aversive habits that cloud our mind: ill will, anger, coldness, fear, and so on. It doesn't uproot the seed in the same way that mindfulness does, but it nulls the aversive effect. In our gardening analogy, you could say it covers over the weeds, preventing them from getting any sunlight, so they can't thrive and sow more seeds.

The combination of *mettā* and mindfulness is very powerful. *Mettā* suppresses aversion to help us be more friendly and live in accord with the Dhamma, while mindfulness weeds away at the hindrances.

The second *brahmavihāra* is compassion. As we undermine our habitual aversion to suffering, our hearts show their capacity for compassion and our speech and activities become more caring. We practice this *brahmavihāra* by bringing to mind someone who is having a hard time—could be ourselves—and wishing them to be free from suffering.

The third *brahmavihāra* is *muditā*, often translated as appreciative joy. As we undermine fear, jealousy and other aspects of ill will, our hearts are more easily gladdened by good news. We're not so ready to dismiss our own achievements with a self-deprecating remark like "that was nothing really," but to congratulate ourselves for the effort we made. And when we hear of another's success, we feel happy for them. We cultivate this *brahmavihāra* by bringing to mind someone who has had good news—again, this can be ourselves—and saying, "May your happiness continue, may your happiness increase," or if you prefer, "I am happy that you are happy."

While compassion lets us bear the suffering in the world, *muditā* helps us acknowledge its joys. *Mettā* forms the basis for both in its cultivation of friendliness.

All three of these *brahmavihāras* need the support of the fourth: equanimity. Equanimity is one of the factors of enlightenment. Remember the bird with the wide wingspan, steadying the flock through the ups and downs of their journey.

Without equanimity, *mettā* easily overshoots into attachment and we become dependent on our friends for our sense of worth. With equanimity, we learn to accept that friends have separate lives, other responsibilities, other affections.

Without the balance of equanimity, compassion slides into pity. What's happening is that we're seeing ourselves as the stronger party caring for the weaker one. It can become an addiction, needing to be needed. Equanimity restores the balance, lets us see the strength at the core of the other's being, trust to their capacity to heal and recover. If the person is dying, equanimity helps see this not as a tragedy, but as part of the mystery of life, nothing to pity them for. After all, our own turn will come quick enough.

Muditā escalates into excitement unless it is supported by equanimity. We latch on to the joy, identify with it and believe life is going to be perfect from now on. When we inevitably fall from grace, we are shocked and confused, wondering what went wrong. Equanimity gives us the balance we need to recognise joy as a temporary gift, to enjoy it to the full and then let it go when the time is right.

What we let go into is equanimity, that peaceful balance of mind which knows better than to cling to the good stuff or struggle with the rotten stuff.

The classic phrase used to cultivate equanimity is the reflection: "All beings are the owners of their *kamma*." This reminds us that we have no direct power over our own or others' happiness. It is designed as an antidote to the delusion of ourselves as a benign deity who can make people happy just by wishing this. It sounds comical, but in fact it is a delusion easily stirred by practicing with the *brahmavihāras*. Even the term *brahmavihāra*, "abode of the gods," suggests this. It feels godlike to have our hearts filled with goodness, kindness, joy, friendliness, as if we are above and beyond the troubles of the world. In that sublime state, our thoughts of a person being well and happy are easily mistaken as the reality for that person.

The reflection "All beings are owners of their *kamma*" brings us down to earth. We realise our limitations. You may be able to find a phrase which carries the same meaning but resonates easier in your heart. For example, I sometimes use the phrase "I trust you to find your own path to *Nibbāna*." This helps me to see the other person more objectively and cultivates respect for their separate path in life.

Just as *mettā*, compassion and *muditā* need equanimity to balance them, equanimity needs the other *brahmavihāras* for its own balance. Without them, equanimity easily slips into indifference. We let go of others to such an extent we no longer feel anything for them. When this happens, it's time to start practising with whichever of the other three is most appropriate.

Right understanding polishes one side of the sword of wisdom. The *brahmavihāras* polish the other side. With this double-edged sword we cut our way through the jungle of hindrances, clearing another step along our eightfold path.

This brings us to the next section of the path, *sīla* in Pali, usually translated as morality or ethics. *Sīla* is the expression of wisdom in daily life. I'm going to use the Pali word *sīla* because we often associate morality with a strict, joyless approach to life. Family photos from Victorian times illustrate this. No one smiles. The children look miserable in their heavy, awkward suits. An austere father towers over them while his wife sits demurely at his side, laced and buttoned within an inch of her life. Desire finds no expression in this picture of morality.

But we need to remember that desire can also be wise. The desire to be happy is perhaps our most basic drive in life. It only gets us into trouble because we don't rightly understand what allows for happiness, what causes suffering. The Buddha promises us that if we follow this path we will be content and therefore happy. Morality in this light is seen as a step towards happiness.

I want to touch on the law of *kamma* here to clarify the link between morality and happiness. *Kamma* is the Buddha's teaching on causality. He discovered that happiness and unhappiness are governed by the laws of *kamma*. When we hear of someone's good fortune, we might say, "Ah, that's your good *kamma* showing up," and we might think along the same lines for misfortune. But this is a mistake.

The Buddha said that *kamma* was one of five laws operating in the universe. The first are the laws that govern the physical world. These, rather than *kamma*, could be at the basis for lots of common misfortunes: infections, car crashes, and so on, as well as major events like earthquakes, drought and hurricanes. And physical conditions and the laws governing them can bring good fortune: health, strength, a good harvest or good weather.

The second set of laws are the biological laws of heredity. We may inherit a parent's musical ear or a family gene for heart disease.

The third are the laws that govern our mind. We might get Alzheimer's and no longer be able to think clearly, or we may be born with a very high IQ or a talent for languages.

The fourth is the law of *kamma*.

Finally, there are the laws of Dhamma, that all phenomena are subject to change, ageing and death. No matter how impeccable our *kamma*, we will die.

Thus, *kamma* is only one of five sets of laws governing events in our life. We cannot ascribe someone's handicap or poverty to bad *kamma*. Neither can we ascribe their musical genius or longevity to good *kamma*. What we can ascribe to their previous *kamma* is a person's happiness or unhappiness. These, the Buddha discovered, operate under the law of *kamma*.

When we think, speak or act motivated by greed, hatred or delusion, we sow bad *kamma* which will eventually ripen to harm us and diminish our happiness. Similarly, thoughts of goodwill sow seeds of *kamma* that will ripen to benefit us and make us happier.

The harm we do ourselves from acting out of ill-will happens at the point of becoming, *bhava*, in the wheel of dependent origination that we spoke of last night. Remember the *saṅkhāra* seeds, our habitual drives, that can germinate and then sprout through our senses to urge us to react to circumstances. At the point of *bhava*, our seed has blossomed into a sense of self who is now about to think, act or speak under the influence of this habitual drive. At the moment the thought, deed or act starts, a seed of that *saṅkhāra* is sown, to sprout at some future time when the opportunity presents itself. For now, this *saṅkhāra* has come out of potential into action, to give birth to a thought, an act or an utterance that carries out its will.

How does this cause unhappiness? Say we were speaking out of ill-will. We say something nasty. We might feel powerful as a result, but since all things fall apart, sooner or later we feel vulnerable again. How do we get back to power? Find someone we can vent our anger on. So we get in the habit of nasty speech.

Where does this lead us? We lose friends and gain enemies. Out of fear, some people might rally around us, but their suppressed feelings get in the way of real friendship, and most will be delighted to stab us in the back when they get the opportunity. A bully lives in a state of suppressed fear that his own deeds will be perpetrated on him.

Similarly for greed, the enjoyment is temporary while the stress of continually needing to consume is exhausting, while overconsumption itself can harm our bodies. And everything we consume has to be paid for, so we get stressed out with overwork. Satiating greed makes us feel needy rather than satisfied.

Delusion manifests in the myriad untested assumptions we make that let us ignore what doesn't serve our agenda. We might take our family and friends for granted, assume they will always be there for us. If one of them suddenly dies or emigrates we might get quite a shock to find how much we needed them. We may have many regrets about how little we appreciated their company and support.

On the other hand, if we think, speak or act out of generosity, goodwill or wisdom, the law of *kamma* tells us that we will reap the benefits. There will be social benefits as everyone prefers people who are generous rather than stingy, caring rather than unkind, wise rather than foolish. Also, the benefits go deep within us, as each kind word helps heal our own heart. Each act of generosity counters our sense of neediness. Each wise thought undermines our ignorance and delusion.

It is the motivation that matters for the law of *kamma*, not the act itself. If a doctor cares for his patients only because he gets well paid, he won't reap the benefits of kindness, but will suffer the consequences of greed. Similarly, if our efforts to solve a conflict end up making it worse, we won't suffer any karmic harm, so long as our motivation was good.

Sīla, the second stage of the eightfold path, is therefore not a simple matter of following rules for good behaviour. We also need to examine our motivation. Often we are aware of mixed motives. We know we are angry, but we still feel it would be best to confront the person who angered us. Which seeds are we nourishing here, ill will or wisdom? We can consciously make a suitable good wish like "May this do more good than harm, may I learn from any mistakes I make," to help us move in the right direction.

The Buddha divides *sīla* into three sections: right speech, right action and right livelihood.

Right speech has four aspects. It must be truthful, timely and useful, as well as being said gently rather than harshly. Let's see how each of these leads to happiness.

Truthfulness in the long run is easier on our psyche than lying. Probably the most usual way we lie is to exaggerate things for effect. If we lie or exaggerate, there's always a danger of being caught out, which leads to restlessness and worry. Apart from that, others come to distrust and disrespect us to some extent, which can limit their friendships.

Speech is useful from the point of view of *sīla* if it promotes happiness. Friendly greetings are useful and small talk can also help us feel at ease. The main temptation towards unhelpful speech is gossiping. To gossip is to talk about the doings of third parties, often feeding on their misfortune. It can easily spread rumours and allow unchallenged backbiting.

I remember a neighbour telling me about a couple who had broken up. They had been building a house extension when the wife ran away with the builder. It might have been funny in a Hollywood movie, and the grin on her face told me she was seeing it in this light, not feeling for the family and the pain this would be causing.

Sometimes it can be difficult to draw the line between gossip, small talk and the genuine need to discuss a third party's behaviour. During friendly chatter we often mention news of people we know in common.

Ask yourself, how would I feel if this person was listening to our conversation? If you would feel any way embarrassed, it's likely that your talk has strayed into gossip.

On the other hand, if we've been hurt by someone, it often helps to discuss the matter with a third party. Keeping it all to ourselves for fear of generating the kamma of wrong speech is not always the wisest course. We often need the help of a friend or counsellor to move towards forgiveness. The motivation here is not to gossip, but to clarify our thoughts and let our heart heal through sympathy. Basically we're asking our friend or therapist for help in bearing the difficulty. We could see it as an extension of mindfulness practice. In mindfulness we let our angry thoughts crash through our psyche. He did this, she did that. I can't understand how they didn't notice. Eventually anger wears itself out. Letting these angry thoughts be heard by a friend or therapist brings the matter to a new level of consciousness. The shared awareness allows a bigger space for the anger to express itself and for the futility of anger to be acknowledged. Often the process can help turn our hearts towards understanding and forgiveness.

Timely speech is especially important when we have something difficult to say. Suppose we feel hurt by a friend's behaviour. If we see they're despondent, harassed or pre-occupied by something else, best hold back. It's so easy for negativity to spread like a virus. What was intended to restore friendship, despondency might translate into rejection, while harassment might see as yet another injustice. Best ask them to meet to discuss something a bit sensitive, so that they will be more prepared for a genuine heart-to-heart conversation.

Harsh speech adds cutting words or a hurtful tone to whatever message we need to give. In the short term, this might make us feel more powerful, in control. But it often provokes the other into a riposte, and an argument can easily break out. Even if the other doesn't react but is crushed by our remark, we've lost some degree of their friendship. So in the long run, caring speech promotes our own happiness, while harsh speech leads us to the unhappiness and social isolation of the bully.

Right action has three components: to refrain from harming others, stealing their property and misusing our sexuality.

The greatest harm we can do to another is to take their life. The Buddha doesn't confine this precept to human life and many Buddhists would also be vegetarian for this reason. However, the Buddha didn't forbid his disciples to eat meat. This was probably pragmatic, for they had to survive on alms rounds, so had to accept whatever they were given.

While most of us would not want to kill or harm others we can take this precept further by asking ourselves what we could do to promote others' welfare. Purchasing ethically produced goods would be one avenue; giving to charities which combat poverty would be another. We can also look after animal welfare as best we can, avoiding factory farmed produce for example, because of the horrendous suffering involved, or becoming vegetarians. Vegans take this a step further and avoid all animal products. This prevents much suffering, for example the separation of calf from cow at the moment of birth, so that we can take the cow's milk for our dairy products.

Moving on to the second component of right action, not stealing. Few people who come on retreat would be involved in gross theft. But we can take this further to ask whether we are using more than our fair share of the earth's resources. Even governments now agree that human activities are adding to the problem of climate change. The effect is already being felt in many developing countries and threatens homes and livelihoods as well as food and water supplies. Consumption of fossil fuel is a major component driving climate change. When we take a flight or drive, rather than use public transport, we add to the problem. Every manufactured item we purchase adds to our carbon footprint. We need to regularly ask ourselves whether our energy consumption is justified or whether we're frivolously frittering away the Earth's resources and fuelling climate change.

The third component of right action is not to abuse our sexuality. Sexuality gives joy that can nourish and sustain a loving relationship. But if it is used frivolously or to gain power over another, it can lead to a lot of suffering. Infidelity can cause enormous hurt and break up relationships. Abortion is surely suffering from the foetus's point of view and very often from the mother's view as well. And we have the horrors of childhood sexual abuse and vulnerable people being forced into prostitution.

While many of us will not have to face the suffering of abortion, sexual abuse or forced prostitution, we do have to face many challenges in maintaining this precept within a society where sex outside of committed relationship is quite common. The main questions to keep in mind are: could this lead to hurt or other harm for myself or others? Will it lead to happiness for myself or others?

The final strand of morality in the Eightfold Path is right livelihood. We need to be sure our livelihood is not harming others. The livelihoods the Buddha listed as wrong were those dealing with weapons, poisons, slavery, including buying and selling children and prostitution, intoxicants and meat. Weapons, poison, slavery and butchery can obviously kill and harm, while intoxicants promote delusion. Few people would argue with the advice not to have anything to do with slavery or forced prostitution. The harm these do is beyond question.

But the other areas mentioned here are tolerated in our society, making this a very challenging aspect of the Eightfold Path for those already employed in one of these. Although few poisons are sold legally nowadays, there is the tricky area of pest control. If your work involves dealing with these, see whether you could stock a compassionate alternative. For example, there are rat and mouse traps that do not kill the animal, and also alternatives for dealing with slugs.

Butchery obviously involves great suffering for animals, and very often there are long, frightening journeys involved before slaughter. To be directly involved in this must be an incredible challenge to a sensitive heart and can only foster cruelty and indifference. Rearing animals for slaughter is part of these same business. The Buddha's unequivocal advice is to get out of this aspect of farming and anything else to do with the meat trade for your own spiritual welfare as well as the welfare of animals.

Many people are employed in the weapons industry, from soldiers on the ground to scientists in the lab. So much war seems pointless and horrific when seen from a distance or with hindsight. Who, in hindsight, could justify the atrocities of the First World War, the Vietnamese War? But many would argue that it was justified in the Second World War in order to prevent the rise of Hitler. In 1995, over 8,000 people were massacred in Srebrenica as the UN stood by. Was the UN right not to attack the invading Serbs in order to defend these civilians? These are hard questions. In war, each side justifies their action, seeing the enemy as the greater threat to humanity. But can you stand by as atrocities are committed? Would it be justified to kill the guards of a concentration camp in order to liberate those within?

There are no easy answers here. It's a question of choosing the lesser of evils. Certainly a soldier's life is not to be envied from the point of view of *kamma*. It would need the wisdom of a Buddha to choose the most compassionate response in such a situation. Bhante has an essay, "Is Armed Intervention Ever Justified?", on the Satipanya website, which explores this in more depth. He distinguishes between force and violence, which helps us clarify *sīla* in our response to the question of war. His essay also cites wonderful exemplars of the non-violent approach to conflict management. Great leaders like Nelson Mandela and Gandhi brokered peace for warlike situations. And figures like Aung San Suu Kyi and Dalai Lama inspire us to look only for a peaceful solution.

The injunction not to deal with intoxicants poses hard questions for many people, as almost every shop, restaurant and hotel is expected to supply alcohol. If we can change job, then best do this, but if not, do we make ourselves redundant to avoid this problem? What about the consequences for our family? Would the harm to them be justified? Our culture makes it easy for us to justify alcohol, and most of us know people who live good lives while drinking moderately. On the other hand, many road accidents are alcohol-related, as well as domestic and street violence and sexual abuse. Our cultural ease with alcohol also facilitates alcoholism with all its problems. And if we're interested in liberation, can it ever help to cloud our mind with alcohol?

As I think you will agree, *sīla* is not an easy matter. For each of us there will be difficult ethical questions to face at some stage in life. We need a clear mind to find the appropriate response in complex situations and a stout heart to meet the challenge.

The last section of the Eightfold Path concerns the cultivation of mind and heart in meditation practice. Let's first take a look to review our progress. We hacked out a clearing using the sword of wisdom with its double blade, right understanding and right intention. We stepped into the clearing as we brought wisdom into our speech, action and livelihood. Now we need to rest a while, assess our new surroundings, polish our sword of wisdom before we tackle the thicket again.

This section of the path also has three strands: right effort, right mindfulness and right concentration. Right effort involves the factor of energy that we met in the factor of enlightenment. So here we have again the leading trio in our wild geese. To see their interrelation, we have the analogy of three children wanting to pick some flowers from a tree. None of them is tall enough to reach the flowers, so the strongest one, right effort, bends over to let the tallest one, right concentration, stand on his back, while the

steadiest of the three, right mindfulness, provides a shoulder for him to lean on. Supported by right effort, balanced by mindfulness, concentration can then pluck the flowers.

Now this image isn't quite in accord with our image of the wild geese which had mindfulness in the lead. But they can come together if we still see mindfulness as the leader, just not the tallest. Mindfulness tells concentration to draw back if he is overreaching, unbalancing the trio. When mindfulness is happy that the trio are well balanced, it is the ability of our minds to focus on whatever is taking our attention that lets the Dhamma clarify for us.

Right effort involves all the energy and resolution we bring to our meditation practice. The Buddha delineates right effort into four components: to prevent unwholesome states from arising, to let go of those that have already arisen, to encourage new wholesome states and to perfect those that have already arisen.

The effort we make to maintain moment-to-moment awareness prevents unwholesome states from arising. If we can maintain awareness at the level of sense contact and feeling, the hindrances don't get a chance to blossom and spread their seeds. This carries out the first component of right effort.

The second component involves the effort we make to hold attention steady on *dukkha*. This allows us let go of hindrances that already cloud our consciousness. As we notice the transitory, uncontrollable nature of pleasure and pain, we undermine desire. Working with aversion brings us to the edge of our comfort zone. Right effort allows us to hold attention there till the boundary starts to dissolve, and we realise it was all illusion. Really, there was nothing to fear or hate. Our efforts to stir energy through physical exercise and mental resolution undermine dullness and lethargy, while the effort to centre attention on some calming focus undermines restlessness. As we stir the factor of investigation, we clarify the Dhamma for ourselves, undermining doubt.

The third component of right effort involves encouraging wholesome states to manifest. This also results from the effort we make to maintain mindfulness in meditation. For example, all seven of the factors of enlightenment are being developed and perfected and these transmute into the five spiritual faculties to help us through daily life.

The final component involves the effort we make in practising *mettā* and the other *Brahmavihāras*. These bring our wholesome states to perfection.

We bring bare attention to our sensory experience including the sixth sense of our mind with its feelings, emotions and thoughts. We sense any reactions to these. Desire trying to wrap us around pleasant feelings. Aversion trying to push away unpleasant

feelings. Delusion trying to shut out physical sensations for the sake of a mental pleasure world. Sensing the pain of reactivity, wisdom persuades us to relax again, to let pleasant and unpleasant sensations be just as they are.

Concentration, the final strand of the Eightfold Path, describes the mind's ability to focus, like looking through a telescope. It brings stillness to the mind by unifying it with undistracted focus on whatever calls attention. Increasingly, what calls attention is *dukkha* and what causes it, as well as the opposite side of the coin, the absence of *dukkha* and the conditions that foster this. In other words, it is the Four Noble Truths that interest us, and their manifestation in our experience is what calls attention.

At times the hindrances are kept in check by the factors of enlightenment, and we sense a current of ease running underneath our usual sense of experience. Our being tiptoes towards the mystery. What is the experience of ease? What would be left of us if there was no urge driving us into action? We become more familiar with the seeming absence of our usual self, with the fluid, changing, unsatisfying nature of the reality we inhabit, and the quiet mystery that runs beneath. This focus is only possible on the back of right effort, our efforts not to grasp at the temporary pleasures of the world and to cultivate instead the qualities that sustain our meditation. And it needs the leadership of mindfulness, the reminder to relax our focus whenever mindfulness senses that new seeds of grasping or aversion are sprouting up. It's easy for these to sprout as we gaze beyond our usual boundaries. We get confused or frightened, restless or dull, or so deeply desiring the end of suffering that we cloud our minds with attachment to progress and aversion to whatever seems to be getting in our way.

The Buddha's promise is that one day the turmoil will end. We will satisfy our desire for the end of suffering. With that we will know for ourselves what remains when all desire fades away.

A quick recap before finishing. The path starts with wisdom. Lost in the jungle of ignorance, we ponder the Buddha's teaching to get an inkling of what causes suffering and what relieves it. As the truth sinks into our heart, our attitude to the world grows friendlier. The jungle doesn't seem quite so impenetrable, and the sword of wisdom cuts through delusion to form a clearing. Here, *sīla* blossoms in the form of right speech, action and livelihood, to be rewarded by the law of *kamma*, opening our hearts to happiness.

We rest a while in the clearing to cultivate our heart and mind in meditation. We make the effort needed to maintain mindfulness. Supported by effort, led and balanced by mindfulness, our mind focuses on the Dhamma and we learn the Four Noble Truths

for ourselves. This sharpens the sword of wisdom, the first strands of the Eightfold Path. Step by step, the Eightfold Path leads us from the jungle of ignorance to the freedom of enlightenment.

I hope this reflection on the Fourth Noble Truth has been helpful. May we and all beings follow the Eightfold Path to the end of suffering.

Free Will

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 40 min

In this exploration, Bhante Bodhidhamma tackles the Western philosophical problem of free will from a Buddhist perspective, revealing how our fixation on choice and control actually deepens suffering. Drawing from the Brahmajāla Sutta (DN 1), he explains how speculative views about freedom are "merely the feeling of those who do not know and see, the worry and uncertainty of those immersed in craving."

The talk examines three Western approaches—fatalism, libertarianism, and determinism—showing how each misses the Buddha's central insight. Using the honey bowl discourse and dependent origination (paṭicca samuppāda), Bhante demonstrates how our experiences arise through contact, feeling, and perception, creating the illusion of a separate self that demands control.

Rather than debating free will, the Buddha's path focuses on clarity and investigation. True freedom comes not through choice but through understanding the conditioned nature of experience and following the Noble Eightfold Path. The talk concludes with the liberating recognition that awakening isn't a choice we make but a discovery we uncover through devoted practice and surrender to the Dhamma.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma sambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

I thought I'd tackle the problem of free will. How does that come up in the Buddha's teaching?

This idea of free will has been with us for a heck of a long time. Even going back, were we at the mercy of the gods or could we instruct the gods to do things for us? So in terms of polytheism, that's how it began - this idea that there was some controlling deity or deities, and the idea was to get them on your side, sympathetic magic, things like that.

Then somehow it corrupted into the idea that if you actually did the ritual perfectly, you could then control. And that was when the Buddha appeared. So the Brahmins there, who controlled the whole business of sacrifice, they knew the specific words,

nobody else could learn them, and they knew the specific action, exactly what to do, and this would bring about the desired results. So there's some sort of free will thrown in there with some sense of control. That's what we want, isn't it? Control.

I think in the West we've cornered ourselves into a very sharp individualism. We don't really see ourselves too much as social beings, as social will. We tend to see ourselves as very little individual pods who demand to do what we want to do. So the idea of free will, especially from the Enlightenment, is something that's core stuff for us. And it comes out, as you'll see when I talk later, in capitalism, the idea of freedom, freedom of choice, all that.

The other thing is that with the Enlightenment - that's ours, 18th century, which I totally believe in, the idea of rational - so free will is to do with something about thinking about it and about coming to some sort of philosophical conclusion that we have or we don't have free will.

But there's a very interesting discourse here, or at least there's a part that really interests me, from the Brahmajāla Sutta, the opening discourse, actually the longer discourse of the longer discourses. And he lists quite a huge amount - I think 64 different speculative views. Some of them you'll have heard of: whether the cosmos was infinite or finite, whether the enlightened person was born or died or what not. And everybody has a view on these things. And this is what he says: he says all such views are merely the feeling of those who do not know and see, the worry and uncertainty of those immersed in craving.

And what catches my attention is "merely the feeling." We tend to be up here, and if we can work something out logically, it separates out from feeling. Therefore you believe in free will, whether you actually feel it or not, or rather you discard feeling, you push it away, on the understanding that there is free will. Even if I don't feel free, so long as I say to myself I am free, I go around thinking that I am free. I don't know if that makes sense. Hopefully, as we go on, it will get more obvious.

If we take another discourse, which the Buddha actually called his honey bowl discourse - it's a delicious sweet you can still buy in India. And he gave a cryptic teaching there, and all these monks who were listening to him didn't ask him anything about it. They went off to this other monk called Mahākaccāna, who was very good at expounding the short teachings of the Buddha. So they ask him, and he says to them, "Why don't you ask him?" And they go, "Right then." They say, "Well, whatever." So he gives them the longer teaching, and then they go back to the Buddha and say, "This is what Mahākaccāna said." It's funny, isn't it? And the Buddha says, "Well, if you'd have asked me, I would have said the same thing." A roundabout way of getting there.

Anyway, the core of it is this. What we counter-know is dependent on contact. That's the part of the Wheel of Dependent Origination, contact. So if it's something that's visual, there's got to be contact at the visual base, the retina. But remember there's also the sixth sense in Buddhism, which is emotion, thought. So something must arise into the mind to make contact - your stimulus. So that's, for instance, when you wake up in the morning. The first thing that comes up, you don't beckon it, it just arises. So much of our day is just stuff arising, either coming from an outside stimulus or from something inside us.

And then he says that upon this, feelings arise, feelings and perceptions. Now, in Buddhist psychology, feeling and perception arises at the same time. And all a feeling is, is a distinguishing in the mind between what is experienced as pleasant or unpleasant. And that's your perception. So whatever feeling arises, as it arises, it's always experienced as neutral. But as soon as you flip into a perception of it, it immediately cuts the world up into likeable, unlikeable.

So, for instance, in your meditation, you might find some emotion arising, which you describe or which you label as, or at least your attitude towards it is unlikeable. It's a bit of depression or something. Now, if you take your attention away from the emotional value of it to the sensation value of it in the body, and you get down to just thick feelings or those feelings that come up with depression, whatever - heat, whatever it is - then you'll see as you move towards that base, the idea of like and dislike begin to fade out a bit, until you can get to a point where there's just sensation. And at that point, you're at the point where the stimulus comes in. So you've gone back on it.

When you do something like that, you begin to realise that it's our definition of things. It's our definition of things which is the core problem, because it comes from our view, our view of something. So, for instance, if we're conditioned to be racist, as soon as we see somebody of another race, unpleasant feelings arise. It'll just happen naturally. If you're not conditioned that way, it doesn't arise. So these feelings that we get are also based on our views and opinions. And they arise with feeling. So the heart-mind work in unison. It's we in the West that have split these two up. If you go East, for instance, to Thailand, when they say - I can't remember what their word is for mind, something like *citta* or something - you'll see they're not actually pointing to the head, they're pointing to the heart.

Then he says, as soon as we perceive something, we'll start thinking about it, and then you get that proliferation.

So now, at the root of this feeling perception is the me. That self-awareness. When you're in meditation and you get that very strong feeling of being an observer, you've distanced, shall we say, so much away from your body, your feelings, your sensations, that you get this feeling of the watcher. Turn on that. Where's that coming from? If you're aware of the watcher, you can't be the watcher. As soon as you make something an object, you can't be it. So, if you're observing and there's that feeling of watching, of a watcher, just shift your attention and try and catch where that feeling's arising from.

So now, as it's most deluded, this me thinks it's this body and mind. And what's its purpose? What does the self want? It just wants to be happy, doesn't it? I want to be happy, full stop. So, in order to be happy, it has that feeling, that need to control. If something painful comes up in the body, it wants to get rid of it, so you take a tablet. If emotions come up that it doesn't like, it just suppresses it. And underneath all that, remember, it's always afraid of the body falling sick, the body dying, the body growing old.

So this business of always wanting to live in a pleasant atmosphere, in a happy atmosphere, is, shall we say, the motivation behind the self. But it's coming from that root misunderstanding that we are this body and this mind and this heart, and the happiness of this body, heart and mind is also dependent on the world. So good food makes me happy. So I want to control my food. I want to be able to cook beautiful things for myself.

So this, of course, the Buddha points out in the second sermon that he gives to these five companions who deserted him because he'd gone a bit soft eating rice pudding. And he points out, he says, "Well, if the self were the body, it'd be able to say, 'be like this, be like that,' be able to control it." He's not talking here about simple movements of lifting something. He's talking about what we really want, which is not to grow old, a bit more beautiful, a bit more handsome, and definitely not to die.

So that we have, that wanting to control is, I think, what we mean by free will, the desire for free will. That's actually what I think we mean at the root of it. Because, if we're to receive what we desire, then we need to control the source of pleasure. Full stop. Simple as that.

Now it's because we fail to do that, in the West anyway, we have these three ideas. They split into fatalism, libertarianism and determinism. So you can read all these philosophers and they'll slot into one of these one way or the other.

So fatalism is just that understanding that actually you don't have any free will at all. In fact the self is utterly impotent. So acts of free will don't have any effect. We don't really have any control over our lives. Anything that happens to us was previously ordained, it's going to happen. So now if on Thursday I'm driving into Newton Abbot, it doesn't matter if I go fast or slow, whether I take this turn or that turn, if I'm going to have a crash, I'm going to have a crash. Full stop. It's bound to happen. You get this view from people who believe in the stars, don't they? And then you get that psychology of self-fulfilling prophecy. So if the stars say, "You're bound to fall in love," then they'll find anyone - a chicken, a horse, whatever - they'll fall in love. It's got to happen.

And when you think about it, the really important things of our lives, well, it's difficult to say we've got any control at all. For instance, we didn't choose to be born. We definitely don't know the hour and day of our death. We didn't have a choice in cultural conditioning. What about things like economic, social, cultural? We just ended up with that. And then there's the elements - mercy of the elements. We don't even choose to fall in love, now that I've mentioned it, actually. And I suppose there's a bit to do, I suppose, with the personality as well. If you're a fatalist, that hopeless resignation. If you're that sort of person, you tend to be one, I think. Or the other side, sanguine optimist or something. I suppose at best it might build up a stoic patience, a fortitude, a stiff upper lip. On with the British.

So this whole idea that we don't have choice, everything's predestined. I mean, it comes up in the spiritual literature too. So in terms of the Buddha's day, there was a Makkhali Gosāla. And all he said was, if you went down one side of the Ganges, doing great acts of compassion and huge donations and he came up the other side murdering and pillaging, it would make a blind bit of difference because the whole road of *kamma* was set. Every soul that was born would have to go through the whole process of karmic refinement and in his case it did actually lead to some sort of heavenly state. But of course it undermines any morality because it doesn't matter what you do in the end because the universe is so manufactured through *saṃsāra* that it'll push you to that definite end - a sort of absolute fatalism.

In Christianity you've got Saint Augustine of course - he started the one about predestination. If God knew everything, he knew whether you were saved or not. And at worst that was Calvinism and Scottish Presbyterianism - you're predestined. From that there came the Protestant work ethic, of course. So that even though you couldn't tell whether somebody was going to go to heaven or hell by their earthly deeds, you can understand that one presumed that if you were successful in business, basically you had to go to heaven. So then you get that work ethic, and people who are rich get to heaven, and people who don't, well, they don't go to heaven. They go to hell.

Islam is also fatalistic. It's all written on the tablet, this original tablet. Your life's written on this tablet. And there was a lovely case I heard of where a friend of mine was working on an oil rig out in the Middle East. And two people fell off the rig, two Westerners. And the current was taking them away, and they were shouting for help. And there were two soldiers just standing there watching them. And the manager came rushing down and threw out the lifeboard, pulled it back in. And he said to these soldiers, "Why didn't you do that? Why didn't you help him?" He said, "The will of Allah." Heavy, isn't it?

And in our existentialism, we've got Albert Camus. He's the one who wrote the myth of Sisyphus. Now, Sisyphus ended up in hell, if I remember rightly, because of avarice. And his job, if you remember, was to roll a boulder up a hill, and then, of course, it would go down the other side, so he had to go back down and roll it back up. And for Camus, that was the metaphor of life. Every morning, you roll this thing to the top, and overnight it fell back down again. And when he came to make a judgment about what was the point of having a consciousness which suffered? What was the point of that? It's absolutely absurd. Take God away, take any ultimate freedom away, take the idea of salvation or *Nibbāna* or liberation away. What's the point of being conscious when it's such a misery? So his idea was that a human being, really to maintain his dignity, he only had one choice, which was to commit suicide. Luckily he was saved, the consequence of his own philosophy. Died in a car accident. One wonders whether he'd have carried that one through, actually.

So that's all there's been to fatalism, and definitely the Buddha wasn't into that. Predestination, everything's set.

The opposite of that, of course, is libertarianism. And that, I think, is definitely the fruit of our enlightenment, 18th century enlightenment. Here, of course, it gets corrupted when a person says they want to do their own thing in their own way in their own time - a teenage rebellion. But the idea is that we do feel empowered to make choices. And when you look back, of course, you do see that you have made certain choices. I mean, you could think that those choices are conditioned, but from a libertarian point of view, there's this bit of rationality come in. So that things just don't happen, you can stop, you can think about whether this is good or this is bad. And those decisions, a libertarian would say, are not random, and they're not predetermined. So there's a sense of freedom, a sense of being able to guide one's life. And you can choose - the idea of choice - and thereby we affect our decision-making.

So that view went on to support things like individual rights, freedom of speech, freedom of voting, and indeed the capitalist market, because it's the individual now who has to make choices for themselves, and they build up their own wealth. I mean, that's at its most painful, you might say. On the other hand, it does make an individual entirely responsible for their actions. So if a person ends up a robber, you can't suggest mitigating circumstance. Poverty, it's their choice. It will be a robber, so we'll hang them. Get on your bike when there's unemployment. You blame the worker for lack of skills because they've not got jobs and stuff like that. It leads, doesn't it, to a dog-eat-dog society, if you take it to an extreme.

But the idea of that at a spiritual level, unfortunately from a Buddhist point of view...

Unfortunately, it does give the idea of something inside us, this little person, that is a sort of rational self, detached from the world, able to see things from this vast, indifferent plane, and make decisions about it. Now, from the Buddha's point of view, that's the source of our misery, actually.

So if you walk into a supermarket with the idea of buying biscuits, and you're walking down the aisle, you come across a brand you hadn't seen before, Goblet or something. You pick it up and it says, "Goblet makes you happy." You look at multi-flavoured biscuits. Then you think, well, in my mind I'm going to buy my favourite figs. So there you're stuck between a so-called choice. Well, you can always say, well, all that's heavily conditioned, but there's some sort of rationality there. Do I want this? Do I want that? Feeling.

See, that's the problem with libertarianism, it lifts choice, it lifts freedom into this idea that it's up in the head somewhere. But actually you can see, even on a simple thing like choosing a biscuit, or making a vote, making a vote which we call a freedom of vote, but actually it's your feeling, isn't it? When you see certain politicians, you feel sick. When you see others, you feel happy.

So this business of capitalist freedom of choice, you can definitely argue that it's just juggling with conditioning. And it's based on this immediate fix. See, it's very interesting because before the war, if you look at the adverts before the war for products, they were very centred on the product and very pragmatic. And people only bought what they needed. That was the idea. You only bought what you needed. So if you were selling a clock in an earlier advert, you would simply point out that it has an alarm. It's got red lighting so you can see it in the night. And you'd buy it if you needed it.

If you do it these days, because this was Freud coming through, you've got to put a naked woman next to it. And the desire that comes up is immediately latched onto the clock so you buy it. It keeps you awake.

So that business of a sort of separate rational self, that won't work in the Buddha's teaching. Because that's also embedded.

And the third position is this determinism. So now, here there's the idea that the personal self, that the self does have a choice and it does affect things. So it's unlike fatalism. But unlike libertarianism, even the choices you make are determined. So whatever's going to happen is going to happen. Now, if you think about that, if everything is just cause and effect, cause and effect, as a sort of sequel from the past, it's very difficult to imagine anything but a repetitive universe. Where does the newness come in? Where does something stop this chain of cause and effect? How is it that we have actually a very creative universe? So it can't be just as simple as a direct historical cause and effect.

The Jains seem to have held that in the Buddhist scriptures. Now, you've got to be careful here because this is Buddhist propaganda. There's a man called Upali, for instance, who was a great supporter of the Buddha, a very rich person. And he told the Jain leader, Nigantha, some teaching about what the Buddha had given. And the Nigantha sent him, delegated him to go to the Buddha to prove him wrong. So, of course, Upali gets up to the Buddha there and starts his discussion. And by the end of it, he becomes a follower of the Buddha.

So he wants to become a follower. He says, you know, and I shall leave the Nigantha. This is where the Buddha's magnanimity, one of the little examples of his magnanimity, is, well, don't. Don't stop supporting your other teacher. You can support me, but don't stop supporting him. Anyway, Upali returns back to the Nigantha and tells him that he's now been converted. And the Nigantha, it seems, is so angry that he spews blood and dies. So it's that sort of tale which makes you think, well, when they're talking about Jains, maybe it's a bit of propaganda. I think he died in the Jain way, starving himself to death.

And what the Buddha points out about the Jain theory, which was some idea of pre-destination, you had to stop. You had to stop doing. So you stopped killing, and eventually you stopped eating. The idea was just to draw *kamma* to an end. So the Jain saint actually dies of starvation. You build up your courage for it, I suppose. What the Buddha points out is that even that decision is part of *kamma*. That actually won't end the sequence of cause and effect. It's like when we don't do something has an effect.

Even if you take this gathering now, we've all come from different paths to create this particular situation. And in this situation, hopefully something creative is happening. Only because we've all come here from different places. So there is something about the way the universe works which is about different lines of cause and effect meeting at a certain point to create something new.

So we see that these three perspectives, fatalism, determinism, libertarianism, I think we might argue that if you look back in time, you might just get the feeling that everything has been predetermined. Your life's actually been fairly set, and you didn't have much of a choice, and you've ended up where you are because... But when you're actually stuck in a present dilemma, when you're actually stuck between this and that, it definitely feels like you've got a choice. So again, it's to do with feeling. It's to do with the way we're looking at something as to which side of this business you tend to fall on.

Anyway, you might be relieved to know that from the Buddha's point of view, we're simply asking the wrong question. So you can now forget the first part of this particular essay. Because this whole business of free will just arises out of this profound delusion beneath us, this nebulous idea of me, me in control. So as the self discovers the world, there's pleasant, unpleasant experiences, so it wants to create something out of it, this dualistic world. So all things are over there as rivals or this side as accomplices. It's just driven by greed, aversion, indulging, accumulating, rejecting, annihilating. And it's this way that the self gains this idea of power. It's just a little game it's playing.

So obviously the right question is, how do we put an end to suffering? Remember that the Buddha always reduced his teaching to a very simple statement, suffering and the end of suffering, full stop. So the question is, how do we end suffering? And how do you get down to really cut the root?

The first thing is to understand this business about conditionality. And as we've already said, it's a concurrence of past events meeting present situations, which allows us this feeling of creativity, something new all the time.

Secondly, the aim is not concerned with freedom of choice at all. The aim to end suffering is not to do with choice at all. It's to do with clarity. It's to do with seeing where the path is. It's to do with investigation and exploration of our lives and the way things are and how it is that we keep falling into suffering.

If you, like for instance, if we set out for a walk in the country, you've already decided where you want to go. It's not random. You've decided where you want to go. So in one sense, you want to be happy. You want to find this happiness. And you've got your map. You've got your compass. When you come to a fork in the road, you don't

choose, well, shall I go down this one or shall I go down that one? You already know where you're going to go. And all you've got to do is consult the map and make the right decision.

So in the Buddha's path, the path is already delineated. So this choice, this feeling of choice that we have, turns out to be nothing but a doubt. It's not actually... See, the self lifts it up to the idea of, well, shall I do this or shall I do that? But actually, if you know all the facts, you wouldn't have a choice. The path would be just directly in front of you. Spiritually speaking, especially.

So, there's two types of doubt when I say doubt. There's what you might call honest doubt and sceptical doubt. So, honest doubt is just coming from that business of not knowing. And it comes from, shall we say, a sense of a grounded humility. Like, I don't know. I really don't know. Accepting that. And it's a very difficult place to be, isn't it? We like to know. That not knowing can cause us extreme anxiety. Like you don't know whether you're going to have the job next week. You don't know whether the cheque's going to come. It creates anxiety.

But if we can sit patiently, if we can sit calmly within that not knowing and accept that state and then just keep looking, keep observing, then the path manifests. It either manifests because somebody's pointed it out to us or because our own experience manifests. One of the points in the process of these vipassanā ñāṇa, the vipassanā understandings, is the business of what is the path and what is not the path.

And it's a very simple thing, most of you have probably been there, is that in your meditation you'll suddenly start maybe getting these beautiful states. They're very peaceful, very spaced out, very lovely and joyful. And of course there's the self immediately wants to get in there and say, well this is it, finally I made it. I remember one man told me he had this, quite deluded really, he had this amazing experience while sitting on the toilet. Now that's not relevant. You can have these amazing experiences anywhere. Remember that Luther had his great breakthrough while he was sitting on the toilet. It's faith only.

But he absolutely insisted. He said it was Nibbāna. And just what he was describing was just amazing. A blissful state, really. So, knowing that whatever nibbāna is, it is not felt. Whatever nibbāna is, it is not an emotional state. Whatever nibbāna is, it cannot be described. Immediately, it takes you off that indulgence. That's a correction. That's a correction to that not knowing, that doubt which comes up from, shall we say, this desire to seek the end of suffering. That's a wisdom thing. That's coming from something deeper than the self.

When you get the doubt which is really a sceptical doubt, a doubt which is a mental illness in the same way that sloth and torpor and all these hindrances are, then of course there's something else going on there, and that's usually a fear of commitment, usually a fear of giving yourself to something because you don't know what's going to happen, but that fear stops you committing and therefore stops you meditating.

One of the people who used to organise the meditation group, his father, when he was a young child, put him on a table and opened up his arms and said, "Jump, son." And he jumped and he moved away. Splat on the ground, he said. And he says, "That'll teach you. Don't trust anybody." You can imagine, yeah? So when he came to the Buddha's teaching, it was quite amazing that he should actually put his heart and soul into it.

So, just to be aware of that, that the path isn't about, shall I do this or shall I do that? And that's one reason for a schedule. You set your schedule down, a schedule that you know you can follow, and you just do that religiously. You don't let this little self come in and say, "Well, shall I do it? Can't do it? Maybe a little kip. I'll go for a walk. Don't feel like it." And all the time you're just feeding the self.

When it comes to joining the order, you say, look, I don't get up in the morning and say, shall I wear blue? It doesn't occur. Even the idea of what shall I eat? What am I going to eat? So it's taking out all that edge around where the self can manifest. It doesn't mean to say it doesn't manifest in very peculiar and staged ways, but at least you try and draw a circle around what you can do, what you can't do. And then you liberate. That's the benefit. You then liberate this wisdom factor, this *paññā*, this intuitive intelligence to investigate.

If this intuitive intelligence gets locked into what the self wants to do, then it's just taken all over the place. Fine, you feel nice when you get out for a walk, but has it helped you overcome suffering? Not at all. All it's done is it's given you a greater addiction to walking the countryside. Just deepening your attachment to the country. Which I've learnt since coming down to Devon, by the way. Terrible.

We could almost say, if you really think about it, when have you been most happy? Isn't it when you've been doing exactly what you wanted to do? The actual doing of it. It's never occurred, has it? When you've been doing exactly what you wanted to do, it's never occurred, shall I do this or shall I not do that? And it's the same with interest. If you notice, whenever you're interested in something, do you ever have any problems with concentration? No. So a lot of our practice is giving up that choice, is raising the interest to discover the path. And all that stuff just follows naturally, the clarity and all that, and the energy and the concentration.

Now when it comes to will itself, there is will, there is will in terms of power. The Buddha equates that to action. So he states it quite clearly. Will I call action. So those of you who know the Wheel of Dependent Origination, there comes that point, so we say it starts off with that contact we talked about. It starts off with a perception feeling of being pleasant, unpleasant. It would then have that reaction of wanting, not wanting. That's your *taṇhā*.

Only then does this self come in. Which is very interesting because in language we say, "I want that." But actually it's, "that want I." That's how it happens in terms of psychology. As soon as that "I" comes in, you can't stop it, you've empowered it. As soon as that "I" says, "I want," then you get that empowerment, that's the will coming in, and you have that next link, *bhava*, which is becoming. That's when you become, that's your act. Act of thought, word or deed.

So that's why in your meditation, when it comes to things like pleasant, unpleasant, you just want to keep the mind very close to that business of wanting, not wanting, liking, not liking, wanting, not wanting. And that's the way out to liberation by understanding *dukkha*, by understanding suffering and unsatisfactoriness.

So this power that we have is quite mysterious. It's totally neutral. It's not good or bad. It depends how you use it. It depends on your attitude. And you can't separate it from the action. You can try. When you do walking meditation, just stand there. Keep saying, "intending to walk. Intending to walk." And even though you're saying it and intending it, nothing's going to happen. And then suddenly the foot lifts. So what is it that has taken something out of a potential into an actual? That's what the Buddha's calling will. And you can't separate it from your foot. You can't say, well, that's it over here, and this is my foot over here. It's one and the same thing. It's within the structure of this whole becoming business.

But the power of that will is your conditioning. So remember, an action forms an intention, moves you to an action. And if that action is wholesome or unwholesome, then you're going to get the product of that conditioning. So if it's an unwholesome action, it moves you towards an unwholesome conditioning. This is inwardly. Remember, all kamma in terms of liberation is inward. It's not something to do with the outside world at all, actually.

And anything you do which is wholesome, it will produce that wholesome conditioning within you. And in Buddhist understanding, that's what's driving us to a particular destiny. And that's why, of course, in the Noble Eightfold Path, right view heads it. As soon as you understand, as soon as there's a seeing, as soon as there's a perception of the way things are, this immediately informs your attitude.

Of course, when it gets down into the attitude, you may find the opposite attitude to be too strong. So you might go down and you very clearly perceive that the body does not need tea. But that's not going to stop you doing it because of this huge conditioning to drink tea. But at least there's the perception that at this present time the body doesn't actually need tea, and it's hanging on to that and waiting for that to drop into the heart as an attitude. And then it balances up with the desire to have tea, and eventually because you're not feeding the desire to have tea anymore, that drops away, and the right attitude of seeing food and water and all that as nourishment for the body—not as a place for seeking happiness—begins to get the upper hand and lead you to the enlightenment. That's the one I'm struggling with!

So that's called *dharmachanda*, the will for Dhamma. And that translates into Mahāyāna as the *bodhicitta*, the heart seeking enlightenment. So eventually, that's the force. That's the force behind your drive to liberation.

And just finally, to end off with this lovely refrain: when anybody gets liberated, you always get this little refrain at the end of it. "Birth is destroyed"—now, this is the birth of self, remember. "The holy life has been lived. What had to be done has been done. There is no more coming into any state of self-existence." Can you feel the relief in that? What had to be done has been done.

So it's a case really of being clear that the path to enlightenment isn't a choice. It's not a choice. It's a discovery. What leads us to it is the general dissatisfaction about our lives. And once you perceive which way to go, then it's a case of building up that courage, that determination, resolution to follow it. And then, of course, you get the benefit of it.

That's the answer. That's what we have to do. So, what's the message? Abandon free will. Devote yourself. Surrender to the path.

May these words have been of awesome help to you in your path to liberation. Thank you very much.

Free Will: Is It Available or Useful?

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 12 min read

This essay examines the Western philosophical problem of free will through the lens of Buddhist psychology and understanding. Bhante Bodhidhamma explores three Western positions—fatalism, libertarianism, and determinism—showing how each reflects different feelings about control and choice that arise from the fundamental delusion of selfhood. Drawing on the Brahmajāla Sutta (DN 1) and the Buddha's second discourse to the five companions, he demonstrates how our sense of having free will stems from the self's desire to control experience and avoid suffering.

The essay reveals how the Buddha reframes the entire question: rather than asking whether we have free will, we should ask how to end suffering. True freedom is not the ability to choose according to our desires, but liberation from the very self that experiences choice as a dilemma. On the spiritual path, clarity replaces choice—when we understand what needs to be done according to Dhamma, there is no hesitation or doubt, only purposeful action guided by Right View.

This teaching offers profound insight into how attachment to personal agency creates suffering, and how the Eightfold Path provides a clear direction that transcends the illusion of individual choice. The ultimate freedom is not free will, but the Arahant's complete surrender and release from the burden of selfhood.

Free will: is it available or useful?

In truth, it is preferable not to have choice...

Free will has been a problem since the dawning of consciousness. Are we completely at the mercy of the gods or do we have some control over our lives? Is there a measure of free will? Do we really have choices? Is having choice the same as free will? In the highly

individualistic culture of the West, the sense of being an individual as opposed to a social

being or indeed another animal embedded in nature, makes the notion of free will, freedom

of choice, very much part of our self definition.

However, from the Buddha's point of view it is not a question we should be asking because

it is leading us astray ... But let us first look at the notion of free will.

Our culture, with its biased emphasis towards thought, rationalises our desire for freedom.

We generally think only in terms of what we are free to 'think and do'. There is our much

vaunted freedom of thought and speech. And freedom to act whether it be something trivial, such as which soup to buy, or of great importance, such as the decision to take a job. As to exactly how free we really are becomes a bone of contention between different

philosophies.

However, in ordinary daily life, whatever the arguments are, we 'feel' ourselves to be in turn

restricted and confined or 'free and easy'. ♦ And this is the starting place for the Buddha.

In the Discourse on the Supreme Net (Brahmajala Sutta, No 1 in the Long Discourse), he lists many views around such speculative topics as whether the world is eternal or not, whether it is infinite or not, whether the self is eternal or not and so on. All such views he

says are 'merely the feeling of those who do not know and see, the worry and uncertainty of

those immersed in craving'. ♦

So how do our feelings influence our view of free will? According to the Buddha's psychology

whatever we come to know is dependent on contact, by which is meant stimuli coming from

one of the six senses, the sixth being that part of our mind (some would prefer brain) that

receives not only these outer stimuli but stimuli arising within the mind by way of memory.

From contact arise feelings which are perceived as pleasant, unpleasant or neutral. Feelings

and perceptions arise simultaneously. As soon as we perceive something, we begin to think

about it. And this thinking proliferates, fuelled as it were by that feeling (emotions and moods) which finds expression and relief in thinking and imagining.

If, for instance, boredom arises in my mind, there will be an immediate desire to seek distraction.

I decide to eat something. If there is nothing to snack on, I feel frustrated. My free will is thwarted. So all thinking and imagining turns out to be but metaphor for our feelings. This

may come as a surprise. But think of the 'isms' of the last century, for example Fascism and

Communism. Each has elicited a tremendous amount of emotion from its followers.

Now, the root feeling-perception we have is of being 'me'. That self-awareness, the feeling

of presence, lies at the heart of our relationship to the world. At its most deluded, the 'me'

believes itself to be this body and personality. The fundamental aim of the self is to feel safe and happy in this body and heart-mind and in the world. So, in order to fulfil that aim, it desires to control the body, emotions and thinking as well as the world with all its

sentient beings, including humans of course, and objects and the whole of nature to boot!

It is fearful of the body falling sick and dying. It likes to live in an interior atmosphere of

happiness so it suppresses anything it experiences as painful, such as fear and depression

and indulges whatever it experiences as pleasurable, such as sex, greed, attachment to people, love of arts and so on. When the self can fulfil these desires and feel happy, it has

exercised its free will freely.

In the second talk that the Buddha gives to the five companions soon after his enlightenment, however, he points out how this self wants to be in control. He states: 'If the self were in control of the body, it would be able to say: Be like this, or be like that, but

since it is not in control of the body, it therefore cannot be the body.' Here, the Buddha is

not talking about simple movements, but the body as an organism. We cannot make it grow

any taller or prevent it from growing old and so on.

This wanting to control is what the Buddha would have said we really mean by free will. For

after all, if we are to receive all that we desire then we need to be in control of the pleasure

we seek. With money, for instance, we can satisfy our sensual pleasure. But then we need

to be in control of how much money we have. So it is because we fail to achieve this that

different views have arisen on this subject. And in our Western philosophy and religious tradition we have three main positions: fatalism, libertarianism and determinism. Fatalism is the view that the self is impotent. Acts of will by the self have no effect. It is that feeling of having no control over our lives. Everything that happens has been previously ordained and the self can do nothing about it. ♦ It does not matter whether I run, walk or skip blindfolded across the road, I shall only be knocked over if it was bound to happen anyway. Such a view can engender a hopeless resignation or sanguine optimism that we might be lucky. It is all in the stars. Or then a person may respond with stoic patience and fortitude.

Even though this is an extreme position, there is plenty in our life experience that seems to support this view. After all, we did not choose to be born, nor do we know the hour or day of our death. We have had no choice in the cultural conditioning we have received. We can do little about the economic-social-political conditions we find ourselves in. We are at the mercy of the elements. We do not even choose to fall in love. Indeed, when we look back on our lives we can get a feeling that what we thought in the moment were choices were actually no choices at all, but simply what was going to happen anyway!

Such belief also has spiritual consequences. For what then is the point of choosing to do good or bad? It will not make the slightest bit of difference to what is going to happen. In the Buddha's day, such a belief was taught by a certain Makhali Gosala. He said if one were to go down one side of the Ganges, murdering and pillaging or come up the other side with great acts of generosity and compassion, it would not make the slightest bit of difference.

It is also the doctrine first propounded by St. Augustine that since God knew everything, he

knew who was to be saved and who was to be damned. Taken to its extreme, the doctrine of predestination, especially as it was explicated by Calvinistic Protestantism, meant that no matter how you behaved, it was already ordained that you would spend eternity in hell or heaven.

Islam can also be fatalistic in the same way, saying it is all the Will of Allah. Indeed, when one considers the inherent suffering in being alive, the inability to find permanent comfort, it is not difficult to take a fatalistic position. Albert Camus, the existentialist novelist and philosopher, felt that it was absurd to suffer a life that only offered dissatisfaction and death. He thought the only way human beings could maintain their dignity in the face of a purposeless existence was either by stoic acceptance or by committing suicide! In the end, a fatalist feels disempowered. The Buddha, on the other hand, empowers us to seek our true destiny to become like him a completely liberated being.

Libertarianism, on the other hand, is the understanding that we do have free will. That 'we can do our own thing in our own way, in our own time'. Such a person feels empowered to make choices and believes in the power of positive thinking. Again looking back on our lives, we can see that decisions made in childhood are still having their effect, such as choices we made about what we wanted to study and what sort of work we wanted to do. It is we after all who create our own perceptions of the world and then try to manipulate the world to fit in with our desires. We may not always get what we want, but we would not get anything were it not for the freedom of our will to choose what we want. Indeed, when we take the time to ponder situations, we can make rational and responsible decisions which effect the situation. Such actions are not, therefore, predetermined nor are they random. For instance,

rather than be ensnared in power games with people at work, I can sit back for a moment, think about the way things are and make decisions to undermine those power games and

work towards harmony.

Such a view supports the notion of individual rights, free voting and free speech and even

on a more abstract level, a capitalist market left to its own communal dynamic, its own 'free

will'. However, it can tend to put the accent too much on the individual and underplay the

effects of society. The individual is made entirely responsible for their acts without any mitigating circumstance. For instance, in high unemployment, the fault can be placed on

the worker for not searching for work, dismissing as unimportant the prevailing economic

situation the worker finds themselves in, or blaming the worker's lack of skills training which,

of course, does make them unable to respond creatively. Such extreme forms of capitalism

lead to a dog-eat-dog society, where some gain the exercise of free will that comes with power and others find themselves utterly disempowered to make any choice that might change their situation.

At a spiritual level, libertarianism gives lie to the idea that there is a rational self somehow

detached from the world which, from a godlike position, can intervene in events. It is that

feeling of 'me' again. A 'me' that floats within the world untouched by it, yet able to act upon it. A 'me' that is not part of the chain of cause and effect. From the Buddha's point of

view, this is the source of all our misery! The self is as conditioned as everything else.

We say the Buddha was self-enlightened. But what do we actually mean by that? Does it equate to the Western idea of the self-made man, the self-made woman? Such ideas give the impression that such people arrived at their achievements without the help of any other

person whatsoever. But riches, fame and power are gained by the support of others - if not

on their backs. The Buddha would have been the first to acknowledge his indebtedness

to

all the teachers who had influenced him. For surely, it was gratitude that made him think

of offering his teaching to his two main teachers. It was the fact that no-one in his day, as far as we know, had reached the full enlightenment, and the final leap, as it were, had

to be into an unknown that made him self-enlightened and thereby able to start a new dispensation.

The third position is determinism. Here, unlike fatalism, personal decision-making does have

an effect on events. But unlike libertarianism, it understands that personal decision-making

is also part of the cause and effect chain. In the Buddhist scriptures, the Jains are said to hold this view, but only as a strictly historical sequence. It meant that the work of a spiritual

seeker was simply to put an end to the effects of past kamma. So, one stopped doing anything and finally one stopped eating altogether. This was the proper end of whoever sought the Jain path to liberation. The Buddha's response was that this did not take into account present decisions. Even the present decision to stop eating was an act of will and

therefore would have karmic effects. There was no escape from karma. Even an enlightened

being produces karma, but since all delusion of self is gone, there is no more attachment

and so no self-becoming.

As for these perspectives, fatalism, determinism and libertarianism, it might be argued that

it is when we look back on events that there may arise that feeling that everything has turned out just as it was meant to. We can feel that events have occurred and would have

occurred despite our decision-making. But when we are struggling in the present with a choice - whether to change jobs or not, whether to get married or not - we can have the feeling that we do have a freedom of choice and that our choice will have a considerable, if

not at times a revolutionary, effect on our lives.

However, from the Buddha's point of view, we are asking the wrong question. Free will or

no free will, the problem lies in the inherent unsatisfactoriness of life. At the most profound

level, the level from which all consequent illusions arise, we find the 'me', this nebulous idea

of a self. The self discovers that the world is full of pleasant experiences and unpleasant experiences. It creates a dualistic world, itself opposed to other - whether accomplice or rival - and the pleasant opposed to the unpleasant. It enters a game driven by greed and aversion - indulging and accumulating or rejecting and annihilating. So it is that the self feels itself to have power, the power to choose.

The right question, then, is how do we put an end to suffering? And to do so means to cut

at the very root. First of all we need to correct our understanding about conditionality. There is indeed cause and effect coming through from past events. But there are also conditions that arise from different sources, which add a chaotic element to the otherwise

preconditioned moment. At the beginning of any course on meditation that I teach, a group

of people arrives from different starting points, different lines of cause and effect. Coming

together, they now influence each other, in the creative, dynamic present. The outcome of

the course will depend on that unforeseeable mix of people.

Secondly, because the aim is to put an end to suffering, the concern is not with freedom of choice arising out of the self's definition of free will, but with discovering the Path to liberation - a liberation from that delusion of a self. In truth, it is preferable not to have choice but simply to be clear as to which way to go. When we set out for a country walk, we are clear about the destination. We have a map and compass and we set out. Should we come to an ambiguous fork, we stop and consult the map. The walk is a process of discovering a piece of countryside with the joyous grand finale at a teashop! The Eightfold

Path is a blueprint which saves us from the dilemmas of seeing the world as a procession of

choices which lead to success or failure. It presents life more as an exploration, one of trial

and error. Even error is part of the Path. It is learning what is not the Path.

So, choices turn out to be but doubt. On the one hand the ignorant self, driven by greed and aversion; on the other hand a growing wisdom, driven by the desire to be liberated from that very self. The search is for clarity. With clarity arises the knowledge that this has

to be done. Freedom of choice does not come into the reckoning. For choice on the spir-

itual

path is a manifestation of dilemma, of 'don't know'. 'Should I follow this path or that path? Should I stay with this teacher or find another? I seem to be getting nowhere in my

meditation, what should I do?' When we do discover what it is we ought to do to follow the

Path, we feel safe, satisfied and eager. That is why we are ♦ at our happiest when all choice

is removed and we are doing exactly what we ought to be doing according the Dhamma.

Yet there is will. The Buddha equates will with action. It is a power that produces a thought,

word or deed out of a desire. It is what actualises our wishes. In itself, it is neither good nor

bad, skilful nor unskilful. All that is determined by our attitude, which again arises out of our

wisdom or lack of it. So it is that Right View heads the Eightfold Path. And the will supports

that desire to be liberated. This is known as dhamma cetana. It is the force that powers the

seeker along the Path.

So when choice arises out of the self, the self deludes us into thinking, 'I should be able to exercise my free will to satisfy my desire'. But in the spiritual life, when choice arises, it arises because of doubt as to what to do. That is why we go to the Dhamma, to the teaching, for guidance. It is the Buddha within seeking the Path and it is usually exactly what 'I' don't want to do.

So when someone is liberated, it is the freedom from that self, from the illusion of choice

arising out of the notion of free will, that the Buddha says is the one taste of Nibbana just

as salt is the one taste of the ocean. Not the unsatisfiable freedom of the hungry self, but the freedom of one released from prison. That is why whenever someone is liberated and

attains the end of the path and becomes an Arahant, there is no mention of free will, but of

surrender. Here is the normal scriptural refrain of someone who is liberated:

Birth is destroyed.

The holy life has been lived.

What had to be done has been done.

There is no more rebirth into any state of 'self' existence.

Full Catastrophe Ethics

Noirin Sheahan · 3 min read

Noirin Sheahan examines how to respond skillfully to the overwhelming reality of climate change and potential social collapse. Drawing from a bioethics paper endorsed by Buddhist scholar Joanna Macy, she presents six ethical maxims for navigating environmental crisis: grasping the immensity of what's coming, cultivating radical hope beyond optimism, maintaining ethical boundaries, appreciating this unique historical moment, training body and mind for resilience, and acting for future generations of all species. The essay explores how common reactions to climate news—anxiety, rage, numbness, despair—can be transformed through these practices. Sheahan connects each maxim to the potential for deeper Dhamma practice, suggesting that climate collapse presents both unprecedented challenge and spiritual opportunity. She emphasizes how Buddhist principles of interconnectedness, non-attachment, and compassionate action provide essential resources when external securities fail. The essay concludes with an invitation to explore how these maxims align with Buddhist teachings and can be integrated into meditation and daily life practice, offering a framework for maintaining integrity and purpose amid civilizational uncertainty.

Full Catastrophe Ethics.

How do you react to news of climate change and forecasts of ice-caps melting, cities flooding or burning, widespread drought and famine, breakdown of essential services like water and electricity, hundreds of millions of refugees seeking homes in temperate regions like ours? Do you shrink into a ball of anxiety and disbelief? Weep? Pound your fists in frustration and rage? Numb out? Feel totally out of your depth and inadequate? Trust the scientists to find a way out?

Any or all of these happen for me depending on circumstances. Afterwards I might be prompted to read some relevant articles, sign a petition, donate to an environmental cause, re-commit to living sustainably, toy with the possibility of learning basic survival skills. Then I'll turn back to more immediate concerns. Till the next depressing news bulletin.

The 'out of my depth and inadequate' feeling I find particularly troublesome. It begs so many questions. Surely there is something I can do to help myself face what might be coming down the tracks?

I was relieved and grateful therefore to come across a bioethics paper suggesting ethical maxims that we can practice to help us face the environmental and social disaster that the authors see coming as soon as 2031 – only nine years away!!!

The paper was publicized in a recent Zoom event featuring Joanna Macey, the renowned author, climate activist and Buddhist scholar in conversation with the authors of the paper. She enthusiastically endorsed their suggestion to prepare ourselves so as to behave with as much integrity as possible in the face of environmental and social breakdown. Here's a brief summary of their suggested maxims:

Work Hard to Grasp the Immensity. The possibility of environmental and subsequent social collapse is inconceivable for most of us. We enter a fog where we no longer know how to think, where right and wrong become meaningless. And yet that incomprehension may be a necessary steppingstone to the next maxim.

Cultivate Radical Hope. This not based on optimism that some solution can be found to restore the social security we now enjoy. Having worked through grief and anger and a depth of despair, hope takes the form of faith that some values are worth preserving to the end - kindness, not abandoning people, behaving with integrity.

Radical hope sees openings for positive action, finds gaps in the gloom.

Have a Line in the Sand. Know that there are some things you will not do, some actions you will not embrace. Be prepared to die rather than cross your red line.

Appreciate the Astonishing and Unique Opportunity. Acknowledge what an extraordinary transition is coming for humanity and the biosphere. Appreciate what is vanishing before your eyes, be glad for every blade of grass that is still green, every tree still standing. Practice gratitude for being alive now, able to breathe now.

Train Your Body and Your Mind. Develop the capacity to deal with despair. Learn skills for getting beyond the limits of ego. Climate collapse will bring widespread physical, psychological, and spiritual trauma. As our physical and social resources

shrink, our mental and spiritual resources will become ever more valuable to ensure human survival and flourishing.

Act for the Future Generations of All Species. Think beyond yourself and your immediate circle. Act for the benefit of the poor, future generations, other species, forests, seas and mountains. Act, personally and politically, to limit the damage - every 0.5° C increase avoided will save millions of lives, species, resources. We are all in this together, interconnected, a multiplex unity.

The authors of the paper aren't proposing these maxims as absolutes, but as a bare beginning that will provoke discussion. Personally I feel very grateful to have this skeleton upon which I can begin to take on board the spiritual challenge that is to come.

Over the coming months I hope to examine each maxim in more depth, see how it ties in with the Dhamma, see how we could put the maxim into practice in our meditation and daily life. I hope to be back with a series of tips on the subject and if

any of you would like to practice alongside me on this, please get in touch.

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Greed, Hatred and Delusion as Foundations for Mindfulness

Noirin Sheahan · 43 min

In this retreat talk, Noirin Sheahan returns to the jewel of the Buddha's teachings, the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10), focusing particularly on the third foundation - contemplation of mind (cittānupassanā). She explores how the three mental poisons of greed (rāga), hatred (dosa), and delusion (moha) can become objects of mindful investigation rather than obstacles to overcome.

The talk distinguishes between skillful desire (chanda) and reactive craving (taṇhā), showing how even beneficial activities like gardening or parenting can involve both wholesome motivation and subtle greed. Through practical examples, Noirin demonstrates how to work with anger using the Buddha's teaching of the two arrows - the initial hurt and our reactive response that creates additional suffering.

Drawing on the Dhammapada's instruction to guard the mind, she guides practitioners in recognizing these mental states both internally and externally, seeing their arising and passing away. This contemplation develops the capacity to rest awareness within difficult mind states without identification, gradually weakening their hold and opening pathways to greater freedom and compassion.

Tonight I'd like to revisit what's held as the jewel of the Buddha's teachings, the *Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta*, focusing especially on the third part, contemplation of mind. *Satipaṭṭhāna*, remember, is often translated as a foundation or support, or more evocatively, as a posture for mindfulness, a resting place for awareness.

There are four *satipaṭṭhānas*: body, feelings, mind and *dharmas*, the last one including the main teachings of the Buddha. When we're in the third *satipaṭṭhāna*, we're directing attention inwards into our mind.

Sometimes the Buddha distinguishes between consciousness, *viññāṇa* in Pali, and the mind, the *nāma* component of *nāmarūpa*. Consciousness is the knowing of experience, while *nāma* comprises mental factors like will and perception, which can in themselves be known. The analogy often used is a movie theatre with consciousness as the screen and *nāma* as the picture we see on the screen. For *satipaṭṭhāna* meditation we include both screen and the movie, the knowing and the mental factors that can be known.

In this *satipaṭṭhāna*, we're looking backwards, you could say, looking into what's looking. We're letting attention rest within the mind that's asking attention to rest. This is possible because the mind has a receptive aspect, the mind door, as well as its active components like perception, attention and intention, the components that enable it to direct experience, to focus attention, to cognize.

The mind door is similar to the physical senses and is considered as the sixth sense in Buddhism. The receptive aspect of mind can detect mental activity and thereby act as a doorway, allowing that mental activity become conscious.

The guidance for this *satipaṭṭhāna* starts with: "And how does one abide contemplating mind as mind? Here one knows mind affected by greed as mind affected by greed and mind unaffected by greed as mind unaffected by greed." The Pali word *rāga* is used here which can be translated as greed, lust, passion, attachment or craving.

In Western culture, passion can be seen in a positive light, as when somebody says, "I'm passionate about gardening." Likewise, we often think of attachment in positive terms. Mother and baby, for example, are encouraged to make a strong bond of attachment. And if this doesn't happen, they both suffer emotionally. But in Buddhism, we speak of passion and attachment in the same sense as greed, lust and craving. Along with hatred and delusion, *rāga* is described as one of the three poisons of the mind.

How can we think the attachment between mother and baby in terms of mental poison? And what about passion? Are we never to get enthusiastic about anything?

The Buddhist term *chanda* can be used to describe skillful desire. Ajahn Sucitto describes *chanda* as "desire as an eagerness to offer, to commit, to apply oneself to meditation. It's a psychological yes, a choice, not a pathology." *Chanda*, skillful desire, is in contrast to *taṇhā*, which is the desire that comes in reaction to our feelings. *Taṇhā* leads to suffering, as we vainly try to grasp pleasures that are always slipping through our fingers, whereas *chanda* is grounded in wisdom rather than reactive delusion.

If we're passionate about gardening, we can bring this into our Dhamma path by reflecting on the benefits, for example, care for the earth, respect for nature, beautifying the world, giving pleasure to others, promoting bodily and mental health. We can see gardening as *muditā*, appreciating the good things in life. But greed can easily slip in, as when we want to have the best garden in the neighbourhood. Although the activity is skilful, we can start grasping after its fleeting pleasures and turn it into something stressful.

It's similar for the attachment between parent and child. Parenthood can be brought into our Dhamma path by reflecting on the goodness involved. When the child brings joy, we can be grateful, remembering that joy itself is part of the spiritual path. But again, we have to guard against role identification, otherwise we will be devastated when the child disappoints us or flees the nest. Once we get emotionally involved in how we want our children to turn out, we're on the slippery slope.

Because we're not yet enlightened, all our attachments are going to have some level of greed as well as compassion, goodwill and *muditā*. Even during meditation practice, we'll all spend some time craving a better meditation. In this Sutta, the Buddha clarifies that this is not a problem. All we have to do is recognize the mind state of greed when it is present. We don't have to judge it as wrong or combat it in any way. We only have to know the experience of greed while it is present.

By simply noting "greed, greed" whenever this arises, we learn not to identify with the mind state. It is just another phenomenon arising due to conditions. It doesn't represent me. The more we clarify this, the less we will be troubled or controlled by the state. Greed will be welcome when it comes, because we're interested to get to know its raw energies.

Whenever we notice ourselves wanting a better meditation, we have a golden opportunity to get to know greed. There may be some pleasant feelings associated with thoughts of insight, peace and tranquility. Probably also unpleasant feelings associated with the fact that these aren't happening right now. Acknowledging both the pleasant and the unpleasant moves us towards equanimity, the objective observer, the bird-watcher in the hide.

This, of course, is a very wise and worthy state of being, the state we normally cultivate in *vipassanā*. But to get to know the mind state of greed a bit better, we can creep out of the hide, get a bit closer to those birds which fascinate us. Of course, we have to be very patient, knowing we'll scare away the birds at the slightest noise. And we must be prepared for a long wait back in the hide whenever this happens, letting body awareness cool whatever passions have been generated.

When we're studying the mind state of greed, the bird we want to see more clearly is the knowing of pleasant feeling. We relax as best we can to allow pleasant feelings become more prominent. Then we focus attention on the mind that watches these, the knowing of pleasure. This is a tricky business. Our attachments to pleasure run deep and of course we can only enjoy pleasure if we know it, are conscious of it.

We're so deeply attached to the pleasure of knowing, of being conscious, that we simply take it for granted. The sense of self grows strong as we resist the notion that consciousness might not actually be me, mine. Could it really just be something that's happening? A chance combination of some sense object out in the world being detected by a sensor based in my body, animated by a moment of attention. It's hard to think about life in these terms. It gets too complicated for our brain to cope with.

In my case, reflections like these stir the desire to build a better picture of what's going on. This is another example of greed mixed in with *chanda*. In this case, dhamma *chanda*, the desire to understand the true nature of the world.

Armed with the instructions to know the mind affected by greed as the mind affected by greed, I don't have to curb greed, but simply let mindfulness rest in this instance of third *satipaṭṭhāna*. Attention retreats from its usual external orientation to explore the experience of knowing. There's a sense of moving inwards to what feels like my core. But what can be said about the experience?

There's certainly a pleasure in knowing experience. Pleasure is most clearly epitomized as pleasant sensations in the body. Greed tends to embroider these with thoughts of me and mine, but mindfulness detects the effort needed to blow up these bubbles of thought and the stress involved in that. Seeing the futility of grasping, greed fades and equanimity allows awareness to rest more easily in those pleasant sensations which now acquire perceptions of ease and goodwill.

At the same time, I start to lose touch with what I had termed the core of myself, the sense of being the one who knows experience. I realize that I cannot actually experience pleasure and maintain the sense of myself as the knower of pleasure.

As usual with any *satipaṭṭhāna* contemplation, mindfulness brings us to the edge of our comfort zone where we are resisting the limitations of our human condition. Resting awareness within the discomfort allows us bit by bit to make peace with our limitations. This exercise helps us come to terms in particular with the limitations of consciousness, learning that we cannot have that broad overview of all experience which brings the sense of being the observer, the one who knows, while also knowing any one experience in any detail, such as pleasant feeling in the body. We have to compromise, let attention move in and out as conditions dictate.

At times like these, it could be useful to practice with the second part of the instruction on greed, to notice when the mind is not being affected by greed. While we are willing to compromise to allow attention move around as circumstances dictate, the mind is not being dominated by greed. However, reflecting the mind is not affected by

greed brings us to another edge to the comfort zone. It's pleasant to experience a quiet mind without the strong pushes and pulls associated with greed. But because it's so pleasant, greed also wants to know the mind that is not affected by greed. It's a conundrum.

We slowly learn to accommodate this limit to what we can know by allowing greed to come and go as we explore non-greed, the absence of greed. In my experience, energies of greed burn in the face and head but are continually being cooled, washed away by the more calming energies of the breath. The exercise helps us get to know greed in a non-judgmental way. Moments of greed meet moments of non-greed. It's not a battle, just a dance.

But a dance doesn't last forever. Greed can turn to anger at its inability to possess the pleasant, calming feelings associated with non-greed. To help us work with this, we have the next line of the Sutta which goes: "One knows mind affected by anger as mind affected by anger, and mind unaffected by anger as mind unaffected by anger."

Anger is a manifestation of ill will. It's a reaction against what we perceive as unpleasant. Within the context of *satipaṭṭhāna* meditation, anger isn't a problem but an opportunity to get to know ill will. In milder forms, ill will might take the hue of disinterest or dullness. We simply turn away from the world of experience, shield ourselves with mental fog. If the perceived threat penetrates that fog, ill will might take more active forms like irritation, impatience or suspicion. If the sense of threat grows really strong, we forget any agenda except defending ourselves and ill will could manifest as fear, hatred or rage.

The Buddha's metaphor of the two arrows illustrates the sad stupidity of ill will. We have the initial unpleasantness. For example, someone insults us. The hurt we feel at the insult is like being pierced by the first arrow. Rather than tend to this wound, we react with anger. This is like stabbing ourselves with the second arrow. Every time we speak or act on this anger, we remind ourselves of the insult, unwittingly stabbing ourselves again and again.

The metaphor graphically illustrates the pain we inflict on ourselves through anger. The pain of the second arrow isn't immediately obvious. In fact, we generally feel better when we react with anger. The insult hurts, makes us feel small and insignificant. But the reaction of anger builds us up again, makes us feel righteous and strong. In our psyche, it is the other person who is diminished as we hurl insults back at them.

It's similar for all the other shades of ill will. At a surface level, they make us feel better. Impatience and irritation insist that the problem is out there. We would be fine if it wasn't for the idiot in the car in front who insists on stopping at all the traffic lights. It's only when we look at the experience in more detail that we can feel the second arrow.

Suppose the memory of a hurtful remark comes up in meditation. The body grows tense and in our mind we might fire daggers at the person who hurt us. While the image and thoughts put the enemy outside ourselves, we feel the push of aversion within our own body. At times it becomes apparent that anger splits us in two. The angry, assertive part holds all the power and feels like me. It flails about, tightening this muscle and then that, but it can never really pin down the you it seeks to crush.

Eventually we give up the useless battle and let the images fade. Tensions start to relax. As they do we have to admit that the anger was only a distraction covering up our original hurt at the harsh words. There's nothing for it but to feel those hurting sensations. This is to tend to the wound of the first arrow.

It's not easy to bear with the hurts and fears that underlie anger. Much easier to contort our body and mind in ill will. But with each reaction the habit grows. Eventually we see no good in the world. Everything is useless. Nobody is trustworthy. We're on the slippery slope towards a life of bitter isolation.

If we can learn to bear with unpleasant feelings, this has a transformative effect. The enemy is no longer out there. What we were crushing, we realize, was our feeling of hurt. Those feelings are embedded within our flesh, which might be trembling in fear. But there's also an impulse towards self-compassion. Within the fire of purification we learn to forgive ourselves for the hurts we've unwittingly caused and this makes it easier to forgive others.

We won't be able to tend to these inner wounds unless we allow the mind state of anger to reveal itself in mindfulness. Easier said than done. Most of us have been strongly conditioned to repress anger. This may be true for women even more so than men. The cultural message in my youth was, "Nice girls don't get angry." This forms a powerful part of our self-story and causes us to suppress anger.

It's not that suppression is always wrong. In daily life, it's often wise to suppress anger. To be able to suppress in a skillful way, we need to get to know the forces of suppression within us. In my experience, suppression is felt as a fierce weight on my head

which bears down through my forehead. Just sitting with this allows healing. And then, in a social situation where I need to contain anger, that suppressive force can come to my aid. I can welcome it joyfully as a friend.

Occasionally, expressing anger might be wiser than suppression, especially if our habit is to hide anger in passive aggression. Learning to assert ourselves is part of our spiritual path. Of course, we need to be ready to apologize when we get it wrong. A good rule of thumb is to do the opposite of what you really want. If you want to let rip at somebody, that's the time to take a few deep breaths before opening your mouth. If you're scared to say anything, want to clam up and nurse a new grievance, that's the time to summon courage and let it rip. Surprisingly, the release can sometimes propel us to a position of deeper friendship.

Anger plays a huge part in human life, for the most part destructive, but can be used skillfully when we've learned to befriend the state through mindfulness. Thus, we want to welcome the mind state of anger whenever this occurs in meditation. Allow awareness to examine all its various facets in body and mind. See where we're clinging. Let go if possible. Bear with the pain if not.

Within the honest gaze of mindfulness, we sense that anger keeps missing the target. It aims at the imaginary enemy but hurts only our own flesh. Seeing this futility the habit of anger fades and alternative pathways for coping with life's difficulties start opening up.

The skillful response to life's vicissitudes starts with accepting situations as they are. This doesn't mean becoming a passive doormat. We can recognise a situation as undesirable without letting that disturb our mental balance. "It's undesirable, but it's happening and I have to deal with this reality, not waste time thinking about how it ought to be." Acceptance fosters calm, which in turn allows for clear thought about how we might respond. If necessary, we can act vigorously to combat a threat and our actions will be more effective without anger clouding the mind.

A big part of exploring these alternative pathways is to notice when the mind state of anger is not present. This can prove a great boost to our spiritual self-confidence. Especially as awareness deepens, it might seem as though we must be the most hateful, angry person in the world. It's important to be able to counter that with direct proof that we can also be free from anger. When you're practicing *mettā*, for example, you could stop for a moment to acknowledge that the mind is not angry at this moment.

At times, however, even the absence of anger can prove challenging. When the heart is filled with *mettā*, the last thing it wants is to feel anger. And yet to notice the absence of anger, we have to remember what it is that's absent. So this practice deliberately recalls anger.

We must allow anger to arise, remind us of what is absent, and then fade, letting us see the absence of anger. This is certainly a challenge, but it develops the ability to work through anger towards whatever traits we detect in the absence of anger. These will probably include compassion for our human condition — at the mercy of strong desires and yet incapable of satisfying these.

The third exercise in the Sutta is to know mind affected by delusion as mind affected by delusion, and mind unaffected by delusion as mind unaffected by delusion. Greed hooks us to pleasant feelings while anger binds us to unpleasant feelings. When delusion predominates, we're ignoring sense data, dismissing it as unimportant. This happens when the experience is not very stimulating, neither threatening nor enticing. Ordinary activities like walking, standing in a queue, brushing our teeth, relaxing after a meal — all these are easy prey for delusion. Similarly, when things go quiet or the mind goes dull in formal meditation.

We withdraw to shield ourselves from the experience of sensations and feelings arising and passing at their own pace and without any respect for what I would prefer. Wrapped tight in a blanket of ignoring, we make up a little story. We tell ourselves we are an individual who lives within our body-mind system, that we are in charge of this subjective inner world, deciding what to say and where to go, what thoughts to think, and — if only other people didn't keep messing things up — what feelings to have.

While we're young and healthy, it's very pleasing to think that this lithe body and these feelings of vibrancy and strength are mine. If we're clever, then we feel proud of this, assuming cleverness is our personal achievement. Whatever advantage we have, we assume this is ours. The illusion gives us energy and confidence, helps us pursue our dreams. But it also makes us vulnerable.

The older we get, the more trouble we find. We were proud of our beauty, so now we're aghast at being wrinkled and ugly. We delighted in striding up mountains. Who is this old geezer who pants when climbing a few steps? We could motivate people, galvanise a crowd into action. How come I'm now alone and ignored? Sometimes we feel bewildered, sometimes ashamed, as if we have caused this decline, sometimes angry, believing the world has failed us. The illusion has now become a source of misery. We nurture delusion at our peril.

So we need to be vigilant. Watch out for those moments when we quietly withdraw and ignore what's going on around us. How easily this happens. How often have you resolved to follow the breath, only to discover five, ten, twenty minutes have elapsed without ever noticing the abdomen rising or falling? We've been completely lost in thoughts, worries, daydreams, plans.

If we catch ourselves early in this delusive drift, chances are the thought stream will be somewhat daft or inconsequential — wondering about tomorrow's weather, whatever happened to our old school books. These fairly neutral thoughts are typical of the deluded mind. It's not that greed is getting us all excited about a plan or daydream, or that anger is compelling us to rehash old grievances. Instead, it seems we're thinking just for the sake of it.

Why do we do this? Thinking divides the mind in two. There's the thought and the thinker. An external world and me. While the thoughts and images vary from weather to school books, the thinker feels constant. This allows us to perpetuate the idea of a permanent, real entity inside — a me which is at the centre of experience, knowing it, feeling it, commenting on it.

We also delude ourselves that we are in control. We can easily pretend that we've made the decision to open a door, until we try to do this mindfully and see how difficult it is to stop barging through rather than feel the hand moving towards the doorknob and the thousand other sensations that arise and pass before we step through the door.

Even when the mind has steadied in *vipassanā* and we're no longer lost in thought, the illusion is propelled by subtle, barely verbalised perceptions that associate I, me, mine with pleasant feelings. It seems that I'm the observer of all my experience. If we direct attention towards that sense of self, a subtle image may emerge, perhaps a glow of light or a pleasant feeling. We perceive this glow, this feeling, as me. But as soon as we rest attention there for a moment, we notice the glow shifts position, and now it seems like I am looking at things from a slightly different perspective. What in fact has happened is that the initial image faded, like all phenomena do, and we've created a new idea of self around another pleasant experience. When we see this sense of self shifting around like this, we begin to get a feel for the delusion that ensnares us.

We don't want to let the focus on delusion make us believe that the sense of self is innately wrong. It's quite the opposite, in fact. We need a healthy sense of self to accomplish anything, including getting ourselves to be mindful. We just want to see through the belief that this self is a substantial, permanent entity located somewhere within the body-mind system.

In fact, the instinctive tendency towards delusion can even be used beneficially. Delusion is fuelled by a need to feel whole within ourselves, self-sufficient, autonomous. When practising *mettā* for ourselves, we allow this powerful selfing instinct to find expression as conscious good wishes for ourselves. We are evoking a sense of self in order to care for ourselves. In this instance, the instinct to identify as a separate self is being used wisely. The idea, "this is me," energises the body and mind, lets us get ourselves together to accomplish things.

But at times we sense that idea fading. Attention rests on sensations without any central headquarters and no one commenting. We witness the body and mind operating according to their own laws. We see that the perception not-self fits this experience and sense the liberation on offer when we stop clinging to the idea of a self. Despite this, selfing starts up again.

On our way to liberation, we have to make peace with the mind affected by delusion. We need to cultivate a friendly attitude towards the deluded mind. The *Satipaṭṭhāna* Sutta gives us great support for this, letting us welcome delusion as an opportunity to explore delusions. Delusion will be present in all states of anger and greed, as well as more neutral states, like dullness. Whenever you feel a strong sense of self, use the reflection, "This is the mind affected by delusion," to establish yourself in the third *satipaṭṭhāna*. Allow the experience to unfold in whatever way it will.

Perhaps you'll start questioning that sense of self, wondering if it's really true. Perhaps anger will be stirred at the very thought of having your identity questioned. Perhaps greed will be stirred at the delightful self-image presented by delusion. We're also asked to notice the mind without delusion. At times when the central headquarters disappears, try reflecting, "This mind is not affected by delusion." As for anger and greed, noticing the absence of delusion may well prove a challenge. It may bring up grief as we acknowledge that the only way we can know this peaceful state is by continually saying goodbye to any budding sense of self.

Curiously, the exercise can also strengthen self-acceptance. Absence makes the heart grow fonder, we say. As clinging fades, appreciation for this suffering being, this body-mind system that seeks liberation, flows more strongly.

I'd like to end with some of the instructions given in what's termed the refrain of the Sutta, a section that's repeated again and again throughout all four *Satipaṭṭhāna*. Firstly, we're asked to practise the exercises internally, which is what I've been discussing — noticing our own greed, hatred and delusion. We're also asked to practise these externally, meaning we notice these in other people.

When we're in a crowd of frantic shoppers, we could pause for a while, acknowledging the greed driving our thoughts and feelings, and then reflect, "This is most likely what's driving all the other shoppers as well." When we're walking outdoors or in a similarly tranquil situation, we could take a moment to reflect on the absence of greed in our own mind and very probably in the minds of others around us. We do the same for anger and delusion.

If we see someone in a rage, we can reflect on the ill will driving their thoughts and feelings. Curiously, this can stir compassion rather than deepen our hostility. When we're in a social gathering, we can take a moment to reflect on the absence of ill will amongst the people present. This might deepen our sense of connection and trust. If someone is tipsy or talking in a highly charged melodramatic manner, we could reflect that delusion is dominating their mind at the moment. When we're meditating with others or we see someone absorbed in gardening or other grounded occupation, we could reflect that delusion is not a dominant force in their minds at this moment.

Recognising the presence or absence of greed, anger and delusion in others is a form of *mettā* practice. It brings other people into consciousness at quite an intimate level. This may stir a degree of comradeship and we start to see the others in a friendlier light. At other times the opposite may happen and the exercise brings up some emotional reaction. This is part of the purification process, helping us acknowledge others as human with similar challenges and limitations as ourselves and also with a similar potential for liberation. If we can bear with the negative emotions mindfully, the payoff is purification and increasing ability to relate skilfully to others.

The next instruction in the refrain is to see the arising and passing away of these mind states. Say someone treads on our toe and we feel a surge of anger arising. Very quickly that anger is going to persuade us of whatever story aversion normally brings up, and we'll be stuck in a very solid sense of self and think that life has always been this miserable way and always will be. If we can catch that moment of anger arising, we see that this story is being constructed, willed into existence. We're choosing the story out of habit. Although this is very unedifying to see, it's ultimately liberating. We learn to respond differently, tell ourselves more helpful stories that are closer to the truth. Same for greed and delusion. If we see them arising, we realise we are cooperating, willingly buying into these states. Of course, we have to be patient with these deeply conditioned habits, but slowly intuition starts to find more helpful ways of reacting.

To see the passing away of greed, hatred or delusion is also very instructive. For example, when we come home from a shopping trip, we could sit down, relax and feel the frenzy of shopaholism die away. This gives us a taste for the absence of greed. Let's see the value of the state. If we've had a blow-out with a colleague, we could go somewhere quiet, wait for the anger to die down, detect when the mind becomes rational again, appreciate the absence of anger. Similarly, we can detect the final moments of delusion. If we've been the one telling the melodramatic story, we can track the buzzing giddiness till it touches down to reality. Who knows what we will find? Perhaps relief? Humour? Shame? Whatever arises is part of our path to non-delusion.

Let's finish with a verse from the Dhammapada: "Let the discerning one guard the mind, so difficult to detect and extremely subtle, seizing whatever it desires. A guarded mind brings happiness."

Guilt

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 2 min read

Bhante Bodhidhamma examines guilt through a Buddhist lens, distinguishing it from the existential guilt found in Abrahamic traditions. Rather than viewing guilt as evidence of inherent sinfulness, he presents the Buddha's teaching that wrongdoing arises from ignorance (avijjā) of 'the way things really are.' This fundamental misunderstanding leads to actions rooted in greed, hatred, and delusion that ultimately harm ourselves and others.

The essay explores both healthy and unhealthy manifestations of guilt. Appropriate guilt serves as a guardian of society, helping us recognize when we've caused harm and motivating us to make amends. However, excessive scrupulousness can create imbalance, while absence of guilt after harmful actions indicates a need for deeper reflection on consequences.

The teaching emphasizes using meditation to face guilt directly, opening to its painful tremors rather than avoiding them. Through experiencing guilt's suffering, we gain insight into the consequences of unskillful action and develop genuine remorse. When possible, making direct amends is encouraged, but when reconciliation isn't feasible, sitting with guilt while cultivating fierce determination not to repeat harmful behavior becomes the path forward. Ultimately, understanding our own suffering from guilt cultivates compassion for others who also experience this consequence of deluded action.

Like shame, the Buddha calls guilt a guardian of society. That guilty feeling means we know we are at fault. We know we have done some harm. This leads to the fear of consequences. This is not the same as existential guilt which someone may suffer from if they are brought up in one of the Abrahamic religions. For we are told we carry the sin of Adam. From an early age, we may have been told that we were essentially sinful. This is not the fundamental reason for our transgressions. The Buddha said wrong doing is secondary. The prior reason is non-culpable ignorance that causes us to fall into a delusion. We are essentially ignorant of the 'way things really are'. Because of this we commit errors based on acquisitiveness, aversion and fear. But paradoxically it is all done to make 'me' happy. Even so this leads us into actions of thought, speech and deeds that harm us and harm others. And that is when we feel guilty. If we did not feel guilty; if we did not perceive that we were a cause of another's suffering and of our own (how easy it is to blame our unhappiness on others!); if we are not worried about the consequences, what then would stop us doing harm? Guilt like all our unwholesome states must be faced. In our meditation we open up to its tremors. The fear of being caught.

The dread of consequence. Now it may be that the guilt we feel is inappropriate. To be unable to sleep because you purposely took a pen from the office, criticised your boss to someone whom you suspect might tell them or swatted a fly out of irritation may point to a guilt ridden conscience. A conscience full of scruples and qualms (the bug bear of the monastic life with all its 227 rules!) is a sign of imbalance. It is often relieving to talk to a friend whose judgement you trust to give you a wiser perspective. On the other hand when we feel no or little guilt after committing what society and ordinary people would consider wrong tells us we need to contemplate the consequences of what we have done. I knew someone who stole from a small book shop on the grounds of Marxist critique of a capitalist society, regardless of the effect on the struggling owner. However, when guilt is justifiable, we do need to turn into the feeling of guilt to really see how painful it is. Really opening up to the misery of that mental state is a departure for reflection. 'I would not be suffering this tormented heart, if I had not behaved unskillfully'. If we can put right what we did wrong, all well and good. Sometimes a simple apology. A gift. But if an occasion for reconciliation does not arise, then it may be possible to do something by way of reparation. Here is a rather extreme example. When a Hindu confessed to Gandhi he had murdered a Muslim child, Gandhi told him to find a Muslim orphan and bring him up as a Muslim. But if even that is not possible, then we have no option but to sit with the guilt and express our remorse and sorrow within ourselves. And, of course, a fierce determination not to behave in a similar manner again. When we experience within ourselves the suffering of guilt, realise it is the product of deluded unwholesome action, then we are more able to forgive others who do harm, for they will also suffer the same. Guilt, then, is also a first step towards compassion.

Guilt — Real and Unreal

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 24 min

In this talk from the Foundation Course, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines guilt as both a natural guardian of morality and a potential source of psychological suffering. Drawing from the Dhammapada, he distinguishes between proper guilt — the awareness of having acted against one's conscience — and neurotic guilt arising from harmful self-definitions formed in childhood.

The talk explores how wholesome guilt, accompanied by shame (hiri) and moral dread (ottappa), serves as protection against unskillful actions. However, when we identify the actor with the action ("you are bad" rather than "that action was unskillful"), we create damaging self-concepts that fuel anxiety and restlessness in meditation. Bhante explains the three components of karmic action: intention, effort, and completion, showing that mere arising of unwholesome thoughts is not itself karma.

Using practical examples and Buddhist psychology, this teaching offers a path to freedom through accepting guilt feelings in meditation without identifying with them, understanding that we are fundamentally wise beings obscured by ignorance, not essentially evil. The talk concludes with guidance on counteracting unwholesome karma through present wholesome actions, emphasizing that "nothing is preconditioned" — we can always change our karmic trajectory through skillful choices.

Foundation Course 2. Talk 2.

Guilt, real and unreal.

Guilt and feelings associated with guilt are sometimes a great problem for meditators. They can be very insistent. Some say it's to do with their Christian upbringing, or guilt only arises because of the concept of a vengeful deity. But guilt is a human phenomenon, and each individual suffers their own particular amount of it, depending on their understanding and the offense committed.

If the search for pleasure and the self-identification with pleasurable things brings about a syndrome of emotional responses, guilt also creates such a one, but a wholly different set of reactions.

Guilt itself is just the knowledge of having done something against one's conscience. Conscience here means simply knowing, but a knowing of a particular kind. It is the knowing of what is right and what is wrong. In Buddhism, it is better to talk of what is right and wrong in terms of skillfulness or wholesomeness. Everyone has a conscience, and every conscience is different. Even though there is a broad agreement about such things as murder and theft, when it comes to the outer reaches of our definitions, the edges get frayed. Is it right to execute someone who has killed another? At what point is abortion the killing of a human being?

Our conscience tells us what is wholesome for us, or what is unwholesome for us. This conscience, then, is our moral wisdom, and therefore contains within it right or wrong understanding. This understanding determines our intentions and acts of will, which in turn determine our karma, so it is obviously very important to investigate conscience closely. We need to question all our understandings and opinions about morality, good and bad.

The Buddha makes it quite clear that ignorance is no excuse. Being ignorant will not save us from the consequences of an unwholesome act. This is a verse from the *Dhammapada*: "A fool, while he performs unskillful deeds, does not know them to be unskillful. But that fool still suffers for his unskillfulness, just as one burnt by fire." In other words, a child, just because she doesn't know what matches do and still plays with them even after parental warnings, will still be burnt. She may even burn the house down.

We are not isolated individuals, we are an integral part of an interrelated world. If we do harm, harm comes back to us. So knowing what is unwholesome and unskillful is of great importance to us if we want to put an end to the suffering we cause ourselves and unjustly to other human beings.

So having a conscience means that whenever we do something we know it to be wholesome, unwholesome or neutral. When we know that what we have done is wholesome, pleasant feelings arise. Our self-esteem grows. The proverbial helping of the old person across the road makes one feel good. To do good is to feel good about oneself. It dispels feelings of self-hate, self-belittlement.

On the other hand, if while driving my car, an old person steps onto the zebra crossing and screeching to a halt, I wind down my window and shout abuse to the effect that all old people ought to be done away with as kindly as possible, afterwards, if I am truthful with myself, I shall know myself to have been cruel. I have gone against my knowledge of what is wholesome and skillful. I have crossed my conscience. This knowing that I have transgressed a moral law is guilt.

The dictionary definition talks of failure to do one's duty, the fact of having committed an offense, the state of having willfully committed a crime. Now we can see what guilt is. It is simply knowing one has done what one ought not to do. It is perfectly right and proper in such a case to feel and know oneself to be guilty. Knowing oneself to be guilty is just awareness of having done something harmful.

Now this knowledge is accompanied by two feelings in Buddhist psychology: shame and dread. Shame is just those varying degrees of embarrassment, plus the knowledge that one has lost the respect of others and self-respect. If I'm caught shoplifting a battery for my Walkman, I feel so small. I feel humiliated. I know people now see me not as a worthy citizen, but as a petty thief. Shame can be a very painful experience. Knowing this sets a barrier, a protection against me doing such things.

You used to hear parents say to young people, "Have you no shame? Don't you feel ashamed?" It's gone out of fashion now because of our general rejection of guilt as a good thing, and the fear of creating a guilt complex. But in Buddhist understanding, guilt has a proper role to play, and it is entwined with self-esteem and self-respect, and the esteem and respect others have of us. Perhaps we ought to say to our children, "Have you no self-respect? Don't you want to be respected?" It may be a more positive way of saying the same thing.

Now, at the same time as feeling ashamed, I also feel afraid. For when I'm caught red-handed, dread also arises. I fear the consequences of my act. I know I can be prosecuted or fined. I may even lose my job. Knowing there are inescapable consequences for what I do also creates a barrier, a protection against my doing unskillful, unwholesome acts.

The Buddha, again in the *Dhammapada*, warns us: "Not in the sky, nor in the middle of the ocean, nor in a cave of a mountain, nor anywhere else is there a place where we can escape from the consequences of an unwholesome deed."

There's a story concerning this verse. It was the answer the Buddha gave to some monks who told him about this strange event. They had been traveling on a boat which suddenly stopped mid-water and apparently refused to move. The people on the boat drew lots, and three times it fell to the wife of the skipper. He decided he didn't want so many people to suffer on account of his wife, so he had a sandbag tied round her neck and had her thrown overboard. Now, to our modern ears, this might seem highly suspicious, and a clever way of ridding himself of a troublesome wife. But the commentary goes on to say that this was the consequence of having drowned a pet dog, because she had been made to feel ashamed of it. A heavy consequence indeed, though it's nice to see animals being given the high regard they deserve as fellow beings.

In Buddhist understanding, these two reactions to doing harm—shame and dread—are not only the guardians that prevent someone from committing an unskillful act, but also the guardians of order in a society. If people felt neither shame nor dread of consequences, what would stop them from doing harm? In fact, such people are often described as psychopathic, mentally ill.

The fact about hardened criminals is that personal gain seems to get the better of discretion, of shame and dread, even though their actions may make others suffer a great deal and bring great suffering to themselves. In the case of violent political actions, all such considerations are discarded in favor of the ideology. The ends justify the means. It's right and proper to kill opponents.

Now, if there is such a thing as a balanced conscience whose guardians are shame and dread, and if there is such a thing as a moral code of behavior that is the foundation of social and interpersonal harmony, why has guilt become such a great problem for us?

Let's take a typical case. Billy, a lively lad, found an easy supply of comics and sweets. He just makes sure no one's looking while he helps himself. When Billy's finally caught, his parents are very upset and the first thing they tell him is that he's a thief. Being a thief is bad, very bad. Therefore, Billy comes to understand that he's a thief and he's bad.

Billy has been told he's bad, off and on, every time he upsets his parents. He's alternatively selfish, cruel, lazy, good for nothing, a nuisance, a "why we put up with you I'll never know." A part of Billy knows himself to be Bad Billy, Big Bad Billy. It becomes a self-definition, and with it, low self-esteem, low self-respect—that is, self-hate.

Identifying the action with the actor creates a wrong identity. No doubt, the act of stealing is not something to encourage in children, but one theft doesn't make a thief. In fact, a million thefts don't make a thief, if by thief we mean someone who is a thief by nature. Once we're taught as children to get into these traps of self-definitions, it's very difficult to find an escape.

This sort of guilt is not the proper guilt about an action committed, but a neurotic guilt about the person who committed the action. So my fear of consequences is compounded by the fear that that's the sort of person I am and I can't do anything about it.

The understanding that humans are somehow essentially evil, some more than others, bad at the core, so to speak, is a chief cause of mistaken self-definition and later leads to all our problems with guilt. The Buddha taught that we were born in ignorance,

that because of our ignorance we acted with wrong intention, but always with the idea of fulfilling our desires. Not knowing what desires led to suffering for ourselves and others, and what desires lead to happiness, is the essential problem.

At fundament, the human is wise, is enlightened, is a Buddha, meaning someone who has the potential to be enlightened. If we truly grasp this point—that it is our ignorance that must be dispelled, that we are not essentially evil—then in our meditation we must allow these damning self-definitions to emerge. These voices must be listened to: "You're useless, you're inadequate, you're wicked and evil, you're terrible, no one can love you, you can't love anyone," and so on.

Through the power of our intuitive wisdom, we see these as disembodied voices, voices we have taken into ourselves. The personality is but a collection of such habits, and just as habits are formed, so they can be unformed. Meditation should help us to confront these often painful self-definitions, see them as mere opinions, as changeable, and by not indulging them, through this understanding allow their power over our thinking to die out.

Meanwhile, poor Billy, although he was caught, didn't take the opportunity to clear his heart of all the offenses. He swore in tears that he had only ever taken one comic and one bag of sweets. That's why he was let off lightly with warnings of lashings and thrashings, if ever he should even think of doing such a thing again.

Unfortunately for Billy, guilt feelings, especially of the fear of being found out, sit uncomfortably in his mind. Since no one does find out, Billy represses those feelings and begins to see this as a clever ploy. He's now compounded his stealing with lying, and both have been fairly successful in satisfying his desires. But the result of this is to laden his mind with all sorts of unresolved guilts.

Since boyhood, Billy hasn't stolen a thing, but feelings of guilt still dog him. Whenever a policeman should appear, panic arises. Worse, whenever he does do anything wrong, the proper guilt he ought to feel is fueled by all the unresolved guilt, so that he feels overly guilty and anxious, and has to apologize profusely even when he inadvertently steps on someone's toe.

It is also possible that such is the store of unresolved guilt, coupled with self-definition of being a bad person, that his worldview is so distorted he sees all sorts of people out to get him, conspiracy everywhere, paranoia at worst.

Again, it is in meditation that these phantom guilts can be dealt with. Let them come to the attention. Feel them fully. Accept them fully. Don't criticize or look for excuses and scapegoats. Don't get into conversation with them. Let them be. Just let them disclose themselves and sit equanimously within all the discomfort. Slowly, their strength declines. Their power dissolves.

Unfortunately, yet again, Billy is to be pitied, the more for his parents have told him that even bad thoughts are something he should be ashamed of and feel guilty about. The Buddha's teaching is very clear on this. Thoughts and images that arise in the mind are the consequences, the results of past actions. When Billy walks into a newsagent, the idea arises of stealing a book, to slip one inside his coat. That idea has been conditioned by Billy's past actions. It has become a conditioned response whenever he sees books. Up to this point, what Billy is suffering from is the karmic results of past actions, the *vipāka*. He has not yet committed any new karma.

What happens next is crucial. If Billy is taken to the idea, it will obsess, possess his mind. He will make a decision to take the book. Billy, by this decision, has only reinforced the thought, the intention of stealing. On the other hand, he may exert himself. He may even put the book in his coat and then decide against it. If he takes his action up to this point, he has reinforced his inclination to steal, but we cannot yet say he has stolen, or that he has created any new karma in the sense of a completed unwholesome action.

It is only when these three components all come together can we talk of a karmic action: the intention, the effort or exertion, and the actual completion of the act. In this case, when Billy walks out of the shop with the book. Up until this actual moment of taking, Billy is only reinforcing his state of mind, the mental habit, which will have the unwholesome result of making further temptations harder to overcome. These are the consequences of intention and exertion.

But upon the actual completion of the act, the stealing itself, not only is there the inner consequence, but the outer consequence too. At some point in time, because we are all interrelated, interfused, a result will arise from that harmful, unskillful action.

In the *Dhammapada*, the Buddha warns us: "Even an unskillful person may still find happiness, so long as his unskillfulness does not bear fruit. But when his unskillfulness does bear fruit, he will meet with unwholesome consequences."

Let us recap a moment. Firstly, we can say that unwholesome actions have the same root cause as sensual pleasure. We do them because we think they will bring us pleasure and happiness. A biting remark fulfills our desire for revenge, and our self-esteem

is restored. Robbing a bank will bring us all that lovely lolly, and we'll be happy for the rest of our lives. Sometimes we do things harmful for the sheer sake of excitement, such as driving in a dangerous way. Whatever the pleasurable satisfaction we gain, it is gained at the expense of ourselves and quite unjustly at the expense of others.

Secondly, we can see that there are two rounds involved. The first is unskillful actions with guilt feelings that bring success and lead to repetition. The second is unskillful action that arouses no guilt feelings but lead to painful consequences later.

Thirdly, we cannot say that an unwholesome karmic action is fully completed till the three ingredients are there: intention, exertion and completion of the act.

Fourthly, these guilt rounds with their attendant feelings of shame and dread subsist the pleasure syndrome and go to make life harder for us. Making money to get rich is one thing. Making money out of the sale of arms to get rich is another. Worse still, when all this is fueled by unresolved guilt, it all adds up to create greater anxiety, worry, fear, and restlessness.

In meditation, this now becomes a great hindrance. When restlessness and anxiety arise in the mind, we need to see if they are coming from guilt. To our surprise, we may find memories there of unwholesome actions we've done, even as children.

In my own case, when I was about twelve years old, I caught a mole and took it to my teacher. It was a great catch. It caused a sensation, and I was for a while a celebrity. But after everyone had seen it, the teacher told me to take it back, for it was impossible to keep. Moles eat a lot of worms, it seems.

Now, I don't know whether it was because it had bit me when I caught it, or whether I was angry at the teacher, or whether it was the result of past conditioning in cruelty. But, without really thinking about it, I took a large piece of wood and battered it to death. When that memory came back to me, I was filled with horror. I felt a certain panic. Even though I've meditated on it for years now, it still makes me feel uncomfortable. Such wanton cruelty. It's no good me arguing that perhaps the mole was getting its comeuppance. I did it. I performed the foul deed.

What the outer consequences are, I don't know. Perhaps I've already suffered them. I hope so. But I'm painfully aware of the inner consequences. But having observed all this in meditation and reflecting upon it, in time, the emotional power of the memory has decreased. This has been my karma.

The first steps, then, in overcoming guilt feelings is to face up to them, and there's no better place than in the meditation. The second is to reflect on the act.

There is a mistaken understanding that you can put things right, but the spilt milk is spilt, it is gone. That little mole cannot be resurrected, nor can its suffering be wiped out of history. All we can do is accept the consequences. Now in truth there's great relief in that, because now we can stop worrying. What will be, will be, though I can undermine unwholesome *kamma* coming my way by doing wholesome things.

One of the incidents in Mahatma Gandhi's life illustrates this well. A distraught Hindu came to him saying that he had killed a Muslim child during one of the riots. What bad *kamma*! Gandhi told him to adopt a Muslim orphan and bring him up as a Muslim. This good deed would go a long way to counteract the earlier unskillful one.

This is a very important point to grasp in the Buddha's teaching on *kamma*. Nothing is preconditioned. We can assuage unwholesome consequences in the future by doing what is good now. There are further steps to purifying the mind of guilt, but this is dealt with in a later talk. Enough it is to say here that the first step is acceptance.

If upon reflection we understand guilt to be unreal, an overreaction, we will still have to suffer from it. We will still have to patiently allow it to rise up into our consciousness. However, in the process of letting go of such guilt, we can say that some part of the store of unresolved guilt is being expended.

This needs a little further explanation. Although I've used terms like "store of guilt," in Buddhist understanding this isn't quite right. What is more correct is to talk of a disposition, a tendency, which has been conditioned by past actions. If I tend to feel overguilty, then by allowing it to pass, that tendency will be weakened.

Let us end with two salutary tales from the *Dhammapada*. First is the story of the careless monk. One of the rules of a monk's life is to put back whatever has been used. Now it was the habit of this monk that no matter what he used—table, stool or mat—he would leave it out in the open, exposed to the sun or the rain. When monks pointed this out to him, he just shrugged his shoulders, saying little damage was done, and anyway, he meant no harm. But he was warned that small faults are in the habit of growing large. He was a wise fellow after all, for he took their good counsel.

When the Buddha heard this, he said: "One should not think lightly of an unskillful deed, imagining, 'A little will not affect me.' Just as a jug of water is filled by falling drops of rain, so also the fool is filled up with unwholesome conditioning by accumulating little by little."

The second is the story of Billa Lepadika, a rich man who was ready to kill the organizer of a community offering of food to the Buddha and his monks. Billa Lepadika had been annoyed by this organizer for asking him and others to give. He noticed his small

offering was kept apart and thought the organizer was doing this to show him up. That's why he was going to kill him. But in fact, the organizer put a little of what he had given in every bowl, thereby hoping to increase Billa Lepadika's merit. Billa Lepadika was repentant and apologized to the organizer for not supporting him properly.

The Buddha overheard this and said: "One should not think lightly of doing good, imagining 'A little will not affect me.' Just as a water jar is filled up with falling drops of rain, so also the wise one is filled up with merit, accumulated little by little."

So there we have the Buddha's teaching. Be scrupulous about unskillful deeds. Do good no matter how small. It all counts. So when it comes to guilt and guilt feelings of low self-esteem, low self-respect, self-hatred, by doing what is wholesome, these are counteracted by feelings of high self-esteem, high self-respect, self-acceptance, self-care and self-understanding.

By observing and sitting patiently with guilt feelings in meditation, we will purify the mind of anguish, remorse, anxiety and sorrow. And by doing what is wholesome and skillful in our daily lives, we will re-establish that sense of wholesomeness and innocence, which is the joy of being at peace with ourselves and at peace with the world.

I hope you found this talk interesting and helpful. May all of you be happy and peaceful. May all of you attain the *nirvanic* peace within.

Happy New Year

Carl Fooks · 2 min read

Drawing from childhood memories of New Year's Eve disappointment, this essay explores the common pattern of unsustainable resolutions and relates it to our approach to Dhamma practice. The author examines how we often begin spiritual practice with intense enthusiasm only to burn out, likening this to 'sprinting for the marathon.' The essay introduces Right Resolve (sammā saṅkappa) as the Buddha's solution to this predicament—one of the factors of the Noble Eightfold Path that provides a balanced approach to aspiration. Rather than the harsh, punitive resolutions that typically fail, Right Resolve teaches us to move gently away from greed, ill-will, and cruelty toward peaceful renunciation, loving-kindness, and compassion. The key insight is finding the 'balancing warmth' that makes transformation sustainable—approaching change with gentleness, compassion, and kindness rather than force. This teaching offers practical wisdom for both formal meditation practice and daily life, showing how sustainable spiritual development requires patience and self-compassion rather than heroic effort.

I remember the first time I was allowed to go to my parents' perennial New Year's Eve party. I don't remember how young I was, but I remember feeling excited to be present for the grand crossing over of one year to the next. I don't know what I was expecting but it was something noticeable and significant. Something like the machinery of the universe whirling and clunking over into The New Year. As the time drew near - "how long mum?", "is it near yet?" - my excitement and anticipation grew. "It won't be long now," my mum would assure me. And then ... it was here. The music went off, the radio went on, the countdown began with the chiming of Big Ben's bells: "ten, nine, eight, seven," my excited expectation reaching fever pitch. "Three, two, one." And then ... nothing! Well, except for cheering adults and a drunken rendition of Auld Lang Syne. I can't begin to tell you how disappointed I was. I had spent the preceding couple of years pretending to be asleep in bed while the adults celebrated, but would creep out to try to witness The Big Event, always to fall asleep near the time, waking up only with the cheer after it had happened. Charged up with excited anticipation about finally witnessing my first New Year, I was left wondering what on earth was wrong with my parents and their friends! Thus New Year struck me as rather pointless. Particularly when I became old enough to be pressured into making New Year's Resolutions. I couldn't work out what was wrong with my behaviour that I had to change it by resolving to do something different, especially given nobody continued with theirs beyond the first few

weeks anyway. It seemed to me to be a time of collective delusion. First of all with The Big Event that wasn't, and then with resolutions that, well, aren't. None of which is intended to say that making resolutions is pointless. On the contrary, resolving to do something can be really helpful. A common mistake with resolutions, at any time of the year, is the way we relate to them, engage with them. If we're not paying lip-service to the tradition, we typically choose something we really want to change and we put in a Herculean effort for the first few weeks that is unsustainable. Eventually, we burn out and give up. This, of course, is a simile of our relationship to the Dhamma. Burning brightly with interest and good-will, we throw ourselves in only to find ourselves unable to sustain the pace. We are sprinting for the marathon. The Buddha, of course, knew this about us and came up with a factor of the Noble Eightfold Path for exactly this: Right Resolve (*sammā-saṅkappa*), also variously translated as Right Thought, Right Intention, Right Aspiration; "a right way of thinking/aspiring, which has a balancing warmth." This is taught as the intention to move away from greed, ill-will, and cruelty, towards peaceful renunciation, lovingkindness, and compassion. I don't know about you, but when I first heard this, it sounded so far away from what was possible, it seemed unachievable. What was missing, for me, was this "balancing warmth", and it is that which makes it sustainable. So rather than choosing resolutions that will effectively punish us, we need to find ways of orientating towards them gently, with warmth, compassion, and kindness. This helps make them sustainable and easier to integrate into our lives.

Hindrances and Factors of Awakening - read by Marie Carroll

Noirin Sheahan · 48 min

In this teaching, Noirin Sheahan examines the classical framework of the five hindrances (pañca nīvaraṇa) and seven factors of awakening (satta bojjhaṅga) as presented in the Theravāda tradition. She explores each hindrance in detail: sensual desire (kāmacchanda), aversion (byāpāda), sloth and torpor (thīna-middha), restlessness and worry (uddhacca-kukkucca), and doubt (vicikicchā). Rather than viewing these as obstacles to overcome, Noirin frames them as 'golden opportunities' to understand dukkha and develop wisdom. She emphasizes the balance between welcoming hindrances as learning experiences while maintaining the alertness needed for investigation.

The teaching then turns to the seven factors of awakening, using Bhante Bodhidhamma's vivid metaphor of wild geese in V-formation. Mindfulness (sati) leads, supported by three energizing factors—energy (virīya), investigation of Dhamma (dhammavicaya), and joy (pīti)—balanced by three calming factors—concentration (samādhi), equanimity (upekkhā), and tranquility (passaddhi). Noirin provides practical methods for cultivating each factor, emphasizing that these qualities can be 'detected and developed in every meditation session.' This teaching offers both newcomers and experienced practitioners valuable insights into working skillfully with the inevitable challenges and supports encountered in Vipassanā practice.

The Hindrances

We usually start our practice with high hopes and great determination, but after a while the rot sets in. We can't stop planning our next holiday, we get annoyed with ourselves for being so distracted and we try another few breaths. But we're so tense we can't feel anything in the body. We decide we're hopeless at meditation and should never have come on retreat. Misery sets in, we give up and soon we're dozing.

All such difficulties in meditation are termed hindrances and are completely normal, part and parcel of spiritual life. Every hindrance is a form of suffering – *dukkha*. Remember, *dukkha* includes even minor irritations. Our job as we grope our way towards liberation is to understand *dukkha*, fully understand it. Each hindrance is a golden opportunity.

But there's a balance to be struck between welcoming the hindrance and relaxing so as to feel its dukkha as a moment to moment experience. It's through sensations and feelings that we learn the Dhamma. We can overdo the welcome, rejoice at the first hint of suffering, delight in the chance to propel ourselves towards liberation, and we imagine ourselves as courageous warriors, certain of victory. But the felt experience of dukkha is not at all delightful. It can feel like a deep wound. Only by embracing the wounds of humanity can we glimpse what lies beyond. For this, the warrior in us needs to admit their vulnerability, feel their wounds, and take care of themselves. It's quite a challenge to get the balance right, lifelong learning. An endless supply of patience is required.

The Buddha described five hindrances: sense desire, aversion, dullness and lethargy, restlessness and worry, and doubt. Don't worry if you can't work out which box your difficulty falls into. Just do your best to maintain mindfulness, knowing there's some hindrance afoot. After a while, the particular flavour of the difficulty may become more obvious.

First, we have sensual desire, stimulated by lovely sights, sounds, tastes, sensations and aromas. In Buddhism, the mind is also considered as a sense door. There is a lot of pleasure to be had from mental activities. Why else do we enjoy reading, watching a film, planning? In fact, this is the main area of sensual desire that comes up during meditation. We're trying to follow the breath, but daydreams about food or sex or the great novel we're going to write are much more enticing than the sensation of breathing. The usual reaction for most of us is to get annoyed with ourselves, redouble our efforts to follow the breath. But a moment's inattention and we're off in fantasy land again.

I always liked to write talks around personal experiences and was racking my brains trying to remember one until I recognised what was blocking all my memories. It was the sensual desire happening right now as I long for a good example. This illustrates the main problem with the hindrances. We're so driven by them, we don't notice what's driving us. Fish will be the last to discover water.

When we notice we've got lost in fantasy several times, we need to take a step back. Ask ourselves, what's going on here? In my case, I'd acknowledge I'm trying to write a Dhamma talk. Very often that simple acknowledgement brings perspective and I can reflect that no Dhamma talk will bring lasting happiness, whereas meditation practice does bring me in that direction.

Sometimes we just can't let go. We can't be bothered following the breath because we're so intent on indulging our fantasy. In this case, we let sensual desire become the focus for mindfulness. We can use the noting word desire, desire, as we feel the experience. As I explore this now, I feel pleasant sensations in my head, along with a very enticing imagery light that seems to contain the perfect example for the Dhamma talk. There's tension in the jaws and my chest. The breath for the moment is still. It's as if I don't want to breathe for fear of disturbing my wonderful example of sensual desire. As I continue to watch, the bright light gradually dims and fades. The tension relaxes. The breath flows normally again. Desire has now burnt itself out.

Because I've been mindful of the hindrance, I've now undermined the force of desire inside me. The next time desire arises, I find it easier to persuade myself to let it go. This is such a gift to our future selves. Trying to satisfy all our desires is exhausting. Each one gives a moment's pleasure, but then we're off again looking for something else. There is another source of pleasure. It's the contentment that comes from relaxing, realizing we have enough to satisfy our needs right now. This wisdom is strengthened every time we work our way mindfully through desire.

So when we notice we're obsessing about something, the perfect birthday present, the perfect sponge cake, this is an indicator that sensual desire is at work. Congratulate yourself for having acknowledged the issue. Often that's the hardest step. Then see, can you encourage yourself to let go? Gently remind yourself how fleeting is the pleasure that comes of satisfying these desires. If, despite all your wise words, you're still hell-bent on imagining the perfect sponge cake, then let sensual desire be the focus for mindfulness. Feel its energy, any pleasant tingles, any tensions. You really want to experience the thirst for imaginary pleasure. It is a perfectly valid form of meditation.

Suppose your mood has flipped and you're judging yourself harshly for being distracted by the silly desire for the perfect sponge cake. This is the second hindrance, aversion. Again, the hardest step is to notice what's going on. We're so busy condemning ourselves as bad meditators, we don't notice the fact that we're judging. But with practice, we get better at spotting this. And we say, oh, this is the experience of judging. And with that, judgment often stops. This is the magic of mindfulness. Anger, judgment and other stressful states often disappear on acknowledgement. We only cause ourselves suffering by mistake, unwittingly. As soon as we notice the suffering, we stop causing it.

At other times, however, the anger or judgment runs so deep that noticing these isn't enough to bring them to a stop. In fact, they may get even stronger because now we're judging ourselves for being angry, angry at ourselves for judging, and we're going

round in circles and we don't know how to get out of the loop. The hindrance of aversion can be a very painful experience. When we're assailed by aversion like this, we let the experience itself become the focus for meditation. We feel the tensions, the unpleasant sensations, how the breath is affected. We notice the stream of thoughts. And we're not trying to get rid of anger or judgment, but curious about it. We want to become intimate with the experience and learn to relax with it. This is a challenge as none of us likes to feel our anger, feel our judgment. But if we can persuade ourselves to just give it a try, the pain itself teaches us how to be more accepting of our human imperfections and more compassionate towards ourselves and others.

Physical pain is one very common cause of aversion. It can stir fear, anxiety, anger or other forms of mental pain. Often we move automatically so as to relieve pain without first becoming mindful of the pain and the desire to move. Alternatively, the spiritual warrior comes crashing onto the scene, guns blazing, and we determined to sit rock still for the full meditation hour, suppressing any feelings of anxiety or vulnerability. If you sense this, or if the pain is too strong, then it's best to move. Move slowly and mindfully so that you can watch how the mind changes from aversion to relief as you get more comfortable. This is a valuable lesson. We realize that physical pain wasn't actually the issue. It was our mental reaction that caused the suffering. Pain is a great teacher. So we need to encourage ourselves to sit with it, feel it, learn from it. But we also need to take care of the body, respect our limits, and learn from those magic moments as we move to relieve the pain.

The third hindrance is sloth and torpor. We keep nodding off. And again, the hardest first step is to recognize what's going on. We can get so overpowered by sleepiness, so mentally dull that we can't even summon the energy to say, this is sleepiness, dullness, lethargy. Like all the hindrances, we want to experience this one, feel it, learn from it.

So sit up straight, drag that head up into the air. Sometimes opening the eyes helps, letting in the light. Joseph Goldstein describes imagining his eyelids being held open by toothpicks. And though the waves of sleepiness came and went, they couldn't quite overpower him because his eyes were being held open by toothpicks. If that doesn't work and you're still nodding off, try standing. The Buddha also recommends mental stimulation. For example, you could repeat the Four Noble Truths. Think about what they mean. It's one time in meditation where thinking is encouraged, but only till you've woken up the mind. Then it's bye-bye intellect, hello sensations and feelings again.

Once we've aroused ourselves enough to be mindful, our aim is to investigate the experience. Feel the dullness in the mind, sensations in the body. Usually there are pleasant feelings drawing us into a doze as well as unpleasant ones associated with our wish to stay awake. It's a rich mixture.

I remember going through a lot of sleepiness on a retreat till I suddenly realised I was waiting for the sleepiness to pass so that I could then meditate. This was a big discovery for me as I could then recognize that same waiting mind state in many situations. When I was bored at a committee meeting, for example, each time I noticed the waiting state, I would then grow more alert, be able to participate. And this helped me overcome habits of laziness and passivity and to become more active and engaged in life.

The next hindrance, restlessness, is sometimes felt in the body. We keep moving around, trying to get comfortable, or it can be felt in the mind. We flit off into one worry after another. Again, the major challenge is to take that little step back, recognise what's happening and say to ourselves, okay, this is the experience of restlessness. What can I learn from this? That simple acknowledgement is sometimes all that's needed. A moment ago, we were fidgeting and worrying, not knowing what the matter was. But now that we've recognised the problem, named it, our troubles are over. Such a relief when this happens. It really builds our faith in the practice.

Sometimes it doesn't resolve so easily. We know we're restless, worrying, but we're still restless and worried. In this case, let restlessness itself become the focus for meditation. Feel the aversion, the desire to move, to think. You want to get to know the raw experience. Allow it to express itself. Watched mindfully, restlessness eventually burns out.

But sometimes we can't manage to be mindful. Restlessness is too strong, keeps sweeping us away into worrying and fidgeting. In this case, it can be good to open the eyes, look at something calming like a plant or the sky, and this gives a broader perspective and the worries and fidgets won't so easily overwhelm us. We'll be aware of them.

I was anxious, restless, worried for weeks after major surgery to remove my voice box. Luckily, my hospital bed was by a window and during the daytime, my eyes were glued to a big tree in the lawn outside. My body and mind were exploding with restless energy, but it seemed as though the tree could soak up all the impact. And during sleepless nights, the clouds in the sky did the same job. Sounds could also soak up my restless energy. I always preferred it when the world was busy. And although it was very unpleasant few weeks, it opened my eyes to the peace on offer from what I had often ig-

nored. Trees, clouds, background sounds. I began to intuit a vast ocean of peace, cradling my restless mind. This was a beautiful discovery, a great compensation for the loss of my voice box.

Learning to bear with restlessness is a wonderful gift. When it gets overwhelming, take whatever support you can from the outside world. A calming focus for the eyes, background sounds for the ears, the sense of touch can also be very soothing. I spent a lot of time fingering the bedsheets just to feel their texture. And sometimes walking can help. Not the very slow Mahāsi pace, but a gentle meander. We're not trying to get rid of restlessness, but supporting ourselves as we feel its energies in moment to moment mindfulness.

The final hindrance is doubt. We need to differentiate here between honest doubt and skeptical doubt. If you have never tried watching anger, you might doubt whether this could possibly be beneficial. This is honest doubt. We genuinely don't know the answer. Skeptical doubt is where we refuse to consider watching anger because we're not sure whether this could be beneficial. Skeptical doubt prevents learning. We're unwilling to take risks, unwilling to experiment, to find out for ourselves what is false and what is true.

For many of us, doubt takes the form of self-doubt. We agree that the teachings are useful but are convinced we couldn't possibly do the practice. If this gets the upper hand, it becomes paralysing. We can't try out anything new, can't commit, can't take on responsibilities.

Once again, the major step is to recognise what's happening. Instead of believing thought that says, I can't possibly meditate. I couldn't ever have any insight. I shouldn't have come on retreat. I might as well go home now. We pause for a moment, acknowledge this is the experience of skeptical doubt. This gives us some perspective. We can reason with ourselves, encourage ourselves. Is this part of a larger pattern in life? Doubting we can succeed at anything? Can we use the retreat situation as a golden opportunity to learn to work with this hindrance? We might still feel full of doubt, but so long as we stick with the retreat, do the practice, doubt has been undermined and self-confidence has been strengthened, that's not a bad exchange.

Every hindrance cultivates the opposite virtue as we work through them mindfully. Working with sensual desire cultivates generosity and contentment. Anger transforms to goodwill. Mindful observance of sloth and torpor cultivates energy and resolve. And working with restlessness brings forth tranquility and doubt transforms to confidence and trust.

This transformation comes about because we're learning to feel our feelings without believing their usual message. The feeling of doubt in my experience is most intense in my face, where the skin seems to shrink back towards my skull, prompting thoughts like, I can't do this. But I'm doing it anyhow, taking a footstep or taking another mindful breath. The feeling of sleepiness is gorgeous and every bit of me wants to curl up around it and forget the outside world. But for mindfulness practice, I do whatever I can to stay awake and alert. Same with all the hindrances. We let them happen, feel the feelings, hear the thoughts without believing them.

The hindrances are like emotional storms. It would be a relief to do the bidding of each storm, to go with the flow, sleep when we're sleepy, lash out when we're angry and satiate all our desires. But the relief is short-lived and all we've done is to sow the seeds of future storm and weaken our ability to deal with them. As they say, only dead fish go with the flow. If we go against the flow, be mindful of the challenge. This can be uncomfortable, confusing, but it's worthy work, ennobling. We are weakening the potential for future storms, cultivating emotional resilience and spiritual strength.

May we welcome each hindrance as a golden opportunity to learn the Dhamma and walk the path to the end of suffering.

The Factors of Enlightenment

To help us bear with the hindrances, it's good to remember that just being mindful of these develops skillful qualities like patience and resilience, which in turn back up the strengths we need for *vipassanā*. These are termed the factors of enlightenment. Sounds lofty, but in fact these are very practical qualities that can be detected and developed in every meditation session.

Pantya Bodhidama uses the image of wild geese in flight, with mindfulness in the lead and the other qualities following. As you know, wild geese fly in a V-shaped formation, with one flank spread widely, almost abreast of the leader, pushing ahead, the other flank in the slipstream, taking it easy. This is a very helpful image because three of the enlightenment factors are stimulating, keeping us alert, while three have a calming effect, making sure we don't run away with ourselves.

In the lead is mindfulness, *sati* in Pali, often translated as awareness. As we breathe in, we know we are breathing in. As we breathe out, we know we are breathing out. At one level, we're aware all day long, hearing sounds, seeing what's in front of our eyes and so on. But we're not usually aware of being aware. It's this level of awareness that

we're cultivating in vipassanā, termed *sammā sati*, right awareness. We hear a sound and we know we are hearing. Simple as that. And yet we very easily forget all about this simple and natural ability to know experience as it happens.

We get too busy doing this and that to even notice that life is happening now. Not in the future with our great plans, but now. This sound, this footstep, this breath. These fleeting experiences can seem irrelevant. We assume we should be doing something, achieving something. It's very hard for us to believe that not doing is also worthwhile. It's only through mindfulness practice that we see how any doing, any judging, interfering, any attempt to achieve adds tension and stress to present experience. And thus, mindfulness trains us to relax, become content with being rather than doing.

Within that magic combination of alert relaxation, we sense our minds opening, some vital energy stirring, some potential within us becoming conscious. This is *satipaṇṇā*, our intuitive intelligence, which is waking up and looking for the path to full awakening, enlightenment.

To help us find and keep to the path, we have all the supporting factors for mindfulness. The first of the slipstream is called *samādhi* in Pali, the ability of the mind to direct and rest attention. Unfortunately, *samādhi* is usually translated as concentration, which suggests straining to hold attention. But think of how easily your attention is held by a good film, a story, a puzzle, a hobby. That's the flavour of concentration we are aiming for in support of mindfulness. The word focus is also helpful.

We start by focusing on the sensations of the abdomen caused by breathing. If a sound grabs attention, we change focus and attend to the pitch and rhythm of the sound as we note hearing, hearing. If we find ourselves getting bored, restless, fed up, we broaden the focus to acknowledge that sense of restlessness or boredom. And to our surprise, perhaps, we might then notice the sensations at the abdomen coming into focus again, rising and falling.

The concentration we develop in Vipassanā keeps shifting its focus so that attention lands wherever it is naturally called. Concentration has a calming effect because it gathers our mental energies and trains them in one direction. Suppose we're lost in a foreign city. A thousand thoughts clamour for attention. Will I ask someone the way? Should I try that street? Should I find a police station? While the mind spins around like this, it grows more and more agitated. To calm ourselves, we choose to act on one and do that mindfully. It hardly matters which we choose. The important thing is to give the mind a focus for mindfulness. This will have an immediately calming effect.

It's the same in meditation when any of the hindrances show up. The mind spins around trying to think our way out of the difficulty, but only grows more and more agitated. If instead we focus attention somewhere – the breath, the footsteps, the emotions underlying our disturbance – a degree of calm follows and we can bear with the disturbance more easily, learn a useful Dhamma lesson from the experience.

The calming effect of concentration is balanced by the stimulating effect of energy, the leading factor in the wide flank of our wild geese formation. We have the physical energy of the posture. Experiment for yourself. Feel how much more alert you are when you sit up straight and how this dulls down as you let yourself slump. Standing is even more energising when we need an extra shot during bouts of sloth and torpor.

There is also the energy that comes from resolution. Again, experiment. See how alert and determined you feel when you make a firm resolution to be mindful. Bhante Bodhidharma recommends St. Augustine's approach using the phrases I can, I ought, I want, I will to open four avenues for the energy of resolve to flow. Try saying I can be mindful. I ought to be mindful. I want to be mindful. I will be mindful. Repeat these to make their meaning sink deep. Although attention will still wander, you'll find it easier to rein it back in, gather it around the breath or footstep or whatever aspect of present experience is calling attention.

Resolve itself can be strengthened by reminding ourselves of some broad aim for the practice. Although we let go of aims as we relax into present experience, we can remember them when we need to summon more energy to deepen our resolve. For example, bring to mind whatever inspired you to learn to practice in the first place. Maybe it was a book you read, a teaching you heard, a meeting with someone who radiated wisdom or compassion. Maybe it was an experience that gave you a glimpse of your spiritual potential. Having brought your inspiration, the goal for your practice to mind, you might find more meaning and depth in the resolutions: I can, I ought, I want, I will. Then let go, relax. Trust that those intentions will support your ongoing practice as you attend to the sensations of breathing.

Thus our first pair of supports for mindfulness are concentration, calming us by gathering and directing attention, and energy, prodding us to wakefulness. The second of the slipstream factors is equanimity. This is an evenly balanced state of mind not disturbed by unpleasantness, not enchanted and enslaved by pleasure.

When something very enticing happens – the sound of your name being called by a friend, the taste of chocolate – we usually react automatically, looking around eagerly for our friend, anticipating a pleasant chat, devouring the chocolate. We're so caught up in our reaction, we hardly even register the initial moment of pleasure. If equanimity

were established, we would feel the pleasure of the call, the taste, but not get excited. We would enjoy and appreciate the situation while knowing it as fleeting and unstable, not something to invest our hopes in. We might still look around gladly for our friend, but not be dismayed or disgruntled if they're already disappearing, waving goodbye.

Equanimity develops as we encounter *dukkha* mindfully. Seeing how fleeting and unreliable pleasure is, we learn not to get so excited. Seeing that pain is impermanent, we grow confident that we can bear with *dukkha*. The mind grows less reactive, steadier, better at seeing the wider picture, more willing and able to bear the ups and downs of life. Equanimity is hard-earned, but worth every tear we shed, every gnashing of teeth needed for its cultivation.

Equanimity is balanced by investigation of Dhamma, the second of the supporting factors on the wide flank. While equanimity persuades us to step back, see the larger picture, investigation requires us to cozy up to whatever calls attention. Say we're doing walking meditation. Investigation prompts the question: what is it I'm really experiencing? The question draws attention close to the basic sensory data. We feel how the foot peels off the floor, moves through the air, touches down again.

Thinking can be temporarily suspended. But whenever it sneaks in to trap us in stories, plans, musings, we lose contact with the movements of the feet. Slowly it dawns on us that there's no room for my plans, my dreams, no room for anything I normally think of as I and me and mine, in that strangely familiar, fluid level of reality. There is only the awareness of the feet walking. A pleasant experience, but without room for the endlessly enchanting story of me. It's the mental factor of investigation that has led us to this strange and unsettling conclusion. We've brought our attention to the feet as they walk and discovered the Dhamma, the truths that the Buddha claims will set us free from delusion, free from suffering.

Investigation is based on curiosity. We want to know what's true. Without curiosity, meditation can help us relax, be happy, take it easy, stop trying to achieve anything. While this is indeed a welcome and healthy contrast to the busyness of modern life, it's not leading us to full awakening. It's only as we focus on detail that we start to see *an-icca*, *dukkha*, *anattā* – how sensations and feelings keep changing whether we like it or not, and how unsatisfactory that is for our usual grasping sense of self. The up-close, microscopic view challenges our fuzzy view of the world.

Any form of Dhamma study sharpens the factor investigation. Listening to Dhamma talks, taking part in discussions, reading scriptures and Dhamma books, all these stir curiosity, stimulate us to discover whether our own experience corresponds to that described in the talks, the books, the scriptures. If, the moment you start meditating, your

mind settles into a blank daze and all your enthusiasm for Dhamma study goes out the window, see if the noting word learning, learning, brings back that sense of curiosity. It helps if you can think back to happy learning situations in life. Did you enjoy learning how to ride a bike? Bake a cake? Learning is a challenge, yes, but how else are we going to grow any wiser?

For many of us, the notion of learning the truth about life, the universe and everything is so exciting that we immediately get lost in our speculations about what Nibbāna is and isn't. Whenever this happens, we have to let go of heady excitement, bring ourselves back down to earth as gently as we can, so that this breath, this footstep can do their job of teaching us the Dhamma.

To help us calm down, we have the final factor on the slipstream of mindfulness: tranquillity. This is the felt peace of a mind and heart at rest. It's a contentment with present experience, just the feeling of the foot lifting off the ground perhaps. It's hard to believe we can be content with so little, but we can. The advertising industry would collapse if we could all detect this potential.

Whatever helps us feel relaxed and at ease cultivates tranquillity. One way to do this is by auto-suggestion. We lay off investigation for a while and instead use the noting words: calming, calming. The idea of the breath as gentle wave can help, as if we're in a hammock or a boat at harbour being rocked by rhythmic waves of breathing. Body scans can also be calming, especially if we focus on the limbs and bring attention downward. As you are breathing out, let attention flow down from left shoulder to left hand. Feel the hand resting on the lap until, at the next out-breath, run attention from right shoulder to right hand. Keep scanning down the limbs till you feel the mind settling, growing tranquil.

One mistake that's easy to make is to expect tranquillity to mean perfect, deep peace and disdain anything less. That's a bit like expecting to win Wimbledon when we first take up a tennis racket. We need to remember we're practising, training, and that any move in the right direction needs to be noticed, encouraged. Look out for any pleasant, relaxing feelings in meditation. Appreciate them. Make much of them.

Another danger, of course, is that we curl up around the pleasant feeling of tranquillity and get dozy, or allow a lovely trance to take over, where we can fool ourselves that we're totally enlightened and don't need to do any more work. This is why tranquillity needs the balance of joy, the final factor on the wide flank of our wild geese formation, pushing us onward.

Joy in Vipassanā can be understood as enthusiasm for practice. We want to continue being present, being aware, learning the Dhamma. Like tranquillity, joy has a pleasant feeling, but it has more energy. It naturally follows from investigation of Dhamma. Investigation uses the mind's ability to solve a puzzle, sort out this from that. Joy is the feel-good that comes when we're engaged and interested in what we're doing.

The joy of Vipassanā is subtle and we might even believe meditation to be a flat, joyless affair. But it can be instructive to ask yourself: is there anything holding me to meditate a moment longer? If you can relax enough to find the answer, you will get a taste of the Vipassanā joy, the joy of interest, curiosity. In this case, we're interested in finding out what's holding us to meditate. But any question asked mindfully will engage attention, cultivate the joy of Vipassanā.

This joy of engaged interest is easily overlooked. Taking the time to notice and appreciate the experience is like cultivating a new pathway for the energy of life to flow. Again, the more we appreciate it, the more often our psychophysical energies will use this pathway in future.

Another reason we fail to detect joy in meditation is because we tend to be over-achievers. We want to be enlightened now rather than crawling slowly through the labyrinth of delusions. This is why tranquillity makes such a good partner for joy in this final pair of our wild geese formation. Tranquillity helps us relax enough to notice the joy of engaging with this puzzle we call the Dhamma.

Another error is to cling to preconceived notions. We've heard of meditative joy as gorgeous tingly feelings all over the body, as if we're being massaged by an ocean of butterflies. And so we expect total over-the-moon rapture and disregard anything less. We have to be patient, realistic, remember that we're learning to enjoy meditation, and that again, each small move in that direction is to be welcomed.

To recap, the factors of enlightenment can be imagined as a flock of wild geese soaring high in the sky in their classic V-shaped formation. In the lead is mindfulness. Breathing in, we know we are breathing in. Simple as that. On the wide flank prodding us onward are energy, investigation of Dhamma and the joy of being engaged in an activity so interesting and worthwhile. In the slipstream calming us down we have concentration, equanimity and lastly – taking it very easy in this slow, slow slippage towards liberation – comes tranquillity, the peace of a still, untroubled mind.

In the Theravāda scriptures, the Buddha says we must develop and pursue these seven factors. In a translation of a related Tibetan scripture by Anālayo, the words are cultivate and make much of, which I like. We are to care for, appreciate, celebrate and make much of these seven factors. In turn, they lead to our long-lasting happiness and well-being.

I remember seeing a documentary about a nomadic tribe in Nepal. Although their journey was challenging, hazardous, and for some proved fatal, the sentiment that inspired the trek was: it's the journey that counts, not the destination. This is the attitude we need so as to cultivate the factors of enlightenment.

The process can also be likened to training a puppy dog. The trick is to reward good behaviour, ignore the bad. So too in Vipassanā. We don't make any big deal out of lapses in attention when the mind wanders. We just get straight back to the job. On the other hand, we look out for, appreciate, pat ourselves on the back for any traces of tranquility, joy or any other factors of enlightenment. It's okay to celebrate our successes. In fact, it's more than okay. It's necessary.

May we soar through wide open skies to our true home, the peace and joy of liberation.

How Much Pain, Physical or Mental Should We Suffer?

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 2 min read

This essay explores the delicate balance between developing spiritual qualities through enduring pain and the wisdom of knowing when to seek relief. Bhante Bodhidhamma addresses how pain and suffering can serve as vehicles for cultivating patience, equanimity, and insight, while warning against pride-driven self-mortification that the Buddha rejected as meaningless torture. Drawing from practical meditation experience, particularly with knee pain during sitting practice, the teaching emphasizes matching endurance with quality investigation rather than mere stoic endurance.

The essay examines the subjective nature of what constitutes bearable versus unbearable suffering, touching on sensitive topics like suicide while maintaining that only the fully liberated can make such choices without karmic consequences. Central to the discussion is the Second Noble Truth—understanding that while physical and mental pain may have multiple causes, our relationship to them through aversion, fear, and despair is self-generated. This insight into how we create dukkha through taṇhā (unwholesome desire) points toward liberation through understanding rather than mere endurance. The teaching offers practical wisdom for both meditation practitioners dealing with physical discomfort and anyone facing life's inevitable sufferings.

The question as to how much pain and suffering we should bear needs to be referred back to primary aims – the one to purify and strengthen the heart, the other to bring an end to delusion by way of insight. If the pain and suffering is bearable, it becomes a vehicle to develop patience, equanimity, affectionate awareness and insight. Once we feel, if only temporarily, that we have reached that limit, then it seems wise to find a way to bring an end to the pain, or at assuage it. For instance, in sitting meditation aching knees are well documented. Unfortunately, the knees don't bend that way and relief comes only when the tendons at the top of the legs lengthen. In the meantime, we have to deal with the pain. So long as the pain is bearable we can continue to investigate, but when it becomes so painful that all the effort is to endure, then at least we are developing forbearance. But there may come a point when the pain is just too much and then it seems wise to change the posture and not grit the teeth and clench the jaw and be praised for our heroic stance against pain? Our unshakeable endurance! And find we have damaged our knees. This has happened. In fact, I began to have a loose cartilage myself at one point in early Zen practice. But when circumstances completely

undermine the process of spiritual investigation, what point is there in suffering them – save, of course, to build up that quality of endurance. Even here we have to be careful. A meditator once told me he had a very bad tooth ache. I asked why he did not take an aspirin until he could see a dentist. He said he was building up the virtues needed for greater suffering. I asked him: suppose there will be no greater suffering for you? It seems to me we should match endurance with the quality of investigation. Not to do so may indeed be an act of pride. ‘I’m bigger than pain’. Such an attitude leads us into self-mortification which the Buddha found to be meaningless torture. Rather endurance should be balanced with care of the body. For those in dreadful pain, there may arise the option of suicide. Of course, what is considered to be bearable or unbearable is subjective, always personal and individual. The topic of suicide is a delicate one. Suffice here is to say that it is generally understood that only those who are fully liberated can take their own lives without some unwholesome karmic consequences. But this has been questioned. However, it is important to remind ourselves that understanding how suffering and unsatisfactoriness (dukkha) arise, we need to know that the given, be it physical or mental pain and illnesses may have a multitude of causes, but our relationship to them of aversion, fear and despair is self-generated. To investigate how we create suffering and unsatisfactoriness is a path to liberation by way of understanding the Second Noble Truth – the Cause of Suffering is Unwholesome Desire, tanha. (I’ll have another go at euthanasia – a good death again sometime. I had a shot at it with <https://www.satipanya.org.uk/essays/Assisted%20Suicide.pdf>)

Identity and Not-Self

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 21 min

In this exploration of one of Buddhism's most challenging teachings, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines anattā (not-self) through the lens of everyday experience. Drawing from the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10), he explains how our identification with roles—whether as cook, teacher, or meditator—becomes a source of dukkha (suffering and unsatisfactoriness) when things don't go as planned.

Using vivid personal anecdotes about failed attempts with gas cylinders and printer cartridges, Bhante illustrates how emotional storms can become "rocket fuel for awakening" when met with mindful awareness. He demonstrates the practical application of internal and external mindfulness practice from the Mahāsi tradition, showing how we can observe the process of "selfing" (upādāna) as temporary identities arise and dissolve based on conditions.

The talk offers valuable insights into working with identification patterns in daily life, explaining how unpleasant sensations can serve as messengers reminding us "this is not who you really are." This teaching provides both theoretical understanding and practical tools for recognizing the conditional, impermanent nature of all constructed identities, pointing toward the peace that comes from seeing through these limited self-concepts.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa.

Homage to the Blessed, Noble and Fully Self-Enlightened One.

The Buddha's teaching on *anattā*, not-self, is a hard aspect of the Dhamma to understand. We will all be grappling with it till the moment of enlightenment. To motivate ourselves for the challenge, it's worth reflecting on the suffering we experience because of identifying with our body, our mind, our life stories.

Take the example of role identification. Whatever role we're playing in life—father, daughter, gardener—we want to do it well, which is a good motive, no problem there. It's when we over-identify, can't see beyond our role, that *dukkha*, suffering, emerges.

On a good day, we get a buzz out of doing things well: cooking a meal, mending a puncture, teaching a class. But we all have days when these go wrong. The sponge cake turns out as a stodgy lump. The tyre deflates the minute we put the wheel back on. We go blank when trying to teach. This is when the dukkha of identification is felt.

The more we identify as a good cook, a good DIYer, a good teacher, the harder it is to bear the letdown. We can't stop thinking about it. What went wrong? How could I have made such a mess of things? What did they think of me? We look for someone to blame. If he hadn't interrupted, it would have been perfect.

While none of us enjoy those times when we've made a hash of something, it is worth dwelling on them long enough to acknowledge that the source of the misery is not actually the gooey mess or the deflating tyre. It's the sense of me and how badly I've let myself down. That's the real nub—a loss of confidence, perhaps an almost desperate need to reassert ourselves, prove our ability.

The more clearly we can acknowledge the suffering that comes from identification, the more we will be willing to explore the difficult Buddhist teaching of anattā, not-self. And there is no doubt anattā is a difficult nut to crack. We all have a strong sense that we are the ones baking the cake, mending the tyre, teaching the class, living our life. It's hard to even toy with the idea that this might not be so.

The Buddha's advice is to keep breaking down experience into smaller and smaller chunks. It's easier to get glimpses of the truth in these. Then gradually, over time, the notion of not-self becomes easier to contemplate. We start to see its benefits, how much easier life is when we're not identified by our roles or opinions or abilities or achievements. It's wonderful to have nothing to defend.

One instruction from the *Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta*, the Four Foundations of Mindfulness, that I found very helpful for exploring anattā is the advice to practice internally and externally. Internal can be interpreted to mean our subjective felt experience, while external means our mental understanding of it. We feel the sensations of breathing for internal practice. For external practice, we reflect that we are breathing.

The Mahāsi noting technique provides a way of practicing both internally and externally. We feel the breath and at the same time make a mental note of it. Same for walking, eating, talking. All of life can be known both internally as moment-to-moment sensations and feelings, and externally as our objective mental perception of what's happening.

Say we are practising mindfulness of breathing. Feeling the sensations of breathing is to practise mindfulness internally. Although we don't usually make the thought conscious, we assume we are the one who's sitting here breathing. If we're also practising externally, then we're noting "rising, falling" as we track the breath.

As concentration deepens, it can seem like our identity shifts. Instead of being the one who is sitting here breathing, we sense ourselves as the observer, some sort of spaced-out entity hovering around our head, the one who is watching the body breathing. On a good day, we'll also be able to watch our thoughts coming and going, watch emotions rise and fade, realise we don't have to get caught up in them.

All of this is helping us disentangle our confusion about identity. Internally, we feel ourselves breathing, thinking, growing happy one moment, sad the next. But because of our external perspective, we realise we don't need to identify with our thoughts, emotions, breathing. We see this as happening of their own accord, driven by various stimuli, but not driven by what I now think of as me.

This can be a lovely experience, a sense of coming home, having found our true self—a sort of disembodied entity that hovers in and around the body, equanimous, interested, watching the show without getting caught up in it. But after a while, we might grow uncomfortable. Things start to feel sticky, as if there's a sheet of velcro passing over each sensation, pulling us along with it. We start getting caught up with experience again, identified with thoughts and feelings and emotions. We are again the one who is sitting here breathing and now anxiously trying to find our way back to the lofty crow's nest from which we've been able to observe the show.

Although there's a temptation to see this as bad meditation, we should really see it as a precious opportunity to learn the Dhamma more deeply. Pema Chödrön likens these episodes as rocket fuel for enlightenment.

To take a practical example: we got a new connector for our gas canister the other day, and so I overcame all my fears about gas and explosions and went to hook it up. After about a dozen failed attempts, all the bits eventually came together. It looked perfect. But gas started leaking the moment I opened the cylinder. I took it apart, reread the instructions, reconnected it. Still no go. Disappointing.

I was then asked to look at the printer because it wasn't working. It needed a new toner cartridge. And again, I overcame my deep suspicion of all things electrical and mechanical and managed to replace the cartridge. But no go. Every page came out

white as snow with nothing at all being printed. Again, I took it all apart, reread the instructions, watched a few videos on replacing the cartridge, tried again. Still no go. Another disappointment.

And this time I felt the edge of bad humour. My mind was starting to close up, feel oppressed by others and by the world in general. A bit later, Bhante came over, took the cartridge out and, in his own words, gave it a few thumps and put it back in place. Lo and behold, it worked perfectly. Of course, I was impressed and amused and grateful, but alongside these happy responses, my incipient bad humour gave a painful kick within. Why couldn't it have worked for me?

I decided to go to my room to explore this more deeply. Rationally, it was just silliness, the mind building a mountain out of a molehill. And yet there was—not quite a mountain, but certainly more than a molehill of frustration at my failure to connect up a gas cylinder and change a toner cartridge. But what was more distressing was the admission of being so emotionally impacted by such trivial matters. What was the point of decades of Dhamma practice only to be getting distraught over nothing?

This is the dukkha, the suffering, of identification: identifying with self as manager, the one who is supposed to sort out problems; identification with self as meditator, who should by now have developed outstanding equanimity; not to speak of self as meditation teacher who should know the Dhamma upside down and be able to instantly see through this latest delusion.

As always, mindfulness allowed the storm to blow itself out. Looking back now, I sense the truth of Pema Chödrön's advice to see these times when our buttons are pressed and we feel like a two-year-old again as rocket fuel for enlightenment. Emotional storms have so much energy that negative thoughts and feelings we normally suppress come skyrocketing into consciousness. In the light of awareness, their pain becomes so acute that our system is forced to learn a new way of coping with the dukkha.

This new coping mechanism, learned from within, from moment-to-moment awareness, opens up new pathways for energy flow in the body and new doorways in the mind. We discover new thoughts and perspectives which are gentler, kinder, more patient and forgiving.

In my own example, a new doorway opened because of feeling so acutely the pain of identification, how it traps the mind in a prison of delusion. The pain of this prison sharpened when the storyline of "me who should be better at everything" had fallen away, and I could more clearly feel the emotional patterns underlying the thoughts.

Practising mindfulness internally, I could feel how eagerly the body and mind pounced on a pleasant feeling, sending tentacles of energy around it to clutch and hold as mine, while a bright light switched on in my head, which I perceived as me—confident, on top of things, in control. A whirlpool of energy rose around my chest and head to sustain this delight. The feeling of confidence was gorgeous, but watching it, the external perspective showed up the craziness and pain underneath.

Seeing this, I desperately wanted to escape the prison of identification. The external perspective let me recognise the crazy whirlpool of energy and the bright light as what the Buddha terms *upādāna*, usually translated as grasping or clinging. It's also sometimes referred to as selfing. What is happening is that unskilful desire, *taṇhā*, has driven us to create a new identity so as to fulfil this desire.

The better we get to know this experience of selfing, the more we are persuaded of the Buddhist teaching on *anattā*, not-self. Knowing from our direct experience that a me has suddenly arisen makes it hard to take me too seriously. We start to see how various mes arise and fade depending on external stimuli. When things go well, a happy, pleased, self-confident me emerges. But that fades quickly when things go wrong and the deflated, miserable me takes its place instead.

Back to my own example of watching the fallout from my emotional storm. Internally, I was experiencing the selfing process, which was generating a confident, delighted sense of me—one who could fix all the printers and gas cylinders in the world. However, the external perspective knew this as delusion. Undermined by that news, the confident self suddenly collapsed into a timid, scared, stiff entity which felt it had no right to exist. A moment later, the confident self reappeared, wildly insisting it was totally in control of the situation.

This yo-yo between elated confidence and abject fear continued for some time. Both identities felt excruciatingly painful and vulnerable. There was a strong desire to abandon the meditation, but I persisted, allowing my emotional roller coaster to take its course, trusting that a lesson would eventually be learned.

In *vipassanā*, we can't interfere; we can't tell ourselves to stop being deluded. We have to bear patiently with our greeds, hatreds and delusions, trust them to burn out in the light of awareness, teach us the Dhamma as we suffer their flames.

And sure enough, the energy of the roller coaster gradually diminished. As it did, so my attention extended gingerly beyond the whirlpool of elated and fearful energies in my chest and head to sense my arms, legs, my body sitting. I couldn't really feel these in any detail. I only knew them as faint suggestions. They seemed like strangers from another world—alien, scary.

Luckily, curiosity was stronger than fear, and each out-breath let awareness rest more attentively in the seemingly alien body. At last, some feelings rippled through. They were unpleasant and carried the message that the heady whirlpool of confidence was not me, not mine. The emotionally energetic, deluded part of myself felt this as a threat. But some wisdom emerged from the depths to welcome the unpleasantness. Here was something I would not want to cling to, therefore very welcome.

Letting attention rest on the unpleasantness became a non-interfering way of containing and restraining the deluded self. Gradually, the energetic, bright-light me felt glad of being contained and limited—embodied rather than a totally deluded mental entity. It became like looking in a mirror.

Perhaps we've all had similar experiences where we sense ourselves as both watching and being watched. Sometimes I was the watcher, the observer, the disembodied entity that hovers near my head. This was the external mindful perspective. Sometimes I was the mirror image. This was the internal mindfulness perspective, bringing the embodied experience of me—the experience of sitting and breathing and knowing that I was being watched.

The desire to know who I really am has always been very strong for me. And part of me that was observing, watching, felt this now as an almost overwhelming attraction towards the mirror image. I wanted to grasp hold of the image, devour it even. But whenever I gave in to that desire, it was as if I'd gobbled up my own reflection. All that was left were little shivers of fear and grief as I realised how I destroyed what I desired.

I had to suffer the fear and grief, wait patiently till peace prevailed, before I could again glimpse the mirror image. I became grateful for any unpleasant sensations in the mirror image. These acted like repulsive forces, countering the attempt to grasp and own the image. They carried the message: this isn't who you really are. That understanding also helped me not to grasp and thereby destroy the image of me that I desired so deeply.

I became grateful for the fact that the body can repel the mind as well as attract it. By this stage, I'd forgotten altogether about my sense of having let myself down. It just wasn't an issue. And I was very glad I'd persisted with the meditation, hadn't given up at the height of the emotional storm.

The great gift of sitting with the misery was that the message "this is not who you really are" became for the first time totally welcome. As the meditation went on, the message brought joy, relief, gratitude. I understood it as necessary to counter the strong desire to identify with my body and mind—the only reflection I can find for whatever it is I sense myself to be.

In subsequent meditations and in daily life, I was better able to recognise all mes as temporary and conditional. I could smile at them, appreciate them, but not be surprised when they dissolved. This is such a gift. The deluded me expects too much of me, expects me always to be on top of everything. Being able to see myself as limited brings forth compassion, as well as appreciation for whatever efforts I make to follow the path, fulfil my various roles.

And if I'm getting a bit heated in conversation, clinging to my opinion, then I can focus on some unpleasant sensation and welcome them as messengers that this strongly opinionated one is not your true self either. Again, this brings a smile and allows me to be more flexible, ready to change my mind and see the other's point of view.

I hope this illustration of working with the dukkha of identification encourages you to explore the teaching around anattā, not-self, and perhaps also see how those external and internal mindfulness perspectives can help with this challenging teaching. In this way, may we all see through our identification as daughter, manager, cook or whatever—see these as temporary, conditional, not ever designed to be satisfactory.

As the Buddha said, whatever is inconstant, conditioned, unsatisfactory, is not worthy of being thought of as me. We sell ourselves short by investing in these limited identities. Our continued practice leads us to a truth, a resting place beyond all such limitations. May we all experience the peace and bliss of *Nibbāna*.

Identity and Not-Self

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 21 min

In this profound exploration of one of Buddhism's most challenging teachings, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines anattā (not-self) through the lens of our everyday identifications and emotional reactions. Drawing from the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10), he explains how practicing mindfulness both internally (subjective experience) and externally (objective observation) can help us recognize the suffering that comes from over-identifying with our roles, abilities, and achievements.

Using vivid personal examples—from failed attempts at fixing a gas connector and printer to the emotional storms that follow—Bhante demonstrates how these moments of frustration become 'rocket fuel for Awakening' when met with sustained awareness. He reveals how the process of 'selfing' (upādāna) creates temporary identities that arise and fade based on external circumstances, leading us to recognize the conditional nature of all our various 'selves.'

The talk offers practical guidance for working with the dukkha of identification, showing how unpleasant sensations can serve as messengers reminding us 'this is not who you really are.' Through patient observation of our emotional reactivity, we can discover new pathways of gentleness, patience, and compassion—ultimately leading toward the peace of nibbāna beyond all limited identities.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa.

Homage to the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

The Buddha's teaching on *anattā*, not-self, is a hard aspect of the Dhamma to understand. We will all be grappling with it till the moment of enlightenment. To motivate ourselves for the challenge, it's worth reflecting on the suffering we experience because of identifying with our body, our mind, our life stories.

Take the example of role identification. Whatever role we're playing in life – father, daughter, gardener – we want to do it well, which is a good motive, no problem there. It's when we over-identify, can't see beyond our role, that *dukkha*, suffering, emerges.

On a good day, we get a buzz out of doing things well: cooking a meal, mending a puncture, teaching a class. But we all have days when these go wrong. The sponge cake turns out as a stodgy lump. The tyre deflates the minute we put the wheel back on. We go blank when trying to teach. This is when the dukkha of identification is felt.

The more we identify as a good cook, a good DIYer, a good teacher, the harder it is to bear the letdown. We can't stop thinking about it. What went wrong? How could I have made such a mess of things? What did they think of me? We look for someone to blame. If he hadn't interrupted, it would have been perfect.

While none of us enjoy those times when we've made a hash of something, it is worth dwelling on them long enough to acknowledge that the source of the misery is not actually the gooey mess or the deflating tyre. It's the sense of me and how badly I've let myself down. That's the real rope: a loss of confidence, perhaps an almost desperate need to reassert ourselves, prove our ability.

The more clearly we can acknowledge the suffering that comes from identification, the more we will be willing to explore the difficult Buddhist teaching of anattā, not-self. And there is no doubt anattā is a difficult nut to crack. We all have a strong sense that we are the ones baking the cake, mending the tyre, teaching the class, living our life. It's hard to even toy with the idea that this might not be so.

The Buddha's advice is to keep breaking down experience into smaller and smaller chunks. It's easier to get glimpses of the truth in these. Then gradually over time, the notion of not-self becomes easier to contemplate. We start to see its benefits, how much easier life is when we're not identified by our roles or opinions or abilities or achievements. It's wonderful to have nothing to defend.

One instruction from the *Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta*, the Four Foundations of Mindfulness, that I found very helpful for exploring anattā is the advice to practice internally and externally. Internal can be interpreted to mean our subjective felt experience, while external means our mental understanding of it. We feel the sensations of breathing for internal practice. For external practice, we reflect that we are breathing.

The Mahāsi noting technique provides a way of practicing both internally and externally. We feel the breath and at the same time make a mental note of it. Same for walking, eating, talking. All of life can be known both internally as moment-to-moment sensations and feelings, and externally as our objective mental perception of what's happening.

Say we are practising mindfulness of breathing. Feeling the sensations of breathing is to practise mindfulness internally. Although we don't usually make the thought conscious, we assume we are the one who's sitting here breathing. If we're also practising externally, then we're noting "rising, falling" as we track the breath.

As concentration deepens, it can seem like our identity shifts. Instead of being the one who is sitting here breathing, we sense ourselves as the observer, some sort of spaced-out entity hovering around our head, the one who is watching the body breathing. On a good day, we'll also be able to watch our thoughts coming and going, watch emotions rise and fade, realise we don't have to get caught up in them.

All of this is helping us disentangle our confusion about identity. Internally, we feel ourselves breathing, thinking, growing happy one moment, sad the next. But because of our external perspective, we realise we don't need to identify with our thoughts, emotions, breathing. We see these as happening of their own accord, driven by various stimuli, but not driven by what I now think of as me.

This can be a lovely experience, a sense of coming home, having found our true self: a sort of disembodied entity that hovers in and around the body, equanimous, interested, watching the show without getting caught up in it. But after a while, we might grow uncomfortable. Things start to feel sticky, as if there's a sheet of Velcro passing over each sensation, pulling us along with it. We start getting caught up with experience again, identified with thoughts and feelings and emotions. We are again the one who is sitting here breathing and now anxiously trying to find our way back to the lofty crow's nest from which we've been able to observe the show.

Although there's a temptation to see this as bad meditation, we should really see it as a precious opportunity to learn the Dhamma more deeply. Pema Chödrön likens these episodes as rocket fuel for enlightenment.

To take a practical example: we got a new connector for our gas canister the other day, and so I overcame all my fears about gas and explosions. I went to hook it up. After about a dozen failed attempts, all the bits eventually came together. It looked perfect. But gas started leaking the moment I opened the cylinder. I took it apart, reread the instructions, reconnected it. Still no go. Disappointing.

I was then asked to look at the printer because it wasn't working. It needed a new toner cartridge. And again, I overcame my deep suspicion of all things electrical and mechanical and managed to replace the cartridge, but no go. Every page came out white as snow with nothing at all being printed. Again, I took it all apart, reread the in-

structions, watched a few videos on replacing the cartridge, tried again. Still no go. Another disappointment. And this time I felt the edge of bad humour. My mind was starting to close up, feel oppressed by others and by the world in general.

A bit later, Bhante came over, took the cartridge out and, in his own words, "gave it a few thumps" and put it back in place. Lo and behold, it worked perfectly. Of course, I was impressed and amused and grateful, but alongside these happy responses, my incipient bad humour gave a painful kick within. Why couldn't it have worked for me?

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This new coping mechanism, learned from within, from moment-to-moment awareness, opens up new pathways for energy flow in the body and new doorways in the mind. We discover new thoughts and perspectives which are gentler, kinder, more patient and forgiving.

In my own example, a new doorway opened because of feeling so acutely the pain of identification, how it traps the mind in a prison of delusion. The pain of this prison sharpened when the storyline of me who should be better at everything had fallen away, and I could more clearly feel the emotional patterns underlying the thoughts.

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ent, on top of things, in control. A whirlpool of energy raised around my chest and head to sustain this delight. The feeling of confidence was gorgeous, but watching it, the external perspective showed up the craziness and pain underneath.

Seeing this, I desperately wanted to escape the prison of identification. The external perspective let me recognise the crazy whirlpool of energy and the bright light as what the Buddha terms *upādāna*, usually translated as grasping or clinging. It's also sometimes referred to as "selfing". What is happening is that unskillful desire, *taṇhā*, has driven us to create a new identity so as to fulfil this desire.

The better we get to know this experience of selfing, the more we are persuaded of the Buddhist teaching on *anattā*, not-self. Knowing from our direct experience that a "me" has suddenly arisen makes it hard to take "me" too seriously. We start to see how various "me"s arise and fade depending on external stimuli. When things go well, a happy, pleased, self-confident me emerges. But that fades quickly when things go wrong and the deflated, miserable me takes its place instead.

Back to my own example of watching the fallout from my emotional storm. Internally, I was experiencing the selfing process, which was generating a confident, delighted sense of me, one who could fix all the printers and gas cylinders in the world. However, the external perspective knew this as delusion. Undermined by that news, the confident self suddenly collapsed into a timid, scared, stiff entity which felt it had no rights to exist. A moment later, the confident self reappeared, wildly insisting it was totally in control of the situation.

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And sure enough, the energy of the roller coaster gradually diminished. As it did, so my attention extended gingerly beyond the whirlpool of elated and fearful energies in my chest and head to sense my arms, legs, my body sitting. I couldn't really feel these in any detail. I only knew them as faint suggestions. They seemed like strangers from another world – alien, scary.

Luckily, curiosity was stronger than fear, and each out-breath let awareness rest more attentively in the seemingly alien body. At last, some feelings rippled through. These were unpleasant and carried the message that the heady whirlpool of confidence was not me, not mine. The emotionally energetic, deluded part of myself felt this as a threat. But some wisdom emerged from the depths to welcome the unpleasantness. Here was something I would not want to cling to, therefore very welcome.

Letting attention rest on the unpleasantness became a non-interfering way of containing and restraining the deluded self. Gradually, the energetic bright-light me felt glad of being contained and limited, embodied rather than a totally deluded mental entity.

It became like looking in a mirror. Perhaps we've all had similar experiences where we sense ourselves as both watching and being watched. Sometimes I was the watcher, the observer, the disembodied entity that hovers near my head. This was the external mindful perspective. Sometimes I was the mirror image. This was the internal mindfulness perspective, bringing the embodied experience of me – the experience of sitting and breathing and knowing that I was being watched.

The desire to know who I really am has always been very strong for me. And that part of me that was observing, watching, felt this now as an almost overwhelming attraction towards the mirror image. I wanted to grasp hold of the image, devour it even. But whenever I gave in to that desire, it was as if I'd gobbled up my own reflection. All that was left were little shivers of fear and grief as I realised how I'd destroyed what I desired.

I had to suffer the fear and grief, wait patiently till peace prevailed, before I could again glimpse the mirror image. I became grateful for any unpleasant sensations in the mirror image. These acted like repulsive forces, countering the attempt to grasp and own the image. They carried the message: this isn't who you really are. That understanding also helped me not to grasp and thereby destroy the image of me that I desired so deeply.

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The great gift of sitting with the misery was that the message "this is not who you really are" became for the first time totally welcome. As the meditation went on, the message brought joy, relief, gratitude. I understood it as necessary to counter the strong desire to identify with my body and mind – the only reflection I can find for whatever it is I sense myself to be.

In subsequent meditations and in daily life, I was better able to recognise all "me"s as temporary and conditional. I could smile at them, appreciate them, but not be surprised when they dissolved. This is such a gift. The deluded me expects too much of me, expects me always to be on top of everything. Being able to see myself as limited brings forth compassion as well as appreciation for whatever efforts I make to follow the path, fulfil my various roles.

And if I'm getting a bit heated in conversation, clinging to my opinion, then I can focus on some unpleasant sensation and welcome them as messengers that this strongly opinionated one is not your true self either. Again, this brings a smile and allows me to be more flexible, ready to change my mind and see the other's point of view.

I hope this illustration of working with the dukkha of identification encourages you to explore the teaching around anattā, not-self, and perhaps also see how those external and internal mindfulness perspectives can help with this challenging teaching.

In this way, may we all see through our identification as daughter, manager, cook or whatever – see these as temporary, conditional, not ever designed to be satisfactory. As the Buddha said, whatever is inconstant, conditioned, unsatisfactory is not worthy of being thought of as me. We sell ourselves short by investing in these limited identities. Our continued practice leads us to a truth, a resting place beyond all such limitations. May we all experience the peace and bliss of *Nibbāna*.

If there is no self, who bears the karma?

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 2 min read

This essay addresses one of Buddhism's most challenging philosophical questions: if there is no permanent self (anattā), how can karma operate? Bhante Bodhidhamma clarifies that the Buddha never said there is no self, but rather that the self has no lasting substance—it arises and passes away moment by moment through the process of I-making (ahaṅkāra). Drawing on the teaching of paṭicca samuppāda (dependent origination), he explains how each momentary person arises dependent on conditions, including past actions and habits.

The essay explores how karma functions as the consequences of our actions—wholesome and unwholesome habits that shape future momentary selves. Since only the present person exists, they bear the results of past persons' actions while creating conditions for future persons. This understanding leads to a practical ethics: if we want future momentary selves to be happy, we must cultivate wholesome actions now. Bhante emphasizes that this process requires loving both oneself and others, as happiness depends on both inner cultivation and outer circumstances. The teaching concludes that developing 'a continuous flow of happy selves' not only benefits daily life but also supports spiritual progress, making this profound philosophical insight deeply practical for meditation and ethical living.

Every moment arises dependent on past and present conditions. This is no less true for the self, the sense of being a person. Nowhere does the Buddha say – there is no self. It is patently obvious to all that there is a self. What he says is that it has no substance; it does not last more than a moment. There is only the process of I-making (ahaṅkāra). There is, therefore, a 'person', conscious and sentient arising and passing away all the time – even in sleep there is a sliver of consciousness and sentience or the alarm bell would not wake us. The self or person is but a collection of habits and the body and a consciousness of it all. There are also moments of self-consciousness where the person perceives and feels themselves to be a person. Karma has become everyday speak for consequence. The consequence within a person is the habits they have formed, both wholesome and unwholesome. Now a person can only be in the present moment. Yet past editions of persons of both today, all our yesterdays and even before that, have created acts of thought, words and deeds - all of which have continuing consequences. If this person now feels unhappy, it's to a greater or lesser extent because a past person did something and this person now is bearing the consequences. There is also this person now making acts which may make for worse consequences for a future person. Similarly should this person now experience happiness, because of right inten-

tion, this will determine happier persons in the future. On the presumption that I will continue to arise as a momentary person for some time yet and possibly after death, if I want the future person whom I shall be, although only for a moment, to be happy, I have to start doing and creating habits now that will make for future happiness. This is loving oneself. When I'm happy, I really love being me! Because a lot of this happiness is also dependent on my outer circumstances, I have also to try to steer that towards happiness. That means I engage with people and the environment in whatever way I can to enhance the happiness of myself and others. Depending on the situation, I shall want to express my empathy in joy, compassion, love, patience and so on. This is loving the other. So it is that an ethics born out of the desire to make oneself happy is developed. And you can't do it without a self, without being a person. Our task as human beings is to develop a continuous flow of happy selves. And help others do the same. An added consequence: it's so much easier to make spiritual progress when we are happy.

Impulsive or Spontaneous

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 47 min

In this talk from a 2011 Gaia House retreat, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the subtle but crucial difference between impulsive and spontaneous action. While dictionary definitions show these terms are remarkably similar, their spiritual implications are vastly different. Impulsive actions arise from unconscious conditioning and often lead to regret, while spontaneous actions emerge from wisdom and virtue.

Using the Buddha's metaphor of crossing to the 'other shore' (Nibbāna), Bhante explores how the ten pāramīs (perfections) serve as training grounds for developing authentic spontaneity. He demonstrates how virtues like dāna (generosity), khanti (patience), and mettā (loving-kindness) require careful cultivation rather than mere impulse. Drawing from personal examples, including his own journey from reluctant teacher to joyful dhammadutta (dharma messenger), he shows how accepting situations with the understanding 'this is the way it is' transforms our relationship to difficulty.

The talk weaves together practical wisdom about daily life challenges - from caring for sick relatives to dealing with workplace irritations - with deeper insights about developing samādhi (concentration) and paññā (wisdom). Bhante emphasizes that true spontaneity, like that of accomplished musicians or athletes, emerges only through dedicated practice and the cultivation of wholesome conditioning. This patient work gradually dissolves the murky motivations behind impulsive behavior, allowing actions to arise from clarity rather than compulsion.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa — Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

So I just thought this evening we might approach daily life a bit in terms of our practice. I looked up two words here in the great Oxford dictionary — the contrast between impulsive and spontaneous. It's interesting how close the definitions come. It says impulsive is an action done without thought, and spontaneous, spontaneity, is performed or occurring as a result of a sudden impulse, inclination without premeditation of one's... Not much difference there, is there?

It's interesting that the word impulse comes from the Latin, which means driven on. But spontaneous comes from the Latin, which means of one's own accord. It gives it a slightly different flavour. But definitely in our use of these two words, impulsive is seen

as something not very good, and spontaneous is exactly how we want to be. To live a spontaneous life. Everybody wants to be spontaneous. And I think the added understanding of spontaneous is that you're very happy. You're spontaneous and happy, impulsive and wicked and silly, reckless.

So these two words are very close together and it's... We've just got to look at these *parami*. So *parami* means the other shore. It's translated as perfection, but it just means really those virtues that take you to the other shore. And that's the Buddha's image for *Nibbāna* — it's the other shore. And the sea he uses often as a metaphor for the journey. He talks about those who've not achieved Sotapanna, the first instance, as swimming under the water. Don't know where they're going. And the stream entrant, their head is bobbing up and down. So they sort of generally know where they're going. Oh, no, that's right. No, the stream entrant, his head's above water. So at least he sees or she sees where they're going. The Sakudagami, the one who is a once-returner, is swimming vigorously towards the shore. And the Anagami, the non-returner, is actually standing on the shore. So they've actually in some sense reached the end of the path. And then of course there's the path towards the middle of the island, and that's the attainment of full liberation.

So the idea of the other shore is one way of the Buddha pointing that these virtues are needed. And if we take that trilogy of generosity, well, gratitude actually isn't one of these, pardon me, but generosity is, and renunciation.

When we're generous impulsively, when we give impulsively or even recklessly, or when we help somebody — somebody says, can you help me decorate? — and when you say yes in that impulsive way, there's always that aftermath of, oh, God, do I really want to do that? And then you're trying to work out some way of getting out of it. And at the time when they expect you to come, you've mysteriously fallen ill, disappeared down to the beach or something.

So that impulsive action — if we stop, if we can just stop that, and it's very difficult, of course, when you're in action, when somebody comes and says, can you help me? Can you do this? It's very difficult to just stop and say, no, I won't. But I think we can give ourselves a bit of time by saying, oh, well, I'll have to look at my diary or I'll think about it or whatever. Just give me a moment. So you have to give yourself a bit of space to not fall into that impulsive way of doing things.

And of course when you... If you do something like that, if you decide to do something impulsively, and then you sit with those feelings, rather than letting them take you over, the feeling of self-annoyance and annoyance with the person for asking you and all that, if you sit with those feelings and you let them pass, then perhaps the un-

derlying motivations come up, the ones that are impulsive and driving you on. I mean, that's where the impulse is coming from. It's coming from some underlying conditioning. It may be that you're afraid to lose friendship. It may be that it's one way of not feeling lonely that you go and help somebody occasionally. I mean there might be all sorts of reasons, murky reasons underneath which is making us act in these impulsive ways. This is something that people like Freud understood very well.

But it comes out if you give it time. This is the point. It comes out if you allow the negativity that comes up to just pass away and then just see what comes up. I mean, if nothing comes up, nothing comes up. But something may just come up which manifests to you what's actually making you make these impulsive decisions.

So how do we become spontaneous? I mean, how do we undermine that and become spontaneous? Well, the underlying understanding of spontaneity is that it is virtuous. So absolute spontaneity won't arise until, in a sense, we're fully liberated in that total way, because there'll always be some murky little nasty reason for doing something which is driving us on, even unknowingly. But even so, even if that's there, we can still develop that virtuous habit, that virtuous conditioning, which allows us to act spontaneously in that virtuous way, and it brings more happiness than a feeling of compulsion, of being compelled to do something.

And that's where we get a bit confused because I think we think that spontaneity ought to arise spontaneously. Like you wake up one morning and, yeah, everything's spontaneous. I just woke up and had an egg and everything happened spontaneously. But spontaneity only comes with practice, with actual training. And I think I mentioned this one of the days.

If we look at people like concert performers, pianists, violinists, people like that, and sports people, I think these two manifest what we mean by spontaneity. And we know that an awesome amount of practice goes in to be able to play a piece of Beethoven or something or even to move with that amazing alacrity of a tennis player. I mean, the ball's moving at 100 miles an hour. They're not thinking about, well, should I go over there? Or should I hit it back strong? Should I spin round? What should I do? It's gone.

And this, of course, takes you into things like Zen, which is really high on that spontaneity. And it's interesting that one of the masters of Zen, Takuan, I think his name was called... he talked about stopping but not stopping in my sense. What he meant was the mind sticking. As soon as the mind sticks on something it loses that spontaneity — that's sticking. So if a sportsman just stops even for that moment of doubt of wondering what

to do, that's it, they've lost it. There's only a moment. If a performer just for one moment loses confidence or feels they've lost some concentration, that's it, the music is lost. They hit the wrong note and everybody boos. Get out of it.

So spontaneity also demands that concentration and that giving to the moment, but also that sense of complete looseness, where the mind doesn't hold onto something. Well, this takes practice.

So if we're looking at virtues, our virtuous life, then it's a case of recognizing that every time there's an opportunity to practice a virtue, then that also is leading us towards this beautiful spontaneity, where there's a clarity, where there's a wisdom that comes, so that the action is a response through wisdom, not through some murky impulse. And with it, with wisdom of course, there's a natural happiness comes, a natural feeling of fulfillment.

I'm thinking of one incident there in the scriptures where there's a monk who's ill, but ill in that very difficult way — smelly, the bowels are loose, and he's probably quite nasty, and the monks don't take care of him. And when the Buddha hears that this poor man is squirming around in his own juice, he goes with Ananda to look after him. And there's no doubt in the Buddha's mind as to what has to be done. And then he turns to the monks and he says, who's going to look after you? You've no mother, you've no father, you've nobody to help. If you don't look after yourselves, who's going to look after you? So he's saying to them that there's a very good reason for tending the sick. But in his mind, there was no confusion. Somebody's sick, so you're going to help. And I think that's one of the meanings of compassion.

In something like compassion we often get confused with grief. Not only is there a feeling of obligation. Take for instance somebody who has a poorly parent. Now, you've got a situation there where somebody's life might be having to change to look after this poorly parent. And there's a natural feeling of not wanting to do it, a feeling that, why don't they die quickly and get on with it while they destroy my life and all that. And there's a feeling of compulsiveness, of having to do it.

Now, that means that we're feeling a duty being imposed upon us. Now, whenever a duty is imposed upon us, we're always trying to shrug it off. We always feel it's unfair, it's unjust, and, why me, and all that. And that idea that the beauties that we have towards other people are an imposition by them upon us turns that compassionate act into something which is quite horrible for the person. They're chewed up inside. They don't want to do it really. And it comes out in little angers and not really taking care and moving them towards the window hoping they might jump. Things like that. Murder. All sorts of, I'm fed up. All I want is the money.

But as soon as you take on the duty as a personal responsibility, the whole thing changes completely. As soon as you take it on as a personal responsibility, it becomes a source of training, it becomes a source of generosity, a source of compassion. And it's not anymore a source of personal happiness, a feeling that one's life is being destroyed, because if you take it on as your personal duty, you see it as your personal training. You're using it for your spiritual benefit.

And in that care, I'm thinking of somebody specific, really, who has to look after his mother, and himself is quite sick. And it's amazing. I've known him for years. I've never heard him complain. And he's been looking after his mother for years now. And he seems to just have that very natural generosity. Just, well, this is my mother, and I'll look after her. And there's no... I don't think, never heard him being bitter or backbiting or talking about the pain and all that. And he seems to be in himself quite happy with the whole situation. And that can only come about because he's taken on that task, that duty as something very personal to him.

So in all these virtues, if we see them as a path of training, then we understand that the negativity will arise, but just like, I mean, this is what the vipassanā is for, it makes us more globally aware of what's happening within us. So when we practice a virtue and we can see the negativity come up, then we're not hijacked by it, we actually see it. Even if it's there, and even if it's putting a certain nasty feeling into the equation, the point is, we can distance from it, know it's there, and not act according to those suggestions, to those negative suggestions. And then we put the positive suggestion in our mind and we act from that. And at first it feels difficult, at first it feels hard. But eventually, as it were, the heart's being reconditioned.

Now, here, when we were talking yesterday about the will, you can see that the will is something separate from emotions, is something separate from thoughts. The will is something which empowers, and the practice is leading us to a point of wisdom.

So every time a situation comes up which we are uncomfortable with, that we don't want, that we're fighting against, struggling against, you have to be quite clear to yourself that that's the negativity coming from some sort of delusive thought, from some sort of misunderstanding. And it's allowing that misunderstanding and allowing the emotions that that misunderstanding is producing to come up into consciousness and for them to be recognized. As soon as you did that, you're doing vipassanā. You've separated out. You see it as some negative conditioning within us.

And then sometimes one has to wait for that to dissolve a little bit. But even so, even if it's there in a very strong way, you can always bring the right intention to mind and you do it with right intention. Even though within yourself you might feel horrible. This is the point. In yourself you might feel down, you might feel depressed, etc., etc. But there's this intention which you empower and you keep working that way.

Now, with the action, with the good intention and with the action, it's bound to begin to develop the right attitude. The right attitude has always been there, it's just begun to develop. And when you have right attitude, in time, it has a systemic effect, so the heart begins to respond. And all those negative feelings that we have begin to dissolve and this more positive feeling begins to arise.

I mean, I'll just give you a personal example. I've never, until maybe five or six years ago, ever wanted to teach. I don't know what I'm doing here. It was the most... I remember when I was sitting on a beach in Alicante, down in Spain somewhere, with a bottle of sangria. And I went down to the post office to get this telegram from my father, who said, you know, you've got your BA and your teacher's certificate, and he said, congratulations. And I went and sat on this rock overlooking the sea, the Mediterranean, isn't it? And I remember distinctly saying, there is no way I want to teach. That was it. And I didn't for about two or three years.

But then, of course, you need money. And when I came back to Britain, and I realized that I didn't want to go back east again, and that I wanted to stay here, I also realized that there's no way I can exist in a country which doesn't have an infrastructure to support the monastic life, unless you've got ethnic groups supporting you, like the Thais or the Burmese or something, which I didn't have. There's no way you can exist as a monastic unless you give something to lay people. They won't give you money. Westerners don't give you money for nothing.

So I realized that I had to teach. I felt it was a bit of a... It was a necessary contract. And I took on what's known as the Dhammadutta, which is the duty of teaching the Dhamma. So in this country, you'll hear certain monks, or you'll hear in the conversation, especially amongst Sri Lankans, that they're a Dhammadutta monk, which means that they're missionaries. That's what it is — mission. Come to a foreign land to convert the heathen.

So I made that decision. But even so, there was a long, long time I just felt this negativity, which I only shared with close students, that this was something that was really against the grain because I didn't want to do it. And then, of course, that negativity builds up, and you think, well, what's happening here? I've got to look at this.

And so this was 98, between 98 and 99. And I went to Upandita's center. It's named after him, of course, Upandita Rama. And when I was there, I came across, I'm sure you've all heard of that book, A Course in Miracles. And I came across a little book. It's really strange because I was struggling with this business of teaching. I mean, the alternative was to basically return to the East and return to my little hut, which tended to gain a certain glow after my hut. What happened to my hut?

And I came across this little book, which is one of these serendipity things, which you can't really explain. And here I am wondering about what to do. And this little book was a collection out of the Course in Miracles on teaching and the purpose of teaching and that. Now, I can't remember it, but by the end of that book, I was convinced that this was actually a good path to be on. So I have the Course in Miracles to thank.

And then once that attitude changed, the negativity didn't go. See, the negativity is still there. And even now, occasionally, I'll get this, God, I don't want to go in there and give a talk.

I want to sit in there and go, tea. See? But it's no longer that awful mental state that was coming up for about a year when I just felt I was wasting time. I mean, that's what comes, you see. My inclination is to be a recluse. So I'm wasting time. I mean, that's the big thing, you see. I should be in there, you know, knocking my head against the wall. I shouldn't be out here teaching.

So that sort of negativity, even though it comes up occasionally, it actually is just a dying conditioning, you might say. And the more I gave myself to the teaching, especially when I went to Gaia House, the more I gave to it, the more, to my surprise, there came this lovely feeling of joy. I didn't say to myself, right, I've got to feel joy when I go in there. I didn't. And the more I began to give talks, the more they became sort of spontaneous in the sense that even now I've not prepared it. You just come in and you speak and hope for the best. And that's it. Just make sure I haven't got any bricks.

So it was that sort of passage. Now, I think if you look in your own lives, I'm sure you'll find something which gets you down or whatever and it's a case of looking at that and accepting the motivation there, looking at that motivation and seeing what is it you're doing to make a job which previously you might have been happy with suddenly miserable. What is it you're doing to make something which you can see quite clearly could be very beautiful, could be a real growth area for you, something that you see as a sort of hell realm.

A lot of people do that with their jobs. At first they walk in and they're sort of pretty excited by it, most times. And they're looking forward to it and then they get into it and they like it. A few months down the line, a couple of years down the line, it's, I've got to get out of here. It takes on a board and it takes on all those sorts of things. And it's interesting because even in the most menial tasks, there's spiritual training. Even in something so repetitive of being on a production line can be a process whereby you grow in concentration just by putting your mind on exactly the same action.

I mean, what are we doing here? We do walking meditation. It's exactly the same thing. We're lifting, moving, lowering, placing, up and down, up and down. We do it for 40 minutes, an hour, four or five times a day. By the end of the week, you've walked hours going up and down. But you've never thought to yourself, well, this is really boring. I should be paid more for this. This is ridiculous. I'm being abused. I have to write a nasty letter to Bodhidharma.

So it's even in something so repetitive or so menial, which we all do at some point just in our household chores, just cleaning the toilet. I mean, that's considered a menial task. But to actually bring a joy to it, to actually see it as purposeful, to actually see that it's something that you can develop a certain care, cleaning the toilet bowl, we can do it with care and attention. You know what I mean?

And it's these, like you walk into these public toilets, you see, and there's either a man or a woman sitting there, and sometimes I go and I think, I wonder what sort of life it is down here in the Jakes, living in this subterranean world with the smell of urine. And I think, God, this must be a hell realm. And some of them do give you that impression. I mean, they really are, they don't want to know.

But the other day I was in some station or other, and there was a woman at the main kiosk. And she was having the time of her life. She was having a chat with people and drawing their attention and shouting out about toilet paper and all sorts of stuff. And she was okay. You could feel she was okay. And everybody was okay with it. It was a completely different sort of toilet I've ever been in.

So it's like as soon as you see every situation you're in as something to train in, then that sort of joy arises. And with the joy comes the spontaneity. So you've got these two lines. You've got both the trying to undermine old attitudes, bringing up a good reason for doing things. And by doing that, the heart responds. It's just as simple as that. And we may surprise ourselves occasionally by doing something quite spontaneously, which on reflection we realize has actually come from pure wisdom, that we've actually done it out of that really good heart, one way or the other.

So if we just look at one or two of these, well, I've not got much time now. One or two of these, that trilogy is interesting. Well, take, I mean, the ten perfections are, we haven't got time to go through them all, is giving and morality, which morality is good conduct, slightly better. Renunciation, wisdom itself, energy, patience, truthfulness, resolution, loving-kindness, and equanimity. But just to take patience, for instance.

Patience, that patient forbearance, that feels like an imposition, with a naughty child or with somebody who's messing you about, or that great nuisance, the thumping bass beat through the wall while he's trying to sit there, trying to do some reading or meditating, murderous thoughts arise. And that patience, that ability to bear with the uncomfortable, to bear with that which one does not want.

Now, normally speaking, when something arises that we don't want, you get that negativity, you get the aversion, you get the anger. But to be able to allow that to come, it's always the same process. You allow that negativity to arise. If you push it away, if you bat it away, then it just remains there as a conditioning. And the power of your suppression is in a sense like pushing a spring down. And that's how these rages happen, you see. People don't realize how much anger they've built up in themselves. And then suddenly they do something which is quite awful.

So one actually feels that negativity, you see. And then you have to recognize it. You have to label it as unwholesome. And then, as it were, you change your attitude. And the great phrase for patience is, this is the way it is. As soon as you say, this is the way it should not be, you're into conflict. This is how it... It shouldn't be like this.

Did you ever see that film, *Unforgiven*? Clint Eastwood. Classic sort of silly western. And at the end, of course, he shoots everybody. And everybody's dead. And there's, I can't remember the name of the actor. He's very, very good. But his dying words are, this shouldn't have happened. This shouldn't have happened. I mean, that's it, isn't it? That's where we are. It shouldn't be like this. It should be other. Why am I suffering this? All that sort of stuff.

But as soon as you start using the phrase, start grounding yourself in the present moment as it really is, this is the way it is, then the patience comes as a sort of acceptance, an acceptance of this is the way it is. Now, when we do that, we sometimes get confused. We think, oh, well, that's some form of resignation. But the distinction between these two is that when somebody resigns themselves to something in that sort of bad sense, they disempower themselves. This is it, I can't do anything, I'm miserable, and that's the way life is, it's horrible, and whinge, and all that sort of stuff. And that, of course, is really harmful spiritually, because at that point, you're conquered, you're destroyed by what it is you've resigned to.

But acceptance is a completely different attitude. Acceptance is that beginning with the ground of, this is the way it is, and then with that sort of patience, with that ability to accept the way it is, then there arises what can be done. See? When one sees a situation, there's always something can be done. I mean, if it's music, you can always go for a walk. Or buy a gun or something. Yeah. There's always something can be done to alleviate it. Earplugs. That's an alleviation.

There was a lovely... I used to know this fellow. I wonder how he is now. I often wonder about him. He was a big man. Strong, toughy. I mean, when you saw him, you didn't want to say the wrong word. And he was the head of the Communist Party. This was before it disbanded. This is going back a while. And he was with his partner, and they had a room right at the top of the house, or the flat at the top of the house.

And these students came in, or I'm not sure who the students, young kids came in next door, and started playing rock music, the practicing, drums and everything, 12 o'clock at night. Okay, so he goes down, knocks on the door, and they come, and he says, knock, noise, this time of night. They say, yeah, all right, all right. And they stop, you see. Either next night or a couple of nights on. So down he goes again, knocks on the door. The guy comes out and says, a bit more angry. And they say, okay, okay, we'll stop, we'll stop. So they stop.

So the third time, there's music, he goes down, goes out the door, and he just went, whop, right on his nose. That was it, end of music. Sometimes a hard lesson is needed. And I used to just laugh when I heard of that. He was a lovely man, you see. He was very patient. He'd been woken up. He has to get his clothes on. He has to go down, knock on the door. Can you please stop? He goes down a second time, third time. Enough. Clunk. And that's the end of that. And they don't play music again. It's like... Now, I'm not suggesting.

But it's that ability to accept the way things are, wherever we are, especially, of course, those times when we feel uncomfortable or in a situation which we find hard to bear. Just accepting it. It's like you're accepting the load. Instead of trying to shrug it off, it's like carrying a haversack or a rucksack. If you're carrying a rucksack and you don't want it in your back, it really is painful. But if you accept that you need this rucksack in order to wander over the world, then you're quite happy having this huge weight on your back. You don't complain about it. You carry your house, your washing machine, they're all on the back. And you're quite happy carrying this huge weight. It's amazing when you think about it.

And campers, you see, they want to go camping. They don't mind carrying these huge weights on their back in order to go out and camp in the wilderness. But as soon as somebody says to you, would you carry this for me? You say, oh, yeah. And they go, ooh. So it's that lovely way that we can train ourselves this is the point about our spiritual life we can actually train ourselves to be like this so this is the way it is and the anger goes as soon as you accept the situation as it is and then always at least to my amazement there's always a way of dealing with the situation there's always a way of alleviating the situation in some way or other.

And it's just through that practice of patience that, in a sense, it just becomes part and parcel. Now, I've been here now for three years, and I haven't run a centre before. I mean, this is a new experience for me, running a centre. And thank goodness it's small. And people do things which get up my nose. If people come here and they do things, I think, what the hell are they... They go, I just want to pick the flowers. Pick the flowers. Put them up there. It's very nice. But like, it's always, and you get people putting carpets. You have a carpet, they come back and it's put over here. Like, why? Why are they doing that? They've come to change me.

So, and it's been, and having to work with managers, you can't use it. And you just get, and after a while, you see these irritations, you see these irritations, and you keep saying to yourself, what am I getting, why am I getting irritated? This is really silly. I mean, to actually have these little Bernie things going on in me, for what? And actually silly things anyway.

And slowly, because you see, one of the dangers of living as a recluse or living by yourself in a hut or living by yourself in society, living in your own flat, is that you forget how to live with people. It's like, I mean, I was brought up with brothers and sisters, so we always shared a bedroom. These days kids have a room of their own. Sharing is like a pain, it becomes a war.

And just to be able to allow these irritations to actually see them for what they are, just silly places where the mind grabs, places where the mind is *upādāna*, is grasping, you see. And then you just recognize this is not doing you any good, it's just absolutely silly. And you begin to relax, you begin to relax. And you never approach the person in that state of anger, because if you approach that state of anger, for sure, you express it in some way. It might be just the trembling of your hands as you're talking, but something will leak out. And in that way, unwittingly, you're engineering this anger. So you have to sit with it, wait, wait, wait.

And I found, for instance, at the beginning, it would take three days for these little angers to disappear. It would take them for three days. I'd be sat here thinking, this is ridiculous. And very slowly, just by accepting this is the way it is, it's quite surprising how quickly those old habits begin to be disempowered and just a more natural ability just to be with the way it is, to be with people as they are.

I mean, I'm very lucky here because most people come here with good intent. It's not as though they ripped the flowers up to ruin the garden. I mean, I'm surrounded by people with good intents. I mean, that makes it much easier. But at work, you might find yourself with people who have their knives out for you. I'm thinking of one person who was terribly bullied. And in those sorts of situations, yes, you accept the way things are. This is the way it is, but you definitely don't allow that to go on. You find ways of undermining that sort of really bad behavior. But if you don't accept the situation as it is, then either you're deluding yourself, such as, this person really isn't bullying me, and this is the way it ought to be, or you're just getting yourself into huge fits of anger, frustration, and a final sort of giving in to the situation, of a sort of resignation. And that's really bad spiritually. Really bad spiritually. Both ways are bad spiritually.

So, slowly, through this process of seeing where anger arises, see, that's your sign of impatience. That's the sign there's no patience. Wherever anger or irritation arises, you can say, this is the lack of patience, right? And you're holding on to something, right? If you have children and they do something which makes you angry, then you're holding on to something. There's no need for the anger. Even with children, there's no actual need for the anger. You might manifest anger to get your own way. But to actually feel it in your heart is not actually necessary.

That's something we are putting into the situation by saying, this is not the way it should be. This should be other. I'm not accepting the situation completely as it is.

And with that patience, there always comes a natural wisdom. It arises naturally. You don't have to work at it. And I think the more you find yourself becoming patient, the more this wise response to situations arises spontaneously, arises without having to work at it so much.

And you can take all the other virtues. Giving, you see, giving... Our moral life. You find yourself over-exaggerating in your speech. It's a form of wrong speech. It's a form of not speaking the truth. And just by recognising that, you accept it, you see, and you come back and you correct yourself. You're slightly more clear. You're slightly more careful about what you say.

Renunciation, you see? Renunciation is, if you're doing it as a sort of self-hate thing, or for any other reason apart from seeing where your attachment is, there's probably some wrong intention there. The whole point of renunciation is to see the attachment. So if you decide to have a look at your eating habits and you decide to fast or to do without a meal, you're doing it in order to see the habit. You're not doing it for any other reason. If you do it for some other reason, then maybe some aversion come into it. Maybe some trying to control come into it.

But remember, if you try to control habits, you're into a battle with them. What we're learning here is to allow the feelings to arise, but then always make sure they're not translated into an action, an action of thought, word or deed. But if you're in the habit of controlling it, which means you're pushing away, you're trying to hold it, there's always some negativity there. And that isn't right renunciation.

Energy, you see. Here we're learning how to be calm. There's no need to get over-energetic in things, to put your energy in things which sort of pump up the energy. What we're learning here is that if you do things calmly, the energy necessary for a particular task arises naturally. You don't have to go over the top with it.

And then there's patience. We've had truthfulness, which we've talked a little bit about, especially in terms of exaggeration. Resolution, you see. Every day we have that moment after chanting to make a resolution. If it's done with a good heart, if it's done with real resolve, you'd be surprised. It does work its way through. It does actually come through. Eventually.

Of course, every time, if you're resolving not to do something because it's negative, every time that negativity comes up, you have to bring that resolution to mind. Even if you indulge. So you say to yourself, I will not drink any more coffee. And you're walking down the street and Costa Coffee grabs your nose. And you think, ah, and then you hear yourself, I will not drink, and hmm, and then you go, and you're drinking coffee. Then you say to yourself, okay. I drank coffee. And you drink your coffee and you say, then you make a resolution. Next time, no. And eventually, to your surprise, Costa Coffee will come. Grab your nose, but the body will keep moving past. It won't have that huge effect on you.

Loving kindness, you see? They translate *mettā* as loving kindness, which is all right, it's more the heart side, but it's goodwill. It's that goodwill, and just having that as a basic attitude to all beings, wishing them well. And in the morning just to practise that after your *vipassanā*.

So remember the *vipassanā* has to be brought into an attitude. *Vipassanā* is about understanding and wisdom. You have to translate it into an attitude. And that's why the *mettā* practice after *vipassanā* as a daily practice is absolutely necessary. Otherwise you can become too detached, too disinterested. And that's what draws you back into relationships. So make sure that you always do a little, even if it's only a few lines, just to bring you into an attitude.

And then as you get up, you take with you into your daily life the wisdom and the loving kindness that you've just been practising. It's a substrate.

And then finally, equanimity. And I think I've said before, this is the greatest of all virtues because it subsists them all. It keeps them all balanced, that equanimity. So that we can practise. And we lose equanimity when we get too excited. Every time we fall into an unwholesome state, we've lost equanimity, basically. Equanimity is that calmness of the heart, steadiness of attention and coming from the place of wisdom. That's what brings about equanimity.

So there we have it. We find ourselves doing things impulsively, things that we often sometimes regret, things that make us feel embarrassed afterwards. And what we have to do is recognise that, and then we make that resolution. And we remind ourselves, and then come the next time, hopefully we've got that clear, calm awareness, carrying all day long this sort of just relaxing into the present moment, and we see that old impulse come, and we've got just that enough space to say no, in the sense of not doing it, and then to allow that impulse to arise and to slowly pass away, and then for the right intention to arrive.

And then very slowly you get this movement. And we can surprise ourselves every so often with a spontaneous act which is coming from the heart of wisdom.

So I can only hope, my words have been of some assistance, that your life will become fully happy and spontaneous, leading you towards final liberation, sooner rather than later.

Impulsive or Spontaneous

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 1 min read

This teaching examines the crucial distinction between impulsive behavior and genuine spontaneity in our daily interactions. Bhante Bodhidhamma illustrates how impulsive actions stem from thoughtless habit patterns, often leading to regret, internal conflict, and even dishonesty when we agree to things we don't truly want to do. Through relatable examples and a humorous Mullah Nasruddin story, he demonstrates how impulsive responses can trap us in cycles of discomfort and deception.

The essay then shifts to explore authentic spontaneity, which appears effortless but actually requires dedicated cultivation. Drawing parallels with athletic training and artistic performance, Bhante shows how genuine spontaneous responses emerge from consistent practice and conscious development of virtues like goodwill, generosity, and patience. This reflects core Buddhist principles about the cultivation of wholesome mental states through mindful effort.

The practical wisdom offered here directly supports meditation practice and ethical development. By distinguishing between reactive impulses and skillful spontaneity, practitioners can better understand how to cultivate sīla (ethical conduct) and develop the mindful awareness needed to respond wisely rather than react habitually to life's demands.

When we act impulsively, we do so out of habit. A thoughtless reaction. There's no reflection involved. And the word impulsive suggests that it is not skilful. We often regret what we have done. Somebody asks us to come and help in the garden. And we find ourselves saying, 'Yes, I'd love to!' And immediately comes that sinking feeling that we really didn't want to do it. And that we don't have the time. We would prefer to be doing something else. It scratches on the mind and we think of excuses. It can lead to fibbing. 'Woke up feeling terrible. I've got a job to do. Someone I must see. Forgot all about it.' Of course, we are prolific in our apologies. But it leaves an uncomfortable feeling. That's the dread of being found out. The shame of it. There's a Mullah Nasruddin story. He is tired of his neighbour asking for the use of his donkey. So on the next request, he tells him the donkey is being used by someone else. Just then the donkey brays. And when his neighbour raises his eyebrows, he asks, 'Who are you going to believe? Me or my donkey?' We all want to be spontaneous. It suggests skillfulness and joy. And we think that spontaneity should arise spontaneously! But it's hard work to train ourselves towards a genuine, unaffected naturalness about what we do. Consider sport! How

many times do tennis players practise their shots? And in the immediacy of the game their strokes are spontaneous. Not that they are always as accurate as they would want them to be. Consider performance artists whether actors or musicians. Although their performance seems so natural, there has been an enormous amount of practice beforehand. So it is with virtues. We need to consciously develop them – goodwill, generosity, patience and so on. And then every so often we shall surprise ourselves at our spontaneous, wise and joyful response.

In the Seeing, Only the Seeing... (Bāhiya Sutta) - read by Finola O'Siochrú

Noirin Sheahan · 45 min

In this talk, Noirin Sheahan examines one of Buddhism's most remarkable stories - that of Bāhiya Dārucīriya, who achieved complete liberation upon hearing just a few words from the Buddha. The teaching "In the seen, only the seen; in the heard, only the heard" points to a way of experiencing the six sense doors without constructing a sense of self around them.

Noirin brings warmth and humanity to this profound sutta, exploring Bāhiya's character - his determination, faith, and single-pointed focus that led him to travel 1,200 miles to find the Buddha. She examines the core practice of 'just seeing' - experiencing the raw data of the senses without adding layers of judgment, story-making, or self-reference.

The talk covers essential Vipassanā principles including the difference between ultimate and conventional reality, the process of grasping and clinging, and how concepts like 'self' and 'other' are constructed through our reactive patterns. Noirin offers practical guidance for working with the conceptual mind in meditation while maintaining the balance between tranquility and investigation that characterizes Right View in the Eightfold Path.

Bahiya holds the record for being the quickest of the Buddha's disciples to reach enlightenment. He only got a very brief training, a few words while the Buddha was on his alms round. These were the first and only words of Dhamma Bahiya had ever heard, and yet he gained full enlightenment as he listened. It's an inspiring story.

Bahiya, we are told, was a respected recluse living by the seashore and known as Bahiya of the bark cloth because his robes were made from bark. One day he pondered his own level of spiritual understanding, asking, "Now, of those who in this world are Arahants or have entered the path leading to Arahantship, am I one?" He couldn't answer this, and we're told that a compassionate *deva* appeared before him saying, "You, Bahiya, are neither an Arahant nor have entered the path leading to Arahantship. You do not even have a practice whereby you can become an Arahant or enter that path."

Bahiya, we are told, was greatly chastened by this, but luckily not disheartened, and immediately asked where he could find an Arahant to teach him. The deva then tells him that the Buddha is currently living at Jeta's grove in Sāvatthi and teaching the Dhamma there. It's a long way away, some 1,200 miles, but Bahiya doesn't hesitate for a moment to set out and hurry as fast as he could to Sāvatthi.

When he gets to Jeta's grove, he is told that the Buddha is out on alms round. Not willing to wait another moment, Bahiya hurries out in pursuit, and upon finding the Buddha, throws himself down at his feet, exclaiming, "Teach me the Dhamma, O blessed one. Teach me the Dhamma, O well-gone one, that will be for my long-term welfare and bliss."

The Buddha at first refuses, saying that he is on alms round and not free to teach. Bahiya repeats his request again and again, arguing that either his own or the Buddha's life could be ended at any moment. On the third request, the Buddha relents, saying, "Then, Bahiya, you should train yourself thus. In the seen there is only the seen. In the heard, only the heard. In the sensed, only the sensed. In the cognized, only the cognized. That is how you should train yourself. When for you there will only be the seen in the seen, only the heard in the heard, only the sensed in the sensed, only the cognized in the cognized, then, Bahiya, there is no you in connection with that. When there is no you in connection with that, there is no you there. When there is no you there, then you are neither here nor there, nor anywhere in between. Just this is the end of suffering."

As Bahiya listened to these words, the penny dropped and he was liberated. The Buddha went on his way and just as he had feared, Bahiya died having been attacked by a cow. When the Buddha later came across Bahiya's body, he told his disciples to cremate this and erect a memorial. When they ask him about Bahiya's destination, his future life, the Buddha replies that Bahiya is totally unbound, meaning that he is liberated from suffering and rebirth.

Before we look at the teaching at the core of the Sutta, I think it's helpful to paint a picture of Bahiya for ourselves. One reason is that the teaching itself, as with so much of the Dhamma, invites us to deconstruct our normal understanding of reality, to see that we're not this, not that. Though this is essential, we also have to make an effort to reconstruct our understanding of reality where I am me and you are you and a dog is a dog and so on. This normal understanding is sometimes described as conventional reality whereas the deconstructed version is termed ultimate reality. The spiritual life requires that we navigate both levels peacefully. If we focus only on the ultimate level,

this can lead to abstraction. We grow aloof from the world. If we engage with the story of Bahiya, we warm up the teaching, bring our humanity to the forefront as we listen to the Dhamma.

We can remember also that the Buddha always chose exactly the right teaching for each person. So if we can put ourselves in Bahiya's shoes, we might hear the teachings in a more meaningful way.

Some people think that Bahiya was already highly developed spiritually. The Sutta doesn't give us much evidence for this, and I like the interpretation given by Buddhaghosa, an Indian monk and scholar who lived about a thousand years after the Buddha. Although interpretations lose some of the original purity, I think they have a value in their own right. The Buddha's presence, his calm, authority, body language, facial expression, all these would have added hugely to the words he spoke. As his real-life impact died away, myths and stories would have been added to the teachings as a human effort to retain some shadow of his presence. Of course, this will include cultural bias, and we don't have to take these as gospel, but they may make it easier for us to hear the teachings, to detect human warmth in them, rather than read them as a very dry manual of spiritual practice.

Buddhaghosa gives us a prequel to the Sutta, suggesting that Bahiya was actually a novice in spiritual terms, even a bit of a fraud. Earlier, he and others had gone out to sea. Their ship sank and all his comrades were drowned, but Bahiya managed to cling to a plank and survive. Perhaps he was battered against rocks because by the time he made it ashore his clothes had been torn away. There was, and still is in parts of Asia, a tradition of making sheets of cloth from the sodden bark of trees and Bahiya obviously had mastered this skill. From other suttas we see that being naked could lead to being despised and abused. It shows great strength of character that the half-drowned, bruised and battered Bahiya managed to weave himself a cloak, a task few of us would have the patience to manage, even in the peak of health and well-being.

By a lucky twist of fate, the bark cloth works in his favour. When the local people saw him, they assumed he was an ascetic who had renounced clothing, even assuming he was fully enlightened and arahant. And so they started giving him food. Bahiya realised he was on to a good thing and decided to eschew fine clothes and continue in his bark cloth, becoming known as Bahiya of the Bark Cloth.

Bahiya then starts to wonder whether perhaps he is enlightened. There are reports of people mistaking themselves as enlightened because they've developed concentration to the extent that the hindrances are suppressed and they live in a state of bliss. Perhaps this was the case for Bahiya. Perhaps all this talk of him being an Arahant per-

suaded him to dabble in meditation. He may well have had a mind that concentrated easily. The ease with which he picks up the Buddha's words suggests that. People with good concentration can achieve a state of *jhāna* where the mind is absorbed in bliss. My guess is that Bahiya fell into a *jhāna* and then started wondering whether this bliss meant he was enlightened.

Whatever about concentration, Bahiya's spiritual assets certainly include energy, determination and perseverance. To have survived a situation where five companions perished shows a real strength of will. Bahiya doesn't give up easily and once he realised that enlightenment involves his long-term welfare and bliss, he becomes single-mindedly focused on that goal. His zeal for liberation would have been spurred by acute awareness of mortality, as is pleased to the Buddha demonstrate. Buddhaghosa's story of near drowning gives a context for this.

Although we might think of someone who suffered such a calamity as very unfortunate, in spiritual terms the shock of a near-death experience can be a great motivator. This is why we are encouraged to reflect on our mortality, go to cemeteries or view bodies decomposing, so as to make this more real. A near-death experience makes us painfully aware of the lack of any security in this life. We become disillusioned, perhaps depressed, lose interest in the pleasures of this world. When the Buddha realized the reality of sickness, old age and death, it is said that he returned to his palace like a lion pierced in the heart. That state of misery prompted the Buddha's spiritual life. Similarly, Bahiya was determined to find a truth and security which transcended worldly life.

Last but not least, Bahiya had great faith. He doesn't waste any time doubting the Dhamma or his own potential for enlightenment. He goes straight for this prize. With a certain naive bull-headedness, he is only interested in learning from an Arahant. The fact that the Buddha is 1,200 miles away doesn't faze him for an instant.

So Bahiya is an energetic, resourceful, determined character, and because of his near-death experience, strongly motivated to seek liberation. He's blessed with great faith in his own abilities, in the reality of enlightenment and in the Buddha. We see his single-mindedness again when, after his 1,200-mile journey, he doesn't dream of resting but immediately rushes out of Jeta's grove in pursuit of the Buddha, doesn't hesitate to interrupt his alms round, pesters him basically, until he receives the teachings.

Bahiya's story is a testament to the power of absolute one-pointed determination, faith and energy. But this do-or-die attitude is easily hijacked by greed. It needs to be balanced by an equal preference for calm and tranquillity, a sense that all is okay, just as it is. The Sutta gives this very beautiful description of the personage Bahiya saw when he eventually caught up with the Buddha on his alms round: "Serene and inspir-

ing serene confidence. Calming. His senses at peace. His mind at peace. Having attained the utmost tranquillity and poise. Tamed. Guarded. His senses restrained, a great one, *Nāga*."

This suggests that it was the very presence of the Buddha that allowed Bahiya to calm down, bring his mind to rest upon the words the Buddha spoke, let them penetrate deep enough for full liberation.

The Buddha's opening words, "Bahiya, you should train yourself thus," clarify that this is a training, not an account of what enlightenment is. The Buddha is not interested in philosophy for its own sake, an abstract definition of truth. Intellectual understanding isn't enough for liberation. The truth of enlightenment has to be lived and for this we need training. The Eightfold Path gives the full scope of training, addressing morality, views and attitudes as well as mental training. But in this very succinct teaching to Bahiya, the Buddha focuses on the first step in the Eightfold Path, Right View. It's the way we see and understand the world that's most important. Everything else, our attitudes, our behaviour, our meditation, clicks into place if only we can be clear about what's actually happening in our moment-to-moment experience.

The Buddha's next words to Bahiya describe the bare simplicity of the practice. "In the seen, there is only the seen." When we see, we normally see something. We see a book, a tree, a person. And then we think about it, whether we read it, whether we'd like to read it. Same for the tree, the person. In reference to the seen, there is the seen plus all the thoughts and images and fond or unpleasant memories this provokes.

Now it's possible of course that we don't properly register what we see. We vaguely scan our environment to avoid bumping into things, too preoccupied to bother giving full attention to the visual scene. No thoughts about books or trees or people are evoked. But if we were to be properly mindful, we would detect a quick judgment, labelling whatever we see as irrelevant, not worth thinking about. So there is the seen plus an aversive reaction, dismissing the sight as irrelevant and the consequent decision to ignore.

Could we properly register the sight of a book, a tree, a person and not react, not add any thoughts? Difficult. The term is just seeing and is the spiritual practice we take from the Bahiya Sutta. We train by noticing the proliferation of the thoughts or the desire to avert our eyes, find something more interesting. We then resist the habitual reactions, drop the thoughts, bring our eyes back to the visual object itself, its colour, its shape, its bookness, reminding ourselves that we are seeing. When we train like this, we're com-

ing back closer and closer to the raw experience of seeing. We're dropping our opinions and judgments and preconceptions about the things we see, getting more and more interested in the experience of seeing.

Can you imagine living in a world where we didn't add a thousand judgments and stories, a thousand summary dismissals as irrelevant, as we let our eyes go about their business of scanning our surroundings? The teacher, Gilles Farcet, gives an example of this when he lived for a time in Morocco. He noticed his mind was much lighter than normal. He wasn't as troubled as usual in public. He eventually traced this to the fact that he wasn't reacting to people around him, making up stories about them. He realized it was because their clothing was so different to Western clothing. His habitual way of categorizing people just couldn't work. He had no way of judging, working out what their lives were like, who was rich, who was poor, who had what trade. So he was just seeing the people around him. This gave him a demonstration of the way we clog up our world and weigh ourselves down by adding layers and layers of unnecessary thought to whatever we see. He tasted the lightness of just seeing.

The Buddha uses the same instructions for the other senses. In the hearing, there is only the hearing. In the sensing, this is understood to refer to sensations from odour and taste as well as body. There is only the sensing. In the cognizing, there is only the cognizing. The latter is interesting. Thoughts and images also have their place in very simple, non-reactive way of relating to the world. The thought "book" could arise on seeing a book, but no further thoughts are provoked about whether or not we've read the book or should read it or any other thought stream.

At the very essence of seeing, hearing, sensing, there aren't thoughts, but simple sensations of colour or pressure or vibrations on the eardrum. But to interact in an intelligent way with these, we need to allow several sensations be processed by the mind so as to form perceptions and concepts like book, tree, person. This is happening all the time in the background as we go about our daily business.

I got a glimpse into the extent of background processing going on in my mind one time as I walked into the bathroom of my apartment. Normally the light switch also turns on a fan. But when I pressed the switch this time, the light came on but the fan didn't. I started hearing the fan nonetheless. In fact, I heard every little nuance of its whirring and buzzing as I'd never heard them before. That's because I was listening properly for the first time, knowing something was unusual but unable to work out what. It took a couple of seconds to realize that this was a mental sound playing in my

mind, a memory of what the fan sounded like, not a real sound impacting on my ears. My mind had made its own very accurate recording of the sound of the fan, and had probably been playing this every time I'd pressed that switch for the past several years.

Perhaps this is my mind's way of policing the environment, projecting whatever it anticipates onto the screen of consciousness so that the real data can be compared to the memory. I don't know the rationale behind the mental recording, but it showed me how much quiet, clever and accurate processing the mind can do in the background of our lives.

The training instructions given to Bahiya describe the body and mind carrying out their functions quite normally, seeing, hearing, sensing, cognizing. It's only our usual reactivity that's missing. And reactivity, remember, involves craving. We crave more of whatever sensations are deemed pleasant. We crave to get rid of those deemed unpleasant. We crave to ignore those we deem neutral.

We see the book. If we're an avid reader, this will be labelled pleasant and craving perks us up as we register the pleasure on offer here. But if we loathe reading, then the image will be labelled unpleasant and we crave to be rid of this irritation. If books mean little or nothing to us, we label the sight as neutral. We crave to ignore the sight, not to waste time letting our eyes rest on this irrelevance.

We're seldom aware of the craving underlying neutral feelings. But if you try resting your eyes on some fairly bland surface, you might soon feel a level of impatience. Your eyes will want to rove around, see something else. Your mind will probably want to think. This gives an insight into how deeply we crave to ignore sights we feel as neutral.

Craving leads on to grasping, sometimes called clinging. This is where we establish a sense of self, a central headquarters for experience. The headquarters we call me or I or mine can now marshal our physical and mental energies so as to fulfil craving. In Bahiya's training instructions, the Buddha clarifies that the goal is not to grasp, not to construct a sense of self, a central headquarters.

When for you, Bahia, there is in the seen only the seen, in the heard only the heard, in the sensed only the sensed, in the cognized only the cognized, then, Bahia, there is no you to be found in relation to that.

We practice non-grasping in *vipassanā*. When we become equanimous, thoughts and feelings come and go. We watch our dramas without getting caught up. We have the sense of being the observer of our own experience. We're not interfering, just watching. Bhante uses the analogy of a birdwatcher concealed within a hide.

At times, even the observer disappears. There is breathing, feeling, sensing, cognizing, but no one watching all this. Experience is not centered around me. Awareness doesn't seem to be located within my body as it normally is. When a bird sings, we're just aware of the sound. Usually it's me in here hearing the bird out there. Now there's only the sound without any reference to me at all.

We can still recognize the sound as bird song, and we can still locate the sound, know roughly where it comes from. All the essential perceptions and cognitions needed to negotiate the world are functioning perfectly. We've just stopped referring everything back to me, the hearer, me, the observer. In the hearing, there is only the hearing. There is hearing, recognizing, but no one hearing, no one recognizing. We're no longer automatically mapping sensations and feelings into concepts like me, you, self, not self.

As the Buddha told Bahia, when in the hearing there is only the hearing, then Bahia, there is no you in relation to that.

While Bahia grasped all this in a moment, we can make an effort to follow in his footsteps by bringing to mind concepts of you or that when the mind is steady in meditation. It's easiest to focus on just one, say it's the concept you. In my experience, a strong desire to understand the concept is stirred. Tensions build in the body and the mind starts to polarize. I'm experiencing the effort needed, by an unenlightened being anyhow, to frame and hold a concept.

The calming factors, especially tranquility and equanimity, balance the polarizing effect. I realize that I have to continually let go of the concept for any peace. A very vague you takes shape as an image, as if I'm looking at myself in a mirror, then dissolves again. The dissolving is experienced as peaceful, pleasant, but tinged with sadness as if I'm saying goodbye. Then the desire to form the concept, to know this you, starts the process again. It becomes clear that the desire is associated with a sense of self, an I who wants to know this vague, unstable you, which is continually fading away.

This practice helps us make peace with the conceptual mind. It's the attachment to concepts like you and that which snares us in *dukkha*. As we train ourselves to steady the mind around these concepts, we slowly purify our attachments. We learn that concepts aren't ultimate reality. The only reality in the midst of a concept like you are the sensations and feelings experienced as I try to hold the concept in mind.

We have a preference for pleasant feelings. These are associated with the relaxation, the letting go of the concept. It's lucky we're designed like that. Our preference for tranquility won't let us get too attached to our concepts. And yet we want to know

ourselves. *Dhamma chanda* can be described as the desire to know our true nature. This desire springs from wisdom and drives the spiritual life. But because of attachment, *taṇhā* gets mixed in. We want to gain something out of all this effort.

Perhaps it's power. We want to be in control of experience, not at the mercy of circumstances. Perhaps it's the desire to love or be loved. Perhaps we want to save ourselves from dukkha. In pure form, these desires are all worthy aspects of dhamma chanda. But delusion allows them get hijacked by greed. Delusion tells us we are or could be that entity who is in control, who loves and is loved, who saves the world from dukkha.

Only as we sit still, burning with desire in vipassanā, can we start to separate out *taṇhā*, the greed for spiritual progress, from dhamma chanda, the wise desire to be present with experience, just as it is. The desire to know our true nature stirs us to frame a concept like you, while tranquility and equanimity persuade us to let go of the concept. It's a tight rope.

Because of our deep attachment to conceptual thought, tranquility often presents the wisest option. However, we can go overboard here, come to dread and deplore conceptual thought because it's so disturbing. It is useful to be able to think, however. Even an *Arahant* might need to think about issues when deciding on a course of action.

The story of Brahmā advising the Buddha to teach the Dhamma could be interpreted as the Buddha's rational thinking mind in conversation with his enlightened nature. Brahmā in Indian mythology represents the wisest being. While he lived, the Buddha had being nature, human nature. The Buddha's being, because it is no longer deluded, is the wisest being, is Brahmā. Thus, even an *Arahant* will at times need to generate concepts so as to weigh up matters, decide whether a course of action is worthwhile.

The Buddha used concepts like I and me and you and so on all the time as he taught. In particular, he taught the practice of *mettā*, to cherish and care for ourselves as individuals, to care for each being as an individual being. Being able to frame the millions of colours and sounds and sensations and feelings that arise each moment as concepts—me, mine, you, yours—is a very important aspect of human intellect and interaction. And, at least on this side of liberation, is a necessary basis for compassion.

Thus, we undertake the practice of forming concepts in meditation as part of the path of purification. Although we might sense conceptualization as disturbing a more peaceful meditation, and we might quickly detect ourselves grasping onto concepts like

you and I, we cannot afford to shirk away from the task. Otherwise, we simply get attached to tranquility and equanimity. This can lead to the delusion which marked the start of Bahia's journey, wondering whether perhaps he was enlightened.

Working with the conceptual mind in vipassanā links to the teaching on the destruction of craving, where the Buddha advises us to understand experience within the reflection: "This has come to be." This anger has come to be. This peace has come to be. This boredom has come to be. This itching has come to be. Every experience can be understood within the phrase.

At times, when we watch an experience—say it's an itching sensation—we find that it fades away. What are we left with? Our attention can be riveted, focused on the spot where the itching faded, but we can't name what's holding attention anymore. The desire to describe is felt as disturbing. As the body and mind relax, letting go of the desire to think, the focus for awareness broadens, sensing peace in the broad expanse of a mind that isn't interested in thinking. This is a mind that is, for a few moments anyhow, content within itself, not trying to work things out, sort out this from that.

After a while, restlessness or some other hindrance sets in. I often find the mind flickering at what seems like its outer border, trying to expand the circle of awareness. As it peeks momentarily into what we might call the outer darkness, it labels the darkness as that, because it seems beyond its grasp, objective, external. A moment later, it flickers towards a brightness associated with a physical sensation and pleasant feeling. It labels the brightness as this because it feels like me, mine, eminently graspable.

These flickering movements of mind give us a chance to study the next reflection Buddha recommends in the teaching on the destruction of craving: "This arises with that as nutriment." We grasp at pleasant feelings, think of them as mine, because the mind is not satisfied with its own limits. It senses something beyond itself, something external, something it can call that. But the concept that opens the door to the concept this. Our logical mind demands that if there's something external, then there has to be something internal looking out. And so we start grasping towards the body, feelings, perceptions, etc. as me and mine. We become the observer again.

To let go of that sense of being the observer, we need to make peace with the limits of our knowledge. Can we resist the temptation to look beyond what's right here, right now? Challenging, but a worthy practice.

The last thing the Buddha says to Bahia is: "When there is no you there, then you are neither here nor there, nor anywhere in between. Just this is the end of suffering."

When the mind isn't forming the concept me, then there's no location for the self. There can still be spatial knowledge. We can locate books and trees and other visible objects as well as the source of sounds. We can move our body appropriately. We don't get our arms mixed up with our legs. It's just that the mind isn't generating a focal point for me in the world.

Normally, we locate ourselves as here, somewhere within our body. When we see a tree, we think of ourselves as the one who sees. Focusing more closely, we sense that we are identifying with the moment to moment experience of seeing. We're clinging to those atoms of colour that are being strung together to form the concept tree. This is to cling to the sensory process. In this case, the eye and seeing. But clinging is painful.

Realising this, we loosen our grip, relax. It's a relief to let the tree be there, outside of me. Just a tree, after all. But after a while, a niggling doubt sets in. How is it we know what is there outside of ourselves? To our dismay, perhaps, we sense that we are now clinging to the notion there. It's pleasant to think of there being an external world, something I'm not solely responsible for, something I can let go of, ignore when I wish to. And yet I would be very dismayed to find the tree was not there when next I looked outside my window.

Sadly, I have to admit that I've now gone and attached myself to the sense object. In this case, the tree. I'm projecting part of this delusive construct of me outside of myself. And at the moment it's very bound up with the concept of the tree that grows outside my window.

Clinging to the sense doors, we locate ourselves as here within our bodies. Clinging to the sense object, we locate ourselves as there in the outside world. Both attempts to cling are painful. As we let go of these concepts, equanimity grows. Sensations and perceptions associated with both here and there slide from head to heart. We're no longer interested in defining these as one or the other. It's as if the boundaries to the self grow permeable. The heart can now include aspects of the outer world, such as the tree.

If I were to ask, where am I? I would answer that I'm not located at a particular spot, but as a nebulous consciousness, larger than my body, hovering somewhere in between my inner and outer worlds. When we identify as the observer of experience in this way, we're identifying with consciousness, that which knows experience. It's the birdwatcher in the hide, a very beautiful state of being, very worthy.

At least on this side of liberation, however, it's still a conditioned state, a composite knowing of several sensations and feelings. To take another step along the path, we let that observer melt into its underlying nature, the momentary knowing of a sensation, feeling or mind state.

When we can resist all temptations to locate ourselves either here within our inner world or there in the outer world, or in between as the equanimous observer, then there will be in the seen only the seen, in the heard only the heard, in the sensed only the sensed, in the cognized only the cognized. The body and mind function perfectly. We can interact intelligently with the world. The only thing that's missing is the sense of self. The blackbird sings in the tree. We know this. Hearing happens. But no one hears. No one knows.

I end with the epitaph for Bahia spoken by the Buddha: "Where water, earth, fire and wind have no footing, there the stars don't shine. The sun isn't visible. There the moon doesn't appear. There darkness is not found. And when a sage, a Brahman through his own wisdom, has realized this for himself..."

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